

When Mirrors Are Windows: A View of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics

Guillermo Rodríguez

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Title Pages

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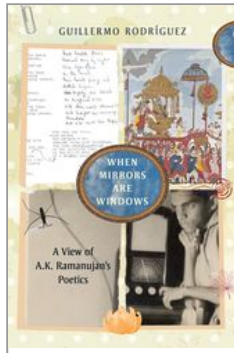
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Frontispiece

Guillermo Rodríguez

(p.ii)

Notes:

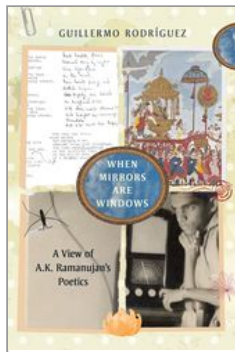
(*) In this draft of the well-known poem found in the A.K. Ramanujan Papers, hereafter AKR Papers, the poet decided to reflect his image in 'shopwindows' (line 3) instead of 'mirrors' (line 3, crossed-out). See the printed poem in A.K. Ramanujan, 'Self-Portrait', *The Striders* (1966), in Vinay Dharwadker (ed.), *The Collected Poems of A.K. Ramanujan* (hereafter: *CP*) (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1995), p. 23. The published version of the poem coincides with this draft from the early 1960s except for the hyphen in 'shop-windows'.

Self-portrait

I resemble everyone
but myself, and sometimes see
in ~~times~~ shopwindows,
despite the well-known laws
of optics,
the portrait of a stranger,
date unknown,
often signed in a corner
by my father.

A.K. Ramanujan, handwritten draft of
'Self-Portrait' from *The Striders**

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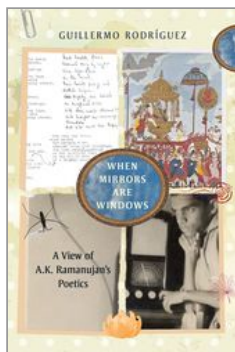
Dedication

Guillermo Rodríguez

(p.v)

*To Monica,
dancer of words,
poet of the body*

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Epigraph

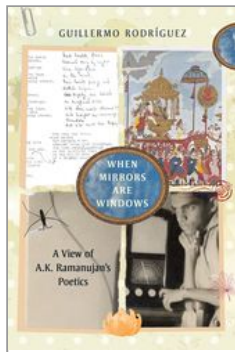
Guillermo Rodríguez

(p.vi)

'Poetry contains, transforms, and returns our reality to us, and us to reality, in oblique ways.'

—A.K. Ramanujan, 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry', *An Introduction to India*, pamphlet containing articles commissioned on the occasion of the 7th Non-Alignment Summit in New Delhi (New Delhi: External Publications Division, Ministry of External Affairs, March 1983), p. 62.

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(p.ix) Foreword

Girish Karnad

There is no other figure like A.K. Ramanujan on the intellectual landscape of India.

He was a teacher who loved teaching. I was fortunate enough to have met him when I was only 16. I was a student of mathematics in Dharwad and he was a junior lecturer in English, teaching at a college some 50 miles away. That distance seemed immense in those days and we did not meet too often, but whenever we did, whether on a railway platform, in the college canteen, or on the long walks he loved, he would hold forth, turning the meeting spontaneously into a class on whatever topic excited him or me at the moment. His enthusiasm for teaching continued to pour forth in the many workshops, seminars, and symposia he conducted throughout his life.

Later, he moved to the USA and taught in Chicago, and I watched in awe as he extended his range of interests to cover subjects as diverse as linguistics, anthropology, folklore, history of religions, literary studies, and ethnography. In spite of his involvement in such a wide range of disciplines, however, there is little doubt that Ramanujan will ultimately be remembered for having brought to light with his translations three distinct bodies of ancient literature, the very existence of which was unknown to the world outside until then—the ancient Tamil Sangam anthologies, the later bhakti poems of the Alvars, and the medieval Kannada *vachana* poetry. Not many translators can claim such a rich harvest: most translators anywhere in the world are content to bring out new versions of texts already recognized as ‘classics’, such as traditional epics or literary works or philosophical tracts. Ramanujan did not merely ‘discover’ these seminal texts, he accomplished something even more difficult: he demonstrated through his translations that the originals were works of rare poetic excellence.

He was a first-rate poet in English—as in Kannada—an advantage most Indian translators do not have; the poet is present in the translations. So is the teacher: along with translating these texts he built a theory of translation, which lucidly explains **(p.x)** the principles underlying his method of work. He despised jargon and obscurity, so that even when dealing with complex issues, his explanations are simple and direct. The result is a body of theoretical analysis, the influence of which it has been impossible for translators after him to resist.

In an age in which the greatness of India's intellectual and artistic heritage was defined primarily in terms of its classical—mainly Sanskrit—texts and judged by patriarchal norms, Ramanujan responded to the feminine aspects of that legacy. Female voices come through vibrantly in these poems.

He drew attention to the coherence, vitality, and relevance of the 'underbelly' of our culture, a whole swathe of lived phenomena, such as proverbs, games, quizzes, swear words, and lullabies, as well as tales, prayers, and songs, often oral and therefore transitory. His contention was that these works, mostly created by women in domestic spaces, were in fact vital sources of everyday creativity in our culture.

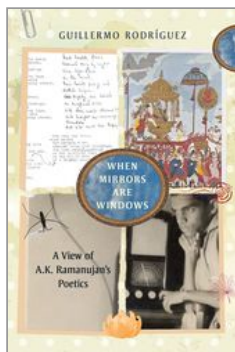
He had an almost uncanny sensitivity to hidden relationships and invisible patterns, operating in disparate genres in different languages, which enabled him to decipher connections between seemingly unrelated, far-ranging phenomena—as when he noticed characteristics common to oral tales narrated even today by elderly women in Kannada kitchens and the Akam poems of ancient Tamil Sangam anthologies. He wove these implications, which are immediate, direct, and often startling, into a single coherent tapestry of the Indian way of living and thinking. At the end of it all, what Ramanujan presented was not just a theory of public literary culture for the edification of scholars, but a concrete vision of life as it is lived in the home.

In the last few years of his life, Ramanujan often commented with sadness on the fact that while American academia piled every conceivable honour on him, including a MacArthur Fellowship, his work was barely noticed in India. A few friends knew that he was on to something unique, but professional academics by and large found his projects outlandish. Fortunately, this situation changed since his death in 1993 and serious attention is now being paid to his output. But in those days when he seemed condemned to academic neglect, I was pleasantly surprised one day to receive a phone call from a person with a distinctly unfamiliar accent speaking impeccable English from—of all places—Kerala, announcing that he was doing research on Ramanujan's work and asking me to share any available material, **(p.xi)** by or on him, that I may have in my possession. I was sceptical, though I supplied every scrap of what I had devotedly collected. Here is the fruit of that labour by Guillermo Rodríguez, the first scholarly book dedicated to the study of Ramanujan. I feel privileged to

have been asked to write the Foreword to it. Rodríguez is deeply involved with India—he has been responsible for founding and running the Casa de la India in Valladolid, Spain. His understanding of Ramanujan is infused not only in his immersion in India, but also in the insights he brings from his roots in Spain. Here we have a study of his oeuvre, driven by passion and illuminated by a cross-cultural sensibility, which draws on insights from across the oceans; it would have delighted Ramanujan.

GIRISH KARNAD (p.xii)

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(p.xiii) Acknowledgements

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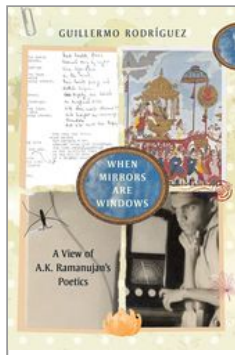
This book would have never seen the light of day without the continued support and generosity of many people. My first thanks goes to my two PhD supervisors, Dr Pilar Abad García at the University of Valladolid and Dr S. Murali at the University of Kerala, for their invaluable advice and encouragement as I shuttled for years between university departments, drafts, and ideas to complete in 2006 the dissertation on which this book is based. They infused in me the necessary academic rigour to write on one of the most complex poets and thinkers of post-Independence India. I am also thankful to the institutions that have provided me with administrative and financial backing during the different phases of this project: the University of Valladolid; the University of Kerala; the regional government of Castile and León, Spain; the city council of Valladolid; the embassy of India in Spain; and the marvellous team at Casa de la India. My thanks are also due to the professors and staff members who assisted me in several other universities, libraries, and research centres where I spent weeks of painstaking but rewarding research: Loyola College (Chennai), Dhvanyaloka Centre for Indian Studies (Mysore), the English and Foreign Languages University (Hyderabad), the Sahitya Akademi (New Delhi), the Study Centre for Indian Literature in English and Translation or SCILET library at the American College (Madurai), and the Commonwealth Institute (London). I am particularly indebted to the efficient team at the Special Collections Research Center of the University of Chicago for its useful suggestions in the arduous task of scrutinizing the AKR Papers. And I shall ever be grateful to Ramanujan's son Krishna for allowing me to include in this book the rare photographs and diverse manuscripts and documents that belong to the estate of A.K. Ramanujan.

I also wish to thank the many scholars, writers, and artists with whom I have had the privilege of discussing the work and legacy of Ramanujan, some of whom had been connected to his life and scholarship for decades. They added much more than new nuances **(p.xiv)** to my perception of Ramanujan as a writer and scholar, for their complementary views also breathed life into my understanding of his composite personality. Many of the scholars who contributed to this creative dialogue and shared their wisdom on a wide range of topics are no more with us: K. Ayyappa Paniker, professor, poet, and guru with that ever-generous smile, and P.K. Rajan, both of whom encouraged me to join the University of Kerala as a researcher; U.R. Ananthamurthy, Ramachandra Sharma, and T.G. Vaidyanathan in Bangalore; and C.D. Narasimhaiah in the poet's native town, Mysore, who remembered Ramanujan as an inquisitive student. I must also mention Ramanujan's sister Saroja for introducing me to her childhood memories in the City of Palaces. In Chennai, I am grateful to the late S. Krishnan and also wish to thank Velu Viswanadhan and my other friends at Cholamandal Artists' Village for the material on Ramanujan that they so kindly shared with me, in particular S.G. Vasudev, for agreeing to the reproduction in this book of the drawing 'Self-Portrait' from his series 'Tribute to Ramanujan'. Likewise, I would like to acknowledge poets Keki N. Daruwalla, R. Parthasarathy, and A.K. Mehrotra for the brief but stimulating interactions on Ramanujan and Indian Poetry in English, and H.S. Shivaprakash for his incisive inputs on the Kannada literary scene. In Chicago, Ramanujan's friends and colleagues opened up a 'new world' to me, and I am obliged to Joan L. Erdman, Wendy Doniger, Sheldon Pollock, Manu Shetty, and the late Norman Cutler and Susanne Rudolph for their insights on Ramanujan's interdisciplinary academic life at the University of Chicago. And I shall not forget Cathy and Dave without whose invitation to the Windy City my journey would not have turned full circle.

I express my special thanks to Girish Karnad for always being there to inspire me and for writing the Foreword to this book, and to the enthusiastic staff at Oxford University Press India, New Delhi, for their impeccable support and guidance throughout this exciting project.

And lastly, I thank the genius of A.K. Ramanujan, without whose absent presence in many hearts and parts of the world I would have never met so many wonderful people.

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(p.xv) Prologue

Guillermo Rodríguez

This book was shaped in several continents, countries, cities, and homes, and was given its present form almost 20 years after I first decided, during a scorching Madras summer in the mid-1990s, to undertake academic research on the late A.K. Ramanujan. In the cross-cultural explorations and extensive research that went into this monograph on one of the finest Indian poets, translators, and scholars of the twentieth century, there have been many twists and turns as well as pleasant surprises and encounters. The journey began in 1993, when, after studying stylistics at the University of Edinburgh and completing my graduate studies in English philology at the University of Valladolid, I decided to embark on an overland trip from Spain to India in search of 'other wisdom traditions'. I did not know then that I was to stay in India for seven years, and that I had left my native town the same week that A.K. Ramanujan's life had unexpectedly come to an end (on 13 July 1993) at a hospital in Chicago. Several months later, living on a houseboat on the sacred River Ganga in Banaras, what I found was no spiritual guide, but a key that opened new windows to the puzzling world before me: Indian literature in English. Among the first books I randomly picked up at a Godowlia bookshop (incidentally run by a fellow Spaniard) were R. Parthasarathy's anthology *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets*, A.K. Ramanujan's *Speaking of Siva*, a selection of medieval Kannada devotional sayings rendered in English, and several of Girish Karnad's plays including *Nāga-Mandala: A Play with a Cobra*, based on a folktale told by Ramanujan. Out of the 10 poets I read in Parthasarathy's anthology, I was soon struck by the unusual imagery and power of suggestion of Ramanujan's poems. And reading his exquisite renderings of esoteric medieval mystic poetry as well as Karnad's contemporary plays I was able to learn about Ramanujan's other facets as a translator, folklorist, scholar, and mentor. Yet little did I suspect that I was to get much closer to Ramanujan's poetic universe when

my backpacking adventure took me to south India in 1994, where I spent the next six years. By chance **(p.xvi)** I rented the rooftop of a sculptor's studio in Cholamandal Artists' Village in the sleepy coastal village of Injambakkam outside Madras (today Chennai), where an overcrowded public bus had stopped en route to Mahabalipuram. One evening, while sharing my interest in the 'exiled' poet-scholar with some of the artists at Cholamandal's café under the banyan tree, I was told that A.K. Ramanujan's last poetry reading in India had by chance taken place at a neighbouring studio, in the company of painters S.G. Vasudev and Velu Viswanadhan, and other friends. Ramanujan, whose father was a Tamil Brahmin from Triplicane, used to visit fellow scholars, artists, and friends regularly in Madras. He had come to the artists' village on his last trip to India, the evening before he flew back to the USA in December 1992. That night he had obliged to read some of his unpublished translations of Tamil devotional poems by Tirumankai Alvar (ninth century AD), the last of the Alvars (the 'god-immersed' Tamil poet-saints), whose compositions were carved in medieval Tamil at a nearby temple. Fortunately, the reading was tape-recorded, and when I listened to it in the same studio where the improvised session had taken place, I too was immersed in the early medieval Tamil bhakti poems through the translator's empathetic reading. The ancient poems came alive in Ramanujan's delicate voice and soft modulation, sounding as fresh as perennial garlands of *kurinji* flowers and as profoundly intimate as personal prayers.

But reading mystic poetry and strolling on the sandy beaches of the Bay of Bengal were not satisfying enough for my inquisitive spirit, so I made up my mind to undertake serious research on contemporary Indian Poetry in English (IPE) at some of the best research centres for Indian literature in English in the country, which allowed me to meet and interview some of the writers, poets, and critics I was reading about. I spent my first brief stints as a research student in India at the Dhvanyaloka Centre for Indian Studies, Mysore, founded by Ramanujan's former professor, C.D. Narasimhaiah, and at the pioneering SCILET at the American College, Madurai; such field trips expanded my understanding of the significance of Ramanujan's legacy as an intellectual and creative treasure house bridging the East and the West, and tradition and modernity. By that time, 'A.K. Ramanujan research' had become something like a discipline to me; Ramanujan had turned into the abbreviated 'AKR' as an object of study in my notes. I found out only much later that Ramanujan wrote in the mid-1950s several radio plays in Kannada language under a pseudonym **(p.xvii)** derived from his initials 'AKR': 'Akrura', which means 'not cruel' or 'gentle' in Sanskrit and is a character from the Mahabharata and the *Bhagavata Purana*.

In 1996, I enrolled in an MA course at Loyola College, Madras, which covered Indian writing in English, and a year later I completed my MA dissertation, a stylistic (linguistic) and symbolic study of a single poem: 'Snakes' from AKR's first poetry book *The Striders* (1966). The essay titled 'A.K. Ramanujan: His "Outer" and "Inner" Forms', was an attempt to illustrate the poet's mastery over

language and his distinctive technique that baffle the reader in the poem by 'making visible its forms' at multiple levels of signification. I was fascinated by the way the 'meaning' of the poem comes to the reader in its *design*, that is, in the particular way the speaker-narrator renders the 'experience' that is articulated through the linguistic structure. At the same time, the archetypal image of the snake allows for a psychological (Jungian), philosophical, and mythological (Hindu) reading: it is a symbol of fear belonging to our collective unconscious, yet it is also worshipped as a symbol of fertility in south-Indian traditions and in Hindu mythology, and is associated with the principle of female energy, Shakti, and with the cosmic waters of Visnu and Maya, the 'illusion' of life, death, and rebirth out of which the power of creation emanates. In my multisided analysis of this imagistic poem, I learnt how a single poem could be shown to contain the essence of AKR's trademark style. Along with a close reading of his 'families' of poems, a typical short poem by AKR might reveal an entire *poetics* if one learnt how to pull its 'strings'. Indeed, the riddle-like cyclical structure of 'Snakes' invites one to go back to the first line and read it over and over again: as the poet-magician re-enacts the rope trick and the snake is reborn, you want to watch closely to see how he pulls it off....

When I interviewed Girish Karnad in Madras while I was working on my MA dissertation, he informed me that he was rehearsing for the premiere of *Nāga-Mandala: A Play with a Cobra* with Guthrie Theater in Minneapolis in the summer of 1993 when he got the sad news that AKR had suddenly passed away during a minor surgery. Karnad had heard the folktale of the Naga-Mandala from AKR and it was one of the many stories and ideas that he had picked up from him in their long association that went back to the mid-1950s. He thus introduced me to AKR as a young, multitalented prodigy who recorded folktales in villages (at a time when no one paid attention to oral traditions), and who had already influenced a whole generation **(p.xviii)** of poets, writers, and scholars in south India when he left for the USA as a Fulbright scholar in 1959. Soon after my research experience at Loyola College (1996–7), I met in Kerala (Trivandrum) another contemporary of AKR who had been following his work closely: the late south-Indian scholar, literary critic, and Malayalam poet Ayyappa Paniker. The former professor of English at the University of Kerala advised me to register as a PhD student at this university to carry out further research on AKR and IPE. Paniker entrusted me with an audiotape of an unpublished interview with AKR, which he had recorded in 1982 in Chicago. It had been lying on Paniker's living-room shelf and, after all the years, he asked me to transcribe it for a publication. When I went through the audio recording it was more than intellectually exciting to listen—so many years after it had taken place—to an illuminating private conversation between two seminal south-Indian minds. AKR revealed new insights into his thoughts and practice as a poet and translator at a crucial time, having just published his translations of medieval bhakti poems by Nammalvar called *Hymns for the Drowning* (1981); he was,

finally, more than 10 years after *Relations* (1971), working on a new collection of his own poems that was to be titled *Soma*.

Though *The Collected Essays* came out only in 1999, my gradual discovery of AKR's other facet as an influential essay writer, besides his work as a translator of classical and medieval south-Indian poetry, folklorist, and bilingual poet, further challenged my view of his poetry in English. This, and the fact that only one monographic full-length book on AKR's poetry had been published by the late 1990s, prompted me to focus on his aesthetics and poetics as the topic of my PhD dissertation. During the first phase of my research, I continued collecting material from diverse centres and libraries across India: Trivandrum, Madurai, Chennai, Bengaluru, Mysore, Hyderabad, and New Delhi, places where I had fruitful encounters and discussions with AKR's former colleagues, friends, and relatives. At a crucial moment in my research, Karnad came to Trivandrum to edit a film he was working on. As he later confessed to me, he thought I was truly an indefatigable and stubborn student. Since I had already researched most of AKR's published works and interviewed many of his acquaintances in India during my field trips, Karnad advised me to travel to Chicago to meet some of AKR's American colleagues and, above all, to research the AKR Papers that had been deposited at the University of Chicago in 1994.

(p.xix) In 2001, a grant from the University of Valladolid finally enabled me to visit Chicago. At the time of his death in 1993, AKR still belonged to the faculty of the University of Chicago which he had joined in 1962 as an assistant professor of linguistics, Tamil, and Dravidian studies. At this university, he, in great measure, contributed in the establishment of one of the finest centres of South Asian studies in the world. AKR's interdisciplinary approach to any subject he studied and taught, and his multidisciplinary interests, made him a highly reputed and sought-after lecturer, so it is little wonder that he held several teaching positions in Chicago, apart from periodical visiting lectureships at other prestigious universities in the USA and around the globe. Intellectually, creatively, and professionally, AKR was probably at the peak of his career when he passed away at the age of 64, leaving behind numerous unfinished projects and works. The AKR Papers, donated in June 1994 to the Department of Special Collections of the University of Chicago Library by AKR's ex-wife Molly A. Daniels, have been, since, kept in the Joseph Regenstein Library of the university. For a number of years they were stored in 21 boxes occupying 31.5 linear feet. The boxes were loosely organized under 'preliminary inventory' and there was no finding aid to the collection until it was processed about 15 years later and placed into 71 smaller boxes divided into 8 series as detailed in the 'Guide to the A.K. Ramanujan Papers 1944-1995', published online in 2010. The Papers contain a wide range of material including AKR's dream notebooks, journals, diaries, and private correspondence, typed and handwritten drafts of his published and unpublished poems (in English and Kannada), drafts of his translations, essays, and books, unpublished academic papers and lectures,

folktale manuscripts in English and Kannada, lecture notes and notecards, scrapbooks, newspaper articles, official documents and letters, and other miscellaneous printed material spanning over 50 years (1943–95). When I first accessed the Papers at the Regenstein Library in the cold Chicago spring of 2001, nothing had prepared me for the vast amount of primary and secondary material that was stacked in large boxes, still placed in a rather hasty and unorganized manner. I spent several months that year at the Department of Special Collections (which became the Special Collections Research Center in 2002), going through thousands of pages of printed, typed, and handwritten material. As I combed through AKR's legacy for uncharted material, I felt simultaneously like a detective searching for unexpected clues to a *perfect crime*—the **(p.xx)** perfect poem of a verbal magician—and an accomplice to the late author, whose works and deeds I had been scrutinizing for a number of years, and who was now letting me into the 'inner' domains of his thought. To become complicit as a privileged external reader of AKR's journals (as well as of his unpublished poems and drafts) was also to become an unexpected collaborator in the process of re-creating and completing the act of literary communication. In this sense, my research work turned both into a scientific undertaking and an aesthetic experience.

The Papers cover all facets of AKR's intellectual interests and academic scholarship, besides providing invaluable literary, biographical, and autobiographical information. Despite being a treasure trove of data for students and critics of AKR's poetry as well as a repository of his contribution to the fields of linguistics, anthropology and Indian folklore, culture, and literature, the AKR Papers had never been described in any critical publication after they were handed over to the University of Chicago. This painstaking assessment of the Papers revealed to me rare views of the author's composite creativity and provided new food for thought, which became the pivot for my PhD dissertation titled 'The Aesthetic and Poetic Thought of A.K. Ramanujan (1929–1993): A Systematic Study of His Published Writings and the Unpublished A.K. *Ramanujan Papers*', submitted in 2006 under the co-direction of Dr S. Murali, University of Kerala, and Dr Pilar Abad, University of Valladolid. I was motivated to undertake this line of research for two reasons. First, on the grounds that the state of critical studies on AKR's poetry was noticeably inadequate and incomplete in proportion to the scope and depth of his work, the quantity and quality of the published and unpublished primary material at hand, and the relevance of the author to contemporary Indian poetry and scholarship. Second, my objective was to point out how AKR's work as a multidisciplinary academic scholar converged with his private thoughts and preoccupations—contained in the diaries and notebooks—as a writer, translator, and poet.

The manuscript of my PhD dissertation forms the backbone of this book. It was after I attended the 'First A.K. Ramanujan Memorial Lecture' delivered by Girish Karnad at Ramjas College, University of Delhi, in March 2012, that the

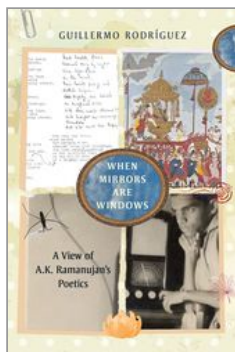
playwright encouraged me once more to bring out a book on AKR. This was the right time. The following day, I was sitting in the offices of the Indian headquarters of Oxford University Press in New Delhi, discussing this book. In the three years (p.xxii) since then, the texts that have been adapted from the dissertation have been carefully revised, transformed, and updated, and edited into a compact book form. As a pioneering study, this monograph aims to fill a critical vacuum by offering a systematization of AKR's poetics and an overview of his life and work, with rare glimpses into the unpublished material from the Papers and other uncollected writings. The unpublished sources are scrutinized side by side with the published writings in order to synthesize AKR's ideas on art and poetry, the intellectual and creative processes behind his poetry in English, and the evolution of his poetics. Except for the editors of the posthumous publications, the Papers are still unknown to literary critics or other scholars. More than two decades after AKR's demise, this is the first critical study that covers a wide spectrum of published and unpublished primary sources, including his private diaries and journals, drafts of poems, and other papers. These diverse sources exhibit a high degree of intertextuality. The methodology applied is therefore primarily based on classification, which entails a systematic description of both the scholarly texts that contain AKR's ideas on aesthetic and poetic traditions, and the private writings that are discussed for the first time. The latter include his personal aesthetic experiences and observations on topics such as the process of composing a poem and his anxieties as a poet engaging with multiple pasts and an ever-elusive present.

With this approach to AKR's 'inner' and 'outer' forms, I wish to illustrate how the poet-scholar paid attention to the manifold aesthetic and poetic contexts and particulars in his life and work, and how these are reflected in his writings and converge as a way of thinking and as a nurturing force behind his creativity. AKR is widely recognized today as a brilliant essayist, teacher, intellectual, and translator with a multilayered genius. His written legacy is a network of miscellaneous disciplines, subjects, genres, sources, and types of material. In this book, the poet in him is analysed as the central axis running through his complex self and personal universe, which he often likened to an upside-down tree. Any study of AKR's poetics that seeks to extract a coherent picture out of his mosaic of ideas and reflections will arrive at a pool of images, at a 'language within a language' that challenges such synthesizing efforts made for the sake of the reader. Space in a book is, however, limited. I am aware that the variety, range, and complexity of the primary texts that are presented and described here allow for multiple analyses (p.xxii) and methodologies, and are open to diverse interpretations. In some cases, the original material and certain subject areas that were of interest to AKR as poet or scholar have only been introduced in general terms or in passing, though they deserve to be treated with a more rigorous scientific eye and further theoretical acumen. I decided against including diacritics for Sanskrit and Dravidian words in the main text of the

book, though the Glossary provides a descriptive list of most of these terms, indicating, also, diacritical marks. Thus, I have attempted to sail the middle path to reach out to a readership of students and academic researchers of Indian literature in English as well as to poetry lovers and those interested in Indian cultural and literary studies in general. Nevertheless, the ideal book on AKR would probably have to be written by a multidisciplinary team comprising a cultural anthropologist, a literary critic and theorist, a specialist in modern Indian poetry in English and Kannada, a Sanskritist, a Dravidian literature expert, a folklorist, a linguist, a translator, and a poet, or by someone who could claim to be all of these in one. And so, despite its shortcomings, I am confident that this book will trigger fresh critical debate, precisely because the new (unknown) material exposed herein will enable general readers, students, researchers, and critics to update old and new interpretations of AKR's poems and poetics, and look at his work-in-progress as a poet-translator-scholar in a new light.

In short, now that the dust of non-literary controversies over some of AKR's academic prose has settled, it is perhaps apt to put poetry back on the centre stage of the discussion around this multifaceted 'gentle' genius. It is only a hope that the AKR *persona* I present here will resemble at least a couple of the many Ramanujans that might be looking at their *image* through poetic windows, and that this AKR will not altogether miss his appointment with the scholar A.K. Ramanujan and the familiar Raman, somewhere in a street market between the certainties of college offices and the private living room of dreams, fears, and memories.

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When Mirrors Are Windows: A View of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics

Guillermo Rodríguez

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(p.xxiii) Abbreviations Used for the Dating of Prose and Poetry by A.K. Ramanujan

Guillermo Rodríguez

Prose: Essays, Papers, and Lectures

(p. 1993)

date of first publication

(p. 1989, 1999)

date of first publication and subsequent publications

(d. 1993)

date of first identified draft

Poetry: Poems and Translations

(d. 1993)

date of first identified draft

(p. 1993)

date of first publication, other than publications in a collection of poems

(coll. 1993)

date of first publication in a collection of poems (some poems were published in journals and anthologies before appearing in poetry collections)

(tr. 1992)

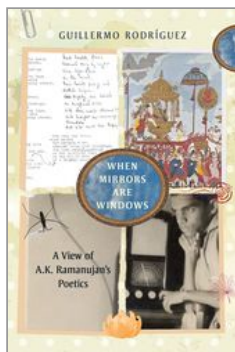
date of publication of translations into English by AKR or other authors

(tr. 1976, 1997)

date of the first publication of a translation and subsequent publications

(p.xxiv)

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Writing on A.K. Ramanujan

The 'Critical Scene'

Guillermo Rodríguez

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Abstract and Keywords

The opening chapter presents an overview of the writings on Ramanujan. It comprises both a typological and a chronological classification of critical texts, and provides an outline of critical approaches, followed by a brief description of the major works that probe into Ramanujan's aesthetics and poetics. Although Ramanujan was an essayist, a translator, and a bilingual poet who worked from 1959 to 1993 at American universities and published poetry, translations, and essays on a variety of subjects, by far the largest part of the critical corpus on the author is dedicated to his poetry in English and was published in India. This asymmetrical situation is traced to the relevance of Ramanujan as one of the pioneers of modernism in Indian poetry in English, and to the growing critical output in general after the 1970s on post-Independence Indian poetry in English, produced mainly by Indian academics.

Keywords: Indian literary criticism, modern Indian poetry in English, contemporary Indian literary history, poetry criticism, postcolonial Indian literature in English

Evolution of the Critical Scene

A.K. Ramanujan (1929–1993) was a man endowed with multifaceted talents. A scholar in several branches of knowledge, lifelong teacher, folklorist, translator, poet (in English and Kannada), and author of fiction and plays in Kannada, his written legacy is a network of diverse disciplines, subjects, genres, and types of material. His extant work forms a colourful and knotty piece of embroidery that awes and challenges any reader attempting to trace in it a single strand of

thought. The threads of the tapestry are carefully intertwined and yield, in complex patterns of multilayered art and painstaking craft, the mind of a genius. And yet there are many loose ends, for his work was left unfinished.

At the age of 64, when he was at the peak of his intense career as a writer, professor, and scholar, AKR passed away unexpectedly in a Chicago hospital due to heart failure when anaesthetized for a minor surgery. After having worked as a professor of English at several colleges in India in his youth, he settled in the USA in 1959, where he spent the better part of his academic career suspended mid-motion between India and the USA till the end of his life. Though AKR produced most of his interdisciplinary academic papers in the USA and published his first collections of translations and poetry in English in the 1960s outside India, it is noteworthy that the greater part of the existing critical corpus on his work is devoted to his poetry in English and was published in India.¹ This asymmetrical situation may be traced to the growing critical output on contemporary IPE from the 1970s onwards, generated mainly by Indian academics who were poets themselves. They included AKR as one of the modernist pioneers in anthologies of post-Independence IPE (see also the section 'Overview of Critical Approaches' in this chapter and the **(p.2)** section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7). Outside India, contemporary IPE had not received much attention as an academic subject since the international publishing industry mainly promoted the more profitable genre, that is, Indian novels. In India, too, there was far more recognition for Indian fiction in English than for poetry, even though well-established foreign publishers operating in India, like Arnold Heinemann, Oxford University Press (with its New Poetry in India series), Orient Longman, and Macmillan, started showing interest in IPE in the 1970s and published anthologies and poetry collections by Indian authors. With a few exceptions, these reached only a limited public. In the 1980s, the first monographic and comparative studies of Indian poets writing in English made their appearance with the rise of new literatures in English and postcolonial literature and theory as new academic fields in India and other English-speaking countries.

At the time of AKR's death in 1993, Bruce King, one of the few non-Indian specialized critics of IPE, declared nevertheless: 'Raman was [a] major poet and scholar by international standards, but his poetry did not get the attention it deserved because no one had the same range of reading and culture he had.'² Two years earlier, in the Introduction to *Three Indian Poets: Nissim Ezekiel, A.K. Ramanujan, and Dom Moraes* (1991), King had already underlined the multiplicity of layers that critics faced in AKR's poetry: 'Of the three poets, Ramanujan is the most challenging as his verse is rich in echoes of a wide range of reading, as there is a complex and developing vision of reality in his poetry, and as there is a continuity between his poetry, translations, and scholarship.'³ Many things have changed in the critical scene on AKR from the time when these statements were made in the early 1990s. At that time only his three

collections of poems, *The Striders* (1966), *Relations* (1971), and *Second Sight* (1986), along with his choice of *Selected Poems* (1976); the four books of translations of classical and medieval Tamil and medieval Kannada poetry, *The Interior Landscape* (1967), *Speaking of Siva* (1973), *Hymns for the Drowning* (1981), *Poems of Love and War* (1985); his compilation of *Folktales from India* (1991); and a handful of academic essays were available to the general reader.⁴

A succession of posthumous books published by Oxford University Press from the mid-1990s onwards, kicked off by *The Collected Poems* (1995), made an enormous impact on the appreciation of AKR as a poet and scholar and sparked abundant critical debate. The author's collected poetry was placed alongside the corpus of translations in **(p.3)** *The Oxford India Ramanujan* (2004). And previously uncollected writings in prose and poetry, including unpublished papers and poems and rare interviews, as well as AKR's Kannada poems and novella, were brought to a wider readership through the publication of *A Flowering Tree and Other Oral Tales from India* (1997), *The Collected Essays* (1999), *Uncollected Poems and Prose* (2001), and *Poems and a Novella* (2006).⁵ About half a dozen authored monographs and a couple of edited monographic collections of critical essays on AKR's poetry have appeared since *The Collected Poems* was published in 1995, along with hundreds of essays and articles published in journals and edited books of literary criticism. These writings together exhibit multiple critical stances and types of approaches to AKR's poetry, and were published with disparate academic and editorial standards, reflecting the complex diversity of India's publishing industry.

As AKR's reputation grew, critics took up the challenge posed by his multicultural background and interdisciplinary work. In the postscript of King's analysis of the publishing history of IPE from 1987–99 included in his revised edition of *Modern Indian Poetry in English*, the American critic praised Ramanujan thus: 'It is now obvious that Ramanujan was a giant, an extremely good poet, a great translator, an internationally famous scholar, and someone of powerful and broad intellectual and cultural interests; he had few equals in the quality of intelligence he brought with many works and his range of achievements.'⁶ Another discerning insider-outsider observer of the critical scene of IPE, John Oliver Perry, admitted in a review article that the body of critical analysis on AKR was still insufficient and lacked an integral and interdisciplinary perspective. After calling for a 'high critical and scholarly dedication' to his work in his review article of *The Oxford India Ramanujan* (2004), he proposed a cross-cutting critical approach:

[W]e need to work out, as part and parcel of the relationships between AKR's original poetry (with its antecedents) and his translations from ancient Tamil and Kannada texts, those relationships between or rather amongst all his other culturally significant productions, as linguist, anthropologist, folklorist, archaeologist, and whatever. In that way, we will

be better able to see the whole man of integrity that the poems endeavour to present, according to his revelations in the interview with his friend and fellow poet, Ayyappa Paniker.⁷

In short, we can identify several factors that have contributed to this atypical critical scene and its development: (a) the peculiar nature **(p.4)** of IPE criticism and its publishing history; (b) the early inclusion of AKR as part of the canon of modern IPE in India, though he lived mostly in the USA after 1959;⁸ (c) the multidisciplinary character of the author (Dravidian scholar, folklorist, translator, bilingual poet); and (d) the fact that AKR published only three poetry collections in English in his lifetime,⁹ while a large corpus of his uncollected and unpublished works was edited and published only posthumously.

In the brief overview provided in this chapter of the heterogeneous critical works on AKR and their varied approaches, I follow typological and chronological criteria and pay special attention to writings that focus on AKR's aesthetics and poetics as well as studies that trace an interdisciplinary line in his oeuvre.

Typological Classification

The extant critical body of writings on AKR in English covers miscellaneous genres and publication formats ranging from full-length monographs to academic essays and papers, notes, newspaper articles, and reviews. A major part of the critical writing on AKR has been produced by Indian academics in India or by Indian diaspora scholars and published in literary journals and edited collections of critical essays on IPE. I focus here primarily on criticism that analyses AKR as a poet and translator (which comprises most of the critical texts) and leave aside, for the moment, writings that study AKR as a folklorist or cultural anthropologist.¹⁰

Bibliographies

Apart from the bibliographies put together by academic researchers in their unpublished dissertations on the author cited ahead in this section,¹¹ there are a few specific bibliographies of AKR's primary and secondary sources compiled in the monographic studies that have been released over the last 20 years. Sumana Ghosh's *A.K. Ramanujan as a Poet* (2004) carries a reasonable 'Selected Bibliography' of secondary sources on AKR that were published in books and journals (these are the only two categories in her classification),¹² but it leaves out numerous review articles of AKR's poetry books as well as newspaper articles and published interviews. A much shorter selected bibliography in Kannada appeared in a brief biography authored by Vishwanatha Badikana in 1995.¹³ On the other hand, **(p.5)** *Millennium Perspectives on A.K. Ramanujan* (2001), a collection of critical articles edited by Surya Nath Pandey, includes an 'Annotated Bibliography' of published primary and secondary sources.¹⁴ This list of secondary sources is, however, not as complete as Ghosh's, and the

bibliography of primary sources does not include all of the uncollected published material.

Biographies

V. Badikana's *Dr. A.K. Ramanujan*, a short booklet in Kannada, is the lone published biography of AKR.¹⁵ This biographical profile of AKR contains the standard version of his life: the family background, his multilingual upbringing, the highlights of his career in India and the USA as a professor, scholar, writer, and translator, and an overview of his landmark publications in English and Kannada. Besides this sparse account, Bruce King's and Akshaya Kumar's sketches of AKR's life and career in their books are the only biographical notes that go beyond the customary one-page introductions that precede most monographs and critical essays on the poet, or retrospective accounts of his life in tributes to the poet published after his death.¹⁶ The lack of biographical research on AKR could be explained by two circumstances: first, the unexpected passing away of the author at the early age of 64, and second, his living away from India during most of the last 34 years of his life, which made it difficult for any tempted Indian biographer to keep up with personal events. AKR travelled on and off to India (and different parts of the globe), and his academic projects and poetic creativity were shaped both in India and the USA.

Nonetheless, biographical research on the author is an essential prerequisite to contextualize his work and thought within the complex multicultural milieus he was immersed in, and to assess how the evolution of his life and career affected his creative writing. As Perry argues in his review article of *The Oxford India Ramanujan* (2004): 'Biographical research and analysis needs to be done [on AKR] to give further substance to intimations that emerge from memoirs, interviews, and sensitive analysis of his varied activities in writing and otherwise....'¹⁷ Autobiography was, in fact, a vital exercise for AKR, as his mock autobiography, published in 1978 in Kannada as *Matthobhana Atmacharitre* (and posthumously in 2006 translated into English as *Someone Else's Autobiography*),¹⁸ and the numerous unpublished autobiographical charts and sketches in the **(p.6)** AKR Papers corroborate (see Chapter 3).¹⁹ The AKR Papers, kept at the University of Chicago, are an invaluable and indispensable source for biographical research, but any attempt to map AKR's life would need to be complemented with substantial field research in India (Karnataka) besides documentation in Chicago. The chronological Chart 1 at the end of this book, which summarizes the highlights of AKR's life and work, is based largely on information gathered from the AKR Papers and from several interviews with AKR's relatives, friends, and colleagues.

Critical Monographs, Essays, and Articles

Monographs on AKR come under the following categories: academic dissertations, critical texts in the posthumous publications, authored and edited

monographs, essays in non-monographic books and journals, tributes and obituaries, criticism in anthologies of IPE, and review articles.

Academic Dissertations

Barring a few exceptions, most dissertations on AKR were researched in India and were submitted to Indian universities. In the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography, I list several monographic PhD, MPhil, and MA dissertations on AKR, which include G.N. Devy's dissertation (University of Leeds, 1979) and my own dissertations submitted to Loyola College, University of Madras (1997) and the University of Kerala and University of Valladolid (2006). Besides these monographic research works, the inventory includes a handful of PhD dissertations that are either comparative studies contrasting AKR with other Indian poets writing in English, or works that trace a particular theme in the work of several Indian poets including AKR.

Introductions, Prefaces, and Notes in the Posthumous Publications

The posthumous books of AKR's poetry and essays that came out between 1995 and 2006 include introductions, prefaces, and notes on AKR written by the author's family, friends, and former colleagues. Among these secondary sources, the most relevant to the reader and researcher of AKR's poetry are Krittika Ramanujan's preface, Vinay (p.7) Dharwadker's introduction, and Molly Daniels-Ramanujan's note in *The Collected Poems* (1995), Keith Harrison's preface and Daniels-Ramanujan's note in *Uncollected Poems and Prose* (2001), as well as Daniels-Ramanujan's 'An A.K. Ramanujan Story' in *The Oxford India Ramanujan* (2004).²⁰

Single-Authored and Edited Monographs

Monographic studies on AKR published so far include seven authored monographs as well as two edited book collections of critical essays by a host of Indian academics (see the section 'Overview of Critical Approaches' in this chapter). All of these were published by Indian publishing houses specializing in academic literature, but with a limited circulation.

Critical Essays in Non-Monographic Books and Journals

Although there are relatively few monographs on AKR, critical writing on IPE includes numerous comparative studies of several Indian poets, and general studies on IPE, published as essays in single-authored books. I have counted over 40 such publications that include AKR as one of the poets under scrutiny; a selection of these is listed in the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography. Without doubt, the largest corpus of criticism on AKR, however, comprises short articles and essays published in journals or edited non-monographic books on IPE. Over 200 papers, articles, and essays belong to this category, most of them published in India.²¹ With a few exceptions, these articles focus on concrete aspects or themes of AKR's poetry, in particular his poems, translations, and other works.

Tributes and Obituaries in Newspapers and Journals

Soon after his sudden demise in July 1993, many newspapers and journals, mainly in India, published articles in homage to the author, written by colleagues, friends, journalists, and fellow poets. These relate mostly to personal meetings and relationships with the poet and recall miscellaneous events in AKR's life and work, besides portraying him as a multitalented scholar-poet who was very active in a number of fields.

(p.8) Criticism in Anthologies of Indian Poetry in English

The majority of anthologies of post-Independence IPE published since the 1960s include poems by AKR; in these collections, the featured poets are often introduced in short write-ups by the editor. As a pioneer of modern IPE, along with Nissim Ezekiel, Dom Moraes, and a few other 'modernist' poets, AKR was considered part of the canon of post-Independence IPE that was being formed in the 1970s (see discussion in the section 'Evolution of the Critical Scene' in this chapter).

Review Articles of AKR's Publications

A good part of the numerous review articles of AKR's works are discerning assessments of his poetry collections, translations, and prose publications. There are also review articles of the books that were co-authored and co-edited by AKR with other scholars.

Overview of Critical Approaches

It is interesting to note that until the late 1990s, that is, before *The Collected Essays* came out in 1999, AKR was regarded mainly as a poet and translator in India and not as a scholar. On the other hand, he was better known as a translator and essayist in the USA, where relatively little was written on his poetry. That is, AKR's critical status in the USA was due to his academic work and his contributions in the field of oral traditions and the translation of classical and medieval south-Indian poetry in Tamil and Kannada, whereas in India he was studied as a (bilingual) poet at Indian universities and was appraised by a larger public chiefly for his translations of Tamil classics and bhakti poetry, and his collections of folktales.

From the 1960s to the 1980s, prior to a new wave of critical theories entering Western and Indian academia, critical approaches to AKR's poetic work could be said to fall under two broad categories: the modernist and the traditionalist standpoints. The former view was prevalent among the Indian poet-critics and the few Western critics who, during the better part of the 1960s and 1970s, stuck to the modernist credo in their literary tastes. Poets like Nissim Ezekiel, Adil Jussawalla, A.K. Mehrotra, K.N. Daruwalla, and R. Parthasarathy, who wrote critical essays on IPE and AKR and/or edited anthologies **(p.9)** of IPE, contributed thereby to the formation of a canon and to the promotion of modernist poets and poetics in India. They saw AKR as one of the path-breaking

pioneers of IPE (along with Nissim Ezekiel and Dom Moraes), and focused on the form, language, and craftsmanship of his poetry. Following the premises of American New Critics (see the sections 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' and 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7), they foregrounded the tensions within AKR's poems and his use of images, irony, and understatement. Among the major themes in AKR's poetry, these writers often underscored the notions of exile and alienation, and the dilemma of a modern Indian mind in America that quarrels with tradition.

The traditionalists, in turn, discerned in AKR's poetry a search for roots and a strong sense of 'Indianness',²² and viewed him as a poet trying to reconcile himself with the past by embracing tradition and translation. More often than not, however, these two critical positions (modernist and traditionalist) were seen as compatible attitudes, as it was gradually understood that they did not stand in opposition to each other, least so in AKR's work. There were those who perceived the strength of AKR's poetry in his imaginative blend of tradition and modernity, and in his intense preoccupation with translation. Thus, R. Parthasarathy, as a prominent modernist poet himself in the 1970s, highlighted the exquisite craftsmanship and scrupulous concern with language in AKR's poems, while admiring his intelligent absorption of the Tamil tradition in his poetic work. Another modernist poet-critic, A.K. Mehrotra, admitted that AKR's modernism and the translations in fact 'reinforced' each other. Among the critics who proposed a multicultural and/or synthetic perspective to AKR, we can also include comparativist critics like Ayyappa Paniker and K. Chellappan.²³ The panorama of modernist and/or traditionalist critical approaches to AKR's work outlined here reflects, to a large extent, the dialectic of critical paradigms operating in IPE criticism in general from the 1960s to the 1980s.

Eventually, in the 1990s, a host of new theories found way into the Indian critical scene. Most prominently, nativism, postmodernism, postcolonial theory, feminist and environmental criticism made a gradual appearance, and this enriched also the critical scene of AKR's work. The new trends coincided with the posthumous publication of the author's collected poetry and essays, and so the range of critical approaches widened significantly. Indian critics were as much **(p.10)** interested in AKR's modernist attitude as in his Tamil and Kannada heritage, his environmental poetics and folk poetics, his multicultural background, cosmopolitanism, portrayal of women, social concerns, anthropological and philosophical contexts, in the plural or shifting identities and the intercultural criss-crossing in his poetry, and in his theory and practice of translation as a (postcolonial) metaphor of the exiled condition. Postcolonial theory was introduced in India mainly by Western critics and scholars working outside India, and Jahan Ramazani and Rajeev S. Patke, to name but two early examples of such theory-oriented criticism, wrote several papers on AKR with the characteristic outsider-insider perspective of postcolonial scholars. The

principal critical attitudes and thematic paradigms that made up the expanding AKR critical scene from the 1990s can be classified as follows:

1. Thematic studies;
2. Comparative studies;
3. Stylistic and descriptive studies;
4. Environmental, social, and gender studies;
5. Anthropological and folklore studies;
6. Postcolonial and cultural studies;
7. Studies of translations and translation theory (see also the section 'Translation and Poetic Practice' in Chapter 8); and
8. Philosophical approaches.

Notwithstanding these tentative labels, when analysing the confusing state of IPE criticism in the 1990s that allowed for such a rich, pluralistic universe of critical assessments, theories, and practices, one discerning Indian critic stated that there were perhaps 'many competent individual critics ... but no schools (save that of comparative literature) as identifiable units'.²⁴ While recent literary criticism has looked at AKR's aesthetics and poetic theory in correlation with his prose writings, translations, and interviews, as opposed to the abundant thematic studies and formalistic analyses of the poems, even the more ambitious critical works published in the twenty-first century do not follow a systematic approach. There is an absence of methodological criticism in the analyses of AKR's multiple vocations and creative legacy as a poet, translator, and scholar, and no account of the uncollected primary sources that relate to his poetics, including the early published sources (poetry and prose) from the 1950s. What is **(p.11)** also striking is that there has been no published study so far that has drawn material from the miscellaneous unpublished writings which can be publicly accessed by researchers of the AKR Papers archived at the Special Collections Department of the University of Chicago since the mid-1990s. The few serious critical works that elaborate on AKR's poetic theory and practice rely primarily on the collected published poetry and works of translations, and bring into the discussion essays and interviews that appeared in the posthumous collections.

Most of the unpublished dissertations on AKR's poetry are either stylistic analyses or thematic surveys that trace AKR's principal ideas, images, preoccupations, and recurrent identity issues and illustrate how these are made visible in AKR's poetic work. Several dissertations stand out for their perceptive and original analyses. Roomy Naqvy's MPhil dissertation, 'Reconstructions of Time and Space in the Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan' (1996), explores in depth AKR's poetics of 'time and space', where abstract notions are embodied in the fragmentary and momentary reality. Aniruddh Kumar Rawat's PhD dissertation, 'The Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan: A Study in the Light of Indian Poetics' (2009), attempts, as the title indicates, an innovative analysis of aspects of AKR's poetry

from the perspective of classical Sanskrit poetic theories. This dissertation was later published in book form in 2012 (see the section 'A Chronology of Writings on A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry' in this chapter). On the other hand, I pursued a double-fold perspective to AKR's poetics in my MA dissertation, 'A.K. Ramanujan: His Outer and Inner Forms' (1997), where I proposed dissecting a single poem, the puzzling 'Snakes' from *The Striders*, first with the help of stylistics to analyse the poem as a linguistic artefact, and then from a thematic, contextual, and subtextual (or meta-poetic) angle to bring out the contiguity of its 'outer' and 'inner' forms.²⁵ I adopted the 'inner' and 'outer' paradigm within a more complex framework in my PhD dissertation (2006) on the poet which surveyed the AKR Papers and has eventually been transformed into this book.²⁶

A Chronology of Writings on A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry

The earliest critical text in English appeared in 1965 as a review article of AKR's first translations of classical Tamil Sangam poems into English in *Fifteen Poems from a Classical Tamil Anthology* (1965).²⁷ This was followed by reviews of his first poetry collection **(p.12)** in English, *The Striders*, most of which were published in England and/or by Western critics between 1966 and 1967.²⁸ We should not forget that AKR's first poetry books in English—*The Striders* and *Relations*—were not released in India, but by the Oxford University Press head office in London.²⁹ Kannada playwright Girish Karnad, AKR's long-time friend, was, in the early 1960s, working for Oxford University Press in Madras and, as the correspondence in the AKR Papers between AKR, Karnad, and Jon Stallworthy from Oxford University Press London reveals, Karnad proved to be instrumental in getting *The Striders* eventually published in London in 1966, after it was rejected by the Madras office. *The Striders* received a Poetry Book Society recommendation and the poems soon reached the Indian critical shores. After the early reviews of *The Striders*, the first critical articles of AKR's poetry written in English were by Indian critics and were published, around 1969, in Indian literary journals like *Osmania Journal of English Studies* and *Thought*.³⁰ Then in 1972 and 1976 came the poetry anthologies that included AKR among the 'modern' Indian poets writing in English; this made him part of the canon that was being 'established' by such collections:³¹ Saleem Peeradina's *Contemporary Poetry in English: An Assessment and Selection*, published by Macmillan and the landmark anthology *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets*, edited by AKR's poet-friend R. Parthasarathy and published by Oxford University Press. The first more extensive studies of AKR's poetry, authored by A.N. Dwivedi and E.N. Lall did not, however, see the light of day until 1983.³²

Another important milestone was Bruce King's short critical analysis of AKR's poetry in *Modern Indian Poetry in English* (1987), which was later expanded in the oft-quoted *Three Indian Poets* (1991),³³ also published by Oxford University Press India. King analyses AKR from a chronological perspective and divides his poetry into three phases: '1957–1976', '*Second Sight*', and '*Last Poems*'. He is sensitive to the importance of 'traditional India', that is, classical Hindu thought,

classical and medieval Tamil poetry, and Kannada bhakti in AKR's poetry, while he is also one of the few critics who insist on the diverse Western influences (Keats, Yeats, Carlos Williams, Pound, Eliot, and others) in his poetics and who have researched the uncollected early poems published in *Quest, Thought*, and *Illustrated Weekly* in the late 1950s. Though King does not examine AKR's aesthetic thought and poetics in this book, his strength lies in his balanced judgement and perceptive analysis when discussing particular nuances in AKR's **(p.13)** poems, including the meta-poems that deal with art, the origin of creativity, and the poetic process.³⁴

Following the publication in critical books of these early analyses of AKR's poetry, it is important to mention a few path-breaking essays by scholars who contributed to the growing critical scene with broader postcolonial, intertextual, metaphorical, and metonymical interpretations of AKR's poetics. Vinay Dharwadker's well-known 'Introduction' to *The Collected Poems* (1995) delineated a framework of coextensive layers to discuss AKR's poetics, which sparked new reactions from academics who had to rethink their binary approach (East/West, tradition/modernity) to AKR's poetry. Dharwadker stressed as a recurrent concern in AKR 'the nature of the human body and its relation to the natural world ... which leads to a concern with natural processes in general and the more abstract issues concerning time'. To illustrate the 'metonymic' model of AKR's poetics, Dharwadker uses the image of concentric circles in which the author's 'impersonal' social poems coexist with the personal poems of family and relationships, and ultimately with the poems on the individual particulars of the self and the body. Thus, Dharwadker argues, AKR's poetry evinces an integrity that negotiates 'between body and mind, nature and cultural, and history and contemporaneity'.³⁵ A few years later, American scholar Jahan Ramazani exploited in the essay 'Metaphor and Postcoloniality: A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry' (1998) the semantic connotations of the concept of 'translation', which serves as a metaphor of the postcolonial discourse of displacement, transfer, and dislocation, and provides a frame for intertextual discussion and multiple transfers in AKR's poetry (Eastern and Western cultures, past and present, the self and the private, national and transnational).³⁶ In another postcolonial essay titled 'The Ambivalence of Poetic Self-Exile: The Case of A.K. Ramanujan' (2001), Rajeev S. Patke, too, wrote on AKR's 'diasporic condition as a form of translation'. Following a similar 'translational' argument, he stated that 'both diaspora and translation may be said to be metaphors for poetry'.³⁷

It was only from the mid-1990s that the first full-fledged monographs on AKR were published, when the poet was no more and when the posthumous collections of his poetry, essays, uncollected poetry and prose, and other works had opened new vistas on his multidisciplinary work that triggered fresh critical responses in India. All monographic books on AKR were published after 1995 and by **(p.14)** publishing houses from India. The first book-length monograph on AKR was A.N. Dwivedi's *The Poetic Art of A.K. Ramanujan* (1995). Though

released by B.R. Publishers in the same year *The Collected Poems* came out, this study draws largely on Dwivedi's earlier critical writings from the 1980s. He therefore pursues in his work the rather outdated standard approach to AKR's poetry that was typical of Indian critics at the time. As Dwivedi admits in the conclusion of his book, he aimed at examining the 'theme and form' of AKR's poetry collections and evaluating his relevance and 'Indianness' as an Indian poet writing in English.³⁸ This work was subsequently followed by other monographs that gradually emerged on the critical scene: Kirpal Singh's *A.K. Ramanujan: The Poet* (1999) published by Vrinda Publications as part of their 'Literature Series' was meant as an introduction to the poet for students and lacks critical depth.³⁹ Surya Nath Pandey's edited collection of essays *Millennium Perspectives on A.K. Ramanujan* (2001) brought out by Atlantic Publishers does not have an organizational structure, but nevertheless contains several thought-provoking papers on diverse critical aspects relating to AKR's poetics by Surya Nath Pandey, D. Ramakrishna, Niranjana Mohanty, and R.K. Desai, to mention a few of its 14 contributors. The introduction by Pandey titled 'The Axis of Ramanujan's Cultural Preoccupations' points out 'the complex configurations of tensions that sustain his poetic universe'. Drawing from AKR's statements in his essays, Pandey underscores his hyphenated condition between East and West, and the interaction of his poetry with the Tamil and Kannada poetic traditions he translated. He also considers the introduction to *Speaking of Siva*, his book of translations from Kannada of medieval vachana poetry, to be AKR's 'poetic manifesto'.⁴⁰ Likewise, the book's opening paper by D. Ramakrishna defines 'Ramanujan's credo' as a synthesis of his 'varied concerns', which displays 'continuity from tradition to modernity, a continuity between his poetry, translation, and scholarship'. On the other hand, Niranjana Mohanty's paper on 'The Points of Return: Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan' is 'an attempt to critically examine the aesthetic configurations' in AKR's poetry. Inspired by Dharwadkar's introductory essay to *The Collected Poems*, Mohanty illustrates in several charts the 'concentric circles' of AKR, with the self at the centre and the various environments at the periphery. After explaining how a strong sense of history ('personal, social or cultural, and linguistic') moulds AKR's aesthetic and poetic 'vision', which is made up of the inescapable 'points of return ... history, (p.15) family, myth and the self', the critic analyses several of AKR's poems to substantiate this theoretical model. Another interesting essay in this volume is R.N. Desai's 'The Negotiation of Art and Life in A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry'. Desai takes AKR's self-reflexivity as a starting point to assess the writer's aesthetic ideas. He scrutinizes several of the meta-poems on art and poetic creativity to demonstrate how they embody the poet's 'creative process' and 'negotiation of art and life', as the title of the paper indicates.

A year after *Millennium Perspectives*, Atlantic Publishers brought out another collection of 14 papers on AKR with the simple title *The Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan* (2002), edited by M.K. Bhatnagar.⁴¹ This book again does not offer

any framework or structure and is a miscellaneous assortment of old and newer essays on AKR, four of which are reprinted from the earlier monograph by the same publisher (papers by Mohanty, D. Ramakrishna, Premila Paul, and S. Armstrong). The result is an incoherent collection of irregular quality that does not throw much additional light on AKR's aesthetic and poetic ideas.

Rama Nair's *'Of Variegated Hues': The Poetry and Translations of A.K. Ramanujan* (2002) produced by Prestige Books sought to be the first extended study to connect AKR's translation volumes with his poetry in English. But her comparative study of the traditional poetics and modern poems occupies, in fact, only one chapter in her book, and though this piece identifies some of the interrelations and key thematic and formal parameters that bind the poetics of Tamil and bhakti poetry to some of AKR's poems, the overall analysis, for lack of critical rigour and thoroughness, remains at the surface of things.

In Sumana Ghosh's *A.K. Ramanujan as a Poet* (2004) published by Jaipur Book Enclave, the academic critic aims to offer 'a presentation of the essential features of Ramanujan's poems', and runs through some of the major themes as well as the craft and imagery of AKR's poetry, as exemplified in the poems and backed up by other critics' comments.⁴² There is, however, no attempt to trace AKR's poetics through the meta-poetic compositions or by exploiting the essays or interviews, which, unfortunately, have no space in this study.

In contrast to the latter work, Akshaya Kumar's *A.K. Ramanujan: In Profile and Fragment* (2004), published the same year by Rawat Publications, is one of the more imaginative monographs on AKR. The book is perhaps the first serious contribution to the intertextual and meta-poetic interpretation of AKR's poetry and offers a description **(p.16)** of his poetics with detailed examples. Kumar adapted, for this book, several of his earlier papers on the poet and tried to organize his material in a coherent form. At the centre of this study lies the 'cultural poetics' of AKR as seen from the perspective of postcolonial theory. Kumar perceives AKR's poems as cultural artefacts 'in which the various texts of culture collide and collude, generate intertextual topologies that no systematic analysis can plausibly paraphrase or account for'. The book is structured in four parts: 'I. Locations', 'II Inter-Textualities', 'III Politics', and 'IV Poetics'. In the chapter devoted to poetics, Kumar looks at 'parody', 'meta-poetry', and 're-forms' as the fundamental paradigms of AKR's poetics. He gives enough weight to the traditional south-Indian poetic conventions and techniques that were absorbed into AKR's own poems, in order to illustrate how the various classical, regional, and Western traditions conjoin in AKR's poetry in 'a frame which is inevitably self-reflexive, dialogic and inter-civilizational', as mentioned on the flap of the book's jacket. Yet despite this attractive metalanguage, the strong theoretical moorings of Kumar's analysis and his careful research of the published essays and translations, he does not systematize AKR's poetics in this study. Nor does the book contextualize the author's poetics within his personal

aesthetic universe, rather than within a cultural dynamics that does not expose the poet's inner core.⁴³

Saranga Dhar Baral's *The Verse and Vision of A.K. Ramanujan* (2008) published by Sarup and Sons contains six chapters that perhaps promise more than they can deliver, as the author hoped to 'clarify' (to himself or to the reader?) and 'visualise better' some of his 'early perception' of the poet 'in proper perspective'.⁴⁴ Baral's examination thus tries to revisit his earlier research work carried out in the late 1980s on the concepts of tradition, alienation, love, and self-search in AKR (revised in chapters 1–4 in the light of AKR's collected poems and essays), combined with poststructuralist, intertextual, and postcolonial perspectives brought into full play rather disorderly in chapter 5, 'Yet Another View of Ramanujan's Aesthetics'. The most thought-provoking critical contribution comes in chapter 6, 'A Second Sight at the First Common Pools', where Baral tackles AKR's existential anxiety and natural fears with notions from Buddhist phenomenology, a topic which Baral later developed in another essay published in 2012.⁴⁵

Another monographic book on AKR is Santanu Banerjee's *A.K. Ramanujan's Poetic Theory and Practice* (2009) brought out by **(p.17)** Sunrise Publications and based on a doctoral dissertation.⁴⁶ It is, after Akshaya Kumar's *In Profile and Fragment* (2004), arguably the most elaborate attempt to carve out a poetic theory for AKR out of the assortment of published prose and poetry texts, translations, and available interviews, all of which the critic wishes to relate to AKR's poetic practice. In the preface, the author claims that 'for the first time the original poems of Ramanujan in English and Kannada are read in the light of the personal poetics located in his various essays, interviews and chiefly the long forewords and afterwords to his volumes of translations'. The critic at first does not clarify that by 'poems in Kannada' he means the collections of poems translated into English by the editors and translators of *Poems and a Novella* (2006). As Banerjee explains, the book 'follows a definite scheme' contained in its six chapters. Chapter 1 is an introduction to the poet's private and professional background and to the critical responses his poetry received. Chapter 2 provides an outline of AKR's professional disciplines and preoccupations as a translator and scholar of folklore and Dravidian literature in Tamil and Kannada. The crucial chapter 3 is an approach to the author's 'personal poetics' based on the published prose, the meta-poems, and the interviews. It falls short, however, of formulating AKR's 'poetic theory' in a structured manner, as such a personal 'theory' gets drowned in the miscellaneous poems, translations, and other quoted sources it could have surfaced from. The critic simply concludes that 'his poetic theory, if it be so called, surely derives from all these multiple sources'. Then, in chapters 4 and 5, the scholar 'seeks to attempt a textual analysis' of AKR's poems by dividing them, on the basis of classical Tamil poetic categories, into *Akam* poems (on love and 'interior' memories) and *Puram* poems (on 'more expansive' public matters

such as history or politics). In chapter 6, the final piece, Banerjee struggles to sum up AKR's principal ideas that were outlined in the previous chapters.⁴⁷

The latest monograph on AKR is Aniruddh Rawat's *Episteme of Desire: The Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan* (2012), published by Adhyayan Publishers and Distributors. This book, a PhD dissertation submitted to Bundelkhand University, Jhansi, in 2009, is a study of AKR's verse 'in the light of Indian Poetics'. More precisely, the author's aim is to use Sanskrit poetic theories (*rasa*, *dhvani*, *vakrokti*, *alamkara*, etc.) to analyse the 'objectivization' and 'symbolization' of AKR's poetry. The introduction and chapter 2 offer the standard version of AKR as a poet who is rooted in the Indian past (tradition, memory, etc.), yet is **(p.18)** modernist in expression. Chapter 3 applies the notion of *rasa-dhvani* (suggestive of an aesthetic emotion) to explain the evocation of poetic imagination in AKR's work, while chapter 4 delves into its linguistic and semantic properties relying on concepts such as *sphota* (literally, 'to burst') from Sanskrit semantics. Chapter 5 is devoted to *vakrokti* (deviation) in AKR's poetry in order to prove how AKR seeks to 'transpersonalize human emotion', and the final chapter focuses on the poet's rich use of imagery. While this is the first time an extensive effort has been made to apply the major Sanskrit poetic theories to AKR's work, the numerous poems that are quoted are not analysed in depth. This is, on the whole, a pioneering and ambitious project, but Rawat seems incapable of testing the Sanskrit theories in a technical and systematic manner in the poetry that is included. It would perhaps have been wiser to choose only a few poems to illustrate in detail how Sanskrit concepts can illuminate our reading of AKR's verse with different critical tools from the standard Western theories. The end result provides only a limited perspective of AKR's poetic imagination and practice in a book that leaves out comparisons with most Western literary theories (except for T.S. Eliot) and all the other Indian traditions of poetics that AKR was immersed in: classical Tamil, medieval bhakti, and oral and folk aesthetics.⁴⁸

In conclusion, the more incisive critical output on AKR was produced first by US scholars and/or Indian scholars living in the diaspora such as Bruce King, Jahan Ramazani, Vinay Dharwadker, and Rajeev S. Patke, followed by Anjali Nerlekar, Ashok Bery, and others.⁴⁹ They belong to a breed of critics who are well-versed in postmodern theory and actively participate in postcolonial discourse. With their critical acumen, they have paved the way for further poststructuralist/postcolonial studies and translation studies on AKR taken up by academics working at Indian universities such as Akshaya Kumar and Santanu Banerjee.

Now that the author's posthumous publications (essays, tales, translations, and poetry in English, and poetry and fiction in Kannada) have allowed the larger contours of AKR's 'poetic theory' to be drawn through the prism of diverse critical tools, theories, and practices, running parallel to the recognition of his lasting influence in several branches of academia, yet another angle of the

‘critical scene’ of A.K. Ramanujan’s poetics might be sought—one that will take a closer look at the ‘small print’ of AKR’s legacy, while widening the academic horizon with indispensable research on the vast pool of primary **(p.19)** sources, that is, the writer’s extant unpublished Papers. Among the most recent writings on AKR is the insightful essay ‘Reading the Small Print: The Literary Legacy of an Indian Modernist’ (2013)⁵⁰ by the young scholar Nakul Krishna, which guides us through the small and big achievements of AKR’s life and career aided by excerpts from his private notes and letters found in the AKR Papers. Krishna presents a refreshing portrait of an Indian poet and scholar living between India and the USA, one of the finest the twentieth century has produced. Quite surprisingly this essay was, 20 years after AKR’s passing, still the only piece of critical analysis to have mentioned the AKR Papers that have been lying dormant at the Regenstein Library of the University of Chicago for too long.

Notes:

- (1.) See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography at the end of the book.
- (2.) Bruce King’s letter to Surya Nath Pandey written in August 1993, in Surya Nath Pandey (ed.), *Millennium Perspectives on A.K. Ramanujan* (New Delhi: Atlantic Publishers, 2001), p. 167.
- (3.) Bruce King, *Three Indian Poets: Nissim Ezekiel, A.K. Ramanujan, and Dom Moraes* (London: Oxford University Press, 1991), p. 18. Second revised edition in 2005.
- (4.) See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography that lists all of AKR’s publications, including the posthumous collections and uncollected works.
- (5.) Except for Stuart Blackburn and Alan Dundes (eds), *A Flowering Tree and Other Oral Tales from India* (hereafter: *FT*) (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1997; and New Delhi: Penguin Books, 1997), all other posthumous collections were brought out by Oxford University Press. See also the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography.
- (6.) Bruce King, *Modern Indian Poetry in English* (London: Oxford University Press, 1987), p. 294. Second revised edition in 2001.
- (7.) John Oliver Perry, ‘The Integrity of A.K. Ramanujan’s Poetry’, *Kavya Bharati*, vol. 16 (2004), p. 87. Perry refers here to an interview that I transcribed and edited from an audiotape that Ayyappa Paniker gave to me in Trivandrum in the late 1990s. Guillermo Rodríguez, ‘Afterwords: Ayyappa Paniker in Conversation with A.K. Ramanujan (Chicago, 1982)’, *Journal of Literature and Aesthetics*, vol. 2, no. 1 (January–June 2002), pp. 139–50. K. Satchidanandan, then editor of the journal *Indian Literature* (Sahitya Akademi), published this interview in 2009 with the same title, text, and notes without crediting the earlier publication and editorial work. He placed the following editor’s note under the title of the

interview: 'A.K. Ramanujan and Ayyappa Paniker, two of our eminent scholars are both no more. This significant conversation as far as we know, was held in Chicago in 1982, is [sic] being published for the first time.' See *Indian Literature*, vol. 254 (November-December 2009), pp. 171-87.

(8.) In an earlier dissertation, I have dealt extensively with the role that anthologies of IPE played in the process of canon-making: Guillermo Rodríguez, 'Post-Independence Indian Poetry in English: The Critical Scene from the 1950s to the Present', MA dissertation (Spain: Departamento de Filología Inglesa, Universidad de Valladolid, 2000). Sections of this dissertation were published in Guillermo Rodríguez, 'Modern Indian Poetry in English: Some Critical Issues', in Murali Sivaramakrishnan (ed.), *Image and Culture: The Dynamics of Literary, Aesthetic and Cultural Representation* (New Delhi: Atlantic Publishers, 2011), pp. 73-86. See also Rajeev S. Patke, 'Canons and Canon-Making in Indian Poetry in English', *Kavya Bharati*, vol. 3 (1991), pp. 13-37 and 'Once More unto the Canon or Rebottling Indian Poetry in English', *Kavya Bharati*, vol. 5 (1993), pp. 13-28.

(9.) I am not counting here *Selected Poems* (1976).

(10.) For cultural, anthropological, and philosophical studies of AKR's essays, see the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography.

(11.) The bibliography compiled in my PhD dissertation on the author includes a comprehensive list of critical writings on AKR until the year 2006. Guillermo Rodríguez, 'A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography', in 'The Aesthetic and Poetic Thought of A.K. Ramanujan: A Systematic Study of His Published Writings and the Unpublished A.K. Ramanujan Papers', PhD dissertation (Kerala: Department of English, University College, University of Kerala; and Spain: Departamento de Filología Inglesa, Universidad de Valladolid, 2006), pp. 503-68.

(12.) Sumana Ghosh, 'Selected Bibliography', in *A.K. Ramanujan as a Poet* (Jaipur: Book Enclave, 2004), pp. 192-206.

(13.) Vishwanatha Badikana, 'Bibliography', in *Dr. A.K. Ramanujan* (a biography in Kannada) (Hampi: Kannada University, 1995), pp. 24-8.

(14.) Surya Nath Pandey (ed.), 'Annotated Bibliography', in *Millennium Perspectives on A.K. Ramanujan*, pp. 169-86.

(15.) Badikana, *Dr. A.K. Ramanujan*, pp. i-viii, 1-23.

(16.) See King, *Three Indian Poets*, pp. 13-19; and Akshaya Kumar, *A.K. Ramanujan: In Profile and Fragment* (Jaipur and New Delhi: Rawat Publications, 2004), pp. 10-13.

(17.) Perry, 'The Integrity of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry', p. 88.

(18.) A.K. Ramanujan, *Matthobhana Atmcharitre* (Dharwad: Manohara Grantha Mala, 1978). Published in English as *Someone Else's Autobiography*, in Tonse N.K. Raju and Shouri Daniels-Ramanujan (trans) and Prithvi Datta Chandra Shobhi (advisory ed.), *A.K. Ramanujan: Poems and a Novella* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2006), pp. 214-323.

(19.) Had AKR lived longer he might have published, sooner or later, a pseudo-autobiography in English. See the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2.

(20.) Besides these contributions to poetry books, there is also the preface to AKR's Kannada folktale collection by his colleagues Stuart Blackburn and Alan Dundes, and the introductions to the different sections in *The Collected Essays of A.K. Ramanujan* (hereafter: *CE*) by Dharwadker, Milton B. Singer, Edwards C. Dimock and Krishna Ramanujan, Wendy Doniger and John B. Carman, and Blackburn and Dundes. See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for a comprehensive list of these valuable secondary sources.

(21.) The A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography in this book can accommodate only a selection of such critical essays.

(22.) In the 1970s, Indian poet-critic-anthologists (often all three in one) of poetry in English, out of their need to assert a still vulnerable identity, also focused on the 'Indianness' of *Indian* poetry in English as a thematic factor to be combined (sometimes paradoxically) with the modernist treatment of Indian content in style and form. 'Indianness' became the criterion to look for in Indian poetry written in English language and emerged as the main issue in many critical arguments of the 1970s and 1980s. As part of this shift of attitude, the term 'Indian' ceased to be merely a prefix as in 'Indo-Anglian' and 'Indo-English' or a qualifier as in 'Indian English', but came to the foreground of critical discourse as *Indian* poetry in English.

(23.) See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for critical works by the poets and scholars cited here.

(24.) Madhusudan Pati, 'The Indian Critical Scene: A Question of Sincerity and Authenticity', *Indian Literature*, vol. 160 (March-April 1994), p. 58.

(25.) See Roomy Naqvy, 'Reconstructions of Time and Space in the Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan', MPhil dissertation (New Delhi: Department of English and Modern European Languages, Jamia Millia Islamia, 1996); Aniruddh Kumar Rawat, 'The Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan: A Study in the Light of Indian Poetics', PhD dissertation (Jhansi: Department of English, Bundelkhand University, 2009); and Guillermo Rodríguez, 'A.K. Ramanujan: His Outer and Inner Forms', MA

dissertation (Madras: Department of English, Loyola College, University of Madras, 1997).

(26.) Rodríguez, 'The Aesthetic and Poetic Thought of A.K. Ramanujan'.

(27.) M. Rama Rao, *The Literary Criterion*, vol. 6, no. 4 (Summer 1965), pp. 108–9, review of AKR's *Fifteen Poems from a Classical Tamil Anthology* (1965).

(28.) See Y.S. Bains, *Literatures East and West*, vol. 2, no. 1 (March 1967), p. 72; Hugh Barker, 'Explorations', *Nonesuch* (Summer–Autumn 1966), pp. 33–4; R.P. Hewett, *A Choice of Poets* (London: Harrap, 1969), n.p.; Kevin Ireland, *Journal of Commonwealth Literature*, vol. 4 (December 1967), pp. 141–2; Burton Raffel, *Mahfil*, vol. 3, nos 2–3 (1966), pp. 85–8; Elizabeth Reuben, *The Indian P.E.N.*, vol. 33, no. 3 (March 1967), pp. 96–8; M.L. Rosenthal, *Poets East and West* (n.d.), n.p.; and Harriet Zinnes, *Prairie Schooner*, vol. 41, no. 3 (1967), p. 353.

(29.) See also Anjali Nerlekar, 'Adarallu Idu: Girish Karnad Talks about A.K. Ramanujan and His Own Dramaturgy', *South Asian Review*, vol. 26, no. 2 (2005), pp. 217–36.

(30.) See, for example, Satyanarayanan Singh, 'Ramanujan and Ezekiel', *Osmania Journal of English Studies*, vol. 7, no. 1 (1969), pp. 65–75; and Y.N. Vaish, 'A.K. Ramanujan: Escapist?' *Thought* (21 June 1969), pp. 14–15.

(31.) See R. Parthasarathy (ed.), 'Introduction' and 'A.K. Ramanujan', in *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1976), pp. 9, 95–6. The earlier anthology that had selected, out of the pool of English-language Indian poets of the post-Independence period only those who followed a modernist, New Critical aesthetics, among them AKR, was Saleem Peeradina (ed.), *Contemporary Poetry in English: An Assessment and Selection* (Bombay: Macmillan, 1972). This anthology was a reaction to a much more indiscriminate, inclusive anthology: P. Lal (ed.), *Modern Indian Poetry in English: An Anthology and a Credo* (Calcutta: Writers Workshop, 1969).

(32.) A.N. Dwivedi, *A.K. Ramanujan and His Poetry*, pamphlet (New Delhi: Doaba House, 1983); and E.N. Lall, *The Poetry of Encounter: Three Indo-Anglian Poets—Moraes, Ramanujan, Ezekiel* (New Delhi: Sterling, 1983), pp. 43–63.

(33.) King's analysis in this book coincides with his overview of the poet in *Modern Indian Poetry in English*, published for the first time in 1987.

(34.) King, *Three Indian Poets*, pp. 13–19, 71–92, 93–116, 117–35. Another critic who has produced insightful studies of some of AKR's meta-poems is Roomy Naqvy. See Roomy Naqvy, 'The Language of Silence: An Analysis of A.K. Ramanujan's "On the Death of a Poem"', *Revaluations*, vol. 1, no. 3 (1995), pp.

75-9 and 'A Poetics of Space', *Indian Literature*, vol. 173 (May-June 1996), pp. 145-6.

(35.) Vinay Dharwadker (ed.), 'Introduction', in *CP*, pp. xviii, xxiii, xxxviii; rpt in 1997 and 2011.

(36.) Jahan Ramazani, 'Metaphor and Postcoloniality: The Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan', *Contemporary Literature*, vol. 39, no. 1 (Spring 1998), pp. 27-53.

(37.) Rajeev S. Patke, 'The Ambivalence of Poetic Self-Exile: The Case of A.K. Ramanujan', *Jouvert: A Journal of Postcolonial Studies*, vol. 5, no. 2 (Winter 2001), <http://english.chass.ncsu.edu/jouvert/v5i2/rspatk.htm> (accessed 15 April 2003).

(38.) A.N. Dwivedi, *The Poetic Art of A.K. Ramanujan* (New Delhi: B.R. Publications, 1995), p. 145.

(39.) Kirpal Singh, *A.K. Ramanujan: The Poet* (New Delhi: Vrinda Publications, 1999).

(40.) Surya Nath Pandey, 'Introduction: The Axis of Ramanujan's Cultural Preoccupations', D. Ramakrishna, 'Ramanujan's Credo', Niranjana Mohanty, 'The Points of Return: Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan', and R.N. Desai, 'The Negotiation of Art and Life in A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry', in Surya Nath Pandey (ed.), *Millennium Perspectives on A.K. Ramanujan*, pp. xi-xii, 7, 36-9, 67-75.

(41.) M.K. Bhatnagar (ed.), *The Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan* (New Delhi: Atlantic Publishers, 2002).

(42.) Sumana Ghosh, 'Preface', in *A.K. Ramanujan as a Poet*, p. v.

(43.) Kumar, *A.K. Ramanujan*, cover, pp. 1, 187-239.

(44.) Saranga Dhar Baral, *The Verse and Vision of A.K. Ramanujan* (New Delhi: Sarup and Sons, 2008), p. vii.

(45.) See Saranga Dhar Baral, 'Buddhist Normatives and A.K. Ramanujan's Radicalism', *Labyrinth*, vol. 3, no. 4 (October 2012), pp. 173-83.

(46.) Santanu Banerjee, 'A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry, Translations and Poetic Theory', PhD dissertation (Banaras: Banaras Hindu University, 2007).

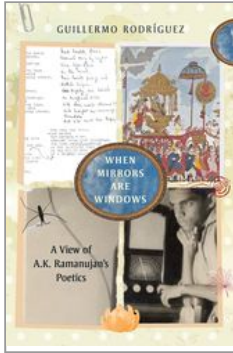
(47.) Santanu Banerjee, *A.K. Ramanujan's Poetic Theory and Practice* (New Delhi: Sunrise Publications, 2009), pp. xi-xii, 94, 96, 134.

(48.) Aniruddh Rawat, *Episteme of Desire: The Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan* (New Delhi: Adhyayan Publishers and Distributors, 2012).

(49.) See Anjali Nerlekar, 'Of Mothers, Among Other Things: The Source of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry', *Wasafiri*, vol. 38 (Spring 2003), pp. 49-53, and 'Converting Past Time into Present Space: A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry (1929-1993)', in Smita Agarwal (ed.), *Marginalized: Indian Poetry in English* (Amsterdam and New York: Rodopi, 2014), pp. 127-50; and Ashok Bery, "'Reflexive Worlds': The Indias of A.K. Ramanujan", in Peter Morey and Alex Tickell (eds), *Alternative Indias: Writing, Nation and Communalism* (Amsterdam and New York: Rodopi, 2005), pp. 115-40.

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When Mirrors Are Windows: A View of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics

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Watching the Birds and the Watcher

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Abstract and Keywords

This chapter provides a cultural contextualization and assesses native or context-sensitive paradigms as valid tools to systematize Ramanujan's aesthetic and poetic universe. It analyses the adoption of a tripartite model in Indian literary criticism, comprising the *marga* (pan-Indian Sanskritic), *desi* (regional), and *videshi* (foreign) elements, and questions whether this distinction serves to articulate contemporary Indian poetry in English as well as Ramanujan's own thought. Ramanujan reinterpreted this model in innovative ways in the study of classical, medieval, oral, and contemporary Indian literary traditions, and introduced as alternative models of literature, most prominently the *Akam/Puram* concentric notions from Tamil poetics, the mother-tongue/father-tongue distinction, and the concepts of context-sensitivity and reflexivity. The last section of this chapter furnishes a brief survey of the diverse aesthetic traditions that Ramanujan was steeped in, ranging from Western aesthetics to Sanskrit aesthetics, medieval bhakti, and classical Tamil tradition.

Keywords: Indian cultural studies, postcolonial studies, Indian literary history, literary criticism, metacriticism, Indian aesthetics, Sanskrit aesthetics, medieval bhakti poetry, Tamil poetics

Questions

*Two birds on the selfsame tree:
one of them eats the fruit of the tree,
the other watches without eating.*

—Mundaka, 3.1.1*

(Multi)cultural Contextualization

How should one approach AKR—as a scholar or as a contemporary Indian poet writing in English? While he was recognized as a reputed academic scholar and translator in the USA, AKR was better known in India as a multilingual poet (in English and to a less extent in Kannada) and translator (from Kannada and Tamil into English). Before attempting to provide a framework to analyse the aesthetics and poetics of an Indian author who writes in English and in Indian languages and displays a multicultural intellectual background, several critical issues inevitably need to be raised. A study of this kind requires a contextualization of terms such as ‘art’ and ‘beauty’, and a qualification of binary oppositions such as ‘Western’ versus ‘Indian’ aesthetics or ‘classical’ versus ‘folk’ literature within a particular (p.25) culture. It also entails the use of a specific metalanguage derived from the aesthetic and poetic tradition in question. In his own attempt at cultural contextualization, AKR observed: ‘[O]ne inevitably sees a culture or literature through what we bring to it, especially through this metalanguage that half perceives and half creates what we see. We become aware of it when we watch ourselves watching, or better still, when we watch other watchers.’¹ That is, we need to consider whether and when certain critical concepts work as universals. If presented in a particular context or attached to a particular tradition, period, and culture, we may look for relativistic elements and opt for a terminology that is context-specific or, in AKR’s words, ‘context-sensitive’ to a particular culture or author.²

AKR was at home in multiple traditions, which formed a many-branched tree. His intellectual appetite was insatiable, wide-ranging, and miscellaneous, thus his creativity drew from multifarious sources. What immediately stands out in an assessment of the author’s published works as well as of the unpublished and private writings³ is that his creative output and the vast material scrutinized cannot be confined to a single system of thought, nor properly defined by broad categories such as ‘Western’ or ‘Indian’. Consequently, any critical analysis of AKR’s poetics needs to accommodate the specificity of the cultural systems that inform his heterogeneous body of writings. In the field of IPE and its criticism, the question of cultural contextualization and related issues has been debated with particular intensity over the last few decades. The present critical situation has outgrown the simplistic view of an East-West cultural encounter or synthesis that has been posited by many intellectuals since the nineteenth century. A brief description of the critical framework in IPE studies and its evolution in the twentieth century is therefore in place here.

The dilemma of whether and to what extent aesthetic and poetic theories and critical concepts ‘imported’ from the West are adequate for critical practice in IPE studies has long been grappled with. As is the case with indigenous literary critics of other so-called ‘postcolonial literatures in English’, Indian critics have tried several ways out of this predicament, sometimes even going as far as denouncing, in the wake of the post-structuralist flourishing of the 1980s, the

neocolonial 'invasion of theory'.⁴ The idiosyncrasies of India, with its treasure house of literary traditions, make for a complex situation in contemporary Indian literary studies. In fact, ancient classical Sanskrit theories provided the starting point for an alternative aesthetics and poetics **(p.26)** during the so-called 'Indian Renaissance' in the nineteenth century. In the field of literature and the arts, the most renowned exponents of this critical endeavour in the early twentieth century were the Ceylon-born philosopher and art scholar Ananda K. Coomaraswamy (1877-1947) and two Bengali writers, Aurobindo Ghose (1872-1950), a poet and literary critic who wrote in English and turned into a spiritual guru, and Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941), prolific writer in Bengali, as well as an educationist, composer, and painter.⁵

Later in the postcolonial context, the strong resistance by Indian intellectuals and critics, particularly in the 1980s, against the onslaught of Western (mainly Anglo-French) theory,⁶ led to the reformulation of theories propounding a contemporary 'indigenous' aesthetics and poetics applicable to all modern Indian literatures including IPE. Notorious among these unifying theories were the long-standing attempts by Krishna Rayan (1972, 1987, 1988, 1991) and Krishna Chaitanya (1965, 1987) to revive classical Sanskrit poetic theories such as *rasa*, *dhvani*, *aucitya*, *vakrokti*, etc., and the advent of more 'exotic' theories such as Charu Sheel Singh's mandala theory. At the same time, there was also a significant effort by the Dhvanyaloka Centre for Indian Studies in Mysore, headed by C.D. Narasimhaiah, to construct *A Common Poetic for Indian Literatures* (1984) through an evaluation and combination of Indian (mainly Sanskrit) and Western aesthetics and poetics. Along the same lines, the critic and poet V.K. Gokak, also highly influenced by Sanskrit theory, published in 1989 his lifelong search for *Pathways to the Unity of Indian Literature*.⁷

Other scholars proposing comparativist and multicultural viewpoints in IPE studies as, for example, south-Indian poet-scholar Ayyappa Paniker and American critic John Oliver Perry, cautioned that there was a danger in resuscitating unifying theories based on Sanskrit poetics, such as the *rasa-dhvani* theory advocated by Rayan and others for contemporary criticism. Attempts of that kind, according to these rather eclectic critics, were prone to proclaim a pan-Indian status and assert a centrist Hindu critical position and a homogenizing 'Indianness' by promoting Sanskrit aesthetics and poetics as the only valid 'Indian' tradition.⁸ Paniker and Perry maintained that the actual effectiveness of Sanskrit theory in IPE criticism and its scope of application were rather limited in a multicultural environment. It should not be forgotten that the ancient and traditionally esoteric Sanskrit language, as well as Sanskrit philosophy and aesthetic theories, have always been linked to the established Brahminical **(p.27)** power structures, so there may have been additional reasons for some critics of IPE to perpetuate this privileged position.

Likewise, there was an increasing interest from the 1970s in promoting Indian regional aesthetics and poetics for the study of Indian poets writing in English, particularly those theories which belong to strong autochthonous literary traditions that evolved parallel to the Sanskrit schools or theories, such as classical Tamil poetics. This development was partly a response by a section of south-Indian critics to the traditional dominance of Sanskrit theory over Dravidian theories, and reflected their desire to provide an alternative indigenous critical framework. Among the south-Indian literary scholars living in India, English-literature professors K. Chellapan and Ayyappa Paniker (contemporaries of AKR) promoted classical Tamil poetics in comparative studies and as a sophisticated aesthetic theory applicable to certain Indian poets writing in English.⁹ At a wider cultural and literary scale, the pioneering essays and translations of AKR, himself a south-Indian scholar and professor of English in India in the early years of his career, are further examples of a lifetime commitment to Dravidian literature and aesthetics.

In 1992, John Oliver Perry, in his ground-breaking meta-critical work *Absent Authority*, analysed in detail the complexities arising out of combining 'Indigenous and Western criticism for Indian English Poetry', and surveyed the various paths chosen by a number of Indian and non-Indian critics since the 1950s. Perry's own position stresses a multicultural contextualization of IPE that accommodates its indigenous idiosyncrasies. By 'indigenous' he understands a wide continuum of Indian literary and critical traditions as well as those Western theories that have been imported, assimilated, and reformulated by Indian critics thus 'indigenized' or 'adapted to indigenous issues and cultural circumstances'.¹⁰ Against the prevalence of Western critical theories, he proclaimed that 'the need is here and now for a complex critical perspective that emerges from foregrounding Indian English poetry in its very specialised indigenous cultural context against a background of other Indian literatures, each with its peculiarities and commonalities'.¹¹

The cultural contextualization and its complexity alluded to by Perry in his evaluation of the critical scene of IPE are defining factors in the appraisal of the aesthetics and poetics of Indian poets writing in English. This observation concurs with AKR's attentiveness to context in literary and cultural studies and to his explication of Indian poetry **(p.28)** as a network of traditions in dialogue with each other. The present analysis thus responds to the conviction that the multicultural complexity of Indian literature, and the cultural contextualization of IPE in particular, provide the theoretical basis and suitable terminology to approach AKR's aesthetics and poetics as an Indian author who worked in English and Indian regional languages (mainly Kannada and Tamil) in India and America.

Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage

It is within the multicultural and meta-critical context of IPE studies that this study of AKR's aesthetics and poetics incorporates both Indian and Western paradigms as critical criteria under scrutiny. We may propose, as relevant critical concepts, 'indigenously Indian' aesthetic and poetic paradigms, such as the classical *marga*/desi/*videshi* distinction (which some critics advocated for IPE studies) or the Akam/Puram conceptual pair (introduced to contemporary Indian literary criticism most prominently by AKR) and acknowledge thereby AKR's advocacy for an indigenous terminology in South Asian studies.¹² Yet we should also underline AKR's personal adaptation of these native categories, as he continually reinterpreted both Indian and Western critical terms borrowed from diverse disciplines. He applied these in innovative ways not only to the study of classical, medieval, and oral literary traditions but also to contemporary Indian literature and to himself.

Marga, Desi, and Videshi as Concepts in IPE Criticism

The *marga* and *desi* components in Indian literature and the arts refer to aesthetic, literary, and cultural categories derived from Sanskrit linguistic terms. 'Marga' (literally 'the Way', 'the high road') signifies the supra-regional, mainstream, or pan-Indian tradition, which has also been called the classical Sanskrit tradition or 'great tradition' in Western scholarship. 'Desi' ('the place', 'the local/e', 'the country road'), on the other hand, denotes the regional or local vernacular traditions of India, which have also been inaccurately named the folk traditions or the 'little traditions'.¹³ Throughout Indian critical history, these ancient concepts have been used in the performing arts, in poetry and other literary forms, and more recently in modern linguistics and sociology, yet their interpretation as critical concepts **(p.29)** in contemporary studies has been questioned.¹⁴ The *marga* (supra-regional) and the *desi* (regional) in combination with the *videshi* (the 'alien', Western, or international elements) make up a three-pronged critical tool that might prove too simplistic a model in a larger sociocultural discussion today, but can nevertheless serve as a starting point to approach Indian literature and has been postulated for the study of Indian poets writing in English.

In the last decade of the twentieth century, the *marga*-*desi* categories were proposed as critical paradigms in contemporary Indian literature, including Indian literature in English, by *nativist* critics such as G.N. Devy. Devy's critical effort was to relate these terms to our appreciation of the history and historiography of Indian languages and literary traditions, in which he includes literature in English. He drew from 'forgotten' regional critical traditions in the Indian regional languages (*bhashas*) to formulate a potentially common poetics for indigenous contemporary critical practice, which is, in some aspects, in line with the multicultural critical perspective. Poet-critic Makarand Paranjape described nativism as 'a form of indigenous literary criticism whose agenda can be summed up as a cry for cultural self-respect and autonomy' and claims that it was 'perhaps the only home-grown school of criticism to have emerged in post-

Independence India'.¹⁵ As a literary and aesthetic concept, nativism gained many followers among Indian scholars since its formulation in Marathi language in the 1980s by Marathi writer Bhalchandra Nemade.¹⁶

In 'The Multicultural Context of Indian English Literature' and the award-winning *After Amnesia*, Devy divides the Indian literary map into three main categories. These constitute what he calls the 'tripartite relation' in Indian literature and criticism defined as:

1. The marga traditions (of Sanskrit, scriptural, Brahminical origin).
2. The alien traditions (gradually nativised, but of Arabic, Persian, or English origin).
3. The desi traditions (of local, indigenous, and regional language origin).¹⁷

Devy proposes these as the basic sources for a native contemporary critical framework in India. However, he sees the multicultural dimension of 'Indian English poets', the 'fate of being suspended' between the marga, the desi, and the videshi, as a weakening and disconcerting factor in IPE.

(p.30) Other models under the same premises have been suggested since nativism, comparativism, and multiculturalism set in as critical approaches in India during the 1980s. Parallel to Devy's formulation on the three types of traditions operating in Indian literary criticism and IPE, comparativist critic Ayyappa Paniker identifies three common features that 'may underlie the poetics of contemporary IPE', namely:

1. The international (related to the English language).
2. The national (related to Indian 'authorship', 'sensitivity', and 'subject matter').
3. The regional (related to 'specific particulars').¹⁸

These three common elements—international, national, and regional—are comparable to Devy's basic categories of marga, desi, and videshi described earlier. Devy and Paniker attempt to illustrate, through these simplified tripartite models, the diverse cultural elements that are embedded in contemporary Indian poets and poetics, particularly in poetry written in English. Yet there are a number of problems with providing simplified outlines such as these. Each component or literary tradition implies a relation or, in AKR's words, a 'quarrel' or 'dialogue' which often occurs within a single tradition, text, or author. A crass divide into three distinct modes would convey the idea of separate cultural realities coexisting in Indian literature, whereas in fact a single text or language, as a complex system, reflects the interaction of each of these parameters. Categories such as Western or Indian, marga or desi, national or regional, as alternatives for the hierarchical terms 'great tradition' and 'little tradition(s)'

used by earlier Western anthropologist and Indologists,¹⁹ should therefore not be wrongly employed as monolithic or static realities.

Though AKR was not a critic of IPE, it is noteworthy that a tripartite pattern also underlies the model of modern Indian literature that is described in some of his prose. In one of the few essays and commentaries on contemporary Indian poetry (including IPE) published in 1983, before Devy's and Paniker's articles came out, he stresses the idea of three traditions interacting in contemporary Indian literature:

Indian writing today, no less than any other expression of India's civilisation, is heir to the complex interaction of at least three traditions (1) the Sanskritic scriptures (The Vedas etc. ca. 1500 BC), epics, myths, philosophies, and **(p.31)** poems; (2) at least 6-10 centuries of recorded literatures in the many mother-tongues (20 centuries, in the case of Tamil), co-existing with the orally current folk-literatures which are just beginning to be collected and studies; and (3) since the 19th century, the traditions carried by English. One must add the Perso-Arabic traditions if one is speaking of languages like Urdu, Sindhi or Kashmiri.²⁰

Now, in this essay, AKR also considers, as a critical factor in Indian writing, a fourth category which arises out of the combination or relation of the three identified traditions in recent Indian literary history. He suggests that we should 'add to these the influence and example of great men of letters'²¹ such as Rabindranath Tagore and the Tamil poet Subramania Bharati (1882-1921). AKR thus highlights in his analysis of contemporary Indian literature the role of groundbreaking writers who lived at the turn of the twentieth century and represent the modern Indian tradition. In such an Eliotian interpretation (see the sections 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7 and 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8) of tradition as an ongoing organic process, the pioneering authors of the early twentieth century who had absorbed in their work the multiple pasts are seen by AKR as a fourth tradition: the contemporary. That is, he acknowledges the tradition of eminent writers who significantly shaped the pre-Independence (colonial) and post-Independence literary scenes with, we may say, their *individual talent*, for the aesthetic vision and original creations of these literary giants influenced several generations of Indian writers and continue to do so even today.²²

The three basic categories in Indian literature that critical theorists identify as *marga*, *desi*, and *videshi*, and which AKR emphasizes as coexisting in a creative confluence in contemporary Indian cultural figures, are conspicuously evident also in his personal literary and intellectual make-up as animated interrelations:

Our writers, thinkers, and men of action—say Gandhi, Tagore and Bharati—made creative use of these triangulations, these dialogues and quarrels.

For those of us who were shaped in that ‘triple stream’, our translations, poems, lives in and out of India, searches (which were often disguised as research, analysis, even psychoanalysis), and all such explorations, including essays such as these, are witnesses to this lifelong enterprise.²³

AKR’s literary career thrived on this ‘triple stream’ that was further expanded and absorbed through the contemporary writers he read. **(p.32)** An unpublished draft of a lecture text on Indian literatures briefly summarizes the hybrid nature of his ‘fourfold’ literary genetics:

Indian literary traditions fourfold

An Indian who had absorbed Indian literature first, then studied English (and some European) literature and literary theory in my teens and twenties, and then took up the serious study of Indian lit. in this country—We knew the Mahabharata much before we’d read it as a single text between covers—Never knew when it was written or that it was first composed in Sanskrit—People like me read it in Kannada or in Tamil—chiefly in Tamil Magazines—as a kind of serial—in the early 40’s. We also read contemporary poetry and novels—Tagore in English translation ... Bengali novels (Bankim, Saratchandra), and Marathi novels (Khandekar) in Kannada and Tamil.²⁴

Mother Tongue and Father Tongue

The notion of three basic traditions interacting in Indian literature is also articulated in other essays by AKR, including ‘On the “Unity” and “Diversity” of Indian Literatures’ (1986), ‘Classics Lost and Found’ (1988), and in his rare piece on the modern poet Subramania Bharati titled ‘On Bharati and His Prose Poems’ (1999):²⁵

After the nineteenth century no significant Indian writer lacks any of the three traditions: the regional mother-tongue, the pan-Indian (Sanskritic, and in the case of Urdu and Kashmiri, [t]he Perso-Arabic as well) and the Western (mostly English). Thus, Indian modernity is a response not only to contemporary events but to at least three pasts.²⁶

In addition to the spatial dimension implicit in the term ‘regional’ (desi), AKR incorporates here a social aspect by adding the term ‘mother tongue’ to label the non-Sanskritic local traditions comprising both written forms and oral folk literatures. The ‘national’ or marga and the ‘international’ or videshi, on the other hand, he called the ‘father tongues’. In this analogic manner, AKR adapted Walter J. Ong’s sociolinguistic distinction of mother tongue (English) and father tongue (Latin) in Renaissance England to the Indian (and his own) context, thereby avoiding earlier binary conceptions that he deemed outdated:

Marga and desi, an old Indian pair—loosely translated as ‘classical’ and ‘folk’, technical terms in native discussions of literature, music, drama (**p. 33**) and dance—have been linked to, or reincarnated as, ‘Great and Little Traditions’.... Ideas like the ‘Great and Little Traditions’ became important in anthropology, and the controversy over them stimulated the search for finer detail and more adequate conceptions.... This may force us to re-examine the notion of the Great and Little Traditions carried by Sanskrit as a ‘father-tongue’ and by the standard regional ‘mother-tongues’.²⁷

Both mother-tongue and father-tongue traditions played a central role in AKR’s intellectual and artistic upbringing. In fact, the distinction between mother tongues and father tongues permeated his scholarship from the earliest stages, and his characteristic use of this paradigm eventually came to be recognized as an influential contribution to Indian studies.²⁸ He applied this sociolinguistic model to the childhood scenario of his Mysore family house and its linguistic ‘areas’, which became his personal metaphors for the marga/desi paradigm as well as convenient substitutes for the ‘great’ and ‘little’ traditions coined by anthropologist Robert Redfield in the 1950s.²⁹ Thus, a spatial demarcation and social differentiation are implied in AKR’s metaphoric depiction of Indian literature and culture. Upstairs in his father’s attic, as AKR used to put it, were the father languages (Sanskrit and English) and downstairs in the kitchen and in the courtyard and streets the mother tongues, Tamil (his parents’ language) and Kannada (the regional language spoken in Mysore). This is how he describes the three-storied ‘scene’ in one of his essays on oral literature:

As we grew up Sanskrit and English were our father-tongues and Tamil and Kannada our mother-tongues. The father-tongues distanced us from our mothers, from our own childhoods, and from our villages and many of our neighbours in the cowherd colony next door. And the mother-tongues united us with them. It now seems appropriate that our house had three levels: a downstairs for the Tamil world, an upstairs for the English and the Sanskrit, and a terrace on top that was open to the sky.... From up there we could also look down on the cowherd colony....

Each had a literature that was unlike the others’. Each was an other to the others, and it became the business of a lifetime for some of us to keep the dialogues and quarrels alive and to make something of them.³⁰

In AKR’s thought and scholarship, these strands are intimately ‘related’ or, to follow his own metaphor, they co-inhabit the same ‘family house’. According to this organic network model, the different (**p.34**) branches of ‘tradition’ in himself are not expressed as separate realities, but as points of connections and departures within a continuous pluralistic environment.

Hence we may summarize that the meta-critical categories described here are sensitive to the cultural constituents and biographical contexts of the author, while they also reflect the diversity of his intellectual pursuit, academic scope, and critical thought. Mirroring the thematic content of AKR's published and unpublished writings concerned with art and literature, the manifold traditions that converge in his intellectual ecosystem (house)—and in the aesthetic and poetic thought it contains—can be said to fall under four principal branches:

1. The *videshi* or international father-tongue traditions: These comprise Western aesthetic models and Western criticism, literary theories and writers,³¹ particularly the classical, romantic, and modern canon of British and American writers, but to a lesser degree also continental European (French, German) and Latin American authors, who were mostly read by AKR in English translation.
2. The *marga* or 'pan-Indian, interregional' father-tongue tradition:³² The *marga* includes classical Sanskrit aesthetics, poetics, philosophy, and literature ranging from the Vedas and Upanishads to the medieval period, read mainly in English translation or in Kannada and Tamil versions.
3. The *desi* or regional/local mother-tongue traditions: This category takes account of classical and medieval Tamil poetry and poetics, medieval Kannada poetry and poetics, and oral narrative traditions in Kannada and other Indian languages that AKR studied and translated relentlessly.
4. The contemporary (colonial and postcolonial) Indian tradition: This additional fourth component exposes the impact and dialogue of the latter three traditions in nineteenth- and twentieth-century Indian writers. It comprises contemporary writing produced in the regional languages (*bhashas*) that AKR knew well (mainly contemporary Kannada and Tamil), works in other Indian languages translated into English, Kannada, or Tamil, and literature originally written in English. The romantic, modern, or postmodern Indian authors who AKR read and studied were renowned writers who had, in various hues and tones and with **(p.35)** diverse aesthetic purposes, incorporated the three available traditions (*marga*, *desi*, and *videshi*) in their work. Their body of literary writings as well as their aesthetic and literary theories make up the colonial and postcolonial literary tradition in India, with its own complex landscape of poetic discourses and quarrels. The recent tradition includes also coeval writers in Kannada like Gopalakrishna Adiga (1918–1992),³³ whose poetry AKR followed closely (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7).

Towards Alternative Models for Indian Literature

As a scholar and specialist in south-Indian (Dravidian) literary traditions, including classical regional traditions in Tamil as well as oral traditions, AKR had strong reservations about the traditional distinction between *marga* and *desi*,

and the Western paradigms of classical and folk, 'high' and 'low', 'great' and 'little' for the study of Indian literature. In his introduction to the path-breaking *Speaking of Siva* (1973), which contains translations into English of devotional medieval Kannada poetry, he expresses his concerns thus:

The several pairs capture different aspects of a familiar dichotomy, though none of them is satisfactory or definitive.... It should not be forgotten that many of the regional languages and cultures themselves, e.g., Tamil, have long traditions, divisible into 'ancient' and 'modern' historically, 'classical' and 'folk' or 'high' and 'low' synchronically.... Even the so-called 'great' tradition is not as monolithic as it is often assumed to be.³⁴

From the time of his youth living in Mysore and as a teacher of English in several Indian cities, AKR was keenly interested in bhakti (devotional) poetry in Kannada and in oral tales. Later in the USA, as a professor of the newly created academic discipline of Dravidian studies in the 1960s, he discovered the classical Tamil Sangam tradition and became immersed in translating the medieval Kannada *Virasaiva* bhakti tradition into English at a time when Sanskrit studies were still the hegemonic area of specialization in Indology. It is, therefore, not surprising that AKR privileged the study of the mother-tongue traditions, that is, the (at that time) lesser known or unorthodox traditions:

(p.36) My interest has always been in the mother tongues, not Sanskrit, because I have always felt that the mother tongues represent a democratic, anti- hierarchic, from-the-ground-up view of India. And my interest in folklore has also been shaped by that. I see in these counter-systems, anti-structures, a protest against official systems. My work in folklore represents the world of women and children. More or less unconsciously, I have decided not to talk about India through the Sanskrit texts, but through the mother tongue texts, both written and oral.³⁵

In his work as a scholar and translator, AKR evolved alternative models that moved beyond the classical marga/desi dichotomy for Indian literature and were based on diverse systems and conceptualizations, absorbing terminology from linguistics, literary theory, classical Tamil and medieval bhakti aesthetics, cultural anthropology, and other disciplines that he constantly revised and adapted to suit new research and 'discoveries'. The technical jargon that AKR brought out of his multidisciplinary 'toolbox'³⁶ into Indian literary and cultural studies includes seminal concepts that he tested in various contexts in his career, which have enriched our view of Indian literary traditions and his own aesthetic universe. Among these tools and ideas, we can briefly highlight the following versatile ideas that he introduced at different periods of his academic life:

In the 1960s:

1. The Akam (interior, private) and Puram (exterior, public) paradigm: These two terms correspond to the distinct genres of love and war poems in classical Tamil Sangam poetry that AKR 'discovered' in the early 1960s. A collection of these love poems was published in his first book of translations as *The Interior Landscape* (1967).³⁷ AKR was highly influenced by the poetics of the Tamil Sangam ('fraternity of poets') and its concentric aesthetics, which he later applied to the study of oral tales and to describe his own cultural baggage of 'inner' and 'outer' forms. AKR's explanation of Tamil poetics, and the conception of *The Interior Landscape*, owe as much to the linguistics of Roman Jakobson and the rhetorical theory of Kenneth Burke, as to the poetics of the English Romantics and later poets such as G.M. Hopkins (and his concept of 'inscape') and Paul Valéry (poetry as 'a language within a language'), and modern Western aesthetics and visual arts (see the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5 and 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7).

(p.37) In the 1970s:

2. Structure, anti-structure, and counter-structure: AKR explains some of the tensions derived from the coexistence of the pan-Indian marga and regional desi traditions by adapting Victor Turner's structure and anti-structure dichotomy in the introduction to *Speaking of Siva*. Yet in his original analysis of Virasaiva bhakti aesthetics, he prefers the term 'counter-structure' to 'anti-structure' to be able to distinguish between the 'ideological rejection of the idea of structure itself' in some bhakti communities and the need to 'develop their own structures for behaviour and belief ... frequently composed of elements from the very structures they deny or reject'.³⁸ This seemingly paradoxical process, which a young AKR diagnosed early (before he read Turner's work) in bhakti traditions, can be said to portray his own life and work as a modern scholar. He belonged by birth to the 'higher' Brahmin caste (which he shunned early in life) yet was drawn as a scholar to the underprivileged 'lower' traditions and counter-structures. Folklore, oral narratives, women tales, and medieval Virasaiva bhakti which opposed caste and hierarchy, made up an essential part of AKR's structuralist ideas in the early 1970s, which he later revised from a post-structuralist perspective (see the sections 'First Thirty Years in India' in Chapter 3, 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7 on bhakti and non-conformity).

3. Permeable membranes: AKR employs scientific terminology (from physics and biology), such as 'osmosis' and '(im)permeable membrane',

as metaphors to illustrate the interrelation between traditions: '[T]raditions are not divided by impermeable membranes; they interflow into one another, responsive to differences of density as in osmosis. It is often difficult to isolate elements as belonging exclusively to the one or the other.'³⁹

In the 1980s:

4. A network of intertextuality: Turning to post-structural critical theory (Julia Kristeva, Roland Barthes, Mikhail Bakhtin) and avoiding binary oppositions, AKR presents Indian literature(s) in the 1980s as a plural and organic interactive system of 'texts ... **(p.38)** engaged in continuous and dynamic dialogic relations'. For instance, in the introduction to *Folktales from India*, one of his last prose writings (first published in 1991), AKR clarifies that the 'pan-Indian' or classical tradition is, in reality, a complex coexistent system of Brahminism, Buddhism, Jainism, Tantra, bhakti, Islam, Zoroastrianism, Christianity, and even modernity as the latest hegemonic discourse. The pan-Indian systems, and the so-called alien or 'modern' inputs, such as the English language and the 'modern' Western world view, along with the local indigenous varieties, including the popular, oral, or folk traditions, are thus placed in 'an ever-present network of intertextuality' and exchange. AKR insists here again that 'we need to modify terms such as "Great Tradition" and "Little Tradition".... What is distinguished as "the classical," "the folk," and "the popular," as different modes in Indian culture, will be seen as part of an interacting continuum.'⁴⁰ In such a *dialogic continuum* (Bakhtin's term),⁴¹ the regional or local (desi) mother-tongue traditions are not necessarily confined to small communities, and the apparently a-geographic, trans-local pan-Indian (marga) and Western (videshi) father-tongue traditions may in fact consist of multiple regional varieties (see Chapter 7).

5. Context-sensitivity and reflexivity: Linguistics was AKR's main theoretical turf and as both structuralist and post-structuralist scholars were prone to develop theories connecting linguistics (Saussure, Jakobson, and others) to cultural anthropology, AKR was no exception. Such was the case with the context-free/context-sensitive rule in grammar and the notion of different types of reflexivity (self-reflexive and reflexive) in language and literary texts he borrowed from linguistics. These concepts became crucial paradigms to describe and *deconstruct* cultural patterns in (India and the West) as well as to define the nature and function of literary works.⁴² Reflexivity and context-sensitivity are discussed in two of AKR's most influential cultural essays with titles that already give away their (self-)reflexive nature: 'Where Mirrors Are Windows: Towards an Anthology of Reflections' and 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking? An Informal Essay'. In AKR's evolution from a trained linguist to cultural anthropologist, Saussure, Jakobson, and structuralism

appealed to him as much as Bakhtin and other post-structuralist theory of the time, including Derridian thought (see the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7).

(p.39) This 'toolbox' containing diverse interdisciplinary critical notions and their inherent world view, 'this metalanguage that half perceives and half creates what we see',⁴³ characterizes much of AKR's work as a scholar, translator, and poet, as will be illustrated in subsequent chapters on his aesthetics and poetics. The student and critic of AKR's work will quickly discern how certain theoretical models were circulated and updated by the author throughout his career, as critical paradigms in his essays come in recurrent variations to approach and revisit a particular subject—and the reader—from various angles. This 'reflexive' critical strategy and 'way of thinking' does not only infuse his scholarly essays and studies on (mainly) south-Indian and folk traditions with an unmistakable critical edge but to a large extent also shapes his own creative work as a contemporary writer. That is, the repetitions and variations of AKR's metalanguage frame his aesthetic and poetic universe, in which the multiple traditions thrive in an 'interactive continuum' of quarrelling relations.

Prior to offering an analysis of AKR's aesthetics, however, I will take a closer look at some of the key critical tools proposed by AKR for the study of literature which I have chosen in order to introduce and explore his own aesthetics and poetics: the Akam/Puram distinction from Tamil poetics which he first adopted in the 1960s (and later tested in other contexts) and the concepts of context-sensitivity and reflexivity, which had a strong bearing on his thinking in the latter part of his career, from the 1980s.

The Akam ('Inner') and Puram ('Outer') Concentric Paradigms

Akam and Puram traditionally denote two poetic genres in Tamil Sangam poetry (first century BC to third century AD), as illustrated at length in AKR's essays on Tamil poetics. The two terms also describe common patterns in Indian society and culture. As is the case with the marga/desi dichotomy and AKR's metaphor of the father and mother tongues in the house, Akam and Puram also reflect a spatial and social conceptualization. In this case the distinction is between what is closer or interior (Akam) and what is farther, public or exterior (Puram):

Some version of this generic division is probably universal, but my details come from the Kannada area.... [T]he division ... is between the *domestic* and the *public*—between the inner circle or the immediate kin within the four **(p.40)** (or more) walls of a house and the larger circles of the extended family, the subcaste, the caste and the society at large. The domestic-public gradations are seen also in the spatial access to the interiors of a house: intimacy and kin-bonds can be measured by how far one is allowed inside a house toward the kitchen. Compartmentalisation of

life-ways into those appropriate for home and those appropriate for the world outside (say, office) is also relevant.... The classical terms *akam* and *puram* express these (as well as other) dichotomies....⁴⁴

The Akam/Puram division can also be paired with the functional distinction between the mother-tongue tradition, which is of domestic and local or regional use (*desi*), and the father-tongue tradition used for communication with the general public, that is, with the 'outer' national/interregional (*marga*) and international (*videshi*) world. Akam and Puram derive from an aesthetic and sociocultural cosmo-vision modelled on a concentric understanding of the world as containing inner and outer spheres. In the context of ancient Tamil Sangam poetry, these two terms signify a difference in genre, content matter, and form of expression.

AKR and other scholars sought to exploit this model to study other literary forms and patterns throughout India. Thus, Akam and Puram, along with other terminology such as context-sensitivity or father and mother tongues, were part of AKR's conceptual 'repertoire' that was later adopted as metalanguage in various fields of South Asian studies. For instance, when the Akam and Puram distinction from classical Tamil poetics was applied to the study of Indian oral-narrative traditions by AKR, it posed interesting questions. In the introduction to *Another Harmony*, Stuart Blackburn, AKR's long-time collaborator in the study of folklore, remarked:

The order inherent in genre classification and the potential of a context-sensitive approach to it are explored by Ramanujan. Using Kannada material as primary data, he elicits a classification that may have pan-Indian applicability. On the basis of thematic, contextual and performance features, most known genres can be positioned on a continuum from domestic/interior (*akam*) to public/exterior (*puram*)....

The genre classification brought out by Ramanujan also raises an interesting theoretical problem. The *akam/puram* division cannot accurately be called 'folk' because those terms are used only in written, classical commentaries to designate types of early Tamil poetry and are unknown to most people; yet they are descriptive of a typology among folk genres. This **(p.41)** situation requires us to rethink the distinction often made by folklorists between native and analytic categories. In a complex culture like India's, with highly developed intellectual and written traditions, it is possible to find categories that are both native (indigenous to the culture) and analytic (not used in folk traditions).⁴⁵

The Akam/Puram paradigm has been explained since the mid-1960s in several of AKR's essays, and the afterwords to his translations of Sangam poetry define Akam and Puram as aesthetic and poetic concepts in a variety of literary and

cultural contexts.⁴⁶ Akam and Puram signify poems of love and war as two genres, but the terms also stand for the private and public spheres in life, that is, for the world of the self and that of others, and for the codes of conduct and expression appropriate to one or the other.⁴⁷ In the aptly titled essay 'Where Mirrors Are Windows: Towards an Anthology of Reflections',⁴⁸ AKR gives some examples of how these concentric pairs of meanings operate in Indian languages and literatures, and also points to different types of correlations ('responsive', 'reflective', and 'self-reflexive') between and within structures and systems. According to the context, the terms have several meanings that can be described as 'concentric series' growing in scope and semantic connotations:⁴⁹

Akam	Puram
1. interior	exterior
2. heart, mind	body surfaces and extremities, for example, back, side, arms
3. self	others
4. kin	non-kin
5. house, family	houseyard, field
6. inland, settlement	areas far from dense human habitation, for example, jungle, desert
7. earth	farthest ocean
8. love poems-no names of places and persons	poetry about war and other [well-matched] love, a 'public' poetry, with names of real people and places
9. codes of conduct appropriate to Akam	codes of conduct appropriate to Puram

(p.42) As AKR comments in the Afterword to *Poems of Love and War*, the two sets relate to each other 'by context and by contrast', so that their meanings 'complement each other systematically':

As we move from context to context, for each meaning of *akam*, there is a corresponding sense of *puram*. It is characteristic of this poetry and its poetics that the meanings seem to expand and contract in concentric circles, with the concrete physical particular at the center, getting more and more inclusive and abstract as we move outward. The context picks and foregrounds one or another of these circles of meaning.⁵⁰

A structural parallel could be drawn here with his own life and scholarly preoccupations. In what is surely the most oft-cited statement by AKR, quoted for the first time by fellow Indian poet R. Parthasarathy in 1976, the poet-scholar reveals the concentric nature of his own double-paired personality:

English and my disciplines (linguistics, anthropology) give me my 'outer' forms—linguistic, metrical, logical and other such ways of shaping experience, and my first thirty years in India, my frequent visits and field trips, my personal and professional preoccupations with Kannada, family, the classics and folklore give me my substance, my 'inner' forms, images and symbols. They are continuous with each other and I no longer can tell what comes from where.⁵¹

In my study of AKR's aesthetics and poetic thought, I make use of the context-sensitive Akam/Puram model so often explored by AKR, and distinguish between the poet's 'outer' and 'inner' aesthetics and poetics to denote differences in approach, content matter, context, and form of expression.⁵² The two types are considered as different vantage points 'in dialogue' with each other, one containing and reflecting the other in a concentric relationship. The adoption of 'outer' and 'inner' as categories to examine two complementary facets in AKR's aesthetics and poetics is supported by his long-standing practice of applying the Tamil poetic concepts of Akam and Puram not only to other texts, languages, and structures but also to his own life. Such an analysis of AKR's aesthetics (Chapters 4 and 5) and poetics (Chapters 6 and 7) does not seek to establish a binary system with a list of items falling either into the 'outer' or 'inner' category, as could be inferred from AKR's statement quoted above. One cannot draw a clear-cut line between the 'outer' and the 'inner', **(p.43)** as the two dimensions are 'continuous with each other'. Within this continuum there is a close interrelation and gradation of elements tilting towards either the Akam or the Puram.⁵³ The differentiation of theme, attitude, and code is subject to which of the two perspectives is taken as a starting point.

One of the purposes behind the model of systematization adopted here is to take into account the various biographical, thematic, and formal contexts displayed in the entire body of AKR writings pertaining to aesthetics and theoretical and descriptive aspects of poetry writing. That is, such a comprehensive exploration accommodates not only his academic study of poetry and thoughts on specific poetic traditions (the 'outer' aesthetics and poetics) but also his private ideas on the self, on being a poet, on the experience of art, and on the art of writing poetry (the 'inner' aesthetics and poetics). This double approach also seeks to identify the distinctive functions of, and relations between, the two main kinds of AKR prose texts analysed. On the one hand, the scholarly essays on poetic traditions and the notes written for academic lectures and courses, with a public purpose in mind (the exterior or outer world). On the other, the writer's personal diaries and journals dealing with his private thoughts and intimate feelings (the

interior, domestic, or inner world) and meant primarily for himself. And so the two text types, public and private, with their diverse functions, codes, styles of expression, contexts, and thematic contents, inherently lend themselves to be analysed in the light of the concentric Akam/Puram paradigm. Two other fundamental notions that AKR derived from the study of Indian literature and culture enrich and reaffirm this critical approach: the concepts of context-sensitivity and reflexivity.

Context-Sensitivity and Reflexivity

In the seminal essay 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', AKR expounds two of his principal theoretical tenets on Indian literature and culture, which he first puts forward as 'the obvious' and then builds up, by means of literary and linguistic samples, into complex critical tools: 'cultural traditions in India are indissolubly plural and often conflicting but are organised through at least two principles (a) context-sensitivity and (b) reflexivity of various sorts, both of which constantly generate new forms out of the old ones'. He then proceeds to identify the different forms of reflexivity: '[A]wareness of self and other, mirroring, distorted mirroring, parody, family resemblances **(p.44)** and rebels, dialectic, antistructure, utopias and dystopias, the many ironies connected with these responses and so on'. In the analysis of literary texts 'and their relations to each other ("intertextuality", if you will)', AKR distinguishes three types of reflexivity: '(1) *responsive*, where text A responds to text B in ways that define both A and B; (2) *reflexive*, where text A reflects on text B, relates itself to it directly or inversely; (3) *self-reflexive*, where a text reflects on itself or its kind.' These three kinds of reflexivity beget, respectively, 'co-texts', 'counter-texts', and 'meta text'.⁵⁴

This framework can be effectively applied to describe the entire body of writings by AKR as well as their positions, orientations, and interrelations.⁵⁵ Most of his own essays are structured through the principles of context-sensitivity and intertextuality. Likewise, reflexivity 'of various sorts' permeates his miscellaneous academic, literary, and private output, lending it a very *personal* coherence. Autobiographical content and self-reflexivity are not only present in AKR's private notes and diaries—his private 'mirrors'—but often emerge in his scholarly essays published in academic journals and colourful books, sometimes seen in public libraries or 'shop-windows'.⁵⁶ We may assess, in this manner, also the interviews and the poems that can be identified as primary sources for this study.⁵⁷ The interviews derive from formal and informal conversations with journalists, scholars, and friends that were only rarely edited by the author and, in some cases, not even meant to be published. Thus, the comments on poetry and on being a poet in these conversations and exchanges are closer to the diaries and journals in content and style than to the scholarly prose. AKR does not speak to himself in the interviews as he does in the *self-reflexive* diaries, but he *responds* to, or *corresponds* with, the interviewer (defining himself and the

interviewer in the process), while he *reflects* on himself and on his (highly *reflexive*) academic work in literature from a personal, 'inner' perspective.

The published poems and drafts on art and poetry, on the other hand, are posed between the *reflexive* (relating to other texts, literary trends, and traditions) and the *self-reflexive* (relating to the poem, to poetry, and/or to the poet's thoughts), and operate as counter-texts and meta-texts. Most of the meta-poems tend to be in some degree *self-reflexive*, that is, they reflect on themselves and on the act of composing. There are unpublished drafts of poems in the AKR Papers that remain self-conscious writing exercises on writing, and some were, in fact, scribbled along his private diary notes. Often such **(p.45)** poems on art and poetry bring together theory, poetry, and the self in a creative exchange between the 'inner' and the 'outer' spheres, and the private and public selves. AKR's composite personality of multiple selves as well as his creative thought process is revealed and illustrated, for instance, in the poem 'Self-Portrait' and its drafting. It is telling that in an early handwritten draft of the poem from the early 1960s, the word 'shop-windows' in the third line replaces the word 'mirrors' which has been crossed out.⁵⁸ This 'small-scale' poetic *revision* of his 'Self-Portrait', one of the first poems he composed in the USA after arriving from India and published in *The Striders*, thus 'mirrors' and anticipates AKR's famous anthological essay on 'reflections' published almost 30 years later.

Within this critical framework, one of the premises of the present study, therefore, is that only a contextual and intertextual study of all primary sources, including public and private prose texts, interviews, and poetry, can enable a coherent analysis of AKR's aesthetic and poetic thought. This may be an 'obvious' critical claim that could be valid for any multidisciplinary poet-scholar, yet it is fascinating to observe to what extent AKR enacted his own (meta-)critical principles in theory and practice throughout his life and career as a poet, translator, and academic.

Explaining reflexivity as an Indian cultural feature of rather complex correspondences in 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', AKR also refers to the 'reflexive/benefactive opposition' and complementariness in certain texts and linguistic structures. He argues that texts, just as many Tamil verbs, can be made reflexive or benefactive according to their orientation, that is, the direction of the action. AKR chooses to compare the Akam (public)/Puram (public) correlation with the following linguistic contrastive example:

Collikkontan: he said to himself, or he said on his own behalf (reflexive).

Collikkotuttan: he said for the sake of another, meaning 'taught' (benefactive).⁵⁹

The distinction between these two orientations or directions, towards the self or towards the other, found in Tamil verbs can further be valuable to systematize and describe the scope and form of AKR's writings on art, poetry, and poetics. At one level, AKR was concerned with poetry as a researcher and professor (the benefactive aspect). As a student, linguist, professor, and scholar, he was constantly revealing to others, through his lectures and translations, **(p.46)** unknown or neglected traditions he had encountered, selected, and identified with. And, at another level, he was a practising poet in several languages, deeply self-absorbed in poetic art and experience (the reflexive aspect). Poetry became, for him, a central way of looking at the world, a personal attitude, and an aesthetic means of self-assessment and self-expression. One can discern a lively correspondence between the objective and subjective facets or vocations in his career. His translation work of Tamil and Kannada traditions, for instance, partakes of benefactive and reflexive processes, but springs from the same creative, dialogic mind. Each component or activity in AKR inevitably reflects and, therefore, contains the other. An explicit example of this reflexive/benefactive interrelation within AKR's body of writings is the essay 'Classics Lost and Found' on Tamil Sangam poetry, in which AKR inserts his own poem 'Prayer to Lord Murugan' as an example of a counter-text to the classical Tamil tradition.⁶⁰

The set of paradigms and correspondences that have been described in this preliminary critical assessment, and which are also important features in Indian culture and literature, provide a useful frame and metalanguage for the systematization of AKR's aesthetic and poetic thought. As in AKR's metaphor of the different levels in his Mysore family house and its linguistic areas, in this indigenous and context-sensitive analytical system there is no real separation of domains, but an 'interactive continuum'.⁶¹ *What is said* on art and poetry in the public and private primary sources comes in different forms and text types, public and private, displaying diverse functions, styles of expression, contexts, and directions (reflexive and benefactive, subjective and objective, 'inner' and 'outer'). In AKR's scholarly prose intended for publication, we *read* his aesthetic and poetic thought through the studies of the poetry and poetics of other poets and traditions. And in order to *hear* the inner voice of his poetic self, we must resort to the private diaries and journals as well as to the interviews and poems.

The distinction between 'inner' and 'outer' in the systematization of AKR's aesthetics and poetics carried out in the chapters that follow is not meant to stand for separate compartments of the writer's self or poetics, but to reveal complementary angles, viewpoints, and layers to his ideas. The different observations and text types respond to and reflect one another as well as reflect on themselves, making for an anthology of personal and scholarly 'reflections' and 'refractions', so **(p.47)** to say, from private mirrors to transparent (or opaque) windows and vice versa. As AKR noted in his papers, on choosing a

metaphor he later incorporated into a poem, 'glass is good, it reflects to the outsider, and refracts for insiders':⁶²

He always knew
glass was good. 'It's rational,
it reflects',
enlisting attitudes of sky,
cloud, dazzle, aeroplanes,
for the man in the street;
filters images of the sun's
eclipse for the passerby;
yet refracts
all things for the man within,
defining some men in, others out,
with apparent transparency. (13-24)⁶³

There are several instances in AKR's scholarly texts where biographical and domestic elements enter the public sphere. In his classroom presentations and public lectures, which he prepared for as a kind of performance, it was quite typical of AKR to disclose personal details, stories, and other autobiographical material (his extended family, father, mother, his education, multilingualism, and so on) in order to place himself as a sample paradigm or object within the scholarly exposition; he maintained this method in some of the published papers. In several of his well-known essays, the author discloses incidents involving him, his life, his childhood and family, to kick off a topic or to illustrate an idea.⁶⁴ The Akam at times enters the Puram intentionally as a device or technique, though there are also instances where the private 'I' infiltrates the scholarly prose in a non-explicit, almost unwitting manner. And in the inverse direction, AKR on occasion muses over academic issues and scientific questions in his journals and diaries corresponding with material in his lectures and essays. We should not forget that AKR played with the idea of publishing his English-language journals in the mid-1970s, but these never saw the public light of day. He did publish a fictional autobiography in Kannada in 1978 titled *Matthobhana Atmasharitra* (*Someone Else's Autobiography*)⁶⁵ in which AKR chooses to speak about himself through a fictional 'other' in the same double-layered vein as the Argentinean Jorge Luis Borges (**p.48**) explores the relationship between the private self and the public self in the short story 'Borges and I' (see also the sections 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3, 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4, 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5, 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7, and 'Translation and Poetic Practice' in Chapter 8).⁶⁶ AKR intended to write a similar novella in English, yet felt more comfortable writing fictional prose in the mother tongue (Kannada) and scholarly prose in the father tongue (English).

It may be apt, therefore, to close this critical frame (in the context of reflexivity, the Akam/Puram paradigm, the private/public spheres, and the *question* of the active/witnessing self) by citing a passage from his 1976 journal:

October 26, 1976. 'From A Journal'

I have been writing a journal for some time, chiefly notes to myself, with no pretensions to style or scholarship; but as explorations, passages from one thought or feeling to another. I needed these notes to clear my seeing, settle my roving thoughts, ... curiously, restlessly, without regard to any discipline (in both senses of the word). I needed them even to form my thoughts, and to see what I was looking at, to listen to what I was hearing.

I am publishing them now, making them public, so that the private may find a place in a larger discussion; just as the larger discussions entered my private journal.⁶⁷

Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview

Aesthetics is a term that has been described in various ways within different traditions subject to historical and cultural factors. It is generally understood as the study of the rules and principles of art. As a branch of philosophy, it deals with the nature and perception of art and beauty. It also refers to the study of the psychological responses to artistic experiences and to the conception(s) of what may be called 'beauty'. As a poet and man of letters, AKR's artistic aesthetics, that is, his literary aesthetics, was intrinsically related to the art he practised and is therefore articulated in his poetics, which will be analysed in Chapters 6 and 7. Unless otherwise specified, the use of the term 'poetics' in this study is circumscribed to the specific denotation of 'theory of poetry'.⁶⁸

(p.49) A succinct outline of Western theory of art, followed by a brief overview of some of the principal Indian traditions of aesthetics, will serve as an introduction to the multiple conceptualizations of art and aesthetics that AKR and many Indian writers of his generation were exposed to: the *videshi* or Western (see the sections 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5 and 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7), the *marga* or supra-regional (see the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5 and 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition' in Chapter 7), the *desi* or regional/local (see the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics', 'Folk Aesthetics', and 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5, and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7), and the contemporary tradition (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7), which integrates the latter three.

The Western Tradition

In the Western tradition, the theory of art is a branch of philosophy and is concerned with the study of the concept of beauty and its appreciation. Three major conceptions of (literary) aesthetics can be identified in Western philosophical discourse and literary history: the classical or formalist, derived from the Greek philosophers, which focuses on the aesthetic object and is strongly theoretical; the romantic or affective which emphasizes the perceiving subject and praxis; and in the twentieth century, a host of aesthetic conceptualizations with an overall predominance of meta-critical theory. The objectivist and formalist ideas had the upper hand in the first half of the twentieth century and gave way to an increased interest in subjective and affective aspects of art during the second half. In the last decades of the twentieth century, the concepts of art and aesthetics were questioned as never before.⁶⁹

The objectivist schools, which have predominated since Plato and Aristotle, were interested in mimesis, the representation of the perceptible world. They described the artist's response to reality and the interpretation of the external object through the manipulation of an artificial medium. During the European Renaissance, the three key topics of aesthetics, which reformulated classical Greek conceptions, were *ingenium/ars*, *delectare/docere*, and *verba/res*. That (p. 50) is, the work of art was discussed in view of these main paradigms pertaining to the making, the purpose, and the form and content of art. Historically, in the West, the purpose or end of a work of art (and of literature in particular), according to the classical rhetoric, has vacillated between *docere*, *movere*, and *delectare*, that is, between education, pathos, and aesthetic delight.⁷⁰ The approach to aesthetics has been mainly philosophical and it was only in the nineteenth century that psychological aesthetics makes an appearance. I shall let this sketch of the classical Western idea of art stand as a backdrop to introduce Indian aesthetics (classical, bhakti, and contemporary), which operate within rather different cultural parameters and offer their own conceptions of art.⁷¹

The Classical Indian Traditions of Aesthetics

In Indian literary history, we can discern at least two principal theoretical branches or traditions that have been termed as 'classical': the hegemonic Sanskrit (marga) tradition of aesthetics with its various treatises and theoreticians, and the Tamil Dravidian (desi) tradition which is derived from the poetic treatise *Tolkappiyam* of the classical Sangam period and from the works of later Tamil commentators and scholars. Whereas the key classical Sanskrit or Greek treatises are based on the art of drama, the Tamil model is culled out of the lyrical art and is intrinsically closer to the poetic mode, as is the case with certain Japanese or Chinese traditions.

Classical Sanskrit aesthetic theories are rooted in an affective model of art that is receiver-oriented. They provide a comprehensive mapping of the multiple elements involved in the artistic event, that is, the artist, the work, the perceiver, and the world, and describe the relation of these components to one another. The fundamental aesthetic system in Sanskrit is the rasa theory. The Sanskrit term 'rasa', as an aesthetic concept, is said to have been first propounded by the sage Bharata Muni in the *Natya Sastra*,⁷² the principal Sanskrit treatise on drama (performing arts and music) written between the second century BC and second century AD. Bharata delineated in the *Natya Sastra* the fundamental aesthetic system of rasa, which was reinterpreted later by other Indian philosophers, notably Abhinavagupta, during the tenth to eleventh century AD. Thus, what it is called rasa theory today is the classical Sanskrit theory of aesthetic experience based on Bharata's *Natya Sastra* and later elaborated as an aesthetic theory between the (p.51) seventh and eleventh centuries AD. It should be noted that the concept of rasa remained open to interpretation and further contributions by eminent Indian theoreticians throughout the centuries, and it can be said without hesitation that rasa is still today the most influential concept of Indian aesthetics and poetics.⁷³

This Sanskrit aesthetic theory is not concerned with mimesis and the order and proportion of the aesthetic object, as were the classical Greek theories, but with aesthetic rapture. It explains the techniques that may evoke impersonal psychological-emotional states (rasa) leading to aesthetic pleasure (*rasanubhava*) and transcendental bliss of the soul (*atmananda*) in the beholder or consumer of a work of art. Rasa signifies 'that which is being relished', a 'flavour', 'taste', 'juice', or 'essence'. The primary aim of art is to produce aesthetic delight yet its ultimate expression lies in the spiritual sublimation of the art experience and thus in the self-realization of the perceiver as corresponding to the doctrine of brahman (the uncreated, transcendent, all-encompassing principle) and atman (the self, the individual perceiver).

Rasa could be defined as the depersonalized, generalized psychological state of aesthetic pleasure that may be provoked by a combination of a permanent dominant emotion, fleeting sentiments, and the causes and consequents of the emotion. It is affected by aesthetic distancing from personal connotations of the emotion and from the object that is the cause of the feeling. Yet the experience of rasa is not an automatic formula. For this 'spontaneous' aesthetic enjoyment to take place, all aesthetic elements need to be in the right combination, thus the various techniques at hand for the artist to evoke rasa are meticulously explained by Sanskrit aesthetician. According to Bharata, in the aesthetic pleasure of enjoying a piece of dance or music, or a poem, painting, or sculpture, both the artist and the spectator-listener forget the intricate technique that is behind the performance or work of art in the same manner as, when savouring a well-cooked dish, it is no more relevant which ingredients were used and how they were elaborated. Just as the correct proportion of its constituents gives a

dish its pleasant flavour, so is the experience of *rasa* contingent on the right combination of its various components. The base component is *bhava*, which can be defined as feelings, ordinary emotions, or personal psychological states that are commonly experienced. Bharata identifies the eight permanent or dominant psychological states or emotions (*sthayi bhava*, for example, **(p.52)** sorrow), and further distinguishes between *vibhava* (the fundamental determinant or cause of the emotion, for example, the dying hero in a play), *anubhava* (the consequences or external signs, for example, tears, sobbing), and *vyabhichari bhava* or *sanchari bhava*, the thirty-three transitory or passing states of the mind that are accessories to the primary *sthayi bhavas*. When the *rasa* essence is relished in art, these feelings (*bhava*), according to the *Natya Sastra*, are generalized (universalized), as the personal psychological mode is ‘transcended’ in the aesthetic experience. Bharata distinguishes eight principal *rasas*: *sringara* (love), *hasya* (comic), *karuna* (pathos), *raudra* (furious), *vira* (heroic), *bhayanaka* (fearsome), *bibhatsa* (disgusting), and *adbhuta* (wondrous). For every one of these eight *rasas*, there is a corresponding permanent psychological state or sentiment (*sthayi bhava*). Abhinavagupta later added a ninth *rasa*, *shanta* (calmness, peace), which is described as the principal *rasa* that underlies all others.

Aesthetic experience is, therefore, not a common worldly experience, but neither is this ‘taste of transcendence’ an otherworldly mystery. It is rather a transient transformation or re-formation of consciousness. Aesthetic rapture is a property inherent in human consciousness. It is in every one of us and is evoked by ordinary human emotions in a psychological (psychosomatic) process that is akin to analogy, inference, correspondence, or reflection. So where does *rasa* take place—in the performer or in the watcher? How can everyday life get transformed into such a heightened state of ‘perception’, into an expression of inner liberation of the soul (a momentary savouring of transcendence) without becoming a spiritual experience as such? Some light can be shed on these questions if we understand this process as a mirroring of some sort. A mirror—the mirror of art—which reflects and ‘enlightens’ personal emotions as the *rasa* (experience of ‘art’) that is latent in human consciousness.

It was the sage Abhinavagupta who explained aesthetic rapture as a transformation of consciousness and who gave it a metaphysical (philosophical-religious) aura. Abhinavagupta interprets *rasa* in his work primarily in psychological terms. He shifts the focus of the *rasa* system to the process of aesthetic response, and formulates a receiver-oriented theory of *rasa*. For him, what matters is the subject who perceives and experiences *rasa* through an identification with the emotions in their pure state, which depersonalizes and universalizes the ‘reflected’ emotion. According to Abhinavagupta, *rasa* (aesthetic **(p.53)** ecstasy) and the mystical experience share similar aims and reach out to transcendence, yet they are dissimilar in respect to their purpose and notion of time. The mystic individual searches for an ultimate union with the

Absolute Truth. Just as the mystic experience, the aesthetic experience is not an ordinary, worldly (*laukika*) experience, though *rasa* is arrived at through the mundane experience. It is both an experience of this world and of the otherworldly (*alaukika*). Furthermore, the aim of the mystic is timeless: he/she yearns for permanent dissolution in the Absolute, that is, liberation (*moksha*). *Rasa*, on the other hand, is a temporary aesthetic experience leading to a state of bliss (*ananda*), which ‘resembles’ the mystic experience. For the audience that goes to a performance the intention is aesthetic pleasure (*rasanubhava*). The taste of *rasa* is the experience of Beauty, the taste of the infinite/immortality, yet one which inevitably needs to be finite/mortal.

In contrast with the Sanskrit traditions, the lesser-known ancient Indian classical tradition of Dravidian aesthetics from south India is an essentially naturalistic view of art and culture. The classical period of Tamil literature, called the age of the Sangam (‘assembly’) poets, is dated by most scholars between 100 BC and 300 AD and comprises *The Eight Anthologies (Ettuttokai)*, *The Ten Long Poems (Pattupattu)*, and a grammatical treatise, the *Tolkappiyam*. This work of descriptive linguistics is also a commentary on Tamil poetics and provides the framework to analyse the idiosyncrasies of the Tamil aesthetic sensibility.⁷⁴ Scholars have identified numerous convergences between the *Tolkappiyam* and the *Natya Sastra*.⁷⁵ Both present a classification of emotional states⁷⁶ and offer a complex system of correlations that describes feelings and particular situations. But the *Tolkappiyam* is distinct in its formulation of a terminology that incorporates an intrinsic awareness of the natural environment and treats culture and the human world as enclosed in nature. Therefore, in this ancient south-Indian aesthetic tradition, no interpretation of art as a purely cultural construct is possible, for the primary idea is that culture, art, and humans are an extension of nature: they are inseparable and cannot be dissociated. In Tamil aesthetics, art and nature share a common frame.

Moreover, Tamil aesthetics and poetics, as indicated earlier, derive their essence from the lyrical genre, unlike the aesthetic theory of the *Natya Sastra*, which is based on drama. The Akam (private, love) and Puram (public, war) paradigms have already been referred to as two **(p.54)** poetic genres and modes representing, in AKR’s terms, the ‘interior’ and ‘exterior’ concentric circles in Tamil aesthetics (see also the section ‘Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage’ in this chapter). In this ecosystem, the *Tolkappiyam* devises a taxonomy of poetic regions or ‘landscapes’ for the Akam love lyric that derives from environmental parameters found in south India. In such a poetics, the mood of a love poem is given by natural clues such as birds, plants, and archetypal landscapes, which altogether make up a poetic metalanguage. Within this conception of art, there is again no question of mimesis, that is, of the artist observing and interpreting the natural world. On the contrary, it is the natural scene that enacts the human scene and is ‘expressive’ of human feelings. In other words, the aesthetic emotion within such a context-specific nature lyric is

to be located in an 'ecological' or environmental grid which the poet as well as the reader is to follow.⁷⁷

We shall not go deeper here into the peculiarities and techniques of the Dravidian aesthetic tradition, since Tamil aesthetics and poetics are further described in specific sections devoted to AKR's 'outer' aesthetics and poetics (see the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5 and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7). AKR was one of the leading translators and interpreters of Tamil Sangam poetry and poetics in the second half of the twentieth century, so it is not surprising that a great deal of scholarship on Tamil aesthetics and poetics in the last decades, especially in the USA, was in part founded on his contributions to the field.

Bhakti Aesthetics

In the medieval period in south India, a new form of expression, a groundbreaking literary, poetic, and aesthetic practice and theory focused on devotion, that is, bhakti (from the word *bhaji*, 'to partake', 'to participate'), as a path to unite with the Absolute. The concept of bhakti was, of course, not new. Bhakti was an essential element in the Hindu tradition, and according to the Bhagavad Gita, one of the three spiritual paths to truth, which were *jnana* (knowledge), *karma* (action), and bhakti (devotion). Gradually, a new understanding of bhakti as a powerful and greatly influential religious practice and aesthetics flourished. It began around the sixth to ninth century AD in the Vaisnava mystic tradition of the Alvar community of Tamil poet-saints, and later thrived in the Virasaiva tradition in the Kannada (p.55) language and spread over most parts of the Indian subcontinent with the rise of the vernacular languages. Poets, musicians, and dancers worshipped their gods (Siva, Visnu, Krishna, etc.) in their regional (desi) vernacular languages, aware of the Sanskrit pan-Indian (marga) classical tradition, but in modes that had gained local attributes: the bhakta (devotee) followed a personal god with a name and shape who was worshipped, sang to, loved, and yearned for.

While bhakti acknowledges and plays with the double understanding of god as person and abstract principle (here and beyond, tangible and intangible, *saguna* and *nirguna*), it is to a great extent the immediacy of god as *saguna* brahman, as god with personified attributes and forms, that enriches the arts as expressions of this spiritual path. The transformative implications of bhakti as a new aesthetics were visible especially in the literary and performing arts, creating new genres in poetry and music, and contributing immensely to dance and theatre forms with regional (desi) and local ornamentation, flavours, and attributes. This shift developed parallel to the evolution and formation of the many vernacular languages in the Indian subcontinent (both of Dravidian and Indo-European stock) and their corresponding literary traditions.

Sanskrit aesthetics in theory and practice has evolved throughout the centuries and numerous philosophers, seminal thinkers, sages, and pundits have strived to accommodate their own philosophical thought into the *rasabhava* classical model of aesthetics. More often than not, theoreticians interpreted the rasa concept in the light of their own thought system in order to suit their theoretical, philosophical, or religious agenda. Following this tradition of creative interaction, an important contribution to rasa aesthetics arises from the widespread impact of the bhakti (devotional) tradition, which had important philosophical, social, religious, literary, and aesthetic implications.

For Abhinavagupta, influenced by Buddhist thought, bhakti (devotion) was only an accessory to shanta rasa. But the concept of bhakti had gained in prominence in the poetry of south India from as early as the sixth century AD, and later evolved into an aesthetic theory with successive contributions by philosophers and spiritual masters such as Rupa Goswami (sixteenth century AD). In fact the bhakti scholars, sects, and religious branches recognized that the aesthetics of bhakti cannot be completely disengaged from the classical Sanskrit or from the oral (folk) traditions, as they share a common storehouse of ideas, motifs, and myths. Bhakti is, in this sense, a meeting place of **(p.56)** several aesthetic traditions. In the bhakti tradition, pan-Indian ideas and local motifs are ‘made’ into new material by wandering poets who sing of the public world and creation, as well as of love and personal mystic experiences, and inspire with their poems peasants, kings, and Brahmins.

At the same time, bhakti in art practice (poetry, music, performing arts) and as an aesthetic theory (which evolved later) also contributed to Sanskrit aesthetics in interesting ways either by way of contrast, sometimes in opposition to the classical tenets, or by integration, addition, and complementation. It can be said that one of the flaws of classical Sanskrit aesthetics was that it did not describe the various types of srīngara (love) as they existed in human relations and in literature, which dealt with human emotions and relationships. The classical rasa theory focused mainly on erotic love (that is, love between male and female). In the early sixteenth century AD Rupa Goswami, a follower of the Vaisnava cult, attempted to fill this void and identified five types or levels of bhakti (devotion) that could apply to the worship of Krishna. In his hierarchical model, he placed the emotion of shanta (equipoise, non-emotion) at the base as the neutral rasa, and moving up in intensity he distinguished between *dasya* (servitude), *sakhya* (friendship), *vatsalya* (parental love), and *madhurya* (a form of srīngara, love) as the culmination of an intense union with the object of worship—Krishna—leading to infatuation and ultimately to spiritual release.

Goswami’s approach and that of other bhakti philosophers and spiritual leaders foregrounded bhakti as the tenth rasa and even claimed that bhakti was the ultimate rasa, a superior emotional state that explained and illuminated all others. The bhakta (philosopher and practitioner in one), did not attempt to

integrate the notion of bhakti into the rasa theory as much as he was seeking to explain rasa theory in terms of bhakti. For the devotee, bhakti became the only *raison d'être* of human emotions (that is, of all other rasabhavas) and of human wisdom: from the Vedas and Upanishads to Buddhist thought, from classical notions of bhakti to classical Tamil Sangam poetry and to the numerous folk traditions. Bhakti was thus aestheticized and rasa was further spiritualized. The experience of bhakti—*bhaktirasa*—was considered aesthetically superior. Because the aesthetic was subordinated to the religious belief and practice, personal feeling (bhava) and visible experience (anubhava)—and their transformation—were the ultimate goals.

(p.57) And so to speak of aesthetics in the bhakti tradition is to speak also of religion. In bhakti, the borders between art and life tend to be blurred as the artist, singer, painter, musician, or poet is usually a devotee. In bhakti, the artist, the object, and the goal are a composite reality and cannot be held separate as in Sanskrit or classical Western aesthetics. Bhakti aesthetics concentrates on the expressive self and on the many ways it can relate to the divine through whatever medium of expression. For the bhakta, art is a path to the divine and a form of communicating a personal spiritual search. The particular art form and the aesthetic experience become a means rather than the end. Personal feeling and experience, devotional love, for example, overtakes art and aesthetic experience, which are rendered secondary. The aesthetic serves a spiritual end, which is the only purpose in real life.

For the bhakti poet/devotee as well as theoretician, bhakti in real life is indistinct from bhakti in poetry or in any other form of performance (dance, drama, storytelling, and so on). Art becomes the ritual of worship. Bhakti is, therefore, the existential bridge between the world (emotions) and transcendence, and moves beyond a traditional secular or religious conception of art. Here, the spectator and the performer do not merely taste the flavour (rasa) of transcendence, but become devotees of that ultimate rasa—the *bhaktirasa* of physical infatuation (*madhurya*)—as they yearn to turn into the very nectar—the food—that is savoured or devoured in a process of ultimate transformation. In some bhakti traditions, the highest expression of art is possession, that is, a complete transformation, a conflation of subject and object, worshipper and worshipped, artist and audience. In the experience of *bhaktirasa*, the artist (performer/poet), the text, and the receiver are merged. Since the artist is a bhakta (that is, a devotee or saint), his/her ultimate goal is to unite with the object of devotion and to embody it, to 'participate' in Visnu or Siva in their multiple forms.⁷⁸

The aesthetic theory of bhakti is intrinsic to praxis and technique, as can be observed in the medieval bhakti poetic traditions of south India that were studied closely by AKR. For instance, the early bhakti poets, the Tamil Alvar poet-saints ('the immersed ones')⁷⁹ who lived between the sixth and ninth

centuries AD, were devotees of Visnu, the god who represents maya (illusion), preservation, and continuity. Visnu brings forth creation through transformation by incarnating in all things and descending to the world in his multiple avatars. The Alvars strived to embody in words the flux of things **(p.58)** and the supremacy of Visnu. In their mystic poetics of process and intimacy, the pivot is always the all-pervading, playful god Visnu in his infinite manifestations. Whereas the Alvar poets stressed possession, incarnation, and continuity through transformation, the Virasaiva *lingayat* saints (worshippers of Siva) from the Kannada-speaking region, firmly believed in their lord's grace in opposition to the orthodox idea of karma. In both traditions, art (song, poem, etc.) can only happen if it is prompted by a spontaneous experience. But the artist or poet needs to work towards such a momentary state of divine inspiration through bhakti, that is, devotion to Lord Siva. The oral vachana poems of the Virasaiva tradition originating in the tenth century AD in the Kannada language, were sung by the worshipping poets to a particular form of Siva. The aesthetics of these poet-saints is framed by their personal devotion to this form of the god, who was marked by a distinct name and specific attributes.⁸⁰ A characteristic belief of the *vachanakaras* was that, contrary to the prescribed (Vedic and folk) religions, artistic inspiration and true vision are capricious and subject to the grace of god (*kripa*). These poet-saints distinguish between anubhava 'experience' and anubhāva 'the Experience', the unpredictable, spontaneous ecstasy that may arrive in the process of artistic-spiritual practice, that is, bhakti (see the sections 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5, and 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition' and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7).

To conclude this introduction to bhakti aesthetics, which has multiple manifestations and ramifications, we could underline several features that differentiate the bhakti aesthetics described here from the Sanskrit aesthetics of rasa:

1. Since the bhakti poets believed in poetry of private thoughts, the mother tongue was the essential condition for their aesthetics of spontaneity and natural feelings. Likewise, other bhakti art forms closely related to poetry (dance, music) were enriched by absorbing from their immediate environment the regional/local (*desi*) flavours, imagery, modes, tunes, rhythms, movements, costumes, and other tangible and intangible forms of expression.
2. In bhakti poetry there is no aesthetic distance. Bhakti breaks down the line that separates the subject of the poem (for example, the god Visnu) from the poet, and also dilutes the poet-saint with character and speaker. Rasa aesthetics, on the contrary, distinguishes between **(p.59)** all the aesthetic elements: artist/poet, actor, actor's role, subject of the work of art, and the different types of states and emotions, their causes and consequences, and the audience.

3. Bhakti aesthetics is a poetics of bhavas (personal emotions) and anubhavas (effects of personal emotions). The Alvars, for instance, did not believe in the refined, depersonalized aesthetic emotion that defined rasa. The ultimate purpose of their compositions was to address a living god and a community, thus their poetry draws on the spontaneous personal feelings of the poet-performer-devotee 'whether aesthetic or not'.⁸¹

In several of the aspects delineated here, bhakti aesthetics is closely intertwined with ancient Indian popular practices or what can be called folk aesthetics (see the section 'Folk Aesthetics' in Chapter 5). Indian oral traditions, ritual performance, and theatre share some of their principal characteristics with bhakti aesthetics, as AKR repeatedly noted.⁸²

Indian Aesthetics in the Early Twentieth Century

Among the stalwarts of the early twentieth-century Indian theory of art and literary aesthetics were Rabindranath Tagore, Aurobindo Ghose, and Ananda K. Coomaraswamy. Each in his own way contributed to forge a modern Indian aesthetics that attempted to explain classical Indian (mainly Sanskrit) aesthetics and notions of art in the light of a Western conceptual framework and almost inevitably, as AKR observed, through the dominating English language: 'The second culture (and the second language) often dominates the first, and gives it a metalanguage to think about itself. Thus, much modern Indian aesthetic criticism is carried on in Western terms—earlier it used to be in Sanskrit terms.'⁸³ The three pioneering authors that will be briefly introduced here were well-versed in Western and Indian theories of art and literature and belonged to a group of seminal intellectuals, writers, and artists of the late colonial period who tried to make the best out of their double heritage of 'East' and 'West'.⁸⁴ In an important sense, these scholars were 'translators' and interpreters of Indian culture. They mediated between two rather dissimilar notions of art and philosophy, the marga or classical Sanskrit and the videshi or Western, while they were prone to highlighting the transcendental aspect of Indian aesthetics in their comparisons with Western theories. I would like to **(p.60)** illustrate through short excerpts from essays by these three thinkers the synthesizing tendency and the predominantly metaphysical aura attached to Indian theory of art in the early twentieth century. The grandiloquent style, the peculiar metalanguage that foregrounded the spiritual dimension of the aesthetic experience, and the holistic vision of these eminent figures of early twentieth-century Indian aesthetics contrasts with the modern scientific objectivity, eclecticism, and postmodern plurality of many Indian intellectuals of the second half of the twentieth century. Within this critical scenario we can place AKR, who adopted a wide canopy of theories and ideas in his appreciation of art and aesthetic experience.

The texts by Coomaraswamy, Aurobindo, and Tagore quoted ahead have been selected from three seminal essays published between 1917 and 1920, a period that coincides with an important rise of the Indian nationalist movement. A.K. Coomaraswamy, art scholar and Western-trained intellectual, was known to tackle diverse concepts of beauty in his discussion of aesthetics, which took place largely within the framework of classical Sanskrit aesthetics, Indian religious philosophy, and the Western theory of art. In his famed essay 'That Beauty Is a State' collected in *The Dance of Shiva*, Coomaraswamy also takes a dip into the medieval Indian devotional tradition (bhakti) to explain beauty as a transcendental state:

[T]here remain philosophers firmly convinced that an absolute Beauty (*rasa*) exists, just as others maintain the conceptions of absolute Goodness and absolute Truth.

The vision of beauty is spontaneous, in just the same sense as the inward light of the lover (*bhakta*). It is a state of grace that cannot be achieved by deliberate effort; though perhaps we can remove hindrances to its manifestation, for there are many witnesses that the secret of all art is to be found in self-forgetfulness. And we know that this state of grace is not achieved in the pursuit of pleasure; the hedonists have their reward, but they are in bondage to loveliness, while the artist is free in beauty.... Let us insist, however, that the concept of beauty originated with the philosopher, not with the artist.... It will now be seen in what sense we are justified in speaking of Absolute Beauty, and in identifying this beauty with God. We do not imply by this God (who is without parts) has a lovely form which can be the object of knowledge; but that in so far as we see and feel beauty, we see and are one with Him.⁸⁵

Aurobindo Ghose was a political activist, spiritual leader, and prolific essayist and poet who wrote poetry in English in a Romantic (**p.61**) vein, combining Indian mysticism with the nationalistic cause. In 'The Significance of Indian Art', he compares the European and Indian views of art in his typical grandiloquence:

The European artist gets his intuition by a suggestion from an appearance once to an external support. He brings down that intuition into his normal mind and sets the intellectual idea and the imagination in the intelligence to clothe it with a mental stuff which will render its form to the moved reason, emotion, aesthesis. Then he missions his eye and hand to execute it in terms which start from a colourable 'imitation' of life and Nature—and in ordinary hands too often end there—to get at an interpretation that really changes it into the image of something not outward in our own being or in universal being which was the real thing seen....

The theory of ancient Indian art at its greatest—and the greatest gives its character to the rest and throws on it something of its stamp and influence—is of another kind. Its highest business is to disclose something of the Self, the Infinite, the Divine to the regard of the soul, the Self through its expressions, the Infinite through its living finite symbols, the Divine through his power in life and Nature....⁸⁶

Rabindranath Tagore, Bengali writer, painter, and educationist, echoes the ancient Sanskrit scholars in 'What Is Art?' (1917), an essay that weaves its central issues around classical Sanskrit aesthetic principles, and distinguishes abstract ideas of art from personal aesthetic experience:

For the true principle of art is the principle of unity. When we want to know the food value of certain of our diets, we find it in their component parts; but its taste-value is in its unity, which cannot be analysed. Matter taken by itself is an abstraction which can be dealt with by science; while manner, which is merely manner, is an abstraction which comes under the laws of rhetoric. But when they are indissolubly one, then they find their harmonies in our personality, which is an organic complex of matter and manner, thoughts and things, motives and actions.

Therefore we find all abstract ideas are out of place in true art, where, in order to gain admission, they must come under the disguise of personification.... In Art the person in us is sending its answers to the Supreme Person, who reveals Himself to us in a world of endless beauty across the lightless works of facts.⁸⁷

These glimpses of Western and various Indian conceptions of art and aesthetics provide us with a preliminary background to map out **(p.62)** AKR's network of aesthetic traditions in its theoretical dimension as well as to trace his personal aesthetics to multiple environments.

Notes:

(*) This quotation is from the *Mundaka Upanishad*, which delves into the secret of the self and opens AKR's poem 'Questions', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 130. It is cited in several of AKR's essays and is a recurring motif in his aesthetic and poetic thought. According to the author, it illustrates 'the ancient conception that the self has two aspects, a watching one (*saksin*) and an active one'. See Ramanujan, 'Repetition in the Mahabharata', in Vinay Dharwadker (ed.), *CE* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1999), pp. 180–1. See also the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5.

(1.) A.K. Ramanujan, 'Parables and Commonplaces', in Guy Amirthanayagam (ed.), *Writers in East-West Encounter: New Cultural Bearings* (London: Macmillan, 1982), p. 139.

(2.) On context-sensitivity, see Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, pp. 34–51.

(3.) 'Appendix 1: Primary Sources for a Study of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics' offers a classification and description of the diverse published and unpublished writings by AKR that have been scrutinized for an analysis of his aesthetics and poetics. It serves as a guide to the well-known publications as well as to hitherto unexplored primary sources, containing the life work of a poet-scholar operating in several literary cultures.

(4.) Makarand Paranjape, "'The Invasion of Theory": An Indian Response', *New Quest*, vol. 81 (May–June 1990), pp. 151–61.

(5.) See, for example, Ananda K. Coomaraswamy, *The Dance of Shiva: Fourteen Indian Essays* (New York: The Noonday Press, 1957 [1918]), pp. 48–53, and *Introduction to Indian Art* (Madras: Theosophical Publishing House, 1923), rpt New Delhi: Munshiram Manoharlal, 1969; Sri Aurobindo, *The Future Poetry* (Pondicherry: Sri Aurobindo Ashram, 1950), *Letters on Poetry, Literature and Art* (Bombay: Sri Aurobindo Circle, 1949), and *The Foundations of Indian Culture* (Pondicherry: Sri Aurobindo Ashram, 1953); Rabindranath Tagore, 'What Is Art?' *Personality* (London: Macmillan, 1917), also published in G.N. Devy (ed.), *Indian Literary Criticism: Theory and Interpretation* (New Delhi: Orient Longman, 2002), pp. 137–52, and 'Modern Poetry', in Amiya Chakrabarti (ed.), *A Tagore Reader* (Boston: Beacon, 1961 [1932]), pp. 241–53, also published in Sisir Kumar Das and Sukanta Chaudhuri (eds), *Selected Writings on Literature and Language* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2001), pp. 280–91.

(6.) See Paranjape, 'The Invasion of Theory'.

(7.) See Krishna Rayan, *Suggestion and Statement in Poetry* (New Delhi: B.R. Publishers, 1972), *Text and Subtext* (New Delhi: B.R. Publishers, 1987), *The Burning Bus: Suggestion in Indian Literature* (New Delhi: B.R. Publishers, 1988), pp. 2–18, 45–51, 55–61, 175–93, and *Sahitya: A Theory for Indian Critical Practice* (New Delhi: Sterling Publishers, 1991); Krishna Chaitanya, *Sanskrit Poetics: A Critical and Comparative Study* (Bombay: Asia Publishing House, 1965), and 'The Doctrine of Suggestion', in S.K. Desai and G.N. Devy (eds), *Critical Thought: Anthology of Twentieth-Century Indian English Essays* (New Delhi: Sterling Publishers, 1987), pp. 140–63; Charu Sheel Singh, *Concentric Imagination: Mandala Literary Theory* (New Delhi: B.R. Publishers, 1995); C.D. Narasimhaiah, *A Common Poetic for Indian Literatures* (Mysore: Dhvanyaloka, 1984); and V.K. Gokak, *Pathways to the Unity of Indian Literature* (New Delhi: B.R. Publishers, 1989).

(8.) See Ayyappa Paniker, *Modern Indian Poetry in English* (New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 1991), p. 12; and John Oliver Perry, *Absent Authority: Issues in*

Contemporary Indian English Criticism (New Delhi: Sterling Publishers, 1992), pp. 315-18.

(9.) See Ayyappa Paniker, 'Indian Poetry in English and the Indian Aesthetic Tradition', in *Indian Literature in English* (Madras: Anu Chitra, 1989), pp. 1-14; and K. Chellapan and Kanaka Bhashyam, 'Encounter and Synthesis in the Poetry of A.K. Ramanujan', *The Journal of Indian Writing in English*, vol. 13, no. 2 (July 1985), pp. 96-104. For comparative studies, see, for instance, the essays on Hopkins's *inscape* and the Tamil *ullurai*, and on Northrop Frye's archetypal criticism and Tamil poetics. Ayyappa Paniker, 'Hardy's Wessex and *Tinai* Poetics', in P.K. Rajan and Swapna Daniels (eds), *Indian Poetics and Modern Texts* (New Delhi: Chand and Co., 1998), pp. 54-61, 'Tolkappiyam and Western Poetics' and 'Inscape and Ullurai', in P. Marudnayagam (ed.), *Across the Seven Seas: Essays in Comparative Literature* (New Delhi: B.R. Publishers, 1994), pp. 1-13 and 15-27, respectively, 'The Postcolonial Experience in Indian Literature', in Rama Nair, B. Gopal Rao, and D. Venkateswarlu (eds), *Framing Literature: Critical Essays* (New Delhi: Sterling Publishers, 1995), n.p.; and K. Chellapan, "'Ullurai" and "Iraicchi": With Special Reference to Tolkappiyam and *Sangam* Poetry', *Indian Literature*, vol. 117 (January-February 1987), pp. 65-71, and 'The Literary Theory of Tolkapaiyar: A Comparison with Structuralist Theories', copy of the author's typescript (March 1998).

(10.) Perry, *Absent Authority*, pp. 268-9.

(11.) Perry, *Absent Authority*, p. 72.

(12.) For instance, in a retrospective analysis of South Asian studies in the USA, John Stratton Hawley observed, with regard to AKR's contribution to medieval bhakti studies, that 'his work with McKim Marriot and others on "indigenous categories," ... has helped Western students of religion to examine the familiar furniture of their intellectual living rooms'. John Stratton Hawley, 'Religious Studies: Medieval Hinduism', in Joseph W. Elder, Edward C. Dimock, and Ainslie T. Embree (eds), *India's Worlds and U.S. Scholars: 1947-1997* (New Delhi: Manohar, 1998), p. 436. See also further comments on AKR's contribution to Indian studies in the USA in the same book on pp. 49, 221, and 222.

(13.) On the distinction between 'great' and 'little' traditions, see, for example, Robert Redfield, *Peasant Society and Culture* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1954), pp. 41-2; and Milton Singer, *When a Great Tradition Modernises: An Anthropological Approach to Indian Civilisation* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1972).

(14.) It is not my intention here to provide an account of the origin and multiple interpretations of these complex concepts, which have been the subject of seminal critical studies in postmodern criticism and other recent scholarship. American scholar Sheldon Pollock, a friend and colleague of AKR at the

University of Chicago, offers, in *The Language of the Gods in the World of Men: Sanskrit, Culture and Power* (Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 2006), a powerful reassessment of the evolution of these terms in early Indian history. On the use of these concepts in Indian literary criticism, see also G.N. Devy, *After Amnesia: Tradition and Change in Indian Literary Criticism* (New Delhi: Orient Longman, 1992), p. 78.

(15.) Makarand Paranjape (ed.), *Nativism: Essays in Criticism* (New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 1997), back cover. Devy, on the other hand, explains 'nativism' as a concept that 'views literature as an activity taking place "within" a specific language, such as Marathi or Gujarati, and bound by the rules of discourse native to the language of its origin'. See Devy, *After Amnesia*, pp. 19–20. In his later work, Devy has focused on the study of Adivasi (tribal) arts and oral literatures.

(16.) Nemade's seminal article has been translated from the Marathi original as 'Nativism in Literature', in Paranjape, *Nativism*, pp. 233–54.

(17.) Devy, 'Muticulturalism', in *In Another Tongue: Essays on Indian English Literature* (Madras: Macmillan, 1995), p. 14. This essay was previously published as 'The Multicultural Context of Indian English Literature', *Englische Amerikanische Studien*, vol. 2 (June 1989), n.p.

(18.) Paniker, 'Indian Poetry in English and the Indian Aesthetic Tradition', p. 14. The three listed features are my own summary of this essay.

(19.) AKR mentions repeatedly in his essays that these distinctions employed in the work of anthropologists Robert Redfield and Milton Singer had to be reassessed. See further in this chapter.

(20.) Ramanujan, 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry in English', *An Introduction to India*, pamphlet containing articles commissioned on the occasion of the 7th Non-Alignment Summit in New Delhi (New Delhi: External Publications Division, Ministry of External Affairs, March 1983), p. 51. Also published as 'Contemporary Indian Poetry', *Financial Express* (6 March 1983), p. 5, and as 'Is Poetry Dead? A Critical Look at the Indian Scene', *The Times of Deccan*, Bangalore (27 March 1983), n.p.

(21.) Ramanujan, 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry in English', p. 51.

(22.) While Bharati's influence is limited mostly to contemporary literature in Tamil language, the influence of Tagore has been remarkable at the pan-Indian and international levels.

(23.) Ramanujan, 'Telling Tales', in *CE*, p. 450.

(24.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Literatures', AKR Papers (May 1985). All quotations from lecture notes, diaries, and journals cited from the AKR Papers are originally handwritten texts unless otherwise specified.

(25.) Ramanujan, 'On the "Unity" and "Diversity" of Indian Literatures', lecture presented at the 38th Frankfurt Book Fair (1986), and 'Classics Lost and Found', in *CE*, pp. 184–96.

(26.) Ramanujan, 'On Bharati and His Prose Poems', in *CE*, p. 333. The essay was drafted around 1983–4, but published posthumously in 1999 in *CE*. On AKR's appreciation of Bharati, see also the section 'Nineteenth and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(27.) A.K. Ramanujan, 'The Relevance of South Asian Folklore', in Peter J. Claus, J. Handoo, and D.P. Pattanayak (eds), *Indian Folklore 2* (Mysore: Central Institute of Indian Languages, 1987), p. 79.

(28.) See Wendy Doniger, 'General Essays on Literature and Culture: Introduction by Wendy Doniger', in *CE*, p. 4.

(29.) See also Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *Folktales from India: A Selection of Oral Tales from Twenty-Two Languages* (hereafter: *FI*) New York: Pantheon, 1991; New Delhi: Penguin Books, 1993), p. xvi. Also see 'Towards an Anthology of City Images' and 'Who Needs Folklore?' in *CE*, pp. 63, 535–6 for AKR's observations on the traditional Indian distinction of marga and desi, and Robert Redfield's classification of literary traditions into 'great' and 'little'. AKR's interpretation of the concept of tradition in the context of his poetics is discussed in the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8.

(30.) Ramanujan, 'Telling Tales', in *CE*, pp. 449–50. An entire unpublished lecture by AKR, 'Sanskrit and the Mother-Tongues', speaks about the cultural and social relations implicit in this multilinguistic environment. See also the interviews by Jamie Kalven, 'Found in the Translation', *University of Chicago Magazine* (June 1992), p. 35, and Uma Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', *Economic Times*, Bangalore (1992), n.p., on the metaphor of the house.

(31.) Many poets of AKR's generation in post-Independence Indian writing in English and in regional languages were drawn to the modernist poets and poetics of the early twentieth century. Modernist poetics was in vogue since the 1930s in some of the Indian regional languages, and made a prominent appearance in IPE after the 1950s.

(32.) AKR uses the terms 'pan-Indian' and 'interregional' to define the marga tradition in *Speaking of Siva* (hereafter: *SoS*) (New Delhi: Penguin Books, 1973), p. 23.

(33.) A contemporary Indian poet like Adiga, exponent of the *navya* (new) or modernist movement in Kannada literature, would typically reflect a particular aesthetic and poetic credo within the regional, pan-Indian, and international literary scene.

(34.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *SoS*, p. 23.

(35.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', interview conducted at the University of Michigan in 1989, in Molly Daniels-Ramanujan and Keith Harison (eds), *Uncollected Poems and Prose: A.K. Ramanujan* (hereafter: *UPP*) (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2001), pp. 55-6.

(36.) See Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 40.

(37.) A.K. Ramanujan, *The Interior Landscape: Love Poems from a Classical Tamil Anthology* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1967). Two years earlier, he had published a booklet titled *Fifteen Poems from a Classical Tamil Anthology* (Calcutta: Writers Workshop, 1965).

(38.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *SoS*, pp. 34-5. AKR cites in his introductory essay (published in 1973), Victor W. Turner's *The Ritual Process: Structure and Anti-Structure* (New York: Ithaca, 1969), though an earlier version of his essay had, in fact, been drafted before he read Turner's book. The essay was delivered as a speech in 1971 at the School of African and Oriental Languages, University of London at the seminar on 'Aspects of Religion in South Asia' (30 March-2 April 1971). Turner, in a detailed commentary (published a few years later) on AKR's introduction to *SoS*, observed the following on AKR's adaptation of the concepts of his book title: '[H]e was so much struck by the resemblance between the opposition indicated in its subtitle and that which he had noted in the Indian data that he made it the title of his paper, "Structure and Anti-Structure: The Virasaiva Example."' See Victor W. Turner, *Drama, Fields and Metaphor: Symbolic Action in Human Society* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1974), pp. 279-89.

(39.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 23. See also Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows: Towards an Anthology of Reflections', in *CE*, p. 27.

(40.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *FI*, p. viii.

(41.) Ramanujan was especially influenced by Russian scholar Mikhail Bakhtin, whom he quotes several times in his essays. Bakhtin distinguished in his theory of communication between texts that can be placed on a monologic or dialogic continuum. See M.M. Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination: Four Essays*, ed. Michael Holquist, trans Caryl Emerson and Michael Holquist (Austin and London: University of Texas Press, 1981). See also the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8.

(42.) In 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 40, AKR quotes the linguist John Lyons (*Introduction to Theoretical Linguistics* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1971]) on the two types of grammatical rules: context-sensitive/context-free. Drafted in the early 1980s, the essay was first published in *Contributions to Indian Sociology*, vol. 23, no. 1 (New Delhi: Institute of Economic Growth, 1989), pp. 41–58, and later collected in *CE*, pp. 34–51. On the other hand, the essay 'Where Mirrors Are Windows' was first published in *History of Religions*, vol. 28, no. 3 (February 1989), pp. 187–216, and appeared later in *CE*, pp. 6–33. Though he quotes Bakhtin's dialogism in this essay, AKR does not, however, identify any source for his interpretation of the term reflexivity. Roman Jakobson, one of the most influential linguists in AKR's career, defined the poetic function of language as one that focuses on the message itself, that is, reflexivity. Jakobson studied 'deixis' (words that need contextual information) and the functions of communication to conclude that poetry is self-reflexive, though the pioneering linguist does not use the term 'reflexivity'. Later, reflexivity became an important concept in anthropology (see, for example, the work of Clifford Geertz) as well as in philosophy and literary criticism. See Bakhtin, *The Dialogic Imagination* and Clifford Geertz, *The Interpretation of Cultures* (New York: Basic Books, 1973).

(43.) See Ramanujan, 'Parables and Commonplaces', in Amirthanayagam (ed.), *Writers in East-West Encounter*, p. 139, quoted in the opening paragraph of this chapter.

(44.) Ramanujan, 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, p. 491.

(45.) Stuart Blackburn and A.K. Ramanujan (eds), 'Introduction', in *Another Harmony: New Essays on the Folklore of India* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1986; and London: Oxford University Press, 1986), pp. 12–13. See also Velchuru Narayana Rao's remarks on the adoption of these categories in other fields of literary studies: 'With this essay [AKR's 'Afterword' in *PLW*] the Tamil concepts of *akam* and *puram* (interior and exterior) entered literary discourse and have been applied both by Ramanujan himself and by a number of others to extensive literary uses in other contexts.' See Velchuru Narayana Rao in *India's Worlds and U.S. Scholars*, pp. 341–2.

(46.) For detailed descriptions of Akam and Puram poetics in Sangam poetry, see Ramanujan, *The Interior Landscape*, pp. 101–4, *Poems of Love and War: From the Eight Anthologies and the Ten Long Poems of Classical Tamil* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1985; and New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1996), pp. 235–6, and 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, pp. 199–200, among other essays.

(47.) As stated by Blackburn ('Introduction', in *Another Harmony*, pp. 13–14), such a context-sensitive approach in genre classification comprises 'thematic,

contextual and performance features' or thematic, behavioural, and prosodic aspects.

(48.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, pp. 8–11.

(49.) The table is reproduced from *CE*, pp. 10–11.

(50.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 263.

(51.) Ramanujan, quoted in Parthasarathy, *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets*, p. 96. According to Parthasarathy, the original source of this commentary is a letter AKR sent to him in 1975: 'The quotation, "English and my disciplines ... what comes from where," is from either a questionnaire that I had sent in 1975 to Ramanujan and the other eight poets represented in *Ten Twentieth-century Indian Poets* or from a letter that Ramanujan had written to me at the time.' Personal e-mail message (23 May 2003).

(52.) The Akam–Puram paradigm could also be used to describe and classify AKR's poems into private 'love' and public 'war' poems. On the other hand, some poems imitate Tamil Sangam poetry or reflect an intertextual awareness of the poetic conventions of the classical private/love and public/war poems. See the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5 and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7. For a critical appreciation of Akam and Puram types in AKR's poems, see, for instance, Molly Daniels-Ramanujan, 'An A.K. Ramanujan Story', in *The Oxford India Ramanujan* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2004), pp. xi–xxxvi, and Akshaya Kumar, *A.K. Ramanujan*, pp. 226–9.

(53.) An Akam–Puram spectrum or continuum with different gradations is suggested by AKR in the analysis of Kannada folktales. See Ramanujan, 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, p. 489.

(54.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 8.

(55.) Furthermore, the (meta-)critical 'toolbox' elaborated from AKR's literary theory and practice could be useful to critical studies of other contemporary Indian poets writing in English.

(56.) See the poems 'Snakes' and 'Self-Portrait' in *The Striders*, in *CP*, pp. 4, 23.

(57.) See Appendix 1 for a classification and description of the interviews and meta-poems.

(58.) Ramanujan, early handwritten draft of 'Self-Portrait', published in *The Striders*, AKR Papers (early 1960s). A copy of this draft has been reproduced in the prelim pages of this book. For the published version, see 'Self-Portrait', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 23 and the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3. See also AKR's poem 'Small-Scale Reflections on a Great House',

discussed in the section 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3. See Ramanujan, 'Small-Scale Reflections on a Great House', *Relations*, in *CP*, pp. 96-9.

(59.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 10.

(60.) See Ramanujan, 'Classics Lost and Found', in *CE*, pp. 192-6. See also the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7, and 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' and 'Translation and Poetic Practice' in Chapter 8.

(61.) See also, in this context, AKR's famous poem 'Small-Scale Reflections on a Great House', *Relations*, in *CP*, pp. 96-9.

(62.) Ramanujan, notecards, AKR Papers (c. 1968), n.p. The phrase appears next to a draft of a poem titled 'Building for the Year 2000', which became the poem 'Real Estate'. See Ramanujan, 'Real Estate', *Relations*, in *CP*, pp. 91-2. This phrase is also quoted in the section 'Looking for the Other to find Oneself' in Chapter 3.

(63.) Ramanujan, 'Real Estate', *Relations*, in *CP*, p. 91.

(64.) For autobiographical insets in AKR's essays see, for instance, 'Classics Lost and Found' on his discovery of Tamil Sangam poetry in Chicago in 1962; 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' and 'Telling Tales' on his father; 'The Clay Mother-in-Law', 'Some Folktales from India', 'Towards a Counter-System: Women's Tales', 'Food for Thought', and 'Telling Tales' on his mother; 'Sanskrit and the Mother Tongues' and 'Telling Tales' on the family house; 'Repetition in the Mahabharata' and 'Tell It to the Walls' on his childhood; and 'Telling Tales' on his learning about folktale indexes in his youth. All essays cited here are found in *CE* except 'Sanskrit and the Mother Tongue', lecture presented at the Association for Sanskrit Studies, AKR Papers (1987).

(65.) Ramanujan, *Someone Else's Autobiography*, in Raju and Daniels-Ramanujan (trans) and Shobhi (advisory ed.), *A.K. Ramanujan*, pp. 214-323. Shouri is the pen name of Molly Daniels-Ramanujan, AKR's former wife.

(66.) See Jorge Luis Borges, 'Borges and I', in *Dreamtigers*, trans Mildred Boyer and Harold Morland (Austin: University of Texas Press, 1964).

(67.) Ramanujan, journal, AKR Papers (26 October 1976), n.p., underline in the original. The part Author never published any of his journals.

(68.) On the diverse interpretations of the term 'poetics', see Alex Preminger and T.V.F. Brogan (eds), *The New Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1993), pp. 929-30. See also the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7.

(69.) This is only a very simplified outline of the Western tradition(s) of aesthetics. To be more accurate, one would have to add numerous other schools and traditions. The metaphysical traditions, for instance, can be considered as a separate branch or tradition of aesthetics. On modern Western interpretations (theory and history) of art and aesthetics that belonged to AKR's intellectual moulding, see, among others, Edmund Burke, *A Philosophical Inquiry into the Origin of Our Ideas of the Sublime and Beautiful*, in *Works*, vol. 1 (London: Printed for R. and J. Dodsley, 1757; and Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2015); George Santayana, *Reason in Art* (New York: Dover, 1982; and New York: C. Scribner's Sons, 1905) and *The Sense of Beauty* (London: A. & C. Black, 1894; and New York: Dover, 2012); Benedetto Croce, *Aesthetic as Science of Expression and General Linguistic*, trans. Douglas Ainslie (New York: Farrar, 1972 [1909]), and 'Aesthetics', trans. R.G. Collingwood, *Encyclopaedia Britannica*, 14th ed. (New York, 1929); Georg Lukács, *Soul and Form* (London: Merlin Press, 1974 [1911]); Jan Mukarovsky, *Aesthetic Function, Norm and Value as Social Facts*, trans. M.E. Suino (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1970 [1936]); Eliseo Vivas, 'The Esthetic Judgment', *Journal of Philosophy*, vol. 33 (1936), pp. 57-69, and *The Artistic Transaction* (Columbus: Ohio State University Press, 1963); A. Hofstadter and Richard Kuhns (eds), *Philosophies of Art and Beauty* (New York: Random House, 1964); Monroe C. Beardsley, *Aesthetics from Classical Greece to the Present* (New York: Macmillan, 1966), and *Aesthetics*, 2nd ed. (Indianapolis: Hackett, 1981); J.M.E. Moravcsik and P. Temko (eds), *Plato on Beauty, Wisdom, and the Arts* (Totowa: Rowman & Littlefield, 1982); Theodor W. Adorno, *Aesthetic Theory*, trans. Christian Lenhardt, eds G. Adorno and R. Tiedmann (London: Routledge, 1984); and Richard Hertz (ed.), *Theories of Contemporary Art* (Englewood Cliffs: Prentice Hall, 1985).

(70.) On the historical evolution of classical European aesthetics in regard to poetics and rhetoric, see, for instance, Antonio García Berrio and T. Hernández F., *La Poética: Tradición y modernidad*, 2nd ed. (Madrid: Síntesis, 1994).

(71.) For divergent Western conceptualizations of aesthetics and their problematics, see Monroe C. Beardsley, *Aesthetics: Problems in the Philosophy of Criticism* (New York: Harcourt, Brace & World, 1958) and Carolyn Korsmeyer (ed.), *Aesthetics: The Big Questions* (Malden: Blackwell, 1998).

(72.) For an English edition of the *Natya Sastra*, see *The Natya Sastra of Bharatamuni*, trans. a board of scholars (Delhi: Sri Satguru Publications, 1986). The exact date and authorship of this landmark work attributed to Bharata are both in dispute.

(73.) For contemporary interpretations of the rasa theory in Sanskrit aesthetics and comparative studies of aesthetics, see, for instance, A.K. Ramanujan, *Hymns for the Drowning: Poems for Visnu by Nammalvar* (hereafter: *HD*) (Princeton:

Princeton University Press, 1981; and New Delhi: Penguin Books, 1993), pp. 161–2; rpt 2005, and A.K. Ramanujan and Edwin Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', in Edward C. Dimock, Edwin Gerow, C.M. Naim, A.K. Ramanujan, Gordon Roadarmel, and J.A.B. Van Buiteneene, *The Literatures of India: An Introduction* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1974; and London: Oxford University Press, 1975), pp. 129–30. See also Hanumantha Rao, *Comparative Aesthetics: Eastern and Western* (Mysore: D.V.K. Murthy, 1974); Ghoshal Sastri, *Elements of Indian Aesthetics* (Varanasi: Chaukhambha Orientalia, 1978); V.S. Seturaman (ed.), *Indian Aesthetics: An Introduction* (Madras: Macmillan, 1992); and A.R. Biswas, 'The Philosophy of Beauty', *Critique of Poetics*, vol. II (New Delhi: Atlantic Publishers, 2005), pp. 425–63.

(74.) See Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. ix–x.

(75.) Devy, for instance, comments: 'Yes, it is certain that it [the *Tolkappiyam*] has a vital link with the *Natya Sastra*. Perhaps the two share a common ancestor. At the present stage of our knowledge about India's literary past, one must inevitably stop at that question.' See Devy, *Indian Literary Criticism*, p. 16.

(76.) The *Tolkappiyam* mentions thirty-two vyabhichari bhavas and eight rasas.

(77.) On the *Tolkappiyam* and Tamil aesthetics and poetics, see AKR's afterwords in *PLW*, pp. 229–97 and *IL*, pp. 97, 115, and his essays 'Classics Lost and Found', 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', 'On Translating a Tamil Poem', 'From Classicism to Bhakti' (with Norman Cutler), in *CE*, pp. 184–96, 197–218, 219–31, 232–59. See also AKR's article on Tamil poetics in *Encyclopaedia Britannica* (1974), pp. 131–208 and in Preminger and Brogan (eds), *The New Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics*, pp. 591–4. For other authors, see S. Ilakkuvanar, *Tolkappiyam with Critical Studies* (Madurai: Kural Neri Publishing House, 1963); Xavier S. Thani Nayagam, *Landscape and Poetry: A Study of Nature in Classical Tamil Poetry* (Bombay: Asia Publishing House, 1966; and Chennai: International Institute of Tamil Studies, 1997); Kamil Zvelebil, *The Smile of Murugan: On Tamil Literature of South India* (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1973) and *Literary Conventions in Akam Poetry* (Madras: Institute of Asian Studies, 1986); and Martha Ann Selby, *Tamil Love Poetry: The Five Hundred Short Poems of the Ainkurunuru* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2011). For comparisons with Western theories and models, see, for instance, Paniker, 'Tolkappiyam and Western Poetics', in Marudnayagam (ed.), *Across the Seven Seas*; Chellapan, 'The Literary Theory of Tolkappaiyar'; and S. Murali, 'Environmental Aesthetics: Interpretation of Nature in Akam and Puram Poetry', *Indian Literature*, vol. 185 (May–June 1998), pp. 155–62.

(78.) On bhakti aesthetics, see, for instance, Karen Pechilis Prentiss, *The Embodiment of Bhakti* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999). On the

philosophical dimension of bhakti, see R. Raj Singh, *Bhakti and Philosophy* (Lanham: Lexington Books, 2006).

(79.) See Ramanujan, *HD*, pp. 103–69. On the poetics of the Alvar poets, see also Norman Cutler, *Songs of Experience: The Poetics of Tamil Devotion* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1987).

(80.) On the Kannada Virasaiva bhakti tradition, see AKR's introduction to *SoS*, pp. 19–55 and his essays 'On Women Saints', 'Men, Women, Saints', 'The Myths of *Bhakti*: Images of Siva in Saiva Poetry', 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle: An Anthological Essay', 'Varieties of *Bhakti*', in *CE*, pp. 270–8, 279–94, 295–308, 309–23, 324–31, 332–43. See also H.S. Shivaprakash, *I Keep Vigil of Rudra: The Vachanas* (New Delhi: Penguin Books, 2010).

(81.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 162.

(82.) See, for instance, the introduction to *FI* and his observations in 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore' and 'Who Needs Folklore?' in *CE*, pp. 508–9, 547.

(83.) Ramanujan, 'Parables and Commonplaces', in Amirthanayagam (ed.), *Writers in East-West Encounter*, p. 139. See also S.K. Nandi, *Studies in Modern Indian Aesthetics* (Shimla: Indian Institute of Advanced Study, 1975).

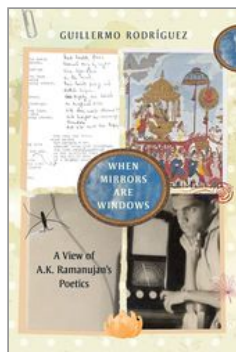
(84.) Tagore, Aurobindo, and Coomaraswamy received part of their education in England. Unlike Tagore and Aurobindo, Coomaraswamy was not born in India, but in Ceylon of an English mother and a Hindu (Tamil Brahmin) father.

(85.) Coomaraswamy, 'That Beauty Is a State', in *The Dance of Shiva*, pp. 44–53.

(86.) Aurobindo Ghose, *The Significance of Indian Art* (Pondicherry: Sri Aurobindo Ashram, 1964), p. 18. This essay was first published in 1920 in the monthly review *Arya* and later in 1947 with the above title by the Sri Aurobindo Circle in Bombay.

(87.) Rabindranath Tagore, 'What Is Art?' in Devy, *Indian Literary Criticism*, pp. 144–5, 152. Previously published in *Personality* (London: Macmillan, 1917), pp. 3–38.

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Living among 'Relations'

Biographical Contexts

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Abstract and Keywords

This chapter focuses on Ramanujan's aesthetics from a biographical perspective. It examines how his early environments influenced his aesthetic receptivity and highlights fundamental features in the first 30 years (1929–59) of his life: his multilingual childhood and education, as well as his hobbies and early professional work that shaped his 'Indian way of thinking', combining a 'context-sensitive' compartmentalization of the world with the 'context-free' dream leap. It also describes how Ramanujan was aesthetically and culturally attracted to what he himself later defined as 'counter-systems'. When Ramanujan moved to the USA in 1959, the experience of being in between two worlds, India and the USA, added yet another skill to his miscellaneous criss-crossings. He became an expert in the art of translating himself and his audience into other cultures, and his twofold academic and poetic vocation was able to thrive in a natural extension of his past while being challenged by new discoveries.

Keywords: literary biography, postcolonial studies, Mysore, University of Chicago, Dravidian studies, Indian studies in America

*Like a hunted deer
on the wide white
salt land,*

a flayed hide

turned inside out,

*one may run,
escape.*

*But living
among relations
binds the feet.*

—Translation by AKR*

'One may begin anywhere', typed AKR in 1959 in his unpublished 'Notes towards a Journal: The Journey', which describes his novel impressions as 'a stranger' who is 'disengaged from the family, the familiar' on his passage by ship from India (Bombay) to the USA via France, a journey to the New World that marked the turning point in his life and career (see the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4).¹ Without attempting to be exhaustive, I have chosen to begin with AKR's early 'familiar' life in India as the natural entry point into the 'inner forms'—the Akam—the 'substance' that contains the 'images and symbols' of the poet's (p.73) creative universe.² I will examine how the poet's upbringing and early environments, his 'first 30 years in India' (1929–59) before leaving for the USA influenced his aesthetic receptivity which was, later in life, nurtured by his 'frequent visits and field trips, [his] personal and professional preoccupations with Kannada, family, the classics and folklore'.³ This biographical perspective will serve as a gateway to the 'inner' contexts of AKR's aesthetic sensibility and allow an introduction to the man and the author before embarking on a random journey through diverse aesthetic experiences that he himself describes at different stages of his life. Chapter 4 on AKR's 'inner' aesthetics looks at the author's aesthetic attitude in the light of particular experiences and the interpretation of art and aesthetic perception as revealed primarily (but not exclusively) in the private writings from the AKR Papers and in the interviews. In addition to the interviews, private diary entries, notes, and other prose pieces, I bring into this dialogue of 'reflections' several published and unpublished poems that AKR quoted, commented, or referred to in his prose. After thorough scrutiny, I have picked these prose texts and poems out of a large body of primary sources in the AKR Papers on the grounds that they directly or indirectly inform us of AKR's aesthetic experiences and sensibility, and disclose aspects of his creative process. Whether or not they contain elements that can be traced to specific autobiographical data is a secondary issue.⁴ Poetry is closely intertwined in his notes, diaries, and other prose reflecting on art and creativity. He constantly refers to concrete experiences in the Papers and how these have sometimes shaped, inspired, or triggered poems. Thus, there is abundant textual fact about these direct or indirect connections. When skimming through the Papers, one notices at once how dream notes, diary notes, journals, and poems are often interspersed and relate intertextually. This is a trait that has already been

identified as an academic and literary technique in his published work and is further evidenced in the manuscripts and other unpublished material.

First 30 Years in India

In the study of Indian cultural patterns and aesthetics, AKR paid particular attention to the multiple levels and environments that coexist in the diverse forms of expression of art as well as in its producers and consumers: 'Aesthetics, ethos and worldview are shaped in childhood and throughout one's early life by these verbal and non-verbal **(p.74)** environments. In a largely non-literate culture, everyone—poor, rich, high caste and low caste, professor, pundit or ignoramus—has inside him or her a large non-literate subcontinent.' In India, popular forms and traditions 'weave in and out of every aspect of living city, village and small town', notes AKR in the introduction to *Folktales from India*, and these are present in each individual from the moment they are born. In such an organic system, he argues, 'what we separate as art, economics and religion' can be expressed in a single tale.⁵ In the tale of AKR's own life, there were several factors of his early environment in India that marked his aesthetic way of thinking.

The Family House

Attipat Krishnaswami Ramanujan was born on 16 March 1929 in Mysore (in the state of Karnataka in south India) as the second of six children. His father, Attipat Asuri Krishnaswami Iyengar (1892-1953), a Tamil Vaisnava Iyengar Brahmin from Triplicane, Madras, was a professor of mathematics and statistics at the University of Mysore.⁶ His mother Seshammal, a Tamilian from Srirangam, was not college-educated, but was widely read in Tamil and Kannada regional literatures. AKR's upbringing in the Mysore family house, where he was exposed to multiple Akam and Puram environments through kinship relations, multilingualism, and his father's multidisciplinary education, provided the basis for his miscellaneous intellectual and artistic output. AKR grew up surrounded by four languages (Kannada, English, Tamil, and Sanskrit) and received a trilingual formal education (Kannada, English, and to a less extent Tamil).⁷ He did not learn Sanskrit formally, but absorbed Sanskrit as a religious language and ritual code. Like most Brahmin children, he inherited orthodox religious conventions at home from his father and elders. His father spoke Tamil and English, and his mother, Tamil and Kannada. Since AKR underwent most of his formal education in modern Kannada and English, these became his literary languages. He acquired formal knowledge of Tamil only at the college level.

I have earlier alluded to AKR's metaphorical description of the different floors in the Mysore house in the context of the father tongues and mother tongues (see the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2).⁸ The three levels (upstairs, downstairs, and the terrace to the outside) also stood for the various types of knowledge AKR was to imbibe during his childhood **(p.75)** years. Downstairs in the kitchen was the Akam or

domestic sphere of family relations, gossip, and quarrels, which left space for tales and stories told by cooks, aunts, and the grandmother, spurring the fantasy and imagination of children. It was also where people discussed the local news and read Tamil and Kannada magazines. Young AKR was fascinated by the tales and popular wisdom he gleaned from his grandmother and grandaunts in the kitchen at dinnertime. Ever since then, folklore and popular culture became a vital interest which never diminished. AKR was also an insatiable reader. Throughout his life he is said to have kept the habit of reading over a hundred pages a day of all kinds of literature, from commercial and popular novels to scientific papers. His interests were therefore quite eclectic. Even as he could spend hours and days listening to elders and collecting oral tales in the villages, he indulged in watching popular films and trash TV in the latter part of his life.⁹

Upstairs in the father's study was the intellectual domain, the place of 'higher' learning: mathematics, arts, literature, and scholarly hobbies. Professor A.A. Krishnaswami Iyengar's library covered a wide range of topics comprising the sciences, literature, and philosophy in several languages (Kannada, Tamil, Sanskrit, English, and even French). Here the young boy was introduced 'to the delights of intellectual life'. AKR spent hours listening to his father, conversing about small and large topics, browsing and reading whatever came to his attention:

Ever since my seventh year I have been reading, mostly for pleasure. The range of my interests I owe to my father's influence and to the early acquaintance with Arthur Mee's Children's Encyclopedia ('Book of Knowledge') with its several thousand pictures....

I read in addition to English Literature, a great deal of psychology, philosophy (particularly Plato, Nietzsche, Schopenhauer, Russell, Santayana), the Indian mystics. I learned to read 200 pages a day.¹⁰

The upper level of the house was equally the site for Sanskrit religious wisdom and astrology, which did not fit comfortably into the rational mould that young AKR had embraced so early. Rather, he interpreted his father's double fascination for astronomical science and astrology as a weakness:

He [father] was a mathematician, an astronomer. But he was also a Sanskrit scholar, an expert astrologer. He had two kinds of visitors: American and **(p.76)** English mathematicians who called on him when they were on a visit to India, and local astrologers, orthodox pundits who wore splendid gold-embroidered shawls dowered by the Maharaja. I had just been converted by Russell to the 'scientific attitude'. I (and my generation) was troubled by his holding together in one brain both astronomy and astrology; I looked for consistency in him, a consistency he didn't seem to care about, or even think about.¹¹

Later in life, AKR was able to explain this apparent incompatibility in terms of 'context-sensitivity' in his essays. And so the perception of his father's eclecticism changed over the years, as he commented in one of the late interviews:

I was very much against astrology. I said astronomy was good, but astrology—throw it away.

... He [father] would just as easily talk about atheism and Bertrand Russell as he would about the Bhagavad Gita. Quite early he had said to me, 'Don't you know that there are two lobes to the brain?' I became convinced as I got older that he needed two worlds emotionally. He needed them for imaginative reasons.¹²

Then there was the highest level in the house, the terrace facing the Kannada-speaking city, 'where one saw dogs copulating and cows being serviced and learned all the choicest obscene words.... As we grew up we all migrated upstairs', observed AKR in another interview.¹³ Overlooking the dusty by-lanes to the lit-up Mysore Palace, the terrace shared a common sky with the outside world, with the sensuous vitality of the city and whatever could be discovered in it. In fact, for AKR, the domestic house shares more than the sky with the outer world: it has a common history, almost a common consciousness, where nothing is lost, but circulates and reincarnates in a creative flow of continuity. His famous poem 'Small-Scale Reflections on a Great House' sums up, with a note of irony, the view of the self, the family, and society at large as part of a cyclic history that begins and ends in the 'Great House':

Sometimes I think that nothing
that ever comes into this house
goes out. Things come in every day

to lose themselves among other things
lost long ago among
other things lost long ago;

(p.77) lame wandering cows from nowhere
have been known to be tethered,
given a name, encouraged

to get pregnant in the broad daylight
of the street under the elders'
supervision, the girls hiding

behind windows with holes in them.

...

And also, anything that goes out

will come back, processed and often
with long bills attached,

...

Letters mailed

have a way of finding their way back
with many re-directions to wrong
addresses and red ink marks

earned in Tiruvella and Sialkot.¹⁴

And ideas behave like rumours,
once casually mentioned somewhere
they come back to the door as prodigies

born to prodigal fathers, with eyes
that vaguely look like our own,
like what Uncle said the other day:

that every Plotinus we read
is what some Alexander looted
between the malarial rivers.

A beggar once came with a violin
to croak out a prostitute song
that our voiceless cook sang

all the time in our backyard.

(p.78) Nothing stays out: daughters
get married to short-lived idiots;
sons who run away come back

in grandchildren who recite Sanskrit
to approving old men.... (1-12, 40-2, 48-70)¹⁵

The family house turned into one of AKR's favourite metaphors for the recycling powers of his eco-aesthetic¹⁶ consciousness. This oft-quoted poem, one of the quintessential pieces from the collection *Relations*, is not only an ironic allegory on history starting with the intricate network of an extended family (the Great House being the container and filter of a personal and family history). Its multiple metaphorical meanings also move in concentric circles to encompass collective memory, culture, and nationhood. Thus, the extended family 'relations' narrate (relate) the 'inner' and 'outer' forms, connecting, in a cross-fertilizing process, the domestic sphere (the Akam) to the outside world (the Puram) of nature, culture, and society.¹⁷ One should note as well that the poet's 'reflections' on such a large ('Great') multilayered subject are nevertheless 'small-scale', underscoring AKR's lifelong 'distrust of systems of thought or

government'¹⁸ and foregrounding the particular, individual experience at the centre of his discourse.

This poem also illustrates how, from the time of his childhood, AKR was exposed to *marga*, *desi*, and *videshi* environments. The house, as he explains elsewhere, 'seemed like a symbol of multiple cultures',¹⁹ which coexisted and influenced one another. AKR's interests remained always in sway between the 'higher' arts and disciplines and the popular forms of expression and communication, be they traditional oral tales, proverbs, and other popular forms of expression, theatre, or mass media. For him, all these were aesthetic forms that embodied a culture- and time-specific ethos and a distinct world view, and which had to be experienced in context and studied in relation to one another. The multiple realities were not independent variables, but interdependent branches of the self. His knowledge of one language and culture inevitably had an effect on his view of the other: '[M]y English has affected my knowledge of Indian languages and my knowledge of Indian languages has affected my English language.... It has given me intimacy and a kind of aesthetic distance.'²⁰

(p.79) Nature and the City

The natural environment began for AKR in the courtyard behind the kitchen, where a coconut tree stood. This growing, bending tree was in several ways another point of connection between the inner and outer worlds of AKR's childhood. Its roots, trunk, and leaves linked the natural world—plant and animal—to the artificial world of social and cultural structures. To keep a coconut tree in the courtyard was customary in south-Indian homes, and it was also an important childhood motif for AKR.²¹ Eventually, the tree in the yard, a childhood scene so often observed through the kitchen window, became another key symbol and personal metaphor in AKR's work. It is there, for instance, in the poem 'Obituary' from *Relations*:

Father, when he passed on,
left dust
on a table full of papers,
left debts and daughters,
a bedwetting grandson
named by the toss
of a coin after him,

a house that leaned
slowly through our growing
years on a bent coconut
tree in the yard.... (1-11)²²

Outside the house on the streets of the city of Mysore, the child met with the full drama of life, the bustle of people, animals, colours, and odours of a south-Indian middle-sized market town which had a name as a royal city of art and learning.

The maharajas of Mysore, rulers of the then princely state of Mysore, were deemed progressive, enlightened sovereigns and patrons of the arts and higher education.²³ The city possessed a splendid past and abounded with artistic monuments, sculptures, temples, palaces, gardens, and ruins. Its busiest lanes and streets formed an urban jungle where children watched from rooftops scurrying crowds, squatting children, shaven Brahmin priests, vendors, street hawkers, beggars, bicycles, rickshaws, carts, and cars mingling with bulls, cows, dogs, cats, rats, and reptiles.

The experience of this organic combination of ancient art, palaces, rituals, and ancient traditions, the animal and the natural worlds, **(p.80)** and commonplace existence in south India became embedded in AKR's aesthetic world view. It is evident from AKR's very first poems in English and Kannada, and was later also influential in his understanding and interpretation of Tamil classical poetry and aesthetics. The portrait of a 'disorderly' convergence of nature, rural life, and the urban space was also a typical feature in the narrative of notorious south-Indian writers of the precolonial and postcolonial periods, often not devoid of caricature, cliché, and colonial bias even in a postcolonial context. Reading the novels of R.K. Narayan, for instance, one encounters in the fictional Malgudi and its surrounding villages an 'imaginary Mysore' with local character set in the pre-Independence years, in the 1930s and 1940s.²⁴ Nature being coextensive with culture, that is, the metonymical relation among the natural world, the city—culture and society—and the family house was an all-pervading motif in AKR's work. It was not, however, absorbed and invoked as an exotic life-sketch of south India, but as a powerful intellectual and aesthetic concept.

At the social and political plane, on the other hand, AKR lived through the deep transformations that the city of Mysore, as most of India's cities, were exposed to in the pre- and post-Independence years. In U.R. Ananthamurthy's Kannada novel *Samskara*, for instance, which AKR translated into English in 1976 and for which he also wrote the afterword, Mysore is depicted as a place of decadence of values and succumbing orthodox social structures in an era of profound change.²⁵

School and College Education: An Artist Is Born

AKR's father thought Ramu, as AKR was called by his close family members, 'intellectually promiscuous'²⁶ and, as an heir of Indian Renaissance ideals, wanted his son to imbibe the best of both 'East' and 'West'. Ironically, by reinforcing his son's natural inclination to Western sciences and philosophies, his father also forged in him a critical attitude to orthodox Brahminical religious beliefs and practices: 'Though they [his father and mother] were orthodox, unconsciously they educated us away from rigid religious belief and ritual. I was sent to the only Montessori kindergarten school in Mysore, and later to a Christian Mission School. In both I learnt English earlier and better than anything else.'²⁷ In fact, AKR's school and college education provided the

germinal seed for his composite intellectual **(p.81)** and artistic universe. In the early school years, he acquired a curiosity for both science and art which, as he recognized years later, proved to be a crucial asset in his academic career: '[M]y miscellaneousness, my criss-crossing between languages, disciplines and my life-long double allegiance to poetry and science have found some kind of acceptance and even acclaim'.²⁸

And so AKR's interdisciplinary thrust and sensitivity to multiple environments were both *learnt* and *experienced* in early childhood as a natural process. His parents stressed education as a substantial component in life and when, in 1932, they decided to take three-year-old Ramu to a Montessori school (Theobald's Kindergarten School), they laid the foundation stone to a multifaceted education that was to provide the right stimulus to the boy's incipient genius. The Montessori method, named after the Italian educationist Maria Montessori (1870–1952), had by then already become popular around the world. In India, educationists, artists, and intellectuals, including Rabindranath Tagore, inspired by the scientific method of the Italian, had set up Montessori centres all over the country.²⁹ Montessori's main contribution to the field of education was to prove that a child is not merely a 'blank slate' to be written on. According to her, each child has a unique creative potential that can be revealed in a context-sensitive educational system by following a number of basic principles:³⁰

1. Preparing the most natural and life-supporting environment for the child.
2. Observing the child living freely in this environment.
3. Continually adapting the environment in order that the child may fulfil his greatest potential—physically, mentally, emotionally, and spiritually.

Considering these educational factors alongside the natural family environment that AKR was exposed to, it is evident that the child was able to expand his natural abilities freely in a 'privileged' experiential milieu that spurred his multidisciplinary talent and made him trust his personal experience and intuition. After kindergarten, AKR was taken to a Christian Mission School (Hardwicke School), and the kind of education he received here from the nuns further added an entirely new cultural dimension to his upbringing.

At high school (B. Banumaiah High School), AKR studied English and Kannada, and though he won essay competitions in Kannada, he **(p.82)** obtained highest marks in mathematics. In 1943, at the age of 14, he failed his first secondary-school final examination after oversleeping for a history exam. This incident turned out to be crucial in the development of his creativity. During the year away from school, he found the time he needed to concentrate on what seemed his preferred natural gift: writing. He thus commenced his literary career writing humour sketches, short stories, plays, and poetry in Kannada, which he contributed to local Kannada magazines. As a boy, he also devoted precious time

to one of his favourite hobbies—the art of magic. From the time he was 12, he performed magic tricks at home and in public and discovered his talent for the acting stage:

I am afraid I was not a good student at High School, because I was addicted to detective novels and had a passion for carrom, badminton and conjuring tricks. I gave several magic shows in Mysore city, once even before the City Ladies' club. Ever since then I have been appearing on the stage either as a speaker or an actor.³¹

AKR's son Krishna Ramanujan also draws attention to this curious facet. Sketching out the early stages of his father's creative student life, he points out, in the introduction to *CE*, what might have inspired the boy-turned-illusionist:

While in his teens, he had the neighbourhood tailor fashion him a coat fitted with hidden pockets and elastic bands in which he concealed rabbits and bouquets of flowers. With added accoutrements of top-hat and wand he performed for local schools, women's groups, and social clubs. The desire to be a magician was perhaps a strange use of the insight he gained from his father's quirky belief in the irrational.³²

In 1944, AKR joined Maharaja's College,³³ University of Mysore, as an undergraduate student in the physical sciences. He continued scoring high marks in the sciences, but his father, who had sensed his son's literary vocation, made him change from science to English Honours in 1946. AKR's solid training in both literature and the scientific disciplines inherited from his father was to become a useful combination when he took up descriptive linguistics in Poona (Pune) in 1958:

He [father] really believed that mathematics was a kind of poetry—and behaved like 'a poet'—woke up in the middle of the night to write down an **(p.83)** equation or something, worked on his problems every day for hours as, later, I found professional novelists did on their novels every morning.

It was my father who wasn't taken in by my high marks in mathematics and science—and wouldn't let me continue with any of it for a degree. And off I went to study English Litt.—craving always for some science somewhere—the nearest I came to it was in my quasi-mathematical linguistics. I have sometimes thought that linguistics and poetry are both a search for forms, in their different ways. My father would have agreed and pointed Poincare [*sic*].³⁴

This happy confluence of art and science in AKR's education is reiterated in one of his last lecture drafts, an unpublished paper titled 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?'

My father who was a mathematician, who gave me my name (but no mathematics, alas) after his friend the great mathematician, taught me that mathematics was beautiful—that one looked for beauty as well as truth in science as well as art. So the Romantic opposition between poetry and science, between the 'two cultures' fostered often by our systems of education, was abhorrent to me.³⁵

The 'great mathematician' referred to here is the renowned mathematical genius Srinivasa Ramanujan (1887–1920), who was a contemporary of AKR's father A.A. Krishnaswami Iyengar, and made such an impression on the latter that he chose the same surname for his second son. At college, AKR founded a group of 'literary friends' with fellow students, who would gather at the home library of a teacher, Kannada poet S. Anantanarayana, to discuss philosophy, art, and literature.³⁶

When I was in India I studied English Literature and thought about Shakespeare and T.S. Eliot and quoted them. I still remember evenings when, two or three friends, we would walk around in the markets of a town in South India where the women from which we bought the bitter leaves, the mango or the bananas did not know even one word of English and we would go and buy all sorts of things in a totally Indian environment and talk about Proust, Plato and Shakespeare. So, it seems to me, the world in which we live is not one world only. Worlds are woven together and interpenetrate, creating the world we know. I cannot forget this, I can't forget the multiplicity of worlds we live in simultaneously, not alternately, and I think this is probably true for us all.³⁷

By 1946, AKR had already established a reputation at college as a multitalented student and writer. He was simultaneously following **(p.84)** his early penchant for entertainment, stage-acting, writing plays and skits in Kannada, and working as an editor of the college magazine and member of the entertainment wing of an all-India students' organization. AKR had produced several radio plays in Kannada broadcast by All India Radio (AIR), and his teachers had even staged one of his plays while he was still an undergraduate student. He impressed his college teachers with his multifarious skills and accretion of knowledge. Professor W.G. Eagleton from Cambridge, who taught at Maharaja's College, recommended AKR in the following terms for a Kannada sub-editor's post at AIR that the young graduate had wanted to apply for in 1949: 'Sri Ramanujam [*sic*] has a great zest for literature, and read very widely, well beyond the bounds of the Honours syllabus. He is extraordinarily well-informed and the range of his intellectual interests is exceptionally wide.'³⁸ It was Eagleton who tuned AKR's English pronunciation to the BBC accent and introduced him not only to English phonetics, Shakespeare, and modern poetry in English, but with less success

also to the aesthetics of Western music, as AKR wrote in a retrospective diary note:

28 Aug. 1971

Heard one Bach-on-cello 3 times reminds me Eagleton again explained a fugue to me in his house once—like all my education, a magpie's nest of mirrors and seeds—some of which I'll shit out undigested, like the Magpie itself and yet unconsciously sowing them for more seed maybe, even by my not digesting them.³⁹

Soon after joining the English Honours course and becoming a student under Eagleton, AKR started to scribble poems and began to keep a diary in English. The first poetry drafts in English that can be found in the AKR Papers date from 1947, and the first diary in English is from 1949. Aptly titled 'A Poem Is Born', this early diary record, which reads as an autobiographical short story, describes in the third person the aesthetic experiences and coming of age of an incipient poet and brings to life the streets of Mysore, his literary friends, mother, father, brothers, and sisters and the family house that permeated AKR's artistic consciousness:

Mother, old dear, was ready with coffee and the morning grumble. 'O, Ramoo, you've grown such an idler these days! It's already eight-twenty and you have yet to take your coffee.... God knows what made you so moping and indifferent. You came late at night, and get up late. Father always had **(p.85)** high hopes for you, but you see what it's come to. It must be those vagabond friends of yours ... something comes over these youngsters....'

He let her go on. It did one good to hear mother talk. But when it came to his friends, he wouldn't let her say that. 'O, no, mother. My friends are such spotless fellows. You can't call them vagabonds, tho' I'm one', he said, in earnest defence, rather proud of his 'Bohemianism'.⁴⁰

A specialist in making the best use out of the existing environments, young AKR thus translated the many-layered reality he absorbed in his native Mysore, in school, college, and the family house, into artistic expression and performance. Having learnt early how to manipulate reality in the illusory art of magic tricks, he took to the creative exploitation of language in plays, and stories as well as poetry, experimenting with multiple levels of signification and a mask of indirection. As a natural performer, he made any act look easy. His early skill in artistic, 'bohemian' disciplines (magic, writing plays, poetry, and short stories) was matched, however, by his intellectual thirst for science; and his natural proclivity for live communicative experience (acting, performing in public,

reading out poetry, folktales, etc.) was complemented by a scientific, questioning need to test abstract knowledge in particular.

Teaching and Publishing in India

Teaching English literature became AKR's first profession, and after graduating from the University of Mysore with a master's degree in English literature (1950), he 'launched into the world'⁴¹ on his own. Between 1950 and 1958, he worked as a college lecturer of English in Quilon (1950-1), Madurai (1951-2), Belgaum (1952-7), and Baroda (1957-8). During this period, besides publishing poetry in English (since 1956) and becoming a sought-after teacher and public speaker, he organized debates as well as variety shows. People travelled 'hundreds of miles to listen to him', according to Kannada playwright Girish Karnad, who met AKR in 1955 in Belgaum.⁴² He also continued writing radio plays in Kannada under the pseudonym 'Akrura' derived from the initials 'AKR'.⁴³ By 1958, about 25 of his Kannada plays had been produced by the AIR stations in Mysore and Madras. In Belgaum, northern Karnataka, he rediscovered oral traditions from a scientific angle, and partly inspired by a chance encounter with the American folklorist Edwin Kirkland in 1955, started a systematic **(p.86)** collection and index of folktales: 'I was twenty-three and I discovered what I had lived in and what had lived in me since childhood—the unofficial verbal world of dialects, that literature without letters (*eluta eluttu* in Tamil).'⁴⁴

Karnataka, which was created as an Indian union state in 1956 (state of Mysore, renamed Karnataka in 1973), and the city of Mysore in particular were in the 1950s the breeding ground for a whole generation of now prestigious *littérateurs*, many of whom became AKR's close friends and collaborators:

I think my interest in Kannada and Tamil, my involvement with them, my need to learn all I can about the literature, folklore, and culture in them, was stirred by the (what seems now) extraordinary place Mysore was in the late '40s and '50s. It was also then that I met Adiga, Ananthamurthy, and a little later, Girish Karnad, Kurtakoti, Lankesh—all of whom are now exciting writers.⁴⁵

The artistic and intellectual environments in places like Mysore, Belgaum, and also Baroda (Gujarat) proved highly stimulating for AKR's initial literary oeuvre. He could have continued to combine his creative side with a professional career at Indian universities, yet his inquisitive nature longed for new experiences and international travel opportunities: 'I have been preparing myself to go abroad for years, but the family has been in straits these years,' AKR wrote in 1958.⁴⁶ Tired and disappointed of teaching English to indifferent or unprepared students, he chose to concentrate on a new career and 'accidentally' obtained a fellowship in 1958 to specialize in linguistics, a promising field that was just being introduced in Pune through a new 'language project' with the help of American visiting professors such as G.H. Fairbanks, a Hindi-language specialist from Cornell

University. Eventually, from Pune, AKR applied for a scholarship in order to pursue further studies in linguistics at an American university and opt for a foreign PhD.

Dreaming of 'Freedom': Towards an Alternative Aesthetics

AKR's early life in India, his multicultural childhood, education, hobbies, and work shaped his 'Indian way of thinking', combining a context-sensitive compartmentalization of the world with the context-free dream leap: '[I]n "traditional" cultures like India, where (p.87) context-sensitivity rules and binds, the dream is to be free of context',⁴⁷ claims AKR in his famous essay.

There are fundamental features in AKR's first 30 years that match the prototype of a middle-class Brahmin scholar of the post-Independence years. These years coincide with a critical period in the history of India. AKR belonged to a generation of modern Indian intellectuals who grew up in a typical postcolonial context, torn between age-old indigenous models and the rigours of modernity. In his notes, AKR recognizes that the increasing cultural gap between the two generations posed one of the major conflicts among his contemporaries: 'My father. The big difference is a striving for consistency in my generation—guilt over inconsistencies.'⁴⁸ In some of his essays and interviews, AKR speaks about his early rationalist mould and the modern outlook which made him break with traditions in his youth, be they religious, social, literary, or aesthetic.

A study of some of his contemporaries would confirm that this rebellious attitude was a (mainly urban) pan-Indian phenomenon across disciplines and languages.⁴⁹ In their search for a new identity, many writers and intellectuals of the first years after India gained independence (from 1947 to the 1950s) lived through a phase of social, political, and artistic-literary change. The process of owning oneself, of being part of the new framework of 'the modern Indian nation' was also a matter of making choices, which seldom followed a trouble-free trail. Many young people and writers of this period faced new transformations, complexities, and choices affecting their lives and aesthetics, whereas earlier generations of writers during the colonial period did not have to experience the 'splits' in such a rapid and drastic manner. These profound changes are foregrounded in Ananthamurthy's *Samskara*. This important novel interrogates the validity of the established social order, showing the decadence of orthodox religious value systems during the 1940s in India. The protagonist of the novel, an acharya, ends up breaking all caste rules related to untouchability, sex, food, and so on. AKR, and a whole generation of English-educated artists and intellectuals, did indeed challenge orthodox Hindu morals in different contexts in their lives. As a teenager in 1946, AKR threw away his sacred thread, thereby renouncing Brahmin tradition. And when his father passed away in 1953 (he was then teaching at Lingaraj College, Belgaum, Karnataka), he refused to

perform the funeral rites. He even recalls in his diaries to have joked at the funeral that 'only priests and cows are pleased by death'.⁵⁰

(p.88) Around the time of his father's death, he started to interact with the Kannada poets of the Navya (New) Movement, which challenged the earlier generation of writers (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7). The critical dichotomies were also particularly evident in Indian poets writing in English who still had to claim a space for English as a modern Indian literary language. During the crucial 1950s, some of these poets felt the need to break away from the 'Anglo-Indian' or 'Indo-Anglian' poets of the pre-Independence period, of which the main exponents were the 'romantic' Sarojini Naidu and the 'mystic' Aurobindo Ghose. They tried to affirm themselves in new terms endorsing *new* or *modern* aesthetic values and criteria. This is as much evident from the poetry and critical writings of the Bombay circle of poets that grew around the poet and professor Nissim Ezekiel, as from the more explicit, quite rebellious *Kavita Manifesto* of the Calcutta group of poets, which appeared in *Modern Indo-Anglian Poetry* in 1959 edited by K. Raghavendra Rao and P. Lal; the latter was also a poet and influential mentor of poets (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7).⁵¹ A new aesthetics and poetics for Indian poets writing in English had emerged, which had earlier taken shape in the regional languages. These literary movements flourished within a new framework of Indian national sovereignty, thus many of the critical issues in those years also bore political clout.⁵² AKR did not only live through the political turmoil of India's Independence (1947) but also witnessed the subsequent tensions that the national/regional language issue (Hindi versus Dravidian languages like Tamil or Kannada) brought about at a time when mother tongues like Kannada became a political tool to carve out new union states (Mysore state in 1956), and English turned into the language of cohesion as the preferred lingua franca, especially in south India, to by-pass Hindi.

In his youth, AKR had wanted to become a modern intellectual, and defied the traditional Brahminical pundit-scholars just as he turned his back on the older generation of Indian writers in Kannada and Tamil who were influenced by Sanskrit literature, nationalism, and Western Romantic ideas. In constructing alternative systems, he did not simply shun tradition and look towards the modern West and its theoretical contributions, including rationalism and secularism, as many others before him had done, but also incorporated what was immediately around him and appealed to him within the tradition. For instance, in 1947 he discovered in the social and **(p.89)** poetic counter-systems of the medieval Kannada Virasaiva poets an alternative to the orthodox rituals and philosophies of the Brahminical system. In one of the late interviews, AKR speaks about his search for Indian counter-discourses as a teenager:

KT:

Was your reaction at 16 a reaction against India?

AKR:

Against Hinduism. And of course, I had the notion that only a kind of modern rationalism was the answer to all the problems we had: the caste system, the problems of a hierarchy by birth ... my unconscious agenda has been to diversify our notions of Indian civilisation. To take it away from the purely Brahmanical view of Indian Civilisation.... If you look at something like *Speaking of Siva*, you find it more democratic.... And my interest in folklore has also been shaped by that. I see in these counter-systems, anti-structures, a protest against official systems.⁵³

And so, from his formative years, AKR was aesthetically, culturally, religiously, socially, and politically attracted to what may be broadly defined as the 'other' or the 'counter-systems'. First, as a young student in India, he evinced an innate urge to compare and contrast divergent points of view experienced at home, on the street, and at school, and to assess given facts and received wisdom in the light of more than one tradition. Along with it came an early social and political heterodoxy at par with the dissent of the medieval Virasaiva poet-saints who spurred his imagination. He did not embrace, however, any particular dogma. As Ananthamurthy observed, AKR was 'a man of ideas, not of ideology ... he liked to play with opposite ideas'.⁵⁴ Members of the Brahmin caste traditionally learnt the classical Sanskrit tradition of the Vedas and the Upanishads, but AKR was instead drawn to the mother-tongue traditions, including folk wisdom and oral literature. Despite being a member of the Vaisnava Tamil Brahmin community that worshipped the god Visnu, in his youth he was fascinated by the anti-establishment, anti-Sanskrit, and anti-caste medieval Kannada poets of the Virasaiva bhakti tradition (see the sections 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2, 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5, and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7). Only much later, in the late 1970s, did AKR translate the poet-saint Nammalvar, who belonged to the canon of orthodox Vaisnavite poetry in Tamil (see the sections 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5 and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7). The vachanas of the Kannada Virasaiva saints were neither *sruti* nor *smṛiti*, as AKR explained, 'not what is (p.90) heard, but what is said; not remembered or received, but uttered here and now'.⁵⁵ These often revolutionary mystic poets derided traditional power 'structures' and sang to Siva in praise of the individual experience, of being constantly in motion, moving free:

The rich
will make temples for Siva.
What shall I,
a poor man,
do?

My legs are pillars,
the body the shrine,

the head a cupola
of gold.

Listen, O lord of the meeting rivers,
things standing shall fall,
but the moving ever shall stay.⁵⁶

Looking for the Other to Find Oneself

Determined to discover the West and with the mindset to study linguistics at Indiana University Bloomington as a Fulbright scholar, AKR moved to the USA. He boarded a passenger ship from Bombay on 1 July 1959. At that time he was already 30 years old, had a decade-long career as an English professor behind him, and was widely travelled in India. He was no small-town youth anymore, but perhaps nothing could have prepared him better for his outward journey to 'the other' than the multicultural ethos he always carried with him:

It was linguistics that took me to America—though, ironically, it was my early involvement with Tamil and Kannada that kept me there.

... Ideally I'd have loved to have lived in India, and worked in Indian Studies.... But I've had to be content with the second best: I've lived in America, and worked in Indian studies, returned to India as often as I could for 'refills'....

I don't think one gets away from childhood, being steeped in things Indian (as I've been calling them, to avoid gobbledygook about Culture, Heritage etc.)—no more than one can jump off one's shadow, or take someone else's bath. They're part of the self, they're the language of the self. I'd add, for most of us, English is also a part of the many-layered heritage—for me, at least **(p.91)** since my adolescence.... Whatever 'Indian Heritage' I know has come to me mediated through such splits and connections.⁵⁷

When AKR finally settled in the USA after becoming assistant professor of Linguistics, Tamil, and Dravidian Studies at the University of Chicago in 1962, he took his self-chosen exile both as a mediating role between Indian and American scholarship and a dialogue within himself. He perceived this cultural predicament of being suspended between two worlds both as a double resource and a source of tension. Just as the childhood house witnessed dialogues as well as quarrels among 'relations', AKR knew that despite inevitable disconnections no part of the self could be isolated from the other. Rather, the different components interacted in a creative give-and-take. He even called himself, half-seriously, 'the hyphen in Indo-American Studies'⁵⁸ to express linguistically the 'splits and connections' that nurtured and coloured his existence as an artist and scholar equally at home in the USA and India: 'At first the dream was of being some kind of a citizen of the world, to be at home wherever I was; it takes time

before you realize that there are limits your culture has placed on you. Only they are not just limits. They are also resources....'⁵⁹

Like the protagonist in the novel *Samskara* and many of his contemporaries, AKR broke most of the 'sacrosanct' caste rules in the USA. Brahmin by birth, AKR had relationships with non-Brahmin women, and in 1962, married a non-Hindu, Molly Daniels, an Indian Syrian Christian he had met a year earlier in the USA. Going against Tamil Brahmins' strict vegetarianism, he also started eating meat. Ultimately, being a Brahmin was a great advantage as he himself conceded: 'I came from a Brahmin family, so I could have it both ways. That is, I could have the privileges of being a Brahmin and also all the privileges of reacting against it.'⁶⁰ In adult maturity, the experience of being 'in-between' two worlds—India and the USA—standing for the early AKR and the new AKR, added yet another skill to his 'miscellaneous criss-crossing'. He became an expert in the art of translating himself and his audience into other cultures, voices, and aesthetic traditions. At the University of Chicago, his twofold academic and poetic vocation was able to thrive in a natural extension of the early environments of his past. And it was challenged by new discoveries, such as when in 1962 AKR came upon an anthology of Tamil classical poetry by U.Ve. Caminataiyar in the basement of Harper Library, University of Chicago:

(p.92) Though I alone stand here, I'm conscious of the many people who are part of me, beginning with parents and teachers, or my wife who's often had to put herself aside for my sake, or colleagues ... and the poets one has read—a gypsy proverb says—one can count all the oranges on a tree, but not all the trees in a single orange.

I came to this country 25 years ago—almost by accident and merely drifted into staying on.... In a way, one needs the other, even if it is the mocking other, to find oneself—the English language and America itself has been that other—which has returned us to our dream—my discovering Tamil poems in a Chicago Library.⁶¹

AKR frequently commented on how he lived in a state of permanent contradiction: '[B]y a curious perversity I read Tamil constantly in the Kannada area, Kannada in the Tamil area, studied and taught English in India, and India and Indian languages in the US. Such perversity, I suppose, serves to keep alive the immediately absent parts of me.'⁶² As a student in India, he avidly read Western philosophers and writers, and later taught Shakespeare, Whitman, Eliot, and the modernists at several Indian colleges. After studying linguistics and obtaining a PhD with the dissertation 'A Generative Grammar of Kannada' (Indiana University Bloomington, 1963), he devoted most of his career to Dravidian studies in the USA, holding teaching posts at the University of Chicago and other American universities. It was not until the early 1960s that AKR discovered classical Tamil Sangam literature in the library basement of the

University of Chicago. He, therefore, first read, translated, and taught the Sangam classics in the USA, far from the native landscapes of the Tamil poets. Eventually, AKR was not only inclined to the desi traditions, folklore, and other alternative aesthetic traditions and counter-movements but was also increasingly sensitive to the role of the other gender in Indian culture; over the years in America, he turned into a dedicated researcher of the role of women in Indian society, folklore, art, and literature. He studied the idiosyncrasies of women saints and tales, in fact, long before gender studies and subaltern studies were in vogue in India and in many Western countries, and advised future anthropologists to follow his example:

Anyone who wishes to study Indian women, listen to their voices, and find alternative conceptions in Indian civilisation, often startlingly different from what one is used to in the classics, should turn to materials like the lives of **(p.93)** the women saints, women's tales, songs, riddles, games and proverbs in oral traditions all over the country, and the myths and cults of goddesses.⁶³

In line with his characteristic unorthodox and inquisitive attitude, AKR explained that he became interested in the oral traditions in the mother tongues because they 'represent a democratic, anti-hierarchic, from-the-ground-up view of India'.⁶⁴ True to this idea of finding 'alternative conceptions', he preferred to look at India not through the cultured male, but through women and the non-literate.

In tracing AKR's environments and his continuous dialogue with 'the other' and with himself, it becomes evident that the aesthetic and poetic thought of a multilingual, multicultural author who was a harbinger of contextualization in literary studies cannot be defined by simplistic notions of an 'East-West' cultural encounter, nor limited to a postcolonial identity search, or fall back on post-Romantic ideas such as 'Indianness', search for roots, nostalgia, exile, alienation, and so on, as may have been attempted in early critical analyses of his work. All such approaches may be valid, yet, as the author explains in his writings, the making of his cosmo-vision and aesthetics was nurtured by a complex organic network of relations or 'family trees' (a favourite metaphor), dialogues, opposites, and quarrels that have been at play in the many particular voices, spaces, and metaphors he inhabited.

In 'Self-Portrait', a short poem from AKR's first poetry collection *The Striders*, which he often used to read in public poetry sessions, the poet recognizes in his self(-image) the influence of other elements, the 'many people that are part of' him.⁶⁵

I resemble everyone
but myself, and sometimes see
in shop-windows,

despite the well-known laws
of optics,
the portrait of a stranger,
date unknown,
often signed in a corner
by my father.⁶⁶

It is symptomatic that the poem, written soon after AKR's arrival in America, portrays the self as a distorted 'other' through a *trans-forming* mirror-reflection, returning *his reality* 'in oblique ways'.⁶⁷ At first, the **(p.94)** poet (or rather the 'I' in the poem?) states that his composite self resembles 'everyone' but himself, which might include private and public figures, parents and teachers, men, women, and poets. But he 'sometimes' sees the reflection of a 'stranger' in public 'shop-windows', suggesting a split personality and implying a personal transformation into another, unrecognizable, or *alienated* self. Or there may be another 'self' looking at the speaker, the 'I', through the window from inside the shop, seeing a 'stranger'. As I have already pointed out (see the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2), the word 'mirrors' appeared in an early handwritten draft of the poem from the early 1960s instead of the final 'shop-windows' for which it was changed.⁶⁸ And window-glass has fitting properties, as AKR noted elsewhere: '[I]t reflects to the outsider, and refracts for insiders'.⁶⁹

This (self-)image-poem was probably inspired by the writings of Jorge Luis Borges, who was deeply concerned with being multiplied in mirror-images and with the idea of the 'double self', that is, the private 'I' and the public 'Borges' (see also the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2, 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7, and 'Translation and Poetic Practice' in Chapter 8).⁷⁰ In one of AKR's early lists of poems designated 'to be published', the name 'Borges' is handwritten next to the title 'Self-Portrait'.⁷¹ Both in his prose and poetry, AKR liked to speak of himself through another voice or persona. He did notoriously so in his Kannada novella *Matthobhana Atmacharitre* (1978) in which the hero, 'the mocking other', is a south-Indian history teacher called K.K. Ramanujan who meets the poet A.K. Ramanujan by chance in Chicago (see also the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 and 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4).⁷² The Indian critic Chirantan Kulshrestha, after interviewing AKR in 1981, commented on the self-reflexive content of this novella:

Perhaps he has been, in some ways, like the central character of his recent Kannada novel, *Another Man's Autobiography* (1979) [*sic*]. The hero's attempt to evaluate his experience of life through an autobiography entails the recognition that each account of what happened to him is really about someone or something else. Can the self be grasped only through its

relations and through its reconstruction of other lives? The narrator thus finds himself in a labyrinth of mirrors reflecting other faces as well as other times.⁷³

(p.95) In the poem 'Self-Portrait', the self struggles to make out, 'despite the well-known laws' of science, a temporary form in its reflected image. It seems to have no fixed presence or identity, no date, no body, no tangible truth. It has no *proper* mirror-image, yet it is anchored to the past, as it is a reflection from memory ('sometimes'). And the most immediate biological and psychological past is the father. In the absence of a recognizable identity, the progenitor is the only identifiable presence that has left a mark: his signature. Despite having expired years earlier and thousands of miles away, the father is the author of the mysterious 'portrait' from which the poetic 'I' cannot escape. By some strange 'law', the father has 'passed on' and haunts the poetic self⁷⁴ who cannot come to terms with his overwhelming *anxiety of influence*.⁷⁵ For in his youth, AKR rebelled against this paradoxical father figure who held two worlds in one brain: irrational astrology and scientific logic. 'Furthermore,' as AKR explains elsewhere, 'Hindus believe that fathers are reborn as sons.'⁷⁶ From distant Chicago in the 1960s, he takes this Hindu notion on with an ironic stance in a (*self*-)reflexive poem that contradicts all scientific 'laws' of logic.⁷⁷

In his research of desi and folk traditions, AKR had to employ critical tools and a specific metalanguage acquired from Western disciplines. For the study of folktales, for instance, he already discerned in India in the structuralist Stith-Thompson index of folk motifs a scientific method (and later a discipline) to introduce a systematic ordering into his fascination for folktales. Thus, he looked for counter-systems in the mother tongues and for consistency in English linguistics and other scientific systems ('context-free' ways of thinking), but for a long time left aside the other father tongue, Sanskrit, which stood for the hegemonic, orthodox Hindu tradition. The scientific disciplines which he specialized in during his first years in the USA (general linguistics, Dravidian linguistics, anthropology, psychology) became a means of analysing and interrogating the context-sensitive literary traditions in the mother tongues. Gradually, in his career, the purely theoretical aspects of these disciplines moved to the backstage, and poetry, translation, and folktales, as cultural forms and creative practice became the main interests that appealed both to the artist and scientist in AKR. A retrospective diary entry written at the age of 49 in the USA sums up the evolution of his professional and intellectual occupations from the early stages in India in the late 1940s till the late 1970s:

(p.96) Dec 9 1978

In 12 years linguistics, anthropology, English lit., psychology have fallen by the wayside, leaving poetry, translation and folktales.

At 20 reading Russell and Huxley, I'd hoped to become a generalist. Intellectual at large—not a 'poet', or a Dravidianist, or translator of Indian literature. So the latter things still don't sit easy on me.⁷⁸

I have already highlighted how AKR was from the time of his childhood and early education exposed to a composite reality of native environments and Western-imported elements. Throughout his multilayered life journey that began in the Mysore house, he continued to enlarge his multidisciplinary outlook both as a scholar and artist. His heterogeneity was further cultivated in the manifold professional engagements at the University of Chicago: 'One of the fortunate things of my life is that I have been able to keep the miscellaneous interests of my youth alive—because I landed up in a place where this was formally recognised. It's good to feel that these interests are not hobbies I pursue outside my field.'⁷⁹ Against a unitary thought and fixed identity, we find in AKR's intellectual and artistic maturity a continuous dialogue and reflexivity of elements that conforms to a complex 'system of presences and absences', one of the characteristic principles that he recognized in Indian texts as well as aesthetics.⁸⁰ The multiple traditions and systems that AKR imbibed and studied formed an expanding continuum that interacted creatively within his self, often inciting curious contradictions. The double allegiance to science and poetry was an essential, but not the only, *dualism* in his life. As AKR explained, there were several underlying tensions exposing his dualistic nature: 'It looks as if I live between things all the time—two (or more) languages, two countries, two disciplines. It's always been like that for me.'⁸¹ A pervading dualism is undoubtedly one of the main features that define AKR as an intellectual and artist, and it is also the principle that informs his translational activity. The Akam/Puram and mother-tongue/father-tongue dichotomies from childhood have already been cited as seminal concepts for Indian cultural studies and as meta-critical tools to approach AKR's aesthetics. It can be said that at different periods of his career, these and various other types of dualism (linguistic, social, cultural, religious, psychological, philosophical, and ontological) thrived and overlapped in AKR and made him question the very nature of art and life (see the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Translation and Poetic Practice' in Chapter 8).

(p.97) AKR's 'exiled' condition has been described by some critics in postcolonial terms as the natural process of an Indian 'diaspora' writer in America who tries to come to terms with apparent cultural contradictions and finds a way of constructing his identity through selective retrieval of the past and traditions.⁸² Yet this lifelong wavering between a fragmentary state and a search for continuity of forms was not only derivative of his condition as an intellectual writing in a 'foreign tongue' far away from the motherland, nor of his intellectual 'promiscuity'. It was equally the result of a complex personality and compound psychology that sometimes posed a modern rational and humanist

attitude and, at others, was deeply immersed in an emotional, spiritual, existential, and artistic anxiety. For instance, AKR's 'protest against the official systems' and his preference for the mother-tongue traditions could in psychoanalytic terms also be interpreted as a reflection of his own struggle with the father figure.⁸³ While he had a difficult relationship with his father and the Brahmin tradition that the latter embodied, he also had a patent obsession with his mother and all that she represented,⁸⁴ from oral tales to food to womanhood and sexuality. Persons close to AKR have pointed out the multiple and often contradictory sides of his personality, and his confusing relationships with women. On the one hand, he is often described as an extremely kind and generous person who was always attentive to detail. He was highly praised as a friend, but according to others he was neither an 'ordinary' man, nor a person easy to live with. Girish Karnad, for instance, stresses that 'he did not have a good relationship with his wife, that's why he devoted so much time to his friends. His friends were his family ... he paid so much attention to detail in his friendships.'⁸⁵ Tensions in his married life are evident from the fact that he married and divorced twice the same woman: he first espoused Molly Daniels (whom he had met in 1961 in the USA) in 1962, and after a divorce in 1971, remarried her in 1976 and got divorced again in 1988.

In this description of AKR's 'inner' aesthetics, I shall not delve further into the author's marital problems. The framing of his Akam world is intended to trace his aesthetic sensibility back to his early biographical environments, that is, it focuses chiefly on how his 'aesthetics, ethos and worldview are shaped' in great measure in his childhood and first 30 years in India.⁸⁶ The domestic world naturally comprises family relations as well as the diverse types of love (the innermost expression of Akam) that play a central role throughout someone's lifetime. But this chapter is not an attempt to explore AKR's entire biography; a comprehensive biographical study would have to **(p.98)** include, in much more detail, his tense relationships and ambiguities with women, some of which are amply reflected in his ironic and often bitter 'love' (and hate) poems and also manifested in his private diaries. The double marriage and divorce already indicates the contradictions in his relation with his wife. A quick glance at the poems as well as the notes and diary entries reveals that AKR could never entirely take his mind off Molly. She became an object of obsession even when he had relationships with other women. As we can read in his poetry, AKR was overtly aware that she was always some kind of a mother figure to him:

Dear woman, you never let me forget
what I never quite remember:
you're not Mother.... (1-3)⁸⁷

Just as the father emerges prominently in AKR's poetry, the mother too is a central figure in his poetic universe, representing the Akam world of mother tongues, tales, folklore, and love. On the original cover of AKR's second

collection of poetry, *Relations*, a portrait of both the father and mother appeared embedded in his forehead. His diary notes indicate that he later regretted the choice of this cover and was in fact quite embarrassed about it: 'The cover picture was bizarre, sentimental, father and mother imprinted on my forehead....'⁸⁸ While numerous incidents and anecdotes involving his father are recollected in many a poem with an ironic twist, the poet's relation with his mother often suggests Oedipal⁸⁹ undertones which, at times, come to the fore rather explicitly, as in the personal 'love poems' that recreate the classical Tamil Akam poetic form:

... she offers me her breast:
'No rush', she says
As I fall to work

and suckle till I glow
on milk still warm, groan
at the taste
of Mother's salt,
and Oedipus,
five, weaned, and jealous,
seems no longer halt
or blind: cured almost. (19-29)⁹⁰

(p.99) In a 1971 diary, he even refers to his lover as his 'latest mother' and to Molly as 'the constant mother'.⁹¹ AKR was deeply interested in psychoanalysis and wrote several papers on the Oedipus myth, which culminated in his influential essay 'The Indian Oedipus' (1983). The darker sides of AKR's genius, his ambivalent relationship with his father and mother, and his anxieties and tensions in his married life are necessarily present in his poems as well as in the diaries. People who knew him well have commented on these domestic pressures and personal contradictions. Karnad further describes AKR as someone who 'was often quite tense inside, though he tried to conceal it with his modest calmness....' And Abu Abraham observes in an article that 'he bore his own pains with stoic calm, never allowed them to affect unduly his work or his abiding interests. His domestic life was full of conflict in the later years of his marriage.' Keith Harrison also writes in the preface to *Uncollected Poems and Prose* about AKR's 'more demonic side' and adds that 'Raman's thought was a delicate poise between a deep-rooted and grave scepticism and an even deeper belief in the essential goodness of the world'.⁹² His late poetic oeuvre bears witness to these increasing tensions, anxieties, and dark fears, yet his sceptical visions were countered by an inexorable humanism and aesthetic sensitivity. Most of AKR's acquaintances agree that he kept the aesthetic core of his acute mind always intact, even when he was suffering from severe pain in the latter part of his life.⁹³ He was always receptive to whatever the present, immediate surroundings would offer thus his aesthetic response was tuned to the vagaries of everyday human existence. As a hobby psychoanalyst, patient, and practising poet, his

habit of keeping a diary worked both as therapy and artistic technique to chart some of 'the many states of being, ... many emotions you go through in the course of a single day. Who are you?'⁹⁴

AKR's preoccupation with a multiplicity of selves and his search for a *centred* identity, besides sustaining his creativity, were nevertheless also connected to an acute existential anxiety. Indeed, his interest in psychology could be traced to the self-analysis of his multicentred psyche, which was constantly 'looking for the centre'. As he put it in a poem by that title:

Suddenly, connections severed
as in a lobotomy, unburdened
of history, I lose
my bearings, ... (33-7)⁹⁵

(p.100) An unpublished part of this poem, which was drafted between 1982 and 1984 as part of a longer 'Composition', is more explicit about his existential angst:

Looking for the center, one stumbles
from knot to knot on the network,
scared of untenanted spaces.⁹⁶

Thus, to deal with his recurrent fears and personal depression, AKR often sought advice in psychology. He studied psychotherapy as his pastime, and, among other attempted therapies, visited a Jungian psychotherapist in the 1980s.⁹⁷

Yet AKR answered this question of the self best through his art, that is, by writing poems. He was a gifted observer of human psychology and of the inner and outer 'landscapes' of things and emotions, and in attending to his own and others' experiences, his senses were trained to retain detail and particulars. He had a natural, 'sympathetic'⁹⁸ predisposition that prepared him to respond to particular ordinary objects and incidents with aesthetic relish. The gypsy proverb about the orange tree that AKR compared to his composite self refers to a personal image for the 'natural process' of individual creativity: the seed in the fruit on the tree. As AKR's 'A Poem on Particulars' puts it, an orange—the fruit of life—is nurtured not only by the roots of the tree but by the entire circle of its past, present, and future environments:

In our city markets
I have often seen a wicker basket
sit
upon its single, ample
hip,
its rattan pattern filled
with another,
subtler

bubble-bed pattern of oranges:

...

But

every one of these
had an absurd, almost human
umbilicus
at the top
where once the Tree
(p.101) had poured its
future
from forgotten roots
and possessed it close,
to feed
this Fall-minded
pot-bellied
bud
till it rounded
for our baskets.

I have heard it said
among planters:
you can sometimes count
every orange
on a tree
but never
all the trees
in a single
orange. (1-9, 28-52)⁹⁹

The image of the poem on the page is that of an upside-down tree (see also the sections in 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4 and 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6). As AKR explains, 'the great Indian image of the cosmic tree is the tree with its branches in the earth and its roots in the air'.¹⁰⁰ There are several such tree poems, especially in AKR's early work. The seed, the fruit, and the tree of life, as well as the family tree in its literal and metaphorical sense are, in AKR's poetry, prominent metaphors for the process of creativity, continuity, and change in his personal history, which encompasses the biological and biographical environments. The tree, therefore, also stands as a metaphor for the human body and for the body of poetry that the poet engenders.

Notes:

(*) This quotation from a classical Tamil Akam poem of first to third century AD appears as the epigraph to his second poetry collection *Relations*, in *CP*, p. 56. See also Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 163.

(1.) See Ramanujan, 'Notes towards a Journal: The Journey', AKR Papers (1959).

(2.) Ramanujan quoted in Parthasarathy, *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets*, p. 96. See also the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2.

(3.) Ramanujan quoted in Parthasarathy, *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets*, p. 96.

(4.) I thus do not claim that the poems I will quote or refer to are the only autobiographical ones, or that other poems by AKR do not contain autobiographical elements. That would soon become a misleading as well as an impossible exercise and is not the aim of these chapters, nor is this book intended as a biography. On the other hand, as regards to the diaries, journals, notes, etc., quoted from the Papers, there is certainly no doubt about them being autobiographical. See also Appendix 1 in this book.

(5.) Ramanujan, *FI*, p. iv, and 'Who Needs Folklore?' in *CE*, p. 533.

(6.) Attipat Asuri Krishnaswami Iyengar (also written Ayyengar) obtained his master's degree in mathematics at the age of 18 and started teaching mathematics at Pachaiyappa's College, Madras. In 1918, he joined the mathematics department of the University of Mysore and retired from there in 1947. During the three decades he taught at the university, he published numerous articles and papers on, among other topics, geometry, statistics, astronomy, and the history of Indian mathematics. Most of his papers on the history of Indian mathematics have been collected and published in a CD form, *A.A. Krishnaswami Ayyangar's Works on the History of Indian Mathematics*, by AKR's brothers A.K. Srinivasan and A.K. Rajagopal, and a group of professors from India and the USA. For online sources, see University of Kentucky, Lexington (November 2007), <http://www.ms.uky.edu/~sohum/aak/> and <http://www-history.mcs.st-and.ac.uk/Biographies/Ayyangar.html>.

(7.) The use of three—or even four—languages in a household is a fairly common feature in India's multilingual society.

(8.) See also the references to AKR's family and childhood in 'Who Needs Folklore?' and other collected essays cited in Chapter 2.

(9.) See Krishna Ramanujan in *CE*, p. xvi. AKR's uncritical consumption of all kinds of pulp fiction and TV content is also noted by Girish Karnad in a personal conversation held in September 1999.

(10.) Ramanujan, curriculum vitae in prose, Poona, AKR Papers (1958), n.p., prepared for his Fulbright scholarship application.

(11.) Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 4. See also the poem 'Astronomer' from *Second Sight*, which he quotes on the same page in this

essay. Though published in 1986, it should be noted that the first draft of this poem is dated 9 August 1971 in the AKR Papers. See also *CP*, p. 134.

(12.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 54.

(13.) Ramanujan quoted in Kalven, 'Found in the Translation', p. 35.

(14.) An undated draft of this poem in the AKR Papers reads 'Wichita and Peking' instead of 'Tiruvella and Sialkot'.

(15.) Ramanujan, 'Small-Scale Reflections on a Great House', *Relations*, in *CP*, pp. 96–9. This long poem, which cannot be quoted here in full, is probably AKR's most cited long poem. It is also one of the poems, along with 'Obituary', 'A Poem on Particulars', 'Self-Portrait', and 'Prayers to Lord Murugan', that AKR liked to quote or refer to in his lectures, notes, and other prose writings as well as interviews.

(16.) The root of the prefix 'eco' is the Greek *oikos*, which means house, household, or family.

(17.) On the nature-culture continuum as a concept in Tamil aesthetics and its influence on AKR, see the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5 and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(18.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (10 November 1976), n.p. In this diary note, AKR explicitly refers to the poem in this light. See also the section 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5 on AKR's opposition of particulars versus universals.

(19.) Ramanujan quoted in T.N. Shankaranarayana and S.A. Krishnaiah, 'Interview with Professor A.K. Ramanujan', in Jaydipsingh K. Dodiya (ed.), *Indian English Poetry: Critical Perspectives* (New Delhi: Sarup and Sons, 2000), p. 88.

(20.) Ramanujan quoted in Rama Jha, "'Between Two Worlds": An Interview with A.K. Ramanujan', *Times of India* (20 January 1980), p. 13.

(21.) This was corroborated by Saroja Krishnamurthi, AKR's sister, in a personal interview, Bangalore (September 1999).

(22.) Ramanujan, 'Obituary', *Relations*, in *CP*, pp. 111–12. The verse lines of poems that are not quoted in full are only indicated in published poems.

(23.) In 1916, Nalvadi Krishnaraja Wodeyar founded the University of Mysore, the sixth in the country.

(24.) Though R.K. Narayan was a Tamilian from Madras, he was educated in Mysore. His famous fictional town Malgudi, in which all of his novels since *Swami and His Friends* (1935) are set, is said to be a recreation of Mysore,

though he preferred not to identify it with any south-Indian town or city. See also R. Krishna Kumar, 'A Writer Who Saw the Extraordinary in the Ordinary', a tribute to R.K. Narayan by C.D. Narasimhaiah, *Hindu* (14 May 2001), n.p.

(25.) U.R. Ananthamurthy, *Samskara: A Rite for a Dead Man*, trans. A.K. Ramanujan (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1976). See also later in this chapter.

(26.) See Krishna Ramanujan in *CE*, p. xvi.

(27.) Ramanujan, curriculum vitae, AKR Papers (1958), n.p.

(28.) Curriculum vitae in prose drafted for an application for a Guggenheim fellowship, AKR Papers (1981), n.p.

(29.) Maria Montessori spent the years between 1939 and 1946 living and travelling in the Indian subcontinent. In a lecture delivered in Ceylon (present Sri Lanka) in 1944, she formulated the essence of her revolutionary ideas (see Maria Montessori, *Education for a New World*, ed. A. Gnana Prakasam [Ceylon: AMI, 1947], n.p.):

Scientific observation has established that education is not what the teacher gives; education is a natural process spontaneously carried out by the human individual, and is acquired not by listening to words but by experiences upon the environment. The task of the teacher becomes that of preparing a series of motives of cultural activity, spread over a specially prepared environment, and then refraining from obtrusive interference. Human teachers can only help the great work that is being done, as servants help the master. Doing so, they will be witnesses to the unfolding of the human soul and to the rising of a New Man who will not be a victim of events, but will have the clarity of vision to direct and shape the future of human society.

(30.) On the methodology followed by Montessori schools today, see www.montessori.org.

(31.) Ramanujan, curriculum vitae in prose, Poona, AKR Papers (1958), n.p.

(32.) Krishna Ramanujan in *CE*, p. xv. AKR's penchant for magic shows as a teenager is also recalled by Saroja Krishnamurthi in a personal interview in September 1999. See also Girish Karnad's comments in Nerlekar, 'Adarallu Idu', p. 220.

(33.) Years before AKR joined Maharaja's College, the celebrated novelist R.K. Narayan and other illustrious south-Indian writers and scholars had studied there.

(34.) Ramanujan, letter to Vrinda Nabar, AKR Papers (27 November 1978), n.p. AKR refers in the last sentence to the French mathematician and polymath Jules Henri Poincaré (1854–1912).

(35.) Ramanujan, 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' unpublished handwritten lecture draft, AKR Papers (1993), n.p. This talk was never delivered as AKR did not attend the seminar in India in the spring of 1993, for which it had been drafted. On this paper, see also the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5 in this book. I have found no other AKR source mentioning that A.A. Krishnaswami Iyengar knew Srinivasa Ramanujan. Though AKR's father was four years younger than Srinivasa Ramanujan, he started teaching at Pachaiyappa's College in Madras (the alma mater of the famous mathematician) soon after obtaining his MA there in 1911 at the age of 18. Srinivasa Ramanujan had enrolled in Pachaiyappa's College in 1906 at the age of 18.

(36.) AKR mentions as early 'literary friends' I.K. Bhogishayana and T.R.S. Sharma in the letter to Nabar. These names also appear in his diaries as friends in his youth, among others. T.R.S. Sharma became a renowned literary critic.

(37.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.K. Ramanujan, Poet (India)', *Jerusalem Poetry Festival*, brochure, AKR Papers (1990), p. 28.

(38.) W.G. Eagleton, letter of recommendation, Maharaja's College, University of Mysore, AKR Papers (7 June 1949), n.p.

(39.) Ramanujan, 'Mescaline Notes', diary, AKR Papers (28 August 1971), n.p. Another diary entry from 1958 also makes reference to these auditions of Western classical music at Eagleton's house.

(40.) Ramanujan, 'A Poem Is Born', journal, AKR Papers (25–27 September 1949), n.p. More extracts of this journal are quoted in the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4.

(41.) Ramanujan, curriculum vitae, AKR Papers (1958), n.p.

(42.) Personal interview (1999). See also Karnad's observations in Nerlekar, 'Adarallu Idu', pp. 219–20. For more details on AKR's professional career in India, see Chart 1 in this book.

(43.) See also the prologue of this book. The pseudonym Akrura means 'not cruel', and is a character in the Hindu epic *Srimad Bhagavata Purana*. Akrura, Krishna's uncle and minister of Kamsa, takes Krishna to Mathura from Vrindavan in a chariot (as told by N.I. Viswanath Iyer, AKR's colleague in 1950 at S.N. College, Quilon, in a personal interview in December 2001). See also K.N. Subramaniam, 'Glass-House Gossip', *Southern Economist*, Bangalore (15 November 1983), pp. 5–6, and Nissim Ezekiel, N.S. Jagannathan, S. Krishnan,

and Ramachandra Sharma, 'Ramanujan's Legacy: The Universe in a Handful of Earth', *Indian Review of Books*, vol. 2, no. 11 (August–September 1993), pp. 27–34.

(44.) See Ramanujan, 'Telling Tales', in *CE*, p. 457. AKR's first publications in the field of folklore were a Kannada book of articles on proverbs—*Gadegalu* (1955)—and two articles and tales in the American journal *Southern Folklore Quarterly* (1956).

(45.) Ramanujan, curriculum vitae, AKR Papers (1981), n.p. On the relevance of some of these Kannada writers in AKR's poetry, see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(46.) Ramanujan, curriculum vitae, AKR Papers (1958), n.p.

(47.) Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 44.

(48.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Notions of Change', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.

(49.) For an outline of the contextual factors that brought about changes in modern Indian poetry during the post-Independence period, see, for instance, Vinay Dharwadker, 'Modern Indian Poetry and Its Contexts', in Vijay Dharwadker and A.K. Ramanujan (eds), *The Oxford Anthology of Modern Indian Poetry* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1994), pp. 185–206. On the cultural dilemmas of modern Indian Brahmins, see also some of the commentaries by AKR in the interview 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor and AKR', in *UPP*, pp. 55–6.

(50.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.

(51.) P. Lal and K. Raghavendra Rao (eds), 'Introduction', *Modern Indo-Anglian Poetry* (New Delhi: Kavita, 1959), pp. i–vii.

(52.) I have dealt with this issue and its implications in IPE criticism extensively in my postgraduate dissertation, 'Post-Independence Indian Poetry in English'.

(53.) Keith Taylor and Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 55. In the version of this interview edited by AKR, the partAuthor's reply reads 'only a kind of modern rationalism and humanism was the answer to all the problems' (AKR Papers). He added the underlined words later.

(54.) U.R. Ananthamurthy, personal interview, Bangalore (19 January 2002).

(55.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 17.

(56.) This poem, translated from Kannada, is by the twelfth-century Virasaiva poet, spiritual leader, and social reformer Basavanna. Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 88. AKR started writing 'recreations' of Basavanna poems from around 1951. See

also the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(57.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar, underline in original.

(58.) See, for instance, S. Krishnan, 'The Hyphen in Indo-American', *Hindu*, Madras (25 July 1993), n.p.

(59.) Ramanujan quoted in Chidananda Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', *Span* (November 1983), p. 33.

(60.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 61. See also the full quote in the section 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(61.) Ramanujan, untitled draft of a lecture-talk, AKR Papers (c. 1984), n.p. The gypsy proverb is cited also in other sources by AKR and provides the central image for the poem 'A Poem on Particulars', *The Striders*. See later in this chapter and also the sections 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7 and 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8.

(62.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', interview conducted at the University of Chicago in 1970, in Molly Daniels-Ramanujan and Keith Harisson (eds), *Uncollected Poems and Prose: A.K. Ramanujan* (London and New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2001), p. 42. In fact, it was quite typical that an Indian academic had to turn to Indian studies due to professional constraints when shifting to the USA after teaching English in India.

(63.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Talking to God in the Mother Tongue', tape-recorded conversation with Madhu Kishwar, *Manushi*, nos 50-2 (January-June 1989), p. 14. Among AKR's essays on Indian women saints and tales are 'On Women Saints', in J. Stratton Hawley and D. Marie Wulff (eds), *The Divine Consort: Radha and The Goddesses of India* (Berkeley: The Graduate Theological Union, 1982; and New Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1984), pp. 316-24, and 'Towards a Counter-System: Women's Tales', in Arjun Appadurai, Margaret Mills, and Frank Korom (eds), *Gender, Genre, and Power in South Asian Expressive Traditions* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 1991), pp. 33-55. Both essays were later reprinted in *CE*.

(64.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor and AKR', in *UPP*, pp. 55-6.

(65.) Ramanujan, untitled draft of a lecture-talk, AKR Papers (c. 1984), n.p. Quoted earlier in this chapter.

(66.) Ramanujan, 'Self-Portrait', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 23.

(67.) Ramanujan, 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry', p. 62. See also the section 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7 on oblique reality in poetry.

(68.) Ramanujan, early handwritten draft of 'Self-Portrait', AKR Papers (early 1960s), n.p. See a copy of this draft on the first pages of this book.

(69.) Ramanujan, notecards, AKR Papers (c. 1968), n.p. Quoted also in the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2.

(70.) In 1961, Jorge Luis Borges won the prestigious Prix International (shared with Samuel Beckett), which aroused great interest in the Argentinean writer in America and brought about a series of publications of his works translated into English. See Jorge Luis Borges, *Labyrinths: Selected Stories and Other Writings*, ed. James E. Irby, ed. and trans. from Spanish Donald E. Yates (New York: New Directions, 1962) and *Dreamtigers*. The latter collection contains the poem 'Mirrors' and the short story 'Borges and I' which, among other pieces by Borges, should be read in relation to some of AKR's writings of the 1960s and 1970s that deal with similar ideas.

(71.) Ramanujan, unpublished notes, AKR Papers (early 1960s), n.p.

(72.) Ramanujan, *Matthobhana Atmacharitre* and Daniels-Ramanujan, A.K. *Ramanujan*.

(73.) Chirantan Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan: A Profile', *Journal of South Asian Literature*, vol. 16, no. 2 (Summer-Fall 1981), pp. 181-4.

(74.) See the first line of the AKR poem 'Obituary', *Relations*, in *CP*, pp. 111-12.

(75.) Harold Bloom, who coined 'anxiety of influence' as a literary concept, also implies in his seminal work that the relation between a poet and a precursor is of a 'filial' sort.

(76.) Ramanujan, 'The Indian Oedipus', in *CE*, p. 384.

(77.) See also the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 on the earlier draft of the poem 'Self-Portrait' and on the importance AKR attached to the various types of reflexivity in Indian literature which is the central idea in his late essay 'Where Mirrors Are Windows' (*CE*, pp. 6-33).

(78.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (9 December 1978), n.p. The '12 years' refer to the period he had been working at the University of Chicago as a professor of Dravidian studies and linguistics. In 1966, AKR had joined the

university as an associate professor of Dravidian Studies and Linguistics,
Department of South Asian Languages and Civilizations.

(79.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 33.

(80.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 15. See also AKR's poem 'Elements of Composition' in this context, in *CP*, pp. 121-3.

(81.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 32.

(82.) Though many Indian writers in the twentieth century left for the West in search of career opportunities rather than forcibly or as exiles, they are often referred to as Indian diaspora writers in postcolonial discourse.

(83.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor and AKR', in *UPP*, pp. 55-6.

(84.) See, in AKR's essay 'The Indian Oedipus', a plausible explanation for this: 'The rivalry between fathers and sons for the mother is because the mother loves her son and the father is left out' (*CE*, p. 384).

(85.) Karnad, personal interview, Trivandrum (9 February 1998).

(86.) Ramanujan, 'Who Needs Folklore?' in *CE*, p. 533.

(87.) Ramanujan, 'Love Poem for a Wife and Her Trees', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 180.

(88.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (12 August 1971), n.p.

(89.) Ramanujan, 'The Indian Oedipus', in *CE*, pp. 377-97. In this and other essays he also compared Indian tales and stories to the Greek Oedipus myth, indicating how it operates in reverse in India: 'This Indian Oedipus does not slay his father, but obeys and fulfills him, often sacrificing his potency for his elders.... At his best, he becomes himself ... by first surrendering to them'. Ramanujan, 'Afterword', *PLW*, p. 285.

(90.) Ramanujan, 'Love 3: *What He Said, Remembering*', in *CP*, p. 225. See also, in the context of the Indian Oedipus and breastfeeding, the passage from the *Yogatattva Upanishad* quoted by Sudhir Kakar which AKR reproduces in *CP*, p. 581. On the poet's lifelong yearning for the mother, see also the late poem 'Returning', in *UPP*, p. 14.

(91.) Ramanujan, 'Mescaline Notes', n.p. See also the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4 on the 'Mescaline Notes' and Molly Daniels.

(92.) Karnad, personal interview (9 February 1998), Abu Abraham, 'A Man for All Climes', *Hitavada, Sunday Plus* (1 August 1993), n.p., and Harrison, 'Preface', in *UPP*, p. xii.

(93.) AKR died on 13 July 1993 in a Chicago hospital due to heart failure during anaesthesia while undergoing a minor surgery on his spine.

(94.) Ramanujan quoted in Harrison, 'Preface', in *UPP*, p. xii.

(95.) Ramanujan, 'Looking for the Centre', in *CP*, pp. 184–5.

(96.) Ramanujan, 'Composition (Part 20)', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (c. 1982–4), n.p. See also Appendix 2 in this book on this long sequence of poems titled 'Composition'. See also the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' and 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7, and 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8.

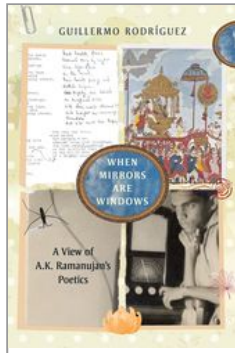
(97.) AKR was particularly interested in Jungian therapy, and his visits to a Jungian therapist are mentioned in his diaries. Among other primary sources in the AKR Papers, a diary from 29 October 1987, for example, mentions this. See also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 on Jungian psychoanalysis and poetic creation.

(98.) See Jerome Stolnitz's definition of the aesthetic attitude in the section 'Aesthetic Experience and Aesthetic Object: Concepts' in Chapter 4 on aesthetic experience.

(99.) Ramanujan, 'A Poem on Particulars', *The Striders*, in *CP*, pp. 53–4.

(100.) Ramanujan, 'The Indian Oedipus', in *CE*, p. 380. The upside-down tree is also the central image in other poems such as 'December Emblems', drafted in the mid-1950s in Belgaum, and 'A Plant', published in *Folio*, Indiana University (Winter 1959), n.p.

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Holding the Mirror

A.K. Ramanujan's 'Inner' Aesthetics

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Abstract and Keywords

This chapter introduces the concepts of aesthetic experience and the aesthetic object before turning to Ramanujan's 'inner' aesthetics. It illustrates some of the factors and processes behind the author's aesthetic sensibility and analyses his aesthetic attitude in particular situations on the basis of revelations and interpretations made in the private writings contained in the A.K. Ramanujan Papers. The poet's thoughts on the aesthetic appreciation of objects or events are exposed in a variety of text-types and discussed at two principal levels of interpretation. On the one hand, in the context of particular personal experiences, observations, and incidents recorded in a literary or prosaic style in the journals and drafts of poems; and on the other hand, by articulating in a more abstract manner in his journals and interviews the processes that trigger an aesthetic response in life, art, and poetry.

Keywords: aesthetic experience, aesthetic object, literary biography, Aldous Huxley, Ezra Pound

*Losing every time I win, climbing
ladders, falling to the bottom with snakes,
I make scenes:*

*in my anger, I smash all transparent
things, crystal, glass panes, one-way mirrors,
and my glasses,*

blinding myself;

In the following two chapters, I propose a systematization of AKR's aesthetics that follows a double approach and analyses first the subjective or experiential 'inner' aesthetics and then the intellectual or 'outer' aesthetics, acknowledging that they are both inseparable from each other and imaginatively interrelated. The biographical overview in Chapter 3 focuses primarily on AKR's childhood and the shaping of a complex aesthetic sensibility in his youth. It provides the background to the present chapter on AKR's 'inner aesthetics', which deals with the author's aesthetic experience(s) described and illustrated through personal observations and incidents as an experiencing subject. The 'outer' aesthetics (Chapter 5), on the other hand, explores AKR's ideas on art and aesthetics as enunciated mainly through his academic disciplines, that is, in his scholarly writings on specific Indian and Western aesthetic and poetic traditions.

AKR did not believe in abstract systems of thought nor did he formulate any particular aesthetic or poetic theory that he would claim his own. In his essays he worked simultaneously with the mind of a scholar and that of a poet. He preferred to assemble a **(p.111)** text through metaphoric exposition, using quotations and examples from personal experiences and diverse traditions, and leaving the interpretation to the reader. We have seen how AKR described his thought and creative process as a concentric continuity: the 'substance' of his personal experiences—his 'inner' forms—and his 'ways of shaping experience'—the 'outer' forms—are 'continuous with each other' and one cannot 'tell what comes from where'.¹ By following a dual approach, as often propounded by the author to interrogate or define himself, this survey of AKR's aesthetics attempts to highlight the 'relations' between forms and the spaces in between. The 'in-betweenness' is that elusive 'centre' constantly sought by his ontological and creative self, but which ironically seems to be always 'missing'.² This complex relational self-search which has biographical, aesthetic, and philosophical associations is, in fact, a recurring theme in AKR's aesthetic thought and poetry.

So rather than attempting to distinguish the 'inner' and 'outer' forms from each other, this study is a sample exercise of composing AKR's 'experiences and forms' into a tentative larger frame—an aesthetics or theory of art, or world view—in an exploration that is inevitably 'continuous' and open-ended.³ The starting point could be any text (a diary note of an intimate experience or dream, an interview or personal thought, a scholarly observation or quotation, an analysis of a tale or poem, etc.) and the direction (private to public, physical to abstract, and vice versa) may move back and forth in a zigzag. In this permeable concentric manner, AKR's 'inner' and 'outer' aesthetic forms conjoin and define also his artistic (literary) aesthetics, that is, his poetics encompassing his ideas on poetic traditions ('outer' poetics) and his creative practice as a poet ('inner' poetics).

Aesthetic Experience and Aesthetic Object: Concepts

Aestheticians have long distinguished a special kind of experience that is distinct from ordinary existence. Although the 'aesthetic experience' is most often associated with 'response' to art, it is not an elite or exclusive 'process'. It can be sensed in nature and in life's commonplace activities. My understanding of the term 'experience' here is aligned with John Dewey's tenets formulated in *Art as Experience* (1934), a seminal work in Western aesthetics which distinguishes between general experience(s) and 'an experience'. An experience may occur in daily life as part of an ordinary activity, but **(p.112)** it is singular and individualizing, such as a work of art is. Artists are, in this sense, no different from other individuals, but they tend to experience aesthetically and make things aesthetic. Such an approach to 'experience' goes well with AKR's own ideas and practice as a scholar and artist (see ahead in this chapter and also the sections 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5 and 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).⁴ The traditional Western model explains aesthetic experience in terms of the dichotomy of the creator, the beholder or critic, and the aesthetic object. Objectivist and other theorists tend to play down the relevance of aesthetic experience in the study of works of art and focus instead on the aesthetic object. By 'aesthetic object', we understand an object of awareness or entity with special sensory attributes or characteristics. Though this meaning may in some contexts be insufficient or too vague, we shall refer to it in critical practice in its general sense, as suggested by American scholar Beardsley: 'For it does seem to be presupposed by critics, and by each of us when he discusses plays and poems and statues, that there is something that can be discriminated out from the process of creation and contemplation, something that can be experienced, studied, enjoyed, and judged.'⁵ In Sanskrit aesthetic theory, as we have noted earlier (see the section 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2), it is indispensable to broach the concept of aesthetic experience in terms of enjoyment or 'taste', for its model of aesthetics is essentially founded on an analysis of affective experiences, comprising determinants, consequences, and a typology of psychological or emotional states. In such an affective aesthetic system, art is primarily judged by what is experienced and by how it is experienced.

The aesthetic experience and object imply an aesthetic perception and an aesthetic attitude, terms that have been much contested as concepts in art theory.⁶ The theorist of art Jerome Stolnitz defined aesthetic attitude in the 1960s as 'disinterested and sympathetic attention to and contemplation of any object of awareness whatever, for its own sake alone'. According to this view, the aesthetic attitude is intrinsically linked to the way we perceive the world. It also entails a distinctive way of experiencing the object as 'fully alive' as possible, amplifying our capacities of imagination and emotion to attend to the 'frequently complex and subtle details' as in a state of 'contemplation'. Stolnitz's understanding is that 'when we apprehend an object aesthetically, we do so in

order to relish its individual quality, **(p.113)** whether the object be charming, stirring, vivid, or all of these. If we are to appreciate it, we must accept the object “on its own terms”....’ This definition allows him to conclude that ‘any object at all can be apprehended aesthetically, that is, no object is inherently unaesthetic’.⁷ This argument concurs with AKR’s aesthetic appreciation of objects or events and his thoughts on aesthetic experience. AKR’s aesthetic attitude, as exposed in a variety of mostly unpublished sources and in some of the poems, can be assessed at two principal levels:

1. Particular aesthetic experiences, observations, and personal incidents that are described and recorded autobiographically in private journals and diaries in a literary, semi-literary, or prosaic style, and also in poems and drafts of poems related to these experiences.
2. Interpretation of the aesthetic experience and the aesthetic object. These personal ideas on the process of aesthetic experience are concerned with the body as mediator between life and art, the nature of the aesthetic object, and the origin of inspiration as reflected in private journals, diaries, interviews, and poems.

It will also be enlightening to discern how the personal experiences and reflections that form AKR’s ‘inner’ aesthetics converge with his scholarly description of the concepts of art and aesthetics in the diverse Indian and Western traditions articulated mainly in the essays. Although some of the diary entries reiterate AKR’s constant preoccupation with aesthetic theories in Western and Indian traditions, the intellectual responses to particular aesthetic theorists and philosophers are primarily formulated in the public writings and are considered in more detail in Chapter 5 on the author’s ‘outer’ aesthetics.

Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR’s Journals and Diaries

AKR seldom talked or wrote in a direct manner about the aesthetic experiences, sensations, or feelings that affected him as a creative writer. As he himself admitted in a letter, only rarely did his experiences find their way onto a page: ‘I’m moved by hundreds of things within and without me, that I don’t know at all how to write about. Only a small number of things ever get written, and fewer still **(p.114)** get written well.’⁸ In other words, in experiencing the ‘hundreds of things within and without’, AKR was not a writer hunting for material to write about, nor did he believe that this was possible. When certain things stirred his artistic sensitivity, there was no other purpose other than that of *living* the experience. When he noted down certain incidents or sentiments, he was recording experiences that simply *happened* to him as a person. The practice of keeping a diary had a central function in AKR’s private life and also defined his creative-writing habits. So the journals served as a working tool for the poet and a kind of sketch pad for the artist, and satisfied at once the need of the relentless fieldworker to record ‘valuable data’, that is, the reactions of the mind and the senses to the outside world. It also had a therapeutic purpose. By

holding up the mirror to himself, the poet carried on the dialogue with his inner self and was able to express his thoughts, memories, and anxieties—past, present, and future. Several remarkable episodes and extracts from the diaries and journals relate to particular personal experiences that had an impact on AKR as an artist and poet, and bear testimony to his aesthetic attitude. I have chosen journal and diary passages that cover different phases in AKR's life, which introduce us to aesthetic experiences and ideas as a college student (around 1949), in his youth (around 1959–60), in his middle age (around 1971), and at the threshold of maturity (early 1980s). These also mark important moments of initiation in AKR's life: the first poems in English, the first journey abroad and the first sight of snow, the first experience with hallucinogenics, and his first major Prize Award.

The earliest dated prose text by AKR in the Papers is an autobiographical handwritten piece dated 25–7 September 1949. At that time, AKR was a 20-year-old student of English literature at Maharaja's College. This is, in fact, the only creative prose piece in English in the Papers that dates from his student days in Mysore, and for this and other reasons it is a unique document. From a historical, critical, and literary point of view, it serves as a starting point to analyse AKR's aesthetics as well as poetics (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6). Under the intriguing title 'A Poem Is Born', the eight-page-long handwritten diary piece takes us back to the family house and the streets of Mysore, and to the years when young 'Ramu' was just beginning to write poetry in English and decided to keep a diary in English. The text reads as an amusing, naive story about the incidents surrounding **(p.115)** the composition of his 'second poem' in English and the struggle to put the experience on paper. Like some of his later journal and diary entries, this is written in the form of an autobiographical short story. The author avoids the self-reflexive 'I' and uses the third person 'he' in the text, and, in speaking of himself as 'another', he already follows a literary technique employed much later in other writing exercises in verse and prose as well as in his 1978 Kannada novella *Matthobhana Atmacharitre* (see the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 and 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3). Whereas in the Kannada novella, the autobiographical elements are lightly disguised with the help of some minor, rather playful alterations (in dates and names),⁹ in the 1949 story there are no such fictional changes and cover-ups. All the names that appear in it were those of actual friends and family members, though there is a note on the side of the last page listing alternative fictional names, for instance, 'instead of Ramoo put Rajan', and so on. Apart from the numerous corrections, this is a clear indication that the surviving rough draft, probably his first autobiographical prose piece in English, was a work-in-progress, and that he had thought of it at some point as a writing exercise. The following are two extracts from the opening and the closing (pages 1 and 7) of the story:

A poem is born. (25-27 Sept. '49)

He was writing a poem.... He had a small, neat hand, with rather feminine curves and angles. He admired it secretly, thought of a young worship-eyed posterity; thought of how he shyly concealed all that behind a modest mask of diffidence—which had the trick of becoming agonisingly real too often, the mask growing into the face. He lopped all those thoughts down; they were getting out of hand.

He must think of the poem, his second....

That fountain in Harding Circle gave him the idea. It rose from a cement pond, with a rotating beam arrangement within the water—lighting the spouts now red, now violet, and now green, and never merely one blank red, violet or green, but mingled, shaded and touched into a softer red, a deeper violet or a wonderfully sharp womanish green. The water rose as tall as the larch, and fell gracefully exhausted in a shower of pearls, catching the red, green or the violet as it chanced. It rose in a frenzy of aspiration and fell with the fatigue of achievements, the water below, ever restless in the ambitions and homecomings of her children, the fountains. It had always seemed symbolic to him, of a poem, of a life, of a hundred other experiences. But **(p.116)** then no one writes about it, though it is staring at you, a living inspiration, lit up for needy poets every evening. He smiled to himself; the grey phases about lotus-eyes or the communist freaks about the strikes and the headlines. Here's beauty, man-made, but heavenly, and these dull poets who are old at thirty, write clumsy slogans of love or war. He shall write of it and make them see....

The emptied mind, in a moment, lost its opaque emptiness, it seemed lit up. A movie appeared screened on the back of his brain. The fountain again, slightly swaying in a breeze, spreading a muslin waft of spray, chilling, sudden, breathtaking. The approaching waft, the keen sensation of chill on the open expectant face, and the dying breeze touching it to a parting iciness—he felt it all, now, here.

'Ah, that strain again!' Unforeseen, the miracle renewed itself in fresher attitudes. Words flooded his brain and he was in a hot enchantment; it gave a curious fleetness to the body and he pranced visibly in pent-up excitement.¹⁰

In the opening section of this narrative piece, the fountain, the object that inspired the protagonist to write a poem, is first described in detail with visual, kinaesthetic imagery foregrounding the colours and the movement of the water spouts. The latter part of the seven-page text recounts the sensations that the moving image, 'the movie', aroused in the young poet when recollecting the earlier visual experience of 'beauty, man-made, but heavenly'. There is a strong

sense of immediacy and physical memory in the description of the experience that shifts from sight to touch: 'a movie appeared', 'he felt it all, now, here', 'a strain', 'a hot enchantment', 'a curious fleeting to the body'. The object that evoked an aesthetic response in the adolescent AKR, alias 'he', is a commonplace sight, not a natural scene or a grandiose monument in his home town, but an ordinary fountain close to the famous Mysore Palace. The entire prose piece is a statement on the sensorial dimension of aesthetic perception and experience. Beauty is perceived as a sudden wonderment, and the physical signs of this strong experience can be caused by objects 'no one writes about'.

Almost 10 years after drafting this autobiographical story in which AKR gives an account of his first flirtation with poetry in English, the young writer received a Fulbright travel fellowship and the Smith-Mundt grant as a student of linguistics, and embarked on the journey of his life. AKR left India on 1 July 1959 from Bombay by ship and arrived in the USA on 28 July after calling at Port Said and Marseille. On this first trip to the Western hemisphere, AKR spent four days, **(p.117)** from 19 to 23 July, in France, and his zeal for new experiences made him pay a short visit to Paris, the city of artists and poets. His impressions of this first face-to-face encounter with 'otherness' on the ship and on land are memorably captured in a short unpublished journal piece titled 'Notes towards a Journal: The Journey', written shortly after the four-week voyage. This short prose text reveals AKR's aesthetic response to a wholly new environment, imagined, but till then unknown. It is also a remarkable biographical document and its argument serves as a metaphor of his personal and artistic passage to the West. As a rite of initiation, it marks a transitional point from the familiar environment (the Akam) to the strange, unfamiliar outer world (the Puram), and illustrates how this transition gradually fades into a new state of awareness. Here are some extracts of this journal text (see also the section 'Biographical Factors and Poetic Creation' in Chapter 6):

Notes towards a Journal: The Journey

One may begin anywhere. Paris from the top of Napoleon's Arch of Triumph, the thirteen boulevards and their toy bustle among the lines of trees that look like mops of green silk. The sun-tanned man in a deep blue jersey and fawn corduroy standing before a huge modern painting and fitting into the quiltwork composition as if he were born for that moment, to stand before that piece which was born with a gap in the composition. Or the ghostly flayed cliffs of Aden, nude without vegetation; ... or the three women in the backstreets of Marseilles gossiping, cigarette in mouth, their feet bared in the trickle of water running from a broken pipe ... the Seine bookshops that are locked up like old trunks, the librarian on the luxury liner who was also the wine steward ... people, places, people without homes, homes without people. One can begin anywhere. For all of them are equal to a stranger's appetite, this is a democracy by novelty,

things have no centre and no hierarchy of foreground and background. It is a hailstorm of detail, which eludes all patterning in perception.

But then, every journey is a disentanglement, a flutter of adieus among the mast ropes.... As one is disengaged from the family, the familiar, everything puts on the stranger-look of a symbol. The journey itself, the seed's self-exile, the salt estranging sea. The towboat, the guy ropes, the receding wharf with its belittled crowd, its motley of mothers and wives, waiting for the emptiness. The sudden need for telescopes....

But a ship is a floating island. Its self-sufficiency disturbs you: it has everything except a cemetery (there is always the sea) ...

(p.118) There is everything here but everything is anonymous, till one sees 'the faces in the crowd.' There is a collective purpose held for four weeks—the self-sufficiency is part of that long-term purpose that stands on Staten Island, a finger through the smog.

The journey, the compass and the captain, the uniforms that change from white to navy blue as the climate chills the weather, the hours that strike backwards as we cross westwards square after square of latitudes—these never appear as detail. Everything is simplified to more than life-size. They baffle you by their didactic intent, the meanings they can casually afford. It is a reckless spree of meanings, an orgy in slow motion for the mind. But soon the spree is over, and things return to you with their tie (knots) loosened. As a lover dwindles into husband, symbol fades into fact.¹¹

In the 1949 Mysore journal, the vision of the familiar fountain in his hometown suddenly came back to him as 'a movie' lighting up the youngster's 'emptied mind'. This journal piece captures the impressions of an experienced poet in an alien setting: France and the ship on the ocean. Their corresponding metaphors are an indecipherable 'quiltwork composition' and a self-sufficient 'floating island' that are overcrowded with detail. Perception yields 'no patterning', but acute visual sense-impressions that stimulate the writer's imagination. Feelings and emotions are expressed by describing the scene: a 'democracy, by novelty' of people and places. The aesthetic dimension of the new experience is juxtaposed to a 'composition' that begins from the top of the Arch of Triumph. From there everything is viewed like a huge modern painting. There is no subjective 'I' or 'he' protagonist. The impersonal narrator is both the observer and the observed, 'things have no centre, no hierarchy'. He can be the 'sun-tanned' man standing before a modern painting in a Paris museum, 'born for that moment': too close to distinguish a pattern, he is part of the painting. When the perceiver has no aesthetic distance, he is a mere object that becomes part of the 'composition', the baffled traveller-writer seems to imply.

AKR thus articulates his first direct exposure to the Western world as an intense aesthetic experience. Since everything the eye experiences is 'a novelty', the viewer cannot immediately interpret what the eye sees. The succession of images is overwhelming, and for the narrator there is no precise meaning to what is perceived, no clear referent to hold on to, for the images are yet an abstraction, a symbol. 'One may begin anywhere' in such an exploration of meaning. The picture is 'a hailstorm of detail' and the signified is elusive, for up **(p.119)** close the huge painting is a world of thousands of anonymous dots. As in a pointillist painting, the scene is a flattened space where neither foreground nor background dominates, yet it provides a profound aesthetic experience. Though the aesthetic object is not understood in all its significance in this new world, it is nevertheless relished as an aesthetic stimulus for the mind and the senses and turns into 'a reckless spree of meanings, an orgy in slow motion for the mind'.

The term 'stranger' acquires several meanings in this journal passage. It may imply an uninitiated newcomer, estranged son, alien foreigner, or visitor whose response to the new world is, to quote Stolzitz again, 'sympathetic' and who accepts whatever is offered for perception and experience 'on its own terms'.¹² The 'stranger' is not hostile to the new environment; he has the appetite of an ecstatic virgin. After the spree is over 'things return' to him, but one is not the same anymore after such an initiation ritual. The initial excitement of the orgiastic experience, the novelty of meeting an anonymous, symbolic 'lover' after disengaging from 'mothers and wives', vanishes back into the factual, the familiar 'husband': 'As a lover dwindles into husband, symbol fades into fact.' There could hardly be a better metaphor for AKR's new predicament as a writer between two worlds, the foreign and the familiar, dream-symbol and 'life-size' reality, than that of the male caught between female 'relations', familiar and unfamiliar.¹³ This transformative experience of entering unknown territory is echoed years later in a phrase by the fictional narrator K.K. Ramanujan in AKR's autobiographical Kannada novella: '[T]here are many initiations: the first kiss, the first intercourse, the first flight on an airplane, sailing for the first time by steamer on the first foreign trip—all these came to light from hidden sources and from discovering the world of others for the first time.'¹⁴

The title 'Notes towards a Journal: The Journey' is also significant. Writing a journal implies journeying, process, discovery. On the boat, the narrator is moving 'towards' a new territory, physically and culturally, and 'towards' a new awareness of the self. The journey is indeed a cultural, psychological, and aesthetic rite of passage. Things, places, and people take on new, unknown attires and meanings, as the traveller leaves behind the familiar past. He is a passive yet attentive witness poised between the 'mother' and 'the emptiness', between fact and symbol: '[E]verything puts on the stranger-look of a symbol. The journey itself, the seed's self-exile, the salt estranging sea.' At a textual level, writing is also a 'journey'. AKR takes down 'notes' *towards*, not **(p.120)**

for, a journal. They capture in words momentary feelings and ideas within a constant flow of sensorial data and are not finished pieces, but part of the creative process of observing and recording his sense-impressions, moving from the old *mother-land* to the new world of America on a 'long-term purpose'. Thus, the writer-poet expresses a 'stranger's appetite' for 'novelty' which takes him to explore unknown territory and record, or recall, incidents and emotions to connect art and life in unexpected ways that can 'begin anywhere'.

In the turning point of this significant prose journal AKR writes: 'There is everything here but everything is anonymous, till one sees the "faces in the crowd".' The phrase in quotes is from Ezra Pound's renowned 'In a Station of the Metro', a haiku-like poem which goes thus:

The apparition of these faces in the crowd:
Petals on a wet, black bough.

First published in 1913, this short poem is the result of an aesthetic emotion that Pound experienced in an underground station in Paris. In a famous article later titled 'Vorticism', Pound made his highly influential comments on the 'superposition' of ideas in poetry and the circumstances that gave birth to his 'one-image-poem'.¹⁵ AKR echoes Pound's passage in his own recollections of the city of Paris and in his experiences of the anonymous crowds, images, painting, and poetry. At another level of intertextuality, one can establish parallels between the 1959 journal and the imagistic poems AKR composed during his journey to the USA and in the months after, some of which highlight the interconnectedness of art and life. There is, for instance, a handwritten poetry composition titled 'On Politics', drafted on 25 July 1959 on a sheet bearing the letterhead 'Hotel Moderne, Paris'. This poem, later published with the title 'An Image for Politics' in *The Striders* in 1966, may have been inspired by an actual experience at a Paris restaurant, though the central image AKR uses is drawn from William Golding's *Pincher Martin* (1956).¹⁶ A particular culinary incident (a first-time attempt at non-vegetarian or 'fancy' kind of food?) might have evoked a strong sense of repugnance in the 'tourist' and spurred his imagination. The aesthetic response developed into a well-defined image-poem that finally stood as an explicit metaphor for omnivorous politicians:

(p.121) Once, I'd only heard
of a Chinese fancy-dish
of fish
that rots
till it comes alive
and a maggot-spaghetti squirms
where once a mackerel gasped for worms:

cannibal
devouring smaller cannibal
till only two equal

giants are left to struggle,
entwined,
like wrestlers on a cliff:

and at last
only One
omnipotent
maggot-ceasar who rent
his rival
and lived—
of all the mob and the triumvirate,
his fat and lonely body stiff
and blind with meat,
his wrings without a wriggle—

for a slit-eyed Chinaman
to pluck and serve on a not-too-clean
willow-pattern plate
to a lean
and curious tourist.¹⁷

In his appetite for new sensations, the 'lean and curious tourist' in Paris ventures on a sensorial and culinary tour that disengages him from past relations as well as precepts. Coming from a culture (orthodox Tamil Brahminism) that practises strict vegetarianism and where purity of food is one of the principles that govern life, a cannibalized 'Chinese fancy dish' would not seem to qualify as an aesthetic object, nor as an appropriate metaphor for 'politics'. But for the perceptive poet, any particular experience of the senses can yield an aesthetic response. The aesthetic attention in the artist is **(p.122)** geared at making the object come fully alive in the experience of ordinary emotions (bhavas in Sanskrit aesthetics).¹⁸ And when the world is observed with a 'stranger's appetite', the aesthetic awareness and response is particularly acute. In fact, in AKR's world view, a permanent state of 'wonderment' (adbhuta) at things old and new is one of the premises of aesthetic experience.

Between 1959 and 1961, AKR composed several interesting short poems titled 'Images'. Relevant to the content of both the journal and the poem quoted earlier is an unpublished piece titled 'Art and Life', composed shortly after his arrival in the USA. In this short poem recalling a visit to a museum of modern art (in Paris?), AKR condenses his personal idea of aesthetics which links particular experiences to art and art to life, often in odd ways. As a haiku-like composition or 'one-image-poem', the piece belonged to a series of short poems typed in 1961 with the title 'Images', of which only two were published in *The Striders*. The AKR Papers contain several versions of the short image-poem:¹⁹

Outside the museum
a pointilliste

anthill

OUTSIDE

THE MUSEUM,

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an h
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 l.

Eventually, this short poem survived as the first lines of the published poem 'Time to Stop' published in *Relations*:

(p.123) There are times
 when
going to museums
makes you see

pointilliste anthills,

Picasso faces on milkmen
framed in the living room
window,

 a violet shadow
all around a dead
or dying cow
 and you come
back at night to see
how it looks
under the gaslight,

and after an accident,
 blood
looks remarkably
like fresh paint.

 Then
it's time to stop

going to museums.²⁰

The poem plays on the theme of art and life with AKR's typical ironic detachment. He does not take Oscar Wilde's motto 'that art imitates life as much as life imitates art'²¹ as an abstract ideal, but as an artistic certainty. As in Pound's imagist oeuvre, in AKR's journals and poems art and life, aesthetics and real incidents, are closely entwined. They are simultaneously visions, descriptions, and enactments of the aesthetic experience. Art can sometimes even become too real and get confused with life. At other times, the aesthetic object may seem attractive at first sight, but then does not arouse the artist's creativity: '[O]nly a small number of things ever get written.'²²

After disembarking in the USA, AKR joined Indiana University Bloomington in the autumn of 1959 and thereafter spent time in **(p.124)** Texas, New York, and Bennington, Vermont during 1960. One of his journal entries describes an experience in 1960 that must have been a rather unfamiliar sight for a south Indian—the arrival of the first autumn snow:

Snow Nov 8, '60

Cars laden with snow—boys looking like amateur actors with powder on their hat—street lanterns lighting up drifting flakes, sometimes fast and whirling, eddies, sometimes slow and floating and scattered,—the trees streaked and stroked by white powdery fingers—leaves carrying a heap of powder like apothecaries paper-folds—footpaths white-sprinkled with cut-outs of shoes' insteps where people have walked, or the tread-patterned strips running parallel all over a street where cars have passed—....

The sky a reddish glow, the leafless branches trellished against it—the red curve of the red and blue mail-box neatly topped by a heap of white. And a silence, as if the mouths of the world have been muffled....

On such days, I look at things about avidly, feel insensitive and rage at my insensitiveness that cannot register for ever all the designs, the colour-contrasts, the masses with their veins showing. The word looks like a woman, beautiful and inviting, but already someone else's wife. I am stricken by my lack and feel empty and cheated and frigid before such wealth and warmth, open, yet closed to me.²³

Once more the prose description abounds with colour impressions, concrete images, and visual detail, and conveys strong physical sensations. The author contemplates the snow-covered city with aesthetic delight, but also expresses the difficulty of absorbing and transforming every element of the aesthetic experience 'for ever' into words. He struggles to translate into his own words the patterns and designs he perceives, for even though the environment is aesthetically stimulating, as a poet it does not seem to fully belong to him. The

metaphor of the inconsumable female body, warm and open yet unattainable, serves the purpose of depicting, in this instance, the torment of not being able to register life in art and the tension in the artist's attitude to the aesthetic object. Like a beautiful woman, the artistic muse can be desired and incited, but not possessed at will.

This frigidity or sterility that becomes a common frustration for the artist and his search for new adventures in life and art lead us to another problematic issue in dealing with aesthetic attitude and perception. According to Stolz, the selective attitude and the purpose **(p.125)** of an individual direct his attention to a particular aspect of an external object, and thereby determine and control the quality of the aesthetic experience.²⁴ But what happens to aesthetic experience when the sensorial mechanism of perception in the organism is purposely altered under the influence of hallucinogenic substances? In the 1950s and 1960s, a cross-section of psychologists, writers, and artists in the USA experimented with hallucinogenics like LSD, mescaline, mushrooms, and hashish to probe into this question and explore the inner reality of the self and the world. They believed that certain substances could create mystical perception, aid artistic inspiration, or reprogramme the brain. Later, during the counterculture of the Vietnam era, the use of hashish and LSD became a trendy practice and a popular symbol.

In the early stages of experimentation with hallucinogenics during the 1950s, a group of psychologists, intellectuals, and artists, partly inspired by Aldous Huxley's essay *The Doors of Perception* published in 1954, ventured into a new realm of experience, seeking a hidden 'inner vision'. In this groundbreaking essay, Huxley describes the psychological effects of mescaline, the chemically active principle found in peyote, the sacred cactus used by Native American shamanic priests in certain rituals. Huxley also gives ample details on the aesthetic effects experienced during his first mescaline session and its mystical or religious-philosophical dimension. His experiments recounted in *The Doors of Perception* encouraged Allen Ginsberg and other poets of the beat generation to try out hallucinogenic mushrooms, hashish, and LSD as mystical gateways to 'other worlds'.²⁵ Huxley's reputation gave the necessary justification and impetus to the intellectuals of the beat generation as the forerunners of a worldwide counterculture. Allen Ginsberg took LSD in 1960, administered by Timothy Leary, an American psychologist who had worked with Huxley, and he soon got other beat poets involved.²⁶ In the Indian English poetry scene, the trend also had a visible but limited impact. Ginsberg and his partner Peter Orlovsky travelled extensively around India in 1962-3, interacted with Bengali poets in Calcutta, and also met Nissim Ezekiel and other Indian poets writing in English in Bombay at the time. Years later, Ezekiel's experiences with LSD in America from 1967 to the early 1970s became quite notorious. Ezekiel was a close friend of AKR since the mid-1950s. In 1967, the year he visited AKR in Chicago, Ezekiel had his first LSD trip.²⁷ AKR, on the other hand, also knew

Ginsberg personally²⁸ and was acquainted with Josephine Miles, the poetess who was a leading inspiration to the beat poets. He knew her **(p.126)** from his time at the University of California, Berkeley, where he spent the second half of 1967 as a visiting professor.

Given the literary precedents and social context of the late 1960s and early 1970s in America, it was by no means uncommon that reputed intellectuals, writers, and artists resorted to psychedelic substances in search of an inner truth as a source of inspiration, or simply as an occasional trial. AKR was not unaware of this trend and among his inner circle of friends and colleagues, hallucinogenics was certainly a topic of discussion. Considering his interest in psychology, dreams, and the invisible links between the physical and the metaphysical, and his propensity to drift into unknown worlds to discover new realities, it is not surprising that on a Saturday evening in the summer of 1971, alone in a Madison apartment, AKR decided to take a dose of mescaline as an experiment and challenge. He was 42 when he got acquainted with the effects of this new hallucinogenic, and as part of his experience, perhaps in an attempt to emulate Huxley and other writers, he jotted down his experience on paper. The difficult personal circumstances faced by AKR during 1971, the year of his first divorce, may also have played a decisive role in prompting him to explore the inner reality of the self and probe aesthetic perception in this *fashionable* way. After AKR got divorced from his wife Molly Daniels, who left for India with their two children, he seems to have gone through a psychological depression in the summer of 1971. This was also the year that his second poetry collection, *Relations*, was published and marked a long standstill in his poetry publishing, since AKR did not bring out his next collection, *Second Sight*, until 1986.²⁹ The 24 pages relating the experience and describing the progressive effects of the chemical substance on his mind and the senses are marked by Molly's absence as she is repeatedly invoked in the notes by the suffering self. 'O Molly, it's all a scream of longing for you!' writes AKR in the early hours of the evening while listening to the Beatles. The author later titled the manuscript dated 28-9 August 1971 the 'Mescaline Notes'. No other such experience seems to have been documented elsewhere in the AKR Papers.³⁰

Contrary to Huxley, who was accompanied by a scientist-doctor and recorded the observations made under the influence of the drug on an audio tape, AKR's was an informal incident 'transcribed' pen-in-hand during the experience itself, as far as that was possible. AKR had no particular pretensions to artistic inspiration when taking the mescaline dose but to sit down and 'meditate'. And like Huxley, he **(p.127)** conceived the act of recording the experience as an intellectual exercise and psychological experiment. He was interested in the dream world and psychology, in philosophical as well as scientific matters, and at some point felt he was stepping into Huxley's footsteps with his experiment: 'The long journey that Huxley started,' scribbles AKR in his ironic mode on the night of 28 August 1971, 'ends, or begins after 20 years in this III floor Apt. and I can't bear

to read Huxley—yet in spite of Heraclitus, he points to a shared dreaming, not just a shared waking—Swinburne’s peyote trances—Huxley used to call it—must read him now.’³¹ Although AKR refers to Huxley in the notes, it may be altogether unjust to draw further parallelisms between the two authors in regard to aesthetics, for their views on the subjects of art, creativity, and the idea of divine or mystic inspiration differed substantially.

As a poet, AKR’s intentions with the mescaline adventure were complex and ambiguous, for he knew that the actual output derived from it would be rather uncontrollable. Within a wider biographical and artistic perspective, the mescaline experience had philosophical, metaphysical, religious, aesthetic, and poetic implications for AKR. Some of the thoughts put down in the notes link up with ideas that had a long-term impact on AKR’s aesthetic and poetic thought and creativity. We shall focus here primarily on the aesthetic dimension of the experience. The author pays particular attention to the psychological and physical transformations that are perceived under the effects of mescaline, which slowly entail the apprehension of a new reality. In the notes, he records in detail the alterations of the sensorial faculties, that is, sight, sound, touch, and taste. He is particularly fascinated by the nature and quality of visual perception,³² and to a lesser degree also by the auditory and tactile impressions. Listening to Vivaldi, the Beatles, Indian violin music, Mozart, Bach, and Schumann on the night of the mescaline trip, he is struck by the intensity of the colours and shapes ‘cartooning’ behind his eyes:

Aug 28, 1971, Saturday

6 pm

Vivaldi—flowing—expectancy—surveying all the objects in front

Slight weakness & tremor of limbs—

lying down—evening sunlight fell on my stretched hand with watch,
golden-yellow hair—the sun was really a reflection in a west-facing window

—

(p.128) Dry chalklike feeling in the throat—shiver in the calves—

My handwriting isn’t clear, getting less coordinated as my forearm muscles
are aquiver—

A coursing of blood all over—

Earlier on, I took account of all fearful objects, tribal spears, the butterflyfish
over-hanging—but I’m not going to be afraid—I’m going to meditate

Put on Vivaldi again.... As I stood meditating, hands together, images of 100's of hands together cartoon behind my eyes—....

As I close my eyes, the after-images glow in 'conventional' psychedelic colors—weak-yellow sunlight of evening—as in some after-fever.

Gradually what appeared as 'conventional' colours turns into a spree/an extravaganza of changing shades and forms:

7:30 pm

... proliferating colors and shapes and points behind my eyes—open them only to assure myself of the real light, the gourd in front, the hard floor—the weakness of the handwriting—close my eyes—a brilliant glow of green with shots of orange, purple—all a changing mist ... behind my eyes—exhausting inexhaustible turnover of colored shapes begetting glowing color shapes, designs of red black and green dots as on tie and die sari.... I want reality to glow—only the colors behind my eyes do. Even the clicks and thuds of the turntable change into scorpions of color—no words—the turnover is exhausting....³³

As the description proceeds here, the handwriting and the syntax become less regular and the inner visions turn more psychedelic. What characterizes this encounter with the 'behind the eyes world', as opposed to the outer 'ordinary reality', is the perception of mutating forms and colours, and the experience of images as a continuous flow:

I watch my own hand with a watch on it
It's there—weak, bodily—burdened with its own weight
I close my eyes and see insects disintegrate it,
leaves cover it, grubs on it—slowly crumbles into a
wrist-bone with a wrist watch on it—

... I'm seeing all the colors in the world I've wanted to see—mists, mingling, waves, diffusion; never really white or black, only aquamarines....

O the pleasures of the visual man! ... I close my eyes on a multiplicity of metallic glints in self-reproducing dynamy of vessels, suddenly all edges a neon-glow....

(p.129) eyes open only to test reality, ears hear the toilet drip, body feels the quivering inner weakness of muscle as of the deep age hidden within all living things, especially middle aged things at 42—... images, floral, the ages flowing through me....

The imagery and colours pouring out of the mind are an unstoppable process that cannot be fully apprehended or fixed as they get increasingly out of control. The fluidity or moving quality of the inner visual 'diffusion' reminds us of the descriptions that AKR made of earlier aesthetic experiences in his journals (and poems), in which the observation of real, outer objects gives rise to a multiplicity of reflections and details in motion. His compelling account in the 'Mescaline Notes', in fact, begins with an evocative image and suitable metaphor for what is to unfold before him through his personal *windows of perception*: The sun ('golden-yellow hair'), that is, what is *seen*, is 'really a reflection' (illusion, maya?) 'in a west-facing window' (see earlier in this section). In the other diary passages quoted earlier, images were perceived as 'a movie ... screened on the back of his brain' (1947) or 'an orgy in slow motion' (1959), often followed by desire, and sometimes failure, to seize and 'register for ever all the designs' (1960). It is also elucidating to read, in this context, a revealing paragraph in AKR's autobiographical novella written between 1976 and 1977, in which the narrator compares his Telugu friend's love intoxication with an LSD trip:

[H]e was like one who, when experimenting with drugs for the first time, has taken too much LSD. His world turned upside down. The earth, the chairs, the faces, the trees, the fingers, his dead sister's hands, twinkling rhinestones in the glass chandelier, everything swirled into a thousand colours. The grand illusion lasted two whole days.³⁴

In his 1971 mescaline experiment, several fascinating aesthetic insights and philosophical questions unfurl for AKR from the heightened attention paid to the visual-sensorial flow and the continuous transformations of the inner world experienced under the effects of the drug:

1. The 'inner' visual images do not have natural but artificial aesthetic associations for him (bright colours, vessels glowing, metallic glints, neon-lights, and so on).

(p.130) 2. There is a dual reality of dream vision and waking life. The waking reality is perceived with all the senses as solid structure that contrasts sharply with the flowing texture of the visual imagery experienced 'behind the eyes'. Thus, there is a tension between the fixity of reality and the changeful, dissolving quality of dream-process. The mental and physical tension between solidity and flow, wakefulness and dream, reveals powerful aesthetic insights but also nurtures anxiety in the restless existence of the self.

3. This dualism experienced in a state of heightened sensorial perception provides the subject with an extraordinary view of life, as it discloses the double nature of the Hindu self (see also the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5). The flow or 'rebirth' of imagery is taken as a metaphor of the transmigrating soul. The identity of

the self as body and soul, 'melting flesh' and 'solid bone', is experienced and literally *lived through* with a particular acuteness and physical-sensorial intensity in this altered state of the mind.³⁵

These and other 'revelations' are registered in AKR's chronological 'Mescaline Notes' as an experiential tour de force where the aesthetic and poetic dimensions are fused with mystical, philosophical, existential, and physical associations:

It's such a rich culture-world—where's nature? Why is it all sculpture? Where the seas, the trees, the grass (why is it only the handkerchief of God)—from which all cities come and to which I hope they'll return—where is the star? Only wastes of color, I don't have the words for all the colors I can distinguish. Blood and mango green thick swathes of it, effluvia of it highly phosphorescent like a smoke in a half-green glowlight—

9:30 pm

... bodies without bones or roots, proliferating endless colors with no power over the fertility of our imagings—except to return constantly to the mother, the affection....

... these marvellous weak-kneed shifting boneless endless tranceshapes—in all this I forgot the pear I bit and the glass of milk I left on the shelf near the window to glint bottlegreen in the gaslight—

Why is waking life so solid, so constant, or is it? And why so different from the behind the eyes world so fertile uncontrollable staunchless flow within **(p.131)** flow, birth within birth of shapes all in focus even in a fiery mist—All the other senses, taste of plum, wet touch of plum, the crunch and juice and shifting of pressures in the mouth, and that drip (that drip, that's Me! The Leaky Tap! in my Sister's Wedding!)³⁶ All these are reality—but I close my eyes, a whole new wilderness, designs and colors enough for a lifetime if I were a painter,—such a difference of texture ... or is it because I've attended too much to the solid unchanging structure of 'reality,' not its changefulness as I'm doing in my mind?—

(Reality) always anchoring me, letting me back in if only I open my eyes, or let my finger feel the metal plug, the pain in the back, the weakness in the knee. Like the plum, its solidity though it's gone, and the seed of solid core it's left behind, indissoluble—like my bones in this melting flesh, always there to outlast me—[*'Through future worlds, birth after birth, have I come'*]—

I said to myself over and over—if each of these images as they turn over were 'real,' whole lives, I'd have many lives already—that's why I

understand though yet metaphorically—[‘*Through future worlds, birth after birth, have I come*’]³⁷

—And the tremendous feeling of age behind me, of many lives—

In this sequence, AKR compares the unremitting flow of imagery and sensations to the chain of rebirths in the Hindu principle of reincarnation. He sees all his past and future lives pass through him as images, which strike in him a familiar metaphor. The original quote in Kannada (translated in brackets) referring to the soul’s endless rebirths is taken from vachanas (sayings, oral poems) number 18 and 19 by Mahadeviyakka (see also the sections ‘The Aesthetics of Bhakti’ in Chapters 5 and ‘Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics’ in Chapter 7), the Virasaiva mystic poetess of the twelfth century AD that AKR was translating around the same time for his collection of Kannada bhakti poetry in English titled *Speaking of Siva* (1973). In these vachanas, the bhakta (devotee) pledges with Siva to dissipate maya (illusion) and cut short the chain of incarnations. In *Speaking of Siva*, AKR translated vachana 18 by Mahadeviyakka thus:

Not one, not two, not three or four
But through eighty-four hundred thousand vaginas
have I come,
I have come
through unlikely worlds,
guzzled on
pleasure and pain.
Whatever be
(p.132) all previous lives,
show me mercy
this one day,
O lord
white as jasmine.³⁸

In the Hindu tradition maya, the veil of delusion and creative power of life, is concomitant with the concepts of dream and art. Indologist Henrich Zimmer suggests that maya allows for a reading in terms of the Hindu mythology of creation as well as of Western psychology of the unconscious and conscious:

The Hindu mind associates such ideas as ‘transitory, ever-changing, elusive, ever-returning,’ with ‘unreality.’ And conversely, ‘imperishable, changeless, steadfast, and eternal,’ with ‘the real.’ As long as the experiences and sensations that stream through the consciousness of an individual remain untouched by any widening, devaluating vision, the perishable creatures that appear and vanish in the unending cycle of life (*samsara*, the round of rebirth) are regarded by him as utterly real. But the moment their fleeting character is discerned, they come to seem almost unreal—an illusion or mirage, a deception of the senses, the dubious figment of a too restricted, ego-centred consciousness. When understood

and experienced in this manner the world is Māyā-maya, 'of the stuff of Māyā.' Māyā is 'art,' that by which an artefact, an appearance, is produced.³⁹

Now, the aim of the bhakti poet-saint is to disengage the mind from maya, the world's illusion created by ignorance, and thus to break the chain of rebirths and attain moksha: 'Karma and the chain of births are cut short by *bhakti*. *Bhakti*, and its faith in the Lord's grace, is the answer to the inexorable logic of Karma,'⁴⁰ comments AKR on the Mahadeviyakka poem (vachana 18) in *Speaking of Siva*. For AKR, however, this kind of grace (see also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6) seems unattainable as he is immersed in a restless 'ecstasy ... an essential helplessness' in his metaphorical experience of rebirths. In a later passage of the 'Mescaline Notes', AKR struggles to hold on to reality, the structure of 'prose', for he is wary of the uncontrollable play of the mind and the unrelenting 'inner changeful dreams':

Need to get up, as if to find my bones of reality always there, the prose, the scaffolding, to outlast the shifting decaying renewing reborn flesh—

(p.133) Even as I piss my eyes close for a second, and there are swarms of designs ... no wonder I stick so close to the bone, the structure, fearful of loss in the literal inferiorities of variation never-stopping except when you open your eyes to the rug—the wool-roughness the hard ridges, the steady patterns which too play tricks at the margins in the corners of your eyes.

10:10 pm

No wonder Heraclitus asked everyone to pledge himself to the waking where alone we've a common (in both senses) world, an unshifting (at least till you think of it) cosmos, an expressible logos.

... an exhausting sleepiness full of dreams behind the eyes—it's a non-sensual non-bodily world, no body to it, an 'ecstasy' but not restful, easy. Though you yield to it—an essential helplessness in the face of this relentless flow of birth and rebirth of imagery—

Constantly tensing up bone and muscle to feel my solidity and how it dissolves, like my mental effort to 'hold' a thought as if the two were compatible—I should simply let go, not hold back, float—

O that drip!—No fear, no fear of loss—one has no identity, one is a process at least behind the eyes—I wish I could shut off that drip, yet it's me coeval with me, can't shut it off (though I can probably physically—like myself)

... this is the nature of the body, deep within, though we firm it, tense it, make it fighting fit. Yet it returns to its infirmness as one ages, or in a fever, or in a trance like this—age must be like this, lying down with uncontrollable turbulence of images—a constant need to wake up from the continuous dream, touching and moulding one's real nose rubbery oily—Why am I so full of words!

... O Molly—I want you to be part of my waking world as you're always in my behind the eyes dreaming world—though you may not want it, like my bones, will resist this flow—this process—doesn't matter, we, each the other hardcore resistant reality against the inner changeable dreams, process—maybe not—maybe nothing can stay

Blue minute diamonds as I close my eyes

Imagine a whole group of peyote Indians around a fire—entranced together each the other's hold on reality—yet a common dream—itsself a dream quickly shattered by law—

... This summarises a lifetime's restlessness, tossings—and not finding utter sleep because of continuous dream, body-ache, being here and yet not here but in the crystal forest.

For AKR, this particular experience sums up his aesthetic vision and illustrates the predicament of life and creativity. It is in this intensified manner, through the body and the senses and beyond, that the tension of being suspended between life and art, between reality **(p.134)** and dream (maya), between resistance and process, is felt and made 'visible'. Under the influence of the hallucinogenic, the complexities of the self are 'exposed' and perceived as strong aesthetic experiences, while the mind is in a state of ecstasy, puzzled yet paradoxically 'full of words' and visions. The inner journey makes the author understand his existence and the world in an extraordinary way. He apprehends in this physical and psychic trip an uneasy double reality of fixity and flow, a constant struggle between waking and dreaming, experienced with a vividness and depth of which he had earlier in life only obtained rare glimpses. Within this continuous flow of imagery and endless state of dream-reflections, the self gets lost in a 'crystal forest' that does not allow for 'utter sleep'. Its incessant, uncontrollable *reflexive* process—and the resistance against it—begets not only a turbulence of images and 'after-images' but also psychological anxiety and physical strain. But, after all, that is life's predicament for the traditional Hindu 'when the self is wrongly identified with the body, mind and senses', as the Upanishads teach.⁴¹ To achieve true enlightenment beyond dualities (that is, to find 'God') seems unattainable for AKR, but ironically worth trying, even if mocking oneself through poetry:

Second Sight

In Pascal's endless queue,
people pray, whistle, or make

remarks. As we enter the dark,
someone says from behind,

'You are Hindoo, aren't you?
You must have second sight.'

I fumble in my nine
pockets like the night-blind

son-in-law groping
in every room for his wife,

and strike a light to regain
at once my first, and only,

sight.⁴²

(p.135) I have so far alluded primarily to the visual dimension in AKR's aesthetic experiences, as sight (including 'inner sight') is the most predominant of the senses (here, altered by the drug) and also the preferred tool and metaphor for the perception of another reality: 'All the other senses, taste of plum, wet touch of plum, the crunch and juice and shifting of pressures in the mouth, and that drip.... All these are reality—but I close my eyes, a whole new wilderness, designs and colors enough for a lifetime if I were a painter....' However, the poet's 'inner discoveries' in the summer of 1971 involve also the auditory perception. The way music is appreciated by AKR during the peak of the mescaline spree reflects again a unique awareness of time, the self, and the body:

11:15 pm
Mozart on the piano—
Even in the speed and slowness of music
reality is the body's discomfort
the body's fidget prevent and save
you from final dissolution and ecstasy—
so much longed-for, to dissolve, to be nothing
but the speed, the slowness, the interval
unbrought-to-earth by the body's ache, its weakness—
even the piano feels like a simile
for the eternal drip—which you lose
and find—like your body in thought—...

3 am

This evening and night has been my first real 'discovery' of Western music—.

AKR's mescaline trip begins and ends to the rhythm of Western classical music. Music is perceived in its primordial sense as 'the eternal drip—which you lose/ and find—like your body in thought'. This primal 'feeling' of music or, rather, of longing to dissolve in between its beats contrasts with the refined and abstract aesthetic towards Western music taught by a British professor to the young student in Mysore in the 1940s.⁴³

In addition to the 24 pages of prose in the 'Mescaline Notes', the manuscript also includes about 10 pages of poetry drafts interspersed with annotations written after the effects of the drug had remitted. It is not easy to assess at first sight how far-reaching the effects of the mescaline experience were for AKR as a poet and writer, but the **(p.136)** physiological, aesthetic, and philosophical concerns described in this remarkable journey did linger with AKR for years and popped up sometimes in unexpected contexts, biographical and poetic. There is an (in)visible thread in AKR's poetry, a loose cycle of unpublished drafts and published poems, that is devoted to hallucinations and 'inner' visions. A few of the poems in *Second Sight* (1986) and in the posthumous collection *The Black Hen* (1995) deal with such experiences. There is also in the AKR Papers a long sequence titled 'Soma Poems', which contains compositions the poet decided not to publish.⁴⁴ In these, the poet plays with the concept of Soma (a Vedic god, 'lord of speech', and also divine elixir) as a multiple metaphor for poetic inspiration. Some of the lines in these poems derive from the poetry drafts scribbled in the 'Mescaline Notes'. Whatever the direct and indirect connections of the mescaline episode to particular poems may be, the traces of hallucinogenic experiences are unmistakably present in AKR's poetry and prose. In *Someone Else's Autobiography*, the narrator speaks thus of the aftershocks of 'someone else's' LSD trip:

Dormant feelings of this kind might suddenly burst forth years later, when least expected: perhaps, while taking a piss off a road in Germany or Mysore, or while looking at the iridescence of piss, or while noticing the gleam in the eyes reflected in a bathroom mirror. To the dismay of one's wife and children, such unsettling confusions are likely to linger for hours and days.⁴⁵

In the last pages of the 'Mescaline Notes', AKR scribbled dozens of tentative 'poems' and observations, for he felt it was 'somehow important to register, record everything still' as the images continued to rush to his mind on Sunday morning:

Aug 29
10:40 A bath

Mind still popping with 'poems'

Like my grandfather
I bathed before
Like my father
I slapped soap
on my back
Like me
I rubbed myself
with a Sears turkey—
towel

(p.137) ...

Like my son I held my
peepee and played gardenhose in the bathtub
and like my grandson
I was unborn ...
There won't be paper enough—feel like tempting my endurance—and
taking another dose for this luminous Sun-day and be the sundance
kid—praying mantis—still on the leaf it's eating, the soul a caterpillar
eating leaf after leaf and moving to another—

AKR refers in this prose paragraph to a classical Hindu motif for reincarnation from the Upanishads,⁴⁶ the caterpillar eating on a leaf, which is a common image in his poetry and notes. It is there, for instance, in the closing lines of the poem 'Elements of Composition', which opens the collection *Second Sight* (see also the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7). Yet one of the clearest evidences of how the mescaline experience got *translated* into final published poems is 'Extended Family', another poem from *Second Sight*, where the poet muses ironically (during a 'bath') over the Hindu concept of family and the chain of rebirths:

Extended Family

Yet like grandfather
I bathe before the village crow

the dry chlorine water
my only Ganges

the naked Chicago bulb
a cousin of the Vedic sun

slap soap on my back
like father

and think

in proverbs

like me

I wipe myself dry

(p.138) with an unwashed

Sears turkish towel

...

I hold my peepee

like my little son

play garden hose

in and out

the bathtub

like my grandson

I look up

unborn

at myself

like my great

great grandson

I am not yet

may never be

my future

dependent

on several

people

yet

to come (1-14, 29-47)⁴⁷

What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience

In a diary entry dated 13 April 1982, over 10 years after recording the mescaline experience, AKR pledged to write in his journal 'not directly about one's feelings', but rather to record 'incidents, objects, persons and briefly, concretely, evocative of sense impression'.⁴⁸ The poet reflected on this practice when he was struggling with a long composition, which eventually became the backbone of a new poetry book: *Second Sight*.⁴⁹ He strived to stick to this self-imposed guideline through most of his life, and in the diaries and journals generally reproduced a thought or 'sense-impression' through indirection by describing objects, incidents, conversations, encounters, travels, **(p.139)** and dreams. There are also rare instances, particularly in his early phase as a young writer, where his feelings are not fully checked by intellectual restraint and formal control. Even on such occasions, as the 'I' surrenders to the experience, aesthetic emotions typically emerge from the attentive observation of an object.

AKR's aesthetic sensibility relies on a primordial, instinctive awareness of the five senses—visual, auditory, tactile, gustatory, and olfactory. Though it is the visual sense, the eye, that first triggers and impregnates a particular aesthetic response, all the senses are naturally integrated in the experience and play a substantial role in the journals, diaries, and poems. For AKR, the entire body is the mediator between life and art.

The personal experiences from the diaries and journals related earlier exemplify AKR's aesthetic attitude to incidents and objects in miscellaneous situations belonging to different periods in his life. Yet they have essential features in common. The various biographical episodes express a writer's need for continuous sensorial stimuli and convey a strong sense of physical immediacy in his relation to objects, incidents, and the world around him. It is through the direct experience of the particularities of an object that an aesthetic quality can be discerned and that imaginative connections are established. Wider associations and questions may arise from this particular contact (in time and space) between the subject, the 'I', and the aesthetic object, but the basis for aesthetic appreciation is close attention to the momentary and unexpected detail. In 'Carpe Diem', a little known early poem published in 1957, AKR manifests his concern for immediacy in aesthetic observation and his search for connections between the present of a concrete sensation and larger, abstract ideas:

Pluck the moment,
said Epicurus.

But when we pluck.
does the fruit forget
the tree's inverted image
moping in the root.
and the slow certainty
of the earth shouldering volcano
waiting in the green hereafter?⁵⁰

Contrary to Plato, who developed a theory of beauty based on the *idea* that beauty is a permanent property in all beautiful things, Epicurus formulated his theory of art stating that beauty is sensed (**p.140**) as a *feeling* of pleasure in a moment of inspiration or grace.⁵¹ AKR highlights the present immediacy of the aesthetic experience, while he is also aware that it cannot be cut off from the umbilical cord of cosmic creation, for the entire past and future is contained in a fleeting moment of insight. To counter Epicurus, AKR again invokes here his favourite Upanishadic motif of the upside-down cosmic tree with the branches in the earth and the roots in the air as a metaphor for immortality and the interconnectedness of creation.⁵² A few months after 'Carpe Diem' (originally drafted in the city Belgaum, Karnataka) was published, AKR wrote in retrospective: 'My five fruitful years at Belgaum taught me how much can be

done in a day if one lived in the Present Discontinuous and plucked every moment.’⁵³ Years later, in one of his last interviews, AKR regarded such a momentary consciousness of ‘the present’ as a ‘rare event’:

Not that you can ever get rid of abstractions—you can’t live purely on sensation, when we try to do that, like in certain types of meditation, we know how quickly that dissipates, when we want to live simply in the present.... The present is the most illusive, just as the literal is the most elusive of meaning ... though those rare occasions when you feel you are really living in the present, are extraordinary because they open out the way nothing else does. But it’s such a rare event.... Nothing that one does in the most abstract realm is unconnected with one’s emotions and one forgets that.⁵⁴

The state of ‘living in the present’ is perceived by AKR as an illusory, almost intangible reservoir of creativity, and it is left to the artist’s ‘eye’ to tap the outer and inner realms of a particular emotion or sensation so as to connect the real world of ‘here and now’ to the timeless undercurrent of imagination. A pure experience of the ‘Here and Now’ is, however, an elusive ideal, and the poet asks how it can be attained:

...
But this here and now
which is here before my eyes
decaying second by second
winking with each dying bubble

here now but gone before one says it
or sees it, growing incorporeal
as able-bodied women
in love with incorporeal wraiths,

(p.141) tease like virtual images
behind the mercury of mirrors.

...
One can cross the Amazon out there,
but how can one cross the sub-
terranean Ganges
between now and now? How does

one reach the horizon here, now
within the iris in the seeing eye?⁵⁵

In AKR’s *Weltanschauung*, abstract ideas, including creativity, art, and beauty, are inextricably rooted to the physical body and biological time which endow them with meaning. To evoke an aesthetic stimulus and response (which can involve an emotion and an idea), often a particular object or image that ‘teases’

the poet is associated with the bodily organs and their inborn, natural responses. The senses entail an immediate presence, but they can even have memory and leave lasting resonances. A well-known much earlier poem by AKR, 'Eyes, Ears, Nose, and a Thing about Touch' from *Relations*, is a review of the human body and how it 'remembers' through the senses:

Eyes are fog,
are trees green or on fire,
a man's face quartered by the cross-
hairs of a gunsight. Crows, scarecrows,
eyes in others' eyes. A brown dog
dipped and gilded in the sunshine,
or blurred through someone else's glasses.

When lucky
it dawns birdcries,
the ear has children with bells;
the fall, delay, and fall
of a wooden doll on the wooden
stairs, what mother says
to cook and early beggar.

Urine on lily,
women's odours
in the theatre, a musk cat's
erection in the centre of a zoo,
(p.142) the day's bought flowers
crushed into a wife's night
of grouses: the sudden happiness

of finding
where noses can go.
Touch alone has untouchables,
lives continent in its skin, so
segregating the body
even near is too far.
Through all things that press,

claw, draw blood,
yet do not touch,
it remembers a wet mouth
on a dry;.... (1-32)⁵⁶

A diary entry written in 1982 reveals how AKR resorted to the old theme of the bodily senses when he was searching for new material to give meaning to the long poem (or sequence of poems) he had worked on and which was then titled 'Composition'.⁵⁷ It is significant that he connected the five natural senses with the eight aesthetic emotions classified in the *rasa* theory of Sanskrit aesthetics

(see the sections ‘Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview’ in Chapter 2 and ‘Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy’ in Chapter 5):

Aug 4, 1982

... Have to do entirely new things—think on new themes—look through my poetry notes—make some regularly—as I used to.

Touch-tack, out of touch, see my old poem on 5 senses—and not repeat it—

Sending poems might help write more

Themes—one could go by the classical rasa—love, heroism, anger, pathos, disgust, terror, wonder, laughter⁵⁸

After establishing the relationship between the senses and rasa, the diary entry works out a list of ‘things’ that make him angry. Eventually these notes formed the raw material for the poem ‘Snakes and Ladders’ drafted in 1982,⁵⁹ where the poet-speaker ‘makes a scene’ (in its double meaning) and smashes ‘all transparent things’ after futile attempts to climb up ‘ladders’ from the beautiful ‘things’ to abstract wisdom or ‘Beauty’, as described in Plato’s *Symposium*.⁶⁰ In a suicidal rage, he smashes ‘all transparent things, crystal’ till blood on **(p.143)** his thumb makes him plummet to objective reality—‘the ground’—only to ‘wake/ wide open, hugging the white toilet bowl’, which he calls his ‘cool porcelain sister’. The year AKR published this poem, he noted in his diary how it was connected to a dream and a memory from childhood:

Oct 4, 1986.

Earlier dream: I enter an elevator and I find a toilet in it, and I’m going down. I remember 180 (180, N. Michigan—analyst’s office). Poem on toilet and elevator and suicide—where, after toying with suicide, I faint, remember a plunging elevator, and wake up hugging a toilet—which I call my cool porcelain sister. My first glimpse of sexual attraction—seeing Veda, full breasted, in a sari, near the Rama Temple.⁶¹

Unlike in Sanskrit aesthetics, which distinguishes natural inborn feelings (bhava) from aesthetic emotion (rasa), in the aesthetics of AKR we do not find such a nature/culture dichotomy (see the sections ‘Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy’ and ‘Tamil Aesthetics’ in Chapter 5). AKR sees a contiguity between ‘natural’ and ‘aesthetic’ feelings, and this may be traced to the influence of Tamil aesthetics and poetics in which ‘nature is closely observed, not mythologised, fabulised or stylised as in Sanskrit.... Furthermore, nature becomes the repertory of images for the entire human civilisation. Natural objects become the vocabulary of culture.’⁶² For AKR, the aesthetic object can be something quite ordinary, a trite situation, a commonplace detail or movement, and need not be culturally refined or the product of a

sophisticated aesthetic tradition. His recollections of aesthetic experiences and writings appear to adhere to Stolnitz's view that 'any object at all can be apprehended aesthetically, i.e., no object is inherently unaesthetic'.⁶³ But in order to 'be apprehended aesthetically', AKR maintains that the object has to speak to the mind and the senses as an immediate, and often unexpected, live experience.

Another poem recalling a real incident during AKR's stay in Madurai as a lecturer of English in the 1950s places two juxtaposed images at the crossroad of two possible approaches to art and aesthetic experience. The poem, published in 1957 as 'Madura: Two Movements', ironically suggests that there are two kinds of art or aesthetics: one represented by the unpleasant, disfigured body of a leper, and the other, by an ancient, nose-less sculpture of a dancing **(p.144)** figure. The published poem concludes with the 'dancer/ bound in a world of sounds/ unmoving she moves/ as nothing in life can move'.⁶⁴ The pun in the ergative verb 'moves' becomes more intricate as the question of 'what moves' the spectator—life/body or art/soul—is given different emphases and twists depending on how it is raised in the various versions of this poem. An earlier draft of this poem from the mid-1950s, titled 'In Madurai I Saw a Quite-Human Hand', follows a symmetric structure in juxtaposing *the aesthetic in life* with *life in art*:

In Madurai I saw
a leper, a crab-like claw,
still a quite-human hand,
but enamelled
by a process well-known
to everyone
to the color of old copper

It moved

But behind him a dancer,
a relief in rock
a well-known question
raised in a well-known answer.

She too moved.⁶⁵

The sculpted artwork of the dancer can 'move' just as the leper in life moves. Any object can evoke an aesthetic response in the artist-beholder, be it crude life or ancient art, still object or alive, and this may happen in divergent ways and circumstances. In the poem, both the leper and the stone sculpture are perceived as aesthetic objects, but they represent two different approaches and experiences. Whereas the first stirs a natural emotional response, the latter speaks to a cultural aesthetic sensibility. The 'well-known question' which appears also in the published poem 'Madura: Two Movements', may refer to

Yeats's poem 'Among School Children'⁶⁶ which ends with the famous rhetorical question: 'How can we know the dancer from the dance?' For Yeats, dancer and dance, body and soul, are inseparable as it is the whole that is aesthetic (see also the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7). AKR does not raise the Yeatsian question of the dancer (the aesthetic (p.145) ideal of momentary totality), but interrogates the purpose and limits of art with a fragmented vision. A poem on the same theme written by AKR in Kannada further explores the diverse aesthetic attitudes in an ironic play of juxtaposition and contrast (disfigured leper/broken sculpture, life/art, present/past, modernity/tradition, desi/marga, India/America):

In the dusty streets of Madurai
This leper husband
Walks disfigured face
Face devoid of nose
Hands sans fingers
Foot without heel
The eye soaked in silt
Flies feasting on it
The oozing wound attracting
multicoloured flies as if it is a flower
...
Behind him stands the ancient monument
on which leans a voluptuous Apsara
Below her broken nose
The mouth flashes a smile
...
Between her thighs
Picaresque Tamilian rouges
Have scribbled in Sanskrit graffiti
I recollected these two images
And I spoke in America
On art and aesthetics
On which poured plentiful applause. (1-10, 13-16, 20-6)⁶⁷

Eventually, in the early 1980s some lines of the original poem drafted in the 1950s were retrieved by AKR and 'added' to 'Elements of Composition', the opening poem of *Second Sight*:

...
add the lepers of Madurai,
male, female, married,
with children,

lion faces, crabs for claws,
clotted on their shadows

under the stone-eyed

(p.146) goddesses of dance, mere pillars,
moving as nothing on earth
can move—.... (27–35)⁶⁸

The different versions of the poem imply that art/soul and life/body are inseparable, but sometimes in complex relationships to each other. The latest version of this series of poetry drafts superposing the two contrasting images of leper and dancer states that the stone dancer paradoxically moves ‘as nothing on earth/ can move’. It suggests an otherworldly power that can ‘reincarnate’ and control the artist, the aesthetic object, and the emotion. Thus an object, ‘stone-eyed/ goddesses of dance, mere pillars’, can come alive to the beholder, or ‘move’ at unforeseen moments. Animate or of stone, an object is aesthetic insofar as it evokes direct personal feelings in a sudden ‘movement’ or sensation that is sometimes experienced as a kind of grace.⁶⁹ Likewise, the artist may become creative ‘by accident’. Artistic genius or grace can come in surprising ways that do not necessarily correspond to the classical notions of art and refined culture, as we can read, for example, in the poem ‘Figures of Disfigurement’,⁷⁰ a late composition from *Uncollected Poems and Prose*, in which an arthritic painter is able to create innovative works thanks to his ‘technical’ handicap.

The aesthetic experience in AKR arises usually from a well-formed image and is a partially unwilled and unconscious act, not unlike the workings of memory, dream, or nightmare. Three poems from different periods, collected in *The Striders* and *The Black Hen*, bear witness to the unpredictability of the aesthetic experience, which is often associated with the natural instinct of the fear of animals. Particular objects that stir the artist’s sensitivity can sometimes become quite terrifying. Here are a few examples:⁷¹

Snakes

No, it does not happen
when I walk through the woods
But, walking in museums of quartz
or the aisles of bookstacks,
looking at their geometry
without curves
and the layers of transparency
that make them opaque,
(p.147) dwelling on the yellower vein
in the yellow amber
or touching a book that has gold
on its spine,
I think of snakes.... (1–13)

Breaded Fish

Specially for me, she had some breaded
fish; even thrust a blunt-headed
Smelt into my mouth;

and looked hurt when I could
neither sit nor eat, as a hood
of memory like a coil on a heath

opened in my eyes; a dark half-naked
length of woman, dead
on the beach in a yard of cloth,

dry, rolled by the ebb, breaded
by the grained indifference of sand. I headed
for the shore, my heart beating in my mouth.

The Black Hen

It must come as leaves
to a tree
or not at all

yet it comes sometimes
as the black hen
with the red round eye

on the embroidery
stitch by stitch
dropped and found again

and when it's all there
the black hen stares
with its round red eye

and you're afraid.

(p.148) In these poems, the uncontrollable natural world rouses the senses and primordial sensations which take over the 'cultured' mind of ideas and conventions.⁷² In 'The Black Hen', the artist believes, quoting a phrase by Keats (see also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6), that inspiration 'must come' as natural 'as leaves/ to a tree', but the resulting work of art stitched on the 'embroidery', an object that is lost and 'found again', does not simply evoke an idealistic aesthetic experience, but awakens the primal instinct of fear which affects the maker as well as the reader who is addressed in the last line: 'and you're afraid'. Art and life, culture and nature, are closely knit in AKR's aesthetics. They are not perceived as separate categories, and the poet

often deals with the contradictions that arise when we try to alienate one from the other.

In his poetry and private prose, AKR expresses his attraction to the innate 'memory' humans have of the most primordial of images and objects: plants and animals, and their interconnectedness with the human body.⁷³ A number of such 'aesthetic objects' derive from real episodes (a childhood encounter with a snake, the experience of tasting fish as a Brahman vegetarian, and so on) that are mentioned in the notes and diaries. These reappear in particular experiences as sharp psychological and physical sense-impressions that link the immediate present with the past and future, and generate a strong imagery with striking aesthetic effects. There is often a secondary level of signification in the description of concrete objects and personal experiences, which is typically exploited by the author to create beyond images and metaphors a 'second language' of personal symbols, conventions, and meta-poetic play, a technique that is analysed in Chapter 6. An additional aspect is the semantic density of the aesthetic object. Some natural objects, such as trees, snakes, and insects, have a highly marked archetypal content with complex cultural, mythological, religious, and philosophical associations in the diverse Indian and Western traditions.

The tree is the most prominent aesthetic object in AKR. It is present as a familiar object and archetypal image with multiple connotations: genealogical, hierarchical, structural-linguistic, biological, philosophical, mythological, religious, spiritual, and poetic. The favourite tree image is the upside-down tree, for 'the great Indian image of the cosmic tree is the tree with its branches in the earth and its roots in the air'.⁷⁴ The inverted tree appears in various mythological and philosophical traditions—Greek, Jewish, Indian, **(p.149)** etc. In the Upanishads, it symbolizes the manifestation of Brahman in the cosmos. AKR also plays with the double meaning of the 'family tree' to imply both the origin of life (or lives) and the representation of structures. In structural linguistics, sentences are analysed as 'trees', and the concept is also applied in other sciences. This cosmic tree thus represents the process of creation as a descending movement. In this cosmo-vision, human beings are an extension of the natural elements—air, fire, water, earth, ether, plants, animals, etc. In AKR's childhood, the natural environment was a ubiquitous presence, which stayed with him throughout his life and influenced his aesthetic vision of the world. In the subtropical climate of south India, insects and reptiles dwell year around in houses, and larger animals live on the streets and always close to humans. Even in many larger cities, houses do not cut off the inside from the outside, and there is no real divide between nature and the cultured, technological world of humans. This environmental feature may denote a psychological and cultural trait in India, according to AKR, where nature is perceived as part of culture and both coexist in a metonymic or concentric relationship.⁷⁵ In notes taken during a

creative-writing workshop, AKR identifies a number of favourite items from his 'childhood topography':

Favourite vegetables: tree, rose, cabbage

Favourite Animals: (horse, cat, snakes) in dreams/metaphors/body movements—'totem'

Metaphors

Body movements

especially in adolescence

Insects: caterpillar, metamorphosis: 'favourite image and fear'⁷⁶

AKR's poetry and prose indeed abound with references to insects, worms, reptiles, birds, dogs, cats, cows, and horses. Certain animals work as cultural and personal metaphors of transience and continuity and stand for the notion of rebirth and metamorphosis. Some of the creatures that play a central role in his perception of art and life include caterpillars, monarch butterflies, inchworms, scorpions, frogs, snakes, and other kinds of reptiles. These animals are symbols of life cycles in ancient mythologies, and archetypes of transformation and permanence that possess a powerful psychological and aesthetic appeal. As AKR notes, animals symbolizing the process of rebirth are among his favourite images, but they also embody his strongest fears. **(p.150)** For example, the metamorphosis enacted by the caterpillar, which eats plants (primordial substance) and in turn is eaten and transformed into a new form, is an oft-repeated motif in his prose and poetry.⁷⁷ In some cases, the simultaneous fascination and fear of certain objects and animals in 'real' life is aesthetically stimulating for the poet and engenders a work of art that will eventually haunt its creator. Often the outcome is a state of tension among artistic inspiration, dream experience, physical pain, and existential anxiety. That is, the aesthetic experience may cause the 'body's discomfort',⁷⁸ and offer a vision of life not unlike the one expressed in the mescaline episode.

Thus, three aspects stand out in AKR's description of aesthetic experience and the perception of art: first, the relevance of the body and its senses in the apprehension of nature, reality, and identity; second, the process of transformation (the body in relation to time and memory); and third, the question of inspiration that 'comes naturally' in the artistic process of creation and in turn affects and leads us back to the body.

The 'Mescaline Notes', written in a transformed physical state, blend physical-sensorial observations, psychological and aesthetic experience with religious-philosophical abstraction. In this respect, they show how the 'inner' experience comes close to the medieval mystic Kannada vachana poems that speak of maya, the world's illusion that is projected on the mind by the bodily senses, in aesthetic and physical terms and as a religious and philosophical concept. AKR translated the Kannada mystics with much fervour from the 1950s to the late 1960s, revised the poems in the early 1970s, and published them in *Speaking of*

Siva in 1973. The ‘Mescaline Notes’, written in August 1971, make explicit reference to popular Hindu notions of rebirth as well as to the mystic Virasaiva aesthetics of Mahadeviyakka. For, ultimately, the sensorial and aesthetic discovery leads to a spiritual quest. At the peak of the physical and visual-aesthetic experience commences a journey into ‘the self’. This state of ‘altered’ perception reveals to AKR unknown aspects of his complex identity and reminds him of ‘ideas’, images, and symbols that relate to Indian and Western traditions.

We have observed how the tension between body and soul experienced *and* described in the ‘Mescaline Notes’ is a key topic that is treated in physical, aesthetic, and metaphysical contexts. It can be abstracted and applied to several planes of life and art. One of the dilemmas of AKR is the solidity of ‘structure’ (wakefulness, reality) battling with dissolution in ecstasy and the potential loss of identity (**p.151**) through infinite ‘variation’ (dream, illusion). Likewise, in the aesthetic experience one can either celebrate and suffer the whims of inborn emotions, or live by ‘drowning’ in the anonymity of *rasa*, impersonal aesthetic bliss. Besides allusions to Hindu notions, there are also the references to Heraclitus, Swinburne, and Huxley, as well as to terminology borrowed from linguistics.⁷⁹

From AKR’s experiential aesthetics expressed in the ‘Mescaline Notes’ and other writings, we can thus infer a dialogue (and struggle) between two sets of consciousness experienced through the body. The first sphere or type of consciousness is closer to what we may call ordinary ‘life’ whereas the second one belongs to the realm of ‘art’:⁸⁰

Body

Life	Art
reality	unreal image, illusion, maya
bones	flesh
identity	chain of lives, rebirth
structure	variation
solidity	fluidity
fixity	dissolution, process, change, passage
wakefulness	dream, imagination
Heraclitus	Swinburne
prose	poetry
personal emotion, bhava	depersonalized emotion, <i>rasa</i>

Within this binary set of paradigms, the passages quoted so far from the diaries suggest that the axis of AKR's aesthetic experience is the body. To test its limits, AKR was tempted to probe into unknown physical sensations, and the experiment with hallucinogenics is anchored in his intellectual search and personal conviction of arriving at abstract ideas only through particular experiences and the bodily senses. We have also seen how primordial sensations and images, often connected with the animal and plant world, are drawn from his immediate familiar natural and cultural environments (both from India or America), and how they can be motivated by unexpected interrelations.⁸¹ The primacy of the body and particulars over ideas is also put forward by AKR in a little known review article on George Orwell's *1984* written in the late 1950s:

(p.152) 'Smell of the Past'

The senses and the body have a deeper memory built into them, which cannot be planned or abolished. The Party wishes to abolish the past and nothing is more deeply rooted in the past than the body. With all their drugs and shocks, they can't abolish the distinction between pain and pleasure—the Soma is older, millions of years older, than the Psyche. And then, sensations, the dull pain in the bowels or the itch of the varicose ulcer have an inviolable privacy which no thought has, and the Party can bear no privacy.⁸²

This article substantiates AKR's belief in the dominance of the body over the world of ideas. It also refers indirectly to the concept of *vasana*, an important term in Sanskrit philosophy that signifies desire-related memory. Vasana is also translated by AKR as 'the smell of the past' a few years later in his 1964 paper on 'Sanskrit Poetics', where it is aptly defined as 'one's residual memories of past lives'.⁸³ The body therefore becomes both a catalyst and one of the main themes of the aesthetic experience. An old belief of his was to understand the body and the senses as the ultimate truth of his 'passing' self and identity:

Oct 26, 1976

A Journal. Passages.

...

Montaigne said, I'm passage, not essence.

Passage 1. On Body Images.

The Webster Collegiate Dictionary entry on 'Passages'—'transition', 'course, progress,' 'part of a composition,' 'pathway' ... and (I'm amused to read) in Med., the evacuation of bowels (J.M. Murry and N.O. Brown, 'the excremental vision'), which, according to Freud, anyway, is the source of

pattern for all 'higher' kinds of production or its opposite, being stuck, being unwilling to give or produce.⁸⁴

Dec 15, 1978

Doing bioenergetics since last week. An abstract belief of mine, an old one, that my body is me and I'm my body, even my soul is my body, is literally believed in by these therapists. Physical exercises. Like yoga, testing one's shallow breathing, one's not standing firm on one's feet, not being flexible in one's back. The body carries our history.⁸⁵

This physical, psychological, and metaphysical notion of the body also fits into some of the religious-philosophical ideas that AKR was **(p.153)** attracted to. He derived a myriad of elements from the Indian marga and desi traditions related to the body, rebirth, and continuity, which were partially shared also by prominent Western thinkers, writers, and counter-culture movements. Among such 'influences' in his experiential aesthetics, we can identify again several converging traditions that are further analysed in the next chapters:

1. Desi elements:

The body is related to the notion of grace in its spiritual meaning (anubhāva, the Experience, in Virasaiva bhakti), yet a more commonplace idea of 'grace' is also behind AKR's modern proclivity to drift into new experiences and take things 'as they come' (see the sections 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 5, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7).

The body is often placed in the context of the cycle of life and death and the rebirth of the soul, which was a favourite motif in medieval (Virasaiva and Vaisnava) bhakti poetry: for instance, Mahadeviyakka's personal notion of time in relation to the body and the soul living through an endless succession of past and future lives (see the sections 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5 and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7).

The nature-culture continuum in classical Tamil Sangam aesthetics as an underlying theme in AKR's experience of art, where there is no distinction between natural and aesthetic emotion as 'nature becomes the repertory of images for the entire human civilisation'⁸⁶ (see the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5 and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7).

2. Marga elements:

The philosophical and aesthetic undertones of AKR's experiential aesthetics can also be traced to the Upanishadic ideas (see the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5) on body (changeable form) and soul (permanence symbolized by gold). In the *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad* there is, for instance, the caterpillar image

that AKR makes use of in his poetry, and also the passage on the goldsmith that he often quotes: 'As a goldsmith takes the material of an image and hammers out of it another newer and more beautiful form, so also the soul, after casting off the body, creates for itself another and more beautiful form.'⁸⁷

(p.154) 3. Western elements:

Many of the Western writers AKR was drawn to, such as Aldous Huxley, T.S. Eliot, W.B. Yeats, Walt Whitman, and several Romantic poets, had absorbed a good measure of Indian philosophy in their work. He could, therefore, relate to their aesthetics in multiple ways as an Indian poet (see the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7, and 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8). For instance, the Upanishadic passage on the soul casting for itself a new form or body is also 'at the back of' Yeats's famous 'Sailing to Byzantium', as AKR comments in his lecture notes on 'Indian Notions of Change'. In these notes, AKR places Yeats's poem next to the *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad*, which is cited as an important source for the Irish poet's notion of art, change, and eternity:

Once out of nature I shall never take
My bodily form from any natural thing,
But such a form as Grecian goldsmiths make
Of hammered gold and gold enamelling
To keep a drowsy Emperor awake;
Or set upon a golden bough to sing
To lords and ladies of Byzantium
Of what is past, or passing, or to come.⁸⁸

We should not forget here that apart from the use of hallucinogenic substances, the notion of reincarnation, or the transmigration of the soul, was also very popular among counter-culture writers and artists of the 1950s and in the late 1960 to early 1970s, as the orientalist revival became part of the spiritual quest of the hippie generation. It is not surprising, for instance, that the success of *Speaking of Siva* as a cult book can be partially traced to the hippie context of the 1970s.

In AKR's aesthetics, the Hindu philosophical idea of continuity through the transformation of matter, be it the artistic medium (art in its many forms) or the body, cannot be understood as an abstraction. The eternity of art must be experienced in a moment of insight through the most primordial of the human being: the senses of the body. These issues lead us finally to the question of the origin of inspiration: where does art come from? Can art be pursued? Inquiry into the source and **(p.155)** mechanism of creativity or artistic inspiration within the process of aesthetic experience and expression is a prominent theme in AKR's writings.⁸⁹ Some illuminating commentaries stressing the relation of

personal experience to art and creativity in general appear in an interview conducted by Rama Jha in 1980:

I think creativity does not come out of cosmopolitanism. Creativity comes out of sustained attention to one's own experience, one's own locality, one's own landscape, you know? And the circumstances which one can understand and feel and experience deeply without any schemes, without learning this, that or the other. This can happen only about things you know best in your own language....

What I was saying was the particularity of the experience. Even when you are cosmopolitan, you ultimately have to know something quite deeply. Maybe as a cosmopolitan you know the inside of a train constantly moving. You like to write about that....

I attend to my experience rather than want to be contemporary. To be contemporary is not the aim. It may be the result.... It happens at the place of contact between me and whatever is outside ... to the skin where all contacts take place.⁹⁰

In this and other interviews AKR bears out the 'immediacy' to things and incidents as the trigger of his creativity, an aspect which also comes to the fore in the aesthetic experiences already described in the journals and diaries. Yet he stresses that, as a creative writer, one should not merely report experiences or go after particular experiences, for lived experience cannot be willed 'deliberately' into art. Art must link the private and the public spheres with unpremeditated attention:

For a long time I found it difficult to regard myself as a writer. I still do. The writers I knew early in life always put me off by their greedy hankering after experiences they could write about. There was a curious calculation, a lack of innocence, in both their living and their writing. They looked at life with notebooks and pens. And what they wrote was ploughed back into their lives. Of course, life and art do, and must, connect at some point, but not in such a transparent fashion. Literature does not merely report the lived experience; on the contrary, it picks up those details of experience which are not really private.... I don't think I deliberately pick and choose odds and bits of experience in my poetry.⁹¹

Ultimately AKR understands art, aesthetic experience, and life itself as some form of grace that cannot be consciously pursued.⁹² **(p.156)** This is the principal idea reiterated by the author in his rare musings on the origin of art or 'the aesthetic' in the diaries and poems. When AKR learnt, in July 1983, the news of his being awarded the prestigious MacArthur Prize Fellowship, which cannot be applied for, he made the following reflections on creativity:

July 21, 1983.

I'm feeling a bit limbo, even barren. For the past month, I've been reading poetry—Frost, Stevens, Heaney—every day hoping a poem would begin within me. Nothing so far. I'll simply read, without expectations of writing, which has become hard....

I also said, I'm glad one can't apply for this scholarship. It made me think one can't truly pursue anything worthwhile—pursue even goodness, you become a prize, beauty you become an aesthete (or pleasure, and you love it). You do whatever you do passionately, and these could occur as side-effects. I'm afraid one has to be tactful even with oneself—not say, 'produce now!' and tie oneself up in knots.⁹³

July 22, 1983.

Nothing worthwhile, not only pleasure, can be truly pursued—I think. But am I right? I include in this non-pursuable set, all values: pleasure, goodness, beauty, even truth? Then how do we attain them, what about all the self-disciplines and how-tos, training in Yoga, drawing, or Tai-chi and exercises in archery? One can acquire skills, exercise them passionately, but the ends can't be too visible—or else they elude you, and turn into something else: pleasure into a chore, a habit, even a pain; goodness into prudery, do-gooder moralism; beauty into mere form; truth into facts; poetry into technique etc. Maybe one has to pursue them without knowing too well one is doing so. One has to be tactful, forgetful, decentered somehow even with oneself, without nagging, without demanding.⁹⁴

What follows from these thoughts is that neither mere effort, nor skill or technique are guarantees for artistic inspiration, as true art lies somewhere between the pursuing self and patient observer. A particular aesthetic experience may arise abruptly out of 'sustained attention' to the ordinary and immediate environment.⁹⁵ As an example of such sudden aesthetic insight AKR provides a commonplace visual experience: 'When I see that scene outside the window, it is what I have seen a hundred times, but one of these days I may suddenly see it as if I had never seen it before. It acquires a quality of experience, and, at that moment, it also becomes aesthetic.'⁹⁶

Notes:

(1.) Quoted in Parthasarathy, *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets*, p. 96.

(2.) A good example of this recurrent theme in AKR's poetry is the poem 'Looking for the Centre', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, pp. 184–5, quoted in the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3. See also later in this

chapter on the pulls and tension in AKR's composite self and the search for an identity.

(3.) When he passed away at the age of 64 in 1993, AKR was at the high point of his career and numerous projects, translation works, poems, and essays remained unfinished.

(4.) John Dewey, *Art as Experience* (New York: Putnam, 1934).

(5.) Beardsley, *Aesthetics: Problems in the Philosophy of Criticism*, p. 17.

(6.) See, for instance, G. Dickie, 'The Myth of the Aesthetic Attitude', in J. Hospers (ed.), *Introductory Readings in Aesthetics* (London: Macmillan, 1969), pp. 28-44.

(7.) Jerome Stolnitz ('The Aesthetic Attitude', in *Aesthetics and the Philosophy of Art Criticism* [Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1960], pp. 32, 35-6) elaborates on each of the concepts in his definition of the aesthetic attitude:

An attitude is a way of directing and controlling our perception.... For the aesthetic attitude, things are not to be classified or studied or judged. They are in themselves pleasant or exciting to look at.... It should, then, be clear that being 'disinterested' is very far from being 'un-interested'.... The word 'sympathetic' in the definition of 'aesthetic attitude' refers to the way in which we prepare ourselves to respond to the object.

(8.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar.

(9.) In *Matthobhana Atmacharitre*, a historian named K.K. Ramanujan meets the poet A.K. Ramanujan. The novella changes the chronology of real incidents in AKR's life and the age of the main character. See also the journal entry dated 26 July 1978 cited in Appendix 1 of this book and Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan'.

(10.) Ramanujan, 'A Poem Is Born', pp. 1, 7; underline in the original. On the two types of poetry AKR calls somewhat disdainfully 'the grey phases about lotus-eyes or the communist freaks', see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(11.) Ramanujan, 'Notes towards a Journal'. Only sections from the beginning and end of the two-page long piece are quoted here. The word 'knots' in the last paragraph is crossed out in the original. Only the first page of this journal is in typescript.

(12.) Stolnitz, 'The Aesthetic Attitude', pp. 35-6.

(13.) I have earlier pointed out AKR's Oedipal fixation with his mother, which often overlaps with the love-and-hate relationships he had with his wife and

lovers. In some of his prose writings and poems the attitude to female relatives, that is, sisters and cousins, also has incestuous overtones.

(14.) Ramanujan, *Someone Else's Autobiography*, p. 229.

(15.) Ezra Pound's impact on AKR's poetics and translation theory will be further discussed in the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poets and Poetics' in Chapter 7. I suggest to read in this context the sections in Pound's 'Vorticism' that describe the visual sense-impression during his Paris metro experience. The poem 'In a Station of the Metro' was published in Ezra Pound, 'Contemporanea', *Poetry: A Magazine of Verse*, vol. 2, no. 1 (April 1913), p. 6, and *Lustra* (London: Elkin Mathews, 1916), n.p. Pound's article 'Vorticism' was published in *The Fortnightly Review*, no. 571 (1 September 1914), pp. 465–7 and republished in Ezra Pound, *Gaudier-Brzeska: A Memoir* (New York: New Directions, 1960 [1916]), pp. 86–9.

(16.) In a 1965 letter, AKR asks Jon Stallworthy at the Oxford University Press, London, to acknowledge in *The Striders* that the source for 'An Image for Politics' was Golding's *Pincher Martin: The Two Deaths of Christopher Martin* (p. 136 of the American edition): 'I knew of similar folk exaggerations regarding fancy dishes in Indian folklore, but the central image of the cannibal maggots I am convinced was clearly from Pincher Martín ... though my use of it seems rather different from Golding's'. See Ramanujan, letter to Stallworthy, AKR Papers (10 November 1965), n.p.

(17.) This is the published version of the poem of which several drafts appear in the AKR Papers. Ramanujan, 'An Image for Politics', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 46. As is the case with a number of his early compositions, this poem plays with the visual image on the page, in this case imitating the shape of a half-eaten fish. See also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 on AKR's experimentation with 'the poem on the page'.

(18.) If we were to apply Sanskrit aesthetics here, the underlying aesthetic emotion of the poem 'On Politics' would be *bibhatsa* (repugnancy), one of the nine *rasas* that are originated by *bhavas* or emotional-psychological states. See the section 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2.

(19.) The two haiku-like poems quoted here are unpublished drafts from 1961 found in the AKR Papers.

(20.) Ramanujan, 'Time to Stop', *Relations*, in *CP*, p. 82.

(21.) AKR quotes Oscar Wilde's famous observation on life and art in 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, p. 512. See also the section 'Folk Aesthetics' in Chapter 5.

(22.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar, quoted earlier in this chapter.

(23.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (8 November 1960), n.p.

(24.) See Stolnitz, 'The Aesthetic Attitude', quoted earlier in this chapter.

(25.) Huxley's mescaline account begins thus:

[O]ne bright May morning, I swallowed four-tenths of a gramme of mescaline dissolved in half a glass of water and sat down to wait for the results.... I was looking at my furniture, not as the utilitarian ... the camera-man or scientific recorder, but as the pure aesthete whose concern is only with forms and their relationship within the field of vision or the picture space. But as I looked, this purely aesthetic Cubist's-eye view gave place to what I can only describe as the sacramental vision of reality.

See Aldous Huxley, *The Doors of Perception* (London: Chatto and Windus, 1954), pp. 3, 10–11.

(26.) See Timothy Leary, *High Priest* (New York: World Publishing Company, 1968; and New York: College Notes and Texts, 1968); rpt New York: Ronin Publishing, 1995.

(27.) None of this is mentioned, though, in the letters AKR and Ezekiel exchanged during 1967 and the following years, except for a couple of references to Josephine Miles. Ezekiel's LSD experiences and commentaries on how LSD affected his personality are recorded in an unpublished essay reproduced by R. Raj Rao in *Nissim Ezekiel: The Authorised Biography* (New Delhi: Viking, Penguin Books), pp. 178–84. On the effects of LSD in Ezekiel's poetry from 1967 to 1972, see also Bruce King's comments: 'The concern with the real, the physical, the practical, for example, contrasts with a new developing interest in the spiritual which followed experimentation with LSD' (King, *Modern Indian Poetry in English*, p. 102).

(28.) U.R. Ananthamurthy has stated that Ginsberg admired AKR's economy of speech. See Ananthamurthy, 'The Gentle Genius', *Indian Express* (25 July 1993), n.p. and *Littcrit*, vol. 38 (June 1994), p. 6. Ananthamurthy's recalling of Ginsberg's comments on AKR at a conference in Hawaii in the late 1970s also came up in the personal interview I conducted in Bangalore on 19 January 2002.

(29.) *Selected Poems* published by Oxford University Press in 1976 did not include new poems, but a selection from his two previous collections *The Striders* and *Relations*.

(30.) The mescaline experience has never been mentioned in published or unpublished sources, nor is it referred to in other sources or elsewhere in the AKR Papers. However, there is an interesting reference to the effects of LSD in AKR's *Matthobhana Atmacharitre*, which is quoted later in this chapter.

(31.) The Greek philosopher Heraclitus wrote on the interplay of wakefulness and sleep: 'The kosmos of the waking is one and shared, but the sleeping turn aside each into their own kosmos.' See Nythamar de Oliveira, 'The Worldhood of the Kosmos in Heidegger's Reading of Heraclitus', *Manuscrito*, vol. XIX, no. 1 (1996), pp. 201–24. Huxley, on the other hand, comments in a 1960 interview on LSD and creativity:

Some people probably could get direct aesthetic inspiration for painting or poetry out of it. Others I don't think could. For most people it's an extremely significant experience, and I suppose in an indirect way it could help the creative process. But I don't think one can sit down and say, 'I want to write a magnificent poem, and so I'm going to take lysergic acid [diethylamide].' I don't think it's by any means certain that you would get the result you wanted—you might get almost any result.... [T]he poet would certainly get an extraordinary view of life which he wouldn't have had in any other way, and this might help him a great deal. But you see (and this is the most significant thing about the experience), during the experience you're really not interested in doing anything practical—even writing lyric poetry. If you were having a love affair with a woman, would you be interested in writing about it? Of course not. And during the experience you're not particularly in words, because the experience transcends words and is quite inexpressible in terms of words. So the whole notion of conceptualizing what is happening seems very silly.

Aldous Huxley quoted in an interview in *The Paris Review*, vol. 23 (Spring 1960), p. 66; rpt in Michael Horowitz and Cynthia Palmer (eds), *Moksha: Aldous Huxley's Classic Writings on Psychedelics and the Visionary Experience* (Rochester: Park Street Press, 1999), n.p.

(32.) Huxley remarked of the effects of mescaline that 'visual impressions are greatly intensified and the eye recovers some of the perceptual innocence of childhood.... Mescaline raises all colours to a higher power and makes the percipient aware of innumerable fine shades of difference, to which, at ordinary times, he is completely blind'. See Huxley, *The Doors of Perception*, pp. 13, 15.

(33.) Ramanujan, 'Mescaline Notes', n.p. The first entry in the notes begins as quoted, dated Saturday, 28 August 1971, 6 pm. All subsequent diary quotes in the remaining part of this section on 'Aesthetic Journeys' belong to AKR's 'Mescaline Notes'. The manuscript contains 24 pages of prose.

(34.) Ramanujan, *Someone Else's Autobiography*, p. 222. See also the next paragraph of this novella quoted later in this chapter.

(35.) These points have further theoretical implications converging with AKR's 'outer' aesthetics that will be dealt with from a different perspective in Chapter 5.

(36.) This is a reference to AKR's poem 'A Leaky Tap after a Sister's Wedding' in *The Striders*.

(37.) In the original, the quote repeated in brackets 'Through future worlds, birth after birth, have I come', is written in the Kannada script. I am indebted to Girish Karnad for the English translation of this Kannada phrase and of vachana 19.

(38.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 117.

(39.) Heinrich Zimmer in J. Campbell (ed.), *Myths and Symbols in Indian Art and Civilisation* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1972), p. 24.

(40.) Ramanujan, 'Notes to the Poems', *SoS*, p. 194.

(41.) See *Katha Upanishad*, 1.3.

(42.) Ramanujan, 'Second Sight', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 191. An early undated draft of this poem in the AKR Papers starts with the lines 'when I was/ benighted, unhappy'.

(43.) See the comments on Eagleton and Western music from the 'Mescaline Notes' quoted in the section 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3.

(44.) See Appendix 2 in this book on the making of the poetry collection *Second Sight* and the cycle of 'Soma Poems'. On the multiple implications of the concept of 'Soma', see the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5 and 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 in relation to the notion of inspiration in AKR's 'inner poetics', and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7 in the context of possession in bhakti poetry.

(45.) Ramanujan, *Someone Else's Autobiography*, p. 222. Aldous Huxley's observations, quoted in *The Paris Review*, no. 23 (Spring 1960), p. 66 on his experiments with LSD are noted here:

After the event, it seems to me quite possible that it might be of great assistance: people would see the universe around them in a very different way and would be inspired, possibly, to write about it.... [T]here's always a complete memory of the experience. You remember something extraordinary having happened. And to some extent you can relive the experience, particularly the transformation of the outside world. You get hints of this, you see the world in this transfigured way now and then.... It does help you to look at the world in a new way. And you come to understand very clearly the way that certain specially gifted people have seen the world. You are actually introduced into the kind of world that Van Gogh lived in, or the kind of world that Blake lived in. You begin to have a

direct experience of this kind of world while you're under the drug, and afterwards you can remember and to some slight extent recapture this kind of world, which certain privileged people have moved in and out of, as Blake obviously did all the time.

(46.) See *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad*, IV.4.3-4.

(47.) Ramanujan, 'Extended Family', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, pp. 169-70.

(48.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (13 April 1982), n.p.

(49.) See Appendix 2 in this book on the making of *Second Sight*.

(50.) Ramanujan, 'Carpe Diem', *Thought* (December 1957), n.p.

(51.) In Greek, pleasure is *hedone*, thus from Epicurus originated the hedonistic theory.

(52.) On the relevance of the inverted tree image in AKR's idea of creation, see ahead in this chapter and the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6. See also Ramanujan, 'The Indian Oedipus', in *CE*, p. 380 and 'A Poem on Particulars', quoted in the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3.

(53.) Ramanujan, curriculum vitae, AKR Papers (1958), n.p.

(54.) Ramanujan quoted in Ayesha Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', *Economic Times*, Bangalore (8 August 1993), p. 12.

(55.) This is an extract from the fourth stanza of an unpublished poem translated by the author from his own Kannada version of the poem. Ramanujan, 'Here and Now', unpublished draft of a poem, AKR Papers (November 1989), n.p.

(56.) Ramanujan, 'Eyes, Ears, Nose, and a Thing about Touch', *Relations*, in *CP*, p. 77.

(57.) See ahead in this chapter and in Appendix 2 on the long poem 'Composition'. See also the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapters 6, 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7, and 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8.

(58.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (4 August 1982), n.p. The *Natya Sastra* defines the eight principal human emotions (bhavas) or psychological states that may evoke rasa or aesthetic emotion.

(59.) Ramanujan, 'Snakes and Ladders', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 138. An early draft of this poem, published in 1986, is titled 'Red, White and Black', AKR Papers.

(60.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (29 December 1979), n.p. AKR refers to the ladder metaphor in Plato's *Symposium* in several sources. See also the section 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5.

(61.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (4 October 1986), n.p. Veda is AKR's younger sister.

(62.) Ramanujan, 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', in *CE*, p. 72. On AKR's understanding of Sanskrit and Tamil aesthetics, see also the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' and 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5.

(63.) Stolnitz, 'The Aesthetic Attitude', p. 24. On Stolnitz's definition of aesthetic attitude, see the section 'Aesthetic Experience and Aesthetic Object: Concepts' in this chapter.

(64.) Ramanujan, 'Madura: Two Movements', *Quest*, vol. 3 (August 1957), n.p. The same treatment of the theme appears in published and unpublished versions of the poem, both in English and Kannada. The poem was first drafted in the mid-1950s and then published in 1957 in English.

(65.) Ramanujan, 'In Madurai I Saw a Quite-Human Hand', unpublished draft of a poem, AKR Papers (mid-1950s), n.p.

(66.) W.B. Yeats, 'Among School Children', in *The Tower* (London: Macmillan, 1928).

(67.) Ramanujan, 'Art and Aesthetics', trans. Bhargavi Rao, *Kavya Bharati*, vol. 9 (1997), pp. 57-8. For other translations of this Kannada poem, see 'Art and Life's Beauty', in Chennaveera Kanavi and K. Raghavendra Rao (eds), K. Raghavendra Rao (trans.), *Modern Kannada Poetry* (Dharwad: Karnatak University, 1976), p. 92, and 'In Madhurai', in Raju and Daniels-Ramanujan (trans), *A.K. Ramanujan*, p. 25.

(68.) Ramanujan, 'Elements of Composition', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 122. See also the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5 and 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and Appendix 2.

(69.) On the notion of grace in bhakti and AKR's poetics, see the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7. See also AKR's ironical poem on grace 'Still Another View of Grace', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 45 commented on in the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.

(70.) Ramanujan, 'Figures of Disfigurement', in *UPP*, p. 9. The image of the disfigured or handicapped person being aesthetic or artistic appears in several other poems.

(71.) Ramanujan, 'Snakes' and 'Breaded Fish', *The Striders*, in *CP*, pp. 4, 7 and 'The Black Hen', *The Black Hen*, in *CP*, p. 195. The latter poem on art and poetry is further discussed in the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.

(72.) On possible inner conflicts between culture and nature, see the poems 'Conventions of Despair' (from *The Striders*) and 'The Hindoo: He Reads His Gita and Is Calm at All Events' (from *Relations*), in which orthodox religious belief is at odds with primordial instincts. Ramanujan in *CP*, pp. 34, 79.

(73.) In Hindu, Buddhist, and Jain religious cultures, animals and trees are respected and honoured, and in some traditions they are venerated as living beings that are part of the chain of rebirth or the transmigration of the 'soul'. In Indian folklore (tales, fables, proverbs, etc.) and local traditions of animistic origin (snake worship, etc.), which precede Hinduism and still survive in some parts of India, animals and trees also play a central role. These cultural motifs are discussed in detail in AKR's essays on folklore and folktales. He also refers in his diaries to rituals related to snakes and trees as experienced during his childhood.

(74.) Ramanujan, 'The Indian Oedipus', in *CE*, p. 380. The tree image appears in some of AKR's earliest poems in English from the AKR Papers. A poem drafted in 1947, for instance, is titled 'Trees of the World'. For the cosmic tree or upside-down tree, see also 'A Poem on Particulars' and other early poems quoted in the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3. See also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.

(75.) See Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, pp. 38, 44.

(76.) Ramanujan, notes from a creative writing workshop, AKR Papers (early 1980s), n.p.

(77.) On the caterpillar in Indian philosophy, see *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad*, IV. 4.3-4 quoted earlier in this chapter. See also the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5.

(78.) An expression used in the 'Mescaline Notes'.

(79.) AKR records in the 'Mescaline Notes' his search for 'the structure, fearful of loss in the literal inferiorities of variation', which reminds us of his essay 'The Structure of Variation: A Study in Caste Dialects', in Milton Singer and Bernard S. Cohn (eds), *Structure and Change in Indian Society* (Chicago: Aldine Press, 1968), pp. 461-74.

(80.) This interpretation is not to overstate the relevance of the mescaline experience, which may have been an isolated experiment in AKR's life. More than an autobiographical anecdote, however, we may consider it an

extraordinary sample of AKR's vision of life and art that should be read in connection with other writings in prose and poetry.

(81.) See, for instance, the poems 'Snakes' and 'Breaded Fish', quoted earlier in this chapter, and 'Waterfalls in a Bank', in *CP*, p. 189. See also 'Coriander Leaves in an American Market', trans. from the Kannada by H.S. Shivaprakash, *Indian Literature*, vol. 186 (July–August 1998), pp. 6, 7; and 'Similitudes', in Raju and Daniels-Ramanujan (trans), *A.K. Ramanujan*, p. 25.

(82.) Ramanujan, 'Inverted Utopias: No Thrush on the Bough', *Akashvani* (16 March 1958). On memory and the senses, see also AKR's essay 'The Ring of Memory', in *UPP*, pp. 83–100. On the concept of Soma, see the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(83.) Ramanujan, 'Sanskrit Aesthetics', handwritten lecture paper, AKR Papers (1964), n.p.; also titled 'Sanskrit Poetics'.

(84.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (26 December 1976), n.p.

(85.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (15 December 1978), n.p.

(86.) Ramanujan, 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', in *CE*, p. 72. Quoted earlier in this chapter.

(87.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Literatures', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p. From *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad*, IV.4.1–6.

(88.) W.B. Yeats, 'Sailing to Byzantium', in *October Blast* (Dublin: Cuala Press, 1927), n.p.; quoted in Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Notions of Change', n.p.

(89.) These issues will be analysed in detail in Chapter 6 in connection with AKR's 'inner' poetics.

(90.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13. See, in this context, the poem 'Eyes, Ears, Nose and a Thing about Touch', *Relations*, in *CP*, p. 77.

(91.) Ramanujan quoted in Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan', p. 181.

(92.) AKR plays with the notion of grace and its various interpretations in a number of poems. See, for instance, 'Still another View of Grace', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 45.

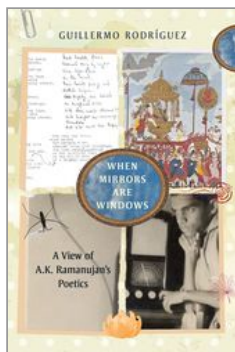
(93.) The metaphor of tying himself up in knots appears in several poems. See, for example, 'Anxiety', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 29.

(94.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (21-2 July 1983), n.p.

(95.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.

(96.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, p. 33. An interview held on the occasion of AKR being awarded the MacArthur grant.

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Reflecting on Art

A.K. Ramanujan's 'Outer' Aesthetics

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Abstract and Keywords

In this chapter Ramanujan's aesthetics is tackled from the 'outer' or scholarly perspective of his academic disciplines and the various aesthetic and philosophical traditions he was steeped in. Both as an artist and as a scholar, he was concerned with how the theory and practice of art could be approached within a variety of cultural systems and contexts each yielding idiosyncratic world views. His close attention to detail and to the larger patterns in a system often led him to venture into intercultural comparisons and establish unexpected parallelisms and interconnections between several aesthetic conventions. This chapter is therefore concerned with a systematic analysis of the major theoretical strands that went into Ramanujan's aesthetic fabric. The different traditions that converge in his aesthetics are treated separately, including Western ideas on art and beauty, Sanskrit and Tamil aesthetics, and oral and bhakti traditions.

Keywords: aesthetics, philosophy of art, Indian philosophy, Sanskrit aesthetics, rasa theory, Dravidian studies, Tamil aesthetics, medieval bhakti poetry and aesthetics, folk studies

*Make of my body the beam of a lute
of my head the sounding gourd
of my nerves the strings
of my fingers the plucking rods.*

—Basavanna, Kannada mystic poet, twelfth century AD*

AKR was steeped in a wide range of aesthetic and philosophical traditions. Both as an artist and a scholar, he was concerned with how the theory and practice of art could be approached within a variety of cultural systems and contexts, each yielding idiosyncratic world views. His close attention to detail and to the larger patterns in a system often led him to venture into intercultural comparisons and establish unexpected parallelisms and interconnections between several aesthetic conventions. This chapter provides a systematic analysis of the major theoretical strands that went into the aesthetic fabric of AKR and which he applied to art and poetry through various academic disciplines (linguistics, cultural anthropology, literature, Dravidian studies, theory and practice of translation, and others). The following classification of AKR's 'outer' aesthetics is, therefore, an overview of the principal aesthetic traditions (identified earlier as marga/supra-regional, desi/regional, and videshi/Western) that AKR studied and described in his essays, lecture notes, and interviews, and which meet in his aesthetics. For the sake of clarity, the different aesthetic traditions are treated here separately.

(p.166) General Ideas on Art and Beauty

AKR's scholarly discussions on art and beauty are not abundant as he, by and large, objected to broaching such issues in an abstract manner. Theoretical deliberations on art, beauty, etc., are usually expressed in references to Western theoreticians, mainly classical Greek and modern philosophers and aestheticians such as Plato, Aristotle, Pater, and Adorno, which are often cited by AKR in comparison with Indian traditions. Some of AKR's recurring concerns about these topics are summarized here and endorsed by quotes from the primary sources, that is, essays, diaries, poems, and interviews.

Particulars and Universals: Experience and Abstraction

One of AKR's oldest convictions was that particulars, or the small commonplace things in life that any individual can sense or experience, matter more than abstract universals and ideals which remain as intangible values. In several diary entries of the 1970s, AKR writes retrospectively on his misgivings about large theoretical concepts and totalizing systems, such as the concept of beauty as an abstract idea:

Nov 10, 1976

'The whole is the untrue,' I read in Adorno. Expresses an old bias of mine for 'Small-scale reflections,' distrust of systems of thought or government, praise or longing for face-to-face community-government-economics—I'd even been attached to guild socialism in my 20s and still talk now and then of decentralization.¹

Dec 29, 1979

Remembering the day I heard from KB, who was then reading Plato ..., that the three basic values were Truth, Beauty and Goodness. It was a revelation, a clarity, a settling. A temporary end to groping. I didn't know then that I'd have to choose even between these three, and that I'd have to unlearn all my capital letters and singulars. Truth, Beauty and Goodness never came together; I've never really known them as singular and in capital letters, nor in their pure forms. Soon after that, I read and reread the Diotima passage in Plato's *Symposium*, where he talked about the small and beautiful things and persons of this world and how one goes up a ladder of abstractions from them to Beauty, singular, capital, out of this world. I could never find that ladder.²

Furthermore, in one of the last published interviews, AKR sides with Yeats when commenting on the aesthetic theory contained in **(p.167)** Plato's *Symposium*: 'Nothing that one does in the most abstract realm is unconnected with one's emotions and one forgets that.... There is no such thing as a simple general critique. That critique is also a critique of oneself, or a justification, or a defence. As Yeats would say: "the ladder of all those things start from the rag-and-bones shop of the heart".'³ Platonic ideals were not only beyond AKR's reach as an individual and artist but they also contrast with the Indian thought systems and aesthetics, as he states in his essay 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?'

I know of no Hindu discussion of values which reads like Plato on Beauty in his *Symposium*—which asks the initiate not to rest content with beauty in one embodiment but to be drawn onward from physical to moral beauty, to the beauty of laws and mores, and to all science and learning, and thus to escape 'the mean slavery of the particular case'.⁴

The defence of the 'particular case', or the face-to-face experience, against the impersonal or non-specific universal, is further taken to the plane of human existence: 'One lives only in particulars. Abstractions are escapist—honesty requires the particulars.'⁵ At the same time, AKR is aware of the inevitability of construing universals, as they are intrinsic to the process of perception. Hence, he recognizes the usefulness of abstract notions in life, though he is deeply convinced of the need to be sensitive to particulars:

Universals are a result of abstraction, they are not what you immediately sense....

You generally think that abstractions are of use only in certain aspects of your life and in as many things as possible we should live not as abstract, not according to some theory. Not that theories are ever absent; they're always present. And behind every fact there is a theory of a fact, because you have a notion of what a fact is.... [S]o behind everything we perceive there is also a judgement, some kind of abstraction. And universals are

really constituted by abstracting. In doing that I think we may be unjust, insensitive, unseeing of a particular human being's particular needs and even the particularities of sensation.⁶

AKR came to the conclusion that the modern obsession with universals also prevents the scholar from realizing the significance of nuances in a work of art or system: 'All meaning lies in particulars. I've always believed that in literature, but I didn't believe it in social (p.168) science. Now I do. The archetypes are only useful to point one to the particulars.'⁷ Close attention to the fine details of a sensation or object reveals the specific cultural and aesthetic qualities in a work of art. This skill is essentially also an academic discipline that allows the cultural critic to contrast particular objects and works against others operating in different contexts. The acceptance of universal patterns and the simultaneous concern for the minutiae in life was a useful theoretical tenet in AKR's comparative studies as well as in his theory and practice of translation (see also the section 'Translation and Poetic Studies' in Chapter 8). In an unpublished early comparative essay on T.S. Eliot's *Murder in the Cathedral* and the Aristotelian theory of tragedy, AKR theorizes on the mode of identifying both the uniqueness and universality of a work of art:

A legitimate way of exploring and defining the 'specificity' of a work of art is to try and fit it into a mould. To the extent it is a work of art its uniqueness will overflow and overwhelm the mould in certain definite ways. It is instructive to see the scope of the mould and the way it is broken by a particular work of art. Both the conformity and the non-conformity, what it shares with other works and what it does not share, together make the work what it is; the 'specificity' is not merely in its non-conformity, as it is sometimes assumed, but in its redistribution of conforming and non-conforming areas (also).⁸

Over the years AKR tested his own cultural specificity in a number of disciplines ranging from linguistics, literature and translation, cultural anthropology, and folklore to psychology and philosophy. The famous distinction of context-specific, or context-sensitive, versus context-free modes was formulated in his essay 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' (drafted in 1980). At the end of his exposition, AKR invites us to re-read, in the light of context-sensitivity, some of the writings of pragmatist philosophers like William James and Alfred Schuetz, whose key notions of 'sub-universes' (James) and 'finite provinces of meaning' (Schuetz), as 'central concepts in any understanding' were relevant contributions to 'context-sensitive' modern thought. Indeed, as a modern thinker, AKR owes much of his theoretical grounding to the American philosophical tradition of pragmatism. His ideas on reality, art, and experience may be read in regard to the tenets of pragmatist thinkers like Charles Sanders Peirce, William James, and John Dewey. While AKR often applied in his essays Peirce's theory of semiotics in his approach to 'universal' systems, he could not align with Kant's imperatives (the

‘universal (p.169) contexts’). Like James and Dewey, he preferred to sail between the ‘tough-minded’ empiricists (experience) and the ‘tender-minded’ rationalists (abstraction) and advocate a ‘pluralistic universe’ (James). This also entails an integral approach to culture, art, and everyday experience as Dewey, based on James’s ideas, propounds in *Art as Experience* (1934).⁹ AKR’s understanding of artistic creativity thus stresses that art engages the trained intellectual as well as the man of physical sensations and feelings: ‘Nobody knows how a poem actually gets written. A poem, like a work of art, is an experience which orchestrates all the different parts of our selves: from the five sensations to metaphysical thinking, one’s whole world is involved in a poem.’¹⁰

The Attitude of the Artist and the Purpose of Art

A persistent idea in AKR’s aesthetic refers to the attitude of the artist, and the capacity of integration and assimilation that art and artists should display: ‘Artists are often crazy and fall apart, but the arts they practice tend to integrate the various brain skills.... Poetry (and the arts) specialise in this property of imagination, integration, incorporation, expansion....’¹¹ This involves the ability of balancing the various ingredients or effects of art: the logical-formal or functional activity, emotional feelings, and the ‘transcendental’ experiencing or relishing of a momentary state of ‘release’ through art.

Artists should also be able to contemplate and ‘forget’ their selves and yet be part of the ordinary social world. As AKR suggests in one of his last prose drafts, the artist should be an attentive observer, not a judge of life. The ultimate aim of the artist is ‘to identify ... with the non-self, even an alien and painful non-self for the nonce’.¹² This view does not merely imply self-denial. In fact, self-denial in an artist can lead him/her away from reality and the world, which is the source of creation. More precisely, the artist has to show a disinterested aesthetic attitude,¹³ and at the same time keep his feet always on the ground. AKR cautions: ‘[A]n artist too needs self-denial, he is the ascetic worshipper of beauty, as Plato didn’t quite see. But such self-denial could cut him off from the sources of his own art.’¹⁴

According to AKR, art is part of the human condition, for ‘the capacity to mention one thing and mean another, the capacity to lie ... are primary properties of consciousness’. And so there is ‘no knowledge, not even ordinary perception, without imagination’. Art (p.170) is ‘an intensive exercise’, it is the capacity ‘to image and imagine’ which is present in all our activities, including science and ordinary life.¹⁵ In AKR’s aesthetic thought, the significance of art is not only circumscribed to the individual, for a work of art is a form of perceiving and expressing culture. He firmly believed that each work of art embodied a whole culture. Yet the first purpose of art was the work in itself and the experience of its formal aesthetic structure and complexities. AKR held to the view that art should rouse a particular emotion in the perceiver or reader.

Literature and art must, above all, evoke an intense 'aesthetic experience' by attending to its forms and nuances:

The whole of culture, every element in it, whether it is kinship or kingship, religious belief and custom, male-female relations, and so on, are background and material out of which the arts arise—always ringing changes on them in ways that will be entirely missed if the literariness of the literary texts, its specific density, is not grasped with both sides of the brain.... If I may exaggerate to make the point, it is read mostly not for pleasure or even pain, but only for immediate 'profit.' But pleasure and pain in the detail of art works are the royal roads to art experience.¹⁶

Thus, AKR was concerned with the production as well as reception of art. As a scholar of Indian literature, he was particularly interested in the affective-expressive aspects of the work of art, and in the prominent characteristic of Indian aesthetics that bases the purpose of art on the incitement of aesthetic emotion in the reader or perceiver. He sometimes used the following paradigm in his schematic notes to compare writers and traditions in terms of their focus of attention in the aesthetic experience: 'Aesthetics, like grammar—for production as well as reception, for author as well as reader—either a writing course or a reading course: Poe's, the writer's; TS Eliot's, the writer's. But Aristotle's and the Indian's the reader's. Romantic aesthetics' = writer's, the classical = the reader's—that art will cure the artist, that art will cure the reader.'¹⁷

In AKR's appreciation of art and understanding of aesthetic communication (encompassing the author, the work, and the receiver), the objective and affective aspects coexist in equal measure. As a linguist, translator, and anthropologist, he was trained to analyse a work of art as an object in a clinical manner and to dissect its parts from a scientific point of view. And as an artist sensitive to the minutiae in life, he felt inclined to highlight the ways of experiencing (**p.171**) and creating an artwork (by the writer), and to also stress its emotional implications (for the reader). The affective dimension is often described by AKR in terms of Sanskrit aesthetics. Preparing a talk on fellow Indian poet writing in English Gieve Patel, a surgeon by profession, who is also a painter and playwright, AKR wrote in his notes:

Kafka: 'we need books that will affect us like a misfortune.' Some of Gieve's work, detached as it is, affects me like that. I've taught myself to see poems, plays and painting as forms and objects. I often lose my objectivity, and feel wrenched in unaccustomed ways. I don't know what to do about that....

In Indian aesthetic terms of *rasa*, the spectrum [of Patel's plays] is not the romantic heroic side *sringara/vira*, but on the side of pity, terror, held down in careful well-formed structures.¹⁸

Form and Content in Art and Culture

The inseparable nature of form and content in art was an important argument in AKR's credo as an artist and critic. It exemplified the formalistic way of thinking about art and culture that was shaped in the early years of his career. In several instances, AKR cites Nietzsche's assertion that 'what is usually called "content" is really "form" to the artist' and 'what others see as form ... the artist sees as theme, motif, "content"'.¹⁹ This belief, which stayed with AKR through most of his scholarly work, stemmed from the early 1960s when he worked primarily in the field of linguistics and imbued the ideas of the Slavic formalists and Roman Jakobson's structuralism (see the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7).²⁰

In the later decades, AKR studied a range of verbal and non-verbal art forms in several Western and Indian traditions to enquire into how art conveys a particular culture or world view through its forms, and to study the ways in which a work of art can affect the individual and the social world. For AKR, art is a form of knowing and expressing. But in order to communicate something, it has to come in 'well-formed structures'. It is by assessing and comparing cultural and artistic forms aesthetically, not by abstracting their meaning, that one can attempt to 'understand' them:

The arts, expressive culture in general, give us a culture's sense of fact. Their concern is not with knowledge as fact, but with forms of knowing. Even realism in art is a form, a convention. 'To the Hindus', it has been rightly said, **(p.172)** 'even realism is one of 57 kinds of decoration.' In a conference of this kind we are as interested in 'facts' as we are in the 'forms' under which Indians view their 'facts.' And such 'forms' and perceptions stand out more clearly when contrasted with similar 'forms' of another culture.²¹

AKR concluded that conceptual frameworks and cultural systems cannot be drawn from the abstract, nor from direct analysis of the 'facts', but need to be pinned down to particular expressive material, for world views are embodied in specific perceptions and aesthetic forms, be they words, poems, tales, epics, or cycles of traditions. He argued with fellow scholars and colleagues that Indian culture and thought systems should be approached through the arts:

I'm convinced now that indigenous conceptual/perceptual systems cannot be directly specified without reducing them to commonplaces. I've learned it is a 'tacit dimension' (Polanyi), where only by indirections you find directions out. This is why we have to begin with the aesthetic (or

perceptual) before we move to ethos and worldview. One of my dissatisfactions, therefore, was that aesthetic materials (e.g. the Mahabharata) were rarely attended to, or treated as if they could be directly used as quarries for worldviews.²²

From the attention to aesthetic material, AKR takes up expressive culture and forms of knowledge in general. That is also where folklore and poetry come in as art that makes 'visible its forms'.²³ As an artist and scholar who was a keen observer of cultural performance, AKR sometimes composed meta-poetic exercises on art and aesthetic by juxtaposing images, situations, and cultural scenarios. In an unpublished late poem titled 'The Condition of Music', AKR ironically plays the cultural anthropologist and contrasts various types of knowledge in aesthetic and cultural traditions, thereby exposing different ways of not only understanding, but enacting the close relationship between form and content:

Tansen the Blind Singer could light lamps
he could not see with a Kindling Song,
bring down a monsoon on a hot roof
in a dry month within his Invocation
to a Cloud.

Mancha the illiterate snakeman
could read by smell any snake in attic
(p.173) or forest, attune his flute to ripple
the air, and compel the deaf to uncurl
and follow.

All the arts aspire to the condition
of music, said Pater, meaning as always
something else. He had forgotten his own
Orpheus and the beasts, and he hadn't heard
of Tansen.²⁴

In AKR's comparative aesthetics, the formalistic tradition and secular search for beauty as pure form, as found in European art and epitomized by Walter Pater and classical aestheticians in the metaphor of 'music', is counterbalanced by the ritualistic forms in India that reveal their 'content' by transforming the world around them. In his treatment of aesthetics, AKR was aware of the different models—secular and sacred religious—that Western formalism and Indian aesthetic traditions projected. His comparative essays reveal that the Indian notion of art as sacred ritual, particularly in oral art forms or performances, appealed to him as much as the formalistic classical school of aesthetics that had influenced modern Western critics, artists, and poets:

Music as a source and model of form has a long history in Europe. Pater summarised this tradition by his saying: 'All the arts aspire to the condition of music.'

... The forms of ritual are as important to Indian art forms, especially drama and literature, as music is to the Western ones.... Indeed every performance must begin with an invocation, a literal invoking of the god-like spirits of disembodied characters to embody themselves—theatre is condoned off from evil spirits.²⁵

As AKR's own playful poem 'The Condition of Music' reveals, no art, no music is just pure form. The famous court singer Tansen, the legendary Greek Orpheus, and the illiterate snake man share a special talent: they can charm with their music the elements, the living, the gods, and the sprits alike; thus, by affecting their audiences and the world in their rituals, they 'make visible' their forms.

After these introductory notes on AKR's general ideas on art, let us now assess how AKR represented in his characteristic allusive, comparativist style the various Indian aesthetic traditions (see the **(p.174)** section 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2) and art forms he was preoccupied with during his academic life from the 1950s to the 1990s.

Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy

As a scholar devoted mainly to Dravidian studies and folklore, the Sanskrit (marga) aesthetic tradition is not treated extensively in AKR's work, yet it contributed significantly to his views on art. Sanskrit aesthetics is discussed in several essays as one of the multiple traditions that AKR studied during his life and career. A good deal of Sanskrit terminology, phrases, philosophy, and thought systems were acquired by AKR as part of his Brahminical upbringing, and these formed a pool of ideas and motifs he was familiar with from the time of his youth:

Though I'm no Sanskritist, I've heard the sounds and words of Sanskrit all through my growing years. My father's study was upstairs and so were all his Sanskrit and English books. That's where he recited the Gita and the Ramayana, did his mathematics and his astrology....

Yet Sanskrit did come downstairs for feasts, weddings, deaths and anniversaries and other life-cycle rituals which were occasions for Sanskrit.²⁶

His exposure to Sanskrit aesthetics at the formal level began at the University of Chicago, where several of his colleagues, including the Indologist Edwin Gerow, had completed PhD dissertations in Sanskrit studies. AKR's access to Sanskrit aesthetics and poetics, however, was largely restricted to English or Kannada works, translations, and critical studies.²⁷ Though he was not formally trained in

Sanskrit, as his field of specialization was Dravidian linguistics, he had always strived to become proficient in Sanskrit. In fact, he usually wrote Sanskrit terms in Kannada script, and in the early 1990s AKR and the Sanskrit scholar Sheldon Pollock exchanged Sanskrit and Kannada lessons, as can be inferred from AKR's diaries of that time.²⁸

Apart from the occasional cross-references to Sanskrit terms and comparisons between Sanskrit aesthetics and other aesthetic traditions (Indian or Western) found in the lecture notes, diaries, and other essays, two monographic papers by AKR are devoted to Sanskrit aesthetics. The first piece is an unpublished rough draft paper titled 'Sanskrit Aesthetics', delivered as a conference paper in the early 1960s, which forms the backbone of AKR's contribution to the **(p.175)** published essay on 'Indian Poetics' co-authored with Edwin Gerow.²⁹ Rather than reproducing here the basic principles of Sanskrit aesthetics that are described by AKR in these essays, it is pertinent to identify which aspects of classical Sanskrit-based aesthetics, ideas, and philosophies the author was particularly drawn to. What stands out immediately is the non-technical manner in which complex ideas related to Sanskrit theories are tackled in the lectures and papers. AKR avoids, wherever possible, Sanskrit terminology generally used by Indologists, and tends to establish connections between Sanskrit and Western aesthetic traditions. Some of the thematic aspects of Sanskrit aesthetics and related Hindu philosophies emphasized by AKR in his essays can be summarized under the topics that follow.

Art as a Depersonalized and Transcendental Experience

The theory of *rasa* applies to drama, dance, poetry, and other arts, and is based on the idea of art as an affective experience involving the artist, the artistic expression, the audience/reader, and the world. It should be noted that AKR stressed the relevance of *rasa* in contemporary Indian criticism as a theory that concerns the artist as well as the receiver of the work of art. In 'Sanskrit Aesthetics' and 'Indian Poetics', AKR interprets the peculiarities of the theory of *rasa* and offers comparative references to Shakespeare and twentieth-century Western writers and critics. He focuses on the depersonalization of feelings in *rasa*, which he sees as the essential characteristic of this affective model of aesthetics.

As a man lives in this world through the senses, he feels pleasure and pain. He seeks one and avoids the other, and the seeking and avoiding make waves rise and fall in the sea of his consciousness. These movements are called feelings. Some of the waves are large, others small ripples, parts of the larger ones. The larger waves are the eight dominant moods: love, anger, fear, and the rest; the smaller ones are the transitory states, but related to the dominant moods: joy and jealousy, irritation and loss of

control, panic and trembling. The moods are excited and heightened by other elements.

... The feelings of an individual man are based on personal, accidental, incommunicable experience. Only when they are ordered, depersonalized, rendered communicable by prescriptions do they participate in *rasa*, which is created by them and in turn suffuses them. By this ordering, one's own history is reactivated in an impersonal context. *Rasa* is a depersonalized condition of the self, an imaginative system of relations. Its existence **(p. 176)** cannot be proved or designed, for 'its perception is inseparable from its existence.' It is not a 'worldly' state, for in the world pity, disgust, and horror are not enjoyed.... But though it is related to personal experience, it is not personal experience. The audience cannot talk to the persons of the drama. *Rasa* comes into being with the work of art and goes out with it. It is outside normal time and space....³⁰

In such a depersonalized experience of art the reader or spectator gets a 'taste' of *rasa*, the generalized aesthetic emotion, not as 'himself', but 'as all men: man is spoken to by man', as AKR puts it. The *rasa* theory is a 'consumer-oriented' theory.³¹ The cue of *rasa* lies not with the actor or poet at work, but with the spectator or reader, who is to keep an aesthetic distance to partake in the aesthetic emotion of *rasa*. Hence, when attaining *rasa* the audience does not identify with the artist or character, for the heightened emotions are communicable only in a depersonalized state.

The experience that defines *rasa* is not an ordinary one; it is within the reach of any individual as a fleeting taste of the transcendent: '*Rasa* comes into being with the experiencing. The critics compared it to the experience of God. It is its own witness, felt in the blood and along the heart through the body laid to sleep, the self in oblivion: a transient twin of the experience of Brahma....'³² It is doubtful whether AKR himself as an artist clung to this view of aesthetic experience as a glimpse of the divine. God was a concept he personally rejected, though he was always attracted to the metaphysical aspect that linked art and poetry to religion. The fact that a great part of his translations and papers are devoted to medieval mystic poetry also testifies to this interest in the transcendental dimension of art and poetry.

In the handwritten draft 'Sanskrit Aesthetics', the idea of *rasa* is defined as the transcendental aspect of art which, unlike the Western mimetic model, brings aesthetic pleasure close to religious experience:

But it is transient. This transience is an essential characteristic of art experience. This stasis can only be a temporary one.... Only saints, the ones who have gone right through life and come out on the other side of conflict, can hold this detachment like the totem-lizards that Malinowsky

describes somewhere. 'First there came the Kayavasi (iguana) the animal of the Lukulubata clan, which scratched its way through the earth as iguanas do, then climbed a tree, and remained there as mere onlooker.'

Only saints, if there are such, can remain on the tree and be onlookers. The rest of us are like the green lizards of one of Whittemore's poems:

(p.177) How is it this green lizard
climbs to the climbless wall?
And when, to where he goes he
comes, why fall?
Surely he who crawls so
far against the law.
Can crawl a lawless minute
more. With awe
I watch the conduct of green lizards.³³

AKR liked to juxtapose the condition of the detached ascetic with that of the ordinary, struggling artist. As a matter of fact, the distinction between saint and poet was one of his favourite topics when describing Indian poetic traditions (see the sections 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition', 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics', and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7) and is also one of the central issues in his own poetics.³⁴ Several of the poems on poetry, including 'The Striders', the opening poem of his first collection in English *The Striders*, deal with this theme (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

Art as Dramatic Experience

AKR was an ardent enthusiast of the performing arts and theatre, and a connoisseur both of the so-called marga or classical forms, based on the *Natya Sastra*, and of numerous south-Indian folk performing arts. In principle, the classical rasa theory is a highly sophisticated theory of drama which applies to art forms that are 'seen as well as heard', as AKR explains: 'Its impact lies not entirely ... in its language, but rather in its visual immediacy. Its poetic or "esthetic" perhaps inevitably centers on the interplay between conceptual and nonconceptual—form, dance, mime, song, characterization ... in a unity that can only be immediate and therefore affective.' Indeed, a complete section in the essay 'Indian Poetics' is aptly titled 'Dramatic Criticism' (see also the section 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition' in Chapter 7) and expounds on how rasa theory turns 'content into forms':

In a play, what the actor acts is not the central mood of love and grief. He acts out the conditions that excite the mood and the responses that follow from it.... The Indian theorists spelled this out in great detail, prescribing for (p.178) each of the *rasas* the correlative consequents, the kind of

dramatic personae, the gestures and scenery and kinds of diction, thus analysing content into forms.³⁵

According to this theory, the actor in the classical Indian performing arts is not expected to enter the psychology of a character and transform into someone other in order to make the audience believe in the story, as is common in Western theatre. Since rasa experience is 'outside normal time and space', neither the actor nor the character ultimately matter. AKR comments in regard to rasa in Shakespeare: '*Rasa* comes into being with the work of art and goes out with it.... The Caesar of the play is a virtual presence, neither the actor nor the original.'³⁶

In the 1950s, AKR wrote several drafts of a poem inspired by Bharatanatyam, a classical temple dance of south India, which is based on the dramatic principles of the *Natya Sastra*. Though the poem was never published, it was one of those early compositions that AKR never abandoned. He kept on revising it till the early 1980s, which is why multiple drafts of the poem exist.³⁷ One of the versions of this poem relates to the idea of art and poetry as an intangible dramatic performance. The poem's allusion to a 'virtual' dancer without a name, poised between the real and unreal, the person and the depersonalized aesthetic experience, body and myth, the non-conceptual and the conceptual, form and content, gains significance in the light of the rasa theory.

Bharata Natyam

Her anklets sprinkle melody
And choke the mind with stardust
As this jewelled dancer
Lives a language on her limbs
Waking ritual into metaphor ...

(I knew her name—
But this is not she)

Who is this airborne dancer
Dressed in all desire?
And who are these shadowshapes
(p.179) That fly, pursue, and suddenly die
But leap, abrupt, in ghostly close-ups
Giving the Dancer
Multitudes of mimic lives
On the taut and troubled screens of feeling?

(She has no name,
For archetypes have none)

She is a myth of dreamdesire
An eidos of the Actual,

Its secret unwritten poem—
The buried tenderness of veined leaves
In ageless stones.³⁸

I shall not go into the stylistic aspects of this poem here, but any reader familiar with AKR's poetry will be able to ascertain that this is quite unlike a typical AKR poem. This unpublished draft dates from around 1956 when he was a young teacher of English at Lingaraj College in Belgaum, but earlier versions of the poem go back to 1952 when AKR was barely 23.³⁹ As was symptomatic of most Indian poetry of the time, Yeats and the English Romantic poets made their presence felt and cast a long shadow over AKR as a budding poet. These and other influences from Western Romantic writers are analysed in the chapters on AKR's poetics (see the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7, and 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8).

The Taste of Art: Food, Rasa, and Soma

In the context of aesthetics and the physical senses, two interrelated Sanskrit terms, *rasa* and *soma*, often appear in AKR's prose and poetry, suggesting multiple layers of signification. The two words are etymologically and conceptually associated with the body, food, self, and art. An entire essay by AKR titled 'Food for Thought' is concerned with the notion of food in Indian culture, psychology, and aesthetics.⁴⁰ In the Upanishadic passage 'Food Chain', quoted in several of his papers, the world originates from food in a cyclical transformation of matter:

(p.180) From food, from food
Creatures, all creatures
come to be.
...
food, the chief
of things, of all things
that come to be,
elixir
herb of herbs
for mortals.
...
From food all beings
come to be,
by food

they grow.
into food
they pass.

and what eats is eaten:
and what's eaten eats
in turn. (1-3, 10-25, 26-34)⁴¹

Food is the primal substance that generates life and metamorphoses its organic and inorganic forms: 'Food is brahman, because food is what circulates in the universe, through bodies which in turn are food made flesh and bone.'⁴² The word 'rasa', in its root meaning, also refers to the gustatory sense and the consumption of food. Rasa, the impersonal aesthetic experience that derives from the sublimation of inborn natural feelings or bhava, is often defined in culinary terms in contemporary criticism. R.N. Rai, in his comparative study of Aristotle and Bharata, gives several definitions of rasa and resorts to expressions in different languages to cite approximate translations of the Sanskrit concept: 'The word has been translated etymologically by the terms "flavour," "relish," "gestation," "taste," "geschmack," or "saveur," for none of these renderings seems to be adequate.... The word "rasa" reveals different layers of meaning when used in different contexts. It ranges from the Aryan's drinking of the soma juice to the yogi's communion with the metaphysical Absolute, the Brahman.'⁴³

In the metonymic, 'consumer-oriented' Sanskrit aesthetic system, it is only a small step from the physical pleasure of a particular **(p.181)** 'flavour' to aesthetic experience and to metaphysical communion, so there are interesting etymological and semantic points of convergence that AKR exploits. In his seminal essay on food in Indian culture, he writes on the interrelations between rasa and food:

Rasa or taste (as in English) is also the basic metaphor for aesthetic experience: *ruci* or taste, *asvada* or eating, and *rasika*, meaning both gourmet and sensitive man, are part of the technical vocabulary of poetics. As with food, Indian aesthetics would insist that the experience is in the experiencer: 'Just as a taste (like sweetness) is created by the combination of different ingredients, a *rasa* (aesthetic) "flavour" is created by a combination of different *bhavas* or "affects"'.⁴⁴

As with food, the focus in aesthetic pleasure is on the experiencing subject. Both art and food are created, by a proper 'combination' of ingredients, to be consumed and relished, and are circulated through forms and bodies. The Sanskrit concept of Soma, on the other hand, does not derive from aesthetics, but plays a prominent role in AKR's ideas on creativity, particularly in the 1970s. This ancient term is mentioned in numerous poetry drafts and several essays and lecture notes in connection with artistic inspiration. In the Vedas, as AKR remarks, 'food is called Soma and that represents the female or Mother principle whereas Agni represents the male or Father principle'.⁴⁵ Soma is cited in the Vedas as an elixir of unknown composition and was the divine drink used by the Brahmins in their sacrifices. It is variously referred to as a plant, a drug, and a god. More significantly, Soma is also the 'lord of speech, leader of poets, and seer among priests'.⁴⁶ Soma, therefore, is the source of ecstasy and artistic imagination, and further extends the aesthetic implications in AKR's thought from the physical and metaphysical to the psychedelic and religious dimensions

(see also the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' and 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7).

The Soul of Art: Creative Transformation and Reincarnation

The famous phrase about the goldsmith in the *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad* cited earlier in the context of the body, is preceded by the **(p.182)** passage on the caterpillar representing the transmigration of the soul (the individual self, *jivatma*). AKR's notes and poems include manifold references to this animal motif that is central to Hindu philosophy: 'As a caterpillar, drawing near the tip of a blade of grass, prepares its next step, and draws itself up towards it, so does this self, striking the body aside and dispelling ignorance, prepare its next step and draw itself up (in readiness to be born again).'⁴⁷ According to the Hindu belief of reincarnation, the soul never dies; it merely disengages from the dying body and takes hold of another body. This is a primary idea in Indian mythology, philosophy, religion, and history, as AKR notes:

Reincarnation, not only a central notion in Indian mythology, but also for Indian history—the past is up-to-date.

Metaphors for it: Caterpillar (a. consumer of life, b. contracts and dilates)

Goldsmith: new uses for past materials

Gita: As a Man casts off his worn-out clothes and takes on new ones, so does the embodied self cast off its worn-out bodies and enter new ones.⁴⁸

As has already been pointed out in Chapter 4, in the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' and 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience', the concept of reincarnation is tackled as a personal spiritual concern and as an aesthetic principle in AKR's poetry and diaries. The classical Indian notions of change, transformation, and fixity amid the flux of things stand out as central ideas that inspire his aesthetics and nurture his body of poetry. One of AKR's unpublished poetry drafts, composed around 1970, plays with the idea of the transmigrating soul in an ironic tone:

I wish I could live and die
Many times and many places
without ceasing to be,
So that there's no question
of whether to be or not to be
But being and going out of Being
as the need takes hold—
The need to testify
The sweat of incompatible selves⁴⁹

(p.183) Some of the poems drafted during this period are, in fact, reminiscent of the 'Mescaline Notes' (see the earlier-mentioned sections in Chapter 4), which associated the flux of colours, forms, and matter with his own predicament of living in the flow of time through past, present, and future lives. As has been illustrated in the previous chapter on AKR's 'inner aesthetics', such a philosophy of life and the common stock of Hindu motifs associated with it led AKR to express his aesthetic convictions through images and animal motifs, typically reptiles and insects, that represent transformation, regeneration, or reincarnation, as, for example, the snake sloughing its skin. The caterpillar image, which conveys the idea of continuity through transformation, appears, for instance, in the *Second Sight* poem 'Elements of Composition' (see also the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7). This key poem contains AKR's aesthetic and philosophical vision of 'composition' (in its multiple meanings) and 'creation' as encompassing culture, nature, life, art, food, time, and the body. The body symbolizes 'matter', which also includes the aesthetic object and the poetic text, and is the reality that the 'I' of the poem clings to. By its own organic 'composition' and action of composing and decomposing, the self transforms endlessly into new forms:

Composed as I am, like others,
of elements on certain well-known lists,
father's seed and mother's egg

gathering earth, air, fire, mostly
water, into a mulberry mass,
moulding calcium,

carbon, even gold, magnesium and such,
into a chattering self tangled
in love and work,

scary dreams, capable of eyes that can see,
only by moving constantly,
the constancy of things

...

(p.184) I pass through them
as they pass through me
taking and leaving

...

and even as I add,
I lose, decompose
into my elements,

into other names and forms,
past, and passing, tenses

without time,

caterpillar on a leaf, eating,
being eaten. (1-12, 36-8, 53-60)⁵⁰

In this Upanishadic cosmo-vision that appealed to AKR, the idea of art and creation merges with the notion of the composite body and the transformation of matter. As AKR explains, ‘material and non-material things are all made of substance, according to a familiar Hindu point of view; some *sthula*, “gross”, others *sukhma*, “subtle”. Nothing is truly destroyed—things are displaced, converted, transformed, according to a belief in the “conservation of matter”.’⁵¹ The ancient concept of endless transformation of matter is also illustrated in the purusa myth of creation, in which the primordial male being splits off like a cell into male and female to create or, rather, to ‘pour forth’ endlessly.⁵² Thus, creation is transformation and nothing ‘new’ is created, as argued by the Samkhya school of philosophy. The Hindu myth of creation expresses ‘a worldview that insists on continuities, on transformations ... one could begin anywhere and make poetry and religion out of it,’⁵³ writes AKR.

The goldsmith (transforming material) and caterpillar (transforming body), two metaphors for transformation and continuity recreated from the Upanishads by the poet, are motifs for AKR’s integrative aesthetics that conceives culture, art, and poetry as being ‘re-made’ out of nature. A diary entry of the mid-1970s evinces this fundamental view by way of Samkhya philosophy and the concepts of prakriti (nature) and samskriti (culture): ‘Oct 30. 1976.... [O]ne works at [a poem] over and over till it reaches a focus, a clarity. One makes only by re-making it. Like the notion of “Nature” in Samkhya and elsewhere—a [*Prakriti*], “already made”—yet to be remade into [*Samskriti*]....’⁵⁴

(p.185) Art, Self, and Ontological Dualism

The dual notion of the self as actor and watcher, as expounded in the Gita, the Upanishads, Samkhya, and other Hindu theories on body, mind, and perception, such as Patanjali’s yoga, pervade much of AKR’s poetry and prose work. His interest in dualistic conceptions goes back to the early 1950s as a student of English and American literature in India. During his Mysore college years, AKR had already discovered, for instance, that Walt Whitman’s conception of the double self could be traced to the Gita.⁵⁵

The Upanishads have a strong presence, in AKR’s third collection of poetry—*Second Sight*. Introducing the poem ‘Questions’, there is the famous passage from the *Mundaka Upanishad* on the active (prakriti) and passive (purusa) aspects of the self: ‘Two birds on the selfsame tree:/ One of them eats the fruit of the tree,/ The other watches without eating’ (see this quote also in the opening of Chapter 2).⁵⁶ Following this quote, the opening line of ‘Questions’ picks up the phrase on the caterpillar (from the *Taittiriya Upanishad*) that closes the preceding poem ‘Elements of Composition’ (59-60), and links this image to the

watcher-actor dichotomy: 'Eating, being eaten,/ parts of me watch, parts of me burn,/ rarely a blue flame' (1-3).⁵⁷ The implications of this dualistic notion in AKR's ideas on aesthetic perception, artistic creativity, religious experience, and psychology, and their interconnectedness, can also be surmised from various unpublished papers. One of AKR's last unpublished lecture drafts is a thought-provoking paper titled 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' (see also the section 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3), which was to have been delivered at a seminar on the brain in March 1993 in India that he could not attend due to his spine problem.⁵⁸ In this paper, AKR focuses on the potential that art has of bringing together, in moments of aesthetic and contemplative experience, the contemplating non-self or true self and the individual self:

One of the properties often noticed by art theorists, that a work of art releases you temporarily from the need to act, delays indefinitely the impulse to act on impulse ... making you contemplate rather than act, suspend judgement than make one, to identify oneself with the non-self, even an alien and painful non-self for the nonce. Indian authors have even called this 'negative capability' to enter Iago as well as a Desdemona, to feel the growth of leaves on a tree as well as the flight of a bird on the twig, ... the Indian philosophers have thought this art experience a transient twin of the religious experience **(p.186)** (*brahmananda sahadarah*) ... noting at least affinity of aesthetic experience to other forms. Through this continual identification and disidentification with objects and persons etc. consciousness or the self, if I may use the word, changes, incorporates the world outside ... not only the language of experience but the experience itself changes.⁵⁹

AKR even borrows here a term coined by one of his favourite Romantic poets, John Keats (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7): the 'negative capability' that describes an artist's natural receptiveness and wonderment at the world as opposed to the firm belief in categorical knowledge posited by other writers and thinkers. For the Hindu believer, true consciousness is the realization that the world's creation is a play (*maya*), and, as AKR notes, the artist or poet simply specializes in foregrounding this illusion, 'for poets are only specialists in what everybody does all the time'.⁶⁰ The simultaneously personal and depersonalized attitude to the world and the double-sided, physical and metaphysical way of experiencing are, therefore, interpreted by AKR in this interesting paper as traits of the human psyche:

The central metaphor of Prakrti and Purusha, one as watcher and the other as the actor, is an ancient one....

Such a division is not only true of the heart of creation, where one is the Unmoving Witness and the other is the moving feminine principle, creating, enjoying, suffering. Such characterizations and divisions are also seen as psychological. The division between the watcher and the actor is also seen as characteristic of the human psyche: in our own minds, one part watches, the other acts.⁶¹

The ontological dualism of universal mind or consciousness (purusa) and primary matter (prakriti), one the unchanging inactive witness and the other the active principle, is one of the fundamental ideas advocated in the Samkhya and yoga texts. These classical Sanskrit philosophical traditions have a presence in AKR's early career and also reverberate throughout his later aesthetic thought.⁶² They are also intimately connected to Jainism, and especially Buddhism, a religion that appealed to him at certain stages of his life (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6). Moreover, the diaries and notes reveal that AKR practised yoga during his youth and testify to his interest in the control of the body and mind. The belief in the double nature of the self (as actor and watcher) was by no means an original idea, but, by embracing **(p.187)** it, AKR was able to understand and express his own struggle as an artist-scholar engaged in several disciplines (see the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 and 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3).⁶³ In the creative activity as a writer-translator, he could at the same time be an onlooker and an agent, or, as he himself put it, detached saint on a tree or 'green lizard' climbing and falling. This double psyche also corresponds with the creative tension AKR underwent as a professional translator, mediating between languages and traditions (see the section 'Translation and Poetic Practice' in Chapter 8). The art of living 'suspended' between at least two cultures, two languages, two countries, two traditions, past and present, and his self-imposed condition as a hyphenated Indo-American was perfected by AKR over the years and allowed him to be, at the same time, the consummate insider and perceptive outsider.

'The self is always a triangular point between A and B,' wrote AKR in English in one of his notecards next to a poem in Kannada. The essence of art and aesthetic experience in AKR's thought is inextricably linked to the complex nature of his self and of the multiple realities it took part of. It was a mystery that led him to inquire into the inner truth of things and to celebrate and suffer the double reality of flesh and bone, art and life, dream and waking, agent and watcher, and along with it to experience the transformative cycle of birth and death. This question was the beating pulse that moved the artist in AKR, watched by 'the watchers':

...

were the watchers there

with me, being born over and over, tearing
each time through a waterbed paradise,
the original ocean

of milk, gills for lungs, the whole body
a sucking at the nipple, a past perfect
of two in one, ...?

my head's soft crown bathed in mother's blood,
wearing tatters of attachments, bursting
into the cruelties

of earthly light, infected air? (16-26)⁶⁴

(p.188) Tamil Aesthetics

The ancient literary tradition in Tamil that flourished during the Sangam age (dated 100 BC to AD 250) appears in AKR's writings as a forgotten treasure that shaped his ideas on culture, aesthetics, and poetics.⁶⁵ Classical Tamil literature and culture held his scholarly and poetic interest from the early 1960s till the end of his life. After a chance encounter with classical Tamil literary texts at the library of the University of Chicago, AKR gradually garnered respect among academic circles as one of the foremost specialists in the field. Many of the lecture notes and essays deal with Tamil culture, and there are a number of monographic and comparative papers on its poetic and aesthetic traditions.

'Sangam' literally means 'academy', 'assembly', or 'fraternity' of poets, a notion that was very appealing to AKR's views on tradition (see the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8). As outlined earlier (see the section 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2), the sophistication of the *Tolkappiyam*, the ancient Tamil grammar and commentary on poetics, lies in the Akam-Puram (or interior-exterior, private-public) paradigm signifying a social and cultural system, a world vision, and a poetic genre. It also displays an extraordinary taxonomy of *dramatis personae* and poetic landscapes to denote archetypal feelings.⁶⁶ There are several aspects of Tamil aesthetics that are repeatedly highlighted by AKR in his notes and in the unpublished and published papers (see also the section 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7).

Interior Landscapes: An Ecosystem of Feelings

In an early interview, AKR explained his admiration for Tamil Sangam poetry: 'These classical Tamil poems attracted me by their attitude to experience, to human passion, and to the external world.'⁶⁷ The *Tolkappiyam* distinguishes between the Akam and Puram poetic genres, and assigns to the Akam (interior) genre five types of love and their symbolic conventions, which AKR calls 'interior landscapes'. This expression, used by AKR for emotions contained in nature, is reminiscent of the terminology coined in Western visual arts, from 1930s

surrealism to abstract expressionism in the 1960s, to represent what is 'contained' in the artist's psyche.⁶⁸ AKR uses it literally and metaphorically in his anthology *The Interior Landscape* (1967), to **(p.189)** introduce the Western reader to Tamil classical poetics and its five landscapes or *tinai* for different types of love: *kurinci* (hillside); *mullai* (forest); *marutam* (fertile area or city); *neythal* (seashore); and *palai* (desert). *Tinai* is a 'complex concept' which AKR defines thus: '[A] genre is represented by a region or landscape, its nature and culture, and the human feelings associated with them—in short, an entire ecosystem used for poetic expression. "Landscape" is a convenient metonymy for the whole cluster of notions.'⁶⁹ Just as the Tamil landscape is divided into the regions, so is time split into larger time units (the six climatic seasons, from the rains to late summer) and smaller time units of the day (from sunrise to night). According to the *Tolkappiyam*, each region contains a particular set of native elements, 'gods, foods, animals, trees, birds, drums, occupations, lutes or musical styles and such others'.⁷⁰ And each landscape is 'presided by a deity and named for a flower or tree characteristic of the region'.⁷¹ In this aesthetic system of 'correspondences', the universe is divided into first elements (*mutal*), consisting of a particular place and time units (the season and time of the day), 14 natural elements (*karu*), and human elements, that is, a specific mood or 'phase of love' (*uri*). AKR elaborates on this convention in his second anthology of Tamil poetry titled *Poems of Love and War* (1985): '[A] landscape (*tinai*), in the Tamil definition, is both a place and a mood; to speak of one is to evoke the other.'⁷² For instance, *kurinci*, the mountain flower, stands for the hill areas, which are watched over by the Tamil god Murugan. The characteristic season of this region is the cold season or early frost, the time of day, the night, and the corresponding love phase, the lovers' union.

Thus each phase of love gets its characteristic type of imagery from a particular landscape. Flower names ... are names not only for landscape but for the associated feeling and of the type of poetry devoted to them—anything in it, bird or drum, tribal name or dance, may be used to symbolize and evoke a specific feeling. A conventional design thus provides a live vocabulary of symbols; the actual objective landscape of Tamil country becomes the interior landscape of poetry.⁷³

Such a system which culls aesthetic feelings from the exterior world, that is, the natural scene with its flora and fauna, is highlighted by AKR as an idiosyncratic tradition that creates its own metonymic universe: '[A]n ecosystem of which a man's activities and feelings are a part. To describe the exterior landscape is also to inscribe the interior landscape.'⁷⁴

(p.190) The Nature-Culture Continuum

AKR was particularly drawn to the nature-culture nexus that underlies the structural organization of Tamil poetry. He often compared its concentric world

view to that of Sanskrit aesthetics, where cultural refinement and natural emotion are seen as separate categories:

[A] contrast between city and country or forest [in Sanskrit literature] appears to be one realisation of a more pervasive thematic contrast which might be described as the nature-culture opposition ... the central theme of Sanskrit aesthetic theory ... aesthetic emotion, *rasa* is clearly distinguished from *bhava*, or natural 'inborn' everyday feeling. *Rasa* is emotion refined, generalised, rid of incompatibles and impurities; *bhava* is the natural feeling of everyday occasion.⁷⁵

In the essays 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' and 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', AKR further juxtaposes concepts from Sanskrit aesthetics with the cosmology of the ancient Tamil people:

In the Tamil poems, culture is enclosed in nature, nature is reworked in culture, so that we cannot tell the difference. We have a nature-culture continuum that cancels the terms, confuses them even if we begin with them. Such container-contained relations are seen in many kinds of concepts and images....⁷⁶

The continuity of city and country, nature and culture is apparent elsewhere too in Tamil. In contrast to Sanskrit, early Tamil aesthetics makes no clear distinction between *bhava* and *rasa*, the raw everyday feelings and the refined emotions of art and poetry. If etymologies mean anything, the native word for culture, 'panpu', sometimes means nature, while in other contexts it connotes culture. *Pan* means 'to produce'; it also means 'a harmony, a musical node'—a complex of meanings, inclusive of both nature and culture: very different from Sanskrit *samskrta* which implies 'a refinement, a redoing' of things natural.⁷⁷

AKR observed that 'there is no hierarchy'⁷⁸ in such a nature-culture continuum where natural scenes and cultural objects are inseparably interwoven. The acceptance of natural and commonplace objects, situations and experiences as aesthetic elements alongside 'refined' cultural objects became an indelible trait of his personal idea of art and aesthetics (see the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4).⁷⁹ Another related characteristic (**p.191**) that AKR absorbed is the aesthetic technique of 'interior landscapes', which permits a creative interplay between external objectivity and internal subjectivity, resulting in an unbroken contiguity of scene and agent.

The eco-aesthetic stance of the ancient Tamils is also concomitant with how AKR perceived his childhood, his environment-sensitive upbringing, education, and living habitat, where the outer environment was an extension of the cultural space inhabited by the family in the multistoreyed house. For the young AKR, nature was not a world apart from culture. Where culture ended, above his

father's attic, there was the open rooftop, the terrace 'open to the sky' from where cows, dogs, and humans could be seen in a 'natural' contiguity. Instead of 'high' cultures and non-literate ones, he spoke of the intricate relations of mother and father tongues and their different uses, and of the cultural web of uncles, grandmothers, aunts, sisters, and cousins coexisting with plants, vegetables, fruit, cows, dogs, bats, snakes, spiders, scorpions, etc. Thus, the concentric environmental aesthetics of the ancient Tamil writers impregnated much of AKR's account of his life experience, and his aesthetic vision and critical discourse.

What follows from this picture of the Tamil Sangam age drawn by AKR is, however, not as much an endeavour to promote Tamil exceptionalism (which was in vogue in south-Indian public life in the decades of AKR's youth), as it is an intentional foregrounding of distinct features of a cultural and literary tradition that was little known in Western academic circles, that is, at American and European universities, at a time when Sanskrit scholarship occupied the better part of Indological discourse. As a south-Indian scholar in America, it became AKR's mission to unearth the literary treasures of this tradition when, by chance, he found an anthology of classical Tamil poetry in the basement of a Chicago library in 1962. And it is also not surprising that he continued projecting the Tamil trademark following the success of *The Interior Landscape* (1967) and after becoming professor of Dravidian studies and linguistics in 1968 at the University of Chicago, a post he kept until the end of his incomplete life.⁸⁰

Nonetheless, in his prose AKR not only differentiates the peculiar Tamil nature-culture conception from the Sanskrit conventions, he also stresses the divergence between the Tamil and Western traditions. In Tamil aesthetics, he comments that there is 'no Wordsworthian or Kantian metaphysical sense of inner harmony with nature; nor of Nature's blindness or indifference as in Hardy, nor nostalgia for it as (p.192) in even Whitman's "I wish I could turn and live with the animals", nor for that matter much contrast between animals and men'.⁸¹ Moreover, AKR surmises in his support of 'The Relevance of Tamil Classical Poetry' that the 'refined' art of classical Tamil poetry emerged out of the oral traditions and should thus dispel unfounded prejudices about a lower or higher aesthetic in India.⁸²

Folk Aesthetics

Oral or folk traditions deeply marked AKR's sensitivity as a writer and scholar from the earliest years. In one of his late essays in the defence of folklore, the author acknowledged the important substratum of non-literate environments in his life and aesthetics: 'Why folklore? For starters, I for one need folklore as an Indian studying India. It pervades my childhood, my family, my community. It is the symbolic language of the non-literate parts of me and my culture....'⁸³ AKR was drawn to sundry oral folk forms including poetry, narrative, proverbs, and riddles. They proved to be an intellectual challenge that matched his zeal for

encyclopaedic erudition in his youth. This parallel interest in folk and 'higher' learning was carefully nurtured in the peculiar compartmental layout of the family house. Long before receiving a formal education in classical Indian literature, AKR had been exposed to oral traditions by way of female relatives, teachers, and friends. Folk traditions shaped his 'sense of what is beautiful and poetic, of what is moral and right, and even [his] most abstract sense of values'.⁸⁴ Later, as a lecturer of English, he took up folklore as a hobby in Belgaum, which soon became his main extra-curricular pastime. To an adolescent with eclectic intellectual interests, the expressive forms of folklore were particularly tempting since many of the oral traditions, including folktales and the Virasaiva saint poetry of vachanas in Kannada, subverted the often hierarchical structure of the Sanskrit conventions he had been taught as a Brahmin: '[I]n the mythologies, one hears the official views'.⁸⁵ In AKR's alternative view of literature he illustrates how oral forms exhibit a distinct counter-aesthetics and a holistic 'living' tradition, as folk narratives, proverbs, and oral poetry are continually adapting to new situations. Stories and tales actually demand to be retold in order to survive: 'They have an existence of their own, a secondary objectivity, like other cultural artefacts.... Cultural forms (such as stories) make people what they are as much as people make culture.'⁸⁶ AKR dedicated a good part of **(p.193)** his career to studying how these verbal and non-verbal traditions exist in modern contexts and have travelled in time, being handed over from the remote past yet ever-changing.

In *Folktales from India*, AKR analysed some of the formal features that make tales aesthetically appealing. This collection of folktales rendered in English from various Indian languages opens with the exhortative remark: '[T]hese tales are meant to be read for pleasure first, to be experienced as aesthetic objects.'⁸⁷ AKR's fascination for the so-called 'little' traditions persisted, therefore, not only because of their sociopolitical message but for their peculiar aesthetic and formal apparatus. One of the qualities that AKR identified in non-verbal and verbal folk forms, including tales, bard-singing, poetry, and sayings, was that they shared many things in common with sacred ritual and theatre, that is, with religious and aesthetic 'genres of cultural performance'.⁸⁸ For instance, both tale and ritual performance had to be re-enacted by following a formal design: 'Folklore, contrary to romantic notions of its spontaneity or naturalness, is formal. It makes visible its forms. Identification and disidentification (of the listener with their characters) have their triggers in the tales and happen at different stages of a tale or a performance—not unlike the process by which a person is possessed or dispossessed in the course of a possession ritual.'⁸⁹

According to this view, it is the live enactment of the ritualistic-artistic form that makes the tale simultaneously an aesthetic experience for teller, character, and listener. Their emotions and world views meet and get (con)fused in every telling. Thus, AKR regarded the tale 'not merely as the variant of a tale-type ... a cultural object, a psychological witness (or symptom) etc., but primarily as an

aesthetic work.’ He believed that only through the experience of the aesthetic form of the tale and its telling, can full access to its inner and outer dimensions be gained. The aesthetic meaning is the experience of a formal design, and all further meanings derive from the particular way that the artist, the teller, renders this experience: ‘[T]he aesthetic is the first and the experienced dimension, through which ethos and worldview are revealed.... The other kinds of meanings (psychological, social, etc.) are created and carried by the primary experiential, aesthetic forms and meanings.’⁹⁰

AKR understood early that the classical rasa theory of Sanskrit aesthetics, with its distinction of artist or actor, character, and audience, and its differentiation between personal feeling and generalized **(p.194)** aesthetic emotion, could not apply to these folk forms. In the folk aesthetics of oral tales, recital, poetry, and drama, there is a sporadic identification and disengaging of elements during the creative act: ‘[B]ard and character, bard and audience, bard and actor, actor and character are merged at crucial moments and separated at ordinary times.’⁹¹ This appreciation of aesthetic feeling in folk performance as an alternation of merging (or possession) and distancing (or dispossession) is also present in bhakti poetry, as AKR explained elsewhere (see ahead in this chapter and the section ‘Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics’ in Chapter 7).

Another aspect is that certain folk narratives are, like meta-poems, overtly self-reflexive, so there are many stories about stories, which complicate the relationship between fictive art and the real: ‘This folk-myth is about myth itself, of how myth generates ritual; how men re-enact myth in ritual, and how “art imitates life, and life imitates art”.’⁹² This famous quote by Oscar Wilde became the leitmotif of AKR’s own condition as an artist. A favourite theme in his work was precisely the ambiguity found in oral ‘performances’, which tend to diffuse the boundaries between the creator (the artist), the created (the work), and the spectator, in an open ‘scenario’ where any crossover can happen: ‘In this story, the story-teller’s life enacts and becomes the story. And the story enters the life of the listeners. Stories are scenarios.’⁹³ So, when AKR told a story—or his ‘story’—in prose or poetry, such a conflation of teller and tale, life and art was not merely a technique, but also a dilemma, as we saw, for instance, in the context of his autobiographical Kannada novella (see the sections ‘Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage’ in Chapter 2, ‘Looking for the Other to Find Oneself’ in Chapter 3, and ‘Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR’s Journals and Diaries’ in Chapter 4) and in the aftermath of the mescaline experience (see the sections ‘Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR’s Journals and Diaries’ and ‘What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience’ in Chapter 4).

The Aesthetics of Bhakti

AKR was first immersed in oral bhakti traditions in Kannada, particularly the medieval Virasaiva poetry, at college in Mysore in the 1940s, and later pursued the study of bhakti more intensively during the mid-1950s in Belgaum.

Describing his fruitful years as a lecturer **(p.195)** in this city, he comments on the political and emotional aspects of his affinity with the Virasaiva saint-poets:

I also saw traditions that were not actually in the writings. To me that was very exciting, just as reading the poems of Basavanna and Mahadeviyakka was like a revelation. It was not a revelation like a flash, but one that occurred over the years. And I began to internalise it. It was also closer to what you could call my feelings against hierarchy. By this time I'd become rebellious towards hierarchy and various Hindu systems of discrimination ... it's not something explicitly political, it was a matter of feeling rather than doctrine.⁹⁴

As many other writers of his generation who lived through India's Independence in their youth, in the 1940s AKR went through a process of personal struggle and revolt against the orthodoxy of the Vaisnava Brahminical community to which he belonged, and found in the medieval Virasaiva bhakti poets an 'alternative' tradition that suited his agenda as an intellectual and poet (see the sections 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3 and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7). In the Kannada-speaking region of south India, popular legends, cults, and religious sects sprung up in the course of history in honour of the wandering Virasaiva mystic poets of the tenth to twelfth century AD. Many of their poems proclaimed the subversion of the caste system and established structures. The Virasaivas were in favour of personal devotion to the lingam, the symbol representing the god Siva. In the mid-twentieth-century society of Karnataka, the poetry of these medieval saints acquired new overtones due to the political and social circumstances of the time at the national and regional levels. AKR learnt about this Kannada tradition from one of his college professors, as he acknowledged in a letter: 'I first read the Kannada *Bharata* and Kannada *vacanas* with one of the finest and most wide-ranging of teachers, V. Sitaramayya in Mysore.'⁹⁵ The bhakti poetry of the Virasaiva saints was depicted in his landmark translation work, *Speaking of Siva*, as a particularly vigorous counter-movement: 'The *vacana* saints reject not only the "great" traditions of Vedic religion, but the "little" local traditions as well.'⁹⁶ Yet AKR's essays on this bhakti tradition recognize that its aesthetics cannot be completely disengaged from the classical Sanskrit and folk traditions as they share a common pool of ideas.

After the success of *Speaking of Siva*, AKR was encouraged to translate the equally fascinating Alvar poetry written in early medieval **(p.196)** Tamil. The Alvar poets, in fact, belonged to the transitional period from the Tamil Sangam (Akam and Puram) aesthetics to the first bhakti manifestations, so they 'formed

Indian conceptions of *bhakti*', giving it 'its figures and meanings'.⁹⁷ In the late 1970s and early 1980s, AKR's aesthetics was imbued with the conception of poetry, art, and life of the Alvar mystics, which have a common ground with Virasaiva bhakti.

I shall outline here several aspects of bhakti aesthetics that are emphasized by AKR in diverse published and unpublished sources. They are exposed most prominently in the essays that appeared in AKR's two translation works of bhakti poetry: *Speaking of Siva*, on medieval Virasaiva poetry in Kannada, and *Hymns for the Drowning*, containing Vaisnava Alvar Tamil poetry by Nammalvar (ninth to tenth century AD). Although the aesthetics of bhakti as described by AKR is intrinsically connected to its poetics (see the section 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7), some features of the devotional poetry of the medieval south-Indian poet-saints are to be considered within a larger framework of art and aesthetics.

AKR often made it a point to explicate the different strands that flow into the devotional tradition called bhakti, which spawned 'unique poems out of shared materials, a great common stock of ideas, forms and motifs'.⁹⁸ With deftly chosen examples, he showed how bhakti evolved out of the classical Tamil aesthetics of Akam and Puram with its interior landscapes, love scenes, and hero worship, converging with the conceptions and mythologies of the Sanskrit Brahminical tradition and local folklore: 'Bhakti saints, like the *vachanakaras*, have been called the "great integrators", bringing the high to the low, esoteric paradox to the man in the street, transmuting ancient and abstruse ideas into live contemporary experiences....'⁹⁹ Quite like his own miscellaneous confluence of cultures and forms, bhakti is seen by AKR as a meeting place of several aesthetic traditions. In the bhakti traditions he translated, pan-Indian ideas and local themes are 'made' into new material by wandering poets who sing about social change, about love and creation, and about their diverse personal mystic experiences. Indeed, the bhakti poet, as AKR indicates, 'is a poet *because* he is a saint'.¹⁰⁰ For the bhakta (devotee), poetry and any other art form is only a means, rather than the end. Hence, in the bhakti tradition, aesthetic experience (*rasa*) is subordinated to personal emotion (*bhava*):

In the terminology of *rasa*, *bhakti* is a new *rasa* that uses other *rasa* (like the erotic or heroic) as *bhavas*....

(p.197) *Rasa* poetry (not confined to Sanskrit) aims at *rasa* or aesthetic emotion, 'emotion recollected,'¹⁰¹ experience generalised and depersonalised by means of a structure, a poesis, a making. In *bhakti* poems, such a *rasa* is no longer the end (though it may be the result, especially when we look at the poems as 'texts'). In them *bhava* 'feeling,'

anubhava 'experience,' are much prized terms. We have here a poetics of *bhava*, not *rasa*, a poetics of personal feeling whether aesthetic or not.¹⁰²

Since the ultimate purpose of the artist/bhakta is to unite with the object of devotion, the personal experience in art and life turns into a possession ritual:

A *bhakta* is not content to worship a god in word and ritual, nor is he content to grasp him in a theology; he needs to possess him and be possessed by him. He needs also to sing, to dance; to make poetry, painting, shrines, sculpture; to embody him in every possible way. In *bhakti*, all the arts become also 'techniques of ecstasy' incitement to possession....

As the poet is entirely given to his god, he believes in a spontaneity that is also possession.... *Rasa* depends on aesthetic distance. But in the poetics of *bhakti*, these distinctions are blurred, if not annulled. The Lord (the subject of the poem) becomes the poet.¹⁰³

For the medieval Tamil Alvars, 'the immersed ones' who lived between the sixth and ninth centuries AD, the god Visnu is 'a master of illusions'¹⁰⁴ who enters the devotee and speaks through the poet-saint. Whereas the Alvar poets followed the orthodox idea of karma, the Virasaiva lingayat saints, who worshipped Siva, believed in divine grace (*kripa*). In such traditions, art is a spontaneous experience:

All true experience of god is *krpa*, grace that cannot be called, recalled, or commanded. The vacanas distinguish *anubhava* 'experience,' and *anubhāva* 'the Experience.' The latter is a search for the 'unmediated vision,' the unconditioned act, the unpredictable experience. Living in history, time and cliché, one lives in a world of the pre-established, through the received (*sruti*) and the remembered (*smṛti*). But Experience when it comes, comes like a storm to all such husks and labels.... The vacana is thus a rejection of premeditated art, the *sthavaras* of forms. It is not only a spontaneous cry but a cry for spontaneity—for the music of a body given over to the Lord.¹⁰⁵

The artist has to find his way towards such a fleeting mystical experience through *bhakti*. According to AKR, the Virasaiva *bhakti* saints rejected the hegemonic Vedic tradition in Sanskrit as well as the local folk traditions and mythologies because these represented **(p.198)** the stagnated conventions, the *sthavara* (static) forms of art and worship. The distinction between *sthavara* (static) and *jangama* (moving) stressed by AKR is essential to fully appreciate the formal and sociopolitical implications of *bhakti* aesthetics, and to assess the influence it had on AKR in his conception of inspiration, art as process and as re(incarnation). Just as genuine art may 'come' as an unpredictable 'Experience' to the devotee, artistic inspiration is sometimes understood by AKR as a form of

grace, as an accident involving some sort of possession that arrives spontaneously, as a dream or nightmare or a moment of ecstasy. It is a partially unpredictable, unconscious commonplace act that can turn for or against the artist. Artists, however, strive towards it and work their 'ways' for this 'Experience' to 'happen' (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

As is the case for AKR, who lived and expressed art through the physical senses, the metaphor through which the bhaktas utter their 'Experience' is the body. AKR often quoted the famous phrase by Basavanna, leader of the medieval lingayat community, as an example of art-in-motion: 'things standing shall fall,/ but the moving ever shall stay' (11-12).¹⁰⁶ Another poem by Basavanna (quoted in the opening of this chapter) illustrates the organic notion of art that breaks the categories of artist, devotee, and god, and with it the distinction between artist and art, for the artist is body and instrument alike:

Make of my body the beam of a lute
of my head the sounding gourd
of my nerves the strings
of my fingers the plucking rods.

Clutch me close
and play your thirty-two songs
O lord of the meeting rivers!¹⁰⁷

The oral vachana sayings were dedicated to a specific form or aspect of Siva. This feature is particularly evident in the so-called saguna poets, who worship a personal form of god. In Mahadeviyakka (also called Akkamahadevi), the god is often desired as a lover and is called *Cennamalikarjuna*, the 'Lord White as Jasmine'. To Basavanna, Siva was the 'Lord of the Meeting Rivers'. As a modern bard, AKR could well have chosen 'Poet of the *Meeting Rivers*' as his signature line, for he yearned to inscribe the aesthetics of a contemporary poet-scholar (p. 199) in a creative sangam (assembly, confluence) of old and new traditions. Whichever 'stream' one takes to analyse his aesthetic vision, one arrives, in AKR's work, at a cross-section of interrelated ideas on art and aesthetics that emerge from the multiple environments and traditions he was exposed to. This does not imply that he followed a fixed set of convictions throughout his life. Ideas were often stretched to accommodate changes and transformations. He often swayed between several parallel thoughts and 'things' during a particular period of time, and travelled back and forth in time to re-make old material into new forms.

Notes:

(*) Basavanna, first stanza of *Vacana* 500, trans. A.K. Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 38. See also the section on bhakti aesthetics in this chapter.

- (1.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (10 November 1976), n.p. AKR refers here to the poem 'Small-Scale Reflections on a Great House', *Relations*, in *CP*, pp. 96-9.
- (2.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (29 December 1979), n.p.; underline in the original. See also the poem 'Snakes and Ladders' in the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4.
- (3.) Ramanujan quoted in Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', p. 12.
- (4.) Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 41.
- (5.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p. See also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.
- (6.) Ramanujan quoted in Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', p. 12.
- (7.) Ramanujan quoted in Kalven, 'Found in the Translation', p. 34.
- (8.) Ramanujan, 'Murder in the Cathedral and Aristotle's Theory of Tragedy', typed rough draft of a paper, AKR Papers (Fall 1960), n.p.
- (9.) Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 50. See Alfred Schuetz's reinterpretation of James's concept of sub-universes in 'On Multiple Realities', *Philosophy and Phenomenological Research*, vol. 5, no. 4 (June 1945), pp. 533-76. The distinction between 'tough-minded' and 'tender-minded' is James's. See William James, *The Principles of Psychology* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1981 [1890]) and *A Pluralistic Universe* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1977 [1909]). Several works by Peirce are cited by AKR in his essays: Charles Sanders Peirce, *Collected Papers*, 7 vols (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1931-58) and *Philosophical Writings of Peirce*, ed. Justus Buchler (New York: Dover, 1955 [1940]). See *CE*, pp. 44, 74, 156, 515, 556, 558, 562-3. For John Dewey, see also the section 'Aesthetic Experience and Aesthetic Object: Concepts' in Chapter 4 and Dewey, *Art as Experience*.
- (10.) Ramanujan quoted in Sangita P. Advani, 'A Whole World in a Poem', *Times of India*, Bombay (29 July 1990), p. 15.
- (11.) Ramanujan, 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' handwritten rough draft written for a lecture to be delivered at the seminar on the mind, organized by the Indo-US Subcommission, Delhi, AKR Papers (March 1993), n.p. The author did not attend the seminar due to ill health.
- (12.) Ramanujan, 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' n.p.

(13.) Stolnitz defined aesthetic attitude as 'disinterested and sympathetic attention to and contemplation of any object of awareness whatever, for its own sake alone'. See the section 'Aesthetic Experience and Aesthetic Object: Concepts' in Chapter 4.

(14.) Ramanujan, 'Love and Death in Mysore and Venice', unpublished lecture presented at the Second Workshop on the Person in South Asia, Life Courses and Family Relationships in Alternative Psychologies of South Asia, Chicago, AKR Papers (1981).

(15.) Ramanujan, 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' n.p.

(16.) A.K. Ramanujan, 'Indian Literatures in the U.S. 1957-1987', *American Understanding of India: A Symposium* (papers read at a conference held at the Library of Congress, 23-5 October 1986; convened in conjunction with the Festival of India 1985-6), ed. Louis A. Jacob (New Delhi: Manohar, 2001), p. 171.

(17.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Poetry', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.

(18.) Ramanujan, lecture draft for a talk on Gieve Patel, AKR Papers (6 August 1984), n.p.

(19.) Ramanujan, 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, p. 218.

(20.) An early paper that deals extensively with formalist linguistics and poetry is 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry', unpublished paper, AKR Papers (c. 1960). See also the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7.

(21.) Ramanujan, 'Love and Death in Mysore and Venice', p. 1.

(22.) Ramanujan, letter to David Shulman, AKR Papers (19 September 1984), n.p. The author referred to in brackets is Michael Polanyi who has written *The Tacit Dimension* (New York: Anchor Books, 1967).

(23.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *FI*, p. xxxi. See also the section 'Folk Aesthetics' in this chapter.

(24.) Ramanujan, 'The Condition of Music', unpublished draft of a poem, AKR Papers (18 January 1990), n.p.

(25.) Ramanujan, 'Love and Death in Mysore and Venice', pp. 2-4.

(26.) Ramanujan, 'Sanskrit and the Mother Tongue', unpublished lecture presented at the Association for Sanskrit Studies, AKR Papers (1987), n.p.

(27.) The relation between Sanskrit and Kannada in his education is described in some detail in the paper 'Sanskrit and the Mother Tongue'.

(28.) See also Pollock's comments in the prologue of his book, *The Language of the Gods in the World of Men*, p. xiv.

(29.) Ramanujan, 'Sanskrit Aesthetics', handwritten lecture paper, AKR Papers (1964). This lecture paper has been cited in the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4 in the context of the Sanskrit term *vasana*, 'the smell of the past'. Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', pp. 115-43. This co-authored essay has five sections, two by AKR and three by Gerow; sections from pp. 115-18 and 128-9 are by AKR. Specific observations in these essays pertaining to poetry are discussed in the section 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition' in Chapter 7.

(30.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', p. 128.

(31.) Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, p. 79.

(32.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', p. 129.

(33.) Whereas the published essay 'Indian Poetics' reproduces only fragments of AKR's earlier drafts, the handwritten text of 'Sanskrit Aesthetics' includes the paragraph quoted here, which closes the lecture paper with an early poem by the American poet Reed Whitemore (1919-2012).

(34.) For more details on the notions of poet as saint or prophet, see also the section on medieval *bhakti* aesthetics in this chapter.

(35.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', pp. 129-30.

(36.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', p. 129.

(37.) See Appendix 1 in this book.

(38.) Ramanujan, 'Bharata Natyam', unpublished draft of a poem, Belgaum Lingaraj College, AKR Papers (c. 1956), n.p.

(39.) Another earlier draft of this poem begins the last stanza with 'The Unreal's bursting life/ Is the dream of the real'. Ramanujan, 'The Dance', unpublished draft of a poem, AKR Papers (1952). See also the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4, on the dancer in Yeats's poem 'Among School Children'.

(40.) Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, pp. 73-95.

(41.) Ramanujan, 'Food Chain', in 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, pp. 74-5. AKR mentions under the poem the following source: 'After the Sanskrit, *Taittiriya Upanishad*, valli 2, anuvaka 2; trans. A.K. Ramanujan'. The Sanskrit poem is also quoted in 'Some Thoughts on "Non-Western" Classics', in *CE*, pp. 119-20, and in the uncollected essays 'On the "Unity" and "Diversity" of Indian Literatures', an

unpublished lecture presented at the 38th Frankfurt Book Fair (1986), and 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry', pp. 51–6.

(42.) Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, p. 75.

(43.) R.N. Rai, *Theory of Drama: A Comparative Study of Aristotle and Bharata* (New Delhi: Classical Publishing Company, 1992), p. 59.

(44.) Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, p. 92.

(45.) Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, p. 88. See also 'Men, Women, Saints', in *CE*, p. 280.

(46.) Arthur Antony McDonnell, trans. *Rig Veda* 10.125, *Vedic Mythology* (1887), p. 109, quoted in AKR's lecture notes, AKR Papers. It is to be noted that the word 'Soma' gained popularity in the West after the publication of Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932). In this famous book, 'Soma' is used in a pejorative sense to denote the drug that keeps the populace of the 'new world' under control.

(47.) *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad*, IV.4.3–4 quoted in Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Notions of Change', n.p. The essay 'Hanchi: A Kannada Cinderella' also speaks of 'nature's metamorphosis of caterpillars into butterflies'. Ramanujan, 'Hanchi: A Kannada Cinderella', in *CE*, p. 376. A different translation of this passage from the Upanishad reads thus:

Just as a leech (or caterpillar) when it has come to the end of a blade of grass, after having made another approach (to another blade), draws itself together towards it, so does this self, after having thrown away the body, and dispelled ignorance, after having another approach (to another body) draw itself together (for making the transition to another body).

Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan, trans. *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad*, IV.4.2, *The Principal Upanisads* (London: George Allen and Unwin, 1953), n.p.

(48.) Ramanujan, 'Indian Notions of Change', n.p.; underline in the original. The last phrase is a quote from the *Bhagavat Gita*, 2.22.

(49.) Ramanujan, untitled poetry draft, AKR Papers (c. 1970), n.p.

(50.) Ramanujan, 'Elements of Composition', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, pp. 121–3. This poem also echoes the poem on food cycles cited earlier, translated or trans-created by AKR from the *Taittiriya Upanishad*, 2.2.

(51.) Ramanujan in *FT*, pp. 228–9.

(52.) *Srsti* or 'creation' in Sanskrit literally means 'pouring forth'. See Ramanujan, 'Some Thoughts on "Non-Western" Classics: With Indian Examples', in *CE*, p. 119. The purusa myth appears in folk traditions and in the classical texts, including the *Brhadaranyaka Upanishad*. Creation myths are cited in Ramanujan, 'Some Thoughts on "Non-Western" Classics', in *CE*, pp. 118–22, 'The Prince Who Married His Own Left Half', in *CE*, p. 402, 'Who Needs Folklore?' in *CE*, p. 545, 'On Folk Mythologies and Folk Puranas', in *CE*, pp. 518–31, and 'Creation in Hindu Myth and Poetry', unpublished lecture paper presented at University of Rochester, AKR Papers (1987).

(53.) Ramanujan, 'Some Thoughts on Non-Western Classics', in *CE*, p. 119.

(54.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 October 1976), n.p. The two Sanskrit terms *prakriti* and *samskriti*, which can be roughly translated as 'nature' and 'culture', are written in Kannada script in the original.

(55.) On Whitman in AKR's poetics, see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(56.) *Mundaka Upanishad*, 3.1.1 quoted by Ramanujan in *CP*, p. 130. This phrase is also cited, explicitly or indirectly, in several papers from the 1980s. AKR writes in 'Repetition on the Mahabharata', which cites the Gita and a longer extract from the *Mundaka Upanishad*: 'In view of this way of thinking, the cast of characters can be divided into watchers and actors ... [illustrating] the ancient conception that the self has two aspects, a watching one (*saksin*) and an active one'. Ramanujan, 'Repetition in the Mahabharata', in *CE*, pp. 180–1. The *Mundaka Upanishad* is also quoted in the unpublished paper 'Creation in Hindu Myth and Poetry', pp. 11–12.

(57.) Ramanujan, 'Questions', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 130. A number of poems in *Second Sight* are connected by an end line to another poem, thus making up a larger sequence of interrelated poems. See the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8 of this book for more details on this poetic technique. See also Appendix 2 on the making of *Second Sight*.

(58.) See the biographical chronology in Chart 1.

(59.) Ramanujan, 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' n.p. On the concept of aesthetic attitude, see the sections 'Aesthetic Experience and Aesthetic Object: Concepts' in Chapter 4 and 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in this chapter.

(60.) Ramanujan, 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' n.p. This phrase is also quoted in the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 and 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7.

(61.) Ramanujan, 'Creation in Hindu Myth and Poetry', pp. 11–12.

(62.) This is also mentioned by his sister Saroja Krishnamurthi in an interview in Bangalore in 1998.

(63.) As indicated in earlier chapters of this book, AKR's complex aesthetic vision could also be studied in the light of the double or multiple personality found in many other contemporary writers such as Jorge Luis Borges. See also AKR's Kannada novella *Matthobhana Atmacharitre* cited earlier.

(64.) Ramanujan, 'Questions', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 130; see also 'The Watchers', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, pp. 137-8.

(65.) See, for example, Daniels-Ramanujan (ed.), 'An A.K. Ramanujan Story', in *The Oxford India Ramanujan*, pp. xii-xv.

(66.) For translations of the *Tolkappiyam* and studies of Tamil aesthetics and poetics, see Ilakkuvanar, *Tolkappiyam with Critical Studies* and Nayagam, *Landscape and Poetry*.

(67.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 45.

(68.) For instance, a well-known painting by American abstract expressionist artist Helen Frankenthaler from 1964 is titled 'Interior Landscape'. See also the related 'inscape' concept of Chilean artist Roberto Matta (1911-2002).

(69.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 314.

(70.) *Tolkappiyam*, p. 20 quoted by A.K. Ramanujan, 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, p. 203. AKR clarifies in this essay that later Tamil writers added 'flowers and kinds of running or standing water ... making a total of 14 slots under each landscape'. See *CE*, p. 203.

(71.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 237.

(72.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 286.

(73.) Ramanujan, *IL*, pp. 107-8. See also Ramanujan, 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, pp. 203-4.

(74.) Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 43.

(75.) Ramanujan, 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', in *CE*, p. 70.

(76.) Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 44.

(77.) Ramanujan, 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', in *CE*, pp. 71-2.

(78.) Ramanujan, 'The Relevance of Tamil Classical Poetry', unpublished lecture, Sir Ponnambalam Memorial Lecture, University of Jaffna, Sri Lanka, AKR Papers (1983), n.p.

(79.) See, in particular, the series of poems on art and aesthetics in Kannada and English analysed in the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4.

(80.) See also the sections 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3, 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' and 'Translation and Poetic Practice' in Chapter 8, and the biographical Chart 1.

(81.) Ramanujan, unpublished draft of a paper on 'Nature and Culture', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.

(82.) For more details on Tamil culture and poetry, see Xavier S. Thani Nayagam, *Tamil Culture and Civilisation* (Bombay: Asia Publishing House, 1970); Zvelebil, *The Smile of Murugan and Literary Conventions in Akam Poetry*; Ramanujan, *Encyclopedia Britannica* (1974), pp. 131-208; and T.R. Sharma, *Toward an Alternative Critical Discourse* (Shimla: Indian Institute of Advanced Study, 2000), pp. 87-110.

(83.) Ramanujan, 'Who Needs Folklore?' in *CE*, pp. 532-3. See also 'The Prince Who Married His Own Left Half', in *CE*, p. 411.

(84.) Ramanujan, 'Tell It to the Walls: On Folktales in Indian Culture', in *CE*, p. 463.

(85.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 56.

(86.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *FI*, p. xxx.

(87.) Ramanujan, 'Preface', in *FI*, p. xii.

(88.) Ramanujan, 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, p. 507.

(89.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *FI*, pp. xxxi-xxxii.

(90.) Ramanujan, 'Hanchi', in *CE*, p. 369.

(91.) Ramanujan, 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, pp. 508-9. On the topic of possession in poetry, see also AKR's essays on bhakti poetry in *HD*, *SoS*, and *CE*.

(92.) Ramanujan, 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, p. 512.

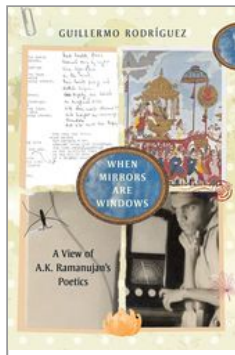
(93.) Ramanujan, 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, p. 512.

(94.) Ramanujan quoted in Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', p. 12.

(95.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar.

- (96.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 25.
- (97.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 103.
- (98.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 103.
- (99.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 39.
- (100.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 165.
- (101.) AKR alludes here to William Wordsworth's famous definition of poetry: '[T]he spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings: it takes its origin from emotion recollected in tranquillity'. See William Wordsworth, 'Preface', in R.L. Brett and A.R. Jones (eds), *Lyrical Ballads: Wordsworth and Coleridge* (London and New York: Routledge, 2005), p. 251.
- (102.) Ramanujan, *HD*, pp. 161-2.
- (103.) Ramanujan, *HD*, pp. 116, 161.
- (104.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 76.
- (105.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, pp. 31, 38. See also 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle', in *CE*, p. 309.
- (106.) Basavanna, *Vacana* 820, trans. A.K. Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 19. The poem is quoted in full in the section 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3.
- (107.) Basavanna, *Vacana* 500, trans. A.K. Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 38.

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Composing an Image

A.K. Ramanujan's 'Inner' Poetics

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Abstract and Keywords

This chapter delves into the self-reflexive domain of Ramanujan's poetics and shifts the analysis to the centre of the concentric circle by offering an overview of the author's interpretation of the act of writing poetry and of being a poet. The study of the author's 'inner' poetics therefore touches on subjective themes and criteria and first assesses how biographical factors such as Ramanujan's multilingual upbringing and multicultural experience, and his self-imposed 'exile' in the USA as a university professor, shaped his literary creativity. It then takes on his views on the art of composition and focuses on the constituents of the poetic act, that is, the concepts of poetry, poem, and poet. These are closely examined taking into account, among other texts, the interviews and private writings, as well as Ramanujan's poetry drafts, so as to delineate his poetics from the perspective of the poet rather than the scholar.

Keywords: multilingualism, poetry, poetics, modernist poetry, modern Indian poetry, Indian poetry in English

Images consult

one

another,

a conscience

stricken jury,

and come

slowly
to a sentence.

—A.K. Ramanujan, 'On the Death of a Poem', *Second Sight*

The 'Outer' and 'Inner' Spheres in Ramanujan's Poetics

The use of paradigms based on the Akam/Puram distinction to systematize AKR's poetics (such as inner/outer, private/public, artistic ideas/scholarly study) is in rapport with several practical and theoretical issues taken up in the next two chapters. 'Poetics', in its strict sense denoting a 'theory of poetry', is a term that can be applied to a system of poetry, an individual poet, the study of poetry, and a form of literary criticism. It can refer to ideas on poetry and poetic practice or, as in the Jakobsonian sense, imply the (linguistic) study of poetry. The Collins dictionary gives several definitions for this term: '(i). The principles and forms of poetry or the study of these, especially as a form of literary criticism[.] (ii). a treatise on poetry.' Likewise, *The Princeton Encyclopaedia on Poetry and Poetics* defines 'poetics' both as a general theory and as an individual ideal. It states, on the one hand, that 'Poetics is traditionally a systematic theory or doctrine of poetry' and affirms also that 'the ideal of the poetry that a poet may dream of or aim at may be called his poetics'. Accordingly, 'poetics' comprises **(p.207)** the personal dimension of a poet's poetic belief, the principles or theory of poetry in a particular tradition, and the scientific study of poetry and its criticism.¹

It follows that the inner/outer paradigm may serve to project the double concern with science and poetry in AKR. This distinction covers the objective dimension (poetry as an object, the forms of poetry) and the subjective perception of poetry (poetry as an event, experiential aesthetics), corresponding to the two main approaches to poetics that have existed in the West since ancient times. The inner-outer continuum with which AKR summarizes his life and work also entails that there are multiple points of connection between the scholar and the poet: while the former strives to be 'scientific' in his use of language, the latter wants to be sensitive to feelings and aesthetic emotions and to the immediate context of time and place.²

The nature of the primary sources allows, too, for an inner/outer or Akam/Puram analysis, since the miscellaneous types of primary material tend to be either public or private in purpose and style of expression. This does not necessarily imply that the different text types constitute independent categories (in function, form, or style), for in some texts the purpose is unclear or ambiguous at the time of writing, and one sphere (public or private) often includes the other. That is, there are private writings with a potential reader in the background, and published writings that are autobiographical and self-reflexive, as is sometimes the case with poetry. Thus, the inner/outer approach not only facilitates an overview of the entire spectrum of primary sources to identify the nature or genre of Ramanujan's texts, it also helps illustrate interconnections between the

diverse texts and an underlying continuity and integrity of thought. Inner and outer suggest a continuum in thought and practice and a metonymical view of the world (see also the section ‘Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage’ in Chapter 2).

AKR studied, taught, described, and translated various poetic traditions, but kept most of his explicit personal views on poetry and theory of poetry as well as his poetry in English out of his scholarly prose.³ In the scholarly essays and papers, which abound with translations and commentaries of Indian poetry, there are only rare instances with self-reflexive comments on what *poetry* and *being a poet* meant for AKR and on how *the poetic act* is understood. As he did not publish any prose piece on his poetic belief or his ideas as a ‘practising’ contemporary poet, it is mainly in the private writings (**p.208**) and interviews and poems that we hear the ‘inner’ voice of the poet. In the scholarly prose, his theory of poetry is generally present as an implicit, second-order expression or reflection.

The diverse primary sources on poetics that I have scrutinized in this study—essays, lecture notes and private prose, poems, and interviews (see Appendix 1)—yield complementary viewpoints, types of content matter, and treatment of art and poetry. Viewed as a whole, the textual sources exposing AKR’s poetics can be described as a many-coloured mosaic. This mosaic is not static, but highly intertextual. As we glance from text to text, it turns into a kaleidoscope that changes forms and directions. The entry point into AKR’s poetic universe can be the academic disciplines and theories that the author absorbed creatively and applied to the study of poetry and poetics, or the diaries and journals in which he recorded his feelings, commonplace thoughts, experiences, dreams, and poetic exercises. If we were to extend this concentric pattern of ‘inner’ and ‘outer’ to AKR’s poetic writing process and to his entire creative output, we could also study how his ‘original’ drafts of poetry (in English and Kannada) shift from Akam to Puram: from (self-)reflexive private notes and scribbles in his notebooks and diaries containing his inner world of private experiences, musings, and observations, to the public domain of published poetry.⁴ Part of this process works by adding a self-protective public mask and filtering out the autobiographical ‘I’ elements in carefully revised poems. In fact, on several occasions, for example in his correspondence with Chirantan Kulshrestha and in the diaries, the author expresses the concern of his poems being too autobiographical.

It is, therefore, with caution that the outer and inner paradigms are to be applied as rigid critical categories in AKR’s poetics, since they are closer to *permeable* layers that overlap. In his organic network of forms, AKR does not want to ‘categorize’ his disciplines, for they originate from the same creative source in his self: ‘I seem to be doing the same thing in all the disciplines. The notion that there is a line to be drawn between different interests is not true.

Everything we have and know is part of the instrument.’⁵ So his expressions as a scholar and poet must not be seen as representing two separate compartments, but as two approaches in a concentric system: ‘My intellectual life and my emotional life are not two different things. I don’t want to draw that sort of line,’ said AKR in a 1993 interview.⁶ Nonetheless, he often described his work and existence in terms of **(p.209)** such and other kinds of dualism (see the section ‘Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy’ in Chapter 5).

As in the Tamil poetics of Akam and Puram, in AKR’s thought ‘the inner and the outer are expressions of one another; the scene and the agent, each containing the other, are related in intimate metonymy’.⁷ Examples of this scene-agent or Akam-Puram confluence in AKR’s creative writing are also found in his Kannada short stories. In ‘Annaiah’s Anthropology’, an Indian anthropologist in America encounters in a textbook pictures of his relatives in India performing the funeral rites of his father, whose death he was unaware of. The picture had been taken by an American anthropologist in his south-Indian home town. This is partly autobiographical: though AKR had not yet migrated to the USA when his father died, he refused to perform the funeral rites.⁸ Indeed, the private world (Akam) occasionally moved to the public domain (Puram) of his essays and short stories, in the same way as public discussion and academic debate seeped into his private journals.⁹

While AKR’s ‘outer’ aesthetics and poetics are classified according to cultural categories (videshi/Western, marga/Sanskritic, desi/regional) the systematization of his ‘inner’ poetics follows a thematic classification. As we move into the self-reflexive domain of AKR’s poetics and to the elements of the creative act, the focus of analysis shifts to the centre of the concentric circle, that is, towards the self, the poet, and his art. In this assessment of AKR’s ideas on poetry, being a poet and writing poetry, the topics under study cover biographical factors and the different constituents of the poetic act, that is, the act of writing and performing a poem, or the art of composition.

Biographical Factors and Poetic Creation

AKR did not pose as a writer who had to live up to a certain type of life in order to produce interesting work. He rather believed that a poet is a poet only in the act of composition. Though he led a simple life and shunned the political or prophetic pretensions of a peculiar breed of poets with too much self-esteem (poets with a capital ‘P’, as he called them), AKR lived his life intensely and created a poetic world that was nourished by a complex psychology and multilayered cultural and linguistic grid. The ‘innocence’ he yearned for was the unforeseen aesthetic experience, caused by the particular effects of a commonplace sight on his poetic sensibility—like the fountain at Harding Circle he **(p.210)** observed as a teenager in Mysore, which made no ‘headlines’, but ‘stared’ at poets every day and inspired his ‘second poem’, as he wrote in his 1949 journal (see the section ‘Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR’s

Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4).¹⁰ One of AKR's perhaps unattainable dreams was to integrate in his poems all the complexities and contradictions of life, and to unfold them as ordinary routine acts: 'May 30, 1984. My dream is to write some poetry, verse, every day—include in it my entire world ... mythology, scepticism, sensuality, ineptitude, divorce, impotent obsessions-deaths.'¹¹ There are two essential themes, however, that are treated extensively in his private prose and interviews, and have a prominent bearing on his poetics: (a) the condition of living away from his homeland; and (b) his multilinguistic background.

Self-Exile and Journeying

AKR did not see himself as a writer in exile. He cultivated an ironic viewpoint about exile and cultural roots through most of his life. This was quite untypical among Indian poets writing in English during the post-Independence years. To write about himself and his culture with ironic understatement implied an aesthetic and/or physical distance from the cultural make-up. Before he left for the USA, this sophisticated insider-outsider perspective was nurtured by the socio-religious nonconformity and experiential attitude to life of the medieval mystic bhakti poets, and the modernist stance of the twentieth-century Western poets and rationalist intellectuals he studied at college and read profusely in his youth. The irony and mystical wit AKR first discovered in these literary sources was gradually refined as an existential and poetic attitude during his self-imposed academic 'exile' in the USA, where he developed an integral approach to art and experience in line with the American pragmatist thinkers (see the section 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5). His frequent physical, intellectual, and metaphorical crossings between India and the USA, the intermittent connections and departures, allowed him to become both the natural insider and consummate outsider in his academic and poetic career.

When AKR boarded the ship and left the shores of his motherland for the first time in 1959, he was already aware that the 'journey itself, the seed's self-exile', would become the turning point of his life and one of the defining metaphors of his art and existence (see also the sections 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3 and **(p.211)** 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4):

But then, every journey is a disentanglement, a flutter of adieus among the mast ropes. You settle old scores with yourself by going away, by tearing up letters, by identifying yourself again and again for passport or visa or the slightly obscene self-baring before a completely clad doctor. You have signed on dotted lines scores of times; pigeonholed your past on a dozen forms that sift your facts from your vanities. You forget the guilt of unanswered letters and feel the very last twinge when an old coat-pocket turns up the image of an unattended wedding—she has three children now. You tear up not only letters—but even your food habits, your notions of

time: it dawns so differently in the Atlantic fog, and the sun cheats your tropic watches by setting behind the Seine at 9.30. Even the shape of bread changes.

As one is disengaged from the family, the familiar, everything puts on the stranger-look of a symbol. The journey itself, the seed's self-exile, the salt estranging sea. The towboat, the guy ropes, the receding wharf with its belittled crowd, its motley of mothers and wives, waiting for the emptiness. The sudden need for telescopes....¹²

The voyage into unknown 'emptiness', the act of disentangling from 'the familiar', and the 'sudden' change of viewpoint, observing the domestic (Akam) from a distance as objects through a telescope, had indeed far-reaching implications for the poet. The journey started a half-conscious process of construing new relations and relationships in which to locate the self. It also entailed a habit of drifting into the unknown 'other' with a natural curiosity, which valued the quality of experience above all. Yet AKR never lost sight of the Indian starting point: India. All the while during this process, looking at old things from new angles and at newness or 'otherness' from old perspectives, was a way of keeping his identity in constant motion. The journey, or rather journeying, was by no means a break with the past, the family and the familiar, but triggered a dialogue and exchange within the diverse strands of his personality and art. It enabled transactions with the past and with 'the other', which brought forth creativity as well as failures. As AKR put it in one of his poems: 'As I transact with the past as with another/ country with its own customs, currency,/ stock exchange, always/ at a loss when I count my change: ...' (16-19).¹³ The perfect transaction, the literal translation, was an impossible act, 'a pursuit of failure', as AKR was fond of describing it.¹⁴ To map oneself onto another culture, language, or country was in this sense a flawed, **(p.212)** yet deeply creative, give-and-take across many borders (see also Chapter 8). In fact AKR's poetry as well as his private prose projected no 'border-disputes',¹⁵ but a resourceful tension and continuity of forms. Alienation and exile were discourses that AKR disapproved of in criticism of IPE. The location of the poet's self, according to AKR, was not to be stressed (physically or emotionally) in terms of displacement, nostalgia, and identity search, but rather be seen as a system, a confluence of multiple 'presences and absences'.¹⁶ The points of convergence 'beyond time and place' were best manifested in the act of writing poetry. A poet and his work could not be pinned down to a set of 'postcolonial' critical clichés, as AKR used to stress in the interviews:

The words 'alien' or 'exile' seem to me to be sentimental ways of thinking about myself. The whole question of roots is not relevant to me.... I'm not studying Kannada and Tamil so that I can have roots. They are the way I think, and I think in them. India is me, and with me. I live in two worlds at least, if not more. I'm constantly in touch with Kannada and English

writers, in addition to writing in these languages, so it's not as if India is a subject or object, something out there. I'm not a physicist living in America, I'm someone deeply involved in Indian civilisation, studying it all the time....¹⁷

I think terms like 'identity crisis, alienation, exile' are only fashionable words employed by critics and students seeking to analyse our writing ... for one thing, I am no exile. I am intimately connected with Kannada and Tamil literature. And my poetry does not exploit the purely physical fact of living in another country.... The fact that I happen to be born in India and am constantly preoccupied with Indian themes should not militate against my poetic being. Like any of my accomplished contemporaries in Indo-English creativity, my poems are rooted in a certain time and place and always seek to go beyond that time and place.¹⁸

One of the good things, maybe, of living abroad is that you become deeply aware and sensitive to the cultural construction of yourself.

And it is not just distance alone that makes you what you are because you are always with yourself after all—your past, your memories, your cultural conditioning are always there.¹⁹

Thus, living away from India since the age of 30 and interacting with India from the USA was, in effect, a creative resource for AKR as a poet. His 'double experience' (see the sections 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3, 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals (p.213) and Diaries' in Chapter 4, and 'Translation and Poetic Practice' in Chapter 8) was always present in his work and is undoubtedly a defining feature of his poetics and aesthetics.

Multiple Languages

The most visible and accountable site for transaction, confluence, and dialogue were, as we have seen, the various languages which coexisted in AKR's life and work and made up his rich repertoire. In AKR's informal discussions on the languages and their relation to the writing of poetry, several interrelated aspects are highlighted.

Multilingualism and Writing

Around 1980, AKR wrote in his notecards a self-study titled 'On the Need for Linguistic Autobiography'. This schematic 'linguistic autobiography' mapped in several charts AKR's competence (speaking, reading, writing) in various languages (English, Kannada, Tamil, Sanskrit, and French), his use of English, Kannada, and Tamil in different contexts, and his relationship to these languages in a diachronic and hierarchical order.²⁰ In the case of writing verse, the first and second languages in terms of preference were, respectively, English and Kannada, whereas for fiction Kannada came first, followed by English. From a chronological perspective, however, Kannada was marked as his first literary

language. AKR reveals in the 1978 letter to Vrinda Nabar that he started writing poetry in Kannada at the age of 14: 'A couple of years later, I did begin to scribble in English, kept diaries etc. I had by now read Dylan Thomas (thanks to Bhogishayana) and Hopkins—and wrote a couple of Dylan-ish exercises.'²¹ As to his interest in novels and poetry, the notecards confirm that he first started reading literature in Kannada (mostly fiction), then in English at the age of 14, and in Tamil at 16. He began to read and appreciate poetry in English at about 17. This linguistic self-assessment and other notes on the topic prove that AKR was constantly attentive to his multilingual condition. Multilingualism appears to have impinged deeply on his practice of writing, and most of the interviews include unequivocal comments on how the multiple languages inevitably affected his poetic creativity.

AKR also felt that being a multilingual speaker and writer could be a handicap of some sort, as it did not allow for the kind of unity that **(p.214)** a monolingual could achieve in a native language. One of the diary entries is rather circumspect about the advantages or disadvantages of using several languages:

Aug. 4, 1982

... Problems: while one feels the riches of three languages in oneself, as one searches for 'the full language experience,' one may feel cheated and fragmented, jack-of-three-languages but master of none. One longs to be, idealises the monolingual who seems whole at least in his language—without none of the discontinuities of first, second and third languages, each vying to be first, yet each specialising (so it seems) in an area of one's experience. One desperately tries then to keep up with the writers and speakers of all three—in vain.

Language-panic—

'consulted my selves'

But in poetry (or fiction etc.) one wants ideally a language that cores every facet of experience.

Multilingualism is in any case not a conscious state in the creative act, as AKR made clear. When writing in one of the languages, there is no 'awareness' of the presence of the other two though they are 'part of the instrument'.²² Hence, in the act of writing, AKR prefers to qualify his condition as a 'multiple monolingual':

Fortunately, when one writes, one isn't troubled by these questions. I've written poems and attempted a novel in Kannada—and written without any linguistic border-disputes with English.

So, too when I write in English, there's no Kannada or Tamil present—at least in my awareness as I write. One feels like a monolingual in each of these two languages (fortunately, I've never tried to write creatively in Tamil).

I feel then like an alternating multiple monolingual, rather than multi-lingual—maybe, that's what people mean by that kind of word.

None of this says anything about the quality of that writing.²³

Language, Interaction, and Choice

AKR often explained how he grew up in several languages, each 'specializing' in a particular 'area of experience' and simultaneously engaging the other in a continuous dialogue. The natural coexistence and interaction of languages found a professional continuity in his trilingual translation work and bilingual writing. The practice of reading and writing in Kannada and English in such dissimilar cultural contexts as India and the USA brought to AKR's poetic creativity a **(p. 215)** degree of code-switching and exchange (structural, stylistic, thematic, etc.) that is yet to be addressed by critics of his work in English and Kannada. Though AKR felt like an 'alternating monolingual' in each of the languages he wrote in, it was not his aim to separate them: 'All my writing, of course, is concerned with the three languages I have. These three I carry with me wherever I go and they are constantly interacting. And everything I do has to respond to some part of this interaction. Whether it is to write in English or translate or write in Kannada.'²⁴ AKR refers especially to a cultural, rather than purely linguistic, interface between the three languages he worked in. The dialogue between his literary languages reflected a process that was both unconscious and conscious.

How then did the poet select the language of writing? He believed that the use of one language or another was determined by a complex combination of personal, cultural, and contextual factors. Writing a poem in a particular language was not a question of choice or control, as poems could not be willed into one language or another. They were triggered by a particular situation. As can be inferred from AKR's diaries and interviews, the choice of language turned into such a persistent issue that an entire anthology of interconnected quotes could be compiled around this topic. It is interesting to note how each of the extracts selected here chronologically adds a nuance to this question, as it gets more intricate and exposes central aspects of his writing process.²⁵

I happen to be an Indian writing in English. It just happens that English is the language of my excitement at times. I have no theories about whether Indians should or can write in English. I do not think that we can choose the language we write in, any more than we can choose the poems that happen to us. (1966)

The language of one's writing is not a matter of choice. Poems don't come to you abstractly and then you ask: 'Shall I write in Tamil, English, or Kannada? Which is the best language for this?' (1970)

... You don't *choose* the language of the poem, it comes with its own language ... I am never quite in control of my languages. For one thing, they are always in a state of change, altering, in the process, one's idiom and one's way of perceiving things other than language. (1981)

... 3 languages: to use and reconcile these three has been my full-time occupation: write in English, and some in Kannada, translate from both **(p. 216)** Kannada and Tamil into English, and to write in such a way that my English or Kannada or Tamil are not sealed from each other. Yet the language of writing is not a matter of choice. A long and complex personal and other kinds of history chooses the language for us—one even feels, the language chooses us. A poem doesn't come in the abstract to ask you, 'you know three languages, in which will you write me?' (13 April 1982)

I don't think poems can choose their language. You choose it after it has come to you, anyway. That is, you may use certain kinds of metrical elements or forms. But even those, ultimately, even those corrections have somehow to come to you. (1982)

I don't think one chooses a language to write poetry in, as one chooses a tool or a weapon. It is determined by a complex set of personal and cultural circumstances. The language of one's poetry (by which I don't mean merely the words) is not a matter of self-conscious or calculated choice. For instance, every now and then I write poems in Kannada for weeks without quite knowing why.

... It's the same with subjects. Poems interrupt linguistics and anthropology, and vice versa. (1983)

It's simply a matter of what language you are immersed in at a given time. If I receive a lot of Kannada books and spend two or three months studying them, I automatically begin to think in Kannada, and am likely to write poems in that language, though this is not a hard and fast rule. Sometimes, even when I'm writing in English, an image or two from Kannada or Tamil may strike me. (1990)

Writing in the English Language

As a linguist, AKR was conscious about the limitations and advantages of writing poetry in a language that was not his mother tongue. He therefore attached a lot of importance to being able to regenerate his English language as a non-native speaker, as much as he exploited the interface of English with the Indian languages and traditions at a deeper level of his creative writing. He details this

mutually enriching dialogic process between his languages in the following two interviews:

... I want to write the language as fully as possible as it exists. That is very important to me when I work in English.... But then the problem with English is that I have also had to escape that, a clichéd native speech, somehow. Because, as all poets know, if you live too long in the living language your **(p.217)** language becomes clichéd. Somehow you have to renew it. It is current but not necessarily expressive. When I am writing in English I am also writing at the same time about my so-called Indian experience, my personal experiences for which it is often very hard to find words in English. But I still have to express it, I am constantly preoccupied with Indian folktales, Indian customs, all kinds of things.... Still, when I am writing in English, I won't publish anything unless I feel this has said something which is true to me. And if it has to be true to me it has to be true to this double experience I have—my living in this country or this point of view I have and my Indian experience—because that experience is not something left behind, it's still here, still going on, both in my family and in the way I think and in my studies.²⁶

Indian English when it is good does get its nourishment from ... each individual's knowledge of Indian culture and Indian languages. Certainly it does for me. I don't know if it shows or not.... I don't know if it makes poetry better or worse.

... [M]y English has affected my knowledge of Indian languages and my knowledge of Indian languages has affected my English language.... It has given me intimacy and a kind of aesthetic distance.²⁷

If AKR exhibited a sophisticated control of the English language in his poetry, it was not only because he was a proficient speaker of English, but also due to his being a linguist in English and Dravidian languages, which made him aware of the strengths and weaknesses of his use of the language. He concedes, for instance, in the interview with Malayalam poet and critic Ayyappa Paniker, that his sense of stress and rhythm of the English language was not as natural as that of a native speaker, yet this peculiarity could be used as a resource in poetry.²⁸ Ultimately, though, for him writing good poetry in a particular language was not a matter of being aware of its linguistics, but part of a more complex artistic process: 'The language (English etc.) of a poem is not a matter of conscious problem solving and New Year's Day resolutions. If you have a problem, it shows in your work. No amount of thinking about grammar and idiom can resolve these problems because you are not putting together a composition. You are actively composing—or decomposing.'²⁹

The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition

AKR's reflections on the process of poetic composition can be assessed in its practical aspects (poetic craft, writing technique, and revision) **(p.218)** and also concerning the intangible elements in the art of poetry. That is, in regard to the importance assigned by the author to an inner source (imagination) or an external source (inspiration or 'grace') as the origin of poetic creation. Accordingly, AKR's conception of the *poet* as a skilled craftsman, as an active creator-self or as a passive instrument—as well as a combination of these—can be examined on the basis of his prose writings and by providing practical examples of his poetic method.

The Body-Tree: Concept of Poetry

AKR's notion of poetry and the poetic event is closely interconnected with his ideas of art and creativity (Chapters 4 and 5). In his aesthetic thought, art and life are interdependent spheres, for one tends to 'imitate' the other. Art is perceived as an experience of the fragmentary presence, that is, of the particular detail and the elusive 'here and now', and at the same time art is 'remade' and received as a 'formal' experience. As someone imbued in the Tamil aesthetic tradition, AKR is also concerned with the relation between nature and culture. In coherence with the writer's aesthetics, the chief concerns in his conceptualization of poetry pertain to: the interrelation between poetry, life, and nature; the significance of particulars and the immediate experience in poetic expression; and poetry as form.

Poetry, Life, and Nature

Poetry and life are inseparable and intimately related in AKR's thought; one is creatively integrated into the other, as they go hand in hand. Poetry is the central metaphor of his self and the principal means of self-discovery and self-expression. It is seen as the nodal point of his activity as a writer, person, scholar, and intellectual. In the course of his career, poetry became a way of thinking and a mode of perceiving life. There is a nurturing link between the two which can take mysterious turns, for poetry reflects as well as refracts life and can change or affect it in often unpredictable circumstances. In a footnote to the posthumously published poem 'He to Me or Me to Him',³⁰ AKR clarifies that it was inspired by a real case of a contemporary Tamil poet who attempted to take his life after reading the mystic vachanas AKR had translated. It was only 10 years later, while translating poems by this Tamil poet, that AKR learnt how his **(p.219)** poetry translations had changed someone else's life; he was awed that the medieval poets had bounced back at him in such an accidental way. It was such and many other 'accidents' in life/poetry that made AKR believe in his dictum: 'Poetry contains, transforms, and returns our reality to us, and us to reality, in oblique ways.'³¹

In AKR's poetics, the creative cycle of poetry is as natural as breathing air or ingesting food, for poetry, as the mirror-window of the chain of life, passes through all 'elements of composition' of which life is made. According to this

poetic belief, the art of 'composition' (that is, the poetic act) takes part in the never-ending process of creation and incarnation, which includes the natural elements, physical body, poet, poem, and reader in a transformative aesthetic experience. This circulating organic process is a fundamental metaphor of AKR's poetics of metamorphosis, and is expressed, for instance, in poems like 'Elements of Composition' and 'A Meditation'. In the latter, the speaker is made into a walnut tree during 'a mediation', which turns into a nightmare when the walnut tree is chopped down and becomes a wooden table, a chair, and eventually the paper on which the poet is writing the poem. Thus, in the course of this transformational chain the poem is created on his very 'body':

...
I know I'm writing now on my head,
now on my torso, my living
hands moving

on a dead one, a firm imagined body
working with the transience
of breathless
real bodies. (34-40)³²

The poet is a passive witness of how his body is transformed by human action from nature (a tree) into a writing desk, a chair, and paper, which represent 'culture' and poetry. Poetry sustains and mediates between imaginary and real 'bodies'. We are also reminded that, in the author's poetic vision the origin of poetry is associated with nature. 'Poetry,' as AKR liked to say, 'has its ecology. Poems involve more than poems.'³³ His favourite natural image for poetry is the 'topsy-turvy' Tree of Life (see the sections 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3 and 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4) which has its roots in **(p.220)** the air, and is equally a metaphor of the human body and the body poetic.³⁴ 'A Meditation' is also a good example of AKR's notion of poetry as an organic continuum incorporating various traditions, transformations, and 'translations'. Published posthumously in *The Black Hen*, it is a re-creation in English of one of his late Kannada poems. An unpublished draft in the AKR Papers has an ending that differs from the published poem and includes two lines ('My body is a shrine,/ My legs are pillars,') from a famous vachana, translated by AKR from the medieval Kannada, which epitomize the jangama (moving) aspect of bhakti poetics (see the section 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7). Thus, AKR's unfinished version of this 'meditation' poem literally and figuratively invokes the bhakti poets who were seized by Siva, the ever-transforming and recycling dancing god of creation and destruction.

Centuries ago, they said,
My body is a shrine,
My legs are pillars,

I didn't know till now,
And they didn't know then,
I was a phrase from their poem,
A fiction made on their lips,
As they are now, here, on mine.³⁵

The 'ecology' of the poem breaks down the division between nature and culture, the artist and the work, the maker and the made, the past and the present, the translator and the translated, form and content, and the real and the imaginary. There is a continuity between these categories which informs AKR's cyclical 'nature-culture' poetics. But where does the cycle begin and where does it end, and what keeps the poetic process going? The tree image, with the fruit in its branches and the seeds in the fruit containing potential future trees, is a recurring personal metaphor for poetry in AKR. Besides being used as a cultural symbol found in folklore and mythology, it represents the potential of the creative spirit that resides in the poet in nature and which sometimes awakens to fulfil the poetic act. After a trip to Jaffna, Sri Lanka, in 1983, where AKR rediscovered his early interest in Buddhism, he wrote a rough draft of a poem titled 'Poetry' that gives the following definition:

(p.221) *Poetry*

Fruit of the nothing tree
blind orange bombs
pointed with names
of blueblack nations
stencilled with white serial numbers
falls into the blind wait
earthworm mounds
fertilized by earthworms dead and alive
keeps back its seeds full of branches
secreting more nothing trees
secreting many more nothing trees
for monkeys, bluejays, black ant colonies
serried with aphid slaves
milkmen of the plant world
living in the moist crevices
of poor sleeping children
mouths and eyes
waiting to be eaten
by anguish consolations and earthworms
in 'approximate worlds', null moments,
very much like our own earth
 orange flattened at both ends
 ...
 on a wobbly axis
made from the wood of the nothing tree³⁶

The poem expands the metaphor of the infinite trees in the orange of the gypsy proverb in AKR's early 'Poem on Particulars' from *The Striders* (see the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3). Life, poetry—the entire chain of creation—is in an eternal flux of birth and destruction, which, according to Buddhist belief, originates and ends in zero ('approximate worlds'), a figure that permeates AKR's poetics and latter poems. Creation, the created, needs to destroy to keep up the cycle of life and death. Just as poetry can bring forth life and words, it can also threaten its creator and the reader, for no act of creation is completely controllable, as it does not belong to its maker:

(p.222)

...

Nothing was left of them,
not even a bone.

Poetry too is a tigress,
except there's no fifth
man left on a tree
when she takes your breath

away. (73-8)³⁷

The poet, like the wise men (the 'Brahmins' who play at creation), in 'No Fifth Man', is devoured by the creature he has created. Often invoked as a muse, dancer, or goddess, the vision of poetry may turn against the poet and become a nightmare, or even death. Poetry 'must come as leaves/ to a tree/ or not at all' (1-3), but it sometimes reveals itself as a ghostly animal or daemon to frighten, or kill, its creator:

...

Yet it comes sometimes
as the black hen
with the red round eye ...

and when it's all there
the black hen stares
with its round red eye

and you're afraid (4-6, 10-13)³⁸

Poetry of Particulars and Immediate Experience

The timeless 'here and now' of aesthetic perception and the objectivity that AKR yearned for in poetry evolved in his thought into a context-sensitive poetics of particulars: 'One lives only in particulars', he repeatedly observed (see also the section 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5).³⁹ To pay attention to the fragmentary, the reality of 'things' which can be sensed, and to distrust abstract

ideas, was the credo the poet clung to throughout his career, and it seeped deep into his academic thinking too: 'The search for universals blinds one to the richness of the text....'⁴⁰ However, that 'truth is in fragments', **(p.223)** as AKR proclaimed in the poem 'Connect!'⁴¹ is not a conclusion that is easily arrived at. As illustrated (literally and visually) in the 'Poem on Particulars', one of the consequences of this honest enterprise is to observe and pick, one by one, the varied fruits that make it into the market and originate from the imperfect 'Fall-minded' bud in the tree. In such a 'natural' framework, the poet is only an acute eyewitness of the bustle of life and carves meaning out of the details of ordinary experience. More often than not, AKR had to admit that poetry is daily routine, for 'poets are only specialists in what everybody does all the time'.⁴² For instance, in the poem 'Daily Drivel: A Monologue', the speaker begins by listing all the ordinary things he did while his wife was at the theatre, that is, among other things, write a poem about it: 'while I scattered my hours/ on the wind not even wishing/ they were precious seed/ that could sprout a harvest/ by springtime' (23-7).⁴³ Hence, the secret of poetry lies in paying close attention to the scattered moments of ordinary life, for even a 'thrown-away seed' may blossom into a poem:

I have known
that measly-looking man,
not very likeable, going to the bank
after the dentist,
catching a cold
at the turn of the street
sitting at the window of the local bus,
suddenly make
(between three crossings and the old
woman at the red light)
a poem.

Which reminds me
of the thrown-away seed
of the folktale tree
filling with child the mangy palace dog
under the window,
leaving the whole royal harem
barren.⁴⁴

And then, when the seed of an experience or idea sprouts into a poem, it also has to be 'true' to its author.⁴⁵ AKR maintained that genuine poetry never leaves one unaffected. It involves a passage **(p.224)** from one state into another, a qualitative shift from the darkness of dull life to a new realm, an insight caused by an intense, sometimes extreme, experience, which changes our way of perceiving the world:

I think (poetry) affects people by being poetry, by making one fully experience in language what one experiences only dimly. That kind of clarity or intensity of experience is something that could be an agent of change. Poetry often takes us through difficult experiences....

Therefore to read poetry deeply would be a subtle way of educating our sensibility, our way of seeing or feeling.... Poetry may take us to places where we do not normally go.⁴⁶

Poetry as Form

AKR explained poetry as an experience in which content and form cannot be perceived separately: 'Ultimately you have to find the form such that if it wasn't in that form you wouldn't know the content.'⁴⁷ The intellectual framework that sustains this argument and the different approaches to poetry as a formal system in AKR can be traced to both Indian poetics and Western formalism (see the sections 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' and 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7). Apart from his academic papers, AKR's scientific interest in formalism and the formal structure of poetry in particular is also corroborated in the private writings and interviews in which he discusses poetics. In another insightful interview published in 1983, AKR confesses that one of his oldest concerns as a poet is the 'form of poetry':

Not just the rhymes or count of syllables but the way it begins and ends and gathers a certain clarity. Content does not come independently of form. The meaning goes on changing with the form. In fact there is a point where you begin to feel that the form itself is the meaning of the poem....

I would go further than that, I would say that the meaning is in the form. The particular nuance is what you experience; you are not looking for some big thought. Even the biggest thought must come to you in a particular form; it must be embodied. The how is as much the what as the what.⁴⁸

The notion of form being content is, of course, neither a novel idea nor an original contribution in Western or Indian poetics; but AKR was a pioneer, among Indian poets writing in English and contemporary Kannada poets, in using natural speech and twisting a particular nuance in everyday experience to make the 'ordinary' look aesthetic. **(p.225)** He borrowed the Austrian writer Karl Kraus's metaphor of poetic language as a sought-after 'virgin' to describe the act of writing in any language as a struggle to say what has never been said before (see the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7). In the poetic process, ordinary language needs to be renewed so that familiar situations and expressions are sensed as if they were first-time experiences. When the poet intensifies a particular expression in a moment of insight, the language is ideally charged to its maximum without losing the appearance of natural speech:

The poet is a specialist in what everybody does every now and then. You are talking to me. You turn witty, you tell me a story, you make a new phrase. Suddenly a phrase begins to sing, and everybody notices it. And then you pass on to something more ordinary. Poets are more consistent about it. They have to make every phrase sing. Poetry intensifies words; from one point of view, it is minimal utterance; from another, maximal. You can feel the temperature of the thing—if the word is right. So poetry is language that has not been used before—intense, creative, imaginative. And yet it is ordinary language, not a thing apart. It is this paradox that interests me. I want my poems ultimately to sound as though I spoke them.⁴⁹

Therefore, the form in poetry is not only in the language nor in the ‘elements of a story, plot, character and so on’. The question is, ultimately, what the poet makes out of all he has: ‘[I]f he can create in the poem a unity of impression, (he) has achieved the discipline of form’.⁵⁰

Fruit of Nothingness: The Poem

In AKR’s poetic credo, poems and words are presented as objects or animate beings and sometimes take on animal or human qualities. In some instances, the poem is imagined to be ‘clear as crystal, but opaque/ and starred with shatter-lines’.⁵¹ ‘Glass’ is a common metaphor used by AKR to describe the qualities of transparency, reflexivity, and refraction that can be attributed to a poem and its making.⁵² On the other hand, poems can also come to life and be like tiny insects, or different types of reptiles, which suddenly swirl into our lives and imagination. In AKR’s short imagistic poems, which abound in his early collection *The Striders*, poems are shown as animate entities with a concrete physical presence and extraordinary qualities: ‘When I feel they are any good, I imagine them to be like the striders (little water-insects) riding between water and sky. “Striders” (p.226) is a somewhat grand-sounding name for a little bug, which for all its little-ness (because of it?) can walk on water; no, it is not only prophets who can do that.’⁵³

That is why AKR, under the spell of the Imagists, arranged some of the poems in *The Striders* to look like animals, plants, or objects on the page.⁵⁴ He wanted the reader to have a visual sense-impression of the syntactic structure he had so carefully arranged. He believed, with Pound, that a poem should be a ‘quarry of ideas’.⁵⁵ Thus, a poem was a concrete linguistic, dramatic, and visual enactment of a particular idea or insight: ‘I want poems to be everything, with all that a language has to offer ... I find that some of our writers write as though they are not in possession of their five senses.’⁵⁶ To write with all the senses was not an easy task, but it was the basis of the ideal poem which poets should strive for:

Nov 25, 1979

A poem should have the immediacy of a sensation, the intensity of a personal prejudice, the generality of a principle. Poems often manage to have one or another of these three, rarely all three. How does one get there?

I added sensation because it cannot be paraphrased, can only be represented by itself; though a poem is made of words, it should baffle words, similarly.⁵⁷

Consequently, it is not enough to have just content and enactment, the poem has to be able to move the reader 'without an extra word'. In this vein of thought, AKR wrote the following draft of 'Haiku' about the translation of another haiku:

I once helped a friend translate a haiku
which said,

The map was small.
When I looked up from it,
Spring was gone.

When the haiku was done,
we felt a chill:
a quarrel

without an extra word,
a crack in an old flute
in new hands. (1-11)⁵⁸

(p.227) This meta-composition makes clear why AKR was so fond of writing and translating short image poems. It is the sense-impression, not the words, what needs to be conveyed (that is, 'translated', carried over) to the reader. Like a Japanese haiku, a poem has to suggest, in the economy of words, a sensation and a moment of insight, else it is 'just words', as AKR put it in one of his Kannada poems, 'Haiku 3':

She frowned upon:
Body, as body,
Drama, as theatrics,
Poem, as just words, words.

All earned opprobrium.⁵⁹

In his lectures on form and style (see the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7), AKR has spoken of 'zero redundancy' as the limit for poets, who should only put into poems the absolutely necessary. Nothing should be 'predictable', but 'functional and mutually defining'. It is then that the poem 'becomes an object, with its own "sound-look," the message itself becomes the code....'⁶⁰ This concept of poem contrasts with another kind of poetry which

does not go all the way in exploring language to the bare object, but gets caught up in self-consciousness. Before AKR began to study structuralist linguistics in 1958, he had been deriding the rhetorical poetry of elder Kannada poets and experimenting with haiku-like image poems in his Kannada as well as English poetry (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7). The first part of an early, unpublished draft of a poem from 1956 titled 'Two Poems on Poetry', admonishes poets who cannot let go from their subjectivity and thus miss the intensity of the image:

I
Some poems remind me
of certain over-virtuous lovers
arrested mid-air by fathers
out of a hothouse past
who truss and inhibit the eloquence
of the wooing body. But love's half-gestures ...

(p.228) II

The word is like a bird
that flits in the blindness
of a pattern-papered room
...
but if only you could put out the self
you'd light the window with the night itself...⁶¹

As an early advocate of modernist poetics (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7), AKR advised other poets to constantly revise their poems and avoid gratuitous wordings and self-indulgence. During a meeting in Chicago in 1967 with the Indian English poet Nissim Ezekiel, AKR is said to have commented on a poem shown to him by his poet-friend: 'I think it is a good poem but ... you could revise it a lot. You could strengthen the poem, discipline the lines and relate it musically to others. Learn to sacrifice in the interest of your art. Sacrifice, so that nothing can be removed from the poem. Poetry should not be self-indulgent.'⁶²

AKR did not only believe that poems should be treated as objects with a 'life' of their own. He was also convinced that words, as elements that signify and make a poem, have an origin, a movement, and a way of turning into things when one deals with them closely (as poets and linguists do): 'One can go mad in a dictionary; people do. For if you pursue etymologies, they pursue you after some time. Etyma become reasons; the word becomes thing, its roots become the only or chief meanings, cancelling the present meanings.'⁶³ For AKR, the act of composing a poem involves an inscrutable process of interaction of meanings and images, which cancel previous meanings as the poem moves forward:

In dreams and poems, meanings unfold, often endlessly... With dreams and poems, if you know the answer already, you'll miss them entirely....

Poems may begin with a single referent but they gather others as they gather speed, like the river in the Yaksa's questions. 'A poem moves on its own melting,' said Frost once. Poem, dream and myth may begin with what's been said in other ways, but soon begin to say what can't be said at all in any other way. That's part of their enigma—that they can't be redescribed, abstracted, said in other more familiar ways and words.⁶⁴

(p.229) In the final act of composition, the poet has no option but to close and *kill the poem*, as the closing 'sentence' cuts off the flow of quarrelling images that often compete in a 'reckless spree of meanings'.⁶⁵ A suggestive meta-poem drafted in 1961, but published in *Second Sight* in 1986, compares the act of writing a poem with an imaginary dialectic of 'images' deciding the fate of the poem:

On the Death of a Poem

Images consult
one
another,

a conscience
stricken jury,

and come
slowly
to a sentence.⁶⁶

Another unpublished draft titled 'A Stab at a Poem' is more explicit about the poet being an assassin of the creature he has brought forth. As he gives birth to a poem on a page, he must also eliminate it from his imagination:

After writing
a poem quickly I wipe my mind clean
with a dirty shirt
like an old-fashioned
assassin
his knife after a prayer meeting

A cigarette
in the corner
of his mouth full
of loyalty's (unspeakable) salt.⁶⁷

There are a few meta-poems (mostly unpublished drafts) about the origin of poetry, in which the poem is again defined as a projection from the zero zone between subject and object. As the poem **(p.230)** incarnates in words, it grows from the seed into a flowering tree and back into 'the fruit in the seed'. The act of creation is ironically called the 'Fall' by AKR, a pun alluding both to the

physical fall of the mature fruit from the tree and to the biblical genesis when man, tempted by fleshly passion, is reduced to an imperfect reflection of God:

... A poem is a name
unspelt by thing
till She finds her flesh
in the Fall's perfect passion
stripping her sense of mode and tense
as the seed in the fruit
plunges through the twigs and the mesh
of At and After and From
to the fruit in the seed
forgetting the rooted tree between them
seeing every You in all my Me.⁶⁸

As we have seen in several other examples, the seed into tree into fruit into seed is the cyclical process-image for the making of poems in AKR's poetics, and recurs in drafts from the 1950s throughout his work (see earlier and the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3). This motif haunts the poet and rises from his mind as an ontological reference of the act of writing. Many of the meta-poems defining poetry and the poem are variations on this theme:

fruit of nothingness
projected blind
into a verbal tumult
secreting its images
to fill in a fissure
eating away like anguish
at an approximate world
always placed on the bias:
the poem⁶⁹

This poetic *exercise* was, like the longer 'Poetry' cited earlier in the chapter, drafted in 1983 when AKR visited Sri Lanka and played with the idea of becoming a Buddhist. On the same page next to the poem, AKR wrote the name 'Garelli', referring to Jaques Garelli, a contemporary French-language poet and philosopher whose essays, **(p.231)** 'The Act of Writing as an Apprehension of the Enigma of Being in the World' and 'The Poem as Ontology of Reference', were published in English the same year.⁷⁰

The Strider: Poet in the Poem

The concept of *poet* is explored in AKR's prose and poetry in its various dichotomies and complexities. He was concerned with the aesthetic and psychological implications of the notion of the poet, and less so with the social role of the poet. Above all, he considered the poet in the art of composing as a mediator between the poem and imagination (or an outer source of inspiration),

between the 'outer' and 'inner' spheres of the self, and between the world and the reader.

Person and Poet

The first distinction AKR makes is between his *person* and the *poet who speaks* through the poem. He insisted that one term should not be mistaken for the other: '[I] don't know if "personal" is the right word, because it is a kind of *persona* that speaks in poetry rather than the person. It is not just Ramanujan who is speaking, but it is a fictional voice ultimately, which only represents some parts of me, not all of me.'⁷¹ He concurred with W.H. Auden, T.S. Eliot, and the New Critics that the person remains always the person and the poet is only a poet in the poetic act, that is, a maker in the act of composing: 'I've never thought of myself as a writer; I just write. I'm startled when someone introduces me in print or in conversation as a "poet".... One is a "poet" only in the poem, though neither poets nor readers, nor a certain breed of interviewers, believe otherwise.'⁷²

Poets share a special talent which makes them no different from 'ordinary' people, and which involves the capacity to perceive and make use of a particular 'function of language'. According to linguist Roman Jakobson (see the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7), poetic function foregrounds the particular use of the code (language) as message (content). 'It's not special to poetry—anytime anyone's witty, in speech ...', as AKR claimed, '[B]ut poetry specialises in it....'⁷³ Even the great poets are, in this sense, equal to the common man: '[T]hese poets (Hopkins, Cummings, Thomas) do explicitly what every poet does, and what the everyday users of language do in those leaps and god-sent errors by which language **(p.232)** changes'.⁷⁴ The difference between poets and ordinary people is that the former are trained as artists to express through language the little changes and twists of the mind: 'I'd suggest that metaphor and metonymy, the capacity to mention one thing and mean another, the capacity to lie (as someone said, there's no negation in nature, only in language), are primary properties of consciousness—and they're exercised most richly in poetry and the arts....'⁷⁵

A poet is also distinct from other individuals in the manner he relates to life and everyday experiences. He is always 'in the business of clarifying experience to himself and to others'.⁷⁶ To such inner conflicts and ironies of life, the poet adds another struggle: the urge to put the experience into words on the page and thereby transmit it to others. Any condition, therefore, can turn into a poem, as in the following composition on 'Pain', which also suggests that poetry can, in some ways, be therapeutic:

When a man speaks
of pain, he gains merit
if he can speak with irony
and does not move on then

to do what poets

do, i.e., make a poem⁷⁷

Like T.S. Eliot in 'The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock', AKR thought of poets as 'poor specimens of humanity'.⁷⁸ His concept of poet is not attached to the romantic notion of poetic genius that is above reality and common life. A poem can be 'born' in the most ordinary circumstance and as sudden as in the poem 'Which Reminds Me', where a man 'makes' *the poem* as he crosses a street (see earlier in this section). While explaining the allusion to a folktale in this poem, AKR commented on the condition of the poet: '[V]ery often they are not great as a people. They are quite lousy people. But they have this talent which seems to be like a thrown-away seed.'⁷⁹

Poet, Prophet, and Seer

A persistent preoccupation in AKR's poetic thought was to contrast the notion of poet as common man with the age-old idea of poet **(p.233)** as prophet or seer. This concern, in turn, reflects another typical dilemma faced by poets and which is treated time and again in AKR's prose writings and poems: the dichotomy that exists between the unconscious side of creativity and the self-conscious, anxious ego of the poet. The notion of poet as prophet or spiritual guru had prominent followers during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries in India and the West.⁸⁰ The origin of this idea is associated with the ancient belief that poets are possessed during the creative act. As AKR explained, the 'possessed' poet-prophet is a common motif in the Western and Indian traditions: '[A]ll poetic efforts begin with an invocation, calling down the Muse, God or Goddess.... Blake called himself a secretary to God.... [A] Kannada poet says ... that the poet is *Narayana*....' The idea, eschewed by the modernist poets, that the poet possesses special powers has been present from Virgil and Milton to the Romantics and is common in Indian classical epic poetry as well as in the bhakti and folk traditions:

Poetry, said Auden, makes nothing happen. Oscar Wilde said, all arts are useless—meaning also that if they're useful, they wouldn't be art.

Prophecy, magic, possession make things happen. In Indian poetry, the legends of poets are about how their words are never false, they make things happen, no less than dream and magic. Here, poet and saint merge. They are known both for their words and their miracles. That's how they're accepted by the community. No less than shamans, poets have to prove themselves by affecting reality, by forestalling it, often adding to it....

A poet, like a medium, is both born (Friedrich) and made. He is, in an old Tamil phrase, a twist in the embryo. Then he has to learn the craft as well as get to inherit his culture—know its past, the flora and the fauna and the stars and places as well as music and dances.⁸¹

Although AKR was fascinated with the idea of poet-shaman or magician and studied it in its various traditions, from the Vedic hymns, classical Tamil poetry, folk performances, and bhakti poetry to the European mystics and Romantic poets, he was not converted to this ulterior vision of poetry. As a practising poet, he preferred to be the lower 'specimen' with an inborn talent of perception, and was critical of poets who saw themselves as heirs of ancient traditions, but were often unable to respond to the immediate, sometimes unsettling, reality before them:

(p.234) *A River*

In Madurai,
 city of temples and poets
who sang of cities and temples:
...
The new poets still quoted
the old poets, but no one spoke
in verse
of the pregnant woman
drowned, with perhaps twins in her,
kicking at blank walls
even before birth. (1-3, 28-34)⁸²

Likewise, he did not side with the notion of poet as a modern-day bard. In his essay on Walt Whitman, AKR begins by 'reminding ourselves that a poet is a poet, and should be treated as one by himself and by other'. He is critical of Whitman's obsession with his own public figure, which blinds him from the 'less spectacular' dimension of poetry: 'Even when he [Whitman] thought of himself as a poet, he thought of himself not as a man working with words but as a Poet, with a capital "P", a public figure.'⁸³ As someone who had searched and partaken in sundry poetic traditions in his career as a student, professor, translator, and poet, AKR came to the conclusion that certain 'poets look everywhere for praise'⁸⁴ and tend to preach to others, confounding the artist and the work. His thoughts on this problem wavered between several conceptualizations in the course of his life, though he usually stuck to his early credo of a poet being 'the poet in the poem':

It isn't true that 'Once a poet, always a poet, and everywhere a poet'. Then the poet becomes a Poet; (s)he pontificates, sometimes even in the poems. He begins to live like a poet—writing his lives and living his writing. The suffering Self and the Writing Self, bhava and rasa become one, fused, confused. The results, often brilliant, but usually disastrous to both life and art, are well-known. Right now I am more with Heinrich Heine: 'The Glow-worm is just a grub in the morning.' Yet

Quote: 'Not only prophets walk on water ...'⁸⁵

AKR held to the view that life (personal emotion, *bhava*) and art (aesthetic emotion, *rasa*) are interconnected, but the poet's presence **(p.235)** in the work should not be too visible. After referring to Heine's comparison of a poet to a 'glow-worm',⁸⁶ AKR is reminded of one of his own poems on a tiny insect, the water strider, also known as the Jesus bug. The two verses quoted in this diary belong to the first two lines of the second stanza of one of his most famous poems, 'The Striders'. This one-image poem opened his first poetry collection from 1966, which carries the same title. The poem plays with the visual shape of the text and is a meta-poetic statement on the poet's relation to the poetic object:

And search
for certain thin
stemmed, bubble-eyed water bugs.
See them perch
on dry capillary legs
weightless
on the ripple skin
of a stream.

No, not only prophets
walk on water. This bug sits
on a landslide of lights
and drowns eye—
deep
into its tiny strip
of sky.⁸⁷

The two stanzas of the poem, separated by the rippled stream, juxtapose two different conceptualizations of poet as well as two attitudes to poetry. In the first stanza, which begins in *medias res* with the connective 'and', the focus is on an object in a particular scene: a weightless insect hovering on water. The voice of the poet urges the reader to search for the tiny insects and 'see them perch'. There is a tight tension between the static, 'weightless' legs of the tiny water bugs and the flowing 'stream'. The poem follows the imagist strategy of keeping an aesthetic distance between the observer and the observed, as in Carlos Williams's 'Red Wheelbarrow'. It captures a pure objective act in time involving seer and seen. The *poet-witness* reflects, in the detached description of the object, 'the actual' moment of an intense visual experience. At the formal level, the quality of the experience is anchored in the language and syntax of the poem. As **(p.236)** the mind meditates on the object (the water bugs are in an object clause), there is no consciousness of time (the verbs are non-finite forms) and self (use of the impersonal imperative).

In the second stanza, there is a radical shift in the negation 'No, not only prophets/ walk on water'. The 'I' of the poet comes through with the word 'prophet', baffling the reader and hallowing the scene with an apparent

metaphysical, spiritual (or religious) significance. But this connotation is soon converted into an ironic 'self-reflection' in the rippled waters of the stream, 'a land-slide of lights'. The subject takes over and *reflects on* the previous impersonal experience. The poem is a journey from sight to insight, and a return to the depths of an inner fear. The poet 'drowns/ eye-deep' ('I'-deep) in his own thoughts, 'its tiny strip/ of sky'. The finite verbs ('walk', 'sits', 'drowns') in this stanza stand in contrast with the non-finite form 'perch' of the first stanza, where the timeless scene celebrates the lightness (and *little-ness*) of living in the *here and now*, walking on the flux of life, the flowing stream of life. The weightlessness, however, turns out to be short-lived, as 'the present is the most illusive of meaning'.⁸⁸ The image moves on, for the mind cannot keep still and associates walking on water with the supernatural skill of prophets. And so 'this bug', now the thinking *poet-seer* or 'prophet' walking on the stream, returns to subjectivity, to his ego-self in the act of thinking. For even in meditation the mind cannot be one with the object for too long; it soon identifies with the 'I' of self-consciousness and, losing the balance between passive and active, 'drowns' in the stream of thought.⁸⁹ In this sense, the poem represents the two components of our self-identity and consciousness: the primordial vision-based self (awareness) and the speech-based thinking self, the ego (aware of being aware). We can also establish obvious parallelisms with Ezra Pound's imagist poetics. On the one hand, there is the phrase 'drowns eye-/ deep/ into its tiny strip/ of sky', which echoes Pound's 'walked eye-deep in hell' in 'Hugh Selwyn Mauberly'. But we can also infer from the movement in the two juxtaposed stanzas of the poem 'The Striders', Pound's theory of the one-image-poem: 'In a poem of this sort one is trying to record the precise instant when a thing outward and objective transforms itself, or darts into a thing inward and subjective.'⁹⁰

The first published version of 'The Striders', which appeared in *Poetry* in 1961, opened with the line 'Put away, put away this dream', which was deleted in the 1966 collection.⁹¹ An even earlier unpublished rough draft of the poem in the Papers dated 26 March **(p.237)** 1960 is titled 'Fear', and has a longer stanza placed before the published two stanzas:⁹²

Fear

That harlot, fear,
bloomed only by night
like tiger lilies
in the mud,
their hearts full of red
dotted stripes.
Nightly, she bedded
on imagined silk
with other men's obscene lips
and thought her rummaging
clientele

did not hurt her lips,
though every morning
was a morning after.

Put away the dream.
And search....

This longer version of the poem is related to the 1956 draft 'Two Poems on Poetry', the poem 'Anxiety' from *The Striders*, and the uncollected poem 'No Dream, No Symbol' published in India in 1958,⁹³ in that it speaks of the anxiety with which all poets look for inspiration in their imagination and cling to the symbolist dream of absolute meaning. Or even of a worse nightmare: the fear of the *self*-conscious poet whose mind is full of images, phrases, and words of 'other men' (poets), but who is incapable of making them his own; the fear of being poet who is unable to twist language, 'the universal whore', and convert her into a 'virgin' (see the phrase by Karl Kraus quoted in the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7 and mentioned earlier in this section) until a new, untouched 'image' appears to him.

As we can see in many other *fear poems*,⁹⁴ primordial fears (of animals, sex, death, drowning or falling, etc.) and their multitude of metaphors did not cease to haunt AKR in his dreams; it was the poet's aim to remove these fears by stopping the mind through yoga or other practices (by meditating on an object, as in Buddhist exercises, or **(p.238)** later in his life with Jungian therapy). And so 'The Striders' is also about what a *poet* means to AKR: a restless artist who can find peace of mind only by 'putting away the dream' and 'searching' for a tiny *apparition*, a concrete image, only to drown in the self an instant after. Whatever other interpretations the unedited draft of 'Fear' may allow for, readers of AKR's poetry should be pleased that the poet managed to overcome his 'fear' and trimmed the poem down to a focused 15-line image (or 'reflection') of a famous water insect not many people in India knew by the name 'strider'.

We may read in this context AKR's observations on Whitman's concept of the poet. AKR praises the passages in Whitman's poetry where 'the "I" is not Whitman the Bard of Personality, but an impersonal experiencing-nature'. In those instances, says AKR, when Whitman 'attends closely to the specificity of things', he achieves 'a concrete objectivity, wherein he anticipates the Imagists'.⁹⁵ And AKR continues by quoting the following verses from *Leaves of Grass*: 'A noiseless spider/ I mark'd where on a little promontory it stood isolated.' His admiration of Whitman's moments of poetic objectivity could well apply to the first stanza of his own short insect poem:

[W]hen the objectivity ... guides the verse—when the 'I' becomes a fictional creation, an 'objective correlative' for his personal attitude; there emerges from the amorphous words, a form. With this fictional correlative, there

appears a detachment from, a full possession of, feeling. His narcissism, like his 'ideas' become an integrate into his poetry....

[T]he poet simply 'witnesses' and 'notes': the words are transparent and we seem to look through them to the things themselves.... There is a distance and detachment, framing everything. Here again is an anticipation of the Imagists (though their concreteness-for-concreteness' sake led them up the blind alley) in its visuality. In such passages ... with the 'I' as witness, the abortive Whitman of barbaric yawps and amorous aching is translated into Whitman the poet. The usual blur comes into focus, revealing clear bright living detail.⁹⁶

In the early 1980s, three decades after AKR wrote his notes on Whitman's technique of visual detachment, he went back to the American bard as a model of integrating ideas and self into poetry 'without mysticism'. AKR's concept of poet as an organic entity, as a non-personal 'I' made up of all the natural elements that pass through it, was developed during this period before he finished his third book of poems in English, *Second Sight*. Published in 1986, this collection **(p.239)** was partly chiselled out of material that the poet had accumulated over the years and which he intended to publish under the title 'Soma' in 1982. At some point he abandoned the 'Soma' project and worked on the long poem titled 'Composition', which was to become a new collection with the same title. AKR kept a journal on the creative process in the crucial stages of this work during the summer of 1982:

July 25, 1982. Journal on 'Composition'

It's too personal now—the 'I' not large and non-personal—find a central tension—the above theme of needing to enlarge self without mysticism, pomposity, generality etc.

Add incidents—a running central image: composing, decomposing—a passage on a compost-like Whitman's, but should be different.

In how many ways do others become us?—the elements, ideas, imitation of clothes and names and words—some don't fit—'influence', fluency, flows river and ocean—

I breathe and the air becomes me, my blood,
I eat and the fish, fowl and flesh become my flesh and blood,
Elate and depress me, make me lose caste and kin status.⁹⁷

The Upanishadic caterpillar motif, the food-cycle poem, and Whitman's notion of poetic 'I', the body, and the cosmos, are clearly at the back of the concerns that poured into the poem 'Elements of Composition' (see the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4 and 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5). Even

‘influence’ is part of this continuity through transformation, as we can read in AKR’s etymological play. And at the textual level, one can trace how this poem on ‘composing’ and ‘containing’ absorbs (in lines 27–35) parts of a much earlier poem, ‘Madura: Two Movements’, published in 1957 (see also the section ‘Western Theories and the Study of Poetry’ in Chapter 7 on intertextuality, and Appendices 1 and 2).

In other poems, AKR reverted to the south-Indian bhakti tradition to contrast the poet as witness with the god-immersed poet-saint. In several pseudo-devotional poems, the speaker expresses in the ironic mode an urgent desire to dissolve and be one with god, hiding his angst as a self-reflexive poet. Though AKR was interested in devotional poetry, it is important to stress that he considered himself a non-believer, as we can infer, for instance, from the following diary entry: ‘[M]y lack of faith or interest in a “higher” or “truer” self or anything **(p. 240)** “beyond” the known self.’⁹⁸ As we saw in some of the early meta-poems, the poet displays an underlying existential (and artistic) fear of ‘drowning’ in the ‘known self’. Having absorbed early the poetic techniques of the vachana poets he translated, AKR was aware that attachment of the ego (the ‘I’) to physical desire (body) and thought (mind) was an obstacle to creativity. Thus he played the poet-devotee begging for poems. Long before the well-known mock-prayer to Lord Murugan (which ends with ‘Lord of answers,/ cure us at once/ of prayers.’),⁹⁹ AKR wrote another prayer poem on artistic desperation titled ‘Prayer before Suicide—A Sonnet:”

Teach me, Lord: to dissolve and not to drown
In the terrible clarity of this pond
Of prose, without a pseudo-poetic frond
Narcissus-aching for rhyme of reflection;
...
Lord, grant me this: let me be one

With me and Thee; let me dissolve, not drown.¹⁰⁰

As Leaves to a Tree: The Poetic Process

The nature of poetic experience and the process by which poems come into being were other essential concerns in AKR’s poetic work. He was interested in how thoughts, dreams, and images of the mind are translated into concrete words and word combinations to become poetry. In his prose writings and poems AKR depicted the struggle of finding the right balance between the conscious and unconscious elements of creativity, and contended with the difficulties involved in the art of composition. These issues extend his conceptions of the poet as witness, seer, dreamer, or maker. He was as much concerned with the unconscious psychological process of the imagination, as with the speculations about an outer source of inspiration. The role of the poet as a craftsman, that is, the conscious aspects of poetry-making, are discussed with equal commitment.

On Imagination as the Origin of Images and Words

AKR refers at times to an inner source as the origin of the poetic act. His early poetry and journals, in particular, relate the poetic experience as a vision of images. Springing from the imagination of **(p.241)** the mind, the poetic experience takes shape as a flow of images and words that need to be penned down. A detailed description of this process is given in AKR's 1949 journal when the aesthetic experience of observing the image of a fountain 'lit his emptied mind'¹⁰¹ and roused his poetic imagination. AKR's autobiographical rendering of this particular poetic experience as a 20-year-old is a unique prose account of his self-discovery as an English-language poet:

A poem is born (25-27 Sept. 1949)

He was writing a poem. Definitely not about raptures of roses and the languors of lilies. He would not be conventional, old-phrased, a Pandanus to the lazy public; no, not for the life of him. Tinned poetry, he called it. Stale stuff. Not that for him. Good or bad, he would be himself, have his own home-industry of phrases, where he turned poetic pottery at the whirling wheel of his own imagination; he would be clay, pot, potter, painter and the tanning 'fixing' sun,¹⁰² all in one. The fancy pleased him immensely. He wrote it down in his day-book.... He must think of the poem, his second....

The words came to his head in English. A line had cut into his mind all evening, when he saw the subtle fountain; he kept repeating it throughout the walk, when he sat at his rice, and alone in his room, like a bee, the line circled, buzzed, trailing away only to return. The relish of the cadence put him in a restless ecstasy; he went to bed and slept on the rhythm of those repetitions. This morning, he rose rather blue in mind, when abruptly the cadence entered and all was different, it sent him packing into an exulted reverie about his own imagination and what he could make of it. Then he thought of writing his second poem.

The image was there, the ecstasy was there. The words would come, as he tuned his mind....

All on a sudden the cadence reappeared, floating embryo soul waiting for the body, poetry elbowing its way through this worrying, infinitely dreary, lonely press ... he should write it soon, have risen earlier; but who was to know, that it would appear so exhilaratingly to-day, so tantalisingly amidst these incalculable little fatalities. Was poetry an antithesis to Life, and Life a petty hounding tyrant? He wished he could note that down, a sharp thought, that. He should make it a point hereafter to carry it with him always, and note it down....

But 'O, that strain again', he quoted to himself; there it was again, that wheeling bee, that returning intoxication. With it came the vision of the fountain. Another phrase flashed in. He saw a new aspect. The rotating changes of colour, so abrupt, improvised by a magician, as it were, but in some way so pre-ordained to harrow, it seemed to him; he always vaguely puzzled if the changes were rung to the tune of an unheard capricious melody. He rubbed his hands; that would be an excellent second stanza.

(p.242) ... The emptied mind, in a moment, lost its opaque emptiness, it seemed lit up....

'Ah, that strain again!' ... Words flooded his brain and he was in a hot enchantment; it gave a curious fleetness to the body and he pranced visibly in pent-up excitement.¹⁰³

The intensity of the experience recounted here by the young poet, and his excitement, are genuinely sincere.¹⁰⁴ The writer's naive attitude to the poetic event in this early journal is poles apart from the ironic mode employed a decade later in his self-reflexive poetry. Nevertheless, AKR's metaphor of poetic imagination as an animate being, in this case an intoxicating bee that flickers in his mind and strains the body, is a common figure throughout his poetry, though its use as a meta-poetic resource changed over the years. There are numerous poems that provide glimpses of that creative instant when words awaken as animal images in the mind of the poet.¹⁰⁵ Another poem even expresses nostalgia about the times when poetic imagination would come easy:

He too was a light sleeper once.

A chuckle in the hall,
the pulse in the neck of a bird
that felt like his own,
a bloodred beak in a lime
tree, a nightmare prince,
anything at all
could wake him to coffee and a mountain-climb
of words on a page.... (1-9)¹⁰⁶

We have also seen how the images that appear in the mind are not always harmless, but can torture or frighten the poet. They often 'come' in the form of animals such as reptiles, elephants, and tigers, or even as 'the black hen' in the famous late poem of that title. An early published poem, 'The Whip', depicts the poet's predicament as a wild animal in a nightmare of insomnia:

Struck insomniac
By truth's nuance
It paces within my cage:

Torment's tiger image.

It's the nuance that hurts.... (1-5)¹⁰⁷

(p.243) Imagination is also movement and change, and can start a process in the poet that transforms an idea into an object. It is like a transition from one state or season (winter) to another (spring), and the poet has to be attentive to the nuances in these changes. In the poem 'I Listened', also drafted as 'Transition', poetic imagination is likened to the budding of spring in the branches of a tree:

I listened
till I almost heard in the bone
of the winter world

the hatch, the crackle,
of a spring—
bud pattern
uncurling

in the branch
behind the word. (1-9)¹⁰⁸

The poetic method of imagination may also involve the introduction of a specific experience through a plain or meditative statement that gradually grows into an image, dramatizing as well as recounting an event through visual and auditory details. At times, the images have to be pursued and the turnover from the multitude of images in the mind to actual poems is not effortless. The poet may 'see' the image as a weak shape, but to put it down into the concreteness of language is always one more step, as associations tumble through the mind in an unstoppable free flow.

It

I see it out there like a small
tree with two broken branches
between two gnarled oaks lifting
their hill head of leaves
into the rain,

but I don't know how to get down
from this guest room window

...
to the small tree with two broken branches
(p.244) out there, below my mind,
in the back of my tongue. I hear it
running like an underground Ganges
under my feet, over my head,

like leaky taps upstairs and downstairs,
purring at my side like the kitchen fridge,
inside me like tummy gurgles,

always running from me.... (1-7, 19-27)¹⁰⁹

In many such poems, the power of association of the mind (by which events and things are recalled, linked, and juxtaposed within the poet's psyche), makes the poetic imagination waver between the objective and the personal, the cultural and the archetypal, the conscious and the unconscious. In this interconnecting way, the poet presents the creativity of his psyche, containing the entire complexity of his thoughts and feelings and the different identities of his self. Events and objects are transformed against shifts in perception until a particular attitude towards the poetic experience begins to emerge. The manner in which the process of poetic imagination is described by AKR is reminiscent of the psychologist Carl Jung, whose method he followed as a patient—and student—of psychoanalysis.¹¹⁰ Rather than allowing for 'free association', it works like a circumambulation of a dream picture, often with an archetypal image (animal, plant, etc.) crystallizing at the centre. As far as psychology is concerned, what the associational process implies is a trip from the conscious to the unconscious or, according to Jung, to the collective unconscious.¹¹¹ Therefore, instead of having a logical order, some meta-poems on the art of poetry-writing follow the psychological process of the speaker. That is, first the senses are stimulated by colours and forms, then, by virtue of the associational nature of the mind, the stimulus gains intensity to evoke a clear image. The sensorial images come first, before the concept (thought and image) arises, illustrating the process of the mind. This is an unconscious process, and the best way of explaining it is by letting it 'happen':

No, it does not happen
when I walk through the woods.
But, walking in museums of quartz
or the aisles of bookstacks,
(p.245) looking at their geometry
without curves
and the layers of transparency
that make them opaque,
dwelling on the yellower vein
in the yellow amber
or touching a book that has gold
on its spine,
I think of snakes.

The twirls of their hisses
rise like the tiny dust-cones on slow-noon roads
winding through the farmers' feet.... (1-16)¹¹²

In AKR's 'Snakes', one of the most fascinating poems on the mythological animal written in English, the central image is a metaphor for the power of imagination as well as for maya, the Hindu veil of illusion and creative life-force. Once the speaker has aroused the archetypal image of snake-fear in his mind, the associational logic triggers off, in a mental flashback, a chain of audiovisual memories in the next stanza, and then the recalling of a series of events from the past in the following three stanzas. Images, ideas, and, finally, events are joined together by a process of associational logic, based on objective correlatives, personal experiences, and cultural conventions, moving from external stimuli to the inner realms of personal experience. The natural order of this psychological process is followed quite accurately by the poet-speaker in the poem. The logic of association, which 'some linguists believe is the mind's natural way of processing thought and information',¹¹³ is also behind the technique by which poetic devices are employed in such poems on poetic imagination. However, storing too many images and words can also be counterproductive and obstruct the poetic process, as AKR laments in another rough draft of a poem:

I can't get close to a poem
Because I'm too full of thoughts.
I can't get close to it
Because I'm too full of words
A man who can't get to sleep
Because the day is too much with him....¹¹⁴

(p.246) The direction and flow of imagination may also get interrupted when sudden images come in between the thoughts and the words, invading the final composition:

Why Songs Don't Get Written

When slowly I turn a thought of trees in the sun
Hexagons of wax,
Squirrels' eyes
And transparencies
Of dragonflies

For a song,

The coming tax
And the monkey's lung
Mother said was hung
In the woman's breast
Also turn, but not so slowly as the trees.¹¹⁵

And even if the right images and words finally come to the poet, the origin of imagination still remains a mystery to him:

From Where?

When, well or ill, the task is done,
the images lose their spin,
lose their hum, as they wobble, roll, lie still,

I ask, where did they come from?

From the mice and the murder clues
in the subterranean granaries I house
but do not own? ... (1-7)¹¹⁶

The poet in search of an answer arrives at further questions. A poetry draft translated by AKR from Kannada into English, aptly titled 'Translations', inquires into the 'special' force behind the tongue that translates the preverbal image into words. The question 'raises' its own answer thus:

(p.247) *Translations*

and as he writes all this here
what special glands press

forth these words? this sorrow
streaked with pleasure

desire laced with rage
these words come from what

animal past what metamorphic
phase?—the question raises

its head is it in fury or in fear
it spreads its spectacled hood

...

in the deep back of his mind¹¹⁷

On Inspiration and the Concept of Grace

AKR interrogates the notion of poetic inspiration from two overlapping perspectives: the psychological, which focuses on unconscious processes of the mind, and the metaphysical, which presumes the existence of an outer source. Both are related to what he sometimes called 'grace'. AKR's reflections on this issue vacillate between the two explanations of how inspiration works in poetry: (a) inspiration as a natural or unconscious state; and (b) the concept of grace and its religious connotations.

The way in which poetry can or cannot be consciously willed into existence was clearly formulated by the poet in meta-poems like 'The Black Hen' (see the full poem quoted in the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4). Even in times of poetic unproductiveness, AKR strictly

followed his belief in poetry as an organic process. In the early 1980s, when he was at pains to put new poems together for a new poetry collection (see Appendix 2), he noted in his diary: 'Aug 4 1982. Struggling to start new poems—to repeat nothing. Don't know how to begin. My belief and practice: they must "come as leaves to a tree or not at all"!'¹¹⁸ AKR puts the last phrase in quotes in the diary entry. Though he does not **(p.248)** acknowledge it, this maxim, which appears also in the first three lines of the poem 'The Black Hen' is taken from a letter written by John Keats in 1818.¹¹⁹ We can infer from this statement on AKR's poetic 'belief and practice' that poetry is a *natural* process that cannot be controlled, but is part of the biological cycle. Buds, leaves, and spring flowers are associated with fertility and regeneration, and stand as universal metaphors for creative inspiration. Along with the seed, the tree, and the fruit, insects, reptiles, and many other nature motifs related to springtime belong to AKR's 'language within a language' on poetic inspiration as a natural cycle of birth and death. These metaphors of rebirth and regeneration define also the poet's complex attitude to the origin of poetry, for nothing is made but remade in the Hindu cosmo-vision (see the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5). On the other hand, AKR's concept of inspiration cannot be identified with a single particular school, say Hindu philosophy, Sangam aesthetics, bhakti, or Romanticism, because the key metaphors he makes use of accumulate from all these traditions a wide array of literary, psychological, philosophical, religious, and personal significances in the course of the poet's work.

In terms of poetic practice, AKR's stance on artistic inspiration is akin to his vision of life as a succession of accidents or fortuitous happenings:

Accidental things. For years I had planned nothing but things happened fortuitously. Poetry also comes that way.

... If something has moved me I've gone further into it. From folktale to psychoanalysis, for instance, I have drifted along.

... I do truly believe in the unconscious having its own way of ordering. Like poetic forms—they come from within, you can only make implicit something that is already there. It's paradoxical that the poem seems so controlled—it's not willed.¹²⁰

The mind, therefore, should not get in the way of the process of creation, for poetry does not belong to the conscious sphere where one can be fully in control: 'The act of writing does not take place in that state of mind. That is all I have to say. It may come to you at odd moments. But if it interferes with it, it corrupts the experience in some sense, at least for me.'¹²¹ AKR insists that the secret of poetry-writing is not simply 'inspiration', but is, in reality, a subtle

combination of conscious and unconscious elements, an interconnectedness of awareness and intuition:

(p.249) [T]he formality of the poem is not inspiration. You are concerned with—should it be right, shouldn't it be right? Do those words express themselves to you? You see these in a kind of position which is not inspiration. I don't know what inspiration is. But it is not a state of mind where you think when shall I publish ...

It is intuitive in the sense that there is much that you cannot control. There is much that you are not even conscious of. It is not a line of division between the unconscious and the conscious. You suddenly become aware of what you were unconscious of and that at another moment you become unconscious in a deep sense of what you are doing. So words such as consciousness and awareness are not words which you can use very simply. Because it is an awareness of a very different kind. Even when I am speaking to you I am aware of something, but most of the time I am speaking I am not fully aware, right? It has been proved both by the cognitive psychologist and psychoanalyst who talk about the arts. Most of what we do is well structured. And yet for a structured thing to be effective, most of it has to be unconscious.¹²²

Hence, the poet cannot choose or pursue 'his poems', but knows how to put himself 'in a place where "they" happen....'¹²³ In this unconscious search, the poet dreams of being 'himself' in the language he uses. He wants to find a personal voice, 'however cracked or small, sick or normal, which follows one's twists and turns, falls and rises and stumbles, in one's "climb to one's proper dark"—though the climb may be like a monkey's on a greased pole, two feet up and three feet down'.¹²⁴ There are no fast rules as to how this poetic originality is achieved, but as we saw earlier in some of the poetry drafts, a major obstacle to finding the proper 'place' is too much self-consciousness:

I don't know how one does it. If only one can be in touch with this level of the linguistic unconscious, this wholeness. True language use is unconscious in this sense; the more self-conscious it is, the more artificial it becomes, and the more trammelled in manners, rules, opinions. Maybe it's by vigilantly negating what is not yourself that you finally find some place in your language (and your world) where you do not have to mimic and perform, like Johnson's women orators and dancing dogs.¹²⁵

AKR's reflections on poetic imagination imply that poetic inspiration often takes place during altered states or experiences, such as dream, trance, or mediation. The origin of these creative impulses is located in the self, that is, it works by baffling the conscious self so that poetry can take its 'place'. There is no acceptance of 'divine **(p.250)** inspiration' in such a model of poetics, despite

his being influenced in his youth by the Virasaiva mystic concept of anubhava, that is, 'the Experience', 'the unmeditated vision', the true experience of grace (kripa) that cannot be invoked (see the sections 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5 and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7). However, the line between imagination as an inner process and such mental states as 'given' by chance or a superior power is not very neat in AKR's poetics. He evolved a personal concept of 'grace' which amounted to a philosophy of life:

Oct 30. 1976.

The poems, too, when they come, surprise me, I feel a poem has chosen me, not me the poem—and this is not being mystical. I've the same feeling about thoughts, ideas, events, persons. Maybe a certain passivity, a need to say 'I didn't work for it, I'm not responsible', in my nature. For years, I took the Buddhist slogan, 'take nothing that's not given', literally. Except, I reversed it to 'Take everything that's given' or 'Say no to nothing', which landed me in dreadful dilemmas with food and women. This refusal to say 'No' has never hurt me, I've drifted into things, paradoxically, I've always wanted, but never allowed myself even to dream of. Maybe I let my Unconscious do the work for me—letting it choose and manouver without my conscious stir....

Teaching myself as an Ouija board, to spell out my deepest desires. If nothing came of it, I could always say to myself, I didn't try for it anyway; if I got the job, the book, the friendship of a person, there was a sense of getting it gratis, by grace, without any stirring or waiting. Maybe an exquisite form of self-deception....

Yet one works for grace in some secret way, works at it—as one does at a poem that has 'come' to you. Pasteur said, 'Chance favours only the prepared.'¹²⁶

In the same diary, AKR confesses that he wrote several poems (he cites 'The Striders', 'Still Another View of Grace', and 'Which Reminds Me') about this belief of taking all that is 'given'. One of the secret ways in which the poet works towards such a state of 'grace' is to see life as a continuous dabbling in new experiences: '[T]his business of drifting to finding oneself in good places and with little fulfilments, what people would call grace, it's continuous, you dip into it, there is always something you can dip into. Finding a new friend, a poem—it can be a complete surprise any time of the day. And it's awesome. It's another view of grace.'¹²⁷ He explains this 'view of grace', for instance, in the half-autobiographical poem of a young Brahmin in a foreign **(p.251)** land, exposed to new experiences and temptations, falling prey to female 'hungers that roam the street':

Still Another View of Grace

...

Bred Brahmin among singers of shivering hymns
I shudder to the bone at hungers that roam the street
beyond the constable's beat.' But there She stood

upon that dusty road on a nightlit april mind
and gave me a look. Commandments crumbled
in my father's past. Her tumbled hair suddenly known
as silk in my angry hand, I shook a little

and took her, behind the laws of my land. (10-18)¹²⁸

The capital letter in the pronoun 'She' suggests both a female figure and the poetic muse or 'grace'. Consequently, the same 'view of grace' applies to the writing of poems. When they come they are accepted as a natural gift:

... Only a small number of things ever get written, and fewer still get written well. I'm amazed that I write at all, sometimes even in English—I don't know quite how or why. A still small voice, not of reason, but odd unreason, says, 'It's a form of grace. Don't question it.' I trust that voice.¹²⁹

AKR also exploits, in his poetics, the spiritual subtext of the concept of 'grace' as a boon that has to be won from a divine source. As a scholar and translator, he was intrigued by the metaphysical or mystical powers that invade a poet's genius in manifold Indian traditions: in the form of Visnu, Siva, or Soma in classical literatures, or as lesser-known folk deities in ritual performance (see the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy', 'Folk Aesthetics', and 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5, and 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition', 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics', and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7). In his lecture notes, AKR further describes how the consciousness of a poet is transformed during the *act of writing* quite akin to the working of a ritual possession or divine 'inspiration':

In this state of 'inspiration' meaning 'being breathed into by a non-self', or ... 'en-theos-mos, being entered into by a god,' important things happen **(p.252)** that distinguish it from ordinary states: the speech, the metaphor, a logic of non sequitur, a different sense of time that includes past, present and future (completed time, 'eternal now') ... it's this different sense of time, non-linear, simultaneous, where future can precede the past, it's this different sense that makes poetry, dream, and prophecy even in the literal sense of divination possible, one can then see the future as one sees the present or past, one can be clairvoyant and see the absent, the missing child, the stolen jewel.

... Though there are many kinds of practices, and there are spontaneous possessions, there's often a ritual preparation: fasting, abstinence, repetitive prayer, certain genres and modes of speech—getting out of the daily round of language and custom.

At the moment of possession, certain rhythmic movement and chanting and music induce the possession and later manifest it. This is very much like the rhythms and meter and technique in poetry—they have many functions.

In the act of writing, they serve also to lull and occupy the conscious, rational, intelligence while the unconscious does its work—like the fairytale prince—dogs guarding the water of life—deeper levels of language (Friedrich), larger mind, realms beyond our control—....¹³⁰

Although AKR's poetics is aware of the metaphysical dimension of artistic grace (and there is, at times, a trace of superstition in his poetic belief), in his body of poetry he wanted to show how poetry is different from divine inspiration in that it 'works' exactly like ordinary life. So, rather than considering himself a 'mystical opportunist'¹³¹ like the Virasaiva saints, AKR developed a pragmatic attitude to art and life through the habit of saying 'no to nothing', be it food, women, or poems. His concept of grace does not recognize a superior force, but interprets art as an extraordinary event. Poetic inspiration is, therefore, expressed in paradoxical terms as an 'ordinary mystery':

Poetry happens unbidden and has to protect itself. The psychedelic experience taps precisely such experiences. But the junkies seek it as a separate state and not as an interruption of the ordinary.... Perhaps that is what grace is all about. And this is where the ironic distance comes in.

My point is, you can't seek such a state, can't organise it or take a pill for it. In my 'Soma Poems', for instance, the extraordinary occurs in a most ordinary fashion, something like the way a poem happens. It's a mystery, but mystery itself is ordinary. Only we make of it something miraculous.¹³²

There is an entire sequence of unpublished 'Soma Poems' drafted in the late 1970s which deals with the topic of inspiration or the paradox of 'whatever one calls "divine" in our ordinary life', as AKR explained in 1982: '[T]hat is, the experience that is slightly different from it. My new **(p.253)** book of poems in English is also about that paradox. I am going to call it *Soma*.'¹³³ The sequence of Soma poems was never published, as he reworked his ideas into a different chain of poems that now form part of *Second Sight*. In these unpublished drafts, the multiple connotations of Soma as the intoxicating substance from the Vedas, Soma as food, as the moon, as a mythological god (the 'lord of speech') that inspires poets, and as a personal metaphor for the 'ordinary' poet, appear in a metonymical relation. The drug-elixir 'given' by the god, that is, *poetry*, is the means to invoke 'the seer and leader of poets', and so the poet's creativity is an

extension of his grace. The poet sees through 'Soma' and takes up different identities. The drug and god are both the sources of inspiration and the explanation for it. Depending on the attitude (aesthetic or philosophical) and personal belief (secular or religious), one can take its ramifications from the physical and metaphysical to the psychedelic (see the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4) and religious. The poet, the muse, the 'divine' experience in ordinary life, as also the poem are part of the same circle of poetic creation. As in the poet/Poet/prophet distinction, AKR highlights the arbitrariness of 'Soma', which can be poetry, the poet, the persona, or the person in search of poems:

*On Discovering That Soma Is a Mushroom*¹³⁴

Would you believe it?

I'm an oak tree with fountains
of falling hair, and Soma, once eye

of heaven, a mushroom at my feet.
Not R., whom you and I
know somewhat, but oak among tall oaks

in a ring of white mountains, for Soma is a mushroom at my feet.
Yes, I'm still R., here and now as always
married and difficult, ...

... for Soma's me,
mushroom, ancient of altitudes,
growing at my feet. Soma of seven minds, ...

bud of the thousand petal lotus in the brain.
Soma, I sit on Soma, caterpillar
(p.254) on toadstool,
eating and waiting to be butterfly;
stand in Soma, warm perishing body in cold silver river;
a lover's hand
in, on, below, between,

and Soma growing at my feet.
It's Soma reads The Hindu ...

is astonished at ordinary things,

... Only Soma can talk
of Soma without irony or melodrama,
come, go, and come again,
while I go on for some years,

here and now as always

till there's no more now, ...

sprouting like this
on my ordinary

English page,
like Soma,

this mushroom at my feet.

What is *telling* is that some of the poems and lines of the unpublished Soma sequence can be directly traced to the poetry drafts in the 'Mescaline Notes' written under the after-effect of the 1971 mescaline experience. In the final sections of these notes, AKR writes:

29 Aug

7 am

Woke up. Still a bit weak. Mind full of plans

Making mescaline poems—

Want to start all over again—with the next dose....

One can't tell

if mescaline

makes poetry

or really, poetry

makes mescaline.¹³⁵

(p.255) In some of the Soma poems drafted years after the mescaline experiment, there is a strong underlying sense that particular mental states are bestowed and derive from an outer source. The poet needs to invoke this superior power in order to create. Such poems thus play with the concept of inspiration and acknowledge different kinds of 'grace', contrasting the old models of spiritual 'takeovers' with the modern, pragmatic view of life from an ironic perspective:

Jazz Poem for Soma (I)

Soma. Why Soma? Soma is not Vishnu.

...

Soma,

No mimic similar, has no similitude,

Grows ordinary as mystery,

Ancient familiar, the always here,

Soma's the same

As you, and you, and you,

When you make the right mistake

And find your best attitude.

So,

poets beware.¹³⁶

The poem ends with a line from one of the medieval Alvar poems on possession in poetry.¹³⁷ AKR had translated this poem for *Hymns for the Drowning*, a collection of Alvar poetry he was working on around the same time as the unpublished Soma sequence (late 1970s). In a note next to this poem, AKR defines 'Soma' as the 'moments of insight, joy, sorrow, when we are besides ourselves'. He wanted to use the traditional patterns of devotional poetry to write an extended meta-poetic work as a statement on his self-reflecting 'moments' of anxiety, frustration, and inspiration as a 'devotee' of poetry. The Soma project was an attempt at 'demythologisation'¹³⁸ that carries with it a fatality and irony, and was meant as a personal coming to terms with poetry as religion. The play with religious and mythological connotations was of help to AKR to take an ironic distance from the ancient as well as new, mystical poets, and to adopt a pseudo-religious personal voice that was modern and secular:

(p.256)

Nov 7 1978

In my adolescence I rejected 'religion, caste, community.' I think I learned effectively to live without them as well as anyone can—but I'm aware they are very much the 'language of the self', as I said before....

They are of interest to me because I know them in my bones—though I've no religion, I can't resist temples, religious customs, their music and poetry. I sometimes even talk of 'grace' with a small g (sic).¹³⁹

Despite his belief in grace, there always lingers in the poet a fear of not being able to write poetry again. That is the risk and the leap of faith that the poet has to accept when he trusts the voice of 'odd unreason':

Regarding the future, after having written a poem there is always a question, a fear whether you will ever write another. Other poets have spoken of this. I'm a little superstitious about that. I don't know how or when or why one writes a poem.... I don't really have any plans: I hope simply to drift into another poem and still another.¹⁴⁰

On Craft and Revision

In AKR's poetic credo, there is no contradiction in trusting both the poetic muse and the skill of the craftsman: 'Inspiration is not only at the beginning of poems and things; the craft has to be inspired continually. Every little change, every self-criticism you make has to be a creative act. There is no line between craft and inspiration, no real line between intelligence and imagination.'¹⁴¹ As we have seen, the poetic process engages both the unconscious and conscious levels of activity, and they are equally part of the same act of creativity: 'When you

correct a poem, you are not another part of your brain than when you write it in the first place. Writing and re-writing are part of the same process. Creation and (self) criticism are not opposites.¹⁴² Once written, said AKR, it is the craft that 'articulates and holds together the poem'.¹⁴³ And the poet has to work at it over and over 'till it reaches a focus, a clarity'.¹⁴⁴ In his lengthy interview with Chirantan Kulshrestha, AKR reveals that this process follows a certain pattern, but that there can be no fixed standard, since 'Poems come in different ways'. In most explanations of the poetic act, he gives equal weight to original inspiration as to the part of revising and redrafting: '[T]he revision has to be as involved in the fashion as the (p.257) original writing. I can't draw a line. The revision is not made out of reason and calculation, as well as everything else is spontaneous. All of it has to be a combination of both.'¹⁴⁵ AKR did not like haste in the act of composing and was against pursuing a poem to publish it.¹⁴⁶ It often took him years and dozens of drafts to arrive at a satisfying result, as the experience of life could make him reconsider an old composition in a different light. This practice was coherent with his cyclical notion of time and his concept of the poetic art as a continuous transformation of poem and poet, where past, present, and future keep up a creative dialogue:

Sometimes I work on a poem for 10 years—not that it makes the poem any better,—it may ripen or just rot, crabbed beyond recovery. I do rework poems a lot. Something around me often touches me and returns me to an old unfinished piece and makes me see what I tried to say there. I return to it and redo it and if this redoing is any good, it reflects not only the change in myself, but in redoing it I find myself changed. So there is a kind of dialectic between oneself and the poem one is writing.... At that point it's sensibility (I almost said 'character') or nothing—all through, in the beginning, the middle, the end. If not, it'll really show. There'll be dead words, holes, borrowings, helpless patches, betrayals.¹⁴⁷

Writing poetry is, therefore, an imperfect occupation of the different parts of the self. The 'inner' and 'outer' forms have to join hands to produce a poem, and there are frequent ups and downs and miscarriages on the way. Poetry requires a great deal of patience and training, for only through a combination of perseverance, exercise in the techniques of composition, and sensibility can the work reach 'clarity': 'It's a silly act, almost like watching a face in water. Gradually it comes clear. It takes time and willingness to change. And inspiration too, for it comes in little words, phrases.'¹⁴⁸ As a matter of fact, AKR confessed that he threw away a lot his drafts, and deemed only a little part of what was written worth publishing:

Most of what you write is not worth printing, it is still worth writing. It is practice, exercise, and may (and will) suddenly lead to poems, perceptions, recognitions. Exercises in rhyme, stanza, forms, themes from myths or memory, are still ways of soothing, of letting poems happen. While the

conscious mind is engaged in rhyme-search and syllable count, the hero steals the water of life.... Writing is more important than publishing, publishing is more important than making money. The order is the same.¹⁴⁹

(p.258) Poetic practice inevitably involves a series of personal habits and writing techniques, for when 'one mediates things, it becomes a practice'.¹⁵⁰ There is a working and exploring of different forms and things in the practice of writing poetry that is part of routine life for the poet:

Poetry and Our City

Working through sonnet forms,
he turns into an alley hill of garbage cans
brimming with brown bags and plastic,
some poking through the lid, paws
and hands of creatures struggling to escape.

Trying to learn haikus and tankas, he
burns acacia leaves in the fall,
the smoke acrid with hints
of marijuana, mafia flames, orange
saris torn in strips in a riot.

He settles down to free verse but finds
eyes green as a broken bottle glinting
from a face spattered with cinnamon
freckles, the right half shriveled and stitched
around half a lip after an accident.¹⁵¹

One of the routine writing techniques that is disclosed in the AKR Papers is the author's habit of keeping a journal on little notecards on which he pledges to write 'no ideas but in things', and small slips of paper with short lines and phrases on personal incidents, experiences, dreams, etc., as well as quotes by others:

I work out many drafts. I write all the time—I keep notebooks, commonplace books. And I write out a draft quickly, I work on it and maybe, there will be 10 or 15 drafts at the end of the day. And I go back to them later. I was never sure of a poem till the end.¹⁵²

I don't think I deliberately pick and choose odds and bits of experience in my poetry. For days I carry scraps of paper in my pockets, with lines and phrases jotted on them. Eventually I file them in the hope of returning to them some day. The process of looking over these slips helps to identify centers and connections. Eight to ten drafts later I am close to a first version, a form **(p.259)** emerging like a face in the water. Revisions aid me in achieving a proper focus; they also transform the original

experience, whatever it was. But, in a sense, the revisions are never over. A poem is never completed—it is, as Valéry said, only abandoned.¹⁵³

The process of writing is, thus, cyclical and open-ended in AKR's poetic thought and practice. There is no conclusion in poetry. Nor is there a preverbal, original *ur-poem* before it comes to the poet, as other poets have maintained. AKR did not believe in the existence of the poem before it is written, though he acknowledged that a poem could have a material origin somewhere: 'They [poems] get created in an act of not merely writing; writing, rewriting, correcting, all of that is the process through which the poem comes into being. And before it has come into being, I don't think it exists. It exists somewhat as a disturbance, as a stir somewhere. It doesn't come through so quickly, only the first draft.'¹⁵⁴

Some of AKR's compositions on poetry give advice on the benefits of dialoguing and quarrelling with the work of art. As we learn in 'Children, Dreams, Theorems', poetry drafts, like children, need to be continuously cared for in a relation of tactful love until they are fully grown up, for poems may 'get lost' for the poet:

Children like dreams get lost
if they are not held close
caressed kissed named

dreams like poems get lost
if their tails are not knotted
for memory

poems like my father's midnight
theorems get lost if you do not
talk to them, take

their part in a quarrel
with their rival theorems
like dead languages

get lost if you do not smell them
early and change their diapers
sprinkle talcum on their bottoms¹⁵⁵

Notes:

(1.) *Collins English Dictionary*, ed. Patrick Hanks (London and Glasgow: Collins, 1989), p. 1183; and Preminger and Brogan (eds), *The New Princeton Encyclopaedia of Poetry and Poetics*, p. 930.

(2.) See also in this context the complementary functions of the 'inner' and 'outer' approaches in my stylistic as well as thematic analysis of the poem

'Snakes' in my MA dissertation 'A.K. Ramanujan: His Outer and Inner Forms', cited in Chapter 1.

(3.) There are, of course, important exceptions to this general characteristic, as has already been noted in the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2, on the types of reflexivity in AKR's writings. A well-known example is the essay 'Classic Lost and Found' in *CE*, pp. 192-6, which includes comments on AKR's poem 'Prayer to Lord Murugan'. See also his paper 'Contemporary Indian Poetry'.

(4.) See also AKR's comments on concentricity in *PLW*, p. 263 quoted earlier in Chapter 2.

(5.) Ramanujan quoted in Daniels-Ramanujan and Harisson (eds), 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 79. In AKR's unpublished and slightly edited typescript of this interview, the last sentence reads: 'Everything we have and know is part of the instrument of perception' (AKR Papers).

(6.) Ramanujan quoted in Kalven, 'Found in the Translation', p. 35.

(7.) Ramanujan, 'Parables and Commonplaces', p. 141.

(8.) See Ramanujan, 'Annayyana Manava Sastra' (The Elder Brother's Anthropology), in G.B. Joshi (ed.), *Innastu hosa kathegalu: Hannondu kathegala sangra* (Collection of Modern Short Stories by Eleven Authors) (Dharwad: Manohar Granthamala, 1972), pp. 1-11. Translated versions published in English as 'Annaiah's Anthropology' or 'Annayya's Anthropology', trans. M.N. Chakravorthy, *Times Weekly*, Bombay (6 May 1973), pp. 13-20; trans. Narayan Hegde, in Ramachandra Sharma (ed.), *From Cauvery to Godavan: Modern Kannada Short Stories* (New Delhi: Penguin Books, 1992), pp. 44-53; and trans. Manu Shetty, *Indian Literature*, vol. 162 (July-August 1994), pp. 84-92. On the other hand, the Kannada novella *Matthobhana Atmacharitre* is a half-autobiographical, half-fictional story that draws its characters from AKR's family environment in Mysore and plays with the double identity of his self.

(9.) See also his comments in 1976 on publishing his journal, quoted earlier in the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2.

(10.) Ramanujan, 'A Poem Is Born'.

(11.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 May 1984), n.p. A year later AKR noted: 'I did write poems till September and put together a volume'. See Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (April 1985).

(12.) Ramanujan, 'Notes towards a Journal'. The first sentence and the last paragraph reproduced here from the manuscript are also quoted in Chapter 4.

- (13.) Ramanujan, 'Waterfalls in a Bank', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 189.
- (14.) Ramanujan quoted in Advani, 'A Whole World in a Poem', p. 15.
- (15.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (4 August 1982), n.p.
- (16.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 15.
- (17.) Ramanujan quoted in Advani, 'A Whole World in a Poem', p. 15.
- (18.) Ramanujan quoted in Carlos Monteiro, 'Siva Sings in Chicago', *Midday*, Bombay (31 July 1990), n.p.
- (19.) Ramanujan quoted in Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', p. 12.
- (20.) Ramanujan, 'On the Need for Linguistic Autobiography', unpublished notes, AKR Papers (late 1980s).
- (21.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar.
- (22.) See Ramanujan quoted earlier in this chapter in Daniels-Ramanujan and Harisson (eds), 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 79.
- (23.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (4 August 1982), n.p.
- (24.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 146.
- (25.) The quotes listed here chronologically are from the following sources: Ramanujan, 'A.K. Ramanujan Writes ...', *Poetry Society Bulletin*, London (1966), n.p.; Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 42; Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan', p. 182; Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (13 April 1982), n.p.; Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 142; Ramanujan quoted in Vaiju Mahindroo, 'An Indian Poet's Several Traditions', *UNESCO Feature*, Paris (1982), pp. 17-18; Ramanujan quoted in Purabi Banerjee, 'A Seasoned Poet Speaks', *Hindustan Times*, Delhi (17 April 1983), p. 4; and Ramanujan quoted in Girish Shahane, 'Working Out the Contradictions', *The Independent*, Bombay (28 July 1990), n.p.
- (26.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', pp. 141-2.
- (27.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.
- (28.) See Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 145.
- (29.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, pp. 42-3. AKR's views on the art of composing and decomposing poetry will be analysed in the next section of this chapter. See also Appendix 2.

(30.) Ramanujan in *UPP*, p. 35.

(31.) Ramanujan, 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry', p. 62.

(32.) 'A Meditation' was originally written in Kannada and published in *Kuntobille* (1990). Several drafts of it in English have been identified in the AKR Papers. AKR's final English version of this poem was first published in *CP*, p. 239 and later as *Hopscotch* in Tonse N.K. Raju and Shouri Daniels-Ramanujan (trans), in *A.K. Ramanujan: Poems and a Novella* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 2006), pp. 163-4. Raju and Daniels-Ramanujan do not acknowledge that the version of 'A Meditation' included in this posthumous collection is, in fact, AKR's own transcreation of his Kannada poem.

(33.) Ramanujan, unpublished draft of a paper titled 'Nature and Culture'. In this context, AKR liked to quote the story of St. John Perse on a Mongolian conqueror who, wanting to take home a foreign bird, had to take with him the nest, the tree, the soil, the province, and eventually the entire empire. See, for example, *PLW*, p. 297.

(34.) See Ramanujan, 'The Indian Oedipus', in *CE*, p. 380. As mentioned, the inverted tree image also appears in several early poems like 'December Emblems' (unpublished, c. 1957), 'A Plant' (p. 1959), and in 'A Poem on Particulars' (p. 1966).

(35.) Ramanujan, 'A Meditation', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (30 August 1989), n.p. AKR adds a note to this poem: 'Reworked from the Kannada original.' Verse lines 2 and 3 are from Basavanna, *Vachana* 820, trans. Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 19. This Kannada bhakti poem is also quoted in the section 'First Thirty Years in India' in Chapter 3.

(36.) Ramanujan, 'Poetry', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (1983), n.p.

(37.) Ramanujan, 'No Fifth Man', *The Black Hen*, in *CP*, p. 245.

(38.) Ramanujan, 'The Black Hen', *The Black Hen*, in *CP*, p. 195, quoted in the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4.

(39.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.

(40.) Ramanujan quoted in Kalven, 'Found in the Translation', p. 36.

(41.) Ramanujan, 'Connect!' *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 178.

(42.) Ramanujan, 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' n.p. Quoted also in the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5.

(43.) Ramanujan, 'Daily Drivel: A Monologue', in *UPP*, p. 25.

- (44.) Ramanujan, 'Which Reminds Me', in *CP*, p. 25.
- (45.) See the paragraph quoted earlier from Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 142.
- (46.) Ramanujan quoted in Banerjee, 'A Seasoned Poet Speaks', p. 4.
- (47.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.
- (48.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 33.
- (49.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 33.
- (50.) Ramanujan quoted in Nakulan (T.K. Doraiswamy), 'A Meeting with A.K. Ramanujan', *Thought* (29 November 1969), p. 12.
- (51.) Ramanujan, notecard, AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.
- (52.) See also the note 'Glass is good, it reflects to the outsider, and refracts for insiders'. Ramanujan, note next to 'Building for the Year 2000', AKR Papers, quoted in the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 and 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3.
- (53.) Ramanujan, 'A.K. Ramanujan Writes ...', *Poetry Society Bulletin*, n.p.
- (54.) See, for example, 'The Striders', 'Still Life', 'An Image for Politics', and 'A Poem on Particulars', among others, in *The Striders*.
- (55.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.
- (56.) Ramanujan quoted in T.S. Sundararajan, 'Encounter with a Poet', *Hindustan Times* (2 November 1969), n.p.
- (57.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (25 November 1979), n.p.
- (58.) Ramanujan, unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (c. 1989), n.p.
- (59.) Ramanujan, 'Haiku-3', in Raju and Daniels-Ramanujan (trans), *Poems and a Novella*, p. 143. See also Ramachandra Sharma's translation of this poem.
- (60.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Style', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p. For the full quote, see the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7.
- (61.) Ramanujan, 'Two Poems on Poetry', parts I and II, unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (16-17 April 1956), n.p.
- (62.) Ramanujan quoted in Nissim Ezekiel, 'Small-Scale Reflections on a Great Friend', *Deccan Herald* (24 July 1993), p. 4.

- (63.) Ramanujan, diary, 'From A Journal: Passages', AKR Papers (28 October 1976), n.p.; underline in the original.
- (64.) Ramanujan, 'When Is a Riddle Not a Riddle', unpublished draft of a paper for the Jerusalem Conference, AKR Papers (1989), n.p.
- (65.) Ramanujan, 'Notes towards a Journal', n.p. See the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4.
- (66.) Ramanujan, 'On the Death of a Poem', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 142. AKR often uses witty puns (here, 'sentence' and 'conscience') in short poems to make his point. Bruce King suggests, in *Three Indian Poets*, pp. 96-7, that this poem published in 1986 is aware of poststructuralist theory. But AKR could not have been exposed to poststructuralism when he composed it since it was drafted as early as 1961. See also Appendix 2.
- (67.) Ramanujan, 'A Stab at a Poem', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (16 November 1972-27 October 1973), n.p. There are several drafts and versions of this poem in the Papers.
- (68.) Ramanujan, 'A Ballet for Prepositions and Others' (3rd stanza), unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (2 November 1959), n.p. Compare also with the 'Fall-minded' oranges in 'A Poem on Particulars', in *CP*, pp. 53-4, quoted in the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3.
- (69.) Ramanujan, untitled, unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (31 July 1983).
- (70.) Jaques Garelli, 'The Act of Writing as an Apprehension of the Enigma of Being in the World' and 'The Poem as Ontology of Reference', in Thomas J. Harrison (ed.), Lois Oppenheim (trans.), *The Favorite Malice* (New York: Out of London Press, 1983).
- (71.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 141.
- (72.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 October 1976), n.p.
- (73.) Ramanujan, unpublished notecards on linguistics and poetics, AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.
- (74.) Ramanujan, 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry', typed drafts of a paper, AKR Papers (c. 1960), n.p.
- (75.) Ramanujan, 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' n.p.
- (76.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.

(77.) Ramanujan, 'Pain', in 'Images', *The Black Hen*, in *CP*, p. 259. There are two more poems on pain in *The Black Hen*, published posthumously, that were written in the early 1990s, when AKR suffered from acute physical ailment in the spine and leg.

(78.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13. This quote and the folktale alluded to in the poem are also discussed in the section 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(79.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13. The poem 'Which Reminds Me' is cited by AKR in several of his notecards in the Papers as a 'poem on poetry'.

(80.) Among Indian poets in the twentieth century, the most notorious examples are Aurobindo Ghose and Rabindranath Tagore.

(81.) AKR, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1980), n.p.

(82.) Ramanujan, 'A River', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 38.

(83.) A.K. Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', *Literary Criterion*, vol. 2, no. 3 (1955), p. 36.

(84.) This phrase is a verse line from Ramanujan, 'Silly Couplets', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (c. 1992), n.p.

(85.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 October 1976), n.p.

(86.) This phrase may be a reference to the last stanza in 'Romanzen V' from Heine's *Neue Gedichte* (1844), which depicts a dialogue between the sun, the poet, and different animals from monkey to glow-worm. Only the glow-worm challenges the sun, but it can brag about being 'a big light' only during the night. For an English translation, see *The Complete Poems of Heinrich Heine: A Modern English Version* (New York: Suhrkamp Publications, 1982).

(87.) Ramanujan, 'The Striders', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 3.

(88.) Ramanujan quoted in Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', p. 12. See AKR's comments quoted in the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4 on the aesthetic experience and attitude to the object.

(89.) See, in this context, another insect poem, Yeats's 'Long-Legged Fly', in *The Collected Poems of W.B. Yeats* (Hertfordshire: Wordsworth, 2000), p. 287: 'Like a long-legged fly upon the stream/ His mind moves upon silence' (9-10). Only when the waters are still, that is, the mind is silent, can one see the fly on the stream.

See also the following excerpt from S.T. Coleridge's *Biographia Literaria*, vol. 1 (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1984), pp. 124–5:

Most of my readers will have observed a small water-insect on the surface of rivulets, which throws a cinque-spotted shadow fringed with prismatic colours on the sunny bottom of the brook; and will have noticed, how the little animal wins its way up against the stream, by alternate pulses of active and passive motion, now resisting the current, and now yielding to it in order to gather strength and a momentary fulcrum for a further propulsion. This is no unapt emblem of the mind's self-experience in the act of thinking. There are evidently two powers at work, which relatively to each other are active and passive; and this is not possible without an intermediate faculty, which is at once both active and passive. (In philosophical language, we must denominate this inter-mediate faculty in all its degrees and determinations, the IMAGINATION. But in common language, and especially on the subject of poetry, we appropriate the name to a superior degree of the faculty, joined to a superior voluntary control over it.)

(90.) Ezra Pound, 'Vorticism', p. 467.

(91.) Ramanujan, 'The Striders', *Poetry*, vol. 98, no. 4 (July 1961), p. 228.

(92.) Ramanujan, 'Fear', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (26 March 1960).

(93.) Ramanujan, 'No Dream, No Symbol', *Quest*, vol. 3 (August 1957–February 1958). The unpublished draft 'Two Poems on Love' is quoted earlier in this chapter.

(94.) See, for instance, Ramanujan, 'Snakes', 'Anxiety', 'Fear', 'The Black Hen', and 'Fear No Fall', in *CP*, pp. 4–5, 29, 132, 195, 275–7.

(95.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', p. 36.

(96.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', pp. 50–4.

(97.) Ramanujan, journal on 'Composition', AKR Papers (25 July 1985), n.p.; underlining in original. See also Appendix 2.

(98.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (7 November 1978), n.p.

(99.) Ramanujan, 'Prayers to Lord Murugan', *Second Sight*, in *CE*, p. 196.

(100.) Ramanujan, 'Prayer before Suicide—A Sonnet', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (9 November 1956), n.p.

(101.) See the episode from this journal quoted in the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4.

(102.) Clay, pot, potter, and sun are common metaphors for the act of poetic creation in the Indian tradition.

(103.) Ramanujan, 'A Poem Is Born', pp. 1-2, 4-5, 7; underlines in the original. The last four lines are also quoted in the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4.

(104.) Though AKR began as a poet writing in Kannada, at that time he thought of English as the superior language from a linguistic as well as a publishing point of view. On the first page of the same journal, he writes in parenthesis: 'These strutting poets, their meanness, and their boasts, they were intolerable. After all they wrote in Kannada or Tamil; but English, that was a richer, subtler medium, it had a humbling great tradition. And, now, where could he print it.' See Ramanujan, 'A Poem Is Born', p. 1.

(105.) See, for example, Ramanujan, 'Two Poems on Poetry', part II, quoted earlier in this section of the chapter.

(106.) Ramanujan, 'He Too Was a Light Sleeper Once', in *CP*, p. 162. This poem was drafted in the late 1960s, but was published only in 1986.

(107.) Ramanujan, 'The Whip', *Thought* (November 1957), n.p.

(108.) Ramanujan, 'I Listened', in Lal (ed.), *Modern Indian Poetry in English*, n.p.

(109.) Ramanujan, 'It', *The Black Hen*, in *CP*, p. 215.

(110.) Jung is quoted, for instance, in AKR's 'From A Journal: Passages', and a Jungian therapist he visited is identified in a diary entry, AKR Papers (29 October 1987).

(111.) See, for instance, Carl Jung, *Man and His Symbols* (London: Aldus Books, 1964), pp. 13-15.

(112.) Ramanujan, 'Snakes', *The Striders*, in *CP*, pp. 4-5. The first stanza of this poem is also quoted in the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4.

(113.) J. Myers and M. Simms, *The Longman Dictionary of Poetic Terms* (New York: Orient Longman, 1989), p. 26.

(114.) Ramanujan, 'I Can't Get Close to a Poem ...', untitled, unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (c. 1979), n.p.

(115.) Ramanujan, 'Why Songs Don't Get Written', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (c. 1970).

(116.) Ramanujan, 'From Where?' *The Black Hen*, in *CP*, p. 271.

- (117.) Ramanujan, 'Translation', unpublished poetry draft, trans. from the Kannada by the author, AKR Papers (25 October–1 November 1988), n.p.
- (118.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (4 August 1982), n.p.
- (119.) In a letter to J. Taylor dated 27 February 1818, John Keats wrote: 'If poetry comes not as naturally as leaves to a tree, it had better not come at all.' As cited in the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7. Keats is one of the poets AKR read profusely. On 'The Black Hen' and Keats, see also the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4.
- (120.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.
- (121.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.
- (122.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.
- (123.) Ramanujan, private notecards, AKR Papers (1983 or 1984), n.p.
- (124.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 44. The phrase 'climb to one's proper dark' is borrowed from W.B. Yeats, 'The Statues', in *The Collected Poems* (London: Macmillan, 1950).
- (125.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 44.
- (126.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 October 1976), n.p.; underline in the original.
- (127.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.
- (128.) Ramanujan, 'Still Another View of Grace', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 45.
- (129.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar, n.p.
- (130.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1980), n.p.; underline in the original.
- (131.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 32.
- (132.) Ramanujan quoted in A.S. Murali Venkatesh, 'A Poet and His Perceptions', *Deccan Herald*, Bangalore (17 August 1980), n.p.
- (133.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 139. See also Appendix 2 on the cycle of 'Soma Poems' and the making of *Second Sight*.
- (134.) Ramanujan, 'On Discovering That Soma Is a Mushroom', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (1979). AKR might have read in those years a book by R. Gordon Wasson titled *Soma: Divine Mushroom of Immortality* (The Hague:

Mouton, 1968), as it contains a chapter by AKR's friend and colleague Wendy Doniger, who joined the University of Chicago in 1978.

(135.) Ramanujan, 'Mescaline Notes', n.p. See also Appendix 2.

(136.) Ramanujan, 'Jazz Poem for Soma (I)', unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (c. 1979), n.p.

(137.) See Ramanujan, 'The Takeover', trans. Nammalvar. This poem is quoted in the section 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7.

(138.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 139.

(139.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar, n.p.; parenthesis in original.

(140.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 49.

(141.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 45.

(142.) Ramanujan, diary, 'Writing: Some Thoughts', AKR Papers (c. 1983), n.p.; underline of the title in the original.

(143.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1980), n.p.

(144.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 October 1976), n.p. See also the longer quote in the context of prakriti and samskriti in the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5.

(145.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 150.

(146.) There is, for instance, an unpublished draft titled 'The Fable of the Printer and the Moth, Chinese Style, or the Dangers of Rushing into Print'. See Ramanujan, unpublished poetry draft, AKR Papers (early 1960s).

(147.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 45.

(148.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.

(149.) Ramanujan, diary, 'Writing'.

(150.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.

(151.) Ramanujan, 'Poetry and Our City', *The Black Hen*, in *CP*, p. 242.

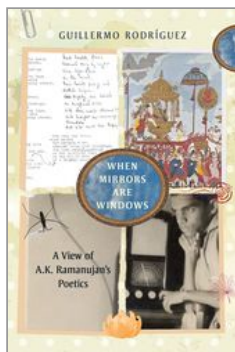
(152.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', n.p.

(153.) Ramanujan quoted in Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan', p. 181. The first phrase in this paragraph is also quoted in the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4.

(154.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', pp. 149-50.

(155.) Ramanujan, 'Children, Dreams, Theorems', in *UPP*, p. 12.

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When Mirrors Are Windows: A View of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics

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Relating Poetries

A.K. Ramanujan's 'Outer' Poetics

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Abstract and Keywords

The critical approach followed in this chapter is pluralistic and takes into consideration the diverse literary and critical traditions present in Ramanujan's scholarly work and their different conceptualizations of poetry and poetics. These multiple components are not placed in a hegemonic relationship, but treated as a network of ideas that feed into Ramanujan's 'outer' poetics. It relates his professional involvement with several Western critical disciplines and Indian traditional poetics and their impact on his poetic thought, covering the mother-tongue (Tamil *Sangam*, Tamil and Kannada bhakti) and father-tongue traditions (literature in English, Sanskrit poetics), and the nineteenth- and twentieth-century Western and Indian poets and their use of the past. The description of these literary traditions and schools draws attention to the scholar's characteristic interpretation of their systems of poetry in the light of his own critical notions and ideals.

Keywords: literary criticism and theory, New Criticism, structuralism, comparative literary studies, contemporary poetry, T.S. Eliot, modern Kannada poetry, Sanskrit poetics, medieval bhakti poetics, Tamil poetics

*you can sometimes count
every orange
on a tree
but never
all the trees
in a single*

orange.

—A.K. Ramanujan, 'A Poem on Particulars', *The Striders*

The descriptive outline in this chapter on the multiple poetic traditions and critical schools that AKR studied and foregrounded in his interdisciplinary work draws mostly from his lecture notes, interviews, and essays, including rare published and unpublished material. It is not an exhaustive list, but pays attention to AKR's scholarly interpretation and evaluation of a selection of critical and poetic systems in the light of his own ideas, choices, and poetic ideals. AKR's poetics is presented in this chapter chiefly from the point of view of the multidisciplinary scholar and literary critic, drawing a genealogical tree of his manifold approaches to poetry and poetic traditions, and their 'relationships'. It is a sample anthology, therefore, that is contingent on meta-criticism, linguistic theory and literary criticism, comparative literary criticism, and practical or applied criticism.

Western Theories and the Study of Poetry

American New Criticism

In the first phase of his academic career between 1950 and 1958, AKR held several posts at universities across India, teaching English (**p.269**) and English literature. During those years and through the 1960s, American New Criticism had a considerable impact on poets, academics, and literary critics in the USA as well as in India, and AKR was not left untouched by New Critical theory and the ideas of the modernist poets which preceded it, like T.S. Eliot and his 'objective correlative'. He was, at that time, particularly drawn to the 'close reading' of the poetic text, the idea of the poem as a self-referential object, and the notion of dramatism in poetry. AKR's assessment of Walt Whitman's poetry in 'Notes on Walt Whitman' (1955), his first published essay in English, is an example of New Critical practice which proposed a close reading of words in a text as opposed to the formulation of extra-textual or abstract ideas about a poet. New Criticism, as a formalist school of criticism, led to the ideology and critical practice of 'the text in itself', which isolated the work from the author and the historical context. The meaning of the text was always inside it, and the role of the critic was to uncover the meaning by close reading of the text without attending to the ideas and subjectivity of the author or the reader. AKR was a lecturer of English literature at Lingaraj College, Belgaum, at the time he wrote this article, and may have had access to the critical works of American critics like J.C. Ransom, W.K. Wimsatt, M.C. Beardsley, C. Brooks, and others, who cultivated New Critical theories in the 1940s and 1950s.¹ He gives the following explanation of his critical thinking in this early article on Walt Whitman:

'Philosophy' is irrelevant wherever it is unrealised in the verbal realities of poetry. An ideal reader is interested in getting at all the poetry there is in a poet; and summarising 'ideas', extracting 'messages' is not the best way of

getting into touch with poetry. He is concerned with the way poetry assimilates 'ideas' into the texture and the structure of its being. So a critic as critic approaches poetry as poetry, poetry as experience—not as biographical data, historical evidence, psychological symptom, or as a reservoir of philosophic insights or as a linguistic witness.²

In this article, which cites Eliot and D.H. Lawrence, AKR stresses the objectivity that Whitman achieves at times and which brings it closer to the imagists. This search for the crystal-like object in poetry remained a constant obsession in AKR: 'I've taught myself to see poems, plays and paintings as forms and objects.'³

Years later, in the 1960s, after taking up Dravidian literature in Chicago, AKR further absorbed and introduced in his work the ideas **(p.270)** of the American rhetorician Kenneth Burke, who was considered an exponent of the American New Critics in the 1940s and was close to some of the modernist poets AKR admired like Marianne Moore, Carlos Williams, and E.E. Cummings. Burke viewed literature as symbolic action; he perceived the poem as drama, a notion that suited AKR to interpret the poetics of 'interior landscapes' in Tamil Sangam poetry.⁴ Burke's critical concepts allowed AKR to draw comparisons between the dramatic criticism of the Indian (Sanskrit and Tamil) and the Western tradition. Several of the American scholar's works, in particular *A Grammar of Motives*,⁵ are cited in a cross-section of AKR's essays on diverse subjects, including Sanskrit poetics: 'Poetry is a kind of drama, drama is a kind of poetry; so the criticism is dramatistic like Burke's. Enactment is a favourite word in modern criticism, the Indians did not use it but would have understood the usage.'⁶ In approaching both Western and Indian texts, AKR's ultimate goal was 'to attend closely to a single text, to see the text itself as a performance, the structure, not simply as a static inlay of categories but a choreography for live feelings'.⁷

Relating Linguistics to Poetry

Disenchanted with teaching English, AKR decided to study linguistics and became a research fellow in the language project at Deccan College, Poona (1958–9), where he attended a summer school of linguistics. In 1959, he received a Fulbright fellowship to study linguistics (anthropological linguistics, generative grammar, poeticism, and stylistics) at Indiana University Bloomington under Fred W. Householder, Edward Stankiewicz, Carl F. Voegelin, and others, which sparked off his academic career in the USA and a lifelong allegiance to linguistics (see the sections 'First 30 Years in India' and 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3, and Chart 1). The close link between linguistics and the writing of poetry is evident from the early stages in AKR's career. He often explored the creative interrelation between these two disciplines while underlining the limitations of linguistics as a tool for poets and pointing out the dangers of being too self-conscious about linguistic aspects in the act of writing:

I don't draw lines between doing linguistics and writing poems because they are all a search for forms that make meaning. Though in linguistics, if you do **(p.271)** technical linguistics which I have done, you try to, you will not express your feelings. That is true, but the sense of form is very important there. I might say that poetry has led me as much into linguistics as the other way round. That is why there is (the) study of semiotics, a new branch of linguistics. Last quarter I gave a course on semiotics in poetry and the reading of poetry. How can linguistics help our reading? I don't know how it helps writing poetry. It certainly helps reading poetry and certainly there are limits to it. That is what I was exploring. But I don't know if the tone and the phrasing of the poem comes through linguistics or not, because you are attending to something else. You are not looking at rules, when you are writing.... I think if you are too conscious of it, the poem becomes contrived.⁸

One of AKR's main occupations in the field of linguistics was its theoretical and practical application to the study of poetry. He was intensely devoted to the scientific analysis of the language and structure of poetry. This analytical practice did not interfere negatively with his creativity as a poet. As AKR clarified in his interviews, what may upset a poem in the act of composing was not linguistic knowledge per se, but undue self-consciousness:

You see, linguistics is not a hindrance in the sense that to be a hindrance is to be self-conscious about the particulars of the language you are writing in. A lot of the linguistics I do is very theoretical and applies to the study of poetry, things like that. I really believed in the way great poems are structured, the way language works in poetry, in a passage of Shakespeare etc.

... Of course there will be poems that fail by too much self-consciousness, and they do fail sometimes. And when they do, I hope I'll have the good sense not to publish them.⁹

Given AKR's early professional background in linguistics, it is not surprising that a number of theoretical arguments in his poetics stem from the study of linguistic schools that had a following at American universities in the 1960s. Some of the most prominent linguists and their literary theories are cited throughout AKR's prose. In his academic career in the USA, he began to study general linguistics and descriptive linguistics, and moved from there to the anthropology of language, structuralism, and semiotics, seeking out links between linguistics and forms of communication in general, including poetry:

For nearly ten years I taught straight linguistics at the University of Chicago, morphology, syntax and so on, which I enjoyed doing. But because I had always been interested in folklore and in the anthropology of

language— **(p.272)** structuralism, semiotics, connections between linguistics and forms of communication in general—over the years I have become more and more involved in South Asian languages.¹⁰

In 1966, as an associate professor of Dravidian studies and linguistics at the Department of South Asian Languages and Civilizations of the University of Chicago, AKR planned a 300–350-page-long book on ‘Literature as Language’, a vast project which was never undertaken. A year earlier, he had taught a course on ‘Poetic Form’ with the linguist E. Stankiewicz. ‘One of the principles of organization for the book,’ as AKR noted in the preliminary project draft, ‘would be to juxtapose what poets have said about language and poetry and what linguists have said about them’.¹¹ He also intended to include a section on Indian, Chinese, Japanese, and Russian essays on poetic language.

AKR was not interested in the historical study of texts, nor was he engaged in a purely theoretical exploration of linguistic concepts and theories. In his interdisciplinary approach to literature, he searched for a larger system that would allow him to connect diverse texts, traditions, and concepts to poetry. In his notes, he reveals the purpose behind his scholarly method: ‘Systemic, “systematic”—not historical, representative—I’m not scholar enough to quote always the earliest or the “best” versions of each theory. Interested in relationships, how the concepts are related to one another, to concepts outside the system, to poetry itself: or is it only to Indian poetry?’¹² The system(s) of thought he adopted as a scholar of literature indeed accommodated various concept systems and theories in the course of his career. He moved from the study of texts as objects and forms, to context and cultural patterns, and to dealing with the ‘text’ of cultures, meaning as relations, etc. His theoretical foundations related to linguistics and the study of poetry thus ranged from formalism to structuralism and semiotics. Eventually, AKR also incorporated into his work some aspects of poststructuralism, which interpreted literature primarily as discourse and theory.¹³ He did revise his structuralist position in the early 1980s, for example, in papers such as ‘Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?’ and ‘Where Mirrors Are Windows’. In these essays, he postulated context-sensitivity and reflexivity as fundamental principles for the study of Indian texts and cultural forms, instead of earlier structuralist methods based on binary systems and analogy:

(p.273) Linguists and anthropologists, especially structuralists in general, have operated on this assumption for a while. To them, any native speaker contains the whole of his language; any informant, any myth or ritual, contains the whole of the culture. Such a holographic view implies uniform texture, the replication of one structure in all systems of a culture, without negations, warps or discontinuities and with no pockets in space or

time. It is a very attractive view, especially to people in a hurry, and I have myself held it for many years, though somewhat uneasily.¹⁴

According to some of AKR's colleagues, however, postmodern theories did not shake his structuralist convictions. The late Norman Cutler, AKR's long-time collaborator at the Department of South Asian Languages and Civilizations, defined him as a structuralist, remarking that poststructuralism as pure theory made AKR feel uneasy in the wake of the rather aggressive invasion of postcolonial and postmodern theorizing at American universities in the late 1980s, a trend 'which forgot about the texts and abandoned the reading and study of the sources'.¹⁵

Charles Sanders Peirce and Ferdinand de Saussure, fathers of semiotics and modern linguistics, respectively, along with Mikhail Bakhtin, Roman Jakobson, and Roland Barthes, are some of the linguists and literary critics who are repeatedly cited in AKR's prose and in interviews. AKR arrived at Indiana University Bloomington to study anthropological linguistics, generative grammar, poetics, and stylistics at a crucial time for linguistics in America. The years 1959-60 coincided with the first publications in English of the landmark works of two of the most influential scholars of linguistics and poetic theory in the twentieth century: Ferdinand de Saussure's *Course in General Linguistics* and Roman Jakobson's 'Closing Statement: Linguistics and Poetics'.¹⁶ Furthermore, the Indiana University 'Conference on Style' organized in 1958 and the subsequent publication of the papers in T.A. Sebeok's collection were path-breaking events that intensified and expanded the application of linguistics and homologous theoretical models originating from structural and generative grammar. AKR had first focused on generative-transformational grammar in his research, completing his PhD dissertation on 'A Generative Grammar of Kannada' at Indiana University Bloomington in 1963, but soon connected linguistics with literature (poetics) and cultural studies, a tendency followed by many other linguists in the 1960s and 1970s.

(p.274) Russian and Czech Formalism

AKR's only monographic essay on linguistics as a concept system for the study of poetry is the unpublished paper 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry'. Drafted around 1960, it can be read in the light of the contributions to the study of poetry made by the Russian and Czech formalists, and later structuralist linguists, in their critical essays published in English by the late 1950s. AKR's paper follows, in general terms, a structuralist agenda for the study of poetry and echoes the principles of Saussure, the Slavic formalists, and Jakobson,¹⁷ while acknowledging the techniques of *discourse analysis*.

The first part of this paper and its conclusions present linguistics as a valuable scientific tool to define and analyse the linguistic and poetic structure of a poem.

Linguistics is hailed as an accurate means to describe, as Jakobson stated, the 'literariness' of a poetic text:

The 'poetry' of a poem is a unique organization of all the resources of a language, its phonology, its morphology, its syntax, its structure in discourse and its semantic fields.

... Linguistics, from this point of view, is the descriptive study of the structural resources of a language. Criticism, at least one part of it, is the study of the deployment of these resources for qualitatively defined poetic ends. It is the study of what makes a poem a poem, not how it came to be written.... [L]inguistics, as developed in the last thirty years, offers a vocabulary for such discussion. Its metalanguage is precise, its terms are embedded in a matrix of relationships. Its procedure is empirical as well as system-oriented.¹⁸

Furthermore, AKR formulates in this paper his interpretation of linguistics as an analytical system for the study of poetry that can take various directions (synchronic, diachronic, and extra-textual) according to the preference of the critic:

Like all such concept-systems, [linguistics] is also heuristic in that such a repertory of ideas is something to think with. For instance, the dichotomy of the synchronic and diachronic aspects of language can be usefully extended to the study of a poem. A poem can be studied as a self-contained synchronic system; or diachronically, as a 'reflex' of a whole genre, an instance of a tradition, or as an end-product of a series of changing drafts.

... Techniques of syntax and discourse-analysis can be extended not only to the study of single poems but to the study of poem-sequences (as in Rilke, Baudelaire, Yeats, Blake, or the sonnet-cycles of the Renaissance) where 'one poem lights up another' (Yeats' phrase), where tactical arrangement itself is a poetic device.¹⁹

(p.275) We can infer from this passage that AKR already had in mind in the early 1960s some of the critical concepts he gradually incorporated into the study of Indian poetry and poetic traditions. The concern with reflexivity and the analysis of families of poems referred to in this paper in the context of nineteenth- and twentieth-century European poetry were among his favourite topics from the 1980s in the study of intertextuality in Indian literature (see the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 and further in this chapter).²⁰

The opening sections of 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry' and the conclusions in the last part of the paper unmistakably trace out some of the principal tenets of the Russian and Czech formalists, which conjoin in the work of Jakobson. One

of the issues repeatedly tackled by AKR is the conception of form as meaning in a poem:

[A] few words regarding the relationship of poetry and language might be in order. The theme of these remarks is given by Nietzsche's observation that what others see as content the artist sees as form. (It was the linguist De Saussure who said that language is form, not substance; one may here hazard the remark that poetry is 'parole' aspiring to the condition of 'language'.)²¹

... What others see as form, as the grammar of a language, the 'rhythm' of a novel, the geometry of a face in a painting, the artist sees as theme, motif, 'content'. As one of these 'forms', linguistic form enters into the poetic form.

... A poem, composed in language has two interacting systems: the linguistic structure which is at once the medium and the content, and a less tangible but no less real poetic structure.... Both the structures (so far as we know) are arbitrary.... In utilising the linguistic resources of a language, a poem transforms the sign itself into a referent; the linguistic code itself becomes part of the message.... The form of the poem (both linguistic and poetic) is what is conveyed, the form is the content; the whole poem is a kind of metonymy for the forms of experience.

AKR proceeds in this essay to summarize the main points of the Slavic formalist approach to poetry, borrowing their general conceptual framework as well as metalanguage:

a) A poet plays between two matrices, the linguistic and the poetic, and the two codes are integrated toward the yielding of one message; b) in this process, where all is form, the form itself is the 'content', the 'code' itself is the 'message'; c) this is achieved by various devices, all of them variously reducing the redundancy of the language system; some of the devices are seen to be the employment of structurally permitted but unused sequences **(p.276)** (in phonology, morphology, syntax, and more commonly in lexical selection and semantic organization), as well as a tight knitting of all the resources of a language towards an interplay of foregrounded structures.²²

AKR does not, however, elaborate on the chronological and conceptual development that took place from Russian formalism to Czech formalism (the Prague School), a process that is traced in Victor Erlich's monograph on Russian formalism, and which eventually led to Jakobson's formulations on poetic language. In later years, when AKR discussed style in a text, he did so predominantly with the aid of the formalistic theories he had absorbed as a student of linguistics. It is thus that he based his notion of the 'ideal poem' on

the economy of language or, in other words, on the idea that a poem 'aspires' to be a perfect object:

Thus literary style can be defined in terms of a reduction of redundancy; the ideal poem being characterised by a zero redundancy, where nothing is predictable and everything is functional and contextual and mutually defining.... [T]he limit is zero; it is here that the poem becomes an object, with its own 'sound-look', the message itself becomes the code, and la langue and la parole are no longer in the Universal-particular relation. This is the symbolist dream, where a poem is all Form and no Content ('aspiring to the condition of music'),²³ where it is all expression and no Communication, where Language-form is no longer Means but End. Nietzsche said, what's form to the ordinary eye is content to the artist's eye. One may add, what's content (like 'story', 'character' etc. to a novel reader or 'the portrait of a mother' to a gallery-goer) is itself form to the poet. Poetry, we take it, is the eidos of our notion of 'literary style'.²⁴

The concern with form was also present in AKR's anthropological study of texts as systems of signification. This was an area of interest he took up in the 1970s and was more often than not tied to the study of poetry.²⁵ Several essays and lecture notes refer to the relation between form and content in poetry, art, and culture. As various aspects of this larger issue have already been examined with regard to AKR's aesthetic thought (see the section 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5),²⁶ it will suffice to cite here a relevant fragment from an unpublished piece on the topic:

The organization of the material of the world, this elements' list as anthropologists would call it, is a semantic organization.... Trees, people, episodes, themes are the content of a poem, looked at from outside it; as they **(p.277)** are objective substantive elements of a culture to the naïve outsider; but they are elements in a system, components of a form to the poet in a tradition and [to] the native in a culture.²⁷

Roman Jakobson and Structuralist Poetics

Though Noam Chomsky's early work in the field of linguistics attracted AKR's attention in his initial stages as a doctoral researcher in the USA,²⁸ it was Jakobson who remained the most influential linguist in AKR's work. The noted Russian scholar, widely recognized as the founder of structuralist poetics, conceived literary analysis on the model of modern linguistic theory. Echoing Jakobson on the relevance of linguistics to the study of poetry, AKR stated in his early essay 'Indian Poetics' (1974), that 'poetics is firmly grounded in the underpinnings of grammatical and semantic theory'.²⁹ Throughout AKR's prose work, several of the models and theories propounded by Jakobson are tested in the context of diverse poetic traditions.

Paradigmatic and Syntagmatic Relations: Metaphor and Metonymy

Jakobson's ideas on poetics as a language-based scientific method stand out in most of AKR's analyses of classical and medieval Indian poetic traditions. One of the tenets of Jakobsonian theory is that the language of poetry can be analysed on the basis of the parallelisms that exist in the poetic function, which are identified at the paradigmatic and syntagmatic levels of linguistic structure. The notion of 'grammatical parallelism'³⁰ is an argument that is invoked, for instance, in the introduction to medieval vachana poetry in Kannada. Vachana poetry, according to AKR, has, despite its apparent spontaneity and rejection of structure, its own 'repertoire' of structures: 'In the free-seeming verse there are always patterns that loom and withdraw, figures of sound that rhyme and ring bells with the figures of meaning.'³¹ In 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle', one of AKR's last essays, he defines figures of sense in terms of Sanskrit poetics (*arthalamkara*) and of Jakobson's syntagmatic and paradigmatic relations:

Figures of sense play with the logical syntax of language, with linguistic relationships. As Roman Jakobson showed, metaphoric figures are paradigmatic, metonymic figures are syntagmatic (1987). These two basic dimensions are, of course, not independent of each other; they are also **(p. 278)** variously projected onto each other, especially in poetry: lists project the paradigmatic onto the syntagmatic, parallelisms project the syntagmatic on to the paradigmatic.³²

Here, AKR alludes to Jakobson's influential essay 'Two Aspects of Language and Two Types of Aphasic Disturbances'³³ and its distinction of metaphor and metonymy, which proved to be very convenient to explicate also the contextual poetics of 'natural environments' in Tamil Sangam poetry. AKR stressed that classical Tamil poetry, with its peculiar poetic figures and structural devices derived from the *Tolkappiyam*, is founded on a metonymical world view (see the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5 and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in this chapter).³⁴

Jakobson's Communication Diagram

In 'Language and Social Change', a sociolinguistic essay on the Tamil language, AKR provides as a 'heuristic scheme' of language Jakobson's renowned communication diagram. Based on this scheme, Jakobson outlined the functions of language. He defined *poetic function* as one which stresses the verbal message:³⁵

CONTEXT
MESSAGE
ADDRESSER-----ADDRESSEE
CONTACT
CODE

Jakobson's diagram was preferred by AKR for its clarity and was used as a model for the study of various literary and non-literary forms.³⁶ But he also found in it several shortcomings when applying it to the analysis of Indian poetry:

Jakobson's programmatic scheme and functions. Structuralism has often concentrated only on the code—if you include Senders and Receivers and Context, we get to the structure functioning. We get an ethnography of speaking—an incredibly complex description of language use.

... Now, this is for ordinary language—if we think of poetic language, this gets even more complicated. For instance, who are the senders, who the receivers? The poet and us readers.

Example. In classical [Tamil] poems the poem includes a context, sender and receiver, as part of the code—in romantic poems, the sender and receiver (**p.279**) are created by the poem. Also there are vocatives in the poem—an explicit receiver and there's also a reader—present now. What about a performer who reads a poem, is he a 'sender'? What about code? Is there not a double code? One linguistic and a literary one?³⁷

AKR's lecture notecards challenge Jakobson's model with regard to the complexities raised by poetry, where irony, indirection, implied meanings, internalized contexts, meta-codes, multiple receivers, and so on, do not permit a simplified assessment: 'Both poet and reader are created by the text for the nonce. "Oratory is heard, poetry is overheard".'³⁸ He quotes Yeats to illustrate the non-linear nature of the communication process in poetry, thereby highlighting what he perceived to be one of the foremost problematics when adapting the communication diagram to poetry. Yet he is also aware that a systematic linguistic framework as the one provided by Jakobson is indispensable to point out the poetic function, that is, the peculiarities of poetry and other literary forms:

The Poetic foregrounds this particular use/instance of the code = message. It's not special to poetry—anytime anyone's witty, in speech ..., proverb, riddle[.]

It's a function of language. But poetry specialises in it—poets are specialists in what everyone does all the time. Though poets often say they are disgusted with language, 'practical, soiled, maid of all work'—Kraus: 'Language is a universal whore whom I'm trying to convert into a virgin'.³⁹

Semiotics and Poetry

Charles Sanders Peirce

In the 1960s, Jakobson turned to the semiotics of Charles Sanders Peirce (1839–1914), the pioneer of semiotics in the USA, to substantiate his theory of the poetic sign and the mechanisms of signification. It is likely that AKR gained

interest in Peirce through the essays of Jakobson and other structuralists, as there is no reference to Peirce in AKR's prose until the 1970s. Peirce's distinction of iconic, indexical, and symbolic signs was taken up by AKR in his notes and half a dozen essays from the 1970s onwards to define the relations between signs, texts, and poetic traditions.⁴⁰

According to semiotics or the theory of signs, meaning is not one fixed entity, as the New Critics believed, but a system of relations. In some interdisciplinary analyses of poetic texts and cultural patterns, **(p.280)** AKR expressed his belief in the unlimited signifying power of the sign: '[M]eanings ... breed further meanings by metaphor, metonymy, etc.... I believe with Pierce that "symbols grow" and semiosis is "unlimited"'.⁴¹

Roland Barthes

Modern semioticians, including French structuralists like Roland Barthes, who based their theories on Saussure, saw the literary work as a 'system' of signs containing signifiers with multiple meanings. Barthes claimed in his semiotics phase of the 1960s that a text created a 'secondary system' of signification.⁴² AKR referred to this concept to exemplify in several essays⁴³ the transition or 'transposition' of traditions that took place in the historical development from classical Tamil Sangam poetry to medieval devotional bhakti poetry: 'In *bhakti* a whole poetic tradition is taken over as a signifier for a new signification.... [Nammalvar] follows the classical score closely, yet transposes it to a new key....'⁴⁴ With this notion of structural transposition and Barthes's layers of signification, AKR explained how poets reworked a whole tradition and cultural world view into a many-layered poetic language:

Transpositions

Though language consists of signs made of *signifiers* and *signifieds*, such signs are continually transformed. They become *signifiers* in a secondary system of connotations (Barthes 1967: 68).⁴⁵ The signs of this secondary system become in turn the signifiers of expressive systems like mythology; poetry weaves into its language all the cultural significances of words and things, their mythic and ritual uses, and 'returns' them to ordinary language, however indirectly, making a rich many-layered set of signifiers renewing the 'language of the tribe'.

... So no good bard is only a reciter, nor does his art simply reproduce a past poem. He uses the whole tradition as his instrument, a keyboard, a language of possibilities. The signifiers may remain the same, but what is signified continually changes, in Tamil (and early Indian) poetry.⁴⁶

Intertextuality, Reflexivity, and Poetry

The quote on the continuous transformation of the *signified* leads us to assess the impact of intertextuality, and eventually poststructuralism, **(p.281)** in AKR's late work. The term 'intertextuality' was coined by the French semiotician Julia Kristeva in the late 1960s. In essays such as 'Word, Dialogue, and Novel', she claims that any text 'is constructed of a mosaic of quotations; any text is the absorption and transformation of another'.⁴⁷ AKR had, in his early studies of Indian literature, discerned that intertextuality, a concept that subverts the idea of the text as a self-sufficient, closed totality, was particularly relevant to Indian poetic traditions. It was mainly in the 1980s and early 1990s, when poststructuralism took roots in American academic circles, that he published essays elaborating on this issue. Quoting Barthes, who adopted Kristeva's theory of the text, AKR stated in one of his last essays (published in 1993): 'We have been reminded in the last few years by text-theory that "any text is a new tissue of past citations...."'⁴⁸

Intertextuality implies that a text originates from its relationships to other texts and to the structure of language. The idea of the 'open' text, which challenges the traditional notions of individual authorship, originality, and author's 'influences', aided AKR in reinterpreting Indian classical and medieval poetic texts as well as folk texts:

Various bodies of literary, religious, sastric, or ideological materials, as they come into being at different periods, become part of the vocabulary of Indian literatures.... [A]ll these become part of the web of Indian allusion, the common stock that makes Indian intertextuality possible. As all reading presupposes intertextuality in any culture, reading Indian poems presupposes the specifics of Indian intertextuality—any universality that we may leap to requires the ground of such 'interanimation' of local meanings. I do not mean to say that every reader needs a detailed textual knowledge of these various texts but much of it is part of common parlance.⁴⁹

AKR's thinking in this and other essays of the late 1980s steers visibly away from the classical structuralist model. The notion of intertextuality also informed his theory of reflexivity and relational paradigms (responsive, reflexive, self-reflexive) in Indian texts developed in the latter phase of his career (see the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2). For instance, in the introduction to *Folktales from India*, an intertextual approach to folk texts is introduced in a meta-critical tone:

(p.282) When we look at texts this way, we need ... to see all these cultural performances as a transitive series, a 'scale of forms' responding to one another, engaged in continuous and dynamic dialogic relations.... Texts, then, are also contexts and pretexts for other texts. In our studies

now, we are beginning to recognize and place folk texts in this ever-present network of intertextuality.⁵⁰

Another literary genre that AKR found particularly appealing for the study of intertextuality in its synchronic and diachronic aspects was Tamil Sangam poetry. The Sangam was a fraternity of poets who culled highly suggestive poetry out of the interrelation of a set of traditional images, motifs, texts, and genres, thus creating 'a language within a language' for the sake of poetic economy. In the afterword to *Poems of Love and War*, his last book of poetry translation, AKR remarked:

No two poems of these Eight Anthologies are alike, though the art language is the same.... The poems in this book ... I hope, demonstrate that there is another code, the poetic, which organizes the formulaic and all other traditional codes that the poet inherits and habitually composes with. Individual poems are created out of all given 'elements of production,' and all the language of past poems.⁵¹

The 'elements of production' or the elements of which poetry is made, and into which it is transformed and decomposed by way of scientific interpretation or 'translation', are key concepts that offer multiple readings in AKR's intellectual and poetic universe. They pertain to the process of writing poetry as well as essays: as a writer of scholarly prose, AKR moved in his career towards the 'anthological essay'.⁵² In such pieces, he built an argument by juxtaposing and interrelating miscellaneous quotes, poems, texts, and commentaries from various periods, traditions, and cultures. These 'elements' were carefully placed so that one example would 'light up' another. In 'Food for Thought', the author explains this anthological method in terms of semiotics. As an open-ended anthology moving 'towards' a transforming system, AKR argued, an essay was a passage of passages, as it were, with no (single) author and no fixed meaning:

This is an open anthology to be enlarged by fellow-natives and para-natives.... This essay/anthology/collage/primer falls into two parts: both cite **(p.283)** poems and passages from Indian literatures to exemplify certain principles regarding food. Each passage will display a different paradigm in which 'food' participates. Each paradigm presents food in a different aspect, gives it a new 'interpretant', a new 'translation'. The first section will draw from these well-known passages a system of signification (in Eco's sense of the term; see Eco 1976).⁵³

A similar strategy was followed by AKR in much of his late poetry from the 1980s. I point out here an evident example of reflexivity, intertextuality, and textual transformation or 'participation' in AKR's poetry that has already been cited: the poem 'Elements of Composition' (see also the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4, 'Sanskrit

Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy’ in Chapter 5, and ‘The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition’ in Chapter 6), which opens the poetry collection *Second Sight* with a list of physical elements and images from the past that are transformed and reworked into a continuum of give and take. This poem can be read both as a metaphysical and meta-poetic manifesto, for it does indeed incorporate ‘elements’ from the past. For instance, it integrates five verse lines drafted in November 1959 and fragments of the poem ‘Madura: Two Movements’ (‘dancer/ bound in a world of sounds/ unmoving she moves/ as nothing in life can move’), published in 1957–8 and drafted also as ‘In Madurai I Saw a Quite-Human Hand’. As shown in the section ‘What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience’ in Chapter 4, the older versions or drafts were gradually transformed into a newer composition published in 1986.

In fact, a close textual analysis of the drafts and poems that went into *Second Sight* and their ‘evolution’ further indicates how AKR’s inclusive and transformational approach to texts was extended to poetic practice (see Appendix 2). A long draft titled ‘Composition’ was, at one point, a long poem of 26 sections, which incorporated more ‘fragments’ and poems that can be traced to the 1950s. Eventually, AKR decomposed the piece into 12 poems and published them in *Second Sight*, interspersed with other old and new poems. Here are some excerpts from ‘Elements of Composition’ and ‘Connect!’, which were still parts of the same ‘Composition’ in 1984 and eventually appeared as independent poems in *Second Sight* (see also the section ‘Tamil Sangam Poetics’ in this chapter and ‘The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition’ in Chapter 6):

(p.284) *Elements of Composition*

Composed as I am, like others,
of elements on certain well-known lists,
father’s seed and mother’s egg

gathering earth, air, fire, mostly
water, into a mulberry mass,
moulding calcium,

carbon, even gold, magnesium and such,
into a chattering self tangled
in love and work,

scary dreams, capable of eyes that can see,
only by moving constantly,
the constancy of things

...

I pass through them
as they pass through me
taking and leaving

...

and even as I add,
I lose, decompose
into my elements,

into other names and forms,
past, and passing, tenses
without time,

caterpillar on a leaf, eating,
being eaten. (1-12, 36-9, 53-60)

Connect!

Connect! Connect! cries my disconnecting
madness, remembering phrases.
See the cycles,
...

... Connect,
connect, beasts with monks, slave economies
and the golden bough.

But my watchers are silent as if
they knew my truth is in fragments.... (1-3, 5-9)⁵⁴

(p.285) For the poet, truth lies in particular elements that are composed and decomposed in the natural course of action. By decomposing his 'Composition' of 26 sections into shorter poems, AKR followed in his creative process of 'composing' the same method that he describes in the essays and poems. The final form chosen for *Second Sight* conforms to his belief in multiple particulars in dialogue and exchange with each other. In accordance with his theory of reflexivity and intertextuality, AKR produces an open 'interanimation' of split texts as opposed to a grand unified statement contained in a single long 'Composition' by a 'self-reflecting' poet. It is left to the reader to compose the fragmented individual pieces, interconnected ideas, and loose formal structure back into a whole anthology of aesthetic impressions and 'reflections'.

Poststructuralism and Deconstruction

AKR's belief in a composite and unstable identity and in the transformation of the signifier, his notion of the poem as a continuous drafting that is never finished and is eventually decomposed into its 'elements of production' out of which it was moulded, and his questioning of the original text as a self-evident truth is reminiscent of poststructuralist and postmodern ideas. Barthes stated in 1968, in his famous essay 'The Death of the Author',⁵⁵ that 'writing is that ... space ... where all identity is lost, starting with the very identity of the body writing.... [T]he book itself is only a tissue of signs, an imitation that is lost, infinitely deferred.... [T]he text is ... a multi-dimensional space in which a variety of writings, none of them original, blend and clash.' There is no explicit

reference to the term 'poststructuralism' in AKR's essays, but some of the poems on poetry and the art of 'composing' in *Second Sight* seem to mirror Barthes's poststructuralist theories. For instance, the *Second Sight* poem 'Drafts', which belonged to the earlier ('original') long draft titled 'Composition' in 1984, suggests that poetry is the writing of drafts, an exercise of copying copies, since the true 'original' can never be traced:

Drafts

1

A rough draft, getting rougher:
a struggle in the crowd to see
the well-known

(p.286) but half-seen Hyde Park rapist's face,
half-seen perhaps only by another,
unseen

...

2

Itself a copy of lost events,
the original is nowhere, of which things,
even these hands,

seem but copies, garbled by a ciphered
script, opaque as the Indus,
to be refigured

...

3

And we have originals, clay tigers
that aboriginals drown after each small-
pox ritual,

or dinosaur smells, that leave no copies;
and copies with displaced originals
like these words.... (1-6, 13-18, 28-33)⁵⁶

One of the principal tenets of poststructuralism, besides Barthes's affirmation that there is no original creator before the text that engenders it, is Derrida's theory that meaning is constantly deferred: 'The meaning of meaning ... is infinite implication, the indefinite referral of signifier to signifier.... [I]ts force is a certain pure and infinite equivocality which gives signified meaning no respite, no rest, but engages in its own economy so that it always signifies again and differs.'⁵⁷ When Derrida formulated his highly influential definition of meaning, he was, in fact, reinterpreting the 'relational exercises' of the structuralists. As Alex Preminger puts it: '[I]t was but a step from meaning-as-relations to

Derrida's appropriation of Saussure so as to claim that all meaning is endlessly deferred, never capable of being fixed.⁵⁸

Like Derrida, AKR was fascinated by 'the proliferating, the elusive, the allusive, the ever-self-recontextualizing' qualities of meaning in a text.⁵⁹ Derrida's notion of *différance*, which implies both a spatial **(p.287)** and temporal dimension, blends well with the idea of art as a never-ending flux of transforming objects (matter) and continuity (time) that we find in AKR's aesthetic and poetic thought. Although these speculations on Derridan echoes in AKR cannot be substantiated in the latter's prose writings, except for random quotes in the lecture notes, we can observe how some of the *Second Sight* poems do yield to the pressure of poststructuralist theories. In some instances, the poet places old ideas in dialogue with poststructuralism, with Indian theories, and with himself. Several of AKR's closest colleagues⁶⁰ have acknowledged his interest in Derrida's work, and remarked that the scholar-poet explored poststructuralist and postmodern notions during the latter part of his multidisciplinary career. But I have found no extended references to Derrida or deconstruction theory in the published and unpublished primary sources.⁶¹ This can be accounted for by the fact that most of AKR's published and unfinished papers were rooted in work that was begun well before the 1990s and even 1980s. True to his aesthetic and poetic thought and interdisciplinary methodology, AKR was not preoccupied with discussing theories in his essays, but chose illustration, contrast, and allusion to place old and new ideas—and poems—in dialogue with each other, so as to 'suggest', rather than affirm, a particular idea.

One should not forget that AKR's poetics was, in part, influenced by Vedic philosophy, the Upanishads, Samkhya philosophy, Buddhism, Vaisnavite mythology, Sanskrit poetics, and other ancient Indian traditions (see the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' and 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5, and 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition' in this chapter). As some scholars have suggested, Indian thought systems often go hand in hand with Derrida and the postmodern deconstruction theory.⁶² The concepts of creation through transformation and the continuous flux of life in all its forms are imaginatively present in AKR's diaries, prose, translations, and poetry. 'Influence,' as AKR notes somewhat wryly in his journal while working on a draft of 'Composition', derives from 'fluency, flows, river and ocean'.⁶³

Cultural Anthropology and Poetry

Claude Lévi-Strauss connected linguistic structuralism to cultural anthropology in the 1940s and 1950s, and in the 1960s and 1970s had become an indispensable referent in social and cultural anthropology. **(p.288)** In his work, he considered 'the relations among phenomena, rather than the nature of the phenomena themselves, and the systems into which these relations enter'. He developed his thesis 'in dealing with some of the major aspects of culture—language, kinship, social organisation, magic, religion and art'.⁶⁴ AKR at large

adhered to these structural principles during his early career in the USA, which included several assignments as professor of anthropology. Lévi-Strauss is cited by AKR in diverse essays, mostly in connection with literary devices, and cultural and poetic patterns as meaningful relations.⁶⁵ He was cautious, though, to apply structural anthropology as a universalizing instrument, and supported the cultural context in the analysis of texts:

For structures are not meaning, but carriers of meanings, signifiers, that are rendered into signs by the given culture (in space, time, or society). Even the deepest structures have to be interpreted culturally or individually, depending on our point of view.

[S]tructure at each level of abstraction can signify; meanings are not archetypal, universal, do not inhere in them; they require cultural assignment.⁶⁶

AKR wished to demonstrate, for instance, that the Lévi-Straussian opposition of nature and culture did not apply in Tamil poetics where 'culture is enclosed in nature' and a 'nature-culture continuum' prevails. Thus, he attempted to prove through classical Tamil and medieval bhakti poetry that 'the opposition is itself culture-bound' (see also the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics', 'Folk Aesthetics', and 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5).⁶⁷ In AKR's cultural anthropology, the particularities of poetic language in a tradition were perceived as a compelling medium to approach its cultural patterns. As he adduced in the inquisitive essay 'Food for Thought', 'communicative acts presuppose signification systems, as parole presupposes langue, as pragmatics presupposes a syntactics—or even better, I would say, as poetry presupposes language. Cultural systems in use are more like poetry, or at least more like the poetic use of language than like ordinary language.'⁶⁸ This idea is already expressed in AKR's notecards in the late 1970s, when he began to assess the complexities of the communication process in poetry and in other 'cultural forms':

(p.289)

Literature and anthropology

[L]anguage models in anthropology. Structuralism. Binary systems and transformations. Yet language is culture, culture is communication—we need, as for language itself, a communication model.

... Now cultural forms, like myth, have been treated as ordinary language models—I think some cultural forms are more like poetic language than ordinary language—so involve all the complexity.⁶⁹

It is evident that in describing culture in practice, AKR trusted poetry more than 'ordinary language'. In his essays, he preferred to quote a set of interrelated

poetic texts or tell a story, rather than indulge in theoretical speculations to explain particular cultural traits. It was amusing for him to call himself an anthropologist and, at the same time, a specimen of anthropological study. As a writer in Kannada, his short story 'Annaiah's Anthropology' is such a mocking conflation of object and subject, outside and inside, science and life, truth and lie, theory and art in practice. Ultimately, what was foregrounded in his cultural anthropology and did the talking for him was *poetic irony*, the twin of literary expression in modern culture. Poetry was the discipline and art that illuminated all spheres of his life and thought.

Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition

We now return to Indian literary traditions and how their diverse poetics were interpreted by AKR. In his academic career, the scholar worked his way through several traditions, genres, periods, and languages, and found in each of these aspects and ideas he was particularly drawn to: 'In each of the languages something has left a mark sometimes, especially in the great poems I live with and try to translate. The voices and sensual concreteness of classical Tamil, the range of the epics, the bite and tenderness of the *bhakti* poems, the direct narrative power of folklore ... are ideals.'⁷⁰

His lecture notes and papers often sought to identify features that were common to Indian literary traditions. In the essay 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', AKR proposes reflexivity and context-sensitivity as two of the organizing principles of India's cultural traditions, 'which constantly generate new forms out of the old ones'.⁷¹ Other characteristics that come to the fore in the description of Indian poetry in AKR's notes are the relation between author, text, **(p.290)** and reader, and how these were understood in different ways in each of the Indian traditions:

1. There is not one Indian literary tradition.
2. A text creates writer as well as reader. They come into being with the text. Before the text, the writer (not a biographical real person, but as writer, not the 'suffering self' but the 'writing self') doesn't exist. Before it is read, there is no reader.
3. Yet there are 'real' writers and 'real' readers, of whom the 'implied' writers and readers created by the text are selections. The relation between the 'real' writer who lives in the world, who is born, marries, receives prizes and brickbats, dies, and the 'implied' author who lives in the text—the relation is conceived differently in different cultures, and in different traditions within Indian culture.

Court poets

temple poets—a god behind the 'real' poet

sastra writers—always named⁷²

In his papers, books of poetry translation, and collections of folk narratives, AKR presented Indian poetry as a network of traditions with intricate interrelations and a common pool of motifs, while highlighting the idiosyncrasies of regional and folk traditions which had not been taken as seriously by Western scholarship as the classical Sanskrit tradition (see the sections ‘Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy’, ‘Tamil Aesthetics’, ‘Folk Aesthetics’, and ‘The Aesthetics of Bhakti’ in Chapter 5).

In general, in studies of Indian literary theory, the sophistication of concepts from the classical Sanskrit tradition sets the frame for most discussions on poetics. As AKR clarified in his essays on Indian literatures, there is a pan-Indian stock of images, ideas, and concepts from Sanskrit (classical Hindu texts, as well as Buddhist, Jain, and Tantric literature), which underlie or interact with most regional or desi traditions. Classical Sanskrit texts on aesthetics and poetics provide, therefore, the metalanguage and common conceptual framework in Indian literary studies in the light of which (and often against which) regional and local traditions are placed and described.

AKR was not a Sanskritist, but he often referred to Sanskrit poetic terms in dealing with other literary traditions he taught and translated, mainly Tamil Sangam poetry and medieval bhakti poetry in Kannada and Tamil. In fact, he devoted most of his papers on Indian literature to the study of the mother-tongue desi traditions in Tamil and **(p.291)** Kannada, and their subtle relationships with the father-tongue marga tradition in Sanskrit. Being of Brahminical family background, firmly anchored in Sanskrit classical literature and religion, the weight of the marga tradition is evident in AKR’s philosophical ideas, but it did not dominate his poetics. The two interrelated monographic essays on Sanskrit literary theory, the unpublished ‘Sanskrit Poetics’ (d. 1964) and ‘Indian Poetics’ (1974, co-authored with Edwin Gerow), offer a rather biased outline of Sanskrit aesthetics (see the section ‘Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy’ in Chapter 5) and poetics. Perhaps the most striking feature in these two papers is AKR’s tendency to weave into his exposition comparisons with Western concepts or theories, a trait that gave away his solid grounding in Western literary theory and linguistics rather than his expertise in Sanskrit theory.

A good part of his description and interpretation of Sanskrit poetics is centred on linguistic concepts. As a starting point, the Sanskrit term for literature, *sahitya*, is defined by AKR as ‘a togetherness of word and meaning’: ‘It is on the relationships possible between word (*sabda*) and sense (*artha*) that all utterance is classified ... the type of utterance that interested the poetics most is that in which neither word nor sense is self-important, where both are indispensable because they serve the overall structure. This is the joining which is called *sahitya*.’⁷³

The relation of *sabda* and *artha* is vital to understand the notion of poetry in the Sanskrit tradition, and in 'Indian Poetics' AKR compares this conceptual pair with the Saussurean distinction of the signifier and the signified:

The Swiss linguist Ferdinand de Saussure once said that the relationship of *significant* and *signifié*, the expresser and the expressed, the forms and the meanings of words, are distinct and inseparable, like the two sides of a piece of paper. This inseparableness, as Indian thinkers have also pointed out, is not peculiar to poetry. Except in the cases of mantra and *sastra*, it is true of all expression. But in poetic utterance, the relationship becomes usable for a further dimension....⁷⁴

AKR draws attention, here, to one of the principal characteristics of poetry, that is, the oblique use of language which, in Sanskrit, is termed 'vakrokti'. According to this theory, 'the crooked way of saying it, the bend in language is the source of the poetic'. Vakrokti is a defining characteristic of the poetic, and AKR further maintains that 'there is **(p.292)** in all language an obliquity of a sort. There is no natural relationship between a word and its meaning.' He explicates this by pointing again to Saussure: '[T]he connection between word and object is by custom, habit, and arbitrary convention'. AKR supplies, in this paper, several examples of the arbitrariness of the signifier-signified relation, and underscores the value of context in language to arrive at the following conclusion: 'All kinds of explicit meanings can be deployed in the strategy of poetry to evoke implicit meanings.'⁷⁵ The latter statement is not only directed at Sanskrit language or poetry. The examples given are from the English language. We can, therefore, presume that AKR reflects, in these early essays on Sanskrit poetics, his general assumptions about poetry.

Another feature that stirred AKR's interest was the confluence of poetry and drama in Sanskrit poetics. Sanskrit authors evolved a kind of critical theory for poetry, which AKR labels 'dramatic criticism' and compares to Kenneth Burke's critical model.⁷⁶ He also employs the New Critical concepts of texture and structure to distinguish between two of the principal theories of poetics in the Sanskrit tradition: on the one hand, *alamkara* (poetic ornamentation), which is concerned with poetic language and figures of speech (that is texture), and, on the other hand, *rasa*, which derives from drama and applies to the structure of a poetic whole:

There are writers who recognise no overall structure as such is needed to make poetry, that even structure is there only to enhance texture.... But I think the Indian *alamkara-rasa* quarrel gives a clue to the basis of this difference. The two concepts rose out of two different concerns—*alamkara* out of poetry, *rasa* out of drama. *Alamkara* is a theory of poetic language,

arising out of a consideration of poems.... If you don't wish to consider a poem a kind of drama the texture becomes of interest in itself.⁷⁷

In 'Sanskrit Poetics', AKR elaborates on the notion of *alamkara* and analyses a few common figures of speech defined by the Sanskrit poetics, who had a remarkable proclivity for lists and categorization.⁷⁸ Summing up his point, AKR takes up figures of speech as a deviation from ordinary language, an old issue in Indian classical poetics:

There are two questions in all poetics—a) what makes a poem one piece, not two, or 1½? b) what makes poetic languages different from all other language? The most frequent answer ... was ... a deviation from the normal language, **(p.293)** 'crooked language'. It deviates from ordinary language in two ways: a) at the word-level, b) at the meaning-level.... The deviation involved in a figure of speech is not therefore deviation from the literal, but from certain logical relations, like identity, cause and effect, difference. Expressions are poetic when they deviate from these logical relations in significant ways. The poetic imagination works in this systematic illogic, and the *alamkaras* define this system of distortions.⁷⁹

According to AKR, some aspects of the *alamkara* system of deviations anticipated the work of modern critics of the Prague School of criticism as well as William Empson's critical theories: '[Empson's] ideas of ambiguity, his enumerations and definitions and modes of analysis come very close to the Indian.'⁸⁰ The *alamkara* tradition and Sanskrit figures of speech are, nevertheless, not as prominent in AKR's prose as the concept of *rasa*, which is discussed in most of the writings on Indian poetics. The theory of *rasa* as expounded in the *Natya Sastra*, the influential ancient treatise that focuses on the experience of art, is treated by AKR as the foundation of Indian aesthetics (see also the sections 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2 and 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5) as well as poetics. After the *Natya Sastra*, there were other important developments in Indian poetics, such as the theory of *dhvani* (suggestion or suggestiveness) as formulated by Anandavardhana in ninth century AD, which was combined with the notion of *rasa* to articulate the *rasa-dhvani* theory. However, AKR did not pay as much attention to the *dhvani* school of Sanskrit poetics as he did to the other theories cited earlier. In his later essay 'Parables and Commonplaces' (1982), 'rasa' is defined by AKR in the following terms:

[Rasa is] ... the generalisation (*sadharanikarana*) of private contingent natural-born daily feelings (*bhava*). The thirty-three transitory feelings, which include embarrassment and death, are strictly subordinated to the eight or nine major moods (*rasa*) or essences. All objects of nature, even character, action, gesture and language, are properties and 'object-

correlatives' (closer to Santayana's correlative objects than Eliot's 'objective' correlatives) evocative of such essences.⁸¹

Many of these critical inquiries and statements suggest a convergence between Sanskrit poetics and diverse Western traditions, and testify to AKR's comparativist method. He also discussed the **(p.294)** limitations of Sanskrit critical theories, such as *rasa* and *alamkara*, when compared to modern poetics:

[There is] ... no discussion of the unity of the arts; [or] a common vocabulary like 'rhythm' or 'structure'; no talk of the rhythm of a novel or the orchestration of the poem or the architectonics of a play, as in the West. They speak of one kind of very inferior poetry reluctantly, as a residue, the painting—like poem, the Imagist poem, the merely descriptive poem. Such a poem would have no *rasa* to inform it, it would have the unity of the object it describes.⁸²

In order to experience *rasa* in poetry, AKR argued, the reader needs to be attentive to all the elements of a poem and observe 'the relationship of the poem to its various parts'. For the right combination of all elements is the key to the transcendental experience of art (see also the sections 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2 and 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5) and of poetry:

[T]he whole transcends the parts, incorporates them, and defines them after being created by them. This relationship is called the *rasa*, the 'mood' of the poem; it is what is experienced through the poem's parts.

There are outlines of a theology in this way of looking at things ... and poetics and theology do meet at certain points of time.⁸³

Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics

AKR's knowledge of Indian poetics was deeply marked by his early exposure to the mother-tongue traditions. He had first, almost unconsciously, absorbed oral literature as a living tradition by way of grandmothers and aunts in the kitchen of his childhood house. Later at college, his rebellious nature towards orthodoxy was spurred both by Western rationalism and the south-Indian anti-Sanskrit intellectual movement and social activism of the pre-Independence years (see the section 'First Thirty Years in India' in Chapter 3). In those years, AKR found inspiration in the medieval Kannada bhakti poetry of the Virasaiva saints (see the sections 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2 and 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5). The Sanskrit tradition was identified with the religiously hegemonic Brahmin caste, making it all the more fascinating for the young AKR to search for a different source of wisdom in the oral *desi* literatures:

(p.295) I suppose I am ideologically radical towards Sanskrit. I came from a Brahmin family, so I could have it both ways. That is, I could have all the privileges of being a Brahmin and also all the privileges of reacting against it. My discovery over the years is that the mother tongues have so much in them, so much that is alive, and are much more pervasive, in all strata of society, in all ages from children to the very old, men and women, literate and non-literate. What holds them together? It's not Sanskrit. It's these mother tongues. I think I went into linguistics because of that. These spoken tongues had to be very, very important. It was important to me in my youth to have discovered this.⁸⁴

The living tradition of the oral forms and the medieval Virasaiva bhakti poetry in Kannada infused in the student of literature a message of heterodoxy, plurality, and diversity that was seen as subverting the social establishment and Sanskrit norm. These traditional forms, along with the Tamil poems of the Alvar saints he translated later in life (the 1970s), instilled in the writer-translator a distinct concept of poetry, poet, and poetic inspiration that had a long-lasting impact (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

Mystical 'Sayings': Virasaiva Poetry in Kannada

AKR was introduced to the medieval mystical poetry of vachanas at college in Mysore in 1947. He was so impressed by the poetics and socio-religious message of this tradition in his Kannada mother tongue that he soon started translating some of the poems into English. Initially, in the early 1950s, he experimented with the format of the free-verse vachana and wrote versions and poetic exercises inspired by the poets he most liked: Basavanna, Allama Prabhu, and Mahadeviyakka. In fact, in those days, he did not think of these renderings of twelfth-century 'sayings' as translations at all, but treated them as his own poems, as can be inferred from the poetry drafts and material available in the AKR Papers. AKR started translating Basavanna, the leader of the lingayat poet-saints, around 1951, and published his first translations in *Quest* and *Illustrated Weekly* between 1956 and 1958, along with his first original poems in English. Critics have not paid sufficient attention to the fact that, together with his first poems, AKR published a few vachana-like poems he signed as the author 'after' a particular Kannada mystic.⁸⁵ In some cases, the identification of these early poems as either translations or 'original' poems is not very **(p.296)** clear. This ambiguity exposes the intimate relationship between his poems and the Virasaiva vachanas during the early stages of his poetic career in English.

AKR's interpretation of the powerful aesthetics of Virasaiva bhakti poetry and its social implications as an important counter-movement to the established traditions has already been emphasized (see the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2, 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3, and 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5). As a native Kannada poet, AKR first viewed the poetry of the medieval Virasaiva saints as the wisdom

literature of his (the Kannada) people, and as an essential part of their religious and literary tradition. He saw in it mystical-religious poetry with philosophical connotations (see the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4), as well as social protest poetry, and oral popular poetry with an equally aesthetic and political message. Here, we briefly focus on the poetic language of the vachana form, and summarize some of the poetic techniques specified by AKR in his writings on the Siva-worshipping lingayats.

Oral Poetics: The 'Freedom of the Vachanas'

The vachanakaras, who broke the orthodox social and religious norms of the time, sang vachanas or sayings to emphasize the immediacy of the spoken word as a vehicle to embody and express an instantaneous personal experience. They spoke in the common language of the people and did not believe in poetry as a formal composition in stylized language and metrical form. Repetition and parallelism, as AKR pointed out in the introduction to *Speaking of Siva*, citing Jakobson, are typical technical devices of this oral poetry. AKR was also attracted to the sincerity and freshness of the language and to the ironic attitude of some of these 'sayings', all of which, from his biased perspective as a pioneering poet in Kannada and English, brought the vachana form close to the conversational mode of modernist poetry. So the younger AKR was quick to point out his affinity with this type of 'free' poetry: 'Such untrammelled speech in poetry has a fresh "modern" ring to it in imagery, rhythm and idiom—a freedom that modern literary writers in Kannada have not yet quite won.'⁸⁶

(p.297) Esoteric Poetics: 'The Language of Secrecy'

Not only are colloquial expressions and everyday situations and images favoured by the Virasaiva poets. Like other mystical poetic traditions around the world, the vachana also shares commonalities with various esoteric forms of literature. Riddle-like structures, allegory, paradox, and oxymoron are integral features of the vachana form. In particular, poets like Allama Prabhu who were devoted to God as a formless principle (nirguna),⁸⁷ often composed esoteric or cryptic poems, as AKR noted in his essay on 'the language of secrecy' of these poets:

[O]bscure riddle-like questioning poems that participate in an ancient and pan-Indian tradition of *sandhyabhasa* or 'twilight language', or *ulatbamsi*, 'reversed or topsy-turvy language'—examples of which go back to the Vedas and the Upanisads, and in the mother tongues to the *caryagitis* ... in which poets like Allama steeped their poetic works....

So un-like the modern surrealists, they did not depend on dreams, automatic writing, ouija boards and other ways of enticing the unconscious.⁸⁸

The nirguna poets drew from a network of images, motifs, and esoteric poetics that were common in other traditions like yoga and Tantric literature, that is, a secret language that was steeped in the ancient pool of Indian wisdom traditions. For the Kannada saint-poets, the riddling language, however, was a poetic technique, not an end in itself, else the poems would have remained playful exercises rather than mystical-religious compositions sung by the devotees. AKR, who had a penchant for cracking riddles, emphasized this functional difference in 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle'. In this late essays drafted in 1993 and the much earlier introduction to *Speaking of Siva*, he identifies the esoteric ingredients of the vachanas as poetic qualities and illustrates how the Virasaiva mystics employ language to perplex the mind: '[R]iddle and paradox are also meant to shatter the ordinary language of ordinary experiences, baffling the rational intelligence to look through the glass darkly till it begins to see.'⁸⁹ As AKR concludes in the Allama essay, the 'experiential reading' of a mystic poem tends to overtake abstract interpretation. It is through wonderment ('adbhuta' in Sanskrit aesthetics) in the drama of the poem that the poem and the reader are *fulfilled*.⁹⁰ As a poet in English, AKR made several attempts at recreating vachana-like riddle poems. The best-known example is (p.298) his meta-poem 'Anxiety' in *The Striders*, which reveals its mysterious metaphor-generating paradox and failure to end his existential (and poetic) anxiety only in the last line, and is also the modern counter-poem to vachana 972 by Allama Prabhu, who speaks of the futility to find words for the mystical 'experience'.⁹¹

In the end, the riddle-like poem of the Virasaiva bhakti saints does not wish to evoke simply an aesthetic experience, that is, the depersonalized essence (rasa) of an emotion (bhava), but yearns for anubhava, the 'Experience with a capital E', as AKR put it. That is, the mystic poet wants to reproduce a spark of God's grace, which 'cannot be captured in scripture nor explained by the *sastras*'.⁹² And it does so by putting to use the structural elements of poetic language that seek to destroy ordinary language and the intellect, thereby challenging the idea of structure in a social and religious sense, but paradoxically creating a new poetics, and along with it, 'their own structure for behaviour and belief'.⁹³

The 'Immersed' Poets: Vaisnava Poetry in Tamil

In the 1970s, AKR translated a large number of medieval Tamil poems from the sophisticated *Tiruvaymoli*, also called the Tamil Veda, composed by Nammalvar, who was considered the greatest of the Alvars (see also the section 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5). In the late 1970s and early 1980s, he was also struggling to put together a new collection of poems in English, after almost a decade had passed since the publication of *Relations* in 1971. He was simultaneously occupied with a new set of poems in English and *Hymns for the Drowning* (1981), his second translation project of bhakti poetry and only collection of medieval Tamil bhakti poetry. The poetics of Nammalvar and other Alvars is described with passionate detail in the afterword of *Hymns for the*

Drowning. It is, therefore, not surprising to find in the unpublished poetry drafts and notes in the AKR Papers, alongside the published poems of *Second Sight* and interviews of that period, numerous interconnections between AKR's translation work of Alvar poetry, his theoretical ideas on poetry, and his poetic creativity (see also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

Poetry of Connections

The Alvars were devotees of Visnu, god of reincarnation and cosmic continuity. For them, poetry, which plays with words and meanings, **(p.299)** is a spontaneous manifestation of lila (god's play): '[G]rammar becomes poetry, and poetry becomes theology.'⁹⁴ Vaisnava theology is a cosmological vision of 'the one in the many', and is reflected in a poetics of connections and continuity through transformation. A formal example of this continuity is the poetic technique of beginning the first unit of a poem with the last unit of the previous poem. This device is picked up by AKR, interestingly, to link some of his own poems in *Second Sight*. Since AKR was so deeply involved in both projects around the same time, during the late 1970s, this third poetry collection is closely related to *Hymns for the Drowning* in its genesis, chronology, themes, and technique.

Poetry of Possession

The Alvar poet was a devotee who was believed to be taken over by the divine spirit in the process of creation, sometimes in a frenzy of possession. But the Alvar poets do not only conceptually associate poetry with possession. In the following meta-poem, the saint-poet Nammalvar depicts the 'takeover' of the poet by a demon-like genius thus:

Poets
beware, your life is in danger:

the lord of gardens is a thief,
a cheat,
master of illusions;
he came to me
a wizard with words,
sneaked into my body,
my breath,

with bystanders looking on
but seeing nothing,
he consumed me
life and limb,

and filled me,
made me over
into himself.⁹⁵

Such a possession ritual is related to the Vedic tradition of visionary poets and its notion of Soma, the intoxicating elixir of the Brahmins (**p.300**) and 'lord of speech' (see also the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5). In the poetry of possession the poem, poet, and object of devotion become interchangeable elements and play out a container-contained relationship: the poem is contained by the poet-speaker, who is taken over by the divine genius to consummate the poem, that is, the possession. God, the world, and the devotee stand in a metonymical relation that is typically expressed at the physical plane of partaking. In this process of 'mutual cannibalism', as AKR described it, god can be both eater and eaten many times over.

On the other hand, two of the poetry drafts from the cycle of unpublished Soma poems (see Appendix 2) from the 1970s deal with poetry as possession and grace. They refer to Soma in a mythological sense and incorporate translations from Nammalvar and Manikkavacakar.⁹⁶

Soma, I said, is no Visnu
But Visnu can play Soma
Enter the rests of flesh
To make them sing
[Nammalvar poem from *Tiruvaymoli*, 10.7.1 comes next]

Yet Siva is sometimes Soma
And will grab a man by his smallest hair
as he did once
the poet with words like rubies
making him cry
[Manikkavacakar poem from *Tiruvacakam*, IV.59-70 comes next]

These reflexive exercises in intertextuality, or rather juxtaposition of texts, show how the poet searched for motifs, themes, and solutions (that is, inspiration) in traditional sources in his creative practice.

Poetry and Grace

Ever since his encounter with Virasaiva bhakti poetry in Mysore, AKR was obsessed with the notion of grace and its relation to poetic inspiration. Nammalvar's poetry taught him to see that the answer lies 'in the very nature'⁹⁷ of human existence: 'This is how Nammalvar looks upon grace, as an interruption of the ordinary by the extraordinary. Perhaps that is what grace is all about. And (**p.301**) this is where the ironic distance comes in.... In my "Soma Poems", for instance, the extraordinary occurs in a most ordinary fashion, something like the way a poem happens.'⁹⁸

The extraordinary moment of grace that all devotees as well as poets patiently crave for, and secretly work for, requires an occasion that comes sometimes as an ordinary 'accident'. For Nammalvar (and AKR identifies here with him), the

main obstacle to receiving the grace of ‘sharing’ with god, and of writing good poetry, is self-consciousness: ‘When Nammalvar speaks of the Lord there is no self-consciousness because the Lord was no stranger to him. The poet should not be self-conscious about using myths or legends or whatever. If he is, he is something less than a poet.’⁹⁹ It is precisely this self-consciousness that can be said to permeate many of AKR’s abandoned Soma poems. In his diaries, he occasionally expressed his lack of confidence and inspiration during the years of his Soma experiments. Most of the poems from this sequence now remain as unpublished samples of AKR’s creative dialogue with the mystics he translated, for he only rescued a few of the original Soma poems for the *Second Sight* collection published in 1986 (see Appendix 2). In 1980, he confessed in an interview: ‘About being influenced by my own translations, I really don’t know. The poet does not function by design, and must speak a little more than what he knows. Sounds silly, perhaps, but this is how I see it. Poetry happens unbidden and has to protect itself.’¹⁰⁰

Poetry of Immediacy and Absence

Inspiration is, elsewhere in the notes, compared to a lover who does not earn a gratuitous rejoinder, but receives ‘it’ in unexpected situations. In some medieval Alvar poems, Visnu is worshipped as an accomplished lover. He teases the devotees who long to merge with him in passionate physical union. The principal tension in the mystic love poetry of the Alvars is the interplay between oneness and separateness, between the all-encompassing presence and the mysterious absence of Lord Visnu. The god is not distant, though he seems unavailable at times. He is a lover who needs to be sensed and experienced. And the more intimate the relationship, the nearer the senses are to the experience of physical immediacy (for example, touch, taste, and smell), and the more dramatic the poetry. ‘Sharing’ is not only a theme, as AKR points out, it is also a poetic technique: **(p.302)** ‘[I]n *bhakti*, the relationship is everything. In the *alvar* poems, the figure of speech, the as-if of erotic allegory, becomes the here-and-now of dramatic poems.’¹⁰¹ It is, in fact, quite common to find, in Alvar poetry, single-sentence poems with the same rhetoric of nearness and separateness, desire and unavailability that is found in the lover-beloved relationship of classical Akam poetry, yet transposed to the spiritual level.

Now, having attended to AKR’s explanations on the poetics of the ‘immersed’ poets, we may still pose the question: who are ‘the drowning’ in the title of the book? AKR states in the introduction that ‘the title *Hymns for the Drowning* plays on the meaning of such an immersion for poet and reader’.¹⁰² Or does it stand for the struggle of the poet-translator, that is, for his own fear/dream of ‘drowning’? For, as the poet-speaker in ‘The Striders’ already knew, there is an *existential* difference between *immersing* deep into the absolute and *drowning* ‘I-deep’.

Oral Tales: The Poetics of 'Performance'

AKR devoted much of his academic life to the study of folklore, and drew important notions on poetics from the analysis of folktales and other oral popular traditions. As someone who was familiar with the natural environment of the Kannada tales and knew how tales worked within their cultural contexts, he understood the folktale as an aesthetic object (see the section 'Folk Aesthetics' in Chapter 5), a site of 'freedom and resistance',¹⁰³ a poetic text, and a *performative* event. AKR's observations on the poetics of oral traditions derive from a comparative and interdisciplinary approach that accommodates Sanskrit and bhakti poetics, linguistics, structural anthropology, and semiotics. The study of folktales led him to consider the notion of intertextuality in the light of structuralist and poststructuralist text theories.¹⁰⁴

The poetics of folklore that AKR studied in bard recital, ritual performance, and theatre shares some of its features with bhakti poetry. He found in folk traditions the same spontaneity, possession rituals, and lack of aesthetic distance. The poet/audience, poet/character dichotomies of *rasa* poetics do not apply here. As is the case with bhakti poetics, 'folk-poetics ... differ from classical *rasa*-poetics in important ways.... [F]olk-poetics ... works on a different view of emotion: bard and character, bard and audience, bard and actor, actor **(p.303)** and character are merged at crucial moments and separated at ordinary times.'¹⁰⁵ In the diverse folk forms described by AKR, the latter categories are constantly crossed, fused, and undone, 'not unlike the process by which a person is possessed or disposed in the course of a possession ritual'.¹⁰⁶ For in oral traditions, including folktales, folk theatre, and performance, the main thrust is on the expression of bhavas (personal emotions) embedded in a narrative structure that suggests the transient nature of ritual. Despite the subjectivity that lays emphasis on emotions, spontaneity, and passage, AKR insisted that Indian folktales display a structure and a formal design, comprising a set of techniques that aim to achieve particular transformative effects on the audience/listener.

Quite like a poem, a folktale, as ritual art form, is perceived by AKR as both 'structure and process'. In cultural anthropology, he claimed in his lecture notes, 'text is event, as much as event is text.... One can learn a lot about the major cultural forms by looking at its literary forms, and vice versa....'¹⁰⁷ The performative nature of oral tales, which AKR saw in poetry at large, was particularly appealing to a poet-scholar who was steeped in structuralism, cultural anthropology, and poststructuralism. It was, at the same time, held as a poetic and critical ideal:

The ultimate parole in folklore is a full-fledged performance in its original cultural setting—as every reproduction of it is a reduction, whether in video, tape, photograph or text and narrative, we can only point to it. But

the finger is not the moon, and there's not much sense in crying for the moon.

To attend closely to a single text, to see the text itself as a performance, the structure, not simply as a static inlay of categories but a choreography for live feelings.¹⁰⁸

For AKR, poems and folk traditions, including ritual, performance, theatre, and oral tales reflect a live movement. This tendency to interpret a poem as text and event owes as much to his early study of folklore in a living cultural context as to the influence of reader-response theory in his later academic career. In the 1970s, AKR had already come a long way from the New Critical perspective of the 1950s, which ignored the reader in the *close reading* of the text. As an experienced interdisciplinary scholar, he now stressed that the audience of a tale or reader of a text, like a dreamer or participant in a ritual, does not remain unaffected by this process, but undergoes a **(p.304)** transformation that follows the path drawn by the teller, actor, or poet in the tale, performance, or poem:

[L]ike a cockfight, a dream-text needs no interpretation—if it is fully realized, dwelt upon, experienced, the dreamer is changed, the dream's message is delivered and becomes effective.... [A] poem or a play or a dream, ritual or cockfight begins with one state and ends with another—so does a ritual.... cultural forms, like poems, have careers, a dramatic curve, that too needs to be interpreted, not only the major cultural themes.¹⁰⁹

AKR was well aware of the effects that folktales and other folk traditions could have on the audience in their particular cultural environment, so he attended to their two-way significance: 'Cultural forms (such as stories) make people what they are as much as people make culture.' He did not only believe in the folktale as an aesthetic object and poetic text that enacts its meaning, but described a tale as a living entity: '[A] travelling metaphor that finds a new meaning with each new telling ... [folktales] have an existence of their own, a secondary objectivity, like other cultural artefacts.... The story tells itself.'¹¹⁰

The 'direct narrative power'¹¹¹ that AKR admired in folklore is recreated in multiple ways in his poetry in English, and concerns formal and thematic aspects. There are, for instance, in AKR's collections long narrative poems inspired by tales, which he drafted in prose and later reworked into verse form, such as 'A Minor Sacrifice' in *Second Sight*.¹¹² In some poems the allusions to folktales are more explicit and appear in juxtaposition with commonplace situations. Based on a well-known folktale, AKR wrote, for example, 'Which Reminds Me' as a poem on poets, inspiration (grace), and the making of poems (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).¹¹³ In an interview, he made the following comments on this poem:

There are a number of poems which ... deal with folktales. One of them is about poetry.... About this there is a tale about a mango which is brought by a king to his queen and the queen eats all the nice part of the mango and throws the mango seed out of the window. A mangy dog eats it or licks it. And then it becomes pregnant whereas the queen is still barren. And I have thought poets who are poor specimens of humanity, very often they are not great as a people. They are quite lousy people. But they have this talent which seems to be like a thrown away seed.¹¹⁴

(p.305) Tamil Sangam Poetics

A crucial discovery in AKR's career was his almost accidental encounter with Tamil Sangam literature in the library of University of Chicago in 1962, which proved to be a landmark year in AKR's life. It was the same year that he became assistant professor of linguistics, Tamil, and Dravidian Studies at the University of Chicago (till 1966) and also married Molly Daniels in Chicago. The early 1960s were also an important phase for AKR as a poet in English. By then, he had already composed the bulk of poems that were to be published in his first collection of poems in English, *The Striders*, and the Oxford University Press head office in London accepted his poems in 1964 (see also the section 'A Chronology of Writings on A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry' in Chapter 1, Appendix 1, and Chart 1). Being already a promising poet and scholar of Dravidian linguistics, Tamil Sangam poetry was for AKR a literary gem 'lost and found' and posed a double challenge. While AKR painstakingly scrutinized the ancient poems at the formal level with linguistic scholarship, he also relished the Tamil compositions and their poetics with the artistic envy of a poet. The unexpected uncovering of roots in a distant land eventually turned into in a commitment to translate the ancient Tamil poems into English, with the aim of making a little known poetic tradition of high literary and historical value available to the general public. Thus, AKR was able to 'repossess' the Tamil poems by re-enacting the poetic scenarios and landscapes of the ancient Dravidians in the English language.

AKR was awed by the formal and aesthetic qualities of the Sangam poems (see the sections 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2 and 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5). Their formal simplicity hid a rich poetic system and a refined technique. He openly acknowledged that Tamil poetry had had a significant impact on his poetic and aesthetic thought: '[Tamil Sangam literature] has taught me new things about poetry, poetic systems, and about nature and culture itself....'¹¹⁵ The transparency and suggestiveness of the Tamil poems were rooted in the long tradition of poetic communities or fraternities (Sangam), which had developed a poetic code out of the natural environment. In the poetry of the Akam or love genre, first translated by AKR in the early 1960s, the flora and fauna of a particular region gave away the underlying mood of a poem. Classical Tamil poetry, as we saw, had forged over the centuries 'a language within a language' and a poetic taxonomy of 'interior landscapes'.¹¹⁶

(p.306) Within this poetic system, the Tamil poets employed a fixed stock of symbols and signs that suggested more than what was actually 'said' by the persona (lover, girlfriend, etc.) in the poem. An entire poetic universe and catalogue of human feelings was embedded in the language of natural signs. In AKR's words, '[N]ature becomes the repertory of images for all the human events of a civilisation. Natural objects become the vocabulary of culture.'¹¹⁷ This common repertory enabled the ancient Tamil poets to compose cycles of poems in which one poem spoke to another poem. Even lyrical genres were in dialogue and the Puram (war) poems often moved from the public domain to the intimacy of Akam (love), and vice versa.

Though AKR acknowledged the interrelation between his poetry in English and the translations from classical Tamil, he was not fond of shallow comparisons:

I am overwhelmed by these poems that I translate. I think they are some of the great poems of all time. I hesitate to put my own poems next to them. I feel that the tones are different. The translations require some kind of explanation which my poems don't want ...

There is a lot of interpenetration between them. I'm also a little afraid that people may compare my poems to the others. I don't like the competition.¹¹⁸

Notwithstanding the note of prudence in comparing the translations with his original poems, it is patent that the interpenetration AKR alluded to was also discernible at the level of poetic ideas. AKR emphasized in his essays, notes, and private prose particular features of Tamil poetics, sometimes with cross-cutting references to his poetry in English. His commentary on Tamil poetics offers interesting clues to his own poetic universe.

The Poetics of Nature: 'Interior Landscapes'

The inseparable union of poetics and cosmo-vision in classical Tamil literature was an essential characteristic that AKR pointed out in his literature papers and cultural essays: 'When I study classical Tamil, I am on the one hand interested in its poetics, on the other in the social arrangements or world view reflected in the literature.... I feel that none of these can be studied without the others.'¹¹⁹ Tamil poetics is presented as a unique poetic system of natural objects and human psychology that was close to his own sensibility as a poet. **(p.307)** The interdependence of poetry, emotions, and nature is captioned in AKR's metaphor of 'interior landscapes' (see also the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' and 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2, and 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5). With this borrowed coinage, he introduced the ancient Tamil conventions as a poetic system with a contemporary appeal.

In his numerous essays on this poetic and social division in Tamil classical poetry, AKR made it clear that ‘*akam* poetry is directly about experience, not action; it is a poetry of the inner world’.¹²⁰ As described in the section ‘Tamil Aesthetics’ in Chapter 5, the taxonomy of Tamil poetics, first explained by AKR at length in the landmark collection *The Interior Landscape*, classifies the entire spectrum of Akam poems into five *tinai* or landscapes. These correspond to five types of love: union (hills), patient waiting (forest), anxious waiting (seashore), infidelity (pasture), and separation (wasteland). Two additional types are identified: ‘unrequited love’ and ‘mismatched love’, but these were not the subject of ‘true love poetry’. The elements that define a poem are the ‘first things’ (time and place), the ‘native elements’, and the ‘human feelings’ (phases of love).¹²¹

One of the seminal contributions of Akam poetics, AKR taught us, is that the human feelings in a poem are contextual, that is, they are subject to—or given by—both the ‘first things’ and the ‘native elements’, which allows for conventions that ‘make for many kinds of economy in poetic design’.¹²² The correspondence of nature and human feelings, and the contiguity of exterior and interior elements in the ancient Tamil poetic tradition, was a long-standing preoccupation with AKR, as was poetic ‘economy’. The natural world ‘order’ embedded in Sangam poetics informed a good part of his essays and lecture notes: ‘Tamil presents an order growing out of nature. Classical Tamil convention does not redo nature, but places and orders it.’¹²³

The imagistic poetic design of Tamil poetry and the ordered continuum of ‘nature-culture’ feelings it displayed were truly a discovery for a scholar-poet who had been teaching to south-Indian college students the grandeur of English literature, Shakespearean drama, and English Romantic poetry, as well as the modernist poetics of Eliot and Pound. Decades before AKR stumbled upon the Tamil classics, Ezra Pound had found inspiration in another ancient Asian lyric tradition, the Japanese haiku, to create his **(p.308)** modern ‘one-image-poems’. The irony of AKR’s finding in the early 1960s is that his was the discovery of a mother-tongue tradition in an unexpected place. The ‘interior landscapes’ of Tamil poetry were interiorized by AKR in Chicago, far away from the landscapes of his motherland.

The ability of the Tamil bards to condense a situation of human relations and feelings in a few concrete images and natural objects became a poetic ideal for AKR, who had earlier eschewed the Romantic and the progressive Kannada poets, and turned to the austerity of the European classical tradition defended by T.S. Eliot and other modernist poets of the twentieth century. In his studies of Tamil poetry, AKR drew parallels with the Western tradition and underlined the idiosyncrasy of the Tamil poetic technique:

These classical Tamil poems attracted me by their attitude to experience, to human passion, and to the external world; their trust in the bareness, the lean line with no need to jazz it up or ornament it. They seemed to me Classical, anti-Romantic, using the words loosely as we know them in European literature. A great deal of modern Indian writing has been ruined by Romanticism of the Shelleyan variety. And not just our writing but our taste (both in Indian languages and in English). We have been recovering from it in this generation. Look at the classical Tamil poems, their attention to experience. Yet their attention to the object is not to create the 'object' of the Imagist, but the object as enacting human experience: the scene always a part of the human scene, the poetry of objects always a part of the human perception of self and others. This seemed to me an extraordinary way of writing poetry.

... The ability to engage entirely the world of things, animals, trees, and people, attending to their particularity, making poetry out of it and making them speak for you—this seems to me extraordinary.¹²⁴

In an effort to compare the sophistication of Sangam poetics with the individual poetics of Eliot, AKR again refers in the afterword to *Poems of Love and War* to a much discussed Eliotan concept: '[F]irst things and native elements, are seen as the "objective correlatives," or rather the correlative objects, of human experience.' The notes to AKR's essay elaborate on the differences between the two concepts: "'Objective correlatives" (Eliot 1959), and what I have called correlative objects, are very different things: the first are sought and found by individual poets, the latter are given by culture in which the poets dwell.'¹²⁵ On the other hand, the external-internal continuum of object and feeling in Sangam (p.309) poetry is also concomitant with the complex relationship between the real and the imaginary that was a crucial concern in modernist poetry (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in this chapter). The Tamil poetic treatise *Tolkappiyam* establishes 'two kinds of proprieties: those of Drama and those of the World'.¹²⁶ The Sangam poets had to find a balance between the two, suggesting dramatic scenarios in a real, recognizable world. AKR clarified that 'the strategy of the poet is to deploy both, to keep the tension between the forms of art and the forms of the world'.¹²⁷ This is possible since Sangam poetics is built on a metonymical cosmo-vision that is concentric and continuous with nature: 'In this world of correspondences between times, places, things born in them, and human experiences, a word like *kurinci* has several concentric circles of meaning: a flower, the mountain landscape, lover's union, a type of poem about all these, and musical modes for these poems. But its concrete meaning, "a mountain flower" is never quite forgotten.'¹²⁸

The 'Poetic Design' of Sangam Poetry

AKR described in his papers on Sangam poetry how the poetic conventions of classical Tamil poetry aimed for a particular 'poetic design'. The Tamil poets achieved an effective economy and suggestiveness at the formal level through a set of poetic conventions and rhetorical strategies.¹²⁹ Here is a short overview of some of the poetic conventions that AKR repeatedly analysed and appraised in classical Tamil poetry, and which he also experimented with in his poetry, especially from *Relations* (1971) onwards.

The Economy of the Concrete Image

Tamil Sangam poems were short compositions with highly evocative imagery. The literary conventions and poetic language codified in the *Tolkappiyam* made use of 'an entire "science of the concrete"',¹³⁰ producing condensed yet transparent poems that allowed for abrupt shifts of scene within a few lines. The clarity of an image could be attained by a distinctive kind of 'focusing technique'.¹³¹ For instance, a Sangam poem could begin with abstractions about love and move towards the concreteness of an image, a flower, or an animal, in consonance with the progression of the character's feelings. Such a form of progression displayed 'the method of the entire intellectual (p.310) framework behind the poetry', as AKR saw it. The characteristic poetic techniques 'of the concrete' brought into play by the ancient Tamil poets that AKR admired conformed to a sensibility that was concentric and 'eco-aesthetic', as defined earlier. A poem could begin anywhere, with the micro or macro, at the concrete or abstract level, but the meaning always worked through a particular image. This 'concreteness' appealed to AKR as it gave the ancient Tamil compositions a strikingly 'modern' look. Indeed, the comparisons of ancient and modern south-Indian poetry often served to express his poetic esteem for the former:

To me, poetry is a modest enterprise. I'll have to find my meaning in the ordinary, the here and now.... I try to look closely at the particular and thence to the general though, in the event, the general may not even get stated....

In fact I think the Sangam lyrics read so fresh because of their concreteness. It is this quality that enables them to transcend their time. The modern Kannada poets, I have noticed, tend to have general ideas.¹³²

AKR's critique of modern Indian poetry in comparison with the Sangam tradition was also directed at the modern Tamil poets, some of which he had read and become acquainted with during his visits to Madras. When the Tamil poet Nakulan interviewed AKR in 1969 to discuss the modern and classical Tamil poets,¹³³ the despondent attitude of the former towards Sangam poetry prompted AKR to defend the formal classicism of Tamil poems. While Nakulan claimed that Sangam poetry contained only 'few memorable lines', AKR set the

sharp images of the Tamil classics against the abstractions and romantic strain that many contemporary south-Indian poets of the 1960s seemed to follow:

Form isn't a thing apart from the so-called elements of a story, plot, character and so on. But the point is, the writer, if he can create a unity of impression, has achieved the discipline of form.... I prefer the classical. A typical Sangam poem has a well-defined, well-wrought complex form. It has an articulate body of conventions behind it. The image is not flaunted here but is sharp and pointed. As for the memorable line, you will notice that it is what comes before and after that gives this quotable line its sharpness and emphasis.¹³⁴

Ullurai or Inset

A typical Sangam poem unfurls sharp images with an intense associational and expansive quality. Thus, a distinctive feature of Sangam poetics was the technique of describing an action or person **(p.311)** by giving the natural setting and its elements (for example, the kurinci flower in the mountains). The *Tolkappiyam* treatise, states AKR in *Poems of Love and War*, evolved a 'theory of comparison' around this technique called '*ullurai uvanam*, hidden or implicit metaphor'.¹³⁵ He defined this type of comparison as an 'inset' of the natural scene, in allusion to G.M. Hopkins's 'inscape'. Unlike the mechanism of metaphor, ullurai is an implicit comparison with no explicit markers or elements of comparison. The natural elements from the exterior landscape are not compared to human qualities, they are *continuous* with the human scene, as in the following poem:

What She Said

Bigger than earth, certainly,
higher than the sky,
more unfathomable than the waters
is this love for this man

of the mountain slopes
where bees make rich honey
from the flowers of the kurinci
that has such black stalks.¹³⁶

The ullurai device or inset increases the suggestive power of the image and makes of association and metonymy an integral part of the structure of the poem: 'The inset is essentially a "metonymy," and *in presentia* relationship, where both terms are present, where the signifier and the signified belong to the same universe, share the same "landscape". Both are part of the scene.... The man belongs to the scene, the scene represents the man.'¹³⁷ AKR once again relies on the terminology of the theorist of rhetoric Kenneth Burke and his notion of dramatic criticism to state that 'scene and agent' are one in the Tamil

technique of comparison. Elsewhere in his notecards, AKR describes ullurai as 'both metaphor and metonymy, a device that describes a man's character by describing a man's property: almost a pun in the world "property". A man is what he has.'¹³⁸

Dramatic Scenarios

The dramatic scene of an Akam (love) poem in the Sangam convention usually unfolds in a handful of lines. It typically presents a situation with **(p.312)** the archetypal male-female relationship (outside and inside marriage) at the centre and a host of characters around the lovers. The *dramatis personae* are limited to a small number and confined to family, friends, confidantes, etc. The poems often introduce the situation, context, and personae of the poem in the title itself, and play with the point of view in the poem.¹³⁹ Some of the poems, in fact, were meant 'to be overheard ... so the speech in the poem often has ulterior motives; it is a multiple utterance.... The poems, with their given titles and situations, carry the entire context with them.'¹⁴⁰ Human relationships are at the centre stage of the nature-culture continuum encompassing the natural elements, human features, and actions. In this poetic 'scenario', the reader plays a spectator-listener role. Like the audience in a play, he/she is invited to look at the dramatic stage of the poem. AKR maintained that 'no poem is addressed to the reader. The reader only overhears what the characters say to each other or to themselves or to the moon. A poem in this tradition implies, evokes, enacts a drama in a monologue.'¹⁴¹ Indirection and understatement become important techniques in this art of creating and overhearing a scene. The poem suggests the entire scenario and context within a few lines, as the poetic language becomes the landscape and stage of human feelings. The context outside the poem is thereby internalized. It comes into existence in the text because there is a 'poetic code'.

Inspired by the dramatic quality of the Tamil lyrics, AKR's poetry in English abounds with dramatic monologues and sets of human relations. In these he often 'recalls' fictitious family situations, including 'love scenes' which remind us of the Tamil Akam poems, though ironically of the types of love considered 'unworthy' of poetry, that is, 'unrequited' and 'mismatched' love, which were 'abnormal, undignified, fit only for servants'.¹⁴² AKR, too, believed in a poetics of the human scene, that is, a poetics of private, archetypal relationships (Akam) as the ideal theatre for poetic action, but in his own poems the stance was that of a modern, often self-mocking, persona. Such 'relations' enabled the poet to suggest a whole world outside a concrete dramatic scene:

I have tried to keep the human scene central in the poems. The more I pay attention to the human world, for me the line between the poem and the novel, the lyric and the story, begins to blur; and anyway in Indian poetry there's never been a clear line. Any single poem implies a persona, a voice,

a specific scene, a whole dramatic situation. This is true of both the Tamil poems and the Sanskrit ones.¹⁴³

(p.313) In dramatic scenarios of this kind, the use of the mask becomes an important resource to distance the personal feelings. The poet can take up a plurality of identities to hide his self in passivity and irony. This makes his poems seem personal yet distant, as if he were watching himself perform. It is a multiple state of being that allows for freedom and transparency. The acceptance of a plural identity in AKR may seem a modern poetic strategy, but it is also a poetic technique exploited by the ancient Tamil poets. In his afterword to *The Interior Landscape*, AKR states that such a poetic stance helps to depersonalize poetry. The narrative monologue to render the nuances of a particular experience was typical of the classical Tamil fraternity poets. Like them, AKR sought to poeticize inner experiences in short imagistic poems, which had the properties of drama in real life.

Akam and Puram as Poetic Devices

Akam and Puram are, as AKR notes, not only a ‘thematic division’ but central ‘poetic devices’ in Tamil poetry. The multiple meanings of Akam and Puram that have already been alluded to (see the section ‘Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage’ in Chapter 2) show that the different interpretations and uses of this pair of concepts are complementary and expand in concentric circles: from self and body to spatial references, poetic genres, and codes of conduct. Many Sangam poems move across these connotations and manage to shift from the Akam (inner) to the Puram (outer), and vice versa, within a few lines. The Akam and Puram notions serve as a configuration that allows for imaginative crossovers as part of an elaborate poetic technique: ‘Often the poetic moment is actually poised on the threshold, though a figure in the poem may move (actually, or in imagination) from outer to inner.’¹⁴⁴

AKR was inclined to see poetry as a process that took place simultaneously within the poem and outside of it, within the poet and reader; a process which played with imagination and reality, and with the infinite tensions and crossovers of the ‘forms of art and the forms of the world’.¹⁴⁵ He learnt from the Tamil Sangam poets that ‘a poem, being a speech-act, a language event, like an act or ritual in society—is not only structure, but process—has a career, a movement that’s expressive—... also re-orders a variety of materials, relationships, by reversal, transformation, juxtaposition’.¹⁴⁶ Thus, in his own translational career and poetry of ‘relations’ and ‘reversal’, **(p.314)** AKR drew from the Sangam fraternity of poets and the later bhakti mystic traditions a set of poetic techniques and a model of literature that connected him to the modernist poets and theorists of the twentieth century.

Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics

W.G. Eagleton, the English professor at Maharaja's College who praised young AKR's exceptionally wide reading and intellectual acumen, noted in 1949: 'He is particularly interested in modern literature, both in English and in other languages. He has a very good knowledge of both Kannada and Tamil, and has plenty of experience of literary work in Kannada.'¹⁴⁷ Despite this early impact of modern poetics in AKR's career as a student, scholar, and poet, in his prose work the presence of nineteenth- and twentieth-century poets and poetic traditions is relatively meagre. Except for an early paper on Walt Whitman, an article on contemporary Indian poetry, and the collected essay on the Tamil poet Subramania Bharati, nineteenth- and twentieth-century poets are usually referred to in his essays in passing for comparative purposes or to support a wider argument.¹⁴⁸ However, the weight of certain contemporary poets in AKR's poetics is manifested in the interviews and in the diaries and notes in the Papers, which reveal his predilections and practice as a critic of contemporary literature, a facet that is kept timidly in the background in most of his scholarly essays. When AKR writes and talks about nineteenth century and contemporary poetry, he is equally comfortable with Western and Indian poets, proving his early exposure to multiple contemporary traditions (Kannada, Tamil, English, American, French, and German, among others).

Western Poets

Every poet in the course of his/her life will have favourite authors and admire particular poets that cross his/her way. Sooner or later, the poet pays tribute to these models, which are deliberately or unconsciously integrated into his/her personal poetics. AKR is no exception to this rule and there are aspects of his poetry and poetics that carry the visible mark of Western poets he read and studied since he went to college. Some of these influences are (openly or implicitly) acknowledged in his work, either in allusions in the poems or in references in his **(p.315)** prose, and are thus part of AKR's web of intertextuality along with the many other traces, textual tissues, and techniques that went into his body of poetry. There are a few poets that AKR studied more closely and who occupy a larger canvas in his private and scholarly prose. His deep knowledge of, and admiration for, William Shakespeare is well known, and the English bard's impact on AKR as a poet is evidenced, for instance, in the choice of the sonnet form in his latter work. As has been mentioned, AKR taught Shakespeare both in India and the USA and he frequently cites him in his prose, at times in unexpected contexts (see, for example, the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5, on *rasa*).

Among the later Western poets, Walt Whitman and W.B. Yeats had a special place in his studies, and of the modernist poets, Ezra Pound and T.S. Eliot stand out in his writings. Other poets in whom AKR showed keen interest include William Wordsworth, William Blake, S.T. Coleridge, John Keats, Percy B. Shelley, Henry D. Thoreau, G.M. Hopkins, D.H. Lawrence, Oscar Wilde, W.H. Auden, E.E. Cummings, Robert Frost, Wallace Stevens, Marianne Moore, and Robert Bly.

From non-English language poets, AKR mentions, among others, Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, Heinrich Heine, Rainer Maria Rilke, Paul Valéry, Charles Baudelaire, César Vallejo,¹⁴⁹ and Jorge Luis Borges. The presence in AKR's poetry of continental European and Latin American poets like Borges, whose motifs and ideas, rather than formal technique, influenced his writings from the early 1960s, certainly deserves more critical attention (see also the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 and 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3). In the 1966 *Poetry Book Society Bulletin*, AKR publicly recognized the multiple traditions (see the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 and 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8) that went into his first collection of poetry, but names only English-language poets:

Of modern poets in the English language, W.B. Yeats, Ezra Pound and Wallace Stevens have spoken to my concerns more than others. The first poem ['The Striders'] pays a sort of tribute to them by echoing them. In the Indian epics, sometimes a young man has to battle with his own gurus who taught him archery: before battle, he sends a couple of arrows that fall at their feet. Regarding all these that have become part of me, I can only say with the planters' proverb: one can sometimes count the number of oranges in a tree but never the number of trees in an orange.¹⁵⁰

(p.316) This is a rare instance of AKR acknowledging in a published source the echoes of others in his poems. But he could also be sarcastic about his 'modernism', as the following note to the unpublished draft 'Towards a Poem with Footnotes' proves: 'I've been changed with modern poetry. This is the most modern of all my poems—: because it was written an hour ago. It has footnotes longer than the poem. Like every bad poem it's terribly sincere.'¹⁵¹

The English Romantics

Like most of his contemporaries, AKR had imbued in his college days the Romantic poetics that had been prevalent in colonial India during the early 1940s and well into the postcolonial period, particularly among Indian poets writing in English, many of whom were professors of English. AKR mentions in particular his admiration for Keats, but also refers to Wordsworth, Blake, Coleridge, and Shelley in his prose. The influence of the Romantics in AKR has indeed been underestimated and could be the object of an illuminating monographic study. There are a number of interrelated features that bring AKR close to the poetics of the Romantics, some of which are highlighted here epigrammatically:¹⁵²

1. First, the way AKR paid attention to, rather than eschewed (like many of his fellow modern poets), the very idea of tradition in Indian literature, and his close commitment to folklore and medieval (later also classical) south-Indian poetry from a very young age, could be called a Romantic

attitude (see the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8).

2. The focus on the 'visible world' (Walter Pater) that is experienced through the five senses (see the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5), and put to practice in Keats's synesthetic poetry.

3. The foregrounding of particulars rather than universals (see the section 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5) is a common Romantic trait.

4. The attention to the minutiae in life, for example, insects, as in Coleridge (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6), and the close relation between the natural world and the human world (see the section 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5).

5. The motifs of metamorphosis and rebirth in reptiles and insects, such as snakes and caterpillars (see the section **(p.317)** 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5), were characteristic of Romantic poetry.

6. AKR's invoking of Keats's *negative capability* that describes an artist's natural wonderment at the world (see the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5).

7. On the origin of poems, AKR observed that they should come as an 'ordinary' experience and again quoted Keats's 'as naturally as leaves to a tree or not at all' (see, for example, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

8. The aesthetic experience as a quasi-mystical experience (see the sections 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' and 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5), which is prominent in many well-known Romantic poems, such as Coleridge's *Kubla Khan*.

9. Possession or grace as a source of poetic inspiration in the act of writing is another common theme in Romantic poetry, where muses, gods, and goddesses abound (see the sections 'The Aesthetics of Bhakti' in Chapter 5, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in this chapter).

10. The concept of 'interior landscape' which derives from the Romantic idealization of nature as expression of feeling, as seen in Wordsworth, and the innovative contribution of G.M. Hopkins's 'inscape' (see the sections 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5 and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in this chapter).

And finally, we should not forget that many of the European-language texts containing Indian philosophical concepts, images, and motifs from the Vedas and the Upanishads (the sources as well as their treatment) that the English Romantics read were the same that were prevalent in twentieth-century Indology in India. These had actually come down via the nineteenth-century

Western orientalist scholars to the English Romantics, who were the first English-language poets to absorb Hindu notions and philosophy, much before later seminal writers like Whitman, Yeats, and Eliot discovered them for their own use.

Walt Whitman

'Notes on Walt Whitman' (1955) is an early exercise in literary criticism that points out the poetic successes and failures of the foremost of **(p.318)** American poets. AKR criticizes in it Whitman's obsession with forging an image of himself as the prophetic American bard and declares that a critic should approach 'poetry as experience'. He condemns Whitman's habit of embracing abstract ideas and ideals in often 'inarticulate' poetic sequences and his neglect of poetry that is 'close to speech'. He, therefore, proposes to study 'his Free verse, unimpressed by its being a "pioneer experiment," as it contributes to making Whitman a poet'.¹⁵³

While AKR's modernist influences in the 1950s made him take a New Critical stance in this article, his analysis of Whitman's poetry evinces a personal predilection for poetry that is 'attentive to experience, sensitive to words', rather than to abstraction and grandiloquence. He describes the best of Whitman, quoting D.H. Lawrence, as 'poetry of the immediate present, instant poetry, as well as poetry of the infinite past and the infinite future'.¹⁵⁴ AKR then analyses in several passages the devices employed by Whitman to 'express the immediacy, the thronging minute particulars which are the content of every moment. His lists are, particularly, expressions of his sense of the swarming simultaneity of things in the present....'¹⁵⁵ Attention to the particulars of life and the experience of an immediate present were among the qualities that AKR idealized in his art and poetry (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6). AKR seeks out further features in Whitman's free verse that were in line with his own poetic thought. For instance, 'objectivity' and 'detachment' are underlined as virtues of Whitman's worthwhile passages, and seen as antecedents of the imagists:

This belief in the equality of things, makes him a poet of great precision in rendering details; he attends closely to the specificity of things.... His egalitarianism gives him a concrete objectivity, wherein he anticipates the Imagists.... Contrary to popular belief, Whitman is not so much the poet of personality, but of attentive detachment. This detachment, again, fulfils poetically his pledge as a democrat to treat all things as equal. Hence his glimpses, vivid self-contained pictures....¹⁵⁶

Another reason for AKR's early admiration for Whitman was the connection he had perceived between 'Song of Myself' and the Bhagavad Gita in the

conception of the double self (active prakriti and passive purusa), which also lingered in his own poetic oeuvre:

In fact the idea of Prakriti and Purusha is central to Song of Myself

Urge, Urge ... opposite equals advance ...

(p.319) Equality but it's a Purusha-eye-view a vertical view of the world
—'omnigenous'

In fact, the liberated take that view, because they are Purusha—so,
Whitman speaks often in the voice of Krishna to Arjuna.¹⁵⁷

Whitman's 'Song of Myself' remained as an undercurrent in AKR's poetry and traces of it can be detected in 'Elements of Composition' and other poems in *Second Sight*, a composite poetry collection that was largely misapprehended when it was published (see Appendix 2). In the essay 'Parables and Commonplaces', when commenting on intercultural encounters and dialogues with Indian philosophy in Western literature, AKR did not choose his examples randomly: 'In the literatures too, the encounters have left major marks—one could talk (as others have done) of Yeats and the *Upanishads*, and of Whitman's *Leaves of Grass* as a combination of *The Bhagavad Gita* and the *Boston Globe* as Emerson called it.'¹⁵⁸

W.B. Yeats

Yeats is, after Eliot, the most frequently quoted modern poet in AKR's writings and features in numerous passages of the papers, lectures, notes, and private prose throughout his career.¹⁵⁹ What is more, some of the most persistent questions and preoccupations in AKR's thought find a starting point, and often solution, in the Yeatsian model he often quoted: '[T]he ladder of all those things start from the rag-and-bones shop of the heart' (see the section 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5).¹⁶⁰

Several issues related to poetic creativity in AKR, in its theoretical and practical dimensions, can be attributed to the Irish poet. AKR had attempted a doctoral dissertation on Yeats when he was a lecturer at the University of Baroda from 1957 to 1958. During his research on Yeats in the 1950s, he learnt, for instance, how Indian and Western philosophy and mythology could be combined and integrated into poetry in a modern context without making it sound contrived. Yeats's use of the *Upanishads*, Greek, and Irish mythology, as well as other literary traditions (from Dante to the Romantic poets) impressed the young AKR and made him pay attention to his own traditions (starting with the *Upanishads* and medieval *bhakti*) not only as thematic material but also as formal resources, as we saw. The most strikingly Yeatsian characteristic in AKR's thought, however, is his **(p.320)** treatment of the concept of poet and poetic inspiration. The conflict between sage and poet, the dichotomy of chance and choice, and

the notion of double self (self and anti-self) and the related metaphors of mirror, mask, and dance in Yeats were topics that AKR revisited throughout the years.¹⁶¹ For example, the Yeatsian question—‘How can we know the dancer from the dance?’—associated with this dichotomy, permeates AKR’s series of poems on the dancer (see the section ‘What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience’ in Chapter 4), and in ‘Where Mirrors Are Windows’, his anthological essay on reflections (see the section ‘Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage’ in Chapter 2), AKR quotes Yeats’s famous phrase ‘mirror on mirror mirrored is all the show’.

Like the Irish bard, AKR believed in poetic creation as a result of the warring elements of the divided self and something akin to possession by an outside force. Yeats inquired into the role of the poet in exploring the tensions in his double self and the dialogue between the spiritual and physical worlds. This artistic process is picked up by AKR in his notes on Yeats’s ‘Per Amica Silentia Lunae’:¹⁶² ‘One goes on year after year gradually getting the disorder of one’s mind in order and this is the real impulse to create.’¹⁶³ For instance, some of AKR’s meta-poems (see the section ‘The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition’ in Chapter 6 and Appendix 1), in which an external force seems to seize the poet, are reminiscent of Yeats’s notion of the ‘Daimon’ that descends upon the artist.¹⁶⁴ And, in moments of poetic ‘need’, when AKR sometimes sought refuge in other writers’ lives and work, and the images of the Kannada mystics and Yeats were the first to be conjured out of his past. A diary entry from the early 1980s reflects on moments of artistic change and addresses the ‘source’ of creativity through Yeats’s verses, which ‘remind us’ of some of AKR’s early poems like ‘The Striders’ or ‘Self-Portrait’:

Aug 28, 1982

Seeking as I’m now, to change, to write new poems, to finish things I began 20 or even thirty years ago, and to begin in new ways—I’m casting about in poets and their lives.

Goethe prescribes, the critical faculty, intellect, and desire must be suspended until images take shape of their own will.

I call to the mysterious one who yet
Shall walk the wet sands by the edge of the stream
And look most like me, being indeed my double,
(p.321) And prove of all imaginable things
The most unlike, being my anti-self,
And standing by these characters disclose
All that I seek;¹⁶⁵

Other features AKR admired in Yeats and which he incorporated in his work process were the frequent revision of drafts that Yeats was known for, his

arrangement of poems, and the use of poem sequences and traditional forms (see also the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8) to create a dialogue between poems until, as Yeats said, 'one poem lights up another'.¹⁶⁶

I did get to Yeats and Eliot a few years later [a few years after 1946], I was quite taken with Yeats, and read everything I could by him, about him. I was particularly taken with his constant revisions (his *Visions* fascinated me but didn't make much sense) his use of arrangement as a poetic device, and his sense of *oeuvre* [*sic*]*—*he was writing his *Collected Poems* from the word 'go'. Yeats's way of making poem relevant to poem is somewhere at the back of my mind....¹⁶⁷

Ezra Pound

Ezra Pound is cited by AKR as an example of the creative exchange between the Western and Eastern (Japanese and Chinese) traditions and, above all, as a modern master of translation. His poetic work introduced AKR not only to Imagism (see the sections 'Aesthetic "Journeys": Experiences from the Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4 and 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6), but also to intertextuality, juxtaposition, and cross-cultural allusion in modernist poetry, which had had a cross-fertilizing effect in India: 'Ezra Pound's poetry is affected by the Chinese and in turn has affected poetry in far-flung places like Japan and India.'¹⁶⁸ Readers and critics of AKR's poetry have noted that certain phrases in poems like 'The Striders' or 'Conventions of Despair' were borrowed or adapted from Pound. To which he retorted: '[T]hat's part of my expressive means. I've read Pound, and I've read Indian things. Why shouldn't I use what I have?'¹⁶⁹ Pound also eased AKR from the extemporal bonds of tradition that many Indian poets were tied to, for his pioneering work made him realize that a contemporary poet-translator must not only know but also challenge manifold traditions and engage in an artistic give and take vis-à-vis the classics and anonymous masters:

(p.322) Oct 30, 1976

Pound slows down the reader, in an age of speed-reading.—[H]e slows down the reader by every device, irregular rhythms, disconnection, or connection only by cross-reference or allusion across whole pages, Chinese, Greek, medieval French phrases often in their native orthographies etc. His is a poetry [in] slow motion.

His translations become modern poems and his own cantos have the look of translations—and often are a pastiche of translations. He's a Bricoleur, a junk-sculptor with all of (his) history for the junk to play with, juxtapose and reweld into a new form.¹⁷⁰

AKR's early zeal to recreate medieval bhakti poetry and 'make it new' can also partly be ascribed to Pound's influence. Therefore, his concept of translation (commented in detail in the introductions and afterwords to his collections of medieval and classical south-Indian poetry collections) and his poetry translations, hailed widely as a layperson's and scholar's delight, must be read in the context of Pound's own translation theory and poetry:

Certainly in English poetry I have read and even studied—Yeats, Wallace Stevens, Carlos Williams and various others. And I am constantly reading poetry. One doesn't know what becomes part of oneself. I have read a lot of Ezra Pound, partly to learn about translations from him. He certainly frees you from certain kind of ... shackles that mere scholarship places on you as a translator, because I also happen to have a scholarly interest in these poems. But if it overweighs my poetic feelings or my involvement with these poems, then the translation would become dry. They wouldn't speak anything to anybody who does not know anything about India.... Ezra Pound released you from wanting to be simply a scholar.¹⁷¹

T.S. Eliot

As many modern Indian poets writing in English during the post-Independence years in India, AKR's prose and poetry was under the continuous spell of T.S. Eliot, modernist poet par excellence. Eliot's presence was more than conspicuous in Indian poetry circles of the late 1940s and 1950s, more so since many of the young Indian poets of the time were professors of English, including some of the regional-language poets.¹⁷² In the case of AKR, Eliot's essays on poetry and criticism served as a backdrop for his ideas on tradition and innovation in Indian literature, and translation, and occupied a prominent place in his comparative studies and modernist poetics.¹⁷³ It is indisputable **(p.323)** that Eliot's celebrated essay 'Tradition and the Individual Talent' (1919) formed the backbone for his views on the concept of tradition and for his personal theory (if we may call it a theory, for it cannot hold as an abstraction alone) and practice of literary tradition he evolved out of it (see the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8). By the late 1950s, when AKR left for the USA, Eliot's literary criticism had already become so entrenched in his thought that it operated as the principal starting point to discuss and explain Indian literature in a foreign land. And AKR realized soon that it was highly relevant to the Indian context: 'T.S. Eliot spoke of a simultaneous order for European literature, but the phrase applies even more strongly to Indian literary traditions, especially until the nineteenth century.'¹⁷⁴ More precisely, AKR insisted that Eliot's essay provided pertinent cues to understand how the classical Tamil poets operated within a 'continuous' poetic tradition or Sangam (fraternity of poets).

AKR's critique of Eliot as a poet, rather than as essayist, is not disclosed in the academic papers and essays. One has to go to the diaries and private notes to learn more about his assessment of Eliot's poetics. The aspects of Eliot that AKR underlines there have a strong footing in the modernist features he tried to implement in his own poetics:

Nov 10, 1981.

.... Eliot, unlike many other poets, say WB Yeats, is a poet of many voices, and one must learn to hear them, distinguish them, listen to what they say to each other, how they negate, modify, color each other towards complexity. Eliot is a thinking poet, but he thinks in voices. It is through them he creates concepts, they develop on the page. So we must attend to the progression, as well as to the rhythmic returns of these elements. We must attend to 'ideas' not as pre-existing notions, but created by the words,—and not merely the single words, but the tone, the placements—on the page. That's a pledge we must take.

He also makes poetry of the struggle to find a language for such an exploration.¹⁷⁵

AKR's relation to Eliot was, therefore, two-faced. On the one hand, he was a fervent follower of his ideas on tradition in poetry and admired his ability to recreate a personal poetic voice out of the classical tradition, and, on the other, there was in AKR the poet a good measure of *anxiety of influence* towards Eliot and his poetry that made him hide his admiration. He conceded elsewhere in the context of the (p.324) ancient Tamil Sangam poets: '[E]very author is a belated arrival who has to prove himself new—and subject to the "anxiety of influence" that Harold Bloom (1973) has devoted himself to describing.... But the Tamil poets do not seem to be anxious. They are continuous with their past.'¹⁷⁶ In 1971, AKR wrote his well-known poem 'Prayers to Lord Murugan', an anti-prayer that was partly an attempt to emulate Eliot's modern ironic style combining self and (Tamil religious) literary tradition. In the early 1980s, however, he decided against another long self-reflexive meditative poem when he split his draft of 'Composition' into shorter poems. He had a poem of 26 sections ready for publication, but he 'decomposed' it fearing that critics would point to Eliot and the *Four Quartets* instead of paying attention to his personal stylistic innovation.¹⁷⁷ Curiously, AKR copied around that time the following lines from Eliot's 'Little Gidding' in his private notecards: 'A condition of complete simplicity/ (Costing not less than everything).'¹⁷⁸

Other Contemporary Western English-Language Poets

AKR's pledge in his 1981 diary to 'attend to "ideas" not as pre-existing notions, but created by the words ...' as well as to 'the tone, the placements-on the page ...'¹⁷⁹ calls to mind the poetics of the imagists, poets like Wallace Stevens and

William Carlos Williams and his dictum 'No ideas but in things' from 'The Red Wheelbarrow'.¹⁸⁰ The Imagists stood up for the primacy of image in poetry. They wanted to draw the reader in by sharing the perception and articulation of the sensory, involving things seen, smelt, tasted, tactile sensations, sounds heard, etc. In Imagist poetry, images were not merely physical description but had to contain ideas and feelings. Language, when used precisely, according to the Imagists, should appeal to the senses of readers and evoke a response directly generated by the 'thing' or object described. For Pound, who enunciated the principles of Imagism, an image was an 'intellectual and emotional complex'.¹⁸¹

Some of AKR's meta-poems from his early phase in *The Striders* (for example, 'The Striders' and 'A Poem on Particulars') can be read as allusions to the poetics of Stevens and Williams, who treated philosophical significance as something inherent in an ordinary object. And he did not hide his admiration for the Imagists. In the interview conducted in 1982 by fellow south-Indian poet-critic Ayyappa Paniker, AKR stated: 'I read a lot of them [English and American (p.325) poets]. At different times I read different ones. I have read a lot of Williams, Stevens, and among the older ones Yeats.' A few years later, in 1989, he conceded in another taped conversation: 'Influenced by people like Williams Carlos Williams, I carve out of ordinary language and ordinary experience a shape....'¹⁸²

By the same token, AKR was interested in the relation between the real and the imaginary in poetry, and pointed out connections between the ancient Tamil poets and Marianne Moore's poetic vision: 'In this view of the relationship of reality to poetry, they [the Sangam poets] seem to anticipate Marianne Moore who suggested that poets ought to be "literalists of the imagination" and that poems ought to be "imaginary gardens with real toads in them" (1961, 41).'¹⁸³ AKR was also well read in the younger generation of American poets and followed actively the poetic trends of the second half of the twentieth century. In 1969, he stated in an interview: 'I would say there are many good poets writing now in America, both of the older generation like Robert Lowell, Karl Shapiro, Eberhart and many others, and the younger ones like James Tate. There is also a great variety of American Voices: think of Lowell, Ginsberg, Hecht and Denise Levertov. It is an exciting scene....'¹⁸⁴

It is noteworthy that, in the early 1980s, after having lived in the USA for a quarter of a century, AKR felt that the time had come to accommodate his poetry to the contemporary American poetic scene. He made a schematic self-assessment of his career in one of the journals that reveals the new directions he wished to take:

1. What I've done for 25 years—languages, translation, essays on Indian litt., poetry

2. What I'd like to do: a. integrate my writing more closely to American poetry today, not consciously b. teach a course on Contemp. Am. and Brit. Poetry here and in India c. poetry and culture SSRC d. theatre e. translations into Kannada f. introduce Indian poetry to poets in English.¹⁸⁵

Contemporary Indian Poets

As a bilingual poet writing in English and Kannada, AKR had always considered himself part of the modern Indian poetry scene which gained ground in the post-Independence years in India. Even before leaving India for the USA in 1959, he had befriended some of the pioneering poets of the modernist movements who were then shaping up, notably Gieve Patel and Nissim Ezekiel in English, and **(p.326)** in Kannada P. Lankesh and the elder Gopalakrishna Adiga, one of the major exponents of the *navya* (new) poetry that flourished in the 1950s under the impact of New Criticism and modernist poetics imported from the West. After settling in the USA, AKR tried to keep up with the developments that were taking place in contemporary Indian poetry scenes he had been in contact with, particularly in English and Kannada, but also in Tamil, Marathi, and Malayalam. This is how he describes in his 1983 overview of contemporary Indian poetry the changes and external influences in these poetry circles:

Poetic forms, ranging from the Japanese haiku, the European sonnet, and English nursery rhyme to Whitmanesque free verse, were adapted for Indian use. A medley of isms, like surrealism, Marxism, imagism, has swept through Indian poetry as it has elsewhere in the world's poetry. The influence of the English Romantics in the 20's and earlier, yielded to that of T.S. Eliot (with a time-lag of decades), and later still to that of Pound, or of Baudelaire, and more recently to the influence of Cummings, Ho Chi Minh, Neruda, Borges, Gunter Grass, or Allen Ginsberg....¹⁸⁶

AKR's critique of contemporary Indian poetry in English and in the regional languages was founded on the idea of a triple stream of traditions—regional, Sanskritic, and Western—coexisting in Indian literature as a storehouse of raw material available to modern poets (see the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2). The success of a poet was partly contingent on his/her ability to combine these resources effectively through an individual poetic voice:

Poetic, not necessarily scholarly, assimilation of all these three resources [regional, Sanskritic and Western] in various individual ways seems indispensable. Neither Tagore in Bengali, nor Vallathol in Malayalam, neither Bendre in Kannada nor Bharati in Tamil ..., and among a younger generation neither Buddhadeba Bose in Bengali nor Adiga in Kannada, would be what they are without a strong presence of all three. The malaise and feebleness of some modern Indian poetry (in English as well as in our

mother-tongues) is traceable, I believe, to the weak presence or total disconnection with one or another of these three resources. The strong presence of the three is certainly not sufficient, but it is necessary.¹⁸⁷

As a translator-editor of many fellow Indian poets, AKR contributed to making Indian regional writers available to a wider readership.¹⁸⁸ Among the poets that merited his attention were some distant, and **(p.327)** not-so-distant, predecessors who had, at one point or another, been models in his poetic career. One of the poets of the older generation whose work AKR translated and had a high regard for was Subramania Bharati. In the only monographic paper on a contemporary Indian writer 'On Bharati and His Prose Poems' (see also the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2), drafted in 1986 and published posthumously, AKR underscores Bharati's creative use of traditions, which build on the nexus of continuity in Indian poetry and made a creative impact on the course of Tamil literature:

When they [the three traditions] meet in a poet of genius, the poetry is dynamic, changing from phase to phase; the tensions among the three produce not only some of our best poetry, but change the history of prose and poetry in the poet's native tongue, as Bharati's did. The dialectic creates new problems and new solutions—like Bharati's prose poems. Bharati, at his best, renews the traditions he uses. Make the Vedas new, he had said once.

... Bharati here uses contemporary Tamil to reach back into the past of the Vedas and forward into a future in modern Tamil poetry—he draws the bow back only to launch the arrow forward.¹⁸⁹

As examples of the use Indian poets made of traditional material in a modern context, AKR also cites the adaptation of regional folktales and stories in the poetry of the Kannadiga writer Chandrasekhar Kambar and the poet Shankara Kurup, whose 'Master Carpenter' he helped translate from Malayalam to English.¹⁹⁰

Contemporary Kannada Poetry

In 1979, AKR wrote a draft for an introduction to an anthology of twentieth-century Kannada poetry in English translation, which he had planned to publish. In this short synopsis of modern Kannada poetry, he highlights the evolution of the *navya* period:¹⁹¹

The second period, often labelled *navya* or the New Poetry began as a kind of 'modernist' revolt against the 'romanticism,' the 'milk-and-Tennyson' (or so it seemed) of the earlier generation. Eliot and his tenets, techniques, biases and models ... entered Kannada. As with the earlier generation, the writers were mostly teachers of English who had turned to Kannada, or teachers of Kannada who had turned to English.... V.K. Gokak of the earlier

generation, and the younger Gopalakrishna Adiga were the rival pioneers of the New. But Adiga's extraordinary intensity, boldness and range won out as the major **(p.328)** voice of the period. Cliques, critics, and controversies rallied and raged around him, and still do.... Since the sixties, though there has been no major poet (in my opinion), a number of good poets followed out Adiga's examples, yet grew away from him: they wrote in colloquial Kannada, but in tones less resonant, less rhetorical, more ironic, about things less momentous than the 'earth' or the entire Civilisation as Adiga tended to. Of these many, Lankesh and K.S. Narasimhaswamy are notable.... Chandrasekhar Kambar (like Bendre in the first generation of modern writers) is special in his use of folklore and folk poetry....¹⁹²

Among the latter group of prominent Kannada poets who introduced a colloquial, ironic style in the 1960s, critics have also included AKR. As stated by Kannada scholars D.R. Nagaraj and H.S. Shivaprakash, the groundbreaking Gopalakrishna Adiga was one of the first Kannada poets to have absorbed, into his style, some of the techniques of modern European literature, notably of Eliot. While Shivaprakash gives credit to the earlier Yarmunje Ramachandra and Pejavaras Sadashiva Rao as pioneers of the modernist idiom in Kannada poetry that was later perfected by Adiga, Nagaraj cites the latter along with the short-story writer and poet Ramachandra Sharma as the first exponents of the *navya* or modernist mode of Kannada writing. The earlier *navodaya* or 'Romantic' phase (prevalent from 1920 to 1945) and the *Pragatsheela* phase of the Progressive Writers (at their peak from 1945 to 1950) were supplanted by the *navya* phase of the 'new' poets in the post-Independence years. In the early 1950s, Adiga is said to have abandoned the *navodaya* or Romantic poetic style in which he had been immersed, whereas Sharma turned to *navya* from being a progressive (socialist) writer. In Nagaraj's view, these two poets represent the conservative and progressive strains that are found in the *navya* movement. Among the other *navya* writers who Nagaraj considers to have shaped the 'Modern Movement' in Kannada literature, he mentions AKR as a poet and fiction writer.¹⁹³ Shivaprakash, in turn, considers AKR as 'an interesting exception' rather than a major voice in Kannada poetry, and as a poet who 'stopped engaging intensely with the living Kannada milieu and idiom' after leaving the country.¹⁹⁴

We now know for a fact that AKR's reaction to both the Romantic and progressive Kannada poets began very early. In his 1949 journal, where AKR narrates, at the age of 20, how the fountain at Harding Circle in Mysore stirred his imagination, the two types of Kannada poetry prevalent at the time are dismissed as 'the grey phases **(p.329)** about lotus-eyes or the communist freaks about the strikes and the headlines.... [T]hese dull poets who are old at thirty, write clumsy slogans of love or war' (see the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4).¹⁹⁵ It must be noted

that AKR is often viewed as a special case within the navya movement, one that cannot be easily traced to either of the earlier movements nor classified within a particular group. According to late Kannada writer and critic U.R. Ananthamurthy, AKR was close to Adiga and they often used to discuss poetry in cafés with other contemporary poets in the mid-1950s. As the author of *Samskara* (see the section 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3) observed, Adiga was the leader of the 'new style', but AKR brought into modern Kannada poetry a different kind of 'revolution':

Whereas Adiga had a lot of rhetoric and became a major poet, Raman was not a major voice, but he released us from the influence of Adiga. He brought a 'low' voice of understatement and subtlety which was closer to prose, more imagistic. His short haiku-like poems took away embellishment, but they were closer to a real response. Still writers imitate him.¹⁹⁶

Contemporary Indian Poetry in English

The origins of the 'new' or 'modern' poetry in English in India are usually traced to the 1950s and to two main figures: Nissim Ezekiel in Bombay and P. Lal in Calcutta. The two poetry circles led by Ezekiel and Lal can loosely be said to represent two main streams within early modern IPE, in terms of poetics, critical attitude, and publishing efforts. They were initially not identifiable as separate groups in the 1950s, but at the end of the 1960s their paths diverged considerably. The role of Ezekiel and Lal as poet-critics and editors cannot be over-emphasized, and their contribution to IPE both as creative writers and commentators is essential to understand the poetic scene of IPE in the decades after Independence, particularly in relation to the shaping of poetic trends, the formation of a canon, and the dialectics between tradition and modernism in IPE criticism (see the section 'Overview of Critical Approaches' in Chapter 1).¹⁹⁷

AKR was associated with Ezekiel, Gieve Patel, and the other poets of the Bombay group since the mid-1950s. He was always accepted as an important poet of the New Poetry in India and appeared in most anthologies of IPE. There are several factors that may explain why AKR (p.330) was never purged out of the canon of modern IPE poets. He never abandoned his Indian citizenship and was deeply involved with India, in his professional capacity as a professor of Dravidian languages in Chicago, and in his frequent visits to India, which allowed him to keep in touch with Bombay poets like Gieve Patel, K.N. Daruwalla, A.K. Mehrotra, and Adil Jussawalla. Though he regularly interacted with these poets, whom he constantly encouraged to collaborate in translation projects, AKR was most of the time engaged in his academic and translational work in the USA and did not participate in the IPE scene as an editor or critic. In contrast, some of his fellow poet-friends (Ezekiel, Daruwalla, Mehrotra, and Jussawalla) played an important role as editors of IPE anthologies and published critical articles on the subject. In his rare writings and publishing projects on contemporary Indian

literature, AKR preferred to see poetry written in English not as an isolated body of work, but as part of the larger canvas of Indian literature.¹⁹⁸ He was, as a matter of fact, quite disapproving of the early criticism that was published on IPE in the 1960s.

I am not a critic. Contemporary Indian poetry in English has come in for a lot of fruitless attack and defence: it needs neither. What it needs is a good critic—it has now only log-rolling cliques, patrons, and enemies. And academics. Indian writing in English is one of several bodies of live writing in India—though it gets more attention than it deserves at present, chiefly because it's the only Indian writing that most foreigners can read at first-hand.¹⁹⁹

Although he did not consider himself a critic, he had formed a very coherent critical opinion about IPE poets, which was in tune with his own identity search as a modern Indian poet writing in English. In conversations, he often criticized their ineptitude to forge a tradition of their own, be it individually or as a collective group:

By and large, Indian poets in English have not given evidence of a body of work which you may enter and be in. There are several single, isolated, often good, poems, but they rarely reach a sense of significance within a world of their own. Perhaps this is the result of writing poetry in isolation from the literary, folk and religious traditions.²⁰⁰

AKR regarded Ezekiel among the few poets in English who had managed to develop a recognized body of work.²⁰¹ 'Nissim Ezekiel is certainly of a distinguished class. He keeps getting invited to international poetry events and earns excellent reviews. Arun Kolatkar **(p.331)** and Keki Daruwalla have won prestigious Commonwealth Prizes.'²⁰² By and large, however, AKR had more respect for Indian authors who had mastered poetry in their regional languages, and had moulded a personal voice and depth of thought that was hard to match by English-language writers in India:

If you take the higher ranges, i.e. the better writers, I think the language writers have greater density, greater range. There is nobody like Tagore or Bose or Karanth or Masti or Adiga or La Sa Ra or Karnad writing in English; either in intensity, output, variety, creative use of our past and present, or power of influence. But on the other hand, if you look at the middle standard—a kind of general competence in writing—I think there are proportionately more competent second-rate writers in English than in the languages.²⁰³

In the late 1960s, AKR kept up a regular correspondence with Ezekiel from Chicago.²⁰⁴ The letters dealt mainly with editorial work and publishing, as AKR had been providing Ezekiel with translation material, as well as critical advice,

for the short-lived journal *Poetry India* edited by the Bombay-based poet from 1966 to 1967. He had by then accrued invaluable experience in translating traditional and contemporary Indian poetries into English, which had given him confidence as an Indian poet writing about India in a distant land. Therefore, in his letters to Ezekiel, he encouraged his fellow poets to engage in translation work of Indian regional poetry as a means to overcome their 'isolation' from Indian traditions:

April 10, 1968

... The Indian-English verse has been the most unsatisfactory. Couldn't we get our poets in English to work on a few translations of the poets or writers in the languages? They all write English so well though they do not write poetry so well in English. It might improve their poetry in English to experience the problems of translating both faithfully and imaginatively something from one of the languages. I know for myself I have learnt a great deal from translating and have experienced some really great poems intimately.²⁰⁵

May 28, 1968

... I am disappointed that Indian poets writing in English like Partha are not devoting part of their time and talent to translating, especially as they can easily acquire the necessary knowledge in one of the Indian languages.²⁰⁶

AKR's efforts to persuade bilingual Indian poets writing in English to dip into their traditions and translate from the regional languages **(p.332)** into English was not in vain, for poets like Parthasarathy, Ezekiel, Mehrotra, Pritish Nandy, and others did publish translations after the 1970s. Some poets followed AKR's footsteps and became successful translators of classical and medieval bhakti poetry into English forging their 'individual talent' by engaging with tradition.²⁰⁷

Notes:

(1.) See, for instance, W.K. Wimsatt, *The Verbal Icon: Studies in the Meaning of Poetry* (Lexington: University of Kentucky Press, 1954).

(2.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', p. 38.

(3.) Ramanujan, lecture draft for a talk on Gieve Patel, quoted in Chapter 5.

(4.) See, for instance, Ramanujan, 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, pp. 206-7 and *PLW*, p. 247.

(5.) Kenneth Burke, *A Grammar of Motives* (New York: Prentice Hall, 1945).

(6.) Ramanujan, 'Sanskrit Poetics', p. 39.

- (7.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1980), n.p.
- (8.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.
- (9.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 148.
- (10.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 32.
- (11.) Ramanujan, 'Literature as Language', project proposal for a book on poetry and language, AKR Papers (1966), n.p. As sources for this book, he suggested essays by Hopkins, Coleridge, Eliot, Pound, Stevens, Williams, and Valéry, among the poets, by critics like Empson, Richards, Burke, Davie, and Leavis, and by linguists Firth, Thorne, McIntosh, Jakobson, Levin, and Hill.
- (12.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.
- (13.) See also Vinay Dharwadker (ed.), 'General Editor's Preface', in *The Collected Essays of A.K. Ramanujan* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1995), p. ix.
- (14.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 7.
- (15.) Norman Cutler, personal interview, Chicago (March 2001).
- (16.) Ferdinand de Saussure, *Course in General Linguistics* (New York: McGraw-Hill, 1959 [1915]); and Roman Jakobson, 'Closing Statement: Linguistics and Poetics', in Thomas A. Sebeok (ed.), *Style in Language* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1960). Sebeok, one of the pioneers in the field of semiotics, was already a reputed professor of linguistics at Indiana University Bloomington when AKR studied there. See also Preminger and Brogan (eds), *The New Princeton Encyclopaedia of Poetry and Poetics*, p. 1227. Another landmark work of this period in the field of stylistics was Samuel R. Levin's *Linguistic Structures in Poetry* (The Hague: Mouton, 1962). Levin is cited in AKR's project draft for the proposed book on 'Literature as Language'.
- (17.) Saussure and Jakobson are cited in several parts of this paper. Among the few published critical works that are referred to in this text is Victor Erlich's *Russian Formalism: History-Doctrine* (The Hague: Mouton, 1955).
- (18.) Ramanujan, 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry', n.p.
- (19.) Ramanujan, 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry', n.p.
- (20.) At the time of drafting this paper, AKR had not yet taken up the study of Dravidian literature as an academic field.
- (21.) AKR paraphrases here Walter Pater's statement that 'poetry aspires to the condition of music'.
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- (22.) Ramanujan, 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry', n.p.
- (23.) AKR again cites Walter Pater's famous quote on the purpose of art as aesthetic form.
- (24.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Style', AKR Papers (late 1960s), n.p.
- (25.) See, for instance, Ramanujan, 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', in *CE*, pp. 52-3.
- (26.) See also the sections on Sanskrit and Tamil poetics ahead in this chapter. For further comments on form in Tamil literature, see 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, p. 218.
- (27.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Form', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.
- (28.) AKR's PhD dissertation, 'A Generative Grammar of Kannada', is based on Chomsky's generative linguistics, but he soon became aware of the shortcomings of Chomsky's early model for the study of poetry and in the field of literary and cultural studies in general. See, for instance, the notes in *CE*, p. 579.
- (29.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', p. 116.
- (30.) Jakobson's essay, 'Grammatical Parallelism', is quoted in Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 42. Roman Jakobson, 'Grammatical Parallelism and Its Russian Facet', *Language*, vol. 42, no. 2 (1966), pp. 399-420.
- (31.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 38.
- (32.) Ramanujan, 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle', in *CE*, p. 311.
- (33.) Roman Jakobson, *Language in Literature*, eds Krystina Pomorska and Stephen Rudy (Cambridge: The Belknap Press, 1987), pp. 95-114.
- (34.) See also Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. 246-7.
- (35.) Ramanujan, 'Language and Social Change', in *CE*, p. 97. The diagram that AKR reproduces is from Jakobson, 'Closing Statement', p. 353.
- (36.) The Jakobson diagram is mentioned, for instance, in AKR's studies of communication process in riddles and folktales. See Ramanujan, 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, p. 488.
- (37.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1977-80), n.p.
- (38.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes on 'Linguistics and Poetics', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.

(39.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes on 'Linguistics and Poetics', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p. The quote is by the Austrian writer Karl Kraus (1874–1936). See also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6. The phrase on poets being 'specialists' has also been quoted earlier in the same section in Chapter 6 and in the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5.

(40.) See, for instance, Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' 'Food for Thought', 'Three Hundred Ramayanas', and 'On Folk Mythologies and Folk Puranas', in *CE*, pp. 44, 74, 156, 515.

(41.) Ramanujan, 'Food For Thought', in *CE*, p. 74. AKR quotes here from Charles Sanders Peirce, *Collected Papers*, vol. 2 (Harvard University Press, 1931–5).

(42.) See Roland Barthes, *Elements of Semiology* (with *Writing Degree Zero*), trans A. Lavers and C. Smith (London: Cape, 1967).

(43.) See, for instance, Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 160, *PLW*, p. 280, and 'From Classicism to *Bhakti*', in *CE*, pp. 252–3.

(44.) Ramanujan, 'From Classicism to *Bhakti*', in *CE*, pp. 251–2. Barthes is also cited in Ramanujan, 'Telling Tales', in *CE*, p. 462.

(45.) The reference is to Barthes, *Elements of Semiology*, p. 68.

(46.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. 280–1. The phrase 'language of the tribe' is by the French poet Mallarmé. See also, in this context, AKR's comments in a 1993 interview: 'I'm fond of saying that the signifiers don't change in India but the signified goes on changing'. Ramanujan quoted in Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', p. 12.

(47.) Julia Kristeva, 'Word, Dialogue, and Novel', *Desire and Language: A Semiotic Approach to Literature and Art*, trans T. Gora, A. Jardine, and L.S. Roudiez (New York: Columbia, 1980), p. 66.

(48.) Ramanujan, 'On Folk Mythologies and Folk Puranas', in *CE*, p. 517. The quote is from Roland Barthes, 'Theory of the Text', *Untying the Text: A Post-Structuralist Reader*, ed. Robert Young (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1981).

(49.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 18.

(50.) Ramanujan, *FI*, p. xviii.

(51.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 282.

(52.) For instance, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', and 'Food for Thought' among the anthological essays quoted earlier.

(53.) Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, p. 73. The reference in brackets is to Umberto Eco, *A Theory of Semiotics* (Bloomington: Indian University Press, 1976).

(54.) Ramanujan, 'Elements of Composition', 'Connect!' in *CP*, pp. 121–3, 178. The first two lines of 'Connect!' allude to E.M. Forster's *Passage to India*. AKR analysed Forster's novel thus: '[T]he complexity of non-communication is the theme, the obsession. "Connect, only connect!" cries Forster, but Mrs Moore who connects and becomes one with India, is lost to the world, misunderstood, becomes an echo and a legend'. See Ramanujan, 'Parables and Commonplaces', in Amirthanayagam (ed.), *Writers in East-West Encounter*, p. 146.

(55.) Though this essay first came out in French in 1968, it was only published in the USA in 1977. Roland Barthes, 'The Death of the Author', *Image, Music, Text*, ed. and trans. Stephen Heath (New York: Hill, 1977), pp. 142, 146–7.

(56.) Ramanujan, 'Drafts', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, pp. 157–8.

(57.) Jaques Derrida, *Writing and Difference*, trans. Alan Bass (London: Routledge, 1978), p. 25.

(58.) Preminger and Brogan (eds), *The New Princeton Encyclopaedia of Poetry and Poetics*, p. 936.

(59.) Richard Rorty, 'Deconstructionist Theory', *The Cambridge History of Literary Criticism*, vol. 8, *From Formalism to Poststructuralism* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1995), n.p.

(60.) See, for instance, Edward C. Dimock and Wendy Doniger in *CE*, pp. xvii, 4.

(61.) Unlike Barthes, who is quoted repeatedly in AKR's essays, I have brought Derrida into play here to draw attention to apparent connections between the ideas exposed by AKR in his late prose and poetry, and the theories of the architect of deconstruction.

(62.) An entire monograph with contributions by eminent scholars was published, for instance, in 2004, relating Derrida to Indian philosophical traditions. An elucidating article in this collection titled 'Derrida's Indian Literary Subtext' by William S. Heany II states:

Derridean deconstruction ... has antecedents in Indian literary theory or Sanskrit poetics.... The theory and practice of deconstruction, including the notions of difference, trace, supplementarity, play, iterability, phonocentrism, and presence, not only share attributes with but can also be shown to follow indirectly from an earlier, Eastern philosophical tradition largely unacknowledged in the work of Western writers.... [I]n critiquing his German predecessors, Derrida, especially in his earlier work,

may also be borrowing from and re-contextualizing elements of Indian philosophy widely disseminated in the west since the late 19th century.... [D]econstructive notion of iterability, or the contextual nature of all knowledge, is not a Western invention but has roots in Indian thought....

William S. Heany II, 'Derrida's Indian Literary Subtext', *Jacques Derrida's Indian Philosophical Subtext*, Special Issue of *Consciousness, Literature and the Arts*, vol. 5, no. 2 (2004), ed. Dimple Godiwala and William S. Heany II, available at <http://www.aber.ac.uk/tfts/journal/archive/haneyderrida.html> (accessed 15 February 2014).

(63.) Ramanujan, journal on 'Composition', AKR Papers (25 July 1982), n.p.

(64.) Claire Jacobson, 'Translator's Preface', in Claude Lévi-Strauss, *Structural Anthropology*, vol. 1, trans Claire Jacobson and B.G. Schoepf (New York: Basic Books, 1963; and London: Allen Lane, 1968), p. x. First publication in France in 1958.

(65.) See Ramanujan in *CE*, pp. 5, 44, 163, 372, 440, 516, 556, 579, 580, 587.

(66.) Ramanujan, 'Hanchi', in *CE*, p. 372 and notes in *CE*, p. 579.

(67.) Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?' in *CE*, p. 44.

(68.) Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, pp. 73-4.

(69.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1977-80), n.p.

(70.) Ramanujan quoted in Banerjee, 'A Seasoned Poet Speaks', p. 4.

(71.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 8. See also the longer quote in the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2.

(72.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Literatures', AKR Papers (May 1985), n.p.

(73.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', p. 115. There are instances in other texts where AKR has made use of these concepts to offer his own definitions of poetry.

(74.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', p. 115.

(75.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', p. 116.

(76.) Ramanujan, 'Sanskrit Aesthetics', handwritten lecture paper, AKR Papers (1964), n.p.; also titled 'Sanskrit Poetics'. On Kenneth Burke, see also the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in this chapter.

(77.) Ramanujan, 'Sanskrit Poetics', n.p.

(78.) AKR acknowledges the PhD work of Edwin Gerow on alamkara poetics as the main source for this unpublished paper. In the co-edited essay on 'Indian Poetics' published years later, the section on alamkara is signed by Gerow.

(79.) Ramanujan, 'Sanskrit Poetics', n.p. A note in brackets at this place of the handwritten essay drafts reads '(Prague: violation?)'.

(80.) Ramanujan, 'Sanskrit Poetics', n.p.

(81.) Ramanujan, 'Parables and Commonplaces', p. 140.

(82.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Poetics', AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.

(83.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', p. 130.

(84.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', in *UPP*, pp. 61-2. Some phases of this paragraph have been quoted in the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3.

(85.) Among the early publications are the following poems with their original titles and credits added by AKR: Ramanujan, 'Of Corruption (after Allama Prabhu)', *Quest*, vol. 3 (August 1957), p. 22; 'Her Love (after Akkamahadevi)', *The Illustrated Weekly of India* (18 May 1958); 'I, Thy Target (Allama Prabhu, 12th Century)', 'Of Illusion (Basavanna, 12th Century)', 'Of Courtesy (after a Kannada Mystic)', and 'Three Poems Translated from the Kannada by A.K. Ramanujan', *The Illustrated Weekly* (2 February 1958).

(86.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 46.

(87.) Saguna poets, on the other hand, worshipped a god of personified attributes and forms. See Ramanujan, 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle', in *CE*, pp. 320-3. See also the section 'Aesthetic Traditions: A Brief Overview' in Chapter 2.

(88.) Ramanujan, 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle', in *CE*, p. 310.

(89.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 49.

(90.) Ramanujan, 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle', in *CE*, pp. 321-3.

(91.) Ramanujan, 'Anxiety', in *CP*, p. 29, and vachana 972 by Allama Prabhu in *SoS*, p. 168.

(92.) Ramanujan, 'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle', in *CE*, p. 309.

(93.) Ramanujan, *SoS*, p. 35.

- (94.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 126. As an example of this word play AKR analyses, in detail, the poem 'The Paradigm', in *HD*, pp. 122-6.
- (95.) Ramanujan, trans. 'The Takeover', from Nammalvar's *Tiruvaymoli*, 10.7.1, *HD*, p. 76. See also the first two lines quoted in the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.
- (96.) Manikkavacakar, a ninth-century Saiva saint, is cited and translated in the afterword to *HD*. Ramanujan, *HD*, pp. 118-19.
- (97.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 140.
- (98.) Ramanujan quoted in Venkatesh, 'A Poet and His Perceptions', n.p. On AKR's 'Soma Poems', see also the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 and Appendix 2 in this book.
- (99.) Ramanujan quoted in Venkatesh, 'A Poet and His Perceptions', n.p.
- (100.) Ramanujan quoted in Venkatesh, 'A Poet and His Perceptions', n.p.
- (101.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 153. See also *HD*, p. 164.
- (102.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *HD*, p. ix.
- (103.) Ramanujan quoted in Kalven, 'Found in the Translation', p. 36.
- (104.) See the reference to Roland Barthes in Ramanujan, 'On Folk Mythologies and Folk Puranas', in *CE*, p. 517.
- (105.) Ramanujan, 'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore', in *CE*, pp. 508-9. See also the earlier quote in the section 'Folk Aesthetics' in Chapter 5.
- (106.) Ramanujan, *FI*, p. xxxii.
- (107.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1977), n.p.
- (108.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1980), n.p.
- (109.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (c. 1977), n.p.
- (110.) Ramanujan, *FI*, pp. xi, xxx-xxxi.
- (111.) Ramanujan quoted in Banerjee, 'A Seasoned Poet Speaks', p. 4.
- (112.) Ramanujan, 'A Minor Sacrifice', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, pp. 144-8.
- (113.) Ramanujan, 'Which Reminds Me', *The Striders*, in *CP*, p. 25.

(114.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13. The last few lines of this quote contain phrases that have also been quoted in 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.

(115.) Ramanujan, 'The Relevance of Tamil Classical Poetry', n.p.

(116.) Ramanujan, 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, p. 210. Though AKR does not mention it here, it was Valéry who defined poetry as 'a language within a language'. On Valéry in this context see also the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2.

(117.) Ramanujan, 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', in *CE*, p. 72.

(118.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 67.

(119.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 33.

(120.) Ramanujan, *IL*, p. 103.

(121.) I am not using, here, the Tamil words for the types of landscapes and elements since those have already been introduced in the section 'Tamil Aesthetics' in Chapter 5. See also Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. 236–46.

(122.) Ramanujan, 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, pp. 203–4.

(123.) Ramanujan, 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', in *CE*, p. 72.

(124.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, pp. 45–6.

(125.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. 239, 314. AKR refers to T.S. Eliot, *Selected Essays* (New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1950).

(126.) *Tolkappiyam* quoted in Ramanujan, *IL*, p. 114.

(127.) Ramanujan, *IL*, p. 114.

(128.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 241.

(129.) See Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 244.

(130.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 303. The expression is from Claude Lévi-Strauss, 'The Science of the Concrete', *The Savage Mind* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1966).

(131.) See Ramanujan, *IL*, p. 109.

(132.) Ramanujan quoted in Venkatesh, 'A Poet and His Perception', n.p.

- (133.) This is the earliest published interview. Nakulan is the pen name of T.K. Doraiswamy.
- (134.) Nakulan, 'A Meeting with A.K. Ramanujan', pp. 11–13. AKR described Nakulan here as an English teacher 'bred on English Romanticism'.
- (135.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 244.
- (136.) *Tevakulattar Kuruntokai*, 3, trans. Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 244.
- (137.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. 246–7. AKR follows Jakobson's use of the terms 'metonymy' and 'metaphor', as can be inferred from the notes to this essay.
- (138.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.
- (139.) See, for example, 'What the Passerby Said to the Lover Eloping with the Girl' or 'What Her Girl Friend Said to Her Lover on His Return', trans. Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. 66, 83.
- (140.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 232.
- (141.) Ramanujan, 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, pp. 208–9.
- (142.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 236. See, for instance, AKR's love poems in *Relations* and also the series in the posthumous *The Black Hen*, which even imitate the title and structure of the Akam poems.
- (143.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 47.
- (144.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. 265–6. See examples of this in the Tamil poems quoted on the same pages.
- (145.) Ramanujan, *IL*, p. 114.
- (146.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes, AKR Papers (late 1970s), n.p.
- (147.) W.G. Eagleton, letter of recommendation, Maharaja's College, University of Mysore, AKR Papers (7 June 1949), n.p.
- (148.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman' (1955), 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry in English' (1983), and 'On Bharati and His Prose Poems' (1999). The essay 'Classics Lost and Found' (1989) and the unpublished lecture 'On the "Unity" and "Diversity" of Indian Literature' (1986) also deal, to some extent, with contemporary literature. See Appendix 1.
- (149.) César Vallejo is alluded to in the poems 'Saturdays' and 'Looking and Finding', *Second Sight*, in *CP*, pp. 150, 179.

(150.) Ramanujan, 'A.K. Ramanujan Writes ...', *Poetry Book Society Bulletin* (London: 1966), n.p. The proverb on the orange tree is cited in several other AKR sources and inspired the poem 'A Poem on Particulars' in *The Striders*. See also the sections 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3 and 'Biographical Factors and Poetic Creation' in Chapter 6.

(151.) Ramanujan, notes to the poem 'Towards a Poem with Footnotes', unpublished draft, Bennington, AKR Papers (1960), n.p.

(152.) I am indebted to one of the reviewers of the manuscript of my PhD dissertation 'The Aesthetic and Poetic Thought of A.K. Ramanujan', which I had intended to publish in 2007, for drawing my attention to some of these many parallelisms that exist between the English Romantics and AKR's poetics.

(153.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', p. 38.

(154.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', p. 39.

(155.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', p. 45.

(156.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', pp. 50–3.

(157.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes on Walt Whitman, AKR Papers (mid-1950s), n.p. For more details on Whitman in AKR's 'inner' poetics, see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.

(158.) Ramanujan, 'Parables and Commonplaces', p. 143.

(159.) In the published essays Yeats is cited, for instance, in 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', and 'Varieties of Bhakti', in *CE*, pp. 9, 71, 330.

(160.) Ramanujan quoted in Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', p. 12. This Yeatsian quote is cited in several other primary sources.

(161.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors are Windows', in *CE*, p. 9. See W.B. Yeats, 'The Statues', *The Collected Poems* (London: Macmillan, 1950). On sage and poet see, for example, Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 165.

(162.) W.B. Yeats, 'Per Amica Silentia Lunae', *Mythologies* (New York: Macmillan, 1959).

(163.) Ramanujan, diary notecards, AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.

(164.) See W.B. Yeats, 'Anima Hominis', part VII, *Mythologies*.

(165.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (28 August 1982), n.p. The verse lines quoted by AKR are from W.B. Yeats, 'Ego Dominus Tuus', *The Wild Swans at Coole* (New York: Macmillan, 1919).

(166.) Ramanujan uses this quote by Yeats, for instance, in the unpublished paper 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry'. The full quote by Yeats is as follows: 'I must leave my sights and images to explain themselves as the years go by, and one poem lights up another'. See Yeats, 'Preface' to *Poems*, quoted in T.R. Henn, *The Lonely Tower: Studies in the Poetry of W.B. Yeats* (London: Methuen 1965 [1899]), p. 126. This phrase is also used by AKR in other sources.

(167.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar, n.p.

(168.) Ramanujan, 'Some Thoughts on "Non-Western" Classics', in *CE*, p. 116.

(169.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 67. See Keith Taylor's comment in this interview on the reference to Pound in AKR's poem 'Conventions of Despair'. See also the phrase 'drowns eye-/deep/into its tiny strip/of sky' in 'The Striders' borrowed from 'walked eye-deep in hell' in Pound's 'Hugh Selwyn Mauberly', commented on in the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 and 'Translation and Poetic Practice' of Chapter 8.

(170.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 October 1976), n.p.

(171.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.

(172.) For example, Nissim Ezekiel, who wrote in English; Gopalakrishna Adiga and Ramachandra Sharma, in Kannada; T.K. Doraiswamy in Tamil; and Ayyappa Paniker in Malayalam were all professors of English.

(173.) See Ramanujan, 'Murder in the Cathedral and Aristotle's Theory of Tragedy', unpublished paper, AKR Papers (n.d.), n.p.

(174.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 8.

(175.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (10 November 1981), n.p.

(176.) See also Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 284.

(177.) See the section 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition' in this chapter, and the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8, and Appendix 2. See also Dharwadker, 'Introduction', in *CP*, p. xxxvii.

(178.) T.S. Eliot, from 'Little Gidding', *Four Quartets* (New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1943). Quoted in AKR, unpublished notes, AKR Papers (early 1980s), n.p.

(179.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (10 November 1981), n.p. The full quote appears earlier in the chapter.

(180.) William Carlos Williams, 'The Red Wheelbarrow', *The Collected Poems 1: 1909–1939*, eds A. Walton Litz and Christopher MacGowan (New York: New Directions, 1986 [1923]).

(181.) Ezra Pound, 'A Few Dont's by an Imagiste', *Imagist Poetry*, ed. Peter Jones (Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, 1972 [1913]), p. 130. First published in *Poetry* 1 (Chicago, 1 March 1913).

(182.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 149 and in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 77. See also AKR's comments on *The Striders* in *Poetry Book Society Bulletin* quoted earlier in this section.

(183.) Ramanujan, 'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry', in *CE*, p. 211. The reference is to Marianne Moore, 'Poetry', *Collected Poems* (New York: MacMillan, 1961), p. 50.

(184.) V.M. Cherian, 'Introducing a Linguist', *Span* (August 1970), p. 15.

(185.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (early 1980s), n.p.

(186.) Ramanujan, 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry', p. 53.

(187.) Ramanujan, 'On Bharati and His Prose Poems', pp. 333–4.

(188.) See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for publications of contemporary Indian poetry translated by AKR.

(189.) Ramanujan, 'On Bharati and His Prose Poems', pp. 334, 343.

(190.) See Ramanujan, 'The Indian Oedipus', in *CE*, p. 396. For a first English version of Kurup's poem, which was later anthologized in *The Oxford Anthology of Modern Indian Poetry* (1994), see G. Sankara Kurup, 'The Old Carpenter' (also as 'The Master Carpenter'), trans K.M. George and A.K. Ramanujan, *The Beloit Poetry Journal*, vol. 16, no. 4 (Summer 1966), pp. 28–35.

(191.) See D.R. Nagaraj, 'A Note on Modern Kannada Poetry', in U.R. Ananthamurthy, Ramachandra Sarma, and D.R. Nagaraj, *Modernism in Indian Writing* (Bangalore: Panther Publishers, 1992), pp. 107–14; H.S. Shivaprakash, 'Modernism and After: Some Reflections on Contemporary Kannada Poetry', *Indian Literature*, no. 158 (November–December 1993), n.p. On the different trends in Kannada poetry, see also Cheenaveera Kannavi and K. Raghavendra Rao (eds), *Modern Kannada Poetry* (Dharwar: Karnatak University, 1976); Dharwadker, 'Modern Indian Poetry and Its Contexts', in Ramanujan and Dharwadker (eds), *The Oxford Anthology of Modern Indian Poetry*, pp. 185–206;

K.D. Kurtkodis, 'Tradition and Modernity: Modern Kannada Poetry', in K. Satchidanandan (ed.), *Indian Poetry: Modernism and After* (New Delhi: Sahitya Akademi, 2001), pp. 15-23; and R. Shashidar, 'The Politics of Modernism: Modernist Poetry in Kannada', in Satchidanandan (ed.), *Indian Poetry*, pp. 24-36.

(192.) Ramanujan, 'Translator's Note', unpublished rough draft of an introduction to a planned anthology of contemporary Kannada poetry, AKR Papers (1979), n.p.

(193.) AKR wrote poetry, fiction, and plays in Kannada. See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for his Kannada publications.

(194.) Personal interview (April 2015). See also Shivaprakash, 'Modernism and After'.

(195.) Ramanujan, 'A Poem Is Born', p. 1.

(196.) Ananthamurthy, personal interview, Bangalore (19 January 2002). The writer meant 'low' voice in a literal and metaphorical sense, for AKR was known for his low, soft voice which would sometimes squeak when he was upset or excited. See also Girish Karnad's description of AKR as a young poet and friend in Nerlekar, 'Adarallu Idu', pp. 217-27. See also the biographical Chart 1.

(197.) There were also other minor poetry groups and publishing centres in Delhi (Keshav Malik), Allahabad (A.K. Mehrotra), and later Orissa (Jayanta Mahapatra). I have scrutinized the developments of IPE and its criticism in my monographic dissertation titled 'Post-Independence Indian Poetry in English: The Critical Scene from the 1950s to the Present' (Spain: University of Valladolid, 2000). See also King, *Modern Indian Poetry in English*.

(198.) See 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry' (1983) and the posthumous anthology *The Oxford Anthology of Modern Indian Poetry* (1994).

(199.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 50.

(200.) Ramanujan quoted in Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan', p. 182.

(201.) Nissim Ezekiel (1924-2004) is considered (along with P. Lal) the patriarch of 'modern' Indian poets in English and one of the main exponents of IPE from the 1950s till the 1980s. His first collection of poems, quite appropriately titled *A Time to Change*, was published in 1952. He brought out two more collections in the 1950s: *Sixty Poems* (1953) and *The Third* (1959). Nissim Ezekiel, *A Time to Change* (London: Fortune Press, 1952), *Sixty Poems* (Bombay, 1953), and *The Third* (Bombay: Strand Bookshop, 1959).

(202.) Ramanujan quoted in Monteiro, *Midday*, p. 8.

(203.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 51.

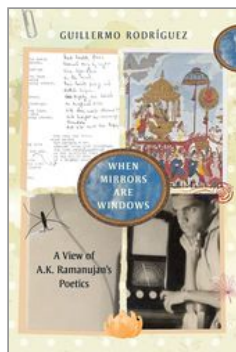
(204.) A good part of this correspondence is now with the AKR Papers at the University of Chicago.

(205.) Ramanujan, letter to Nissim Ezekiel, AKR Papers (10 April 1968), n.p. On discussing material for the poetry magazine *Poetry India* edited by Ezekiel.

(206.) Partha is short for R. Parthasarathy. Ramanujan, letter to Nissim Ezekiel, AKR Papers (28 May 1968), n.p.

(207.) See, for instance, R. Parthasarathy, *The Tale of an Anklet: An Epic of South India* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1993), which won the Sahitya Akademi Award for translation into English in 1995.

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Translating Tradition

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Abstract and Keywords

The last chapter deals with Ramanujan's concept of tradition as a scholar, as a modern Indian poet, and as a pioneering translator. It shows how Ramanujan was sensitive to the diverse Indian and Western models of literary history and tradition and how he made creative use of 'the past' in multiple ways. Therefore, his notion of tradition is assessed in its theoretical (scholarly and artistic) dimension and in its descriptive aspects, including the experimentation with traditional poetic forms and techniques. This leads to an analysis of Ramanujan's ideas on translation, which covers mainly theoretical aspects—such as the functions of translating and the role of the translator—rather than the technique of translating particular texts. It thus scrutinizes Ramanujan's view of translation in a wider sense of contexts, readers, cultures, and systems, and explores the links of translation to poetic creativity and translation as a metaphor in his life and work.

Keywords: literary tradition, literary historiography, translation studies, cultural translation, postcolonial theory, Indian literary criticism, translator-poet

Of what is past, or passing or to come.

—W.B. Yeats, 'Sailing to Byzantium'*

Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing

The argument about the use of tradition in contemporary Indian literary criticism and discourse gets entangled by the fact that the term 'tradition' has at least two essential connotations, which convey somewhat opposite meanings.

Tradition can be understood in the characteristic Indian sense derived from the

Sanskrit concept *parampara*, or in the conventional Western meaning. The former notion of tradition as *parampara* implies something that is very remote and ancient and which must be continued, whether ‘useful’ or not. Tradition, in this sense, is an uninterrupted chain of continuity. On the other hand, the Western concept of tradition (from the latin *tradere*, ‘to hand down’), which has imbued Indian scholarship to a large extent throughout the colonial period, conveys the idea that something is collected, ‘brought’ to us, and followed for posterity, and is contingent on the linear notion of time, that is, development and progression, evolved during the period of European Enlightenment. According to the literary historian and critic G.N. Devy, the impact of Western notions of tradition and culture on the modern Indian sensibility explains why in contemporary Indian literary criticism the meaning of tradition ‘wavers between conformity and change’.¹ The ambivalence of the term is further increased when the two main interrelated components of *parampara* in India, *marga* (mainstream pan-Indian) and *desi* (regional and local) are accommodated into the concept of tradition.

(p.344) Multiple Traditions and Languages

When AKR published his first book of poems *The Striders* in 1966, he already acknowledged that he belonged to a generation of post-Independence Indian writers that was nurtured and challenged by multiple pasts. Just as he identified three traditions (see the section ‘Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage’ in Chapter 2) when speaking about contemporary Indian poetry, that is, the ‘regional mother tongue’, the ‘pan-Indian’, and the ‘Western’, along with the influence of India’s ‘great men of letters’ (the contemporary Indian tradition), he also distinguished, early, the creative interaction of these strands in his own poetic oeuvre:

Like many other South Indians of my generation, I have several linguistic and literary traditions active in me: the Sanskritic, the poetry of the Dravidian languages (very different from the Sanskritic) I speak and translate from, and of course all that English has brought, as the ‘foster-mother tongue’ of our thinking life. The conflict and the dialogue, the estrangement and the mating, between these traditions within ourselves often make for a contrapuntal articulation—when, rarely, it does reach any articulation. I think some of these crossings (in the several senses of that word) may be seen in some of these poems.²

Since AKR was a creative writer in two languages and a translator in three, the interaction between the different traditions and languages was natural and inevitable, as he explained in a later interview:

I write in two traditions and I belong to at least three. By the accidents of my life I have studied and become part of the Tamil traditions. Then there is the Kannada tradition found in Karnataka province in south central

India, and then the English tradition which came to India in the 19th century, and which I studied in school and college. In English I write in a way which includes both Tamil and Kannada because I can't get rid of them. In Kannada, my English is always in some sense present.³

Hence, poetry was for AKR the site for an inclusive imagination of interacting traditions. Poetry, he maintained, specializes in the 'property of imagination, integration....'⁴ Through poetry he could incorporate, transform, or reflect diverse cultures and past and present literary environments in a contemporary context. This creative attitude of integration presented manifold possibilities that he explored to their fullest, and which resulted in a poetic interplay between the **(p.345)** multiple branches of his self. AKR's inclusiveness also explains in part the relevance of intertextuality in his work. A good number of his compositions are meta-poetic and make reference to other poems or poetic traditions either in form or in content (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and Chapter 7). As in the poem on the gypsy proverb of the uncountable trees in the orange (see the section 'Looking for the Other to Find Oneself' in Chapter 3), AKR insisted that all his environments, including languages, cultures, and academic disciplines, conjoin in his poetry:

You don't just write with a language, you write with all you have. When I write in Kannada, I'd like all my English, Tamil, etc. to be at the back of it; and when I write in English I hope my Tamil and my Kannada, like my linguistics and anthropology, what I know of America and India, are at the back of it. It's of course only a hope, not a claim. I'm less and less embarrassed or afraid of keeping all of these doors open even when it's dark outside and it's 3 a.m. inside.⁵

Another late interview echoes a similar holistic idea of poetry and explains the act of writing as a natural extension of one's entire learning: 'A poem comes out of everything one learns, not just a little part of you. So much of poetry is not self-conscious and the conscious and unconscious elements are very hard to de-segregate. I would say that this is true of a lot of our behaviour as well.'⁶ AKR's composite cultural and intellectual heritage and his unrelenting openness to miscellaneous areas of knowledge undoubtedly kept his scholarly mind as well as poetic creativity in constant motion. The starting point for this interaction and exchange of learning was always the language(s). He usually worked in various languages at the same time. In his poetry a particular language never spoke in isolation from the others, for he perceived his languages as coexisting chords:

In the three languages I know well, whichever one I am working in, the two other are present. I am not a *tabula rasa*. I always think about my languages as certain kinds of musical instruments. If you pluck one string there are other strings which resonate. Like the Indian sitar, there are strings which the musician never touches. They are resonating strings. It is

like that for all of us. Everything we know is resonating with what we talk about in the foreground.⁷

The language of a poem, be it Kannada or English, is, in subtle ways, expressive of a given culture. Its forms and images are shaped **(p.346)** and combined by the poet out of his personal history of past and present circumstances. So culture does not come as an abstract in a poem, but as a particular individual experience or preoccupation:

[C]ulture as a purely public, social creation is not what I am talking about. It is what I call a repertory, a repertoire of images, ideas or preoccupations, prejudices even, which are shared. But ultimately it has to come through me. Because I experience all this through the limits of whatever education I have, as well as whatever temperament, inheritance, whatever I have. So it is *that* which is really talking. Culture doesn't write poetry, I mean, you and I do, right?⁸

Since the perception of traditions and cultures is inextricably attached to the language(s), AKR's theory of translation stood out as a central topic in his commentaries on poetry and poetics. Translation was, for him, the mediating activity transacting between languages, texts, traditions, cultures, disciplines, and past and present. Within this amalgam of voices the practice of translation provided not just an instrument to negotiate between languages and traditions; it was also the mediator between the scholar and the poet, as AKR repeatedly stated:

I belong to three languages or traditions and they are always speaking to each other in various ways: translation makes this explicit. Another reason is that one way of intensifying my understanding of these literatures is to enter into that kind of creative give-and-take which is what translation is....⁹

... There is a sort of competition between writing one's own poetry and scholarly work. Translations require both the scholarly and poetic skills. It's a nice compromise.¹⁰

In other words, the idiosyncrasy of AKR's poetics lies in his unrelenting commitment to engage with tradition as a translator, involving simultaneously the scholar and poet. In AKR's discussion of tradition and translation, he illustrated how a poet should deploy all the linguistic and extra-linguistic resources available in poetry, and discover or invent new ones as he goes along, which provided a fertile ground for explorations between the 'inner' and 'outer' forms. His multi-angle perspective towards tradition and his intense translational activity bridged the poet and the scholar and also the Indian- and Western-educated writer. Without this text-and-context-sensitive **(p.347)** approach and (self-)reflexive engagement with tradition(s), his poetry would not

have had the resonance and universality it was able to achieve. Therefore, AKR's seminal contribution to contemporary Indian poetics is primarily found in his conceptualization of tradition and translation and in how these are put to use for poetic practice.

In his essays, interviews, and diaries, the concept of tradition is discussed by AKR in all its complexity in connection with other poets' understanding of tradition as well as from his point of view as a modern Indian poet. He is sensitive to the various Indian and Western models of literary tradition and distinguishes different treatments of tradition and the past. For a comprehensive study of his *use* of tradition as a poet in English, one would need to assess not only AKR's idea of tradition in its theoretical (scholarly and artistic) dimension, but also his integration of tradition in its descriptive aspects, particularly the poet's experimentation with traditional poetic forms and techniques.

The Ideal Tradition: A Language within a Language

In the introduction to *Folktales from India* and other late essays, such as 'Where Mirrors Are Windows' and 'Classics Lost and Found', AKR defined his idea of literature as a network of traditions, an entire system of 'presences and absences'.¹¹ As we have seen in the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2, this complex network exposes various types of reflexivity (responsive, reflexive, self-reflexive) and comprises the Vedas, the Upanishads, Samkhya philosophy, Buddhism, the epics and other classical Sanskrit texts, Sangam literature in Tamil, medieval bhakti poetry, Indian folk literatures, the contemporary Indian writers, and Western traditions. As AKR postulated, this network should not be understood as a static hierarchical order, but as an interactive system of literary traditions in motion, which continually produces 'co-texts', 'counter-texts', and metatext'.¹²

Leaving intertextual theory aside, AKR's understanding of tradition as an organic continuum that connects past, present, and future can be traced to several sources. Apart from the Upanishadic model of time and history that explains matter (nature, the body, art, etc.) as a continuous process of reincarnation, that is, as a cyclical transformation of the past always 'up to date', transformed into the present, AKR was particularly drawn to the notion of tradition that was prevalent in the Sangam era of Tamil classical poetry: 'A Tamil **(p.348)** classical poet inherits this repertoire and is trained in it; he does not think about tradition, he thinks with it, within it. Tradition, in his precise sense, provides him his material, his medium, his model, his universe of signifiers.'¹³ To make his point, AKR contrasts the role of tradition in the classical Tamil convention with the post-Romantic conceptualization of the past and originality in poetry. The modernists favoured 'individual talent' as opposed to 'tradition', which was often seen as an impediment to originality and individuality: 'But the Tamil poets do not seem to be anxious. They are continuous with their past.'

Tradition is their language for poetry, which they share with their masters, their peers, and their immediate audience—they both learn and modify it.¹⁴

Among the various Western models of tradition, AKR saw parallelisms between the classical Tamil concept of tradition and T.S. Eliot's 'Tradition and the Individual Talent' (1919), the principal Western source for his own idea of tradition (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7). Eliot's notion of a 'simultaneous order' where an individual poem alters the whole tradition seemed to him to describe the ancient Tamil poets 'more accurately than most modern writers of Europe—every realized poem changes somewhat our idea of poetry itself, yet fulfils a potential in the tradition'. AKR's views on tradition sided with Eliot's approach rather than Yeats's or Pound's, and he often referred to the Eliotan paradigms of tradition and the individual. But he was careful not to mistake Eliot's retrospective individual 'use of tradition' with the Tamil fraternity of Sangam poets who were 'made by the tradition' as they 'shared' their tradition, a quality that AKR truly admired:

[F]or a modern poet like Eliot, tradition is made retrospectively by the individual poet; hence his tradition is not the same as Yeats's or Pound's, though all three were contemporaries and advocates of what each called Tradition. In contrast, individual Tamil poets inherit, share, and are made by the tradition. As the creatures and creators of their tradition the *Cankam* [Sangam] poems make 'infinite uses of finite means,' generating novelty without defying tradition or quarrelling with the given means.¹⁵

In 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', AKR illustrates how the ancient Tamil poets built their network of allusion and reflexivity by creating an ideal poetics that allowed collective and individual creativity to thrive and interact:

(p.349) In such traditions, poems do not come singly, but in sequence often arranged in tens, hundreds, sometimes thousands: sharing motifs, images, structures, yet playing variations that individuate each poem. Every poem resonates with the absent presence of others that sound with it, like the unstruck strings of a sitar.... Every poem is part of a large self-reflexive paradigm; it relates to all others in absentia, gathers ironies, allusions; one text becomes a background of all the others.

Once such genres are established, they not only classify, they generate. The settled conventions make possible, indeed cry out for, another kind of reflexivity. Poems beget metapoems that reflect on themselves or their kind, make the audience conscious of the genre and its limits. Genres give rise to antigenres and metagenres that still use all the properties of the genre they are parodying or reflecting on.

... Thus the tradition of Tamil classical poetry organises itself—or gets organised thus by the anthologists, commentators, and audiences, which include the poets in the tradition....¹⁶

Indeed, many twentieth-century poets had aspired to inscribe their poems within a poetic universe that belonged to a larger poetic body. AKR first learnt about this ideal of tradition while studying W.B. Yeats's work at college in Mysore. He was reminded of Yeats years later when he admired the infinite poetic possibilities that the Sangam poets obtained by building a poetic tradition of finite signs and symbols: 'Yeats' way of making poem relevant to poem is somewhere at the back of my mind always—that's what I like about the traditional bodies of Indian poetry as well: single, realized poems, yet qualifying each other; part of a larger body, a "work".'¹⁷ True to his condition as a contemporary poet with a multicultural heritage, AKR took his appraisal of the Tamil poetic tradition from the formal academic study to his own artistic sphere. In an interview, he compared the advantages these poets had, by belonging to a convention of poets (Sangam) and symbols, with the predicament of the modern poet:

From the almost random 'rag-and-bone shop' of the heart, one falls or 'climbs to one's proper dark.'¹⁸ But the ancient Tamils were a community, a 'Sangam' of poets, with a symbolism and a reality they shared. Not a fabulous mythology, but the realities of nature and culture used as a symbolism, a language within a language which allowed them to write with tremendous economy and allusiveness. Describe a drumbeat or falling water or a wildcat's row of teeth; one little thing could say many things. If the world was the vocabulary of the poet, convention was his syntax. And this was truly matter for envy.¹⁹

(p.350) The Tamil concept of tradition in this sense stands in an inverse relation to the search for originality, individuality, and newness that was in vogue from the 1950s among most modernist Indian poets writing in English who had not been able to forge an idea of their own past traditions as Yeats or Eliot, and later AKR, had shown. The ancient Tamil poets did not strive to be new or original in their use of language, for 'tradition is their language for poetry'.²⁰ They played with variation, nuance, and detail, and moved between conformity and nonconformity in order to interact with the conventions. In this fashion, they were able to expand their vocabulary of signs while being part of the established tradition:

That Harold Bloom notion of 'anxiety of influence' just doesn't apply to this. They [the Sangam poets] want the influence.

... There is no violation of language; it is the fulfilment of tradition.

These poems build a world and the world they build interprets the poems. It's a circle. One has to do a kind of metonymy, a representation of a whole. There are two thousand poems. I translate only two hundred. A single poem does not exist by itself.²¹

AKR realized that only a significant body of poems, that is, a group of poems written over a sustained period of time, could make a larger scheme of reflexive poetics evident: Individual poems are created out of all the given "elements of production," and all the language of past poems.²² It follows that AKR usually published cycles of poems in his collections of translations, and not single isolated or disconnected poems. In his effort to reproduce the poetic code of reflexivity and interrelation that existed between poems in the Tamil Sangam tradition, he usually arranged the translated poems by thematic and formal design.

He experimented with poetry sequences, allusion, and intertextuality in his poetry, and he had several traditions and models to fall back on. His second collection of poems *Relations* in particular is visibly influenced by Tamil Sangam forms since he was writing many of the compositions that made it into that collection during the same period that he was translating Akam (love) poems for his first anthology of Tamil Sangam poems *The Interior Landscape* (1967). When he drafted his famous poem 'Prayer to Lord Murugan' in the late 1960s, which 'draws on the ancient Tamil Hymn Thirumurugatruppadaï',²³ AKR not only had in mind the theme and the imagery of the old Tamil poem (p.351) addressed to the ancient god Murugan, and the ironic attitude of the Kannada medieval poets. In his lecture notes he defined this poem as 'a modern Indian's ambiguous prayers to an ancient god-distant an envious, asking for cancellations of the past, of inconsistencies, a prayer even asking for abolition of prayers'.²⁴ By writing this long composition, he deliberately wanted to become part of the Tamil tradition that parodied prayer poems. That is, he attempted to write 'metapoems that reflect on themselves or their kind',²⁵ and become part of the tradition, as he explained in the interviews:

I've translated a 5th or 6th century poem, the first long poem addressed to Murugan who is an ancient Dravidian god, and some of the references in my poem are to that early poem. So I have in a way set myself in the tradition of the Murugan poems....²⁶

[M]y poem Murugan ... could not have been written if I did not know the classical Tamil, forms and even some of the images there.

That is where it is not just a classical or Tamil poem. It is still alive in the present. That is the need of the creative artist. That is the enterprise he takes up.²⁷

By foregrounding an ironic attitude in this mock prayer, AKR also establishes the connect between the medieval Kannada Virasaiva poetry and the modern poetics of American New Criticism.²⁸ Irony fitted well into the modernist poetics that imbued IPE and Kannada poetry of the late 1950s and 1960s, which were still under the impact of T.S. Eliot and New Criticism. AKR recognizes elsewhere that ‘the Murugan poems ... combine prayer with some of the ironic kind of attitudes that some of the Kannada medieval mystics had. Some of the imagery also of the classical Tamil poems....’²⁹ In his view, the contemporary poet is like the medieval saint-poets who take the liberty to invoke a past tradition as well as to *transform* it. Though AKR may have sometimes overstated the ironic element in medieval Kannada bhakti to suit his own poetics, he liked to stress this affinity with the vachana poets in their departure from tradition, their ironic treatment of earlier material, and in the complex subjectivity that expresses a personal yearning for truth: ‘Irony is something you can’t help in the modern context. You can’t make a naively positive use of myths now, though the Murugan poem makes more than merely ironic use of its material. That’s probably why I translate poems. I have got to jump off my skin and get under the skin of those poems.’

(p.352) This desire to inscribe his poem within a larger system or ‘language’ of literary conventions also explains why AKR made it a point to comment on his long poem on Murugan in public lectures and interviews. One of the few instances in which he explicitly mentions his poetry in English alongside the Tamil translations appears in the essay ‘Classics Lost and Found’. This paper ends by citing the entire Murugan poem and exposing the argument behind it:

Tirumurukarruppatai is a poem of faith and strength; mine is one of lack and self-doubt, in which it is like some other religious poems (e.g. some *virasaiva* poems) that I had translated. These prayers are anti-prayers; they use an old poem in a well-known genre to make a new poem to say new things. The past works through the present as the present reworks the past.³⁰

The cherished vision of AKR in his poetics was to eventually create through his poetry ‘a language within a language’ of his own. Had AKR lived longer, the body of his ‘original’ poetic work in English by itself would perhaps have been large enough for such an exploration. Whether AKR succeeded in grafting his body of poems into the ideal ‘Tradition’, with multiple traditions or ‘languages’ resonating at the back still remains to be seen. His poetry in English will be ultimately judged in the light of ‘Tradition’ at large only after it has passed the test of time. Meanwhile, ironic as it may seem, his pioneering translations of Tamil and Kannada poetry traditions have already become ‘classics’.

A Modern Indian Poet's Use of Tradition and the Past

As a contemporary Indian poet, scholar, and translator with a multicultural baggage, AKR displayed a sophisticated approach to tradition and the past which evolved over the years into a meta-critical stance, poetic theory, and writing technique. He encouraged fellow Indian writers to enter into a dialogue with tradition, and pointed at the vast canopy of material available to the Indian poet, waiting to be explored. Hence, he believed that it was each writer's responsibility to rework and reassess the tradition and make it their own:

We must remember that, in literature, art and culture, tradition is not inherited, it has to be earned, each generation has to work at it anew—otherwise, the past is another country. We have to see it for its own sake, **(p.353)** but also see it for our sake, and see what we can use; if it is our true past, we will also see continuities, connections, relevances, which we can critically examine.³¹

With his groundbreaking efforts, AKR paved the way for a complex-free attitude to the literary past that inspired a whole generation of Indian writers³² and distinguished him from many of his modernist, anti-Romantic contemporaries in the 1960s in India, who steered away from tradition in their effort to write 'new poetry'. The persistent preoccupation with tradition in AKR was not only reflected in a theoretical attitude or in his academic disciplines (translation, anthropology, classical Dravidian studies, etc.), but was also a formal resource³³ as a writer and one of the underlying themes in his poetry. A good number of his poems relate different approaches to tradition and deal with the notion of change and the presence of the past in the present. In his lecture notes on 'Indian Notions of Change', AKR provides a brief review of 'Some Uses of the So-Called "Past"', and cites several of his poems and poetry drafts as exemplifying divergent attitudes to the past:

1. The presence of the past. 'Reincarnation'. Caterpillar passage.
Assimilating the new present to the known 'past' or 'tradition'.
The past as consolation, as resource, as part of our expressive repertoire:
'Some Indian Uses of History', 'A lapse of memory'....
2. New uses for the past ... the use of old traditions with new materials: ...
eg. Neon lights in temples, planes for pilgrimages ...
poem: 'Some Relations': Siva and DDT ...
3. [T]he truly 'modern' temper sees the past as a burden, a weariness,
leading to decadence, not a resource.
[O]ne of the results of modernisation is the creation of a two-faced class.
Ambiguous both about the west and the Indian tradition....
—traditional India produced neither any clockwork, nor orchestration—
has to do with notions of self-consciously interlocked work-schedules.
'Time and Time again'.
4. Discovery of a new past. Historical method.

5. What's really new in India? Decontextualization. Context-sensitive to context-free

—from context-sensitivity to context-free. [L]ack consistency: father

6. Consistency ethic. Gandhi: strove for consistency, to render value context-free. My father. The big difference is a striving for consistency in my generation—guilt over inconsistencies.³⁴

(p.354) Some of the cultural issues mentioned in this schematic outline, for example, context-sensitivity, inconsistency, etc., are tackled in AKR's essays on Indian cultural patterns and literature, as seen in the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2.³⁵ But what was of relevance to the Indian literary and artistic scene of the 1960s and 1970s, and is still crucial to the critical assessment of modern IPE, is how AKR attempted to come to terms with his past as a creative writer at large and the various paths he chose to engage multiple traditions in his prose writings, in his translations, and in his body of 'original' poetry. AKR ended his lecture on 'Indian Notions of Change' with his prayer poem to the Tamil god Murugan.³⁶ The ironic mode was a fairly common, but surely not the only poetic stance employed by AKR to interact with his Indian (Tamil or other) aesthetic and literary past as a contemporary poet. The incommensurable storehouse of Indian themes with all types of material, including legends, folktales, stories, and myths, was always at hand: 'About my roots, that's what I know best. The problem about using myths is that I've to make the past speak to present concerns in a way that is not ideological.'³⁷

Ideally, AKR yearned to cull out of his multiple traditions and translational practice 'a whole body of poetry ... which encloses the whole world. Whatever world it may be. It may be a personal world, it may be a social world but a world which is fully embodied in poetry.'³⁸ In this sense of *embodiment* of a tradition, he explored diverse avenues to assimilate, repossess, transform, or recreate the cultural, literary, and aesthetic pasts to his immediate context(s) as an individual poet living 'in the present'. Tradition for him meant a *continuous* flow of cultural, historical, and biological time, or memory, which he sought to integrate in his poetic art in a creative tension of connections as well as departures from the past and other bodies of writing:

... Because, you cannot entirely live in the past, neither can you entirely live in the present, because we are not like that. We are both these things. The past never passes. Either the individual past or historical past or cultural past. It is *with* us, it is what gives us the richness of—what you call it—the richness of understanding. And the richness of expression. We bring that to whatever is present and some of this understanding might be simply ironic, that is, so much of it cannot be truly supplied, or related to the present.

[T]he disconnection is as much an understanding of the past as making the connection. And people living in the present have to see both, because to assert continuity where there is none, where we cannot see any, is to be a revivalist.³⁹

(p.355) Both *tradition* and *individual talent* are thus 'elements of composition' (see the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7) in a continuous transaction process: 'I pass through them/ as they pass through me/ taking and leaving' (36-8).⁴⁰ Indian and Western traditions, the personal past and work, and other writers' pasts and texts are incorporated into his poetry as a composite of elements which often succeeded, and sometimes failed, to become part of the 'personal repertoire' of the poet and his individual creativity. And as multilingual poet writing in English, the English tradition was for AKR one of the 'public repertoires' that enriched and challenged his individual 'language':

[O]ne doesn't write in English simply in a vacuum. When I write it I have learned English in the English tradition. I know English, English literature, and I have read a great deal of whatever has been written about English literature and so on. So, although I don't want to fit into it or anything like that, the English tradition is also part of my repertoire. Yet I don't want to go back to that kind of mind stock or what I write about. One is actually afraid of repeating it or imitating it too much. Somehow to carve one's own language, one's own repertoire, out of these general, public repertoires that other poets have, that all men who speak English or Kannada have, is somehow a big task and that's the difficulty....⁴¹

Experimenting with Traditional Forms and Conventions

Apart from the apparent use of Indian motifs and content, an evident outcome of AKR's creative interaction with the various Indian and Western traditions was perhaps the even more ambitious experimentation with multiple poetic forms and conventions. Some of the literary forms and techniques that were repeatedly chosen by the poet can be traced to particular traditions (from Shakespeare to the classical Tamil and medieval bhakti poetry he translated), yet AKR believed that traditional conventions had to be continuously recreated into personal modes so as to 'find their form' in an individual poem:

I do not plot and propose experiments, though some pages do. Each poem has to find its form and, in finding its form, it has to be 'an experiment.' In finding this form, one often uses models, precedents, traditions, re-shaping them in one way or another.... If you look at my stanzas or sonnets, you'll see I make up new kinds as I go along. As I change, I hope my expression too will change.⁴²

(p.356) In his poetry in English, AKR was a pioneer in absorbing south-Indian forms, devices, and techniques into modernist and postmodern compositions, and he often experimented with *remakes* by adapting and changing the traditional model to suit his expression. We offer here a brief review of some of AKR's own comments on using indigenous or traditional resources, forms, and prosody in his poetry in English. A comprehensive analysis of his poems in English in the light of traditional forms, which goes beyond the scope of this chapter, would yield numerous examples of re-forms and other experiments and technical devices ranging from diverse Western traditions and the Japanese haiku to classical and medieval south-Indian poetry. Among the Indian traditions, AKR imitated techniques and conventions derived from Akam and Puram poetry (metonymy, inner landscapes, understatement, dramatic scenes, etc.) and other Tamil forms (prayer poems) as well as from the Kannada vachana, Tamil Alvar poetry, and diverse folk forms, some of which have already been described in the sections 'Sanskrit Poetics and the Pan-Indian Tradition', 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics', and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7.

Adapting the Rhythm

Rhythm is defined by AKR in 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry' (see the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7) as 'a recurrence of equivalent units. The units may be at any level from the phoneme and the syllables to constructions and sentence-types and lexical-semantic features.' Within this framework he proposed, as the most effective starting point for the study of poetry, 'the verse-line, with its span of intonational and syntactic features, its rhyme-boundary marking often rhythm-change as well, and the whole line-structure crossing and re-crossing the structure of the language-given sentence'.⁴³ On the other hand, AKR believed that the 'sense of rhythm' of Indian writers in English was of a special kind. He argued that there were certain metrical restrictions in Indian verse in English, since the Indian 'way of speaking and sense of stress' was different from that of native English or American speakers (see also the section 'Biographical Factors and Poetic Creation' in Chapter 6):

For instance, very few even very good speakers of English among us master stress, as you know. And English metre is a stressed metre. Very often I myself use an accented metre in English because that's easier for me. You **(p.357)** know, a kind of *matra*. If you look at the regularities of my verse I usually use very regular verse. But an English speaker may not think it is regular, because he may not count syllables.⁴⁴

AKR added that, this restriction, however, should not inhibit Indian poets writing in English, for the linguistic background could be turned into a creative resource: 'I think you should ultimately use yourself as a resource, and these peculiarities are also a resource.... I think good speakers of English have their

own rhythm. Indian English has its own rhythm, and necessarily so because the pressure of the first language is never absent in Indian English.’⁴⁵

Free Verse

In the 1950s, before getting immersed in Tamil poetics in the USA, AKR absorbed the technique of free verse from his early studies of American and English poetry in India. He admired Whitman’s pioneering use of free verse and commented on a passage of *Leaves of Grass*: ‘The alliteration and assonance, the soft consonants, the repetition of “filament” which slows down the rhythm and enacts the exquisite patient persistence of the spider, may be noted here; these devices are the well-known allies of rhyme-less free verse. One is reminded of Eliot’s remark that no verse is free for the man who wants to do a good job.’⁴⁶

In line with T.S. Eliot and G.M. Hopkins (and other poets he read and studied profusely) AKR was convinced in his early days as a poet that the natural, organic quality of poetry could only be achieved by bringing the verse close to speech: ‘A poet’s style should convey the conviction that it is close to speech (though it may not be actually).’⁴⁷ Both in Kannada and English, he wanted his poetry to sound as if he were talking to someone in an ordinary conversation: ‘Because my Kannada, just as I try in English, tries to be close to speech. In fact, that is the one measure I have for my Kannada writing: “Can I say it? Can I say it ordinarily?”’⁴⁸ Nevertheless, after the mid-1960s, AKR tried to move away from free verse, as he felt that ‘everybody’ was writing in it, and preferred to revert to other traditional English forms like the sonnet form.⁴⁹

The Sonnet Form

Shakespeare, and to a less degree Hopkins, were the principal sources of inspiration for AKR’s experimentation with the sonnet (**p.358**) form. In ‘Linguistics and the Study of Poetry’, AKR analysed Sonnet 30 in Shakespeare’s sonnet sequence. After describing the principal features that are foregrounded in the language of this sonnet, he concluded that his analysis ‘incidentally points up the fallacy of considering poetry as an art of time, as a work of linear sequences; it is, in a new sense, synchronic, rather a-chronic: the whole poem words as one, the later illuminating the earlier, the end contained in the beginning’.⁵⁰

AKR used the sonnet form with ease, and in several interviews criticized poets who could not expand their repertoire to traditional formal verse:

[I]t [formal verse] should be an option. You should not be stuck in informality, just as you should not be stuck in formality. I think an exception is Nissim Ezekiel, who can write in verse. He has always used formal verse, it’s only now that he has moved to different ideas. And I have written formal verse. I have written, as experiments, various kinds of

sonnets and so on. I always use rhymes, for instance. But the rhymes are usually very undefined, as I want them to be.

... I also get that from my own Kannada and other traditions, where you do get rhymes but the rhymes are not in rhymes. I like that, I like to hear the rhyme but not to see it, very often.⁵¹

There are more than a few instances in AKR's poetry where he experiments with sonnets forms, such as 'Prayer before Suicide—A Sonnet', 'Routine Day Sonnet', 'Sonnet', and 'Time Changes', to cite a few examples from different periods.⁵² The fact that he titled some of these compositions as 'sonnets' also hints at the experimental approach to this form. AKR understood the use of the sonnet and sonnet cycles not as an appropriation of a conventional form, but as a mould in which he searched for a personal expression of themes with variations and repetitions. Interestingly, one of the favourite themes explored in the sonnets is the concept of time and how it is perceived not as a 'linear sequence' (as he also claimed in regard to the art of poetry in his study of Shakespeare's Sonnet 30), but as a biological cycle within the body and its 'memory'.

The Tamil Kural

One of AKR's oldest concerns was what he called the 'form of poetry', which meant 'not just the rhymes or count of syllables, but the way it (p.359) begins and ends and gathers a certain clarity'.⁵³ Since the 'meaning' kept on changing with the 'form', AKR argued that the form itself was in the meaning of the poem (see the sections 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry', 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics', and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7). Therefore, in his choice of traditional poetic forms, he often attempted to underline a particular theme or, as was the case in his meta-poetic compositions, to convey the vision of his poetic thought. The Vaisnava theology or cosmological vision of 'the one in the many', for instance, is reflected in a poetics that suggests connections and continuity through repetition and transformation of forms. A formal example of this continuity is the poetic technique of beginning the first unit of a poem with the last unit of the previous poem. This device was picked up by AKR in some of the poems of *Second Sight*. When AKR was working on his long 'Composition' in the early 1980s (see Appendix 2), he was looking for a poetic means that would bind the thoughts and fragments of this (for AKR) unusually long poem, and found it in the Tamil kural:

May 14, 1984:

I'm also putting together my poems, after 10 years. Especially one long poem called Composition now, which was my despair because I liked what I wanted to say but never could find a form and a tone, which I seem to have found. Two lines of 10 and/or 8 syllables followed by a 4-5 syllable, an expanded *kural* where the short lines allow you to clinch a thought, and

run on. I'd be happy to have finished this volume, though I've been scared of letting it go ... fear of criticism mainly, fear of disappointment.⁵⁴

The *Tirukkural* is a fourth-century Tamil book of aphorisms composed by Thiruvalluvar, who wrote it in couplets (kural), one of the basic metres in Tamil prosody. Kural is the common name for the poetic form.⁵⁵ The *Tirukkural* is considered the Tamil book of wisdom par excellence, and is a treatise of the art of living, containing observations on the intricacies of human nature and psychology. Although the long draft of AKR's 'Composition' was eventually transformed into shorter poems, the Tamil poetic form of couplets to link the fragmented poems was maintained by the poet in the cycle of poems that was published in *Second Sight* interspersed with other poems. The original long composition was split into shorter pieces corresponding to the following thematically and formally **(p.360)** interconnected poems: 'Elements of Composition', 'Questions', 'The Watchers', 'Alien', 'A Poor Man's Riches 1', 'A Poor Man's Riches 2', 'Dancers in a Hospital', 'Connect!', 'Middle Age', 'Drafts', 'Looking for the Centre', and 'Waterfalls in a Bank'.⁵⁶

Poetry Sequences, Cycles, or Families of Poems

The arrangements of poems in sequences or cycles and the placing of poems 'in dialogue' with each other is repeatedly highlighted by the author in his books of translations. In the organization of his collections of Tamil Sangam poetry and of medieval bhakti verse, AKR tried to reflect his concern with 'families of poems': '[C]ycles and epicycles, with returning voices, roles, and places, are part of the "interanimation" of these poems ... they weave into the allusive network of the other poems. My arrangement also enacts progression.'⁵⁷ He adopted this cyclical order of poems not only for the translations of Tamil Alvar poetry, which inherited some of the Sangam conventions, but also in his collection of oral bhakti poems (vachanas) and folk stories. He placed tales in cycles, as he would 'arrange a book of poems, so that they are in dialogue with each other and together create a world through point and counterpoint'.⁵⁸ This is why AKR neither translated isolated poems nor all of the poems by the same author:

... I never translate a poem singly. When you do a number of them, the reader begins to see certain regularities, structures conventions.... You read 10 or 15 and sort of start thinking in a new language as it were.⁵⁹

I try to translate groups of poems of seventy, eighty, so that the biases of single poems are in some ways lit up or interpreted by other poems. So I choose my poems. This is one of the reasons I have not simply done translations of all the poems, partly because not all of them come through for me. I do not experience all of them equally and some of them I don't know how to translate. I translate double or triple the number and publish the ones which I think will work as English poems and which are also

somehow faithful to the original. And I also choose them from the point of presenting the world of the original poems.⁶⁰

AKR admired the way Tamil poets played with allusions to other poems within the same Sangam tradition, and were at the same time able to create a poetic dialogue within their own corpus of poems. The technique of arranging poems by cycles was partly learnt from **(p.361)** his early study of Yeats. After the late 1960s, AKR started to adopt this technique in his own English poetry collections, as he explained in a letter to Jon Stallworthy at Oxford University Press London:

I am probably going through a phase where I don't quite know what is traditionally meant by memorability, as I feel every experience memorable, depending on the quality of the attention given to it. The novelistic tone of some poems is also intended, as far as such things can be intended. I also tried to present a family of poems, 'one lighting up another,' however dimly a family of poems with common roots but individual bodies and faces.⁶¹

Soon after completing the poems for his first collection of poems *The Striders*, he delved deeper into his mother-tongue traditions, as can be discerned from his notes and other recorded comments. The poet's characteristic tendency to generate reflexivity and 'relations' in his poetry and to evolve cycles of poems with variations on similar themes began with his second collection of poems, aptly titled *Relations*.⁶² In 1970, he was asked by Chirantan Kulshrestha to 'describe the change of attitude during the six years that span *The Striders* and *Relations*', and the poet gave the following reply:

[A]most all the *Striders* poems were written before 1964.⁶³ Since then I've been doing translations, deepening my acquaintance with the Indian, especially the classical Tamil and medieval *bhakti*, traditions. These traditions explore character and relationships in a lyrical, not a novelistic, way; and include, imply, a great human scene; they create a world through sequences of inter-acting poems.

... I had rather held myself too narrowly in *The Striders*. Some of the poems didn't move freely; So I have been feeling my way towards a longer stanza, a looser line, tones of greater range.

... There are two kinds of poems there [*sic*] of this sort; one is a sequence of poems, variations on a theme, as in a sonnet cycle. If a thing is important to you, it becomes an obsession. Actually, that's what you mean by saying it's important to you. If it's obsessive you begin to see it everywhere for a while and soon find you have written several poems on the same theme, though you might have given it different names; often these poems take similar forms, share a vocabulary, a repertory of symbols, voices. Gradually a number of poems gather around a single obsession often in a progression, a sequence. There are about three or four such

sequences in the new book: 'Sample Entries in a Catalogue of Fears;' a series of prayers to Lord Murugan, the ancient Dravidian god; and one on the modern Indian's uses of history, both honest and dishonest.⁶⁴

(p.362) The play with forms, allusion, and dialogue between AKR's own poems gradually turned into an underlying coherence, where intertextuality and poetry as an *organic process* became an integral part of his technique as well as of the inner 'meaning' of his poetic body during the later period (1980s-1990s) from the unpublished long 'Composition' to *Second Sight* and onwards. Like the Tamil and medieval poets, the author was fond of repetition and variation. Increasingly, his poetry was flooded with variations of motifs, images, and situations that echoed, or 'remembered' earlier scenes and poems.

Translation and Poetic Practice

The Translation Complex

AKR's ideas on translation cover theoretical aspects, such as the functions of translating and the role of the translator, etc., and descriptive features illustrating the process and technique of translating particular texts. Based on his body of writings pertaining to translation in a broad sense of the term, the topics relating to his translational activity can be classified into the following overlapping points:

1. The translation of texts, that is, particular poems and sequences of poems involving theoretical and descriptive aspects.
2. The translation of contexts, readers, cultures, and systems of thought.
3. The history of translation and translators.
4. Translation and poetic creativity.
5. Translation as a metaphor in life and work.

His conception of translation and explanations on the translation of particular texts relate mainly to the rendering of classical and medieval poems from Tamil and Kannada into English, and not to translation of poetry from or into modern Indian languages. They focus primarily on literary traditions that are linguistically, culturally, and chronologically very distant from modern English. Therefore, AKR's concept of translation is fundamentally concurrent with his interest in cross-cultural relations and in the use of tradition and the literary and cultural past. Just as AKR's theory (and 'practice') of tradition can be approached from his 'outer' poetics (the study **(p.363)** of classical, medieval, and contemporary poetry) or from his 'inner' poetics (his own creative process as a poet) in an interdependent *continuum*, so does translation intimately connect the 'outer' and the 'inner' spheres in multiple ways. For example, the inner-outer paradigm can also be applied in translation studies to examine the 'outer' forms ('linguistic, metrical, logical and other such forms of shaping experience') that are required to transpose the original text into its new form, or to analyse the 'inner' forms ('substance ... images, symbols', etc.), including the

contexts, the sender (poet, narrator, performer) and his cultural ecosystem, and the receiver (reader) of the translated text (see the sections 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2 and 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7).⁶⁵

It was AKR's constant effort to provide a double translation, textual and contextual, with his extensive notes, introduction, and afterword to his collections, which were meant mainly for the Western or Western-educated reader, and with which he hoped '(against all odds) to translate a non-native reader into a native one'.⁶⁶ Translation, after all, was for AKR the imperfect mapping of one language system into another.⁶⁷ Thus, he also experimented with a number of technical devices to imitate the particular nuances and 'untranslatable' features of a poem. It was his goal to translate a poem by keeping the 'spirit' of the original and imitating its structure, exploring all the resources of the English language and of the tradition it belonged to.⁶⁸ For this reason, there is also an overall predilection for the techniques of imagery in Sangam and bhakti poetry. In AKR's explanations of translation techniques, it is the visual dimension of a poem that is foregrounded, and he illustrates how the semantic imagery of an ancient Tamil poem is carefully reinforced by the use of symmetrical arrangements of lines and spaces, indentation, typographic design, and other devices of the 'poem on the page' to recreate 'the inner form' of the original.⁶⁹

The process of translation, of course, also involves a dialogue, and sometimes a conflict, between the translator and the author (in AKR's case, an established poet in his own right), who has to perform a balancing act between the 'benefactive' function of representing 'another' (as 'faithful' to the original as possible) and the 'self-reflexive' function of expressing 'himself'. So the translator is inescapably 'an artist on oath'.⁷⁰ The danger of being 'on oath' is that any witness of the transaction can always accuse the translator of being a traitor, **(p.364)** having abandoned his/her neutrality by appropriating, consciously or unconsciously, the original artwork. Conscious appropriations were, for instance, AKR's loose versions of Kannada bhakti poems in the 1950s (see the section 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7), some of which were published along with his early poems in English; he did not claim these to be translations but transcreations 'after' an original model.

A heated controversial debate over AKR as a seasoned translator, however, was sparked off by scholar Tejaswini Niranjana towards the end of the latter's life in 1992 when she placed AKR, in her critical work *Siting Translation*,⁷¹ within a postcolonial, postmodern political discourse. Niranjana accused him of having consciously implanted a Eurocentric, Orientalist, and essentializing version of Kannada Virasaiva bhakti in his famous translation and commentaries, and thus of having appropriated the voice of a tradition that was much more diverse than what a single Western-trained Brahmin scholar in America could bring to it and

to the Western readers he was addressing. These accusations were countered by other scholars like AKR's former student, colleague, co-translator, and editor of his collected essays Vinay Dharwadker in several insightful essays on the theory and practice of translation of his mentor. Dharwadker pointed out that Niranjana's own interpretation of AKR was an essentializing postmodern exercise that did not attend to the complexities of AKR's translation work.

Translation, just as the writing of poetry, always involves a process of selection (of words, syntax, poems, sequences of poems, poets, and traditions). And so, under the kind of aggressiveness and decentralizing postmodern critical canopy that Niranjana operated in the early 1990s, or following other, perhaps more dangerous centralizing discourses of a different breed, AKR could, alternatively, be accused of many things: of having favoured Dravidian traditions (Tamil exceptionalism), or of giving too much visibility to certain alternative or subaltern traditions belonging to the margins like women mystics and many other 'little'—and not so 'little'—heterodox, pluralistic literary expressions.

Criticism, however, also came from within Virasaiva quarters. In the introduction to his anthology *I Keep Vigil of Rudra: The Vachanas* (2010), Kannada poet, playwright, and Virasaiva scholar H.S. Shivaprakash criticized AKR for not attending to the 'radical potential' of the vachanas and not respecting their diversity and nuances. Referring to AKR's sole interest in the 'poeticity' of (p. 365) vachanas, Shivaprakash further commented in a recent interview: 'His translations are excellent reading in English but are impervious and insensitive to nuances of source texts. Translation of proper names like "Lord of Meeting Rivers" is unpardonable ... and dialogic *vachanas* [in source text] read like monologic, confessional and Sylvia Plath-like poetry.'⁷²

All this said, it is certainly true that in AKR's attempt to 'translate the reader' and himself into his presentations of south-Indian traditions, there was the danger of being overshadowed by an inevitable process of 'Westernization' (or, more accurately, of 'acculturation') which took place at two principal levels (and in many other subtle ways):

1. As a scholar: the metalanguage AKR employed to explain and compare the aesthetics and poetics of these traditions to the Western reader derived largely from the English Romantics (and later writers like Yeats, Hopkins, Pound, and Eliot) and from structuralist linguistics and cultural anthropology.
2. As a poet-translator: in rendering traditional poetry into English, he followed the New Critical tenets and modernist poetics he was exposed to, such as imagistic techniques, the use of irony, etc. This implied an adaption of forms, and choices were made with a Western reader in mind.

Once we accept these premises, AKR's immense contribution to south-Indian studies from the 1960s to 1980s, with his landmark works of translation that triggered a new interest (among academia as well as the general public) in lesser- or little-known poetic and oral traditions, cannot be disputed. Most Indian and Western scholars of contemporary Indian culture and literature agree that AKR was a brilliant and pioneering translator-scholar of Dravidian traditions who should be seen within the context of his time (the transitional period between modernism/structuralism and postmodernism/poststructuralism) and his place (an Indian living in the USA, no doubt the centre of academic power in those decades). We may identify today a whole generation of scholars, poets, and translators who are indebted to him: those who were gradually following his footsteps (students in America, and admirers), many of whom have taken pleasure and pain to hide in their work an 'anxiety of influence' towards AKR; and those who disagreed with him from the Indian diaspora or from his own motherland by introducing an array of critical perspectives (Marxist, **(p.366)** post-Marxist, Dalit, or 'counter-Brahminical' theories, postmodern theory, and so on), such as the late Kannada critic D.R. Nagaraj, Tejaswini Niranjana, and H.S. Shivaprakash, among others.

AKR's ideas on translation have thus a central theoretical and practical significance and role to play in his poetic thought as well as in contemporary Indian cultural and literary studies, including IPE. In the remaining section of this chapter, I do not go into specific details of AKR's theory of translation as applied to classical and medieval south-Indian texts, which is carefully expounded in the published paper 'On Translating a Tamil Poem' and other essays.⁷³ I shall focus briefly on some of the aspects of translation concerning his 'inner' creative dimension as an artist/poet and the double-sided view of his existence, that is, points 4 and 5 of the connotations listed earlier in the opening of this section.

Translation and Poetic Creativity

The author often referred to the relevance of tradition in contemporary Indian poetry and was deeply interested in how translation could influence a contemporary poet, since the practice of translation had been closely linked to his own making as a poet and scholar. He often cited other modern poets and their ideas on translation, notably Ezra Pound, but also Robert Frost, who defined poetry as that 'what gets lost in translation'.⁷⁴ For AKR, writing poetry and translation were two parallel activities, and one nurtured the other. On the one hand, translating the classical and medieval poets provided a source of poetic inspiration and traditional repertoire, which shaped his writing habits: 'Oct 29, 1987. I always begin with a model I admire, or even an imaginary one, then develop my own style. That's why I'm a translator of classics.'⁷⁵ And on the other hand, he believed that 'only poets can translate poetry',⁷⁶ thus a translator accomplishing a poetry translation was, in fact, creating a new poem:

A poem can be translated only by another poem. There is no such thing as a literal translation. No amount of that kind of scholarly translation will convey the poem, from one language to another. And to walk the tightrope between one's scholarly knowledge of the original and the enterprise of making a new poem is an experience itself.

[Y]ou are ultimately translating the experience of the poem-experience as well as the language and structure of the original because that experience cannot come by itself. It comes through the poetic means of the original. We **(p.367)** may have to find slightly different means, equivalent means, in the language in which you translate it and that takes time. And you translate as you do your own poem, except with one extra lobby. It is the loyalty to the original and your knowledge of it.⁷⁷

If the poet-translator succeeded in this crossover, he would fashion 'a third [language] that will look like the one and speak like (or for) the other'.⁷⁸ But more often than not the translator despaired in a 'pursuit of failure', as translation was by nature an impossible task: 'You're mapping what has organically come out of the possibilities of one language onto another language which never even dreamed of the poem. In doing so, you begin with a sense of impossibilities. Thus translation is a modest art, it's the art of the imperfect.'⁷⁹

Why translate then? AKR asked this question many times over during his career and in one of his notecards he gave a brief outline of the motives behind a poet's translational practice:

1. Writers translate 'because, as writers they have to like other writing', that is, they translate out of admiration or 'envy, aggression'.
2. Writers translate 'to learn new ways of writing, to extend technique and sensibility.

A for oneself

B for others who are writing'⁸⁰

The latter point was typically substantiated by AKR with examples from other Western and Indian writers who had enriched their poetic style and repertoire by translating poetry (he cites Pound, Yeats, Baudelaire, Bankim, Tagore, and others), while the first argument was employed to justify why he chose to translate particular bodies of poetry and individual poems and left aside poets he admired less:

When I started translating them [the classical Tamil Sangam poets], I found that there were any number of poems which I would have liked to have written myself. I do not translate out of love but out of envy, out of a kind of aggression towards these great poems. I think one translates out of

a need to appropriate someone else's creation, done better than one could ever do.⁸¹

By translating the classical and medieval poets he envied, AKR wanted to repossess the past tradition he wished to be part of: 'Translation is the way in which I repossess a poem, because as a writer, I'd like to possess or re-experience past traditions. So I'm not **(p.368)** simply translating for scholarly reasons. This is why, although there are so many ancient great works, I don't do them all. I translate what I want, what I care for, what touches me as a writer....'⁸² In contrast to the dull academic approach that permeated much of Dravidian scholarship and translation work of south-Indian poetry into English in the 1960s and 1970s, AKR's translations stunned readers with their intense poetic and aesthetic quality as well as their faithfulness to the 'original'.

The clue to this success was partly that AKR perceived translation equally as a scholarly discipline, art, and existential urge. He was often so immersed in his translations that he wished to re-enact the experience of the poet and the reader in the poem: '[T]ranslating a poem is the most intense, intimate way of reading it, possessing it, even (be) possessed by it.'⁸³ In fact, his own poetry often got fused with the poems of other traditions, as we have seen in some of his meta-poetic poems and drafts (see the sections 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6 and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' and 'Tamil Sangam Poetics' in Chapter 7). Hence, as a translator-poet, he could *remake* the past and at the same time *reclaim* a timeless poetic body-space that he felt already belonged to him:

[O]ne way of intensifying my understanding of these literatures is to enter into that kind of creative give and take which is what translation is. When I translate an ancient Murugan poet, I have to become that old poet, to some extent, at least temporarily. It is in a way an out-of-the-body experience which is one of the old meanings of the word translation.⁸⁴

In this manner, working on ancient poems in a faraway land, AKR was able to be at the same time a contemporary poet, transparent to the non-native reader, loyal to tradition, and *himself* in the translation: 'Not only to realize the pastness of the past but the presence of the past. But it's in America, the other, that I learned to do it, though I'd begun much earlier. In this business of translating and retranslating, from one tradition to another, funny things happen....'⁸⁵

An interesting aspect of how translation impinged on AKR's poetic creativity is to observe how he sometimes worked in two or three languages at a time and wanted to 'transcreate' his own Kannada poems into English. As he explained, some poems 'came' to him in English and some in Kannada, so there are poems in Kannada that have a 'double' or 'twin' in English, and vice versa. In this way, we **(p.369)** find not only a dialogue between his entire output of English poems

and between the Kannada poems as a body of writing, the reflexivity is also present between the poems that have been 'born' in different languages, some of which he tried to accommodate, that is, translate, in the other language. In the process of translating from one language into the other, the translation became another poem. For AKR had to make new poems in order to be true to his poetic belief that poems are original experiences, that is, he had to re-experience the translation as a new poem. Or, in other words, he had to accept the new poem not as a translation, but as a poem in its own right. Somewhat like his translations of medieval bhakti or classical Tamil poetry, which he wanted to 'repossess' in the act of translation, only that, in the case of his own compositions, the poet-translator was 'repossessing' the past of his own experience. Therefore, the poems that AKR reworked into English from Kannada should not be labelled as 'translations' of his own poems, but rather as versions, 'twins', or 'cousin brothers' of the other poems 'born' earlier. The dialogue (reflexivity) between AKR's English and Kannada poems was made available to non-Kannada speakers for analysis and discussion after Oxford University Press published in 2006 along with his Kannada novella, the Kannada poems in English translated by Tonse N.K. Raju and Shouri Daniels-Ramanujan aka Molly Daniels.⁸⁶

Translation as a Metaphor

The translational activity, as we saw, linked AKR's facets of scholar and poet and provided a site for creative exchange between his academic profession and artistic interests. One could say that he translated *between* and *with* the two spheres, outer and inner, for in the process of translation all his talents (scholarly and artistic) were combined and challenged to produce the best results. The act of translation combined the scientific fastidiousness of a linguist, insight of anthropological scholarship, and creative imagination of a bilingual poet, who aimed to 'carry across'⁸⁷—from the original to the final translation—his entire scholarly knowledge, art, and experience:

Though only poems can translate poems, a translator is an 'artist on oath.'⁸⁸ He has a double allegiance, indeed, several double allegiances. All too familiar with the rigors and pleasures of reading a text and those of making another, caught between the need to express himself and the need to represent another, **(p.370)** moving between the two halves of one brain, he has to use both to get close to 'the originals.' He has to let poetry win without allowing scholarship to lose.⁸⁹

As we read in his volumes of translations, essays, and unpublished writings, AKR did not limit his understanding of translation to the linguistic translation of texts, nor was it merely a creative means to mediate between literary traditions, past and present, languages and cultures. For him, translation was a way of thinking, living, and writing in several languages, cultures, and countries. He had become used to translating himself from the time he grew up as a child in the

multilingual, multi-storeyed family house. As the author remarked in his half-fictional autobiography: 'Coming down from my father's study, I translated to myself, and now that I am in this country, my troubles and my thoughts seem to need a translator again.'⁹⁰ There was no other solution but to translate and get translated into his past, even if it meant going back to 'conventions' and old fears of reincarnation:

...

I must seek and will find

my particular hell only in my hindu mind:
must translate and turn
till I blister and roast

for certain lives to come, 'eye-deep',
in those Boiling Crates of Oil.... (15-20)⁹¹

AKR's obsession with a double self or split personality was also partly explained—if not solved—through the concept of translation: 'The self is always a triangular point between A and B',⁹² he scribbled in English in the margins of a poem composed in Kannada. Hence, in AKR's interpretation of the term 'translation' it is often linked to the concept of metaphor in a literary, cultural, and autobiographical sense: 'A translation is a metaphor of the original', one reads in his notecards. And metaphor, as he stressed, means in Greek 'to carry across', which describes figuratively what the act of translating involves. The translations, just as his poems, effected exchanges between his cultural worlds, creating cross-cultural bridges yet with the translator 'always at a loss', as he wrote in a poem: 'As I transact with the past as with another/ country with its own customs, **(p.371)** currency,/ stock exchange, always/ at a loss when I count my change: ...' (16-19).⁹³ As a translator-poet, AKR stood in-between the 'inner' and 'outer' shores of his self and it was his lifetime job to continually ferry between them, often with deviations to form triangles and other many-sided geometrical forms.

In his translational journeys, the poet and scholar were equally challenged. The translator not only 'mediates' between texts, languages, time periods, and cultures, between text and reader, and translator and author, he also 'walks the tightrope' between the poetic art and the scientific method. The conscientious translator-poet aims at formal and linguistic precision as a scholar and at aesthetic experience and communication as a poet, for the poems must stand and live on as poems. The objective is to let the original form and content 'reincarnate' into another work of art, that is, another *poem* reaching out to the reader, and not 'just words' on the page.

To conclude, AKR's motives behind his translational passion and predicament can be located between the inner and outer spheres: he vacillated between (a)

repossessing the past for himself and thereby making a great literary tradition (and an idealized cultural space) his own for the sake of personal satisfaction and artistic gain; and (b) the generous act of making a rich tradition available to the modern reader and to as wide a readership as possible.

During the course of his career, he became an unrelenting specialist in carrying words, images, texts, structures, cultures, and readers across languages, cultures, and time. Poetry and translation were his true laboratory where the connections were, often unwittingly, made. Translation was the experimental time-bridge and creative landscape where his poetics of dialogue, 'quarrel', and (at times mad) 'connections' was first experienced (relished or suffered), and then delivered by the scientist in polished, multifaceted poetic forms. Or, to take the metaphor further, AKR was at the same time the Western-trained scientist in the laboratory, the suffering specimen under scrutiny,⁹⁴ the quarrelling as well as the listening student, and the passer-by staring at the experiment through the window glass (seeing himself and others), overhearing the talk, and, finally, also the camera recording the scene, the author, the watching soul, the god. And all the while the moving camera eye (not the drowning 'I'), the Watcher, 'makes the scene', knowing that the entire universe is *still* in that single orange drop in the crystal test tube, even after falling and shattering into a myriad of fragments.

(p.372) The dualism present in the practice of translation and in writing poetry was fostered by the peculiar person versus scholar dichotomy that AKR encountered when he arrived in Chicago. In the academic milieu of the USA, the Indian scholar-anthropologist at times saw himself as an object to be studied, that is, an anthropological specimen. Occasionally in his essays, the Akam deliberately enters the Puram; Raman meets A.K. Ramanujan at his office work, and vice versa, the professor now and then steps into the poet's private bathroom to look into *his* mirror. Ultimately, through translation the restless poet-soul always prayed to his transformed gods and dreamed the impossible: to join the timeless Sangam confluence of ancient poets, to dissolve 'for the nonce'—not drown—in the impersonal cosmic waters of the One or the Nothing. But 'thanks' to *translation*, there was no respite: all elements of composition were continuously altered, exchanged, and reconfigured in the never-ending transformative (trans)action that is poetry. And so we can continue the dialogue *now* and talk and quarrel with the immortal poems the poet left us with:

O god of knowledge, busy wizard
of diagnosis, father of needles, dials,
and test tubes, send your old companion here,
that mother of mothers, goddess though of ignorance,
send her soon so she can kiss away my pain
as she has always done.

12 December 1992; 11 April 1993⁹⁵

‘The poem stops because poets are human, because they are mortal,
because it is 3 a.m. But the poem goes on.’⁹⁶

Notes:

(*) This is the last line from ‘Sailing to Byzantium’. The last stanza of this poem is quoted in full in the section ‘What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience’ in Chapter 4.

(1.) Devy, *After Amnesia*, pp. 16–17.

(2.) Ramanujan, ‘A.K. Ramanujan Writes ...’. See also the section ‘Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage’ in Chapter 2.

(3.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahindroo, ‘An Indian Poet’s Several Traditions’, p. 17. See also the interactive relation between Sanskrit and the Dravidian languages in AKR’s paper ‘Sanskrit and the Mother Tongues’.

(4.) Ramanujan, ‘Can We Talk about Poetry Now?’. For a full quote of this phrase, see the section ‘General Ideas on Art and Beauty’ in Chapter 5.

(5.) Ramanujan quoted in ‘Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR’, in *UPP*, p. 47.

(6.) Ramanujan quoted in Kagal, ‘A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns’, p. 12.

(7.) Ramanujan quoted in ‘A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR’, in *UPP*, pp. 76–7.

(8.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), ‘Afterwords’, p. 140.

(9.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahindroo, ‘An Indian Poet’s Several Traditions’, p. 8.

(10.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, ‘Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing’, p. 34.

(11.) Ramanujan, ‘Where Mirrors Are Windows’, in *CE*, p. 15. See this quote also in the sections ‘Looking for the Other to Find Oneself’ in Chapter 3 and ‘Biographical Factors and Poetic Creation’ in Chapter 6.

(12.) Ramanujan, ‘Where Mirrors Are Windows’, in *CE*, p. 8.

(13.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 280.

(14.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 284.

(15.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 285. AKR’s comment in the previous paragraph is from the same source. The phrase ‘an infinite use of finite means’ is by the German linguist Wilhelm von Humboldt (1767–1835).

(16.) Ramanujan ‘Where Mirrors Are Windows’, in *CE*, pp. 15, 18.

- (17.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar. See also the longer quote in the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poets and Poetics' in Chapter 7.
- (18.) AKR quotes Yeats's 'The Circus Animals' Desertion' and 'The Statues'. These phrases are quoted earlier in the following sections: 'General Ideas on Art and Beauty' in Chapter 5, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poets and Poetics' in Chapter 7.
- (19.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', p. 46.
- (20.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 284.
- (21.) Ramanujan quoted in 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', p. 68. See also Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 284 on 'originality' in classical Tamil and modern Western poetry. In AKR's edited version of this paper, the second sentence of the passage quoted reads: 'The notion of the Prague School and others, the notion where *the poetic* is a violation of language, is also not there'. AKR Papers.
- (22.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 282. See also this quote in the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7.
- (23.) Ramanujan quoted in Venkatesh, 'A Poet and His Perception', n.p. The Tamil spelling is by the interviewer. The spelling of the Tamil term is as in the original source. See the Glossary in this book for an alternative way of spelling.
- (24.) Ramanujan, lecture notes on 'Indian Notions of Change', n.p.
- (25.) Ramanujan, 'Where Mirrors Are Windows', in *CE*, p. 7.
- (26.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahindroo, 'An Indian Poet's Several Traditions', p. 18.
- (27.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.
- (28.) Ayyappa Paniker stressed this point in a personal conversation in September 1999.
- (29.) Jha, 'A Conversation with A.K. Ramanujan', p. 8.
- (30.) Ramanujan, 'Classics Lost and Found', in *CE*, p. 192.
- (31.) Ramanujan, 'The Relevance of Tamil Classical Poetry', n.p.
- (32.) AKR's creative understanding of tradition had, for instance, an important impact on writers like R. Parthasarathy and Girish Karnad, to name just two notorious examples.
- (33.) See, for example, AKR's adoption of Tamil poetic conventions (like the *kural*) described below in this chapter.
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(34.) This quote is reproduced as an extract from Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes on 'Indian Notions of Change', n.p.

(35.) See, for instance, also Ramanujan, 'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking?'.

(36.) Ramanujan, unpublished lecture notes on 'Indian Notions of Change'. The poems he cites in this lecture, 'Some Indian Uses of History on a Rainy Day', 'A Lapse of Memory', 'Time and Time Again', 'Some Relations', and 'Prayers to Lord Murugan' are from *Relations* in *CP*.

(37.) Ramanujan quoted in Venkatesh.

(38.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.

(39.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.

(40.) Ramanujan, 'Elements of Composition', in *CP*, p. 122. More lines of this poem are quoted in the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7.

(41.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 140.

(42.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', p. 49.

(43.) Ramanujan, 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry'.

(44.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 143.

(45.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 143.

(46.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', p. 51.

(47.) Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', p. 39.

(48.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords'.

(49.) See the interview 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', p. 77.

(50.) Ramanujan, 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry'.

(51.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 143. See also the interview with Becker and Taylor in *UPP*, p. 77.

(52.) Ramanujan, 'Prayer before Suicide—A Sonnet', unpublished poetry draft, 'Routine Day Sonnet', in *CP*, p. 68, 'Sonnet', in *CP*, p. 220, and 'Time Changes', in *UPP*, p. 22.

(53.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 33. See the longer quote in the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.

(54.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (14 May 1984).

(55.) See the following explanation by G.U. Pope (*The Sacred Kural of Tiruvalluva-Nayanar [with Introduction, Grammar, Translation, Notes, Lexicon and Concordance]*, [New Delhi and Madras: Asian Educational Services, 1990], n.p.; first edition in 1886) on the kural:

Kural means 'anything short,' and is properly the name of the couplet, as being the shortest species of stanza in the Tamil language. Thiruvalluvar's poem (The Kural) is thus by no means a long one; though in value it far outweighs the whole of the remaining Tamil literature, and is one of the select number of great work which have entered into the very soul of a whole people, and which can never die.

(56.) All these poems were published in *Second Sight* in 1986. Some fragments of the long composition still remain unpublished. See Appendix 2.

(57.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *HD*, p. xvi.

(58.) Ramanujan, 'Preface', in *FI*, p. xi.

(59.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 32.

(60.) Ramanujan quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 148.

(61.) Ramanujan, letter to Stallworthy (16 October 1970). See also the phrase by Yeats on how 'one poem lights up another' in Ramanujan, 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry'.

(62.) As the poetry drafts and private notes indicate, *Relations* also includes a good number of poems that had been composed before the publication of *The Striders* and had been either rejected by Oxford University Press or deliberately left out of the first collection by the author.

(63.) AKR's first collections of Sangam poetry were published in 1965 and 1967.

(64.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', pp. 47-8.

(65.) Ramanujan, quoted in Parthasarathy, *Ten Twentieth-Century Indian Poets*, p. 96. See also Jakobson's heuristic scheme illustrated in his communication diagram. See the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7.

(66.) Ramanujan, 'Translator's Note', in *Samskara*, n.p., parenthesis in original.

(67.) See further AKR's comments on translation in Advani, 'A Whole World in a Poem'.

(68.) See Ramanujan, 'Translator's Note', in *SoS*, p. 13; 'Introduction', in *HD*, pp. xvi-xvii; and 'On Translating a Tamil Poem', in *CE*, pp. 229-31.

(69.) See, for instance, Ramanujan in *HD*, p. xvii and 'On Translating a Tamil Poem', in *CE*, p. 227.

(70.) Ramanujan probably rephrased with this comment the critic Desmond MacCarthy: '[A] biographer is an artist on oath.... A biographer who works as an artist becomes the biography'. See Desmond MacCarthy, 'Lytton Strachey and the Art of Biography', *Memories* (London: MacGibbon, 1953), pp. 31-49. See also a reference to this comment in Leon Edel, 'Biography: A Manifesto', *Biography: An Interdisciplinary Quarterly*, vol. 1 (1978), pp. 1-3. See further in this section on the translator's dilemma and his 'double allegiance'.

(71.) Tejaswini Niranjana, *Siting Translation: History, Post-Structuralism, and the Colonial Context* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1992), pp. 181-5.

(72.) See Shivaprakash, 'Introduction', in *I Keep Vigil of Rudra*. Shivaprakash was brought up as a Virasaiva and was then drawn to Marxism and socialism at college, which he later combined with a deep interest in Buddhism, yoga, tantra, and Sufism. His recent comments on AKR as a biased translator of vachanas are from a personal e-mail interview I conducted with this eclectic scholar in April 2015.

(73.) See, in particular, Ramanujan, 'On Translating a Tamil Poem', in *CE*, pp. 229-31. See also the translator's note in *SoS*, and the introduction to *HD*.

(74.) See Ramanujan, 'On Translating a Tamil Poem' and 'On Folk Mythologies and Folk Puranas', in *CE*, pp. 219, 516.

(75.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (29 October 1987).

(76.) Ramanujan quoted in Das Gupta, 'Suddenly a Phrase Begins to Sing', p. 34. See, for example, AKR's experimental use of classical Western and Tamil techniques in his poetry outlined earlier in this section.

(77.) Ramanujan quoted in Jha, 'Between Two Worlds', p. 13.

(78.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 297.

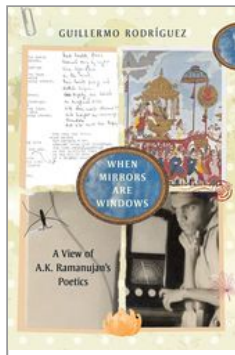
(79.) Ramanujan quoted in Advani.

(80.) Ramanujan, unpublished notes, AKR Papers (n.d.).

(81.) Ramanujan quoted in 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR', p. 46.

- (82.) Ramanujan quoted in Advani.
- (83.) Ramanujan, unpublished notes, AKR Papers (n.d.).
- (84.) Ramanujan quoted in Mahindroo, 'An Indian Poet's Several Traditions', p. 8.
- (85.) Ramanujan, unpublished notecards, AKR Papers (c. 1984).
- (86.) Raju and Daniels-Ramanujan, *A.K. Ramanujan*.
- (87.) See Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 14.
- (88.) See earlier in this section the probable source of this phrase placed in quotation marks by AKR.
- (89.) Ramanujan, *PLW*, pp. 296–7.
- (90.) Ramanujan, *Someone Else's Autobiography*, p. 247.
- (91.) Ramanujan, 'Conventions of Despair', in *CP*, p. 34. The term 'eye-deep', which in the poem 'The Striders' is changed to 'I-deep', is borrowed from 'walked eye-deep in hell' in Pound's 'Hugh Selwyn Mauberly'. See also the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7. The poem paradoxically invokes the Hindu cycle of reincarnation, his personal and cultural conception of hell, only to merge with the Christian metaphor of fire in hell.
- (92.) Ramanujan, unpublished notecards with Kannada poems, AKR Papers (n.d.). The quotes further are from his unpublished notecards on translation.
- (93.) Ramanujan, 'Waterfalls in a Bank', from *Second Sight*, in *CP*, p. 189. Quoted in the section 'Biographical Factors and Poetic Creation' in Chapter 6.
- (94.) AKR was fond of saying that he was both a student and a specimen of Indian folklore. See, for instance, Ramanujan, in *CE*, p. 348.
- (95.) Ramanujan, last stanza of the poem 'Pain', *The Black Hen*, in *CP*, p. 274. One of the poet's last compositions before he passed on.
- (96.) Ramanujan, *HD*, p. 168.

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(p.378) Appendix 1

Primary Sources for a Study of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics

Guillermo Rodríguez

Primary Sources for a Study of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics

General Overview of A.K. Ramanujan's Works in English

A descriptive classification of the texts¹ that have been analysed in this book will allow the reader to appreciate the range of AKR's work. It may also be of interest to those who wish to get acquainted with the author's lesser known publications and the unpublished writings in the AKR Papers that are kept at the University of Chicago. The primary sources that are classified in this appendix cover miscellaneous material, disciplines, and topics that are relevant to an understanding of AKR's aesthetics and poetics. For several reasons, the process of delimiting and selecting material to this purpose is not devoid of technical problems. First, it is the first time that the published material is scrutinized alongside the unpublished sources in the Papers for a study of this kind. Primary texts on a particular subject have to be recognized out of a vast amount of material in the Papers and many of the manuscripts are undated. Second, the body of texts comprises diverse genres (prose, poetry, letters, and interviews) and a large part of it is thematically wide-ranging and so interdisciplinary in nature that it challenges any definitive classification. Certain writings that at first sight do not appear to be of particular significance to the writer's ideas on poetry may reveal, after closer scrutiny, unexpected nuances of his aesthetic sensibility. And as to the poems that might be identified as meta-poems or poems on poetry, there can only be a tentative list for the reason that many of the drafts and 'final' compositions, in effect, all of the poetry, could be said to reflect (on) the condition of being a poet and the creative act of writing poetry. The present compilation of primary sources is, therefore, an open inventory since all of AKR's

(p.379) work comes out of the same creative mind and oblique view of life that defines *the poet*.

While AKR wrote and published (essays, poetry, and tales) mostly in the English father tongue, he was also a creative writer (of poetry, plays, proverbs, and fiction) in the Kannada mother tongue, and for many years worked with Dravidian languages, mainly medieval and modern Kannada, classical and medieval Tamil, and, to some extent, modern Tamil and Malayalam. In the present classification of texts pertinent to AKR's poetic universe, I have accounted only for sources in English or those translated into English. This primary material is ordered according to genre into prose writings, poems, and interviews, and the prose works are further divided into scholarly and private writings. All textual sources are identified as published or unpublished pieces. The description follows mainly a chronological order, and in the case of the prose the main themes are also pinpointed.

Published Material

The first category of primary sources is the published material, which comprises a substantial part of the author's finished prose pieces and poems as well as interviews. Most of the prose and poetry is included in the three collections published posthumously by Oxford University Press: *The Collected Poems* (1995), *The Collected Essays* (1999), and *Uncollected Poems and Prose* (2001).² Apart from the collected poems and prose writings, there are also the famous introductions, afterwords, forewords, and notes to AKR's books of translations, namely, *The Interior Landscape* (1967), *Speaking of Siva* (1973), *Hymns for the Drowning* (1981), and *Poems of Love and War* (1985). In 2004, these translation volumes were published by Oxford India along with AKR's previously edited poetry collections in English (1995 and 2001) in an omnibus collection titled *The Oxford India Ramanujan*. Two years later, Oxford University Press brought out a collection of his Kannada works which was the last in the series of posthumous AKR books. *Poems and a Novella* (2006) included translations into English by Tonse N.K. Raju and Shouri (Molly) Daniels-Ramanujan of his three Kannada poetry collections: *No Lotus in the Navel* (*Hokkulalli Hoovilla*, 1969), *And Other Poems* (*Mattu Itara Padyagalu*, 1977), and *Hopscotch* (*Kuntobille*, 1990), and of the novella *Someone Else's Autobiography* (*Matthobhana Atmacharitre*, 1978). A few uncollected essays and early poems in English, and a handful of poetry translations from Kannada **(p.380)** and Tamil, along with several uncollected pieces of fiction and poems in Kannada translated by others, make up the remaining published primary sources available in English. Altogether, the earliest publication of original material in English dates from 1955 and the latest is from 2001.³ Except for material published in the 1950s and a few of the interviews and newspaper articles, most of the published sources in English are available online or at specialized libraries and research centres.

The main difficulty that the published primary sources pose to the researcher of AKR's poetics is the lack of published prose that deals explicitly with his views on poetry as a contemporary poet. Although many of the essays deal with poetic traditions as a scholar and translator, there are no substantial commentaries on the art of writing (contemporary) poetry, nor are there any critical articles or artistic manifestos that could a priori be considered to describe his 'poetic theory'. The majority of these essays and lectures delve into the repository of Indian folklore and south-Indian poetic traditions that AKR introduced to Western scholarship in the 1960s and 1970s. They cover mainly Tamil classical literature, Tamil and Kannada medieval mystic poetry, and popular oral traditions, but leave aside general discussions on art and poetry. Thus, we have a somewhat paradoxical situation. AKR was widely recognized as an essayist and commentator of Indian literary traditions, but unlike other reputed Indian poets of his generation writing in English (such as Nissim Ezekiel, R. Parthasarathy, or K.N. Daruwalla), he did not openly formulate his ideas on contemporary poetry and poetics in any of his published writings. Nor did he contribute articles or essays on contemporary IPE (and its critical scene) to journals or edited volumes in India or the USA, as a good number of his fellow poets in India did. I have been able to trace only one uncollected published essay that deals with contemporary Indian poetry as a monographic topic of discussion, and this short article has remained largely unnoticed.⁴ What is more, AKR was no friend of abstract ideas in discussions about poetry writing or particular poets. He often shunned direct critical value judgements or overt generalization and preferred indirect allusion and oblique statements, particularly when it came to describing his own poetry and that of other contemporary poets. Even in some of the published interviews, he appears uncomfortable with these issues and each comment on his poetics and connected topics is carefully worded. This reluctance to give away gratuitous information conforms as much to **(p.381)** his modesty as a poet as to his predilection for understatement and minimum redundancy. It was part of AKR's way to avoid statements on his poetry in order to let the poetic work stand by itself. He wanted his ideas to be suggested by the poems rather than stated. In any case, the more than a dozen interviews published in the USA and India throughout the years must be acknowledged as rare valuable sources on his personal poetics and related biographical issues.

AKR's published essays are brilliant scholarly papers and are almost entirely dedicated to Indian cultural systems and literatures (classical and medieval poetry, and folk traditions), comparative literature, linguistics, and general cultural studies. Some of the pieces seem quite simple at a first reading, but contain, in fact, carefully constructed arguments that rely strongly on quotation, description, repetition, and suggestion. Therefore, AKR's ideas on poetry and aesthetics have to be abstracted from the scholarly comments on the various poetic and aesthetic concepts and traditions he was so deeply involved with in his professional career, and which are endorsed in these essays. At the same

time, the descriptive analysis of poems, poetic styles, techniques, and poetics belonging to different Indian literary traditions and periods also offer important clues to AKR's poetics. Except for his rare piece on the modern Tamil poet Subramania Bharati⁵ and the essays that introduce the reader to Tamil and bhakti poetics, few of the published essays are on a single poetic or aesthetic tradition. Rather, AKR had a tendency to let the essay(s) operate in an intertextual and interdisciplinary mode of 'reflections' (see the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2) through various literary genres and cultural systems. The structure of some of the essays deserves attention as it sometimes throws more light on the author's poetic thinking than specific commentaries. Many of the essays read like anthologies of quotations and poems. They integrate aesthetic and poetic 'samples' which work by semiotic extension, analogy, allusion, variation, and repetition moving through different contexts and pre-texts, thus achieving an effect that is closer to poetic recitation and dramatic play than to the rational exposition of a monological voice.

Unpublished Material from the A.K. Ramanujan Papers

After his untimely death during an operation at a Chicago hospital, AKR's papers and other documents were handed over to the **(p.382)** Department of Special Collections at the Regenstein Library of the University of Chicago by AKR's ex-wife, Molly A. Daniels, in June 1994. They were first kept in 21 books and could be accessed, but no completed research aid and inventory was available to the researcher, only a 'preliminary inventory'. About 15 years later, the AKR Papers were meticulously classified and stored in 71 smaller boxes, the contents listed in a detailed 'Guide to the A.K. Ramanujan Papers 1944-1995' published online in 2010.⁶ This guide classifies the material into biographical (series I), correspondence (series II), teaching material (series III), research, translation, and writings (series IV), personal correspondence, diaries, and artefacts (series V), audiovisual and digital material (series VI), oversized material (series VII), and restricted student-related material (series VIII, restricted for 80 years). Series VI is further divided into the following seven subseries: essays and articles, linguistics, folklore, verse, fiction, notes, and writings by others. The material in the series and subseries is classified thematically and identified by box numbers and folder numbers. Since my research on the Papers was carried out when the collection had not yet been processed and divided into the present series and subseries, when citing material from the Papers in this book, I do not identify the box and folder numbers.

Although AKR was a trilingual speaker (English, Kannada, Tamil), and bilingual writer (English, Kannada), the majority of his writings contained in the Papers is in English. This shows that ever since he was a college student and lecturer in English in India, the English language served as AKR's main intellectual medium of expression. AKR taught, wrote, and probably thought (as we can infer from his diaries) primarily in English, at least since the late 1940s. The Papers also

hold original material in the south-Indian mother languages, that is, Tamil and especially Kannada. Other than AKR's Kannada works translated into English by others, the original material in Kannada has not been included in the present analysis, which is concerned with his writings in English. Kannada remained throughout his life a very precious literary language. His Kannada writings published from 1955 to 1990 (three collections of poetry, a collection of proverbs, short stories, one novella, and several radio plays from 1955 to 1990) bear witness to his unrelenting creativity in that mother tongue.⁷ The Kannada corpus in the AKR collection at the University of Chicago consists mainly of plays, short stories, translations, original poetry, and his field notes in folklore.

(p.383) For an exhaustive overview of AKR's life and work, one would have to consider also the writings that the author may have left behind in India when he departed to the USA on a Fulbright scholarship in 1959. It cannot be determined with certainty if AKR's entire early writings have been stored in the Papers, but it is perhaps safe to assume that the author had gradually relocated all valuable material to his permanent base in the USA, for it was his habit to keep a record of all his drafts, fieldwork material, and private writings. After AKR's demise, most of this material must have been included in the collection of Papers that were handed over to the Regenstein Library. Apart from the available interviews, some of the most revealing observations on creativity and poetry appear in private prose (journals, diaries and drafts, or copies of letters) and in some unpublished papers, drafts of essays, and lecture notes, all kept in the AKR Papers. All in all, the Papers provide an exceptional opportunity to gain new insights into undisclosed areas of AKR's poetic theory and practice, allowing for a comprehensive analysis of his private thoughts on art and poetry and of the creative process behind the making and publishing of his poems in English. The Papers, thus, light up and complement the commonly accessible texts in the published sources, which offer only a one-sided perspective of AKR's poetic and aesthetics.

Descriptive Classification of the Primary Sources

Prose

The first type of material that is described in this classification is AKR's prose in English which includes scholarly and private writings.⁸ We begin by looking at the multidisciplinary scholarly prose that is available as published and unpublished material, before moving on to the private diaries and notes, which are all unpublished.

AKR was one of the most reputed Indian scholars of the second half of the twentieth century. In his academic career, which, in spite of its abrupt ending, extended over 40 years, he moved progressively through several disciplines. As a transcultural teacher, scholar, and creative writer, he was comfortable in diverse intellectual traditions, feeling simultaneously at home in the 'Indian' and 'Western', 'modern' and 'traditional', 'scientific' and 'artistic' mould. The

frequent criss-crossing between countries, languages, and miscellaneous fields of interest kept his complex identity alive. In **(p.384)** his prose writings, he kept a life-long allegiance to two of his earliest personal interests—poetry and folklore. AKR was since teenage fascinated by oral narrative traditions⁹ and medieval bhakti poetry, and later, as a young scholar in the USA, discovered for himself and for a good part of Western scholarship the treasure house of classical Tamil Sangam aesthetics and poetics. He analysed these traditions from innovative angles as his own academic toolbox expanded to accommodate new systems of analysis and thought over the years. He typically worked on several parallel projects at the same time and in several disciplines and languages. His work as an essayist, therefore, cannot be separated from his occupation as a lecturer and teacher. From the 1950s till 1993, AKR taught at over 15 universities in India and the USA. At the University of Chicago alone, where he lectured from 1961 till the end of his career, he had teaching assignments at four different departments. He was the William E. Colvin Professor at the Department of South Asian Languages and Civilizations and the Department of Linguistics, a member of the Committee on Social Thought, where he taught mostly English and American literature, and a member of the Department of Anthropology, and also lectured at The College.

When we regard AKR's entire academic output, we soon realize that he was a miscellaneous, but not overly prolific scholar-writer. He was known to constantly rework his ideas, and published material only after having carefully revised it, albeit with oft-regretted intermittence. It also needs to be stressed that in almost all of his papers, articles, and essays, he kept a focus both on poetic as well as scientific discipline. He confessed that he inherited this 'double allegiance' to both science and poetry early from his father, who was a mathematician with an equal interest in astronomy and astrology (see the section 'First 30 Years in India' in Chapter 3).

The major courses or subject areas AKR lectured on were English and American literature, Dravidian and general linguistics, structural anthropology, semiotics, poetry and creative writing, translation, Indian literatures (classical, medieval, and oral), Indian civilization and mythology, comparative literature and theory, and psychology. All these academic fields also informed much of his work as a writer of scholarly papers and essays. It can be quickly discerned after scrutinizing the main topics in his scholarly prose, that poetry, translation, and folklore occupied the centre stage of his intellectual **(p.385)** universe, and were also the disciplines he was most engaged with in the latter part of his life.

The fact that he was concerned with such a wide range of topics, both as an academic scholar and teacher, certainly had an impact on his habit of revising his intellectual and scientific agenda. For, just as academic syllabi, especially at American universities, is periodically updated and interrogated in the light of new academic guidelines and theoretical inputs, so too the conscientious

professor may revise his/her academic leanings and shift to different subjects or courses for a period of time to avoid intellectual 'burnout'. AKR moved back and forth between several intellectual domains and often amended both the content and style of his papers, sometimes dozens of times, as he refreshed or realigned his point of view, in a constant dialogue with his writings and himself. And so, many of the topics, samples, and examples put forward in his scholarly prose reappear in a variorum of forms and ideas throughout his career. Writings typically overlap, complement, or echo one another. Sometimes entire essays coexist in different versions as he reworked them towards a 'finished' version. The publishing process of the papers also partly accounts for this. A major bulk of the prose writings were first delivered as lectures in India, Europe, or the USA, then published as conference proceedings or in leading literary or cultural journals, sometimes republished in edited book volumes, and finally collected in the posthumous books.

Considering the heterogeneous nature of the material, the task of identifying and classifying published and unpublished scholarly prose pieces on the basis of the author's aesthetic and poetics is a complex undertaking which also entails a novel approach to AKR's prose work. Though it is far from being conceptual and abstract, AKR's prose is dense in ideas, interdisciplinary in methodology, and usually multilayered in meaning. In the essays and papers it is, therefore, not always unproblematic to single out a particular theme. It was characteristic of AKR to explore themes simultaneously at several planes of argumentation and from various perspectives. He presented particular topics by posing multiple questions and engaging the reader in a dialogue of ideas, prose texts, poems, and other texts. In this manner, he probed into the particularities of literary texts as well as their shareholding with other literary works. His anthological essays, rather than reaching a conclusion, are presented as a process that aims to stimulate the imagination and evoke an intellectual **(p.386)** response through illustration and suggestion.¹⁰ Even in some of the monographic essays, AKR moves across a variety of material and takes deliberate sidesteps into contiguous topics.

Published Scholarly Prose

The Collected Essays (1999)

The Collected Essays of A.K. Ramanujan (or *CE*) was published in 1999 by Oxford University Press. Vinay Dharwadker,¹¹ a former student and disciple of AKR at the University of Chicago, who also collaborated in the publication of the posthumous *The Collected Poems of A.K. Ramanujan* (1995), served as the general editor of *CE* published six years after AKR's death. The time gap may be indicative of the difficulties involved in classifying and revising all the finished and unfinished essay pieces that AKR had left behind. Dharwadker undertook this commendable editorial task with great expertise and also coordinated the work of seven other AKR colleagues and friends who contributed in one way or

another to this publication. According to Dharwadker, AKR had intended in his later years to arrange 35 essays into a possible volume of collected essays. From the notes in the AKR Papers, we can infer that the author had played with several possible titles for such a collection of miscellaneous essays. The posthumously published *CE*, allegedly put together on the basis of AKR's notes, contains altogether 30 essays, 'all the finished scholarly pieces ... that he had contemplated including in such a volume'.¹² It includes the last versions of 26 published essays and four previously unpublished lectures and drafts of essays.

The collection purposely leaves out the essays that appeared as afterwords or introductions in AKR's five books of translations, his collections of folktales, and the co-edited works as well as papers and essays on technical linguistics, and the two prose pieces later published in the *Uncollected Poems and Prose*.¹³ However, the general editor does not account for the exclusion of a few other published and unpublished papers on Indian literature and culture, such as the seminal essay 'Parables and Commonplaces' (1983) as well as some early essays and articles that were not incorporated in any of the two posthumous collections. The 30 essays in *CE* are divided into four sections, 'Literature and Culture', 'Classical Literatures', 'Bhakti and Modern Poetry', and 'Folklore', with introductions by Wendy (p.387) Doniger, Vinay Dharwadker, John B. Carman, and (jointly) Stuart Blackburn and Alan Dundes. The first three sections contain six essays each and the fourth on folklore altogether 12. These sections are preceded by the preface of the general editor and by two tributes, one by the late Milton B. Singer, and the other by Edward C. Dimock and AKR's son Krishna. The essays have been carefully annotated with Dharwadker's comments on the identity of the copy texts, and with the original notes and references by AKR in uniform format at the end of the volume. An additional 'Chronology of Select Books and Essays' compiled by the editor traces the dates of presentation of papers and lectures, and the publication of essays, which helps the reader in following the evolution and recurrence of certain themes in AKR's work, while it also indicates his habit of revising and reutilizing material.¹⁴

Uncollected Poems And Prose (2001)

The slender volume titled *Uncollected Poems and Prose: A.K. Ramanujan*, published by Oxford University Press in 2001 under the joint editorship of Molly Daniels-Ramanujan and poet Keith Harrison, brought to light for the first time two prose pieces, 'The Ring of Memory: Remembering and Forgetting in Indian Literature', probably the last essay AKR drafted, and the short eulogy 'For Barbara Miller', which he wrote two months before his death. The essay on 'memory' in this sparse collection of miscellaneous material had to wait eight years for three other posthumous AKR books to be published first.¹⁵ Unlike the two posthumous collections (*The Collected Poems* and *CE*) introduced and prefaced by Vinay Dharwadker, this volume unfortunately does not offer an introductory commentary by the editors describing the selection of the material,

its arrangement, and the process behind its inclusion in the book, which would have been a valuable addition for students and researchers of AKR's work. For unaccounted reasons, only his late writings (prose and poetry) of the 1990s were considered fit for publication in this volume of uncollected material.¹⁶

Nevertheless, 'The Ring of Memory', an unfinished essay or lecture text on the role of 'memory' in Kalidasa's classical play *Sakuntala* (fifth century AD) and in other Indian narrative and poetic traditions, is an insightful paper that touches on important issues pertaining to aesthetic perception and experience.¹⁷

(p.388) Other Uncollected Published Essays and Articles

Half a dozen miscellaneous essays and articles on classical Indian poetry, Indian and American contemporary poetry, and Indian studies in the USA, published between 1955 and 2001, were omitted in the two posthumous collections.¹⁸ For editorial reasons, they may have been excluded from *The Collected Essays* since most of these uncollected pieces are not as continuous (in topic matter, style, tone, and discipline) with his other scholarly prose as could have been desired for a compact edition of collected essays. But some of this material could surely have found a place in a volume of 'uncollected prose' such as *Uncollected Poems and Prose*. Besides these scholarly essays and articles, there is among the uncollected published prose a unique short piece titled 'A.K. Ramanujan Writes ...',¹⁹ published by the Poetry Book Society in London in 1966 after his collection of poetry, *The Striders*, received the society's recommendation. This article contains interesting comments on the poetic traditions that influenced AKR at that time, and reveals interesting clues about his first collection of poems. The colloquial style and content of this write-up in fact bring it closer to the interviews than to the scholarly prose classified here.

Three uncollected essays—'Notes on Walt Whitman', 'Indian Poetics', and 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry'—are of particular significance to our study for they cover poets and poetic traditions that are not discussed at length in the collected essays, that is, the American poet Walt Whitman, classical Sanskrit poetics, and contemporary Indian poetry. 'Notes on Walt Whitman' (1955),²⁰ AKR's first essay published in India, exposes his early interest in a poet he had read avidly as a student and later taught at Indian colleges as a lecturer of English literature in the 1950s. On the other hand, the essay 'Indian Poetics' (1974), co-authored with the American Sanskrit scholar Edwin Gerow, is AKR's only published piece on classical Sanskrit poetics.²¹ This interesting essay explains a number of seminal concepts from Sanskrit aesthetics and poetics that caught AKR's critical attention, and brings up parallel examples from Western linguistics and drama (de Saussure, Shakespeare, Stanislavski, and others). AKR wrote only the 'Overview' of this essay and a section titled 'Dramatic Criticism', altogether six pages in a twenty-eight-page essay, but the piece stands out as his only published commentary on classical Sanskrit literary theory. Elsewhere in his prose work, AKR did only tangentially deal **(p.389)** with Sanskrit poetics for

contrastive purposes with other Indian traditions. The prose by AKR in this introductory essay on Indian poetics is drawn from a longer unpublished paper, which was drafted by the author in 1964 as a lecture titled 'Sanskrit Poetics'.²²

'On Contemporary Indian Poetry' (1983) is a little known published article that was originally commissioned by the Indian Ministry of External Affairs and appeared also as a newspaper article titled 'Is Poetry Dead?: A Critical Look at the Indian Scene'.²³ Since AKR could not complete a planned essay for the co-edited *Oxford Anthology of Modern Indian Poetry* published posthumously in 1994, this is one of his very few published writings that describes the network of traditions operating in contemporary Indian poets.²⁴ Another noteworthy piece among the uncollected essays is the already cited 'Parables and Commonplaces', which was published in 1982 in London and not in the USA or India as was the case with most of his papers. For this reason, the essay may have been overlooked by the editors of *CE*. Unlike the other three uncollected prose writings mentioned earlier, this is an interdisciplinary piece in typical AKR style. It moves analogically from linguistic and cultural encounters to literary dialogue, and provides samples of transactions and differences that take place in the societies and poetics of both India and the West and are mirrored in their literatures. The essay is thus closely linked to some of the issues explored in section I of *CE*, 'General Essays on Literature and Culture'. It also contains some comments on his own intercultural predicament as a poet, translator, and India-watcher in America.

A rather different uncollected paper is 'Indian Literatures in the US 1957-1987',²⁵ written for a conference in 1986, but published posthumously in India in 2001. Besides surveying the history of Indian literary studies in the USA, this piece also gives some recommendations on how Indian literature should be read and experienced as an art form. As to AKR's published grammars and linguistics papers, which draw on sociolinguistics, Jakobson's structuralism, Chomsky's generativism, and other linguistic schools, they are almost entirely applied to Dravidian languages and dialects.²⁶ In these technical writings, AKR displays his peculiar skill at combining abstract linguistic concepts with meticulous scientific detail, and at observing linguistic features and typologies in a variety of social, cultural, and intra-linguistic contexts. As an interdisciplinary scholar, he was particularly interested in the way **(p.390)** social patterns and changes affect language, and vice versa, how language, in all its functions, can relate to non-linguistic models. AKR does not discuss poetics or the language of poetry in these linguistics papers, but some of his early unpublished papers include technical writings on linguistics applied to the study of poetry. His intense involvement with linguistics as a student, scholar, and teacher in the late 1950s and throughout the 1960s, and the range of his theoretical and applied research in linguistics, merit, however, closer attention, as AKR's linguistic training

permeated his other disciplines as well as his poetry writing and equipped him with a very useful scientific 'toolbox'.

Forewords, Introductions, Notes, and Afterwords to the Collections of Translations and Folktales

AKR's most widely read essays before the publication of *CE* are the well-known introductions and afterwords to his books of translations and folktale collections, which were intentionally excluded from *CE* by the general editor. These are not only valuable reading aids meant to contextualize or 'translate' the reader of his translations and folktale collections, but they also help in placing the author as a translator, poet, and poetic theorist. They are all the more precious primary sources since none of his collections of poetry in English included prose comments. The ideas in these path-breaking essays on classical Sangam, medieval bhakti poetry, and related topics overlap with the observations in the other papers on these traditions in *CE*. In chronological order of publication, these prose writings appeared in the five translation volumes of poetry published in 1967, 1973, 1981, and 1985, and in the collection of folktales that came out in 1991.²⁷

The landmark book of poetry translation, *The Interior Landscape*, which includes 76 translations of one of the earliest surviving Tamil anthologies (the *Kuruntokai* of the Akam or 'love' genre), made classical Tamil Sangam poetry, a poetic tradition that was little known outside the Tamil-speaking area, accessible to the English-speaking reader. *Speaking of Siva*, a selection of free-verse lyrics in medieval Kannada, composed by four of the major Virasaiva bhakti saints of the tenth to twelfth century AD, eventually became a bestseller among publications of Indian literature translations, and managed to spawn the creativity (p.391) of artists, dancers, writers, musicians, and Indian feminists alike. Even British poet Ted Hughes is said to have been inspired by the Kannada vachanas and commented on the translated poems with great admiration.²⁸ It took the author 10 more years to bring out another volume of translations, *Hymns for the Drowning* (1983), which contains poems by the Tamil saint Nammalvar (ninth to tenth century AD), the celebrated saint-poet of an earlier bhakti tradition, the Vaisnavite Alvars (sixth to ninth century AD) of the Tamil-speaking region. *Hymns for the Drowning* proved to be a valuable companion volume to his two earlier books and also served as a bridge work, linking the poetics of the south-Indian bhakti movement to its Tamil sources, including classical Sangam poetry. *Poems of Love and War*, published a little later in 1985, expands his work of translations from Tamil Sangam poetry, taken up in the early 1960s, to include other classical Tamil anthologies of both the Akam and Puram genres. The afterword of this book is without doubt the author's most complete essay on classical Tamil Sangam poetics and its inherent eco-aesthetic cosmology.

Apart from the essays in the books of poetry translation, we also have to consider the scholarly prose in *Folktales from India* (1991).²⁹ The last book published by AKR during his lifetime, this folktale collection is much more than a storehouse of entertaining stories. In the preface and introduction, AKR places India's oral traditions within the wider network of Indian literatures and also manifests his understanding of oral tales as poetic texts. His views on texts and contexts in Indian literature laid out in the introduction go beyond the scope of oral narrative and inform us about his intertextual thinking and aesthetic perception of oral texts.

Unpublished Scholarly Prose from the A.K. Ramanujan Papers

The AKR Papers hold a large stack of drafts of essays, papers, and lecture texts, as well as numerous files with notecards and lecture material that AKR used in his classes. The drafts include early versions of published essays as well as unpublished pieces. Only hitherto unpublished and unidentified scholarly prose has been classified under this section. Prose writings that have already been identified in *CE* as early versions of published essays have not been taken into account.

(p.392) Unpublished Drafts of Essays, Papers, and Lectures

The AKR Papers contain about 24 unpublished drafts of typed and handwritten lectures in English that have never been cited in any previous study of AKR's work. Some drafts are incomplete or survive only as schematic prose outlines of interconnected ideas which AKR build into his lectures and combined with poetry readings. The body of unpublished drafts of papers and lectures that are relevant to the present study can be thematically divided into nine groups: papers or lectures on poetry and the arts in general, Sanskrit aesthetics, classical Tamil poetry and poetics, bhakti poetry, contemporary Indian poetry, comparative literary studies, folklore, general studies on Indian literature and culture, and linguistics papers. Some of these drafts of essays and lectures are unique in their scope and in the way they treat aspects of culture, aesthetics, and poetry that are only randomly mentioned in his published work. Other unpublished writings reinforce or complement the principal points of AKR's poetic and aesthetic concerns formulated in the published essays.

1. Poetry and the Arts in General: No other text discusses art and poetry as forms of knowledge as openly and extensively as a handwritten lecture draft titled 'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?' (1993). AKR wrote this rough draft for a scientific Seminar on the Brain which he wanted to attend in March 1993 on a planned visit to India that he never undertook.³⁰ This undelivered lecture is probably one of his last pieces of formal prose that discusses poetry. The peculiarity of this handwritten lecture text lies in the untypical abstract manner in which the poet-scholar writes about concepts such as consciousness and knowledge in

connection with science, the imagination, poetry, and poetic tropes like metaphor and metonymy.

2. Sanskrit Aesthetics and Poetics: AKR was not a Sanskritist. He is known as a major south-Indian scholar, poet, and translator whose work contributed enormously to introduce Dravidian language and literature studies to a larger readership in India and the West. His pioneering effort in the field of south-Indian studies began in 1961 as a teacher of Tamil at the University of Chicago. However, as a poet and scholar in Indian literature, he was also interested in Sanskrit aesthetics and rhetoric, and in 1964 delivered a lecture on 'Sanskrit Poetics' at the School of Letters, Indiana University. A partly typed **(p.393)** and handwritten draft of this paper still survives. Rather than merely describing Sanskrit poetic devices, the lecture employs a comparative approach, making cross-references to Western poetics, critics, and poets. For technical Sanskrit terminology, AKR relied on fellow University of Chicago teacher and colleague Edwin Gerow, who had obtained his PhD in 1962 in Chicago, with a dissertation on Indian poetical terms.³¹

3. Classical Tamil Poetics and Bhakti Poetry: A number of other drafts of lectures are interesting sources as they complement or expand the themes of AKR's well-known published essays on classical Tamil poetics and bhakti poetry. These unpublished papers include a handwritten piece titled 'The Relevance of Tamil Classical Poetry', delivered as the Sir Ponnambalam Memorial Lecture at the University of Jaffna, Sri Lanka, in 1983; a typed draft of 'Karma in *Bhakti*', presented at the Third ACLS/SSRC Workshop on Karma, Pendle Hill, Pennsylvania in 1980; and 'The Vacanas of Mahadeviyakka', an early typed paper drafted around 1960 on the medieval Kannada bhakti poet-saint, which contains early versions of translated poems published much later in *Speaking of Siva*.

4. Contemporary Poetry: As has already been mentioned, AKR did not write extensively on contemporary poetry, though he was an avid translator of contemporary Indian poets into English. In 1979, he prepared a handwritten draft of a translator's note for a planned anthology of English translations of contemporary Kannada poetry which never went into print. This short introduction to twentieth-century Kannada poetry is AKR's only critical prose commentary in English on the modern Kannada poetry scene, of which he was a vital exponent in his own right.³²

5. Comparative Literary Studies: Two comparative essays, which bear the distinct AKR trait, are also to be highlighted among the unpublished papers. The more prominent of the two papers is 'Love and Death in Mysore and Venice', a typed draft completed in 1981 as a lecture for the Second Workshop on the Person in South Asia (Chicago).³³ This finished piece is a contrastive study of the cultural forms inherent in two literary works, the 1976 novel *Samskara*³⁴ by U.R. Ananthamurthy and *Death in*

Venice by Thomas Mann. As a comparativist essay, it examines the relation between art and culture by means of textual examples from the two works. In an earlier paper, '*Murder in the Cathedral* and Aristotle's Theory of Tragedy', an incomplete draft he typed around 1960 as a **(p. 394)** PhD student at Indiana University Bloomington, AKR had already explored the concept of art as a form of perceiving and expressing culture, and pointed to the specificity of a work of art and its shareholding with other literary art works.

6. Folklore and Oral Traditions: AKR's oldest project was a collection of Kannada folktales in English that he had worked on since the 1950s and which was published posthumously in book form in 1997.³⁵ In an incomplete handwritten draft of an essay drafted in 1988 and intended as the afterword to this Kannada folktale collection, the author compares the communication diagram of the folktale with that of a poem. Another relevant paper on folklore, poetry, and riddles is a handwritten rough draft of a lecture presented at the seminar 'Enigmatic Modes of Culture, with Special Reference to India' held at the University of Jerusalem in 1989. Titled 'When Is a Riddle Not a Riddle?' it describes the similarities and differences in the way riddles, myths, dreams, and poems are experienced and decoded, and thus discloses some of the poet's ideas on how poems work.

7. General Studies on Indian Literature and Culture: 'Nature and Culture in Indian Poetry'³⁶ is an incomplete handwritten piece that takes up the notion of a nature-culture continuum in Indian culture and poetry, as expounded in the collected essay 'Towards an Anthology of City Images' (1971).³⁷ Drafted around 1971 and delivered as a lecture at the University of California, Berkeley, in 1973, this attempts to contrast different approaches to the nature/culture paradigm in language, literature, and aesthetics. Another paper which survives as a handwritten lecture text is 'Translation and Culture'.³⁸ Presented at Carleton College, Northfield, Minnesota, in 1980, this draft resembles the uncollected published essay 'Parables and Commonplaces' (1982) in its emphasis on the mediating role of the translator, the poet, and poetry in cross-cultural and cross-linguistic studies. Also dealing with cross-cultural comparison and mythology is a lecture delivered at the University of Rochester in 1987 titled 'Creation in Hindu Myth and Poetry'. This typed unpublished draft shares part of its content with the collected essay 'Some Thoughts on Non-Western Classics' (1994). AKR often commented on his multilingual upbringing and the relevance of his childhood education to his work as a bilingual poet and trilingual translator. In a handwritten lecture text titled 'Sanskrit and the Mother Tongue', presented at the Association **(p.395)** for Sanskrit Studies in 1987, he describes the complex 'love-and-hate' relationship between Sanskrit and the south-Indian regional languages in his early Mysore environment, and points

out the aesthetic and social effects of Sanskrit on Dravidian languages, poetic traditions, and contemporary culture. Likewise, the typed lecture 'On the "Unity" and "Diversity" of Indian Literatures', delivered a year earlier in 1986 as the keynote address of the Indian Writers' Symposium at the 38th Frankfurt Book Fair, highlights the presence and conflict of three traditions in contemporary India—Western or international, national or father tongue, and regional or mother tongue, and their impact on modernity and poetry in India.

8. Linguistics Papers Applied to the Study of Poetry: Linguistics was AKR's principal academic discipline from 1958 till the late 1960s. During his years as a doctoral researcher at Indiana University Bloomington (1959–62), where he obtained a PhD in linguistics in 1963 for 'A Generative Grammar of Kannada', he received training in several linguistic theories and adjacent disciplines that were in vogue at the time, such as anthropological linguistics, generative grammar, poetics, stylistics, and semiotics. 'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry' (also titled 'On Poetry and Linguistics'), a typed essay drafted around 1960, remains his only technical paper dealing exclusively with the relationship between poetry and linguistics. Written at the crucial time of AKR's early moulding in the USA as a poet and linguist, it reveals, at least in part, the theories the scholar-poet was attracted to in the late 1950s and around 1960, and is, therefore, a fundamental source for the study of his theoretical poetics. Nonetheless, this early prose piece needs to be placed within the context of his early linguistics papers and incipient academic career in the USA, which was influenced by the crucial developments that took place during those years in literary and linguistic studies. True to the postulates of the famous linguist Roman Jakobson, who is cited several times, the essay discusses linguistics as a powerful tool for the analysis of poetry, and bears witness to AKR's early imbibing of, in particular, Russian Formalism, the Prague School linguistic theories, and structuralist poetics. On the other hand, in 1964 AKR typed a five-page project for a planned 300–350-page-long book on 'Literature as Language'. The sections he had sketched out for the book and the source material (by poets, critics, and linguists) he intended to draw from **(p. 396)** give us additional clues about his literary and critical leanings in the early 1960s.

Unpublished Lecture Notes

The AKR Papers contain thousands of handwritten notecards, now filed chronologically, which cover over 30 years of research and scholarship. Most of these are kept in card files which AKR had himself organized to some extent systematically and according to topic matter, but largely without following a strict chronological identification. Many of the writings are undated, but can be placed in an approximate timeframe going by the publications cited, the

handwriting style or the typeface used. The notes deal with all the subjects he taught and lectured on in the USA from the early 1960s till the 1990s. These include general linguistics, Dravidian linguistics, applied linguistics, Indian literatures, English and American literature, comparative literature and theory, translation theory, and other miscellaneous topics. AKR's lecture notes, in fact, illustrate the links between his work as a teacher, lecturer, and essayist. Many of his essays were first delivered as lectures at conferences and to academic audiences, and the notes and course material used in his classes provided the raw material for these lectures and essays. Some of the notes can be identified without much difficulty as fragments of early rough drafts for his public talks, readings, formal lectures, and conference papers.

The countless comments, outlines, sketches, lists, diagrams, quotes, aphorisms, and references contained in the notes, on the one side, prove how vast AKR's reading and spheres of interest were, and, on the other, yield valuable information on the manner in which he ordered and structured his ideas. The notes are mostly schematic, unorganized, but interconnected, and disclose how the scholar had the habit of working on several projects at a time and in more than one language. Despite this 'miscellaneous criss-crossing', a continuous search for order pervades his notecards. Within the countless charts, classifications, taxonomies, lists of motifs, and combinations of paradigmatic and syntagmatic relations, one can infer a persistent search for 'variable structures' which at times became an obsession. The tentative schemes served as provisional route maps with which the scholar-poet could carry out his manifold cultural and linguistic transactions. AKR characteristically followed a **(p.397)** comparativist approach in his search for a system. He was constantly crossing boundaries in this material as he zigzagged through cultures, disciplines, genres, periods, and languages, sometimes even diluting the division between scientific description and autobiography, and between public and private domains. From a thematic point of view, the main characteristic that comes to the fore in his scholarly prose is the recurrence of ideas. Questions and answers circulate in several avatars throughout his career, and are posed from different angles and within several disciplines. The relation between culture, nature, language, and poetry is one of such major preoccupations.

Chronological Classification of the Scholarly Prose

A chronological classification of the essays, papers, and other scholarly prose described earlier in this Appendix enables us to seek connections and parallelisms between published essays and unpublished material. Whereas most of the private prose writings can be dated with accuracy—for journal entries and letters usually carry a date—the scholarly prose, lecture drafts, essays, and lecture notes pose a number of problems in this respect. Of the lecture notes and notecards AKR used for his regular classes and talks, only a few are dated, so they can only be said to belong to an approximate time period after assessing a number of variables, such as the style of the handwriting or typeface, format

(notecards, for instance, were used after 1970), content (if the topic related to a particular published essay), and contextual factors (if the text was placed next to other dated material). Further methodological difficulties arise when it comes to dating the academic papers and essays. AKR often took many years to publish material he had drafted or delivered in public as papers at conferences, guest lectures, presentations, or informal papers. His essays typically went through several different drafts and versions until they were printed, and he often revised, changed, and grafted older material into newer pieces. In order to follow criteria that can yield a reliable textual history of the identified scholarly prose, both the earliest known draft and the first publication date of the published papers had to be identified wherever possible.³⁹ In some cases only a tentative year can be given for a first draft of a paper. The *Chronology of Select Books and Essays*⁴⁰ compiled by Dharwadker in *The Collected Essays*, though incomplete, is a useful aid, and it includes the dates for some first drafts that I could not trace in the AKR Papers. (p.398)

Chronological List of the Scholarly Prose⁴¹

1955	
(p. 1955)	'Notes on Walt Whitman'
(p. 1956, 1999)	'The Clay Mother-in-Law: A South Indian Folktale'
(p. 1956, 1999)	'Some Folktales from India'
1960	
(d. 1960)	' <i>Murder in the Cathedral</i> and Aristotle's Theory of Tragedy'
(d. about 1960)	'Linguistics and the Study of Poetry'; also drafted as 'On Poetry and Linguistics'
(d. about 1960)	'The Vacanas of Mahadeviyakka'
(d. 1964)	'Sanskrit Poetics'
(p. 1966)	'A.K. Ramanujan Writes ...'
(p. 1967, 1999)	'Varieties of <i>Bhakti</i> '
(p. 1967, 1970, 1975, 1994, 2004)	'Translator's Note', 'Afterword', <i>The Interior Landscape</i>
(d. 1968, p. 1971, 1999)	'Form in Classical Tamil Poetry'
(d. 1968, p. 1991, 1999)	'Repetition in the <i>Mahabharata</i> '
(p. 1968, 1999)	'Language and Social Change: The Tamil Example'

(d. 1968, p. 1989, 1999, 2004)	'On Translating a Tamil Poem'
(1960s)	Lecture notes and other academic prose
1970	
(p. 1970, 1999)	'Towards an Anthology of City Images'
(d. 1970, p. 1971, 1983, 1999)	'The Indian Oedipus'
(p. 1973, 1979, 1985, 1994, 2004)	'Translator's Note', 'Introduction', 'Appendix I', 'Notes to the Poems', <i>Speaking of Siva</i>
(d. 1973)	'Nature and Culture in Indian Poetry' ⁴²
(p. 1974)	'Indian Poetics' (with Edwin Gerow)
(d. 1976, p. 1999)	'Men, Women and Saints'
(d. 1979, p. 1989, 1991, 1995, 1999)	'Telling Tales'
(d. 1979)	'Translator's Note', for a planned anthology of contemporary Kannada poetry
(1970s)	Lecture notes and other academic prose
(p.399) 1980	
(d. 1980)	'Karma in Bhakti: With Special Reference to Nammalvar and Basavanna'
(d. 1980, 1983)	'Translation and Culture'. Also drafted as 'Translation in Culture'
(d. 1980, 1981, p. 1989, 1990a, 1990b, 1999, 2001)	'Is There an Indian Way of Thinking? An Informal Essay'
(p. 1981, 1993, 2004)	'Introduction', 'Notes to the Poems', 'Afterword', <i>Hymns for the Drowning</i>
(d. 1981a, 1981b)	'Love and Death in Mysore and Venice'; also drafted as ' <i>Death in Venice</i> and <i>Samskara</i> '
(d. 1981, p. 1982, 1999)	'Hanchi: A Kannada Cinderella'
(d. 1981, p. 1984, 1999)	'The Myths of Bhakti: Images of Siva in Saiva Poetry'
(p. 1982)	'Parables and Commonplaces'
(p. 1982, 1984, 1999)	'On Women Saints'

(p. 1983, 1999)	'From Classicism to Bhakti (with Norman Cutler)'
(p. 1983a, 1983b, 1983c)	'On Contemporary Indian Poetry'
(d. 1983)	'The Relevance of Tamil Classical Poetry'
(d. 1983-4, p. 1999)	'On Bharati and His Prose Poems'
(d. 1984, 1985, 1988, p. 1992, 1999)	'Food for Thought: Towards an Anthology of Hindu Food-Images'
(d. 1985, p. 1991, 1999)	'Three Hundred <i>Ramayanas</i> : Five Examples and Three Thoughts on Translation'
(p. 1985, 1996, 1999, 2004)	'Translator's Note', 'Afterword', 'Notes', <i>Poems of Love and War</i>
(d. 1985, 1988, p. 1989, 1999)	'Where Mirrors Are Windows: Towards an Anthology of Reflections'
(d. 1986)	'On the "Unity" and "Diversity" of Indian Literatures'
(p. 1986, 1999)	'The Prince Who Married His Own Left Half'
(p. 1986, 1999)	'Two Realms of Kannada Folklore'
(d. 1987)	'Creation in Hindu Myth and Poetry'
(d. 1987)	'Sanskrit and the Mother Tongue'
(d. 1988, p. 2001)	'Indian Literatures in the U.S. 1957-1987'
(p. 1988, 1999)	'Classics Lost and Found'
(d. 1988)	Essay intended to be published as an afterword to a Kannada folktale collection
(p.400) (d. 1988, p. 1990, 1994, 1999)	'Who Needs Folklore?'
(d. 1989)	'When Is a Riddle Not a Riddle?'
(1980s)	Lecture notes and other academic prose
1990	
(p. 1990, 1991, 1999)	'Towards a Counter-System: Women's Tales'
(d. 1991, p. 1994, 1999)	'Some Thoughts on "Non-Western" Classics: With Indian Examples'
(d. 1991, p. 1997, 1999)	'A Flowering Tree: A Woman's Tale'

(p. 1991, 1993, 1994, 2009)	'Preface', 'Introduction', 'Notes', <i>Folktales from India</i>
(p. 1992, 1999)	'Tell It to the Walls: On Folktales in Indian Culture'
(d. 1993)	'Can We Talk about Poetry Now?'
(d. 1993, p. 1999)	'Why an Allama Poem Is Not a Riddle: An Anthological Essay'
(d. 1993, p. 2001)	'The Ring of Memory: Remembering and Forgetting in Indian Literature'
(p. 1993, 1999)	'On Folk Mythologies and Folk Puranas'
(1990s)	Lecture notes and other academic prose

Altogether, the scholarly prose comprises notes, lectures, rough papers, and essays written over almost 40 years, from 1955 until a few months before AKR passed away in July 1993. Going by publication dates, the earliest one is the article on Walt Whitman from 1955, and the latest is the essay published posthumously in *Uncollected Poems and Prose* in 2001, 'The Ring of Memory: Remembering and Forgetting in Indian Literature'. Among the published sources there are the introductions and afterwords to the five translation volumes first published between 1967 and 1985, the introduction to the folktale collection released in 1991, and the collected and uncollected academic essays and papers, seven of which were published only posthumously between 1994 and 2001. The unpublished scholarly prose also includes 15 lectures and rough papers drafted approximately between 1960 and 1993. It is important to note that this survey does not account for the non-fiction in Kannada, which was to a large extent collected posthumously in *A.K. Ramanujan Samagra* (2011). In the 1950s, AKR had already published several prose articles in Kannada. He first started writing prose as well as radio plays in Kannada when he joined Maharaja College in 1944 at the age of 15. And he published his first **(p.401)** Kannada article as early as 1946, nine years before his first article in English 'Notes on Whitman' (1955) came out, in the *Literary Criterion* journal, which had just been founded by the renowned scholar from Mysore, C.D. Narasimhaiah, one of AKR's college teachers.

Unpublished Private Prose from the A.K. Ramanujan Papers

Any research work on a poet and his/her poetics would be incomplete without an analysis of his/her private reflections on poetry, inspiration, and writing. It is a special privilege when such type of material becomes available to the researcher for first-hand scrutiny. Private prose in the AKR Papers offers that rare opportunity to enter into the inner domains of the poet's thoughts and preoccupations. When brought to light for the first time in an academic study, it is the responsibility of the researcher to present the material in a systematic arrangement. The present classification offers therefore a first-time description

of the poet's private prose. These writings are placed within the context of the entire body of available primary sources (the referential contexts) and also set against the biographical backdrop (the situational contexts) outside these texts. Under the label 'Private Prose', we shall classify all non-scholarly, non-academic prose material in the Papers that was never published or intended for public use or for publication as such. However, certain aspects of AKR's private life made it into his scholarly essays. As we saw in Chapter 2, AKR often brought into academic discussion his family milieu and trilingual upbringing as a sample case and object of study. The private prose material that is listed here consists of unpublished journals and diaries, draft copies of letters, and other miscellaneous personal notes.

Journals and Diaries

AKR kept dairies and journals throughout his life from the time he was a teenager in Mysore, though he sometimes discontinued this practice for extended periods. Around the year 1970 he started to use loose card files for this purpose, and made it a habit to scribble, mostly in English, on small paper slips he carried with him wherever he went. He also kept what he called a 'dream book' and a 'commonplace book'. In these improvised notebooks he put down his reflections, impressions, feelings, and observations gathered from his travels and meetings, and social and academic events. These included incidents, (p. 402) conversations, reading excerpts, quotes, stories, and dreams (his own and those of others), and occasionally reflections on writing, writers, art, and poetry. In an interview conducted in India a few months before he passed away, AKR revealed: 'I keep a journal, not regularly, but I do keep a dream-book and have, for many years. I keep notebooks—small lined notebooks—into which everything goes. I write fairly often. For months, I write every day.... I also go back to them. They have little bits of poems and stories in them and observations.'⁴³

AKR distinguished between journal, diary, commonplace book, and dream notebook, though their formats were quite similar. In fact, they cannot always be identified as one or the other. Some of the handwritten journal excerpts and diary entries are intermingled with drafts of poems, lecture notes, and reading notes. The available entries in the Papers extend from 1949 to 1992 and cover the years 1949, 1957, 1959-60, 1967-85, and 1987-92, offering among other things a unique overview of the evolution of AKR's thoughts on poetry and poetics. AKR wrote in varying styles and formats, first in diaries and letter pads, and after 1970 on slips of paper and notecards. The notecards were kept in card files for storage purposes and to allow the author to revise and re-read his notes from time to time in a continuous dialogue with himself, as the following diary entry shows:

March 5, 1980.

Bought a bigger cardfile for all my diaries yesterday—rearranged them by year this morning, and felt nice.... Gave me some perspective that I've been struggling for—just glancing through my turmoil.... Making entries as Progoff⁴⁴ suggests has been also toward giving me some time-depth. I've also older diaries—found one for Madurai 1952; one for 60, both a few pages. Writing on these slips has been portable, and easy to file. That's why I've orderly files since '70.⁴⁵

We also learn from the journals that AKR was several times tempted to publish parts of his journal. He flirted with the idea of publishing 'A Journal' at least during 1976 and 1979, but his plans never materialized. In the autumn of 1976, he seemed to have made up his mind to publish a journal (see the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' in Chapter 2), but three years later his plan still lingered on, as we can read in another diary entry that underlines the benefits of keeping a disciplined journal:

(p.403)

Nov 9, 1979.

Fame, fortune, creative vitality in new areas seems missed, coveted, easy for others. Must change one's view of this, and one's ways. A stricter diary would help. A better daily schedule, that includes some writing on ideas as they occur. Maybe publish a Journal of ideas, a writer's notebook with no pretensions.⁴⁶

AKR had always wanted to publish fiction (a novel and short stories) in English. His diaries and journals are full of stories, anecdotes, and incidents that occurred to him or were told to him by others, and they also served as a means to gather material for his writing of fiction and poetry. Yet he succeeded in publishing autobiographical fiction only in his mother tongue Kannada, in which he wrote short stories and one novella.⁴⁷ It is probable that the fear of direct exposure to the public world that is repeatedly expressed in his diaries, and a lifelong preference for understatement and suggestion, prevented AKR from publishing a journal in English, the language of his public domain. Also, to venture into a new, autobiographical genre in English could have undermined his poetry in English, through which the poet spoke obliquely of his private life and self. Hence, apart from the folktales AKR translated into English, his journals remain his only non-scholarly prose written in English. As an anthropologist and professional collector of oral material, AKR applied his fieldwork expertise not only to folklore in India but also to routine life. His journals, besides containing autobiographical material, are full of 'real' stories, jokes, aphorisms, and quotes he heard or read. There is, in effect, an interesting correlation between the journals in English and the Kannada novella. The

novella deals with family relatives and the author's complex personality while it retains a half-protective literary mask, as AKR himself comments:

July 26, 1978

Just finished my Kannada novella, half-playful, half-serious, ambiguous work. Splits me into a younger amateurish historian of the self, and an older ridiculous R. who writes poetry and advises the younger about writing. Have used a lot of stories about my father's relatives etc. told about my mother.⁴⁸

We can infer, thus, that the journals are not purely self-reflexive exercises, and that his pretensions to publish them were not quite 'innocent' or far-fetched. Indeed, much of the private prose in the **(p.404)** journals (now, at last, part of a 'larger discussion') is not fully unaware of the potential reader. Even though AKR was his only reader in the diaries, one eye seems to wink at the other. The journals and diary entries include, among all the primary sources available, his most personal testimonies on art, poetry, inspiration and craft, the process of writing, and the notion of being a poet.

Letters

The AKR Papers contain unpublished letters dated between 1956 and 1993. The correspondence comprises mostly letters written to AKR, but there is also a substantial number of typed carbon copies and drafts of letters written by the author. These include official and academic letters, publication correspondence with his editors, and private letters. Very few of his letters carry comments on poetry, art, or his own poems, though some correspondence addressed to him (and thus not included here as primary sources), contains critical commentaries on poems he sent to friends, fellow poets, or colleagues, requesting their feedback.⁴⁹ One of the literary friends with whom AKR shared poems and translations was poet and translator Leonard Nathan at the University of California, Berkeley, who sometimes wrote to AKR with detailed critical comments. In the correspondence, AKR maintained with fellow Indian poets writing in English, such as Nissim Ezekiel, P. Lal, Adil Jussawalla, K.N. Daruwalla, and Gieve Patel, the topic focuses on publications, as many of these poets were also editors at some point or another, and Indian poets writing in English often helped other fellow poets in getting their work published in journals and anthologies (see Chapter 1). Among these, Ezekiel stands out in importance and in the number of letters exchanged, particularly in the years between 1964 and 1969, when both poets collaborated to find publishable material for the short-lived but highly praised landmark journal *Poetry India*, edited by Ezekiel from Bombay between 1966 and 1967.

AKR rarely discusses poetry or single poems in his correspondence. The letters, however, have a value mainly as historical records. A unique exception is a long letter written to Vrinda Nabar in 1978 in which AKR talks about himself and his poetry. It was drafted in response to a questionnaire Nabar had sent to seven poets as part of her PhD research work, so it is more in the format of a written interview than a letter.⁵⁰ On the other **(p.405)** hand, the correspondence with his editors at Oxford University Press in London dated between 1964 and 1970 provides important clues on the publication history of his first two volumes of poetry in English—*The Striders* and *Relations*. These formal letters reveal to some extent the process behind the selection of poems, and the poetic criteria applied to include or exclude poems and groups of poems in the final collections that were published. AKR also makes key remarks on the personal and poetic significance of the titles he had chosen for the two books of poems.

Poems on Art and Poetry or Meta-Poetry

Now we come to the second type of primary source: AKR's poems on art and poetry. As has been shown in the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, there are a large number of meta-compositions in AKR's work, which testifies to his experimental, and often self-reflexive, view of the artistic and poetic process. Many of these compositions were not published or intended to be published, and some were made public only posthumously. As opposed to academic prose, poetry follows both a linguistic and a literary code and is essentially 'deviated' or 'oblique' language, according to formalist as well as Sanskrit poetics. Therefore any thematic classification of a particular poem or interpretation of its meaning is a tricky affair. The poetic text tends to be multilayered and open to more than one reading, which makes its message more dependent on the receiver (the reader or listener) and on contextual factors than is the case with scholarly prose. That is, poems usually have several interpretative levels yet they may not all reach out to the reader, nor does a particular reading of a poem have to coincide with that of another reader (nor with the intention of the poet). It is, in any case, presumptive that the poetic output of an author contains his/her ideas on poetics and the art of composition.

One may consider AKR's entire poetic work as a primary source for an assessment of his poetics, or one can choose to attempt a tentative selection of poems that appear to capture a particular idea that is expressive of the poetic act. Of value to such a study are those poems that explicitly allude to art and aesthetics, to poetry and the process of making poems, and other interrelated subjects. Many of AKR's compositions combine reflexive and self-reflexive elements (see the section 'Quarrelling Relations: Towards an Appropriate Metalanguage' **(p.406)** in Chapter 2) and can be described as meta-poetic exercises. The unpublished drafts and poetic experiments, and the published poetry of the early and late periods in particular, often addresses the intricate relationships between art, poetry, and life, or between the mind, the maker, the making, and the poem as a work of art. In exploring the artistic process, a

number of meta-poems interrogate both the means and ends of poetry. In some cases, they turn into codified re-enactments or descriptions of the poetic event. This meta-poetic concern can be traced to various contextual factors in line with the artistic and professional evolution of the poet-scholar. The precise motives behind the poet's obsession with the internal and external dynamics of the act of composing, and his questioning of the autonomy of the poem and the role of the poet in this process, are analysed in the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4 and 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6.

Except for a few poems that are cited by the poet himself as illustrating aspects of his poetic belief, and for those poems which are given away by their title (provisional or final),⁵¹ the significance of a poetic text for the study of the author's poetic theory and practice can also be derived from a careful reading and from its intertextuality with other poems. Whichever method one follows, the delimitation and identification of meta-poems is, in any case, open-ended and non-exclusive. The present selection includes a provisional list of drafts and poems about art, aesthetics, poetry, and related themes that can be recognized for closer analysis. As is the case with the primary sources in prose, the poems can be classified as published or unpublished and in chronological order. All unpublished drafts and poems belong to the AKR Papers. The published poems are, additionally, identified as collected or uncollected poems. Poems from posthumous collections are also specified separately.

Published Poems

AKR published three collections of poetry in English during his lifetime: *The Striders*, *Relations*, and *Second Sight*. In addition, there are two posthumous publications of late poems: *The Black Hen*, a collection of poems that was included in *The Collected Poems* alongside the three previous volumes of poetry, and another set of late poems that had purposely been left out of the 1995 collection and was finally **(p.407)** published in *Uncollected Poems and Prose* (2001). *The Collected Poems* and the poems from *Uncollected Poems and Prose* were re-published in 2004 together with AKR's four translation volumes (published in 1967, 1973, 1981, and 1985) in *The Oxford India Ramanujan* edited by Molly Daniels-Ramanujan. All collections of AKR's poetry in English, but not all of his translation volumes, were originally published by Oxford University Press. *The Striders* was printed in London and the other two volumes simultaneously in New York and Delhi. Apart from these collections, there are also uncollected early poems which were published mainly in Indian journals during the late 1950s and in poetry anthologies of the 1960s.

Poems from *The Striders* (1966)

The only published poems that AKR recognizes elsewhere in his prose as being about poetry or the act of writing belong to his first collection. They are 'The

Striders', 'Which Reminds Me', and 'Still Another View of Grace'.⁵² 'The Striders', the key poem to AKR's poetic oeuvre, was first published in *Poetry* (Chicago) in 1961 with an additional first line that was later deleted: 'Put away, put away this dream' (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6). It is mentioned as a poem about poetry in a letter sent on 16 May 1965 to Jon Stallworthy, the then editor of Oxford University Press in London. Stallworthy wanted an attractive title for AKR's first collection of poems and suggested 'A Poem on Particulars' (the title of the last poem in the collection), as he was 'not entirely happy' with the title 'The Striders' chosen by the poet. AKR had to make his case for 'The Striders', the opening poem, and remarked in his response letter: 'The poem itself is about poetry and so I thought it might be appropriate for the title of the book.'⁵³ Another clue to this cryptic poem is offered by a published source the year the collection was released. In the *Poetry Society Bulletin* announcing the 1966 spring recommendations, which included *The Striders*, the author gives a brief interpretation of the poem and reveals the poetic preferences he had at that time (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6). Furthermore, the author refers to 'The Striders' and the poems 'Still Another View of Grace' and 'Which Reminds Me' in a journal piece dated 30 October 1976, in which he muses over the topics of grace, inspiration, and the art of writing poems (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' (p.408) in Chapter 6). In the letter responding to Vrinda Nabar's research questionnaire, and an interview conducted in 1990 by T.N. Shankaranarayanan and S.A. Krishnaiah,⁵⁴ AKR again cites the poem 'Which Reminds Me' as speaking for his notion of grace in life and poetry and his concept of poet. In addition to these poems mentioned overtly by the author, we may identify several other poems in *The Striders* that tell us something about poets, poems, and poetry: for example, the oft-cited poems 'A River' and 'A Poem on Particulars', the closing poem of the collection.

Poems from *Relations* (1971)

AKR's second collection of poetry in English contains a number of poems drafted in the 1950s and early 1960s which did not make it into *The Striders*, and a group of poems written in the late 1960s at the request of Oxford University Press. After the critical success of *The Striders*, Amen House, the Oxford University Press headquarters in London, wanted a new collection of poems, and AKR submitted a manuscript which included some reworked older poems. To this category belongs the poem 'Time to Stop', which is a revised version of a short draft of 1961 significantly titled 'Art and Life'. A later poem from *Relations* titled 'Any Cows Horn Can Do It' and drafted in the late 1960s also speculates on the multiple ways in which memories and poetry may affect life and life may get into poems.

Poems from *Second Sight* (1986)

Second Sight is a work of maturity and AKR's most carefully construed as well as experimental poetry collection. It took the poet 15 long years to come up with a format of poems that satisfied him enough to be taken into print. By the early 1980s he had a body of poems ready, but which acquired its final shape only in June 1984. As was AKR's usual habit, this third collection incorporated reworked versions of older uncollected or unpublished poems as well as a new set of compositions. Unlike the previous two volumes, however, the bulk of this work had undergone a long process of transformation, reflection, and experimentation, with forms, themes, and concepts drawing heavily on cultural and literary theory and Indian philosophy.

(p.409) Three poems drafted in 1984, 'Elements of Composition', 'Drafts', and 'Connect!' which were parts of a long piece titled 'Composition' in 1982, reflect on the all-encompassing process of creating and writing (see the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8 and Appendix 2). Composing and decomposing are key concepts in this collection, which yields multiple readings from the perspective of literary theory, philosophy, and poetics. 'On the Death of a Poem', as the title suggests, is another poem on the process of writing poetry. Drafted as early as 1961, it was originally intended for the series of short poems in 'Images' published in *The Striders*. Another poem from *Second Sight* titled 'He Too Was a Light Sleeper Once' speaks of the condition of the poet as he loses his creative impetus. The poem contrasts the 'light' side of creativity in innocent youth (the 'once' of the poet), with the unproductive, bitter present (the 'now' of the poet) after having gone through adverse experiences. This composition is, in fact, a version of the earlier poem 'On a Poet Now Silent' drafted in the late 1960s for *Relations*. The drafts in the AKR Papers indicate that the last five lines were composed as early as November 1959 during the poet's first autumn in the USA. This poem did not eventually make it into AKR's second poetry volume *Relations*, but was published in an anthology of Indian poetry in English in 1970.⁵⁵

Poems from *The Black Hen* in *The Collected Poems* (Posthumous, 1995)

The Black Hen, published in *The Collected Poems*, contains 60 poems written between 1989 and 1993, which were selected from the 148 poems that the author left behind on computer discs at the time of his death.⁵⁶ The poems were chosen by a team of eight editors and led by Molly Daniels-Ramanujan. Eleven of the poems had previously been published in reputed journals, which was probably an additional reason for including them in a volume of 'collected poems'. The editors picked for the title of this posthumous collection the 'The Black Hen', a short poem that had already been published in *Poetry Review* in 1993. In this collection of late poems that look simple on the surface, but conceal deep metaphysical concerns, the creative act and its uncontrollable effects become almost an obsession. Poetry is part of an existential struggle, as

both the author's life (increasingly under physical pain) and **(p.410)** his work seem to turn to the darker side of existence. Creation (birth) and destruction (death) serve as the axis of a number of poems. In 'The Black Hen', the title poem that opens the collection, the maker is both fascinated and horrified by the work of art. Several other poems in this posthumous collection deal with imagination, the dreamworld, and artistic inspiration, and explore the various ways in which the artistic object or the poem may relate to the life of its maker. We could single out the poems 'It', 'Love 6: Winter', 'Difficulty', 'Poetry and Our City', 'No Fifth Man', 'Bulls', 'Museum', 'Pain' in 'Images', and 'From Where?'

Poems from *The Uncollected Prose and Poetry* (Posthumous, 2001)

The editors of *The Collected Poems* decided to keep a set of poems from AKR's computer discs for a later volume of uncollected material comprising poetry and prose. This resulted in the publication of *Uncollected Poems and Prose* edited by Molly Daniels-Ramanujan and the poet Keith Harrison, who included in this volume 32 of the late poems that were deemed finished poems. Only one of the poems in *Uncollected Poems and Prose*, 'Invisible Bodies', had been published before in 1994.⁵⁷ Some of the poetic texts are, actually, versions of incomplete or fragmented poems published in *The Black Hen* in *The Collected Poems*. Whether this was done intentionally, since several versions of the poem were available, or whether it was due to editorial slips remains unclear. A detailed scrutiny of the computer printouts in the Papers suggests that the poems and fragments may not have been properly ordered by the editors of *The Collected Poems* and *Uncollected Poems and Prose*. Other compositions from the computer disc were considered by the editors to be writing exercises and remain unpublished in the AKR Papers.⁵⁸ Written largely in the same vein as the poems from *The Black Hen*, a handful of poems from *Uncollected Poems and Prose* speak about the unexpected causes and effects that connect the artist to his work and the created object to ordinary life. The poems that deal with meta-poetic and aesthetic issues include 'He to Me or Me to Him', 'Dances Remember Dancers', the latest dated published poem, and a four-stanza version of 'Museum' which was published as a one-stanza poem in *The Collected Poems*. Besides these, the poems 'Figures of Disfigurement', 'Children, Dreams, Theorems', 'Daily Drivel: A Monologue', and 'Love 10' make interesting observations on the process of creation and on the art of writing poetry as happening parallel to routine life.

(p.411) Uncollected Early Published Poems

Not all of AKR's published poems found a place in his poetry books, nor do the posthumous collections comprise his entire published work of poetry in English. Most published poems that remain uncollected are early poems that appeared in Indian periodicals, American journals, and anthologies between 1956 and 1970.⁵⁹ AKR published his first poems in English in the Indian magazines and journals *Illustrated Weekly*, *Thought*, and *Quest* between 1956 and 1958. Most of these poems were later discarded and only a handful was revised for publication

in *The Striders*. About 20 of these early compositions are still uncollected, though a number of them were reprinted in the numerous anthologies that saw the light in the late 1960s and early 1970s, when IPE and Commonwealth poetry in English were beginning to gain critical attention in India and around the world. Some early versions of poems published in *Second Sight* can, for instance, be found in anthologies published in 1970. As to the uncollected early poems in the American journals, it is to be noted that after moving to the USA in 1959 AKR published his first poems in these journals encouraged by Samuel Yellen, his professor in 'creative writing' at Indiana University Bloomington from 1959 to 1961. Some drafts of published poems in the AKR Papers carry notes with observations by Yellen. Throughout his life AKR continued to publish poems in American periodicals, most of which appeared later in his poetry collections. Only a few of the early poems published in American journals (*Folio*, *New England Review*, and *Chicago Review*) in 1959 and the 1960s are uncollected pieces. The acknowledgements in *The Collected Poems* supply a complete list of journals and anthologies in which some of the collected poems were first published. An exception is the late poem 'Stranger', which came out in *Poetry Review* in 1990, but, strangely enough, was not taken into account by the editors of *The Collected Poems* (1995) and *Uncollected Poems and Prose* (2001).

Of particular relevance in studying AKR's poetics are his few early poems on art and life, inspiration and writing that were published in Indian journals and magazines from 1956 to 1958. Some of these poems give contrasting views of art and aesthetics, or deal with the creative process of turning imagination into words and poems. Among these early poems are 'The World Is a Flower' and 'Transition' published in *Illustrated Weekly*; 'The Whip' and 'Carpe Diem' which (p.412) appeared in *Thought*; and three poems printed in *Quest*, 'Madura: Two Movements', 'A Poem on Logic', and 'No Dream, No Symbol'. 'On a Poet Now Silent', mentioned earlier as an early version of 'He Too Was a Light Sleeper Once' from *The Striders*, came out in the 1970 anthology edited by the poet Shiv Kumar. Finally, we should also list here the uncollected poem 'I Listened' printed in P. Lal's controversial anthology *Modern Indian Poetry in English* (see the section 'A Chronology of Writings on A.K. Ramanujan's Poetry' in Chapter 1).⁶⁰

Unpublished Poems and Drafts of Poems from the A.K. Ramanujan Papers

The last category of poems on art and poetry to be identified is the bulk of unpublished poems and drafts from the AKR Papers at the library of the University of Chicago, where the location of individual poems is not specified in the specific inventory or *Guide*. The numerous poems and drafts on art and poetry found in the Papers provide fascinating glimpses into AKR's poetics. The amount of meta-poems may seem surprisingly high to anyone acquainted only with the author's published poetry, but a prominent feature of this unpublished poetry is precisely its self-reflexive, often playful, quality. In the poet's routine writing exercises the self-conscious elements, in form and/or content, often emerge as meta-poetry. This may also explain why there are substantially more

meta-poems in the posthumous collections, which had not been planned in their existing form by the poet, than in his carefully designed lifetime collections. The fact that AKR had saved most of his drafts throughout the years (which is why they survive in his Papers) is in itself significant. We can infer from his notes that he valued the drafts as a reflection of himself, of his life-and-work history, so he continued revising and classifying old material up to the time of his death. A detailed analysis of the drafts and poems, therefore, opens up a new avenue in the critical study of AKR's poetic legacy. The unpublished poems and drafts have never been acknowledged or cited before in any published source or scholarly dissertation. The only mention of unpublished poems is made in *Uncollected Poems and Prose* by Molly Daniels, who clarifies in a note at the end of this posthumous volume that the batch of poems not considered for publication (out of the 148 in the computer discs) was 'in safekeeping' at the Regenstein Library of the University of Chicago.⁶¹ The poems referred to were composed between 1989 and 1993 and represent but **(p.413)** a fraction of the unpublished poetic material that can be scrutinized in the Papers.

Nonetheless, one should not uncritically compare the early drafts and unfinished pieces with the well-polished poems that went into the three poetry books AKR conceived and published in 1966, 1971, and 1986. The finished poems have been revised dozens, even hundreds, of times by the poet. The drafts, on the other hand, reveal the writing process and are of varied types. Some were 'valid' versions of poems whereas others were not intended as poetic end products, nor should they be analysed as such. They are in any case part of the poet's creative writing habits and now documents of his artistic biography. As drafts, we may understand early versions of published poems as well as unpublished poems. Among the unpublished poems, it is not always possible to determine which pieces were 'finished' poems and which were still rough drafts, for even typed or printed poems were sometimes completely rewritten, as we shall see ahead. The fastidiousness with language and the perception of poetry as craftsmanship were among AKR's known trademarks. Only poems that had been chiselled well enough over time were deemed fit for publication by the poet. For this reason, much of the unpublished poetry material in the Papers can be labelled as 'work-in-progress' and is of relative aesthetic value. As Daniels-Ramanujan's remarks in *Uncollected Poems and Prose*, some of the drafts read as 'surface verse' or 'writing exercises'.⁶²

The AKR Papers contain hundreds of drafts and unpublished poems in typed manuscripts and handwritten format, dated from 1947 to 1993. Only a selection of drafts and poems that reveal aspects of AKR's ideas on art and poetry are listed here. Several criteria (thematic and chronological, among others) may be applied to classify such miscellaneous poetic material. A key question concerns the artistic process and the 'maturity' of a particular text. As mentioned, there are in AKR's files fragments of compositions that never went beyond the handwritten rough draft and as such can be thought of as mere exercises. Other

pieces are revised drafts, but still read as unfinished poems. This can also be said of some of the poems that were published in the posthumous collections. As other cautious critics have commented in their reviews of *The Black Hen*, one gets the impression after several readings that the posthumous poetry collections do not entirely yield the kind of balanced, finished work that was AKR's forte.⁶³ Another category of compositions are **(p.414)** the reworked drafts and finished poems that were proposed for publication, but were eventually either rejected by the publishers or abandoned at some stage as alternative versions of a poem. That is, there are certainly pieces among the unpublished poetry that can stand as 'finished' AKR poems in their own right. One may conclude that each written draft or poem has a history of its own, however brief or long. Or, as AKR laconically put it, quoting 'once for all' French poet Paul Valéry, 'no poem is ever finished, only abandoned'.⁶⁴

The most functional criterion of classification is the chronological one, for a majority of the drafts were either dated by the author or can be given an approximate date by contrasting the typeface or handwriting of the text with that of other dated poems. The list of selected unpublished compositions on art and poetry given ahead is divided into four chronological periods in relation to key landmarks in AKR's poetic career: the place of living (India until 1959 and the USA after 1959) and the crucial years 1971 and 1986, which correspond to the dates of publication of the second and third books of poems, *Relations* and *Second Sight*. Poems written in the period between his arrival in the USA in 1959 and the publication of the first collection, *The Striders* (1966), have not been classified separately for the reason that there is an evident continuity in the poetry of the 1960s. The year 1966 does not mark a new chronological phase in AKR's poetry. Drafts from the early 1960s that did not make it into this first poetry collection were simply filed and revised by the poet for his second book, *Relations*. In its initial stage this second collection was to be titled 'Among Other Things', and this is the title that identifies most of the folders in the AKR Papers containing poems of the 1960s. Apart from the dates of the drafts or poems, the place (if stated), the type of manuscript, and the version (if applicable) are also detailed in brackets in the list.

Select List of Unpublished Compositions on Art and Poetry⁶⁵ 1950 to mid-1959: Compositions Drafted in India

'Bharata Natyam' (d. c. 1950). Handwritten.

'The Dance' (d. c. 1952). Handwritten, version of 'Bharata Natyam'.

'These Fairies' (d. mid-1950s). Typed, Belgaum.

'Bharathanatyam' (d. c. 1956). Typed, version of 'Bharata Natyam', Belgaum.

'Two Poems on Poetry' (d. 16-17 April 1956). Typed.

(p.415) 'Prayer before Suicide' (d. 19 November 1956). Typed; early version of 'Prayer before Suicide' (d. 14 February 1961).

'Another Apologie for Poetry' (d. 22 August 1957). Typed, also titled 'A Letter to an Editor or The Incubus'.

'Sonnet' (d. 25 November 1957). Typed.

'On a Word' (d. c. 1958). Typed, Pune.

'A Grammarians Song' (d. 1958-9). Typed.

'In Madurai I Saw a Quite-Human Hand' (d. late 1950s). Typed; early version of 'Madura: Two Movements' (p. 1957-8); some lines incorporated in 'Elements of Composition' (p. 1986).

Mid-1959 to 1971: First Period in the USA till the Publication of Relations

'Ballet for Prepositions and Others' (d. 2 November 1959). Typed.

'I, Even I Was a Light Sleeper Once' (d. 23 November 1959). Typed; early version of 'On a Poet Now Silent' (p. 1970) and 'He Too Was a Light Sleeper Once' (p. 1986).

'A Poem for Jazz' (d. 1960). Typed.

'Towards a Poem with Footnotes' (d. 1960). Typed; early version of 'A Poem on Particulars' (coll. 1966).

'Prayer before Suicide' (d. 14 February 1961). Typed; version of 'Prayer before Suicide', (d. 19 November 1956).

'Metre' (d. 1961). Typed; deleted part of 'Excerpts from a Father's Wisdom' (coll. 1966).

'Art and Life' (d. 1961). Typed; deleted part of 'Images' (coll. 1966).

'Metaphysician' (d. 1961). Typed.

'Some More Advice to the Young Poet, This Time from a Rabid Vedantin' (d. about 1961). Typed.

'A Song' (d. 11 November 1963). Typed; also titled 'A Song and the Monkey's Lung'; early version of 'Why Songs Don't Get Written' (d. c. 1970).

'Truants' (d. early 1960s). Typed; rejected by Oxford University Press for *The Striders*.

'On Getting the Last Line of a Poem First and Other Such Forms of Grace' (d. 20 February 1961). Typed; also titled 'On a Last Line Which Has Nothing Else and Other Such Forms of Grace'.

'Sample Entries in a Catalogue of Middle-Class Fears' part IV (d. early 1960s). Typed; early version of 'Entries for a Catalogue of Fears' (coll. 1971).

(p.416) 'The Fable of the Printer and the Moth, Chinese style, or the Dangers of Rushing into Print' (d. early 1960s). Typed.

'Dancers' (d. about 1967). Typed; rejected by Oxford University Press for *Relations*; version of 'Bharata Natyam' (d. c. 1950).

'Yet, When Some Dancers Dance' (d. late 1960s). Typed; first draft; version of 'Bharata Natyam' (d. about 1950).

'I Still Think It's Hard to Reach Some Words in Poems' (d. 1967). Typed; early version of 'Any Cow's Horn Can Do It' (coll. 1971).

'Why Songs Don't Get Written (d. about 1970). Typed; dropped from the final manuscript of *Second Sight*; version of 'A Song' (d. 11 November 1963).

'Occupational Habits' (d. about 1970). Typed; part of 'Ethnographic Notes on a Potter Caste, after Thurston'.

1971-86: Second Period in the US till the Publication of *Second Sight*

'Greedy for a Year of Poems ...' (d. August 1971). Untitled; handwritten in a journal.

'A Stab at a Poem' (d. 16 November 1972-27 October 1973). Typed.

'Yet, When Some Dancers Dance' (d. 1972-3). Typed; second draft; version of 'Bharata Natyam' (d. c. 1950).

'Yet Siva Is Sometimes Soma ...' (d. c. 1979). Untitled; typed.

'Soma, I Said Is No Visnu ...' (d. c. 1979). Untitled; typed.

'Jazz Poem for Soma' (d. c. 1979). Typed; contains the drafts 'Yet Siva Is Sometimes Soma ...' and 'Soma, I Said Is No Visnu ...'.

'On Discovering That Soma Is a Mushroom' (d. 1979). Typed.

'I Can't Get Close to a Poem ...' (d. c. 1979). Untitled; handwritten.

'When Soma Is Abroad ...' (d. c. 1979). Untitled; typed.

'Soma' (d. c. 1979). Handwritten.

'Poetry' (d. 31 July 1983). Handwritten.

'Fruit of Nothingness ...' (d. 31 July 1983). Untitled; handwritten.

'Composition', part 11 (d. 1982 to 14 May 1984). Typed; last version of 'Bharata Natyam' (d. c. 1950).

1986-93: Third Period in the USA after the Publication of *Second Sight*

'Translations', part V (d. 25 October-1 November 1988). Computer printout; tr. from the Kannada by the poet.

(p.417) 'Here and Now' (d. November 1989). Computer printout; tr. from the Kannada by the poet.

‘Waking Up in Ann Arbor’ (d. 28 November–1 December 1988). Computer printout.

‘A Meditation’ (d. 30 August 1989). Computer printout; tr. from the Kannada by the poet; early version of ‘A Mediation’ (coll. 1995); incorporates some lines translated from a medieval Kannada bhakti poem.

‘Haiku’ (d. c. 1989). Computer printout.

‘The Condition of Music’ (d. 18 January 1990). Computer printout.

‘Silly Couplets’ (d. c. 1992). Computer printout.

The years of the undated compositions have been estimated after reading hundreds of drafts written from the late 1940s to 1993, and cross-checking manuscripts in a variety of typefaces and handwriting styles with dated poems in the same group. Even so, it is not always possible to settle for a precise year, and in some cases only approximate dates are given. Most of the texts that have been selected here are either typewritten or computer printouts and had already been copied from first handwritten drafts, as was the poet’s habit. There are also six handwritten versions that are either first drafts of a poem, or compositions that were not deemed worth typing. It can be assumed in principle that not all handwritten drafts were kept by the poet and that even some typed poems may have been lost despite his archival care. Among the unpublished poems in this list are three drafts (dated 1988–9) that were marked by AKR as ‘translations’ into English of his own Kannada poems: ‘Translations’, part V, ‘A Meditation’, and ‘Here and Now’. They belong to a group of poems originally written in Kannada, which AKR intended to include in a book he had planned of collected poems in English. A revised, shorter version of ‘A Meditation’ was published posthumously in *The Black Hen* and in *Poems and a Novella*, which contains AKR’s Kannada poetry translated by others. The translators and editors of this last posthumous collection do not acknowledge that the poem ‘A Meditation’ in the volume is AKR’s own translation of his Kannada poem, and not the work of the translators N.K. Raju and Shouri (Molly) Daniels-Ramanujan. In fact, it had already been published posthumously as an original poem in English with the same title, ‘A Meditation’, in *The Collected Poems*.⁶⁶

As to different variants or versions of a poem, we can cite several cases among the identified drafts in which poems were redrafted over **(p.418)** a period of time, resulting in several ‘finished’ versions with almost the same content, but significant formal changes. AKR conceived such versions as ‘related poems, poems of the same family’.⁶⁷ There are, for instance, two different versions of the poem ‘Prayer before Suicide’, which was first drafted on 19 November 1956 and rewritten on 14 February 1961, and is related to AKR’s famous poem ‘Prayer to Lord Murugan’ published in *Relations*. Another remarkable case that speaks for the author’s unrelenting search for metaphors of artistic creation is the poem ‘Bharata Natyam’ (see the section ‘Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian

Philosophy’ in Chapter 5).⁶⁸ About a dozen different version of this poem on dance written over a period of 35 years can be found in the Papers. The poem was never published though it is known to his friends who attended his poetry readings in the 1950s. The last available version of the poem was written in May 1984 as part II of ‘Composition’, the long piece that had 26 sections at one point. But months later the lines on the dancer were dropped from this long poem, which was eventually transformed into a set of individual poems published in *Second Sight* (see Appendix 2). It is illustrative of AKR’s redrafting practice to list here the available dated versions of ‘Bharata Natyam’, which still remains as an unpublished dance poem with a long career of artistic failures:⁶⁹

Date of Draft	Title of Draft
(d. c. 1950)	‘Bharata Natyam’
(d. c. 1956)	‘Bharathanatyam’
(d. c. 1952)	‘The Dance
(d. c. 1967)	‘Dancers’
(d. late 1960s)	‘Yet, When Some Dancers Dance’ (first version)
(d. 1972–3)	‘Yet, When Some Dancers Dance’ (second version)
(d. 14 May 1984)	‘Composition’, part II

Landmark Phases in the Published and Unpublished Meta-Poetry

The published and unpublished poems and drafts that have been provisionally selected among the primary sources to study AKR’s ideas on poetry span 43 years from 1950 to 1993, covering almost every year during this period. These meta-poetic compositions can be divided into four chronological periods according to landmark events in the poet’s life: the year that the poet left for the USA (1959) and the publication dates of the second and third poetry collections, *Relations* (1971) and **(p.419)** *Second Sight* (1986). Consequently, we can recognize in AKR’s poetic career a first period in India that goes from 1950 to 1959, followed by three distinguishable periods in the USA: 1959–71, 1971–86, and 1986–93. In addition, we can identify several short phases in his life which yield a comparatively large number of such meta-poems:

1. The years from 1956 to 1959, which the poet spent as a lecturer of English in Belgaum and Baroda, and as a student of general linguistics in Pune.
2. The period from mid-1959 to the early 1960s, corresponding to AKR’s first years in the USA as a PhD researcher in linguistics.
3. The years from 1979 to 1984, during which the author strived to put together a new collection of poems after a fairly long period of barrenness.

4. The last five years in AKR's life from 1988 to 1993.

It is interesting to observe how, in these meta-poetic phases, AKR's biographical contexts converge with salient stylistic features and major preoccupations in his poetry:⁷⁰

1. The author's self-reflexive musings on 'being a poet' in his youth and his half-intended imitative play with the theories and writings of other poets he studied and taught during the 1950s in India.
2. The self-conscious concern with the language of poetry during the 1960s, which coincides with AKR's career in linguistics.
3. An explicit and playful experimentation with philosophical concepts in the 1970s and early 1980s, which corresponds to a period of inner search.
4. A more mature exploration of metaphysical issues in the late 1980s and in the poetry of the 1990s, which were years of psychological and physical distress.

Interviews and Recordings⁷¹

The last category of material to be identified and classified for the present analysis comprises the dozen and a half interviews that have been published in various formats in India and the USA since 1969, and the miscellaneous audio and video recordings that are available in private and public archives. Though it can be argued that printed interviews are not a very reliable source, as there is usually **(p.420)** no guarantee (unless the original recordings are available) that the content of the published text conforms to the actual words expressed by the interviewed, most of the interviews are valid sources and some are exceptionally valuable to assess AKR's thoughts on a variety of subjects.

Interviews

It has already been stated that AKR, unlike other Indian poets writing in English, did not publish specific prose pieces expressing his views on art and poetry as a contemporary poet, nor did he write critical articles voicing his opinions on other contemporary Indian poets. Hence, for the general reader and critic acquainted with AKR's work, the interviews are the main sources of information on the author's personal ideas about poetry. The format of the interviews is, of course, not comparable with that of AKR's writings, but unedited or only slightly edited interviews have the additional advantage of providing conversational, colloquial, and untailored primary content. As a rule, it is possible to verify the originality of an idea, comment, or remark in printed interviews by cross-checking the content with other published interviews, and by contrasting ideas with the notes and journals in the private prose. In some cases, however, the interviewer or editor may have shifted the bias on certain issues by leaving out material, or what is worse, may have manipulated or misinterpreted the content. A notorious case of misquotation is an interview conducted by M.N. Upadhyay in

1975, published in 1976 by *The Illustrated Weekly of India*.⁷² This interview was strongly repudiated by AKR. In a letter to the then editor of *The Illustrated Weekly*, the noted writer Khushwant Singh, AKR worded his discomfort thus:

I have just seen M.N. Upadhyay's interview published three months ago (Weekly, July 18, 1976), and I am appalled by it....

Several months ago I had sent Mr. Upadhyay a telegram asking him not to publish his article without my corrections.

I am grateful to you and Mr. Nissim Ezekiel for printing some of my poems which speak for themselves.⁷³

The letter includes a detailed enumeration of all the specific items in the interview that he denied to be of his own. Indeed, a close reading of this interview and comparison with other AKR interviews (**p.421**) and texts on similar issues soon makes any discernible reader aware of its oddities. Therefore, we can go along with AKR and invalidate the content of Upadhyay's interview. As to the other interviews identified ahead, they have been considered as original sources after thorough comparison and evaluation. For the most part, the ideas and style of expression attributed to AKR in all of these interviews are quite uniform, and reflect the tone and the treatment given to the same topics in the private prose.

I have been able to trace in total 19 publications in English which can be classified as interviews.⁷⁴ Eight of these publications (by M.N. Upadhyay, Chirantan Kulshrestha, Chidananda Das Gupta, Girish Shahane, Sangita P. Advani, Carlos Monteiro, Uma Mahadevan, and Jamie Kalven) were written in article form. In these articles, particular comments by AKR are either quoted or built into the text in the form of reported speech. The other 11 interviews (by T.K. Doraiswamy, V.M. Cherian, Chirantan Kulshrestha, Rama Jha, Murali Venkatesh, Vaiju Mahindroo [Naravane], Ayyappa Paniker, Purabi Banerjee, A.L. Becker and Keith Taylor, T.N. Shankaranarayanan and S.A. Krishnaiah, and Ayesha Kagal) follow the typical question-answer pattern of a live interview. Most of the interviewers are Indian journalists and literary critics who interviewed AKR when he visited India, where his fame had grown considerably after publishing in 1967 his first collection of translations from classical Tamil. Among the interviewers are also Western scholars and writers (Jamie Kalven, A.L. Becker and Keith Taylor), two folklorists (T.N. Shankaranarayanan and S.A. Krishnaiah), and two south-Indian poets (T.K. Doraiswamy and Ayyappa Paniker).⁷⁵ Chirantan Kulshrestha, a literary critic who first befriended AKR in Chicago during his research work on American novelist Saul Bellow, interviewed AKR twice in 10 years.

Chronology and Publication of the Interviews

Before examining the content of the interviews and the main topics that are discussed, we should ascertain which chronological phase of AKR's poetic career the interviews belong to. Not all interviews were published immediately after they took place. It is thus worthwhile to look at the publication history of interviews and their chronological distribution. Following is a list of all published interviews following the chronological order of the year the interview was conducted.⁷⁶ (p.422)

Year	Interviewer	Publication
1969	T.K. Doraiswamy	<i>Thought</i> (29 November 1969)
1969	V.M. Cherian	<i>Span</i> (August 1970)
1970	Chirantan Kulshrestha	<i>Uncollected Poems and Prose</i> (2001)
1975	M.N. Upadhyay	<i>The Illustrated Weekly</i> (8 July 1976)
1980	Rama Jha	<i>Times of India</i> (20 January 1980) <i>The Humanities Review</i> (January–June 1981)
1980	Murali Venkatesh	<i>Deccan Herald</i> , Bangalore (17 August 1980)
1981	Chirantan Kulshrestha	<i>Journal of South Asian Literature</i> (Summer–Fall 1981)
1981	Vaiju Mahindroo	<i>UNESCO Features</i> (1982)
1982	Ayyappa Paniker	<i>Journal of Literature and Aesthetics</i> (January–June 2002)
1983	Purabi Banerjee	<i>Hindustan Times</i> , Delhi (17 April 1983)
1983	Chidananda Das Gupta	<i>Span</i> (November 1983)
1989	A.L. Becker and Keith Taylor	<i>Uncollected Poems and Prose</i> (2001)
1990	Girish Shahane	<i>The Independent</i> , Bombay (28 July 1990)
1990	Sangita P. Advani	<i>Times of India</i> , Bombay (29 July 1990)
1990	Carlos Monteiro	<i>Midday</i> , Bombay (31 July 1990)
1990	T.N. Shankaranarayanan and S.A. Krishnaiah	<i>Indian Poetry in English: Critical Perspectives</i> (2000)
1992	Uma Mahadevan	<i>Economic Times</i> , Bangalore (1992)
1992	Jamie Kalven	<i>University of Chicago Magazine</i> (June 1992) <i>Span</i> (1993)

Year	Interviewer	Publication
1992	Ayesha Kagal	<i>Economic Times</i> , Bangalore (8 August 1993)

The interviews were conducted between 1969 and 1992, cover 23 years of AKR's life, and were published between 1969 and 2002. The first three interviews took place after the publication of *The Striders* and *The Interior Landscape*, the author's first books in English, which established him as a poet and translator, respectively. The subsequent eight interviews came out after *Relations* and the book of translations, *Speaking of Siva*, were published. Seven interviews fall into the period between 1980–3, an intense creative phase during which AKR (p. 423) published the translations of *Hymns for the Drowning* and prepared another book of translations, *Poems of Love and War*, and a collection of his own poems which eventually became *Second Sight*. Another eight items belong to the last four years of his life (1989–93). It is striking that almost no interview came out in the 1970s. A majority of interviews came out in newspapers, magazines, and scholarly journals shortly after they had been conducted. Four interviews were published posthumously long after they had taken place: one in an edited collection of articles and essays titled *Indian English Poetry: Critical Perspectives*, two in *Uncollected Poems and Prose*, and the latest in *Journal of Literature and Aesthetics*.⁷⁷ All but two talks (in *Journal of South Asian Literature*, Michigan, and *UNESCO Features*, Paris) were published in India, and three appeared both in India and the USA (in *University of Chicago Magazine* and *Uncollected Poems and Prose*). The two interviews brought out posthumously by Oxford University Press in *Uncollected Poems and Prose* (in New Delhi, London, and New York) are the only ones that reached a wide international readership. The other interviews, published in newspapers and journals (*Thought*, *Journal of South Asian Literature*, *Journal of Literature and Aesthetics*, and three in *Span*), had a more limited circulation.

Further comments need to be added on the posthumous publications. On 26 June 1990 AKR was interviewed by folklorists T.N. Shankaranarayanan and S.A. Krishnaiah in Kodaikanal, Tamil Nadu, while attending an international workshop on folklore. The interview, poorly edited, was published in the year 2000 in a collection of articles on IPE, although it deals mainly with the study of folklore in south India. On the other hand, the editors of *Uncollected Poems and Prose*, Keith Harrison and Molly Daniels-Ramanujan, decided to include in the collection of previously uncollected material two unpublished interviews conducted in 1970 and 1989. In 1970, Indian literary critic Chirantan Kulshrestha, who was then a young Fulbright Scholar in the USA, interviewed AKR at the University of Chicago. He did not publish this talk then, but kept up a literary friendship with AKR, as can be traced from the correspondence. On his second visit to Chicago about 10 years later, as a fellow of the American Council of Learned Societies, Kulshrestha undertook another interview, which came out in the *Journal of South Asian Literature* (Michigan State University) in 1981. The

other interview in *Uncollected Poems and Prose*, by Keith Taylor and A.L. Becker, both of whom also knew AKR personally, took place years later during AKR's stint as a visiting (p.424) professor at the University of Michigan (1989-90). Taylor transcribed the talk, edited it slightly, and sent a typescript to AKR, asking him to edit it so it could be sent to a magazine, but it had to wait over 10 years to be published in *Uncollected Poems and Prose*.⁷⁸ Though he did not get the chance to edit it thoroughly, AKR did some work on the text, and a copy of the interview with his handwritten changes and corrections is kept in the AKR Papers. However, the editors of *Uncollected Poems and Prose* seemed to have overlooked or ignored the corrected text, for the final published version is almost identical to the one in Taylor's typescript, except for very minor corrections which do not coincide with AKR's amendments.⁷⁹ The last published AKR interview was printed in the *Journal of Literature and Aesthetics* in 2002. Renowned scholar and poet Ayyappa Paniker recorded a conversation with AKR at the University of Chicago in 1982. Since then, the audiotope was kept in Paniker's residence in Trivandrum. Almost 20 years later, I was entrusted by Paniker the task of transcribing and editing this conversation for publication. Except for very few inaudible phrases and minor editing, the entire interview was published in its original conversational form in the *Journal of Literature and Aesthetics* from Kollam in Kerala. The interview is highlighted by J.O. Perry in his review article of the *Oxford India Ramanujan* in the following terms: '[A]n enormously revealing interview.... There is much more of AKR's unaffectedly self-aware and self-critical "way of thinking" (and being) in this interview to ponder....' In 2009, the then editor of the Sahitya Akademi journal *Indian Literature*, K. Satchidanandan, republished the conversation without crediting the earlier publication and editorial work (see also the section 'Evolution of the Critical Scene' in Chapter 1).⁸⁰

Contextual Aspects of the Interviews

AKR was not fond of interviews and was rather reluctant to expose any kind of personal opinion about his work in public. He was particularly careful when it came to discussing his own poetry in English and the poetry of other Indian poets writing in English: 'Opinions are only a small expression of one's attitudes. They are an uncertain, often rigid expression. One is more, and often less, than one's opinions. And they don't often match other things in oneself. So please read them as gestures.'⁸¹ At times, the author chose to shift the topic to issues he felt more comfortable with. He usually asked interviewers (p.425) to send him the typescript of the talk so that he could edit it before publication, which he rarely accomplished in time, as he himself concedes in a diary entry written in 1982:

4 Aug. 1982, Northfield, Minnesota

I'm terrified of interviews—so I cover up my nervousness with courtesy and cliché, hoping to rework it all in editing which I never get a chance to do. The interviewer can't wait. He sends me his transcript, which I dare not even read for months—and I'm appalled at my own inarticulate gibberish when I read it, I'm too busy to do anything about it quickly.⁸²

In some instances, AKR declined to discuss his own poetic work to the extent that it was possible without offending the interviewer or compromising the interview. In an untitled article in the Indian newspaper *National Herald* published in 1983, he is even quoted by the journalist as saying: 'Don't ask me about my poems. It's for others to say something about them.'⁸³ Other interviewers were quick to realize AKR's diffidence in their articles. Uma Mahadevan, for example, writes: 'He pauses for he is not comfortable talking about the "how" of his poetry.'⁸⁴ Furthermore, Girish Shahane, who titled his piece on AKR 'Working Out the Contradictions', almost complains about this coyness: 'He is reluctant to introspect about his poetry, and the new directions it has taken over the years. He believes that it might amount to "making claims" about his poems, which he wants to avoid.'⁸⁵ AKR preferred to let his poems speak for themselves. He was already adamant to comment on his poetry and IPE in the late 1960s, when he replied to a questionnaire that P. Lal had sent to Indian poets writing in English: 'I do not know how to reply to your questions because I have really no strong opinions on Indians writing in English.'⁸⁶ But there were rare occasions when the interviewer managed to engage the poet in thought-provoking and elucidative conversation on his poetry, including the poetic technique and artistic process. In such cases, he worded his statements very carefully and usually took pains to qualify questions, concepts, and assumptions that were either too general or which left him unprepared. Large issues hurled at him by the interviewer were frequently toned down to specifics that he deemed relevant to his own experience. Often, he had ready-made replies for questions that he anticipated, as the same issues used to come up during different conversations, thus many of his statements in the various interviews 'sound' like repeated versions of the same idea.

(p.426) Thus, there are contextual factors pertaining both to the author and interviewers that affected the style and the content of the interviews. AKR displayed a cautious attitude and self-conscious fastidiousness during interviews in which he nevertheless appeared to be courteous, casual, and relaxed. The concern for precision and nuance, and the need to be 'in control' of a situation during a conversation are traits which some people acquainted with him have also repeatedly remarked. The interviews, conducted by Chirantan Kulshrestha, Rama Jha, Ayyappa Paniker, and A.L. Becker and Keith Taylor in 1969, 1980, 1982, and 1989, respectively, stand out among the rest for their perceptiveness and in-depth treatment of issues that are highly relevant to AKR's poetics. Becker and Taylor taught at the University of Michigan and were familiar with AKR's work as a translator and poet. The three Indian interviewers, on the other

hand, are scholars with publications on Indian writing in English. Chirantan Kulshrestha authored several articles on AKR and edited an influential collection of essays on IPE. Ayyappa Paniker published extensively on Indian writing in English and served as the editor of a Sahitya Akademi anthology of Modern Indian Poetry in English. And Rama Jha has written a study on Indian English novelists.⁸⁷ Their background partly explains why their interviews probe into issues that were central not only to AKR's thinking as a poet, but also to the critical scene of Indian poets writing in English and in regional languages. These interviews also subtly deal with the issue of being a multilingual Indian poet in America and bring up the questions of poetic art and technique in a discerning and sensitive manner. They carefully seek out critical opinions from the author on the creative aspect of his work as a poet, the processes behind it, influences, and traditions, as well as comments on other writers and literary movements.

Recordings

In addition to the recorded interviews, there are a number of audio and video recordings of AKR's talks and readings of poetry. The modulation of the voice as well as the tone, stress, and accent in these readings provide additional clues to appraise AKR's notions on prosodic aspects of poetry. This material, therefore, complements the observations made by AKR on such subjects in the prose writings and interviews. The audio recordings include raw material from (p. 427) interviews and readings recorded in private gatherings, as well edited material from public lectures and readings kept in public libraries. There are also some video recordings of television appearances and footage of poetry readings for documentaries, some of which are archived with the AKR Papers.⁸⁸

Notes:

- (1.) See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for a list of unpublished lecture texts and essay drafts, and a complete inventory of AKR's published writings in English and Kannada, including edited and co-edited works.
- (2.) For full references of these works, see the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography.
- (3.) This refers to first publications and does not include later editions of published texts, nor works translated by others from Kannada.
- (4.) Ramanujan, 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry', pp. 51-63. None of the critical works on AKR mention this short essay. See ahead in this appendix and also Chapters 2 and 7. Though most of the published writings by AKR that are described here have already been cited in the chapters of the book, I may indicate the bibliographical references of works that are not part of the well-known posthumous publications.
- (5.) Ramanujan, 'On Bharati and His Prose Poems', draft (1983-4), in *CE*, pp. 332-43.

(6.) See 'Guide to the *A.K. Ramanujan Papers 1944-1995*', Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library (2010), <https://www.lib.uchicago.edu/e/scrc/findingaids/view.php?eadid=ICU.SPCL.RAMANUJANAK>. The University of Chicago indicates 1944-95 as dates for the collection, but, in fact, some documents in the Papers date from 1943.

(7.) AKR's collected Kannada works were published in 2011 in Ramakant Joshi and S. Divakar (eds), *A.K. Ramanujan Samagra* (Dharwar: Manohar Granthamala, 2011). Apart from the published Kannada poetry, plays, short stories, and novella, this collection also includes scholarly prose from early Mysore college publications and other magazines and periodicals, as well as some previously unpublished material. See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for a list of AKR's main works in Kannada.

(8.) I am not considering here, under prose, the tales that AKR collected in *Folktales from India* (1991) and in the posthumous *A Flowering Tree and Other Oral Tales from India* (1997), or the fictional prose in Kannada that was translated by others. See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for references of all posthumous publications.

(9.) 'Folklore' was a term the author did not fully approve of, as he preferred to speak of 'oral traditions', but both expressions are variably used in his prose.

(10.) In several essays, AKR highlights his anthological search in the title. See, for example, 'Towards an Anthology of City Images', 'Food for Thought', and 'Where Mirrors Are Windows: Towards an Anthology of Reflections', in *CE*.

(11.) Vinay Dharwadker obtained his PhD from the University of Chicago in 1989, where he also collaborated with AKR on the translation of modern Indian poetry during the 1980s, a project that resulted in the publication of the pioneering *Oxford Anthology of Modern Indian Poetry* co-edited with AKR in 1994.

(12.) Dharwadker, 'Preface', in *CE*, pp. vii-viii.

(13.) Ramanujan, 'The Ring of Memory: Remembering and Forgetting in Indian Literature' and 'For Barbara Miller' (eulogy), in *UPP*, pp. 83-100, 101-3. See further in this appendix.

(14.) In the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography, I have incorporated Dharwadker's bibliographical information from *CE* in the lists 'Earlier Publications of Collected Essays' and 'Early drafts of published essays and papers cited in *The Collected Essays*'.

(15.) The three preceding posthumous publications were *The Collected Poems* (1995), *A Flowering Tree* (1997), and *The Collected Essays* (1999).

(16.) The poems from *Uncollected Poems and Prose* are discussed in the section on poetry of this appendix and the two interviews, conducted in 1970 and 1989, have been classified in the section on interviews.

(17.) See Dharwadker, in *CE*, pp. viii, 127, and the footnotes by Daniels-Ramanujan and Keith Harrison in *UPP*, pp. 83, 85 for the only data on this text provided by the editors of the posthumous collections.

(18.) I am not counting here AKR's scholarly contributions to the *Encyclopedia Britannica* (1974), *Encyclopedia of Oriental Literatures* (1982), and *The New Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics* (1993), or the essays in his books of translations and folktales, which are considered below. *Encyclopedia Britannica* (1974), pp. 131–208 (articles on Dravidian literature contributed to the section 'Arts of South Asian Peoples'). See *Encyclopedia of Oriental Literatures* (1982), n.p. (15 articles on Kannada literature). Alex Preminger and T.V.F. Brogan (ed.), *The New Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1993), pp. 591–4 (articles on Tamil poetics and bhakti poetry in the section 'Indian Poetics'). See also the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography.

(19.) Ramanujan, 'A.K. Ramanujan Writes ...'.

(20.) See Ramanujan, 'Notes on Walt Whitman'. This is also the only essay of literary criticism in which AKR explains the theoretic background of his critical approach.

(21.) Ramanujan and Gerow, 'Indian Poetics', in Ramanujan *et al.* (eds), *The Literatures of India*, pp. 115–43. Sections 115–18 and 128–9 are by AKR.

(22.) Lecture paper delivered at the School of Letters, Indian University, AKR Papers (1964).

(23.) Ramanujan, 'On Contemporary Indian Poetry', also published as 'Contemporary Indian Poetry' in *Financial Express*, and as 'Is Poetry Dead?' in *The Times of Deccan*, Bangalore.

(24.) Among the collected essays, 'On Bharati and His Prose Poems' and 'Classics Lost and Found' are two rare published pieces dealing with contemporary poets and their relation to tradition.

(25.) Ramanujan, 'Indian Literatures in the U.S. 1957–1987', in Jacob (ed.), *American Understanding of India*. A typed manuscript is also available in the AKR Papers.

(26.) AKR's linguistics papers are listed in the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography.

(27.) The preface and introduction to a posthumously published collection of Telugu poetry, co-edited with Velchuru Narayana Rao and David Shulman, is not included here. A.K. Ramanujan, V. Narayana Rao, and David Shulman (eds), *When God Is a Customer: Telugu Courtesan Songs by Ksetrayya and Other Others* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1994; and New Delhi: Oxford University Press, 1995).

(28.) As mentioned in Margaret Dicky Uroff, typed letter to AKR (with handwritten reply by AKR below), AKR Papers (21 April 1981).

(29.) Ramanujan, 'Preface', 'Introduction', and 'Notes', in *Folktales from India*, pp. xi-xii, xiii-xxxii, 323-46. For this introduction, AKR used material from his essays 'Who Needs Folklore?' and 'Telling Tales', in *CE*, pp. 448-62, 532-52. Not all stories published in this book were collected by AKR himself. On the other hand, the unfinished collection of Kannada tales, *A Flowering Tree and Other Oral Tales from India* published posthumously in 1997, does not carry an introduction by AKR, as it was left unfinished.

(30.) Girish Karnad confirmed that AKR did not attend this seminar as he was unable to travel to India due to his acute physical grievance. Personal interview (June 2003).

(31.) Edwin Gerow's work on Sanskrit rhetoric was published as *A Glossary of Indian Figures of Speech* (The Hague and Paris: Mouton, 1971). See also Gerow, *Indian Poetics* (Wiesbaden: Otto Harrassowitz, 1977). The material of the lecture on 'Sanskrit Poetics' was eventually incorporated into the essay 'Indian Poetics' (1974, with Gerow), which is AKR's only published piece on Sanskrit poetics.

(32.) See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for AKR's publications in Kannada.

(33.) A later version of 'Love and Death in Mysore and Venice' was presented as '*Death in Venice and Samskara*' at Carleton College, Northfield, Minnesota. The main thesis of these papers on comparative approaches in literary studies is related to the collected essay 'Some Thoughts on "Non-Western" Classics: With Indian Examples', in *CE*, pp. 115-23.

(34.) *Samskara* was translated into English by AKR. See Ananthamurthy, *Samskara*, pp. viii, 139-47, 149-58.

(35.) See *FT*, cited earlier. The editors of the collection, Stuart Blackburn and Alan Dundes, acknowledge in the preface to this book the existence of an unfinished introduction to the tales that was not included in the final publication. Blackburn and Dundes, 'Editor's Preface', in *FT*, p. ix.

(36.) This lecture is related to another paper titled 'Conceptions of "Nature" in Indian and English Poetry (with Examples from Classical Tamil, Classical Sanskrit, and Seventeenth-Century English)', lecture presented at Carleton College, Northfield, Minnesota (1981).

(37.) The dates given for essays that were collected in *CE* refer to the first publication.

(38.) A similarly titled lecture, 'Translation in Culture', was presented as the K. Kailasapathy Memorial Lecture in Colombo, Sri Lanka, in 1983.

(39.) In some cases, only a tentative year can be given for a first draft of a paper.

(40.) Dharwadker, in *CE*, pp. 597–600.

(41.) The items listed here are ordered chronologically by the first available drafts.

(42.) In *PLW*, this unpublished paper is cited as a lecture delivered at the University of California, Berkeley, in the year 1972, but in the AKR Papers the lecture is mentioned to have taken place in 1973. See Ramanujan, *PLW*, p. 313.

(43.) AKR quoted in Kagal, 'A Poem Comes Out of Everything One Learns', p. 12. Close friends of AKR such as S. Krishnan, Girish Karnad, and others have also pointed out his almost obsessive habit of recording every detail. Personal interviews (September 1999 and November 2000).

(44.) This is a reference to Jungian-trained psychologist Ira Progoff, who developed the intensive journal method.

(45.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (5 March 1980).

(46.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (9 November 1979).

(47.) During 1976, the year AKR recorded his desire to publish a journal, he wrote the first draft of his only novel, *Matthobhana Atmacharitre*, a largely autobiographical novella in Kannada published in 1978. He expressed in a diary entry of 17 August 1982 that he also wanted to write a novel in English. *Matthobhana Atmacharitre* has been published in English translation as *Someone Else's Autobiography* in *Poems and a Novella* (pp. 214–323).

(48.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (26 July 1978).

(49.) For an alphabetical list of AKR's professional correspondence (dating from 1958–3), see the 'Guide to the A.K. Ramanujan Papers' of the University of Chicago library.

(50.) Ramanujan, letter to Nabar.

(51.) Some of the early drafts or versions of published poems that had revealing titles at some point in time were eventually changed.

(52.) An early version of 'Still Another View of Grace', titled 'A Poem on Logic', was published in the Indian journal *Quest*. See Ramanujan, 'A Poem on Logic', *Quest*, vol. 3 (February 1958), n.p.

(53.) Jon Stallworthy, typed letter to A.K. Ramanujan, AKR Papers (1 April 1965). Ramanujan, typed letter to Jon Stallworthy, AKR Papers (14 May 1965).

(54.) Shankaranarayanan and Krishnaiah, 'Interview with Professor A.K. Ramanujan', in Dodiya (ed.), *Indian English Poetry*, pp. 86–116. See the classification of interviews ahead in the appendix for more details.

(55.) Ramanujan, 'On a Poet Now Silent', in Shiv Kumar (ed.), *Indian Verse in English 1970* (Calcutta: Writers Workshop, 1970), n.p. See also below under 'Uncollected Early Poems'.

(56.) See Krittika Ramanujan, 'Preface', in *CP*, p. xv.

(57.) Ramanujan, 'Invisible Bodies', *The New Yorker* (1994).

(58.) See Molly Daniels-Ramanujan, 'A Note on A.K. Ramanujan's *Uncollected Poems*', in *UPP*, p. 104. Some of the rejected poems are classified ahead under 'Unpublished Drafts of Poems'.

(59.) See 'How We Learned about Grasshoppers and What' (early version of 'A Minor Sacrifice', *Second Sight*), in Howard Sergeant (ed.), *Pergamon Poets 9: Poetry from India* (Oxford: Pergamon Press, 1970). 'On a Poet Now Silent' (early version of 'He Too Was a Light Sleeper Once', *Second Sight*), in Shiv Kumar (ed.), *Indian Verse in English 1970* (Calcutta: Writers Workshop, 1970), n.p. A comprehensive list of all the uncollected poems is provided in the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography.

(60.) Ramanujan, 'The World Is a Flower', 'Transition' (early version of 'I Listened'), *The Illustrated Weekly of India* (October 1956–September 1957); 'The Whip', 'Carpe Diem', *Thought* (November 1957–December 1957); 'Madura: Two Movements', 'A Poem on Logic' (early version of 'Still Another View of Grace', *The Striders*), 'No Dream, No Symbol', *Quest*, vol. 3 (August 1957–February 1958); 'I Listened' (revised version of 'Transition'), in P. Lal (ed.), *Modern Indian Poetry in English: An Anthology and a Credo* (Calcutta: Writers Workshop, 1969).

(61.) Daniels-Ramanujan, 'A Note on A.K. Ramanujan's *Uncollected Poems*', in *UPP*, p. 104.

(62.) Daniels-Ramanujan, 'A Note', in *UPP*, p.104.

(63.) See, for instance, Bruce King, 'Maturity: Moraes, Peeradina, Ramanujan, Patel, Shetty, Mehrotra, Daruwalla, de Souza, Alexander', in *Modern Indian Poetry in English* (2001), p. 303.

(64.) AKR first quoted Valéry in this context in the Poetry Book Society Bulletin (1966). See also Ramanujan, 'Translator's Note', in *PLW*, p. xv; and Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan', p. 181, quoted in Chapter 6.

(65.) In the case of untitled poems, the first line is quoted.

(66.) See Ramanujan, 'A Meditation', in *CP*, pp. 239–40. Compare with 'A Meditation', in *Poems and a Novella*, pp. 163–4.

(67.) AKR quoted in Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', p. 150.

(68.) The poem starts with a description of a dancer. Bharatanatyam is a south-Indian classical dance form originating from a sacred Hindu temple dance, *sadir*, which was revived in the twentieth century as a stage dance and became one of the prominent dance styles in India under the present name.

(69.) The poem from *UPP*, 'Dances Remember Dancers', is not connected with these versions.

(70.) Comprehensive biographical details and their relation to the poet's aesthetics and poetics are analysed in Chapter 3 and the section 'Biographical Factors and Poetic Creation' in Chapter 6.

(71.) A list of interviews and audio and video material with references is provided in the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography.

(72.) M.N. Upadhyay, 'A.K. Ramanujan', *The Illustrated Weekly of India* (8 July 1976), pp. 21–3.

(73.) Ramanujan, letter to Khushwant Singh, editor, *The Illustrated Weekly of India*, AKR Papers (12 October 1976).

(74.) The interviews in Kannada have not been taken into account here. Apart from these interviews, there are also a number of other articles by journalists or critics, which include short quotes with comments by AKR. In the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography, interviews and articles come under separate categories.

(75.) T.K. Doraiswamy and Ayyappa Paniker are reputed poets in Tamil and Malayalam, respectively. Both scholar-poets were professors of English in Trivandrum, Kerala.

(76.) The date of the interviews is derived from the text, publication date, or other contextual factors. Some interviews came out in various publications and/or versions. Though listed here, the 1976 interview by M.N. Upadhyay is not treated as a valid primary source. Except for interviews that are quoted, complete references for all interviews are provided in the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography.

(77.) The *Economic Times* published an interview by Ayesha Kagal hardly a month after AKR had passed away in August 1993. Rama Jha's interview appeared first as a short article in the *Times of India* (1980), and about a year later a longer version was edited for the *Humanities Review* (1981).

(78.) The posthumously published interviews here referred to are: Daniels-Ramanujan and Harrison (eds), 'Chirantan Kulshrestha and AKR' and 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor, and AKR', in *UPP*, pp. 41–51, 52–82; Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan', pp. 181–4. Kulshrestha passed away in 1982 soon after his second visit to Chicago.

(79.) In the AKR Papers, there is a typed note by Taylor attached to the typescript of the interview which AKR edited.

(80.) Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords', pp. 139–50. See also *Indian Literature*, vol. 254 (November–December 2009), pp. 171–87.

(81.) AKR quoted in Daniels-Ramanujan and Harrison (eds), 'A.L. Becker, Keith Taylor and AKR', in *UPP*, p. 42.

(82.) Ramanujan, diary, Northfield, Minnesota, AKR Papers (4 August 1982).

(83.) AKR quoted in an anonymous article, *National Herald* (16 May 1983).

(84.) Uma Mahadevan, 'Abstractions Are Escapist', *Economic Times*, Bangalore (1992).

(85.) Shahane, 'Working Out the Contradictions'.

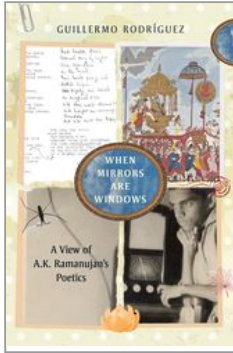
(86.) Quoted from AKR's published letter to P. Lal, which was a reply to the questionnaire (on whether and why Indians should write in English) that Lal had sent out to hundreds of poets writing in English. AKR's comments were included in Lal's 1969 anthology. A.K. Ramanujan, 'Response to P. Lal's Questionnaire', in *Modern Indian Poetry in English: An Anthology and a Credo* (Calcutta: Writers Workshop, 1969), pp. 444–5.

(87.) For Kulshrestha's and Paniker's articles on AKR, see the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography. On Paniker's critical writings on IPE, see the section 'Multicultural

Contextualization' in Chapter 2. See also Rama Jha, *Gandhian Thought and Indo-Anglican Novelists* (Delhi: Chanakya Publications, 1983).

(88.) See the A.K. Ramanujan Bibliography for more details.

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(p.434) Appendix 2

The Making of a 'Composition': A.K. Ramanujan's *Second Sight*

Guillermo Rodríguez

The Making of a 'Composition': A.K. Ramanujan's *Second Sight*

This appendix is intended to throw further light on the making of AKR's last collection of poems in English during his lifetime: *Second Sight*. It was published by Oxford University Press in 1986, when AKR was at the peak of his career (he received the prestigious MacArthur Prize Fellowship in 1983), and had at the age of 57 reached a state of intellectual and artistic maturity. *Second Sight* has been considered his most challenging, intellectually dense, and multilayered poetry collection. It has been seen as 'different'¹ in many ways from his other two collections in English: *The Striders* (1966) and *Relations* (1971). This third collection came out after a long gap of 15 years since his previous book of poems in English *Relations*, following a period in which the poet-scholar had been very active as a translator. From 1973 to 1985, he produced the landmark anthologies of translations of medieval bhakti poetry (*Speaking of Siva*, 1973; *Hymns for the Drowning*, 1981) and classical Tamil Sangam poetry (*Poems of Love and War*; 1985), and translated U.R. Ananthamurthy's famous novel *Samskara* (1976) from Kannada. He combined this intense translation work with collaborations in several other academic projects and the publication of his second collection of poems in Kannada (*Mattu Itara Padyagalu*, 1977) as well as his Kannada novella (*Matthobhana Atmacharitre*, 1978). At a personal level, the 1970s also coincided with some of the most complicated and distressing years in AKR's life as he went through a series of personal crises, marital problems, and professional challenges.

As a creative writer of poetry in English, however, his *Selected Poems* (1976) was the only publication in this span of time, and it did not contain any new poems. The years from 1971 to 1986 should therefore be regarded as an *experimental period* in AKR's poetry in English in **(p.435)** which he was more concerned with *process* than with publishing poetry as polished artefacts. And this artistic, experiential, and visionary phase of experimentation at both the formal and conceptual levels, which produced trials and 'failures', abandoned and revisited work, is intrinsically linked to the long creative process that led to the making of *Second Sight*. I therefore follow a chronological order in this descriptive summary and textual genealogy that touches on the thematic and textual complexities as well as on the evolution of AKR's poetic oeuvre during the period identified and beyond. Some of the information detailed in this appendix has already been introduced in the chapters of the book, but I have attempted to organize it here in a broader chronological perspective.

The Soma Sequence of Poems (1972-82)

The Soma Concept

As has been emphasized in diverse contexts in the sections 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4, 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5, 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6, and 'Medieval Bhakti Poetics and Oral Poetics' in Chapter 7, the concept of soma had profound implications in AKR's aesthetics and poetics and is rooted in his intellectual history and personal use of Sanskrit myths and motifs. We find in his writings as much a de-mythologization and deconstruction of the concept, as an inquiry into it from the point of view of the multiple aesthetic environments—pan-Indian (Sanskritic), regional (bhakti and folk), and Western—that feed into his system of thought and expression. Soma is cited in the Vedas as a plant, a drug and a god, the 'lord of speech, leader of poets, and seer among priests' (see the section titled 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5).² Soma, therefore, is often referred to as the source of creative imagination, and in AKR's associations it covers a wide semantic territory with physical, metaphysical, psychedelic, mythological, religious, and literary connotations. Depending on the context, it can be a personal metaphor for the mind, the soul (versus the body), the self or jivatman, inspiration or inspired consciousness, a mythological god-figure or substance, a symbolic motif of the moon, or an elixir, 'food of the god', a mushroom and a drug. These multiple interrelated layers of meaning that are interrogated in his notes and **(p.436)** reverberate in the background of AKR's poems dedicated to the subject can be classified under three main categories:

1. Modern Western and Indian contexts.
2. Indian Sanskrit traditions: Vedas, Brahmanas, Upanishads, etc.
3. Virasaiva and Alvar bhakti traditions (related to the notions of rebirth, possession, etc.).

An interest in mescaline, peyote (a cactus), mushrooms, LSD, and other hallucinogenic substances was fairly common in the hippie culture of the 1960s among writers and artists, who followed the excesses of the revolutionary poets of the Beat Generation. Much earlier, the word 'Soma' had gained notoriety in the West after the publication of Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* in 1932 (see the section titled 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5), where it is referred to in a negative sense. As a confluence of life, science, art, poetry, and philosophy, Huxley's psychedelic experiments described in *The Doors of Perception* (1954) partly inspired Allen Ginsberg and the poets of the Beat Generation to try out hallucinogenic mushrooms, LSD, and other substances. AKR contextualized this intellectual interest in hallucinogenic experiments and translated their psychological-philosophical imports into his own condition as a Hindu (Brahmin) exploring the Vedic *root* of 'Soma'. Just as peyote is and was used by the Mexican native priests (shamans) to 'talk to God', some scholars speculate that the Brahmins used Soma as their divine drink. The Soma concept as 'lord of speech' reminds us also of AKR's translations of the mystic Alvar poems on the god Visnu possessing the poet, and there are many references to this in his poetry drafts and notes. In 1979, AKR worked at the same time on a collection of Soma poems and on the translations of medieval Tamil Alvar poetry at Carleton College (Northfield, Minnesota) where he was a visiting professor.

We may end this introduction to Soma by quoting from two published essays by AKR that describe the concept, one in the context of the Vedas as a 'psychedelic juice', and another later text in connection with food and ritual:

Soma ... is psychedelic, mind-blowing, not exactly social—probably a sacred mushroom, a juice for which maybe the body itself is the ultimate filter. It is part of the ecstatic religion of the time, not easily contained by social arrangements. (1976)³

(p.437) Food is called Soma and that represents the female or Mother principle whereas Agni represents the male or Father principle. When Agni is satiated with Soma that is the normal order of the Yajña (the sacrifice). (1985)⁴

Brief Chronology of Biographical and Literary Contexts

The following is a brief chronology of biographical and literary details that may help us situate AKR in the background of his personal circumstances⁵ as well as within the literary-cultural milieu of his time until the 1970s when he started writing the first 'Soma Poems'. By listing or connecting here diverse events and persons, I am not suggesting a causal relationship between them.

1947–9

AKR reads medieval Kannada vachanas (from 1947), Bertrand Russell and Aldous Huxley (in 1949), and wants to be a generalist. Intellectually rebellious, his attitude is also counter-Brahminical in religious and social matters, and as an incipient poet, he does not want to follow the older contemporary Kannada poets.

1956

Meets fellow 'modernist' poets writing in English, Nissim Ezekiel, and Gieve Patel, and publishes first poems in English.

1957

Publishes transcreations of Kannada vachana poetry.

1958

Publishes a short article on *1984* by George Orwell titled 'Inverted Utopias: No Thrush on the Bough', which mentions Soma in relation to the body rooted in the past.

1959

Attends a conference by Huxley in Chicago soon after arriving in the USA for the first time.

1960

Allen Ginsberg tries hallucinogenic mushrooms under the guidance of Timothy Leary. The Beat poets also use LSD, marijuana, etc.

1962

Ginsberg and Orlovsky visit India, Calcutta, Bombay, and other cities. They read poetry in Bombay before Indian poets like Nissim Ezekiel, R. Parthasarathy, and others. Several of these poets Ginsberg meets in India are also literary friends of AKR, who is in Chicago that year where he joins the University of Chicago and gets married to Molly Daniels.

1967

Nissim Ezekiel visits AKR in the USA and teaches a course on Indian Writing in English at University of Chicago in March. In April, Ezekiel has his first LSD trip in New York.⁶ AKR spends the second half of the year at Berkeley. His American poet friends in California include Josephine Miles (1911–1985), a significant poet and literary critic who mentored the younger Beat poets at Berkeley, where she taught at University of California, Berkeley in the 1940s and 1950s. Other poets mentioned by AKR are Robert Beloof (**p.438**) and Leonard Nathan (who taught at the Department of Speech, University of California, Berkeley). AKR also knew Ginsberg and had met him in the USA.⁷

1968

Publication of the book *Soma: Divine Mushroom of Immortality* by Robert Gordon Wasson which includes a chapter by Wendy Doniger titled 'The Post-

Vedic History of the Soma Plant'. Doniger later became a colleague and friend of AKR at University of Chicago after she joined in 1978.

1969

Works on translations of vachanas for *Speaking of Siva* (1973).

1971

Divorces Molly, who is in Delhi with their two children. Depressed, takes marijuana and also mescaline given by a friend. Writes notes and poems during the experience with the drug which he later marks as the 'Mescaline Notes' (28–9 August 1971). In these notes, he refers to Huxley, as well as to Samkhya philosophy, the Hindu concepts of rebirth and continuity through change, etc., and cites medieval Virasaiva woman saint Mahadeviyakka and her vachanas on endless rebirth. During the mescaline trip, which is described as an experiential tour de force, he relates to the outer world and external stimuli both as a heightened aesthetic experience and as an existential search for an 'inner truth' leading to the body as pivotal axis.

Chronology of the Unpublished Soma Sequence and List of Poems

Unlike other writers and poets before him, AKR had no supervisor or guide present during his experiment with mescaline. His written record is the only witness to this experience, and while he might have planned to write about it, he could not have predicted to what extent his poetic side would respond to it. AKR wrote notes and poems during and after the effects of mescaline and observed on the next day: '10:40 Mind still popping with "poems".... Mind full of play making mescaline poems.... Must make a few poems for Brad and Stefan—with Stefan's Soma translation as epigraph.'⁸ A number of the Soma poems can be traced to these rather frenzied poetry scribblings—'mescaline poems'—which evolved through the years into a 'sequence', a larger body of poems he intended to publish under the title of 'Soma' in the early 1980s:

1972

First Soma poems typed, some derived from the unorganized lines written during and after the mescaline experience (see list of poems ahead).

1974

Makes important revisions to the Soma poems.

(p.439) 1976

Connects Soma with food cycles, metamorphosis, and the caterpillar image. Poem titled 'Annamayam', after the Sanskrit text *Taittiriya Upanishad*, 2.2 (February 1976), appears next to the deleted phrase 'Soma, a sequence'.

1978

Wendy Doniger joins University of Chicago in 1978. The notes in the AKR Papers mention scholarly discussions with several of AKR's colleagues, including Doniger, on the subject of Soma.

1978-9

Reworks Soma poems during the same time that he translates the medieval Tamil Alvar compositions. A few Soma poems appear intertwined with lines from the translations (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

1979

Writes the autobiographical poem 'On Discovering that Soma Is a Mushroom', in which he refers to himself as 'R'. Several draft versions are filed of this poem.

1980

Starts reworking the Soma sequence into a collection. Speaks for the first time on Soma poems in an interview (Venkatesh, August 1980), where he also refers to psychedelic experiences, and in letters (see, for example, Kulshrestha to AKR, 18 April 1980).⁹

1981

Comments on Soma poems in another published interview by Kulshrestha (1981), who writes: 'The drafts are very unlike the poems Ramanujan has published earlier; still, they bear, in a turn of phrase or in the particulars of an image, his unmistakable signature. There is a marvellous sequence of "soma" poems which adopt non-realistic means to cope with stubborn realities....'¹⁰

1982

Mentions Soma to Ayyappa Paniker in an interview (first published in 2002) as the title for his new book of poems in English. Defines Soma as the paradoxical experience that 'one calls *divine* in ordinary life'.¹¹

Later in the year, however, the poems of the Soma sequence are partially transformed or abandoned. This is the last year that AKR writes poems with the title 'Soma'. In fact, the word 'Soma' appears crossed out in most drafts of this sequence, and it cannot be found in any of the published poems.

AKR starts working on a new project titled 'Composition' (see the section ahead).

In one of the folders in the Papers containing Soma drafts, these are a few short notes next to the draft 'Jazz Poem for Soma' (from the period 1979-80), which give more clues about the poet's personal adaptation of this 'Vedic imagery'. 'Soma,' he writes, stands for 'moments of insight, joy, sorrow, when we are beside ourselves.'¹² AKR's adoption of Vedic and Upanishadic concepts, images, and motifs was a typical feature of his poetry and always posed a challenge to him. In the (p.440) interview conducted in 1980 when he first announced that he would publish a book of 'Soma poems', AKR made the following statement on his use of the past and the connections between Soma and his poetics: 'The problem about using myths is that I have to make the past speak to present concerns in a way that is not ideological. I've tried it out though in my "Soma

poems”.... Poetry happens unbidden and has to protect itself. The psychedelic experience taps precisely such experiences.... In my “Soma Poems” ... the extraordinary occurs in a most ordinary fashion, something like the way a poem happens¹³ (see also the sections ‘The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition’ in Chapter 6 and ‘Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing’ in Chapter 8). The sequence of typed and handwritten Soma poems that I have been able to identify in the AKR Papers was drafted over 10 years (1972–82) and contains the following unpublished poems, some of which cannot be directly traced to the ‘mescaline poems’ (1971):

Unpublished Soma Poems and Drafts (d. 1972–82) That Are Not Traceable to the ‘Mescaline Poems’

‘Soma: He Reads a Newspaper’, based on an early draft of ‘Looking and Finding’ (d. 21 March 1971). Also titled ‘He Looks and Finds’.

‘Soma: He Reads an Old Letter’ (d. 1972).

‘Soma: He Reads a Letter from His Wife’ (d. 1972).

‘Soma: He Takes a Driving Lesson’ (d. 1972).

‘Soma: He Attends a Conference’ (d. 18 December 1974).

‘Soma 1 and 2’ (d. 1978).

‘Jazz Poem for Soma’ (d. 1979–80).

‘Soma: He Is Converted’ (d. 1979).

‘Soma I Said Is No Siva’ (d. 1979).

‘Soma Is No Visnu, I Said’ (d. 1979).

‘When Soma Is Abroad’ (d. 1979).

‘Soma’ (d. c. 1982), new draft.

Unpublished Soma Poems and Related Drafts (1972–84) That Can Be Traced to the ‘Mescaline Poems’

The drafts and poems listed here are linked to the ‘mescaline poems’ in that they may draw from the 1971 experiment an idea, an image, a few lines, or, in some cases, even large parts of the text. Wherever possible, I have indicated the year of the draft.

(p.441) ‘Soma: He Suffers in the Heat’ (d. 1972).

‘Soma: He Can Neither Sit Nor Go’ (d. 1972).

‘Soma: He Watches TV’ (d. 1976). Later titled ‘Photographs of War’ (11 June 1984, see ahead).

‘Soma: Sunstroke’ (d. late 1970s).

'Soma: He Looks into Himself' (d. late 1970s).

'Soma: He Looks at Autumn Leaves' (d. late 1970s).

'Soma: He Is Hungry but cannot Eat' (d. late 1970s).

'Soma: He Looks at a (Persian) Rug' (d. late 1970s).

'Soma: He Looks at Himself' (d. c. 1979).

'On Discovering That Soma Is a Mushroom' (d. 1979). Also titled 'Soma'.

'He Looks at a Broken Bottle' (several drafts from 1979 till 1984 with similar titles).

'Photographs of War'¹⁴ (several drafts from 1976 till 11 June 1984, earlier title 'Soma: He Watches TV').

In addition to these unpublished poetry drafts, it must be noted that there are a couple of poems not originally from the Soma sequence of poems that also contain text from the 'mescaline poems' and were finally published in *Second Sight* (1986):

'Extended Family', first drafted in August 1971 during the mescaline experience (see the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4).

'Looking and Finding', first drafted in March 1971 before the mescaline trip; contains the second and third stanzas of the unpublished draft 'Soma: He Is Hungry but cannot Eat' (which derives entirely from the mescaline notes); these two stanzas were incorporated into the final 1984 version of 'Looking and Finding' along with the early draft by the same title from 1971 that became, at some stage in the 1970s, part of the Soma sequence with the title 'He Looks and Finds', and 'Soma: He Reads a Newspaper' (see earlier in this section and ahead in the section titled '*Second Sight* at Last: The Published Collection of Poems [1986]').

Composing and Decomposing a 'Composition'

At some point in 1982, AKR decided to tone down the Soma project. He changed the titles of several Soma poems, transformed a number of drafts, and abandoned others altogether. There may not have been a single reason for him to take the decision of discarding the Soma sequence as a collection to be published as such. The journals imply (p.442) that it was AKR's fear that people would misunderstand his work and draw too much attention to Huxley and the Soma concept in *Brave New World*, which had different connotations that he wanted to avoid altogether. Whatever his motives behind this change, from 1982 AKR started concentrating on a new project he called 'Composition' that explored the multiple meanings of this expression. It integrated many of his earlier concerns with the body and the senses, Whitman, Hindu philosophical ideas, rebirth, the Upanishads, Buddhism, psychoanalysis, and free association,

and was distinctly meta-poetic. It was also influenced by classical Tamil poetic techniques. He had just concluded his translations of the medieval bhakti poetry of the Alvars (*Hymns for the Drowning* was published in 1981), and in 1982 resumed his translation work of classical Tamil poetry (which resulted in *Poems of Love and War*, 1985). 'Composition' was first a long poem which grew into 26 parts in 1984, and was finally cut into shorter interconnected 'compositions'. When this material was published in *Second Sight* in 1986, it survived as 12 separate poems and was intermingled with early poems of the 1960s, some of which had earlier been rejected by Stallworthy from Oxford University Press, London (see the section '*Second Sight* at Last: The Published Collection of Poems [1986]' ahead). The chronology of this fascinating creative process begins as follows:

1982

AKR works on a new poem titled 'Composition'. The first versions of this poem are developed from an earlier unpublished poetry draft titled 'Because', probably written the same year. This untypical title, and the whole poem, is a response to the question 'Why Translate?' (deleted above the title of the draft), where *translation* implies both literary translation (he mentions 'ancient Tamil waterfalls' in the poem) and the soul's rebirth. His journals on 'Composition' in the AKR Papers reflect the stages of his *organic* process and the emotional distress when inspiration did not come so easily:¹⁵

25 July

Writes in his 'Journal on "Composition"' written in Northfield, Minnesota, of how he attempts to find the right tone for this new poem that is partly inspired by Whitman:

It's too personal now—the 'I' not large and non-personal—find a central tension—the above theme of needing to enlarge self without mysticism, pomposity, generality etc.

(p.443) Add incidents—a running central image: composing, decomposing—a passage on a compost—like Whitman's, but should be different (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

4 August

AKR is still striving for new poems; 'disappointed' and 'unhappy with the quality' of what he has written. Pursues new themes in old concepts and material:

Struggling to start new poems—to repeat nothing. Don't know how to begin. My belief and practice: they must 'come as leaves to a tree or not at all!' (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

Have to do entirely new things—think on new themes—look through my poetry notes—make some regularly—as I used to.

Touch-tack, out of touch, see my old poem on 5 senses—and not repeat it—

Sending poems might help write more

Themes—one could go by the classical *rasa*—love, heroism, anger, pathos, disgust, terror, wonder, laughter (see the section 'What Moves: Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4).

28 August

AKR's poetry writing comes to a relative standstill. Continues searching for change and inspiration in other poets to start something new:

Seeking as I'm now, to change, to write new poems, to finish things I began 20 or even thirty years ago, and to begin in new ways—I'm casting about in poets and their lives (see the section titled 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poetry and Poetics' in Chapter 7).

1983

His avid reading of contemporary poets does not bear the desired fruits. He writes in his diary on 21 July:

I'm feeling a bit limbo, even barren. For the past month, I've been reading poetry—Frost, Stevens, Heaney—every day hoping a poem would begin within me. Nothing so far. I'll simply read, without expectations of writing, which has become hard ... (see the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4).

(p.444) True to AKR's 'belief and practice', a compulsory perusal of these poets alone does not lead to new poems, but there are several other rediscoveries in 1983 that will nurture his new poetic enterprise:

1. He starts psychoanalysis therapy and wants to become a (Jungian) psychotherapist. Writes even playful poetry about it, such as 'In CJ's Office', which appears before the draft 'Questions and Watchers'.
2. He visits Sri Lanka in June and regains interest in Buddhism. On 31 July, he writes a draft of the unpublished poem 'Fruit of the

Nothing Tree' (see the section 'The Poetic Act or the Art of Composition' in Chapter 6).

3. Around this time, he connects the 'Composition' concept with the passage from the *Mundaka Upanishad*, 3.1.1 on the two birds on the same tree representing the watcher and the agent in the self (see the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5). This passage will eventually open the poem 'Questions' in *Second Sight*.

1984

Writes a draft of the essay 'Food for Thought: Towards an Anthology of Hindu Food-Images', which includes the 'Food Chain' poem from *Taittiriya Upanishad*, 2.2,¹⁶ drafted earlier in 1976 with the Sanskrit title 'Annamayam' (see the section 'The Soma Sequence of Poems [1972-82]' earlier in this appendix).

Works substantially on the long poem 'Composition', making important changes, such as structuring the composition as one long piece now divided into 26 sections.

14 May

Notes in satisfaction that he has finally found the right 'form and tone' for the long poem:

... putting together my poems, after 10 years. Especially one long poem called Composition now, which was my despair because I liked what I wanted to say but never could find a form and a tone, which I seem to have found.

He also chooses the final verse format of two and half lines, like a *kural*, a fourth-century Tamil prosodic form:

Two lines of 10 and/or 8 syllables followed by a 4-5 syllable, an expanded *kural* where the short lines allow you to clinch a thought, **(p.445)** and run on. I'd be happy to have finished this volume, though I've been scared of letting it go ... fear of criticism mainly, fear of disappointment (see the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8).¹⁷

30 May

The 'Composition' has now 26 sections (C 1-26) under the same title without separate subtitles. I have been able to identify most of the sections of this long draft with corresponding poems published in *Second Sight* (1986), as listed here:

Composition 1-4: Elements of Composition' (with images from 'Madurai: Two Movements' published in 1957).

C 5: unpublished.

C 6: 'Questions', part 2 (except for stanza 1).

C 7: 'The Watchers', part 1.

C 8: 'A Poor Man's Riches 1' (last two stanzas correspond to an earlier poem titled 'Two Persimmons').

C 9: 'Alien' (lines 2-3 and lines 14-16 from an earlier poem titled 'Two Persimmons') and 'A Poor Man's Riches 2' (stanzas 3 and 7).

C 10: 'Dancers in a Hospital', part 1.

C 11: Unpublished (corresponds to a draft of a poem titled 'Yet, When Some Dancers Dance', also as 'Dancers', an old poem first drafted in the 1950s which was rejected by Oxford University Press for *Relations* in the early 1970s, see Appendix 1).

C 12: 'Dancers in a Hospital', part 2.

C 13-14: 'Connect!'

C 15-16: 'Middle Age'.

C 17: 'Drafts', part 1.

C 18: Unpublished.

C 19: 'Drafts', part 2.

C 20: Unpublished.

C 21: 'Looking for the Centre', part 4.

C 22: 'Waterfalls in a Bank' (stanzas 1-5).

C 23: Unpublished.

C 24-6: 'Waterfalls in a Bank' (stanzas 6 till the end).

After settling on this temporary division, AKR continues to work on this extensive poem. As if the long barrenness of the previous years suddenly unlocked a waterfall of images and words, he hopes to integrate in the new

composition his entire universe, including old fears, quarrels, epiphanies, and 'ordinary' insights of his life:

(p.446) My dream is to write some poetry, verse, every day—include in it my entire world ... mythology, scepticism, sensuality, ineptitude, divorce, impotent obsessions-deaths¹⁸ (see also the section 'Biographical Factors and Poetic Creation' in Chapter 6).

Second Sight at Last: The Published Collection of Poems (1986)

Between June and September 1984, AKR made up his mind to rework the structure of the long 'Composition' and split it into eight sections with separate titles. This decomposed 'Composition' was then called 'Elements of Composition' in his notes and diaries, as is clear from a letter written to him by his friend Keith Harrison dated 16 June 1984.¹⁹ The eight new sections or poems are listed from A to H in his Papers and have the following titles, some of which coincide with titles of poems from *Second Sight*:

- A. 'Composition' (also titled 'Elements of Composition').
- B. 'Questions and Watchers'.
- C. 'Breaking Through' (also as 'Two Persimmons').
- D. 'Connect!'
- E. 'Middle Age' (also as 'Reason').
- F. 'Drafts'.
- G. 'Looking for the Centre'.
- H. 'Waterfalls'.

Contrary to what Dharwadker observes in the introduction to *The Collected Poems*, "'Elements of Composition" was in the year 1985 no more the draft of a "single, long poem".²⁰ AKR may have shown him the early, still complete version of 'Elements of Composition' (arranged in 26 sections) sometime in the first half of 1984, as he then broke up the long poem into shorter individual pieces later in the year. From September 1984, AKR finally put together his new collection of poems for publication. The 'Composition' is fragmented into further 'elements'—individual poems—all made up of tercets with a common thread and formal design. He also inserts or 'adds' (as the opening poem 'Elements of Composition' says in line 14) new pieces as well as lines and ideas from older poems and elements from his life and 'previous lives', dreams, insights, and fears in an exercise of intertextuality and personal reflections. Maintaining a homogenous **(p.447)** metrical form, AKR also provides thematic links between the poems so that poem flows into poem. His thoughts and images 'clinch' on and off, and 'run on' like an intermittent waterfall into a river: poem speaks to poem as one image or idea lights up another, an effect that AKR had admired in Yeats and classical Tamil poetry (see the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8).

There is a unity of design but without the grand epic flavour of Wordsworth or Whitman, or of the contemporary Indian tradition of Tagore or Sri Aurobindo. The sequence also lacks the modernist pretensions of T.S. Eliot's *Four Quartets*. In his personal *anxiety of influence* (see the section 'Nineteenth- and Twentieth-Century Poets and Poetics' in Chapter 7), AKR was 'afraid of criticism' that would interpret his new work from such critical perspectives if he kept the composition as one piece. Thus, the central theme of the body composing and decomposing into macro and micro elements within the continuous flux of life (lives) is carried over to the creative act, that is, to art. A poem for AKR is a 'composition' made of textual tissue, words, and images that are fragments from and of his mind. Perhaps he decided to decompose the long 'Composition' into smaller pieces to conform to his belief that 'truth is in fragments', as Dharwadker suggests,²¹ though this phrase—which survives as a line in the *Second Sight* poem 'Connect!'—was already there *before* he split the long poem into smaller pieces. AKR's 'truth' lies in particulars, in 'food cycles' and poetry cycles, in text that is composed of other text and then decomposed or deconstructed, and in writing as process: all of these 'truths' contain theoretical notions that 'connect' with poststructuralist and postmodern theories. For, to quote Barthes' *The Death of the Author*, 'writing is that ... space ... where all identity is lost, starting with the very identity of the body writing.... the book itself is only a tissue of signs, an imitation that is lost, infinitely deferred.... [T]he text is ... a multi-dimensional space in which a variety of writings, none of them original, blend and clash' (see also the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7). And so, by decomposing his 'composition' of 26 sections in the act of writing, AKR enacts in his poetry the very same biological process that he describes in the diaries and poems. It is left to the reader to compose the individual pieces, the ideas, and the formal structure back into a whole anthology of *reflections* (in the multiple senses of the word) and impressions. And this could go on and on in his entire body of writings and *translations*, as in the Visnu poems of reincarnation in the *Hymns for the Drowning*.

(p.448) At a different plane of interpretation, we may say that it took AKR over a dozen years to transform into published poetry the physical and aesthetic tour de force of continuity, endless sensorial flow, and 'structure and variation' that he had registered during the mescaline trip, and some of the related Hindu notions and ideas he played with (Soma, food cycles, rebirth, self as watcher and agent) in the mid-1980s. The best of this poetry reads as if—at last—his body poetic had matured to reach a momentary state of *grace*, that is, an (illusory?) 'second sight', and as if it were *reliving* the physical hallucinogenic experience of being suspended between a fragmented reality and an unstoppable flowing continuity. Because the *body* and its 'elements', as he aims to prove, also comprise the textual body. Fragments of his earlier poems and other texts are incorporated into his body poetic along with echoes from other poets and traditions into a new *text* in an intertextual exchange and dialogic continuum

with AKR's personal 'tradition' or biography as a poet (in this sense his *biopoetics*). All of it becomes *part of* 'the elements of production' (see the section 'Transacting with the Past: Tradition and Writing' in Chapter 8) of a new composition, as 'a new tissue of past citations' (see also the section 'Western Theories and the Study of Poetry' in Chapter 7).²² In other words, the attempted result is a *composition* that is decomposed while composing new and old tissue in a recirculation process that is a continuous give and take. As AKR explained in his notes, it is a kind of *bioenergetics* (see the section 'What Moves? Interpretation of the Aesthetic Experience' in Chapter 4): by 'exercising' or writing poetic exercises and 'eating other tissue' new tissue is being created and at the same time old cells are burned, that is, eaten. Ideally there is no creator, no 'original'; all drafts are only copies of cells that split from other cells, as in the Hindu myth of creation, where prakriti (nature) is not created, but 'already remade'. AKR already clarified in 1976 that 'one cannot will or "compose" a poem (despite Poe), yet one works at it over and over till it reaches a focus, a clarity. One makes only by re-making it. Like the notion of "Nature" in *Samkhya* and elsewhere—a ... [*Prakriti*], "already made"—yet to be remade into [*Samskriti*] ...'²³ (see also the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5). The poems of 'Elements of Composition', as well as AKR's translations of Vaisnavite mystic poetry and folktales, tell us that a text is not an external or dead entity. It is made up of gross matter and subtle matter, that is, the poet's body of material nature (organic, chemical, elements, the primal matter **(p.449)** that passes and circulates through it) and the non-material thoughts and feelings (the mind or soul). And the poet-scholar reminds us that 'tales and dreams ... take metaphors literally. Such literalization is not merely a literary device. It implies the sense that emotions and thoughts are substances. Material and nonmaterial things are part of a continuum of "gross" (*sthula*) and "subtle" (*sukhma*) substance, allowing transformations. One may become the other'²⁴ (see the section 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5).

By April 1985, AKR had 'put together' the new volume he had so long strived for and it was ready for publication.²⁵ The same year, before publishing *Second Sight* with Oxford University Press in 1986, AKR also submitted for publication to the journal *Indian Literature* two poems that originated from 'Composition', namely, 'Looking for the Center' and 'Elements of Composition', which were part of the *Second Sight* collection.²⁶ Now, the critical moment of piecing together this new collection of poems came when AKR combined the 'new' poems derived from 'Composition' with revised versions of older poems from the late 1950s, 1960s, and early 1970s, some of which had been rejected earlier by Oxford University Press. Whether AKR made the right choice when interspersing older poems with the material from '(Elements of) Composition' may not be the foremost issue here. The question perhaps is whether AKR's anxiety as an established poet who feared comparison with other well-known bards, made him

take his 'de-composing' or dismantling process too far when giving shape to *Second Sight*. In line with the critical comments in Dharwadker's introduction to *The Collected Poems*, and in view of the scarcity of wider critical debate on *Second Sight* (especially in the early 1980s and 1990s), it can be asserted that AKR finalized the poetry collection in such a form and fashion, that many of the specialized literary critics and most of his readers missed the point. In part since 'second sight' (and sometimes irony)—as ordinary as it may at times seem—is, more often than not, a *rare sense* of *grace*. Many readers may have overseen the unconventional, perhaps over-sophisticated, unity and coherence that AKR wanted to achieve in this mature work.

The final poems of the published *Second Sight* can thus be classified into two categories or groups of poems, which are identified here. Whenever available I have added to the list other useful information such as previous publications and source texts, drafts, etc.:

(p.450)

1. The poems derived from 'Composition': The sections from the original 'Composition' were printed as 12 individual poems in *Second Sight* in 1986. They are placed in a somewhat different arrangement compared to the original order. Their final order in the book, where they are combined with other poems, is like this:

'Elements of Composition' (published in *Indian Literature*, vol. 28, no. 2 [March–April 1985], pp. 56–7).

'Questions'.

'The Watchers'.

'A Poor Man's Riches 1'.

'A Poor Man's Riches 2'.

'Alien'.

'Drafts'.

'Middle Age'.

'Dancers in a Hospital'.

'Connect!'.

'Looking for the Centre' (published in *Indian Literature*, vol. 28, no. 2 [March–April 1985], pp. 55–6).

'Waterfalls in a Bank'.

Dharwadker maintains, in the introduction to *The Collected Poems*, that the poems 'Snakes and Ladders' and 'The Difference' from *Second Sight* also belong to this group,²⁷ for they conform to the same metrical pattern as the other poems and were drafted around the same time as the rest of the 'Composition'. However, the various manuscripts of the longer 'Composition' and 'Elements of Composition' in the AKR Papers do not include these two poems in their original arrangements. The first

versions of 'Snakes and Ladders', for instance, originate from an independent poetry draft titled 'Red, White and Black' (see ahead).

2. Other poems that are added to compose *Second Sight*: The 24 poems that were inserted and mixed with the 12 pieces from 'Composition' are of very diverse types and periods. The collection opens with the poem 'Elements of Composition' and closes with the new title poem 'Second Sight', a late choice from this group of miscellaneous poems. We may order them here by the dates of the first drafts; other publications of these poems are specified when applicable:

(p.451) 'Son to Father to Son' (first drafted in India, c. 1958, as 'Three Poems for Father', rejected by Oxford University Press for *The Striders* and *Relations*).

'In the Zoo' (d. 1960; published in 1961 in *Poetry* [Chicago], rejected by Oxford University Press for *The Striders*).

'On the Death of a Poem' (d. 1961 for *The Striders*, was part of a group of short poems with the title 'Images').

'He Too Was a Light Sleeper Once' (d. late 1960s as 'On a Poet Now Silent' for *Relations*; earlier version published in Shiv Kumar [ed.], *Indian Verse in English 1970* [Calcutta: Writers Workshop, 1970], as 'On a Poet Now Silent'; last five lines d. November 1959).

'A Minor Sacrifice' (d. in late 1960s for *Relations*; a version was published as 'How We Learned about Grasshoppers and What', in Howard Sergeant [ed.], *Pergamon Poets 9: Poetry from India* [Oxford: Pergamon Press, 1970]).

'Moulting' (d. 1970, rejected by Oxford University Press for *Relations*).

'Death and The Good Citizen' (d. 1971, published in *Poetry* [Chicago], vol. 89, no. 2 in 1981).

'Looking and Finding' (d. 21 March 1971; later titled 'Soma: He Reads the Newspaper' and 'He Looks and Finds'; some lines were added from the mescaline poems and the final version was drafted in 1984).

'Astronomer' (first d. 8 August 1971).

'Extended Family' (first d. 29 August 1971, as part of mescaline notes; published in *American Scholar* in 1982).

'Fear' (d. c. 1971).

'Highway Stripper' (d. c. 1971).

'Chicago Zen' (published in *The Carleton Miscellany* in 1976; earlier draft of parts ii and iv of the poem was titled 'Buddhist Clichés', d. 1972-3).

'Some People' (d. 18 December 1974, titled 'Soma: He Attends a Conference').

'Saturdays' (first d. 10 November 1978).

'No Amnesiac King' (d. 13 November 1979; published in *Indian Literature*, vol. 28, no. 2 [March–April 1985], pp. 56–7, along with 'Elements of Composition' and 'Looking for the Centre').
'Ecology' (d. before 1979; published in *Poetry* [Chicago], vol. 89, no. 2 in 1981).
'Pleasure' (d. c. 1980).
'Second Sight' (d. c. 1980).
'At Forty' (d. April 1981).
'Love Poem for a Wife and Her Trees' (d. Apr 1981).
'Snakes and Ladders' (d. circa 1982, titled 'Red, White and Black').
'The Difference' (d. c. 1982).
'Zoo Gardens Revisited' (d. early 1980s).

Notes:

- (1.) See, for example, King, *Three Indian Poets*, pp. 93–4.
- (2.) McDonnell, trans. *Rig Veda*, 10.125, *Vedic Mythology* (1887), p. 109, quoted in AKR's lecture notes, AKR Papers.
- (3.) Ramanujan, 'Men, Women and Saints', lecture delivered at Harvard in 1976, in *CE*, p. 280.
- (4.) Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought'. First drafted in 1985 and published in 1992 with the same title. See *CE*, p. 88. See also the section titled 'Sanskrit Aesthetics and Classical Indian Philosophy' in Chapter 5.
- (5.) See Chart 1 for a chronology of AKR's life, career, details, and writings.
- (6.) See Rao, *Nissim Ezekiel*. According to his biographer R. Raj Rao, Ezekiel took LSD 24 times from 1967–9, mostly under supervision of a 'guide'.
- (7.) See, for example, Ananthamurthy, 'The Gentle Genius', *Littcrit*, vol. 38 (June 1994), p. 6.
- (8.) Ramanujan, 'Mescaline Notes', n.p. See also the section 'Aesthetic Journeys: Experiences from AKR's Journals and Diaries' in Chapter 4.
- (9.) Venkatesh, 'A Poet and His Perceptions'; Kulshrestha, typed letter to AKR, AKR Papers (18 April 1980). There is also another letter to AKR mentioning Soma, unidentified author, Delhi, AKR Papers (28 January 1981).
- (10.) Kulshrestha, 'A.K. Ramanujan'.
- (11.) Rodríguez (ed.), 'Afterwords'.

(12.) Ramanujan, handwritten notes next to 'Jazz Poem for Soma', unpublished, AKR Papers (c. 1979-80).

(13.) Venkatesh, 'A Poet and His Perceptions'.

(14.) According to the notes in the Papers, AKR used to recite this poem in several poetry readings in the mid-1980s, but never published it.

(15.) Most of the quotes by AKR in this section have been cited in previous chapters of this book. Ramanujan, journals and diaries, AKR Papers (1982-4).

(16.) See Ramanujan, 'Food for Thought', in *CE*, pp. 74-5.

(17.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (14 May 1984).

(18.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 May 1984).

(19.) Keith Harrison, handwritten letter to AKR, Welch, Minnesota, AKR Papers (16 June 1984).

(20.) Dharwadker, 'Introduction', in *CP*, p. xxxvii.

(21.) See Dharwadker, 'Introduction', in *CP*, p. xxxvii.

(22.) Barthes, 'Theory of the Text', in Robert Young (ed.), *Untying the Text: A Post-Structuralist Reader* (1981), quoted in Ramanujan, 'On Folk Mythologies and Folk Puranas', in *CE*, p. 517.

(23.) Ramanujan, diary, AKR Papers (30 October 1976). As already indicated in Chapter 7, the two Sanskrit terms 'prakriti' and 'samskriti', 'nature' and 'culture', are written in Kannada script in the original; underline in the original.

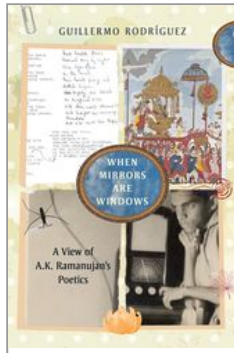
(24.) Ramanujan, 'Introduction', in *FI*, p. xxx.

(25.) Retrospective diary note dated April 1985, written on an earlier diary dated 30 May 1984, AKR Papers.

(26.) These two poems were published along with the poem 'No Amnesiac King' from *Relations* (1971) in *Indian Literature*, vol. 28, no. 2 (March-April 1985), pp. 52-7.

(27.) See Dharwadker, 'Introduction', in *CP*, p. xxxvii.

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Guillermo Rodríguez

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(p.454) Chart 1

Life, Career Details, and Writings: A Chronology

Guillermo Rodríguez

Abbreviations used:

L: Life, events, and honours

S: Studies and professional career; fellowships and grants

W: Writings and publications

1929

L: Born on 16 March in Mysore (in today's Karnataka state), the second of six children. Father Attipat Asuri Krishnaswami Ayyengar (Vaisnava Tamil Brahmin from Triplicane, Madras) and mother Seshammal (Tamil Brahman from Srirangam) had four sons—A.K. Srinivasan, A.K. Ramanujan, A.K. Rajagopal, and A.K. Vasudevan—and two daughters, Vedavathi Bhogishayana and Saroja Krishnamurthi. His father was a university professor of mathematics and statistics. His three brothers became all scientists (a physicist, a materials scientist, and a statistician). His mother was not college-educated but widely read in Tamil and Kannada. Father spoke in Tamil to children, did not master Kannada. Mother spoke Tamil and also learnt Kannada. AKR grows up in a trilingual environment (English, Kannada, and Tamil).

1935

S: Attends Theobald's kindergarten school; learns English. Intellectually promiscuous: reads Arthur Mee's *Children's Encyclopaedia* ('Book of Knowledge').

1936

L: Change of house and school; snake charmer comes to the house.

S: Joins Hardwick School, Mysore; reads English regularly.

1941

L: Starts magic shows in private and public, learnt from a cousin from Madras. Father buys him the equipment.

(p.455) 1943

L: Addicted to detective novels.

S: Joins D. Banumaiah's High School, Mysore; studies English but not a good student; high marks in mathematics. Fails history at secondary school final examination, Secondary School Leaving Certificate (SSLC) examination.

W: First Kannada writing, prose and poetry, during 1943-4, written in his diary when ill with mumps.

1944

L: Discusses literature regularly with friends H.N. Murthy, T.V. Subramaniam, and others; interest in Indian and English writers: Tagore, Hardy, and others.

S: Passes SSLC examination; joins Maharaja College (University of Mysore), studies physical sciences; learns Tamil formally. Wins essay competition at high school.

W: Contributes first writings in Kannada, poetry and prose sketches, to the local magazines and college magazines (for example, the humour magazine *Koravanji*); starts to write radio plays for AIR in Kannada.

1945

W: First radio play broadcast in Mysore (about 25 of his scripts were produced by AIR).

1946

L: Throws away his sacred thread, thereby renouncing the Brahmin tradition. Discusses Sartre, psychology, and yoga with friend T.R.S. Sharma; attends evening literary meetings with fellow students and literary friends Bhogishayana and Sharma, at the house of S. Anantanarayana (English teacher and Kannada poet/novelist); regular friends are Kittanna, Suri, Ragi, Nagaratna, and Narayanamurthy. Reads some of the work of Kannada poet Gopalakrishna Adiga, whom he meets.

S: Ends undergraduate studies at Maharaja College, University of Mysore; high marks in science but changes to English (Honours) as forced by father. Learns English phonetics; obtains University of Mysore Scholarship for English literature, studies under Professor W.G. Eagleton (Cambridge), professor of English and phonetics, who teaches him English poetry, Shakespeare, the modern English poets, and Western music. AKR's English style, from there on, changes to the British model (BBC English).

W: Writes first poem in English for friend Bhogishayana. His teachers stage his Kannada play. Publishes first article in Kannada.

(p.456) 1947

L: Lives in Mysore, Madras, and Srirangam till 1950. Continues to do magic shows. Serves as secretary and president of the Literary Club in College; acts in plays and reads, profusely, English literature, psychology, and philosophy: Plato, Nietzsche, Schopenhauer, Russell, and Santayana.

S: Discovers medieval Kannada Virasaiva bhakti poetry (vachanas) through his teacher V. Sitaramayya.

W: First poetry drafts in English available in the AKR Papers: 'A Teenager's Cosmology' (1947, noted ahead: 'Nagesha Rao's Class'), 'Trees of the World' (1947). Starts diary, dream notebook, and commonplace book in English. Reads Dylan Thomas (thanks to Bhogishayana) and G.M. Hopkins in 1947-8; writes 'Dylan-ish Exercises' in English. Continues to write radio plays for AIR in Kannada.

1949

L: Father goes to Andhra Pradesh and returns, mother sick. Not much writing but reads Russell and Huxley; wants to become a 'generalist'.

S: Obtains BA (Honours) degree in English literature from University of Mysore.

W: First diary entry in AKR Papers: about writing poetry in English titled 'A Poem Is Born'.

1950

S: Obtains MA degree in English (specialization in Shakespeare and eighteenth-century English literature). In summer gets first teaching post as lecturer in English at S.N. College, Quilon, Kerala (1950-1).

W: Writes poems in English (drafts 'The Concert', 16 December 1950, 'An Idiot', 20 December 1950 in AKR Papers).

1951

S: Lecturer in English at S.N. College, Quilon till July; then joins as lecturer at Thiagaraj College, Madurai, Tamil Nadu (1951-2).

W: Writes poems in English and Kannada, and transcreations of mystic Kannada vachanas by the medieval saint Basavanna; writes radio plays in Kannada.

1952

S: Lecturer in English at Thiagaraj College, Madurai (Tamil Nadu) till August, practises formal Tamil, also with cousins. Joins as lecturer at Lingaraj College, Belgaum, Karnataka (Autumn 1952-August 1957).

W: In Belgaum, writes poems (the AKR Papers contain many drafts from this period); produces plays and variety shows, collects folktales in north Karnataka.

(p.457) 1953

L: Father dies in June. AKR refuses to perform death ceremony.

W: Writes many English poems; collects folktales (in Kannada and Tamil, also from mother and relatives); does first public readings of his poetry in English. Starts to interact with Kannada writers' scene: Gopalakrishna Adiga, U.R. Ananthamurthy, G.B. Joshi, Kirtinath Kurtakoti, Chandrashekhara Kambar, P. Lankesh, and others.

1955

L: Meets Kannada writer Girish Karnad. Invites Edwin Kirkland from the University of Florida (who is working at the US information service, Bombay) to give a lecture in Belgaum.

W: Publishes his first book *Gadegalu*, a collection of Kannada lectures on proverbs. Publishes first literary article in English, 'Notes on Walt Whitman', in *The Literary Criterion* (Mysore). Translates Kannada short stories. Writes radio plays under pseudonym AKR ('Akrura' in Kannada).

1956

L: First meeting with Indian English poet Nissim Ezekiel while preparing a Tamil issue of the journal *Quest*.

S: Becomes president of the English Union at Lingaraj College, Belgaum, and runs the debate society.

W: Translates bhakti poetry (first drafts in AKR Papers). First publications of English poems in *The Illustrated Weekly*, Bombay. First publications of his essays in English on folktales in the US journal *Southern Folklore Quarterly* ('Some Folktales from India' and 'The Clay Mother-in-Law') with the help and encouragement of Edwin Kirkland.

1957

L: Sister marries Malayalam writer and critic M.G. Krishnamurti, with whom AKR will work on translations of modern Kannada literature.

S: Lecturer in English, Maharaja Sayajirao University, Baroda, Gujarat (1957-8). Attempts PhD thesis on W.B. Yeats. Visits Nainital in May to attend a workshop on American literature, where he meets poet Ayyappa Paniker. Represents north Karnataka at AIR Seminar for south-Indian radio playwrights; about 25 of his scripts have been broadcast by then.

W: Writes poetry drafts experimenting with the haiku form, also poems with compound adjectives 'a la G.M. Hopkins'. First publication of English poems in the Indian journal **(p.458)** *Thought*, and of poems along with transcreations of medieval Kannada vachanas in *Quest* and *The Illustrated Weekly*.

1958

S: Tired and disappointed with teaching English, becomes research fellow in linguistics (language project) at Deccan College, Poona (1958-9); attends Summer School of Linguistics (1958-9), obtains graduate diplomas in descriptive and historical linguistics under Rockefeller Fellowship; submits Fulbright application form in Bombay.

W: First publication of translations (poems from Kannada bhakti) in *Illustrated Weekly*.

1959

L: Spends first half of the year in Poona then embarks on trip to US. Leaves Bombay on 1 July by steamboat and arrives in the USA on 28 July 1959, via Port Said and Marseille (in-out 19-23 July), and visits Paris on his way. Goes to Chicago to attend a conference by Aldous Huxley (during the 'Darwin Centennial'), where he is introduced to scholar Edward Dimock.

S: Receives Fulbright Travel Fellowship and Smith-Mundt Grant, Fulbright fellowship to study at Indiana University Bloomington. Studies linguistics (anthropological linguistics, generative grammar, poetics, stylistics) under Fred W. Householder, Edward Stankiewicz, and others; main interests in language models, semiotics, analysis of folklore, and mythology (Vladimir Propp, Claude Lévi-Strauss). Takes courses in folklore under Warren Roberts at the department headed by Richard Darson, earlier by Stith-Thompson; meets Alan Dundes as classmate. During winter takes creative-writing course in poetry under Samuel Yellen at Indiana University.

W: Writes poems and journals during his journey to the USA; in Paris writes first draft of the poem 'On Politics' (25 July 1959). Publishes first poem in the USA: 'A Plant', *Folio*, Indiana (Winter 1959). Shows Samuel Yellen at Indiana University Bloomington his earlier drafts and new poems; follows the professor's suggestions in later drafts but also ignores some of his corrections.

1960

S: Stays at University of Texas under American Council of Learned Societies Summer Award, Linguistics Institute; also in Bennington (Vermont) for Fulbright orientation programme.

(p.459) 1961

L: Meets Molly Daniels, his future wife.

S: Indiana University Bloomington. Fellowship in linguistics: research assistant, automatic translation project in spring; research associate in Tamil, South Asian Languages Program, University of Chicago in summer; invited to teach Tamil as a substitute for Radhakrishnan at University of Chicago; meets linguist William Bright and anthropologist Milton Singer.

W: Publishes the poems 'The Striders', 'Snakes', and 'In the Zoo' in *Poetry* (Chicago) and 'Anxiety' in *Atlantic Monthly*. Publishes translations of medieval Kannada vachanas in *Poetry* (Chicago).

1962

L: Marries Molly Daniels in Chicago in June.

S: Assistant professor of linguistics, Tamil and Dravidian studies, University of Chicago (1962-6). Discovers an anthology of Tamil classical Sangam poetry

by U.Ve. Caminataiyar in the basement of Harper Library, University of Chicago.

1963

L: Daughter Krittika born in Delhi.

S: Fellow, School of Letters at Indiana University in summer; obtains PhD in linguistics from Indiana University Bloomington for 'A Generative Grammar of Kannada'. Visits India under research fellowship (1963-4) of the American Institute of Indian Studies; collects folktales in different parts of India; gives talk and readings of translations from Tamil Sangam poetry in Bombay in December organized by P.E.N. at the invitation of Nissim Ezekiel.

1964

L: Travels to India to collect folktales. Visits also Sri Lanka and France.

W: *The Striders* poems accepted by Oxford University Press, London.

Publishes first translations of classical Tamil poems in *Prairie Schooner*.

1965

L: Son Krishna born in April.

S: Visiting assistant professor of Indian studies, University of Wisconsin-Madison in summer, where he arranges a Tamil programme in the summer; teaches a course titled 'Poetic Form' with linguist E. Stankiewicz.

W: First collection of poetry translations published: *Fifteen Poems from a Classical Tamil Anthology* (Calcutta: Writers Workshop). Appears in *Young Poets of the Commonwealth* (p.460) edited by Howard Seargant. Serves as contributing editor for *Poetry India* (edited by Ezekiel); works very closely with Ezekiel on all four issues.

1966

S: Associate professor of Dravidian studies and linguistics, Department of South Asian Languages and Civilisations, University of Chicago (1966-8); academic director, inter-university rotating programme in Indian studies, Chicago, in summer.

W: First book of poems in English published: *The Striders* (London: Oxford University Press); receives Poetry Book Society spring recommendation, London (selectors are Alan Brownjohn and Frank Kermode). First book of translated fiction published: *Haladi Meenu* (The Yellow Fish) by Molly Daniels-Ramanujan, translated into Kannada from English by AKR. Four poems of classical Tamil Akam poetry published in *Poetry India*. First translations of Kannada vachana poems published in USA in *The East-West Review*. Proposes to write a 300-page book titled 'Literature as Language', which is never produced.

1967

L: Meets Nissim Ezekiel in Chicago in spring, who had been invited to University of California to give lectures. In April, Ezekiel has his first LSD experience in the US.

S: Visiting associate professor, Department of Speech; Berkeley, University of California (June–December), where he meets with poet Leonard Nathan.

W: First book of translations from classical Tamil poetry published: *The Interior Landscape* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press).

1968

L: Molly admitted to Committee on Social Thought, University of Chicago.

AKR receives gold medal of Tamil Writers' Association for *The Interior Landscape* in Madras.

S: Appointed professor of Dravidian studies and linguistics, departments of South Asian Languages and Civilisations, and Linguistics, University of Chicago (1968–93).

W: In spring translates classical Tamil Puram poems. Starts work on his long poem in English, 'Prayers to Lord Murugan'.

1969

S: Spends summer in Madras under University of Chicago fellowship, giving workshop in Dravidian studies and linguistics, literature and folklore, and searching for south-Indian translators.

(p.461) W: Works on his collection of translations from medieval Kannada poetry, *Speaking of Siva*. First book of Kannada poems published: *Hokkulalli Hoovilla* (No Lotus in the Navel) (Dharwad: Manohara Grantha Mala).

1970

L: Wife Molly leaves him for the first time.

S: Visits India (Shimla) to give a lecture titled 'The Indian Oedipus' at a seminar on Indian literature. Also spends time at Michigan summer school.

W: Finishes translation of *Samskara*, a novel in Kannada by U.R. Ananthamurthy.

1971

L: First divorce, Molly leaves for India with children. In August experiments with mescaline hallucinogenic and writes the 'Mescaline Notes' (unpublished, AKR Papers).

S: Visiting assistant professor of Indian studies, University of Wisconsin–Madison, in summer.

W: Second book of poems in English published: *Relations* (New York and London: Oxford University Press).

1972

S: Professor, Committee of Social Thought, University of Chicago (1972–93); starts using the concept 'context-sensitivity'.

W: Writes first 'Soma' poem (unpublished, AKR Papers).

1973

S: Visiting professor (summer programme in Indian studies), University of California, Berkeley.

W: Publishes book of translations of medieval Kannada poetry: *Speaking of Siva* (New Delhi: Penguin Books).

1974

L: Molly and children return to USA; mother visits Chicago, dies in November.

W: *Speaking of Siva* nominated for National Book Award in the USA in 1974.

1975

L: Spends summer in India; writes a will and is concerned about death in his diary since M.G. Krishnamurthi (his sister Saroja's husband) and his mother had passed away.

W: Publication of *The Literatures of India: An Introduction* (Chicago University Press), a collection of miscellaneous essays co-edited with Edward Dimock and others.

1976

L: Receives Padma Shri Award from the Indian government for his contribution to Indian literature and linguistics; is criticized by some intellectuals for accepting the award as it is announced during the state of emergency under Indira (p.462) Gandhi. Remarries Molly (reunion since 1975). Moves to Northfield, Minnesota.

S: Studies and reads medieval Tamil Alvar poetry, especially Nammalvar's *Tiruvaymoli*.

W: Publication of *Selected Poems* (poems selected from *The Striders* and *Relations* by Oxford University Press). Publication in English of the Kannada novel translated by AKR, *Samskara: A Rite for a Dead Man* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press), by U.R. Ananthamurthy. Starts to write an autobiographical Kannada novella (published posthumously by Oxford University Press in 2006).

1977

W: Publication of second collection of Kannada poems: *Mattu Itara Padyagalu* (And Other Poems) (Dharwad: Manohara Grantha Mala).

1978

L: Starts to practise bioenergetics.

S: Visiting Benedict professor, departments of sociology and anthropology, Carleton College, Northfield, Minnesota in spring. Acting chairman of Committee on Southern Asian Studies (1978-9).

W: Publication of his Kannada novella *Matthobhana Atmacharitre* (Someone Else's Autobiography) (Dharwad: Manohara Grantha Mala).

1979

L: Chicago CTA buses display his poem 'The Striders'.

1980

S: Elected chairman of the Department of South Asian Languages and Civilisations, University of Chicago (1980–5). Teaches English poetry for the first time at an American university, with David Grene at the University of Chicago.

1981

L: Receives Illinois Arts Council Award for Poetry. Attends UNESCO Poetry Festival in Paris in December.

W: Publication of translations from medieval Tamil: *Hymns for the Drowning: Poems for Visnu by Nammalvar* (Princeton: Princeton University Press).

1982

L: Receives Arts and Letters Award, Federation of Indians in North America.

S: Distinguished Visiting Benedict Professor, Department of English and Department of Asian Studies, Carleton College, in spring.

W: Works on translations of classical Tamil poems and folktales with a National Endowment for the Humanities **(p.463)** grant. Abandons and transforms Soma sequence of poems; starts working on a new poem titled 'Composition'.

1983

L: Starts psychoanalysis therapy and wants to become a psychotherapist. Travels to Jaffna in Sri Lanka to lecture, and rediscovers his early interest in Buddhism.

S: Becomes William E. Colvin Professor, University of Chicago. Receives MacArthur Prize Fellowship (1983–8). Senior fellow, American Institute of Indian Studies in Winter/Spring. Receives an award for literary contribution to Kannada by Karnataka Sahitya Akademi.

1984

L: Receives Distinguished Award, Taraknathdas Foundation, and Arts and Letters Award, Association of Indians in North America.

W: Works in May–June on a new version of the now long poem titled 'Composition' for a new volume of poems in English.

1985

L: Receives Chicago Poets Award, City of Chicago.

W: Publication of second book of translations of classical Tamil Sangam poetry: *Poems of Love and War: From the Eight Anthologies and the Ten Long Poems of Classical Tamil* (New York: Columbia University Press).

1986

L: Delivers the Keynote Address at the Indian Writers' Symposium of the Frankfurt Book Fair.

W: Third book of poems in English published: *Second Sight* (Oxford University Press). Publication of a book of essays co-edited with Stuart

Blackburn: *Another Harmony: New Essays on the Folklore of India* (London: Oxford University Press).

1987

L: Marital problems with Molly. Practises meditation and visits a Jungian therapist.

S: Delivers four lectures at the École des haute études en sciences sociales, Paris, in March–April. Visiting professor at Divinity School and Department of Sanskrit and Indian Studies, Harvard University, in autumn.

1988

L: Second divorce from Molly.

S: Fellow, Institute of Humanities, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor. Delivers Watumull Distinguished Indian Lecturer, University of Hawaii, in March, and Radhakrishnan Memorial Lectures at All Soul's College, Oxford, in May.

1989

S: Winston Fellow, Institute of Advanced Studies, Hebrew University, from January to August. Norman Freehling (**p.464**) Fellow, Institute of Humanities, University of Michigan, in Autumn. Mary Ann and Charles R. Walgreen Junior Visiting Professor, University of Michigan (1989–90).

1990

L: Elected to American Academy of Arts and Sciences.

S: Teaches a folklore workshop sponsored by Ford Foundation near Kodaikanal, India; reads poetry at P.E.N., Bombay. Attends International Poetry Festival in Jerusalem.

W: Publication of third book of Kannada poems *Kuntobille (Hopscotch)* (Dharwad: Manohara Grantha Mala).

1991

W: Publication of collection of folktales: *Folktales from India: A Selection of Oral Tales from Twenty-Two Languages* (New York: Pantheon).

1992

L: Spends his last summer and autumn in India.

S: Lectures at Bard College, Wesleyan University, and in India at Dhvanyaloka, Mysore, in August. Visiting consultant, Centre for Folk Culture Studies, Hyderabad, where he works on a project to set up a field station for the collection of oral traditions in Andhra Pradesh. Helps translate a Marathi play for a theatre group in Bombay; works on getting English versions of well-known contemporary Kannada, Tamil, and Marathi plays.

W: Works on translations of fiction by Devanoora Mahadeva for Penguin Books.

1993

L: Complains of severe pain in the spine; anxious about his health; cancels planned visit to India in March to attend a seminar on the brain. Dies on 13 July in a Chicago hospital due to heart failure during anaesthesia while undergoing a minor surgery.

S: Helps in rehearsals of *Nāga-Mandala*, a play by Girish Karnad, but passes away before it is staged.

W: Some of the works-in-progress that were interrupted are: an anthology of Tamil short stories translated into English, a book of translations of Devanoora Mahadeva's Kannada stories for Penguin Books; 'The Columbia Book of Indian Poetry' (which was to be co-edited with Vinay Dharwadker and Barbara Stoler Miller); production and publication of contemporary Kannada, Tamil, and Marathi plays in English translation; a Kannada folktale collection.

(p.465) Posthumous Publications and Awards

1993

The publisher Katha (India) founds the 'Katha A.K. Ramanujan Award' for the best translation in Indian languages.

1994

Publication of book of translations: *When God Is a Customer: Telugu Courtesan Songs by Ksetrayya and Others* (Berkeley: University of California Press), co-edited with V. Narayana Rao and David Shulman. Publication of *The Oxford Anthology of Modern Indian Poetry* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press), co-edited with Vinay Dharwadker.

1995

Publication of poetry in English: *The Black Hen*, in *The Collected Poems of A.K. Ramanujan*, edited by Vinay Dharwadker (London, New York, and New Delhi: Oxford University Press).

1996

The Association for Asian Studies (USA) institutes the 'A.K. Ramanujan Book Prize' for translations from South Asian languages into English.

1997

Publication of collection of Kannada tales in English: *A Flowering Tree and Other Oral Tales from India*, edited by Stuart Blackburn and Alan Dundes (Berkeley: University of California Press; and New Delhi: Penguin Books).

1999

Publication of *The Collected Essays of A.K. Ramanujan*, general editor Vinay Dharwadker (New Delhi: Oxford University Press).

Recipient of the Sahitya Akademi Award for *The Collected Poems*.

2001

Publication of *Uncollected Poems and Prose: A.K. Ramanujan*, edited by Molly A. Daniels-Ramanujan and Keith Harrison (London and New Delhi: Oxford University Press).

2004

Publication of the omnibus collection of AKR's poetry in English and translations of poetry: *The Oxford India Ramanujan*, edited by Molly Daniels-Ramanujan (New Delhi: Oxford University Press). Received Contemporary Poetry Review Award for the Best Book of Translation.

2006

Publication of a collection of Kannada poetry and fiction translated into English: *A.K. Ramanujan: Poems and a Novella* (New Delhi: Oxford University Press). Translated by Tonse N.K. Raju and Shouri (Molly) Daniels-Ramanujan; advisory editor Prithvi Datta Chandra Shobhi.

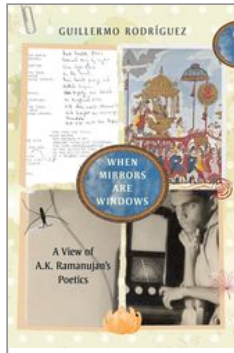
(p.466) 2011

Publication of his collected works in Kannada: *A.K. Ramanujan Samagra*, edited by Ramakant Joshi and S. Divakar (Dharwad: Manohara Grantha Mala).

2012

Girish Karnad delivers the first A.K. Ramanujan Memorial Lecture at Ramjas College, University of Delhi.

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When Mirrors Are Windows: A View of A.K. Ramanujan's Poetics

Guillermo Rodríguez

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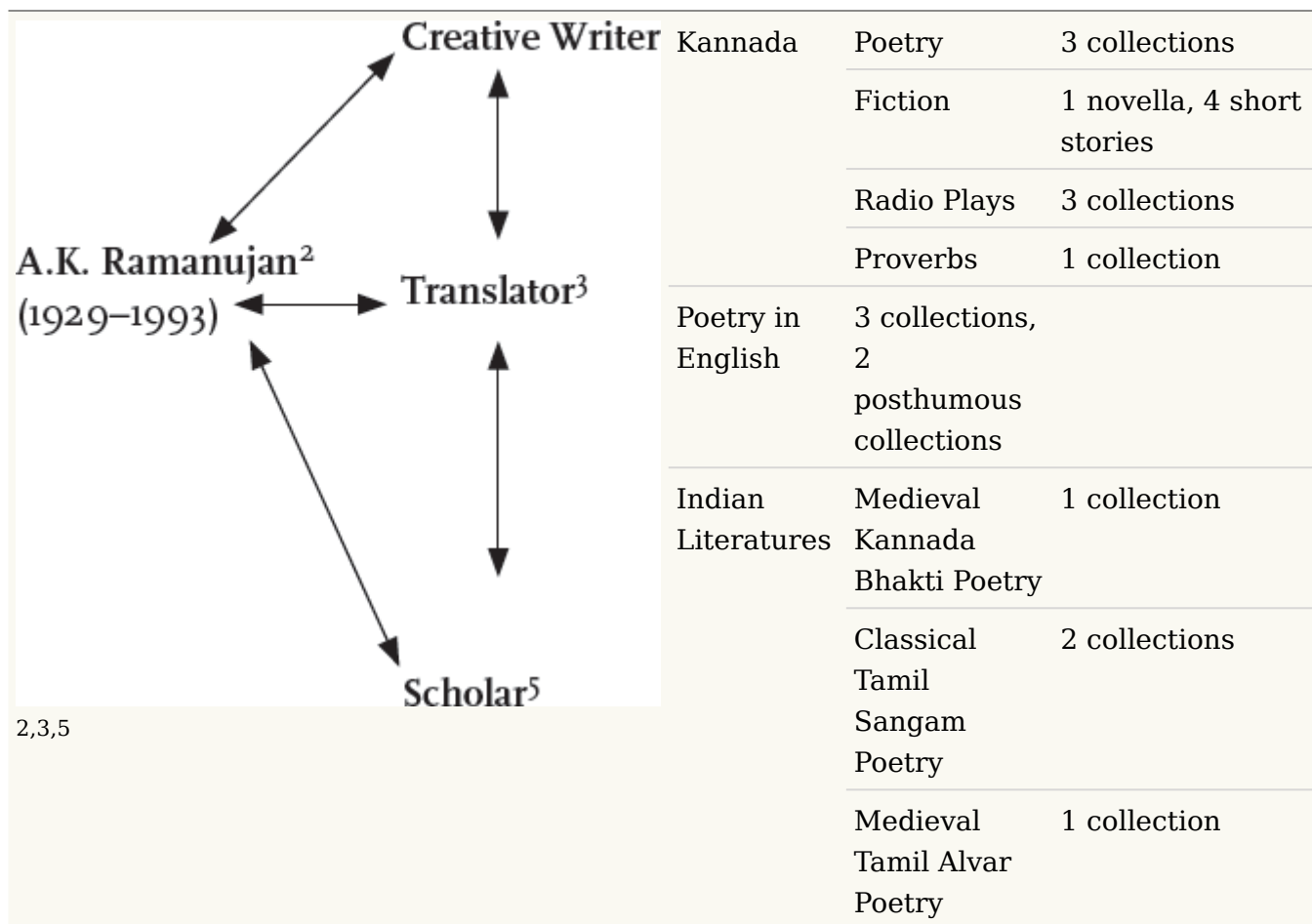
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(p.467) Chart 2

Overview of A.K. Ramanujan's Published Writings¹

Guillermo Rodríguez



	Folktales ⁴ (Kannada, Tamil)	1 collection, 1 posthumous collection
	Modern Indian Poetry (mainly Kannada, Tamil to English)	1 posthumous co-edited collection
	Modern Indian Fiction (Kannada, Tamil to English and English to Kannada)	2 novels
Essays in English (Academic Disciplines)	Linguistics: General and Dravidian	
	Structuralism and Semiotics	1 collection (multidisciplinary)
	Indian Literature	
	English and American Literature	
	Comparative Literature	
	Indian Folklore	
	Cultural Anthropology	

(p.468) Notes

Notes:

(1.) This chart is only a simplified overview of AKR's published works. The list does not include the posthumous omnibus collection (Oxford University Press,

2004) of the previously published volumes of poetry in English and translations, or the posthumous collection in Kannada (Manohara Grantha Mala, 2011) that includes his published works in Kannada and other uncollected and unpublished material. Likewise, it does not account for the posthumous collection (Oxford University Press, 2006) of his Kannada poetry and fiction translated by others into English.

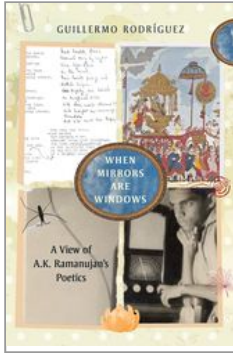
(2.) Countries: India—born 1929 into a south-Indian Vaisnava Brahmin family of Tamil origin in Mysore, Karnataka. USA—1959-93, mainly at the University of Chicago.

(3.) Languages: Kannada, Tamil, and English. AKR translated mainly poetry from Kannada and Tamil into English, also poetry from English into Kannada, modern prose in Kannada and English in both directions, and modern Tamil prose into English. This lists only book-size collections and novels but there are also numerous uncollected modern poems and short stories translated by AKR.

(5.) AKR's contribution to Indian studies has been multifarious and the impact of his work in India and the West as a scholar and translator is evident in various academic disciplines. A book prepared by the American Institute of Indian Studies to commemorate in 1997 50 years of India's Independence and acknowledge US scholarship on India during that period, compiles retrospective assessments of seminal work carried out by US-based scholars in different academic fields from 1947 to 1997. Altogether 26 areas are reviewed, covering diverse disciplines from anthropology to women's studies. The book cites AKR's work in no less than seven chapters (fields): 'Folklore', 'Linguistics', 'Literature', 'Religious Studies: Vedic and Classical Hinduism', 'Religious Studies: Medieval Hinduism', 'Religious Studies: Modern Hinduism/Jainism', and 'Sanskrit'. No other scholar of the second half of the century is mentioned as many times and in as many chapters. Most of his essays were collected posthumously (Oxford University Press, 1999).

(4.) AKR collected folktales from various Indian languages and except for Kannada and Tamil, collaborated with other translators to render them into English. The folktales he published are not translations of written texts but recreations of oral tales collected during fieldwork by him and others.

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(p.469) Glossary*

Guillermo Rodríguez

(p.469) Glossary*

Akam [akam]

Tamil, literally (hereafter lit.) 'inner', 'domestic', or 'private'. One of the two paired categories in Tamil poetics and culture. In classical Tamil Sangam poetry, Akam denotes poems of love, while Puram denotes poems of war and public affairs.

alamkara [alaṅkāra]

Sanskrit, lit. 'ornamentation'. Term applied by Indian aestheticians to poetry, drama, music, philosophy, and the visual arts. In poetry, the figurative use of language or individual tropes, that is, metaphor.

alaukika [alaukika]

Sanskrit, lit. 'uncommon' or 'transcendental'. Otherworldly experience in Sanskrit aesthetics as opposed to the 'ordinary' (laukika) one.

Alvar [Ālvār]

Medieval poet-saint devoted to the god Visnu in Tamil tradition, which recognizes 12 Alvars. *Al*, the verb, means 'to immerse' and is followed by the third person suffix *var*.

ananda [ānanda]

Sanskrit, lit. 'bliss'.

anubhava [anubhava]

Sanskrit, lit. 'experience'. In Sanskrit aesthetics and poetics, the psychological and physical effects of the personal emotion (bhava).

(p.470) anubhāva [anubhāva]

In Virasaiva bhakti, 'the Experience', the unpredictable, spontaneous ecstasy that may arrive in the process of artistic-spiritual devotional practice.

apsara [apsara]

Fairies in Indian mythology. The heavenly, exceptionally beautiful dancing girls in the court of the god Indra.

artha [ārtha]

Sanskrit, lit. 'sense'. According to Sanskrit literary theory, literature (sahitya) and poetry consist of artha (sense) and sabda (word).

arthalamkara [ārtha-alāṅkāra]

Figures of sense in Sanskrit poetics.

atman [ātman]

The supreme self or individual self. The life principle, soul, or individual essence in classical Hindu philosophy. Also, the universal self from whom all individual atmans arise.

atmananda [ātma-ānanda]

Derived from the Sanskrit 'atman' (the self) and ananda (bliss).

Refers to aesthetic pleasure in Sanskrit aesthetics.

aucitya [aucitya]

Poetic 'propriety' of words and ideas in Sanskrit literary theory.

Bhagavad Gita [Bhagavadgīta]

Sacred Hindu text in Sanskrit. Regarded as one of the highest expressions of philosophical Hinduism contained in a chapter of the immense Indian epic, the Mahabharata.

bhakta [bhakta]

Devotee of the Hindu devotional tradition.

bhakti [bhakti]

Sanskrit, lit. 'devotion', that is, the devotional path of Hindu spirituality. Hindu bhakti traditions of medieval origin had religious, social, and literary connotations. Bhakti, as a literary tradition, branched into many different sects and cults spreading from south to north India, from around the sixth century AD to the present.

According to Rupa Goswami (sixteenth century AD), there are five types of bhakti: shanta, dasya, sakhya, vatsalya, and madhurya.

(p.471) Bharatanatyam [bhārata nāṭyam]

Classical temple dance of south India based on the dramatic principles of the *Natya Sastra*.

bhasha [bhāṣā]

Sanskrit, lit. 'language'. Refers to the regional languages of India.

bhava [bhāva]

Personal emotion or psychological state in Sanskrit aesthetics and poetics.

caryagitis [caryāgītis]

Medieval Bengali mystic poems by Bengali Buddhist poets.

desi [deśi]

Sanskrit, lit. 'place', 'local', or 'country road'. Denotes the regional or local traditions of India, which have been otherwise named the folk or 'little traditions'. The desi traditions are of regional language (bhasha) origin.

dhvani [dhvani]

Sanskrit, lit. 'vibration'. Sanskrit poetic theory of 'suggestiveness' propounded by Anandavardhana (ninth century AD) in the work *Dhvanyaloka*.

jangama [jaṅgama]

Sanskrit, lit. 'to go' or 'move'. The 'moving' quality of art and religious culture chosen by the medieval Virasaiva devotees. Jangama stands in opposition to *sthavara* (static).

karu [karu]

Tamil, 'the natural element' in classical Tamil Akam poetry. There are 14 natural elements connected with a region or landscape.

kripa [kṛpā]

Sanskrit, divine 'mercy' or 'grace' that cannot be commanded.

kural [kuṛa]

Couplets in classical Tamil prosody, one of its basic metres.

kurinci [kurīñci]

A flower that grows in the hills of the Western Ghats. It identified one of the five landscapes in Tamil classical literature. The god of the kurinci is Murugan.

laukika [laukika]

Sanskrit, lit. 'ordinary'. A commonplace, worldly experience in Sanskrit aesthetics, in contrast to the otherworldly (alaukika).

(p.472) *lingayat* [liṅgāyat]

Medieval religious community in south India of the Virasaiva cult, who worshipped Siva in the form of the 'linga' (the symbol of Siva). For this they are called lingayats, or bearers of a linga, which they wear on the body.

marga [marga]

Sanskrit, lit. 'the way'. Signifies the pan-Indian or supra-regional mainstream tradition, which has also been called the classical or 'Great Tradition' in Western scholarship. *Marga* traditions are of Sanskrit, scriptural, Brahminical origin.

matra [mātrā]

Sanskrit unit of sound measurement.

maya [māyā]

Sanskrit, lit. 'illusion' or 'play of the mind'. The reality we see but which obstructs pure vision and true consciousness. The force that displays universal consciousness as duality, creating error and illusion. An important concept in Hindu philosophy.

moksha [mokṣa]

Sanskrit concept denoting liberation from the world of maya, that is, from the chain of reincarnation. The ultimate goal in Hindu religious thought.

Mundaka [Muṇḍaka]

Ancient Sanskrit text, one of the 108 main Upanishads.

Murugan [Murukaṭ]

Ancient Tamil god.

mutal [mutal]

Tamil, 'first elements' in classical Tamil Akam poetry, consisting of a particular place and time units (the season and time of the day).

Narayana [Nārāyaṇa]

One of the thousand names of the Hindu god Visnu.

Natya Sastra [Nāṭyaśāstra]

Sanskrit treatise of dramatic art attributed to Bharata, dated between second century BC and second century AD.

nirguna brahman [nirguṇa brahman]

God as a formless (nirguna) principle in Hindu philosophy.

prakriti [prakṛti]

Nature or cosmic prime matter. According to the Samkhya School of Hindu philosophy, the manifest matter or 'seen'. Also, the active principle of the cosmos.

(p.473) Puram [puṛam]

Tamil, lit. 'outer' or 'public'. One of the two paired categories in Tamil poetics and culture. In classical Tamil Sangam poetry, Puram corresponds to poems of war genre and other public or tragic events, whereas Akam poems are concerned with the subject of love.

purusa [puruṣa]

The first or 'pure', unchanging and uncaused cosmic principle of creation. According to the Samkhya School of Hindu philosophy, the true self or 'seer', that is, a 'higher' consciousness. Also the passive principle.

rasa [rasa]

Sanskrit, lit. 'essence', 'flavour', or 'taste'. The rasa theory of aesthetics is expounded by Bharata in the *Natya Sastra* and is based on the depersonalized experience of aesthetic emotion. He identifies eight principle rasas: sringara, hasya, karuna, raudra, vira, bhayanaka, bibhatsa, and adbhuta. Abhinavagupta later added a ninth rasa: shanta.

rasanubhava [rasanubhava]

Transcendental aesthetic experience in the beholder or consumer of a work of art, according to the rasa theory of Sanskrit aesthetics.

sabda [śabda]

Sanskrit term for ‘word’. According to Sanskrit theory, literature (sahitya) and poetry consist of sabda and artha (sense).

saguna brahman [saguṇa brahman]

God with personified attributes and forms (saguna) in Hindu philosophy.

sahitya [sāhitya]

Sanskrit term for ‘literature’.

samskriti [saṃskṛti]

Sanskrit, lit. ‘refinement’, ‘redoing’. Signifies ‘culture’ as opposed to ‘nature’ (prakriti).

sanchari bhava [sanchāri bhāva]

Transitory or passing states of the mind, according to the rasa theory of Sanskrit aesthetics. Accessories to *sthayi bhava*, the dominant emotions. Also referred to as *vyabichari bhava*.

(p.474) Sangam [Caṅkam]

Tamil, lit. ‘academy or fraternity of poets’. Tamil commentators spoke of three Sangams in the classical period of Tamil poetry; the texts of the first are lost; only the poetic treatise *Tolkappiyam* survives of the second; and *The Eight Anthologies (Ettuttokai)* and *The Ten Long Poems (Pattupattu)* belong to the third (c. first century BC to third century AD).

sastra [śāstra]

Sanskrit scripture or sacred book for authoritative instruction in Hinduism.

smṛti [smṛti]

The ‘remembered’ tradition of Sanskrit Hindu texts, that is, the texts which come after the sruti (the ‘revealed’ works).

Soma [soma]

Cited in the Vedas as an elixir of life, a divine drink used by the Brahmins in their sacrifices. Referred to as a plant, a drug, or a god (the ‘leader of poets’).

sruti [śrūti]

The ‘received’ tradition of Sanskrit Hindu texts, of divine revelation, that is, the Vedas, Brahmanas, Aranyakas, and Upanishads.

sthavaras [sthāvara]

Sanskrit, lit. ‘immovable’. Premeditated, static forms of art, according to the medieval Virasaiva devotees. *Sthavara* stands in opposition to *jangama*, ‘the moving’.

sthayi bhava [sthāyī bhāva]

The eight permanent or dominant psychological states or emotions in the rasa theory of Sanskrit aesthetics.

tinai [tiṭai]

Region or landscape in classical Tamil Sangam poetry. According to the *Tolkappiyam*, in Akam, there are five landscapes—kuriṇji, mullai,

marutam, neythal, and palai—presided by a deity and named after a flower or tree characteristic of the region.

Tirukkural [Tirukkural]

Fourth-century Tamil 'book of wisdom' composed by Thiruvalluvar containing aphorisms written in couplets (kural), one of the basic metres in Tamil prosody.

(p.475) *Tirumurukarruppatai* [Tirumurukārruppatai]

Tamil lit. 'A Guide to Lord Murugan'. Poetic work by Nakkeerar, composed towards the final phase of the classical Sangam period.

Tiruvacakam [Tiruvācakam]

A collection of hymns composed in Tamil by the Shaivite bhakti poet Manikkavasagar (ninth century AD).

Tiruvaymoli [Tiruvāymoli]

Poetic work by the medieval Tamil poet-saint Nammalvar (ninth to tenth century AD).

Tolkappiyam [Tolkāppiyam]

Tamil, lit. 'the old composition'. Oldest Tamil work on grammar and poetics attributed to Tolkappiyar in the second classical Sangam period, and believed to have been written around fifth century BC.

Tolkappiyar [Tolkāppiyar]

Said to be the author of the *Tolkappiyam*, the oldest surviving book on Tamil poetics and grammar.

ullurai [uḷḷurai]

Poetic figure in classical Tamil poetry, implying 'that which is inherent in the word', that is, the 'inner' meaning.

Upanishad [Upaniṣad]

Hindu texts from 800 to 500 BC concerned chiefly with philosophical and pantheistic speculations on the nature of the divine and man. The Upanishads are mystic or spiritual interpretations on the Vedas.

There are 108 main Upanishads.

uri [uri]

Tamil, 'the human element'. A specific mood or phase of love in classical Tamil Akam poetry associated with a landscape.

vakrokti [vakrokti]

Sanskrit, lit. 'indirect' or 'oblique' use of language. Deviance as the defining characteristic of poetic language, according to Sanskrit poetics. One of the principal Sanskrit poetic theories.

vachana [vacana]

Kannada, lit. 'saying'. Oral poem in free verse by the medieval mystic Virasaiva saint-poets in the Kannada-speaking region of south India.

(p.476) *vachanakara* [vacanakāra]

Medieval Kannada poet saints who sing vachanas.

Vaisnava [vaiṣṇava]

Devotee of the Hindu god Visnu.

vasana [vāsanā]

Sanskrit, lit. 'desire'. Desire-related memory in Sanskrit philosophy.

Veda [veda]

Sanskrit, lit. 'wisdom'. The oldest and most important Hindu sacred texts, the Vedas are hymns composed in Sanskrit and compiled into four collections dated between 1500 and 800 BC.

vibhava [vibhāva]

The fundamental cause or determinant of the personal emotion (bhava) in Sanskrit aesthetics and poetics which is distinct from the refined, depersonalized aesthetic emotion (rasa).

videshi [videśī]

Sanskrit, lit. 'foreign'. May refer to the Western or international elements present in Indian culture and literature, that is, traditions that have been gradually nativized but are of Arabic, Persian, or English origin.

Virasaiva [Vīraśaiva]

Devotee of the Hindu god Siva. The Virasaivas (heroic saivas) worship Siva in the form of the linga.

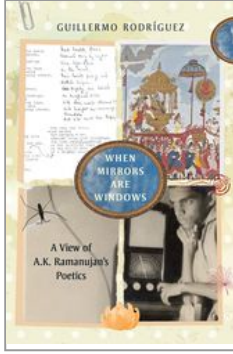
vyabhichari bhava [vyabhicārī bhāva]

Transitory or passing states of the mind, according to the rasa theory of Sanskrit aesthetics. Accessories to sthayi bhava, the dominant emotions. Also referred to as sanchari bhava.

Notes:

(*) The transliteration of Sanskrit, Tamil, or Kannada words in brackets follows the standard transliteration system with diacritical marks as used by AKR in his works. For the sake of consistency with the main text, such terms in the quoted material by AKR in this book have been reproduced from the original source without the diacritical marks.

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(*) See also 'Guide to the A.K. Ramanujan Papers 1944-1995', Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library, <https://www.lib.uchicago.edu/e/scrc/findingaids/view.php?eadid=ICU.SPCL.RAMANUJANAK>.

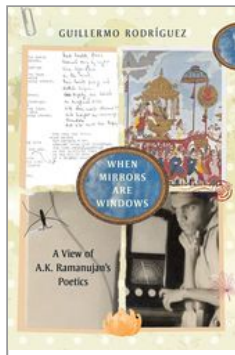
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eadid=ICU.SPCL.RAMANUJANAK](https://www.lib.uchicago.edu/e/scrc/findingaids/view.php?eadid=ICU.SPCL.RAMANUJANAK).

(‡) Other miscellaneous recordings, including poetry readings, are kept at the Regenstein Library, Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago.

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Guillermo Rodríguez

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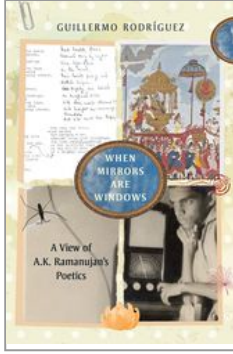
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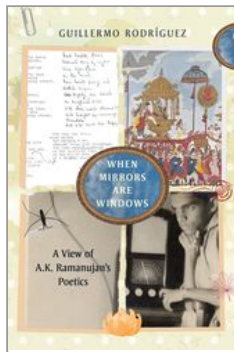
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(p.545) About the Author

Guillermo Rodríguez

Guillermo Rodríguez

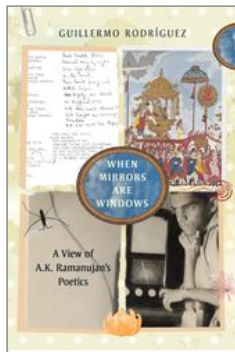
is the founding director of the Casa de la India, a pioneering cultural centre in Spain, supported by the Indian Council for Cultural Relations, University of Valladolid, and City Council of Valladolid. Established in 2003, the centre has now become the model for India's cultural diplomacy abroad.

A passionate traveller, after his college education in Spain, Guillermo made several overland trips from Spain to Asia in the early 1990s. On his first journey to India traversing Central Asia and Tibet, he reached Benares, where he discovered Indian poetry in the translations of A.K. Ramanujan and the poet's anthology of bhakti poems *Speaking of Siva*. Later, in 1993, he decided to make south India his home and lived in Chennai and Trivandrum for seven years. It is here that he became immersed in the artistic and intellectual milieu of the region, at a time when a new generation of postmodern artists, poets, and critics were challenging the earlier cultural establishment. He enrolled himself in the MA programme of Loyola College, Chennai, to specialize in modern Indian poetry in English, and later obtained his PhD in English from the University of Kerala, India, and the University of Valladolid, Spain.

Over the years, Guillermo has been actively involved in numerous cultural and academic activities bringing India and Spain closer to each other. In his multidisciplinary role as an academic scholar and intercultural diplomat, he is regularly invited to deliver lectures at international conferences in Europe. He publishes academic essays and poetry translations and has directed and curated over 30 Indian cultural festivals, international conferences, and civil society

dialogues. In April 2012, he was honoured with the Friendship Award by the Minister of External Affairs, Government of India, for promoting Indo-Spanish cultural relations.

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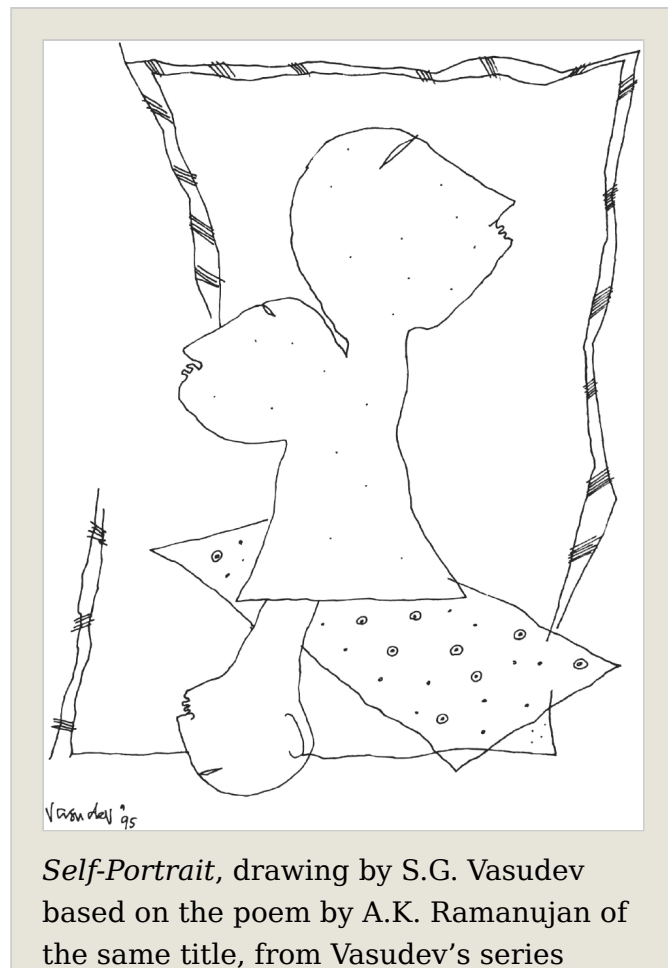
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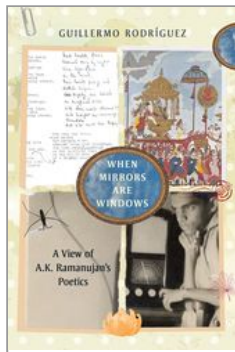


Self-Portrait, drawing by S.G. Vasudev
based on the poem by A.K. Ramanujan of
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'Tribute to Ramanujan', ink on paper
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Plates

Guillermo Rodríguez

Bharathanatyam

Her anklets sprinkle melody
And choke the mind with stardust
As this jewelled dancer
Lives a language on her limbs
Waking ritual into metaphor...

(I knew her name-
But this is not she)

Who is this airborne dancer
Dressed in all desire?
And who are these ~~shapes~~ shadowshapes
That fly, pursue, and suddenly die
But leap, abrupt, in ghostly close-ups, ~~gi~~
Giving the dancer
Multitudes of mimic lives
On the taut and troubled screens of feeling?

(She has no name,
For archetypes have none)

She is a myth of dreamdesire
An eidos of the Actual,
Its secret unwritten poem -
The buried tenderness of veined leaves
In ageless stones.

A.K. Ramanujan,
Department of English,
Lingaraj College, Belgaum.

Typed draft of the unpublished poem
'Bharatanatyam' by A.K. Ramanujan, AKR
Papers (early 1950s), Special Collections

Research Center, University of Chicago
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Of Water and Fire

The wandering touch
of alien flames
~~kindles and~~ claims
the darkening virgin ~~wicks~~

The ~~impatient~~ ocean
draped in turning tide
and muslin ~~foam~~ lace
lures the earth's straying streams
and fulfils their monist dreams
of love's predestined Unity

Lord of all waters and fires
touch me
espouse me
I too am water and fire
gather me
into Thy fierce
consuming Grace

The warden's touch
of flames
claims
the dark virgin wicks.
Ocean
draped in bridal lide
and ~~foam~~ lace
lures the straying stream.
Lord,
touch me
espouse me
I too am water & fire.

Nov 19, 56

- after ■ a medieval Kannada prose-poem.

- A.K. Ramanujan

Typed and handwritten draft of the
unpublished poem 'Of Water and
Fire' (after a medieval Kannada prose-
poem) by A.K. Ramanujan, AKR Papers
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[illegible]

Typed draft of the poem 'A Poem on Particulars' by A.K. Ramanujan with handwritten notes by Indiana University Bloomington professor Samuel Yellen, AKR Papers (c. 1959-60), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.

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Fear

That hawker, fear,
~~The courtesan, fear,~~
 bloomed only by night
 like tiger lilies
 with hearts full of red
 dotted stripes.
 She bedded
 on silk with others' obscene hopes
 and thought ~~and found~~ ~~the rummaging~~ ~~house's~~ clientele
~~though~~ ~~did not hurt her lips,~~
~~though~~ ~~but~~ every morning
 was a morning after;
 only the night had a roof,
 and the day saw ~~her~~ ~~heels~~ on her back
 as if she had slept on a refter.

She put away the dream
 when, in her search,
 she came
 to certain waterbugs
 that perch
 on dry capillary legs
 on the ripple-skin
 of a young running stream.

Put away the dream.
 And search
 for certain waterbugs.
 See them perch
 on dry capillary legs,
 on the ripple skin
 of ~~the~~ ~~running~~ stream.

though every morning
 was a morning after

Not only prophets
 walk on water. A bug sits
 on falling lights
 and dives deep into the sky.

No, not only prophets
 walk on water. ~~The~~ bug sits
 on a landslide of lights
 and drowns eye-
 deep ~~into the sky~~.
 into its little strip
 of sky.

Put away the dream.
 And search
 for certain thin-
 stemmed large-eyed waterbugs.
 See them perch ~~weightless~~
 on dry capillary legs
 on the ripple skin
 of a frisky stream.

March 26/60

That hawker, fear,
 bloomed only by night
 like tiger lilies
 in the mud,
 their hearts full of red
 dotted stripes.
~~She~~ Nightly, she bedded
 on ~~imagined~~ silk
 with ~~other~~ men's obscene hopes
 and thought her rummaging
 clientele
 did not hurt her lips,

Handwritten draft of the poem
 'Fear' (early unpublished version of the
 poem 'The Striders') by A.K. Ramanujan,
 AKR Papers (26 March 1960), Special
 Collections Research Center, University
 of Chicago Library.

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Akka 326

J2

ಎಷ್ಟು ಅಪ್ಪನಾ ಅಪ್ಪನ ಪಾಪ ಪಾಪ!
 ಅಪ್ಪನ ಕೊಡುಗೆಯ ಪಾಪ!
 ಅಪ್ಪನ ಅಪ್ಪನ ಪಾಪ ಪಾಪ!
 ಅಪ್ಪನ ಅಪ್ಪನ ಪಾಪ ಪಾಪ!
 ಎಷ್ಟು ಅಪ್ಪನ ಅಪ್ಪನ ಪಾಪ ಪಾಪ!

Page 42, Akka.

Look at
 love's narrations ~~ways~~
 ways:

if you shoot an arrow
 plant it
 it'll be feather strong;

if you hug ~~me~~
 a body, bones
 must crunch and crumble;

Well,
 the wedding must vanish.

Love is then
 our love's love.

Read ↓

Such love when it ~~is~~ flows into the universe, nor sees it
 as dead but alive, ~~nor~~ not as an it but a Thou, with
 lead us to preserve nature, trees & insects & animals
 & not hurt and tear the ~~these~~ layers. One of the
 finest ecological poems was composed by ~~SSR~~ ~~SSR~~.
 original, which I remember ~~was~~ ~~SSR~~ ~~SSR~~.

Handwritten translation by A.K.

Ramanujan of a medieval bhakti poem in
 Kannada by Mahadeviyakka published in
Speaking of Siva, p. 142, with
 unpublished commentary and Kannada
 original, AKR Papers (early 1970s),
 Special Collections Research Center,
 University of Chicago Library.

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"Akka poem"

P

So goes an old poem
 my great grandfather must have known
 and sung in the temple ~~with~~ with eleven other ~~poets~~
 in the temple ~~then~~ from his Trichy house

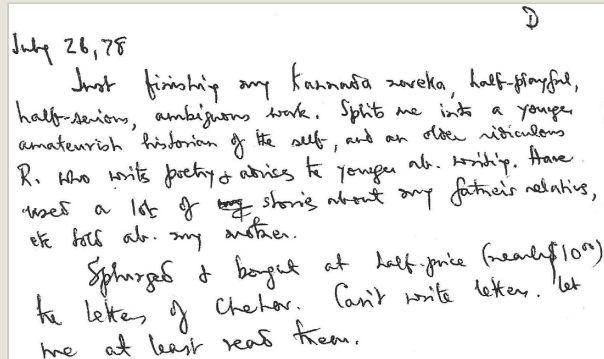
and I can only translate it here,
 just into present Tamil
 into English, but British R.P., ~~but~~ Indian,
 mine with Tamil's and ~~my~~ American
 prepositions, uncertain of ~~my~~ perfect tense,

~~the~~ translation poem, great grandfather, and me now,
 and maybe someone else, ~~re-interpret~~ ~~re-interpret~~
 knowing I mean only translate me, this writing,
 & know I cannot, into anything that's even out there

"another
 Akka poem"

Handwritten draft of the unpublished poem 'Alvar Poem' by A.K. Ramanujan on translating medieval Tamil poetry, written at Carleton College, AKR Papers (1978), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.

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July 26, 78

Just finishing my karnataka zoveta, half-playful, half-serious, ambiguous work. Splits me into a younger amateurish historian of the self, and an older ridiculous R. who writes poetry & advice to younger ab. writing. Have used a lot of ~~my~~ stories about my father's relatives, etc. told ab. my mother.

Sphurged & bawled at half-price (nearly 100%) the letters of Chetav. Can't write letters. let me at least read them.

Handwritten unpublished diary notecard by A.K. Ramanujan, AKR Papers (26 July 1978), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.

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On Discovering That Soma Is a Mushroom

Would you believe it?

I'm an oak tree with fountains
of falling hair, and Soma, once eye

of heaven, a mushroom at my feet.
Not R., whom you and I
know somewhat, but oak among tall oaks

in a ring of white mountains,
for Soma is a mushroom at my feet.
Yes, I'm still R., here and now as always,
married and difficult, a handful

of thumbs with a hammer and nail,
reading a newspaper once a year,
living at two
addresses, office and home,
you or he or even I can write to,

though Soma is a mushroom growing at my feet.
Wedded to doubt and married to a human,
now oak now willow with falling hair
and two addresses, even two children,
16 and 14, girl and boy, in a ring
of mountains, reading a newspaper

on a staircase spiral as if in Istanbul
in Mustafa's place, for Soma's me,
mushroom, ancient of altitudes,
growing at my feet. Soma of seven minds,
single phallic eye, glow of red behind
eye and ear, growing on the line
between left and right,

bud of the thousand petal lotus in the brain.
Soma, I sit on Soma, caterpillar
on toadstool,
eating and waiting to be butterfly;
stand in Soma, warm perishing body
in cold silver river;
a lover's hand
in, on, below, between,

and Soma growing at my feet.
It's Soma reads The Hindu
and The Sun Times once a year,
photographs the rainbow
all around him and the cat and you,
sees distant famine in a present meal,
is astonished at ordinary things,

Typed draft of the unpublished poem
'Jazz Poem for Soma' by A.K. Ramanujan,
AKR Papers (c. 1979-80), Special
Collections Research Center, University
of Chicago Library.

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When Soma is abroad,
dialect and jargon glow,
mother-tongues wear classics on their sleeves,
~~even~~ father-tongues loosen,
schoolbook rules ~~think and sing of~~ ^{yearn like} love and war,
metres breathe, a mountain breeze
or ~~play like~~ lion-cubs
around a majestic father-theme.

Soma, blow ^{blow hard} ~~hard~~ on the coals of Ezekiel's lips,
make chariots of war pirouette among arrows,
bring medicine men in Delhi offices the red robes of shamans,
dawn again on the stones of Jejuri
and circle the squares of Konarak.

Typed draft of the unpublished poem
'When Soma Is Abroad', by A.K.
Ramanujan, AKR Papers (c. 1979-80),
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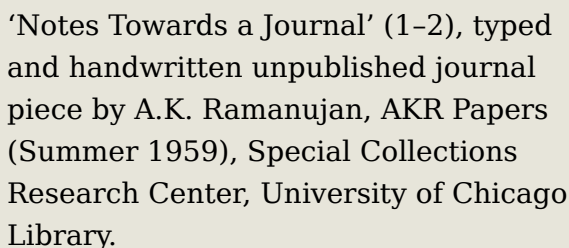
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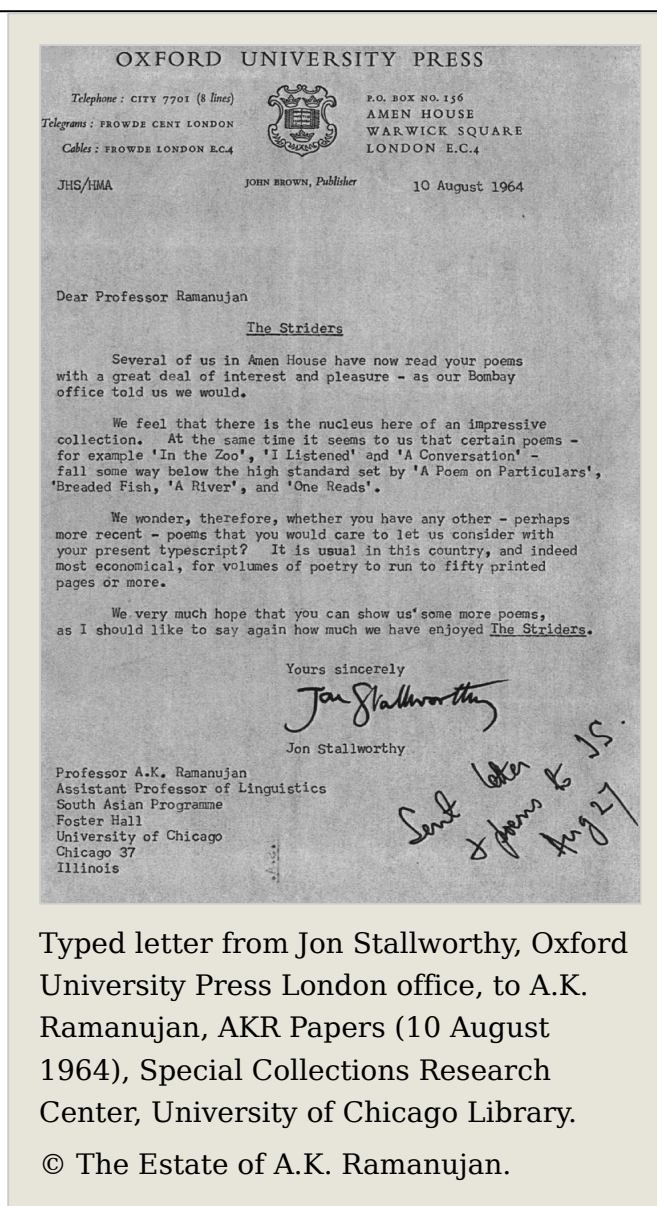
'A Poem Is Born', first page of a handwritten unpublished prose text in diary form by A.K. Ramanujan, AKR

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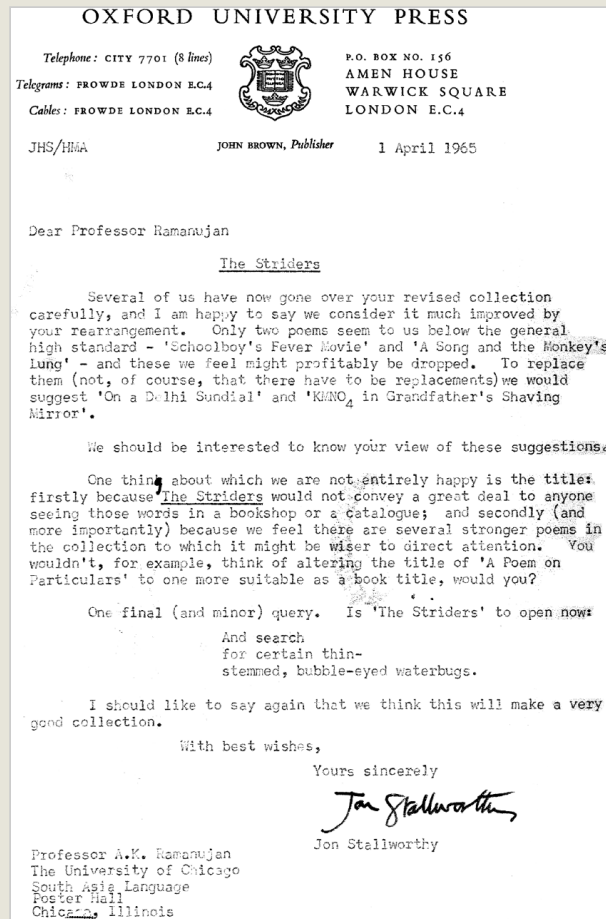
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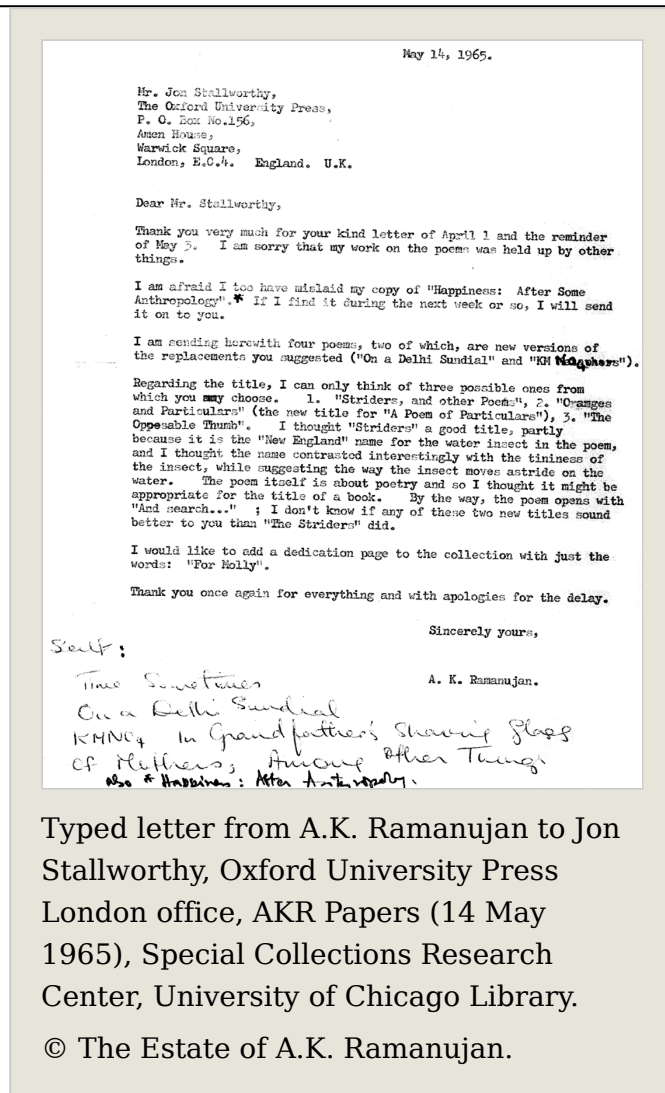
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THE UNIVERSITY OF CHICAGO
CHICAGO • ILLINOIS 60637
SOUTH ASIA LANGUAGE AND AREA CENTER
FOSTER HALL
1130 EAST 59TH STREET

June 6, 1967

Mr. Jon Stallworthy
Oxford University
Ely House
37, Dover Street
London W1
England

Dear Mr. Stallworthy:

Thank you very much for your letter of May 18 acknowledging the arrival of the typescript. After sending you the poems, I found a number of small typing errors in a few pages. Herewith I am sending you those pages with all the corrections made. In the case of the poem ~~of~~ DANCERS, I have rewritten it for the 200th. I am sorry to bother you with replacing all these pages. I hope you would excuse the inconvenience.

Mr. Aroul of the Mexican Embassy in Delhi has translated a poem of mine into Spanish. I would like to include it in a Spanish anthology of Indian verse. We have asked him to write to you for permission. I would appreciate if you would consider his request favorably.

I will be at Berkeley, California for the next six months. But please use this address till I find one at Berkeley.

With best wishes.

Sincerely yours,

A. K. Ramanujan
Associate Professor

AKR/plm

Typed letter from A.K. Ramanujan to Jon Stallworthy, Oxford University Press London office, AKR Papers (6 June 1967), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.

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October 16, 1970

Mr. Jon Stallworthy
Oxford University Press
Thibault House
Thibault Square
Cape Town, South Africa

Dear Jon,

Thank you very much for your letter of August 27 and forgive me for not writing to you earlier. I must thank you very much for the good news about the publication of the poems. Thank you also for sending on your reader's remarks, many of which are quite just. I am ~~probably~~ going through a phase where I don't quite know what is traditionally meant by memorability, as I feel every experience memorable, depending on the quality of the attention given to it. The novelistic tone of some of the poems are also intended, as far as such things can be intended. I also tried to present a family of poems, one lighting up another, however ~~dimly~~ a family of poems with common roots but individual bodies and faces. I do not quite know if I succeeded. I shall certainly try to revise and tighten up some of the poems in the next few months, and add some new poems if they get down to the page. Do give me a deadline if you have one. It usually helps.

Is there any possibility of getting out a cheaper edition of my poems in India? I have an interested audience there, but the books don't ~~reach~~ them because of the cost in rupees.

It might please you to know that Penguin Classics accepted my translations of Kannada religious lyrics for 1971. I am still not finished with the Tamil heroic poetry which you are interested in looking at. I shall send a sample to you some time soon. Thank you once again, and every good wish,

Yours as ever,

A. K. Ramanujan

AKR:ja

Typed letter from A.K. Ramanujan to Jon Stallworthy, Oxford University Press London office, AKR Papers (16 October 1970), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.
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Mescaline notes
 Vivaldi - flourish - ~~Sunday~~ ^{Apr 28, 71} 6 p.m. evening
 expectancy - surveying all the objects in front
 slight weakness & tremor of limbs -
 byip soon - (sunlight evening) fell on my
 shaggy head with weak, golden-yellow
 hair - the sun was really a reflection in a wet-fau-
 dry chalklike feeling in the throat - shiver
 in the calves -
 My handwriting isn't clear, getting less coordinated
 as my forearm aches and aches -
 A compass of blood all over -
 Earlier on, I took count of all fearful
 objects, tribal fears, the puffingish air -
 hanging - but I'm now going to be
 afraid - I'm going to hesitate
 put on Vivaldi again - sitting at entrance
 As I stood meditatively, hands together,
 images of love of hands together cartoons
 behind my eyes -
 Feel fragile - heartbeat faster - breathing hard -
 all muscle seems relaxed, weak -
 I'd do run down 3 stairs & up bec. I heard
 the rumbell - no one -
 faint - music - body muscle weaker -

'Mescaline Notes' (1), handwritten
 unpublished diary entry by A.K.
 Ramanujan, AKR Papers (28 August
 1971), Special Collections Research
 Center, University of Chicago Library.
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have been writing on the floor to the Vinals
 - as I close my eyes, the after-images glow in
 "Conventional" psychedelic colors - break -
 Yellow sunlight of evening - as in some afterglow.
Time picture of Nixon - Used too anaemic -
 the cigarette on the back too 3-D - is turned it
 other way - can't write easily - throat
 slick a little like chalk -
 Now the Beats - drips of fear - also color-
 humour - espy crescendo - color behind the
 eyes - ① Moly, it's all a scream of longing
 for you! It is this! - The No. 9. No. 9 No. 9 -
 & the rainbow like coming & going auric
 & voices in it getting urgent & fainter - Must
 listen to this when out of this - crowd
 Snatches of No. 9 - is the No. 9 - claps - soft
 claps of symbols - crescendo of applause -
 Behind my eyes, drips of real moist
 blood, in folds of clothes - fear of closing
 my eyes - No. 9 music is "Sweet Dreams" -

'Mescaline Notes' (2), handwritten
 unpublished diary entry by A.K.
 Ramanujan, AKR Papers (28 August
 1971), Special Collections Research
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Body - shaky - weak - always on the verge of
a hance, a sleep, but not quite falling off
7.30. Needed water - in walk to the john
then to water - hands tremble -
Reality of sex room bricks, in drains
on the bathroom window, still there -
but as if I'd woken from sleep -
weak of body -
Now have put on Mozart's Jute Sonatas.
Celt takes human voice any more -
proliferation of colors & shapes & prints behind
my eyes - I am then only to amuse myself
of the real light, the sound in front,
the hard floor - the weakness of the hand at
writing - close my eyes - a brilliant glow
of green with spots of orange, purple - all a
chasing dust - Not even here I'm
not just weak from drugs, not from the
drug - but from -

'Mescaline Notes' (3), handwritten unpublished diary entry by A.K. Ramanujan, AKR Papers (28 August 1971), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.
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Time's heavy - maybe due to
 muscle weakness - like being very
 drunk when I close my eyes -
 Time's slow - measured thank god
 by Mozart's lamp & flute -
 behind my eyes - exhaustion
 is exhaustible mixture of colored
 shapes together glowing color shapes, designs
 of red black & green dots as on tie-dies -
 will I be exhausted at the end of this?
 Is this the peak? - I want reality to
 glow - only the colors behind my eyes
 go from the chicks & know of the
 turntable change into scorpions of
 color - no words - the hummer is
 exhaustion -
 7.50. Indian music - sounds too thin &
 scratchy - like a mosquito whine -
 this is so far from familiar - heard
 literally every hour & note 1000 of times in
 Mysore on the radio - feeling dirty - occasional

'Mescaline Notes' (4), handwritten
 unpublished diary entry by A.K.
 Ramanujan, AKR Papers (28 August
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Journal Oct 30, '76

She never thought of myself as a writer;
~~the~~ I just write. I'm startled when someone
 instance, are in print or in conversation as a
 'poet'. The poems, too, when they come, surprise
 me. I feel a poem has chosen me, not me the
 poem - and this is not being mystical. Give to
 some feeling about thoughts, ideas, events. Maybe a
 certain passivity, a need to say "I didn't work for
 it, I'm not responsible," in my nature. For
 years, I look to Buddhist slogan, "Take nothing
 that's not given" literally. Except, I reversed

seem to me.
 to "Take everything that's given," or "Say No to nothing"
 which landed me in dreadful dilemmas
 birth, food and women. This response to
 "Say No" has never hurt me - I've shifted into
 things, paradoxical, ~~things~~ I've always wanted, but
 never allowed myself ^{now} to dream of. Maybe I let
 my unconscious do the work for me - let it
 choose and ~~maneuver~~ maneuver where intent
 to my conscious stir. A. Teaching myself as an
 Ouija board, to spell out my deepest desires.
 of nothing came of it, I'd always say to
 myself, I didn't try for it anyway; it got
 the job, the book, the ~~maneuver~~ maneuver, there was a sense

Handwritten unpublished journal
 notecard by A.K. Ramanujan (1-2), AKR
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November 27, 1978

Ms. Vrinda Nabor
Department of English
University of Bombay
East Wing, First Floor
Bombay 400 032
INDIA

Dear Vrinda:

Here, ~~at last~~, are some answers for your questions. They are not easy to answer because I feel I don't know most of the answers. I don't think of myself as a "poet" etc.; I just happen to write. I am embarrassed and feel uncertain when such questions are asked about my writing. I also know that the satisfactory (to me) answers are complex, and will take too long. Here are some slapdash answers, for what they are worth. I hope you find them useful.

1. I can't think right away of any major events or people or books or courses which were "decisive" for my "poetry." I only know that I started reading detective novels in English at 14, though I'd been reading Kannada earlier, and started Tamil novels at 16 or so. I started reading English poetry only at 17, when I joined the B.A. (Honors) in English Literature. I'd started reading Kannada poetry a bit earlier, and was writing Kannada plays and sketches in my "Intermediate College" days -- mostly for the radio and a humor-magazine called *Koravanji*. In English, I think I knew my *Golden Treasury* pretty well, even knew some of Shakespeare's sonnets by heart.

I did get to Yeats and Eliot a few years later. I was quite taken with Yeats, and read everything I could by him, about him. I was particularly taken with his constant revisions (his Visions fascinated me but didn't make much sense) his use of arrangement as a poetic device, and his sense of *Oeuvre* -- he was writing his *Collected Poems* from the word "go." Yeats' way of making poem relevant to poem is somewhere at the back of my mind always -- that's what I like about the traditional bodies of Indian poetry as well: single, realized poems, yet qualifying each other; parts of a larger body, a "work." I must add that I first read the Kannada *Bharata* and Kannada *vacanas* with one of the finest and most wide-ranging of teachers, V. Sitaramayya in Mysore. He talked of everything from Sanskrit epics to Keynes and Auden. I admired his range, his deep knowledge of two cultures and literatures. Now that I think of it, he was a fine representative of a special Kannada tradition, which began with his teachers -- of being bi-literary in Kannada and English. Even to this day, in Karnataka, many of the writers are deeply read in English (Adiga, Anantamurthy, Lankeesh, etc.). I think sometimes that the full power and creativity of English in India is really not in the English we write, but in our languages like Kannada. As you probably know, I have two volumes of verse in Kannada, and have translated the Kannada *vacanas*, the Classical Tamil poems and Anantamurthy's novel. I think my interest in Kannada and Tamil, my involvement with them, my need to learn all I can about the literature, folklore

and culture in them, was stirred by the (what seems now) extraordinary place Mysore was in the late '40s and early '50s. It was also then that I met Adiga, Anantamurthy, and a little later, Girish Karnad, G.B. Joshi, Eurtakota, Kambar, Lankeesh -- all of whom are now exciting Kannada writers. I admire their work and have learnt from them.

Now that I am acknowledging debts, I must add two friends who were close to me, both of whom had read and understood a great deal more than I: K. Bhogishayana and T.R.S. Sharma. I'm still a little awed by them. They were both in English Litt; but Bhogishayana was reading everything from Collingwood to Proust and Eliot; Sharma was full of Sartre, psychology and yoga. I first heard of these names and subjects from them. There was also S. Anantanarayana, an English teacher and Kannada poet/novelist, who opened his great hoard of books to me. The four of us met every evening and talked a great deal about everything.

2. As I said above, I was writing in Kannada by 1946. A couple of years later, I did begin to scribble in English, kept diaries etc. I had by now read Dylan Thomas (thanks to Bhogishayana) and Hopkins -- and wrote a couple of Dylan-ish exercises. After my M.A., I went to teach in Kerala (1950-1), then in Madurai (1951-2) -- where I was rather lonely, read most of the time, learned more Tamil, tried translating the *vacanas* which I carried everywhere -- and wrote a few more English verses. In 1952, I went to Belgaum, and stayed there till 1957. These five were important years -- because I was back in Kannada country; I returned to Kannada, the *vacanas*, started my collections of folklore in that area; my first effort in English was published in the *Illustrated Weekly* and Nissim Ezekiel's *Quest*. My father died in 1953, and it took me 15 years to write an "Obituary" for him. It was also at this time that I felt one with my family, felt intensely responsible for everyone of them. It was here I became most aware of my sense of family, its place in all my understandings of things Indian, its being the source of much that is good and evil, decent and savage, creative and stifling. Some of this shows up in my verse.

I don't really know when I made any "decisive commitment to writing." Given to chronic indecisiveness, I admire and envy those who are decisive about such things. I've just written something or the other for myself all the time, especially since my 20s.

3. I think I've answered this question in the above pages. I'm not really sure, if all this has anything to do with my "writing" -- tho' it has a lot to do with what I am now. My father was a mathematician, who had a taste for literature, quoted in Tamil, Sanskrit and English (I heard my first Chaucer from him). He really believed that mathematics was a kind of poetry -- and behaved like "a poet" -- woke up in the middle of the night to write down an equation or something, worked on his problems every day for hours, as later, I found professional novelists did on their novels every morning. My mother, who didn't read English, read every scrap in Kannada and Tamil; she, my grandmother, and the women-cooks, told us folktales that they'd heard in childhood. I've collected scores of folktales ever since -- when I was in Belgaum, and later in my linguistic field-trips from 1968 on. I'm working on a book on South Indian tales.

It was my father who wasn't taken in by my high marks in mathematics and science -- and wouldn't let me continue with any of it for a degree. And off I went to study English Litt -- craving always for some science somewhere -- the nearest I came to it was in my quasi-mathematical linguistics. I have sometimes thought that linguistics and poetry are both a search for forms, in their different

ways. My father would have agreed, and quoted Poincare. Right now, I'm eye-deep in debt to Molly, my wife (whose passion is literature, and who's a novelist) for her intense, ever-vigilant sense of what's good and right in this business. I can talk forever about her.

4. It was Linguistics that took me to America (1959) -- though, ironically, it was my early involvement with Tamil and Kannada that kept me there. I was fortunate to be living in the U.S. in the early '60s when the new Indian studies were just beginning to be important. Milton Singer and Edward Dimock offered me the chance to work with them, to start Dravidian Studies in Chicago. And I've learned a great deal about India, especially about Tamil and Kannada India -- and learned to teach, translate from, and explore these languages I'd known from childhood. I'd have probably done something of the sort even if I'd never left India -- but I was getting sick of being an English teacher by 1957, and went into linguistics. Ideally, I'd have liked to have lived in India, and worked in Indian studies. For various reasons, I haven't been able to manage it. But I've had to be content with the second best ~~step~~, lived in America, and worked in Indian studies, returned to India as often as I could for "refills." Maybe, if I'd had the kind of character that was "decisive," "committed" etc. to writing, I'd have found my half-way houses intertable.

5. Again, the answer to this question is in the above pages. I don't think one gets away from one's childhood, being steeped in things Indian (as I've been calling them, to avoid gobbledygook about Culture, Heritage etc.) -- no more than one can jump off one's shadow, or take someone else's bath. They're part of the self, they're the language of the self. I'd add, for most of us, English is also part of that already many-layered heritage -- for me, at least since my adolescence. Since then, it was the language of my dialogue with my father and my college-friends, though Kannada and Tamil were the languages of my dialogue with my mother, relatives, friends, and other writers in my region. Whatever "Indian Heritage" I know has come to me mediated through such splits and connections.

6. In my adolescence I rejected "religion, caste, community." I think I learned effectively to live without them as well as anyone can -- but I'm aware they are very much the "language of the self," as I said before. They are of interest to me because I know them in my bone -- though I've no religion, I can't resist temples, religious customs, their music and poetry. I sometimes even talk of "grace," with a small g. Yet I had to do the poetry of Siva before I could even think of studying the poetry of Vignu -- the god of my parents' subcaste. I'm amazed that it's taken me this long and this distance to work on translations from the Vaishnava Alvars, poems I'd heard from fanatical orthodox uncles in my early years. A form of reverse prejudice, prejudice nevertheless.

6. I thought I'd be tongue-tied but here I am talking about myself for pages. I'm afraid I've no clear, clever, striking answers. My verse has to speak for itself, and for some parts of me. I do often find I've forestalled myself in some old verse, which has said what I've been struggling to think of say, and said it better. I'm moved by hundreds of things within and without me, that I don't know at all how to write about. Only a small number of things ever get written, and fewer still get written well. I'm amazed that I write at all, sometimes even in English -- I don't quite know how or why. A still small voice, not of reason, but of unreason, says, "It's a form of grace. Don't question it." I trust that voice. A short piece called, "Which Reminds Me," says it for me. (The Striders, p. 23).

Typed letter from A.K. Ramanujan to Vrinda Nabar (1-3), AKR Papers (27 November 1978), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.

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Journal on 'Composition' July 25, 82

It's too personal^{how} - the 'I' not large and non-personal - finds a central tension - the above theme of reaching to enlarge self without mysticism, pomposity, generality etc. - this incident - a running central image: Composition, decomposition - a passage on a compost - like Whitman's but shd be different - how many ways do they become us? - the elements, ideas, imitation of clothes & women & words - some don't fit - "influence", fluency, flow, when & ocean - I breathe and the air becomes me, ~~my~~ my blood, I eat. ~~Antarctica~~ fish, soul, and flesh become my flesh and blood, elate and deepen me, make me lose caste and skin status.

Handwritten unpublished journal notecard on 'Composition', by A.K. Ramanujan, AKR Papers (25 July 1982), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.

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Journal. Aug 4, '82

Struggling to start new poem - to repeat writing. Don't know how to begin. My belief & practice: they must 'come' as leaves to a tree, or not at all. I also have had time the last two months to pass to have without much reading - & regularly thinking. Feel not particularly bright - wonder if I drifted into being some sort of "published writer" without quite meaning to. The title and occupation fits me poorly. Constantly tempted to try a novel again - but afraid M. will be offended & feel she enters her territory. Reading to Ted, after a year. Exasperating number of new books - makes one resist, into wanting to do to same.

Handwritten unpublished journal notecard by A.K. Ramanujan, AKR Papers (4 August 1982), Special Collections Research Center, University of Chicago Library.

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Writing: Some thoughts

I read somewhere: ~~something that I've found to be~~ A poet is ~~some~~ a specialist in something everyone does all the time.

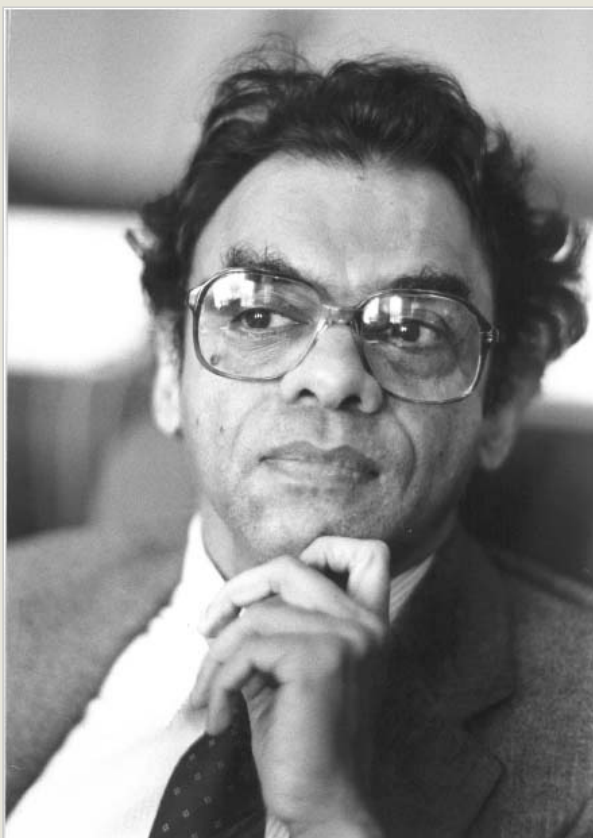
Writers write.

GBS said, a man pursues a woman until she catches him. I don't know if this is true of women. It's certainly true of poems. You do not chase and pursue "your poems". You put yourself in a place where "they" happen to you.

When you correct a poem, you are not another part of your brain than when you write it in the first place. Writing and re-writing are part of the same process. Creation and (self-) criticism are ~~both the same~~ not opposites.

Most of what you write is not worth printing; it is still worth writing. It is practice, exercise, and may (& will) suddenly lead to poems, perceptions, recognitions.

'Writing: Some Thoughts' (1-2),
handwritten unpublished notecard by
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A.K. Ramanujan, location unknown (late
1980s).

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A.K. Ramanujan listening to the radio in the family house in Mysore (c. 1947). He started writing plays for AIR at the age of 16, and about 25 of them were produced by AIR in those years.

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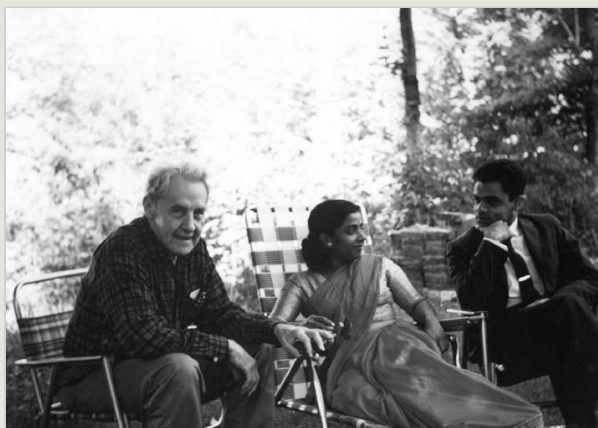
A.K. Ramanujan and his sister Saroja next to the Mysore house (c. 1947).

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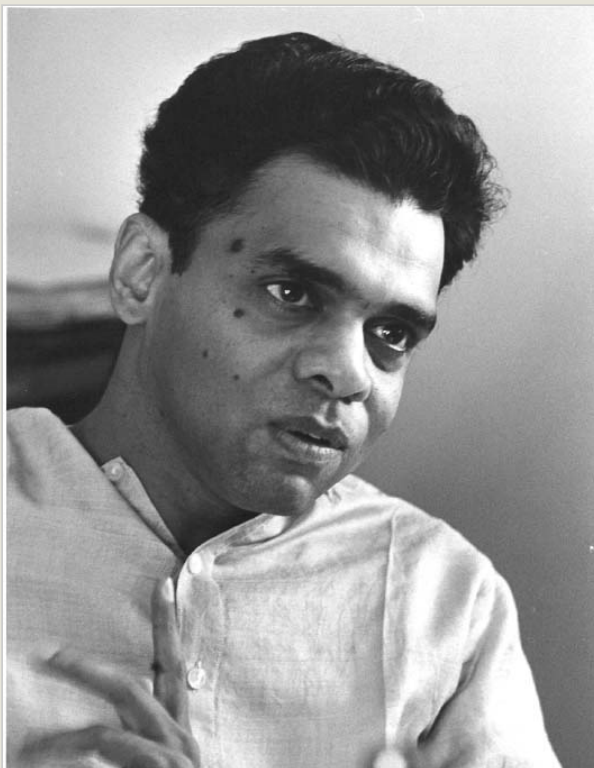
A.K. Ramanujan on the roof of the Mysore house (1949). Photo taken by his elder brother A.K. Srinivasan with a box camera.

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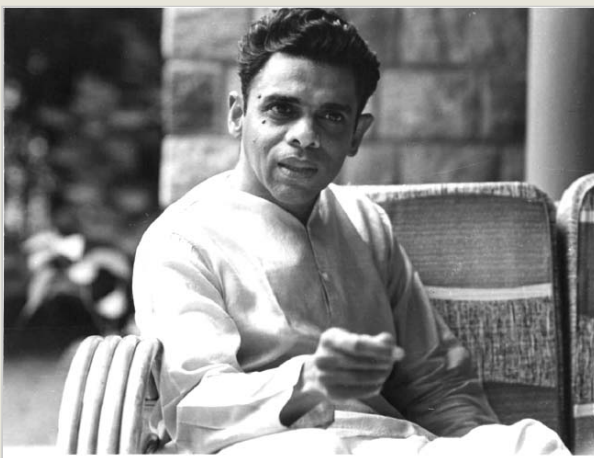
A.K. Ramanujan with his wife Molly Daniels-Ramanujan and the American writer and editor Chard Powers Smith in Vermont, USA (1962). Photo taken on the couple's honeymoon.

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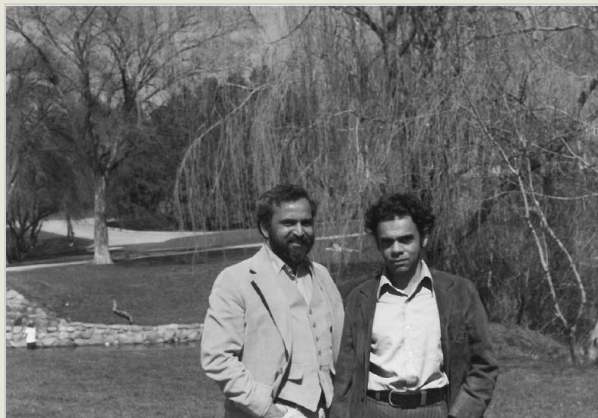
A.K. Ramanujan, location unknown (c. 1966).

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A.K. Ramanujan, location unknown (c. 1966).

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A.K. Ramanujan and the Kannada writer U.R. Ananthamurthy in Northfield, Minnesota (c. 1976).

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A.K. Ramanujan lecturing at the University of Delhi (1983). Seated are the Hindi writer Sachchidananda Hirananda Vatsyayana and an unidentified Western scholar.

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A.K. Ramanujan lecturing at the University of Delhi (1983).

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A.K. Ramanujan, location unknown (1983).

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A.K. Ramanujan speaking to Indian fiction writer R.K. Narayan accompanied by Kannada poet and translator Sha. Balu Rao (1992).

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